

The Age of Ailean

LINN NA DOIRE

The Legendarium OF DIA-THÌR

— The AGE OF AILEAN

(An Aois Ailein)

being the Books of the age, the Annals of its years,
a Gazetteer of its towns, and the Appendices
the Grove Era, GE 1 – 4,603

Bidh e leatsa, agus cha bhi e aig duine às do dhèidh.

It will be yours, and no one's after you.

the Keeper to Ailean at the vigil, as Clann na Ceiste keep it

CONTENTS

PART ONE: THE GROVE AND THE HILL.....	15
---------------------------------------	----

Chapter One: Of the Seven Nights.....	16
--	-----------

I. Of the Fires under the Oaks	16
II. Of the Seven Nights	18
III. Of the Eighth Night.....	21
IV. Of the Warm Arm and the Road South	22
V. Of the Kin Who Followed	24

Chapter Two: Of the Knapper's Son.....	27
---	-----------

I. Of the Watch on the Lip of the Hill.....	27
II. Of the Twelve at the Foot of the Slope	28
III. Of the Water and the Spear.....	29
IV. Of the Households Coming In.....	30
V. Of the First Judgement.....	31
VI. Of the Warmth with No Fire.....	32
VII. Of the Pit and the Word Kept.....	33
VIII. Of the Ring Pegged in the Snow	34
IX. Of Those Who Were Brought Down.....	35

Chapter Three: Of Gormshuil at the Gate.....	37
---	-----------

I. Of the Watching Child	37
II. Of Her Mother's Dying	38
III. Of the Hard Winter and the Warm Ground	39
IV. Of the Gate and the Years Between.....	41
V. Of the Grandchildren Who Took Him for Her Son.....	42
VI. Of the Last Autumn	43
VII. Of Dòmhnall Taking the Hill	45

Chapter Four: Of the Stones in the Valley and the Chair of Birch	47
---	-----------

I. Of the Setting of the Stones.....	47
II. Of What the Stones Did Not Settle.....	48
III. Of the Wars of the Valleys.....	49
IV. Of Fearchar Lamed.....	50
V. Of the Storm	51
VI. Of the Household That Stood	53
VII. Of Somhairle Who Took No Share	54
VIII. Of the Chair of Birch and the Riding North.....	55

Chapter Five: Of the Palisade that Burned Twice	57
I. Of the Hill by the Lake	57
II. Of Growing to the Watch	58
III. Of the Two Hundred Spears	60
IV. Of the Long Waiting	61
V. Of the King's Frost.....	62
VI. Of Uisdean Going Down	64
VII. Of the Two Lists	65
 Chapter Six: Of the Strokes on the Midden Stones.....	 67
I. Of the Road by Gesture.....	67
II. Of the Marks at the Midden's Edge	69
III. Of the Stroke Cut After a Burial	71
IV. Of the Grandson and the Fewer Hearths	73
 Chapter Seven: Of the Tally Wall and the Half-Cut Stone	 76
I. Of the Road East.....	76
II. Of Seann Tarr and the House over the Dead	79
III. Of the Thickening	80
IV. Of the Half-Cut Stone	81
V. Of the Silence	83
VI. Of Cairistiona	84
 PART TWO: SALT AND THE HANDFUL	 87
 Chapter Eight: Of the Old Names.....	 88
I. Of the Word Seann	88
II. Of the Coming to the Harbour	90
III. Of the Storm and the Cracked Stone.....	92
IV. Of the Boats and the Burial.....	94
 Chapter Nine: Of Mòrag the Hard	 97
I. Of the Hill Without Salt.....	97
II. Of the Shingle at Baile ghorm	99
III. Of the Bank Behind the Shingle.....	101
IV. Of the Red Hill and the Pebble Bag	102
V. Of the Years That Followed	104
 Chapter Ten: Of the Shingle at Baile ghorm	 107
I. Of the Pans	107
II. Of the Coming of Iain Dubh.....	108
III. Of the Cairn on the Hill	110

IV. Of the Man on the Shingle.....	111
V. Of the Double Handful.....	113
VI. Of Tadhg Garbh's Boat.....	114
Chapter Eleven: Of the Sand on the Hearths and the Opened Ground.....	117
I. Of the Sand	117
II. Of the Slope	119
III. Of the Valley.....	120
IV. Of the Opened Ground	121
V. Of the King at the Crack	122
VI. Of the White Stones.....	124
Chapter Twelve: Of the Unlit Hearth and the Basket.....	126
I. Of the Hearth Never Lit.....	126
II. Of the Measure Nowhere Written	127
III. Of Achadh dhìreach	129
IV. Of the Basket	130
V. Of the King's Hand.....	132
Chapter Thirteen: Of the Watchers of the Slab	136
I. Of the Line Kept in the Valleys	136
II. Of the First Turn	138
III. Of Ìde Grown Old	140
IV. Of the Question Gilleonan Asked	142
V. Of the King's Night at the Slab	144
Chapter Fourteen: Of Salt for Wool	147
I. Of the Hill Without Salt.....	147
II. Of the Wading at the Ford.....	149
III. Of the Ground the Water Never Dried.....	151
IV. Of Murchadh Gearr on the Salt Road.....	153
V. Of the Trodden Ground.....	155
PART THREE: THE FAR SHORES AND THE NAME.....	157
Chapter Fifteen: Of the Western Shore and the Amber Bead	158
I. Of the Bay of Hawks.....	158
II. Of the Amber and the Wrack.....	160
III. Of the Bead and the Road	162
IV. Of the Ford and the Man Who Bought Nothing	164
V. Of the Years the Bay Was Told Of	166
Chapter Sixteen: Of the Rope's End	169

I. Of the Household at the Shaft's Mouth	169
II. Of the Boy Who Would Not Let It Be	170
III. Of the Rope's End	172
IV. Of the Question She Carried	174
V. Of the Hut and the Lake	175
VI. Of Her Own Ending.....	176

Chapter Seventeen: Of Beitris and the Grey Winter..... 178

I. Of the Lamps, the Traps and the Standing Frame.....	178
II. Of the Weaver	180
III. Of the Wedding and the Grey Winter.....	182
IV. Of the Rock at Ros dhomhain	184
V. Of the Names She Was Given.....	185

Chapter Eighteen: Of the Flint Road..... 188

I. Of the Road He Chose	188
II. Of the Flint Road and Ailig Spor	190
III. Of the Years Between	192
IV. Of Ailig Spor's Death	194
V. Of the Bird Carved at Àth mhòr and the Wolves of Tobar fhiadhaich.....	195
VI. Of the Asking and the Refusal	196

Chapter Nineteen: Of the Hungry Years 199

I. Of the Store within the Bank	199
II. Of Baile chrom	201
III. Of Achadh shean	203
IV. Of the Deed and the List.....	204
V. Of the Giving of the Hill	206

Chapter Twenty: Of the Eight Winds and Tormod the Grey..... 208

I. Of the Hill Given Over	208
II. Of the Winds Given Names.....	209
III. Of the Stones at Ceann leathan	211
IV. Of the Heirs He Buried.....	212
V. Of the Second Bank	213
VI. Of the Grey	214
VII. Of the King at the Gate	214
VIII. Of the Name They Gave Themselves.....	216

Chapter Twenty-one: Of the Forbidden Marriage and the Trench..... 218

I. Of Ealag and Torcall Tochclair.....	218
II. Of the Marriage at the Ford	221
III. Of the Trench at the Black Hill	222
IV. Of the Stone That Would Not Break	224

V. Of the Vein That Chooses	226
PART FOUR: THE LOT AND THE SAYING	229
Chapter Twenty-two: Of the Sharing before the Storms.....	230
I. Of the Custom that Had No Beginning.....	230
II. Of the House at Àth shean	231
III. Of the Lean Year.....	233
IV. Of the Telling.....	234
V. Of the Road.....	236
VI. Of the Hill in Its Old Age.....	237
Chapter Twenty-three: Of Eilidh the Grey and the Boy Who Went.....	240
I. Of Eilidh's Two Sons	240
II. Of the Road West	243
III. Of the Household of Lachlann Ruadh.....	245
IV. Of the Lake and the Name Not Kept.....	247
Chapter Twenty-four: Of Oighrig's Lot and the Stone Cup	250
I. Of the Turns that Wore Thin.....	250
II. Of the Lot	252
III. Of the House with the Door to the Slab.....	254
IV. Of the Cup Ground to Her Hand.....	255
V. Of the Copies	257
VI. Of the Meeting of the Cups	258
Chapter Twenty-five: Of the Coal that Went Home	261
I. Of Gilleasbuig's Turn	261
II. Of the Judgement at the Slab.....	263
III. Of Eilean chrom.....	264
IV. Of the Second Lot and the Basket Unburned.....	265
V. Of the Coal that Went Home.....	267
VI. Of Calum Ciar and the Lot at Dùn ìseal	268
VII. Of the Unwritten Line	269
Chapter Twenty-six: Of the Black Wind and the Five Fires	271
I. Of the Wind that Took the Thatch.....	271
II. Of the Winter the Custom Reached the Coast.....	273
III. Of Lileas, Who Watched the Boats Come In.....	274
IV. Of the Fire She Kept on the Eastern Cape	275
V. Of the Fires that Answered It	277
VI. Of the Boat that Came Home by It	278

Chapter Twenty-seven: Of Anndra Breac 280

- I. Of the Watch at Seann Skell 280
- II. Of the Planks on the Western Sand 282
- III. Of Anndra Breac, Who Made a Telling 283
- IV. Of the Ford 285
- V. Of the King, Who Laughed and Then Was Quiet 287
- VI. Of the Saying Spoken at the Opening..... 288

Chapter Twenty-eight: Of the Fosterling's Return..... 290

- I. Of the Paired Marks at Ros dhomhain 290
- II. Of the Third Rock at Inis thais..... 291
- III. Of the Landing of Laid Stone 292
- IV. Of Lachlann's Dying 293
- V. Of Peigi Dhubh's Holding..... 294
- VI. Of the Leaving of the Red Hill..... 295
- VII. Of the Road East 296
- VIII. Of the Brother Who Did Not Know Him 297
- IX. Of the Songs Sung at the Pans..... 298

PART FIVE: THE GREAT GATHERING 301

Chapter Twenty-nine: Of the Panther Road and the Edge of the Woods .. 302

- I. Of the Bone Pipes and the Turning of the Cats 302
- II. Of Iain Buachaille and the Cattle in the Passes 304
- III. Of the Gatepost Sign and the Boats Named for Wind..... 306
- IV. Of the Wind-Stone and the Broken Grave 307
- V. Of the Pilgrims and the Child Lost at Cnoc bheag..... 309
- VI. Of the Warm Springs 311
- VII. Of the Hollow Man and the Covered Hearth..... 313

Chapter Thirty: Of the Rings under the Oaks..... 316

- I. Of the Middens and the Strait..... 316
- II. Of the Salt Road and the Rebuilt Wall..... 318
- III. Of the Word from the North 320
- IV. Of the Road North..... 320
- V. Of the Marks on the Old Bark..... 321
- VI. Of the Oaks Left Standing..... 322
- VII. Of the Lines in His Face 323

Chapter Thirty-one: Of Murchadh in the North..... 326

- I. Of the Spring That Never Freezes 326
- II. Of the Rough Ground and the Boar-Thickets..... 327

III. Of Eithne and of the Sons	329
IV. Of Dùn chrom and the Bank That Faced Two Ways.....	330
V. Of Beathan at the Slab	331
VI. Of the Holy Hill, the Red Well and the Marsh Houses	332
VII. Of the Valleys Given and Taken Back.....	333
VIII. Of the Summons.....	335
Chapter Thirty-two: Of the Great Gathering at the Ford	337
I. Of the Road Down	337
II. Of the Man Who Came Like a Herdsman	339
III. Of the Hands Between His Hands.....	340
IV. Of the Rings in the River	342
V. Of Those Who Did Not Come.....	345
VI. Of the Warm Water	346
Chapter Thirty-three: Of Somhairle's Grave	349
I. Of the Child Who Counted Names	349
II. Of the Years Before the Fire.....	350
III. Of the Line Given Whole	352
IV. Of the Withering.....	354
V. Of the Grave.....	355
VI. Of the Keeping.....	357
Chapter Thirty-four: Of the Stone at Ceann leathan	359
I. Of the Southern Shores	359
II. Of Alasdair, Son of Torradh	362
III. Of the Stone That Would Not Be Lifted.....	363
IV. Of the Years That Followed.....	365
V. Of the Ford.....	367
PART SIX: CATRÌONA MHÒR AND THE FORD	369
Chapter Thirty-five: Of the Green Axes and the Moor	370
I. Of the Axes That Were Never Swung.....	370
II. Of the Quarry Forsaken and the Moor That Came Down	371
III. Of the Stepping-Stones and the Drowning at the Ford	373
IV. Of the Twenty-Two Marks, and the Ground That Would Not Sit Still	374
V. Of Niall, Born to Raonaid.....	376
VI. Of the Share Ìomhar Asked For.....	377
Chapter Thirty-six: Of Dùn dhearg.....	379
I. Of the Fields East of the Vein	379
II. Of Ailis.....	381

III. Of the Double Bank.....	383
IV. Of the Seal-Skins and the Ford.....	384
V. Of the Salt Carried Home	387

Chapter Thirty-seven: Of the Two Lists and the Asking of the Nine.....389

I. Of the Last Fields and the Last Fords.....	389
II. Of Catriona	390
III. Of the Two Lists.....	391
IV. Of the Cord and the Districts	393
V. Of the Handful That All Burned Together	394
VI. Of the Column and the Old Middens	395
VII. Of the Asking of the Nine.....	396
VIII. Of Her Growing Years	398

Chapter Thirty-eight: Of the Shares Counted 400

I. Of the Hill Left to No One	400
II. Of the Marriages Made for a Share	402
III. Of Raonaid's Share Taken Back	404
IV. Of Niall Sent East	406
V. Of the Word Sent Back	407

Chapter Thirty-nine: Of the Tents in the Valley 410

I. Of the Eve as It Stood	410
II. Of the Father's Three Hundred and Eighth Year	412
III. Of the Tents and the Steward to Each Line	414
IV. Of Gille-Bride Come Down	415
V. Of the King's Answer.....	418

Chapter Forty: Of the Ford below Dùn dhearg..... 421

I. Of the Camp under Artair mac Fhearghail	421
II. Of the Man Alone at the Ford	423
III. Of the First Day	424
IV. Of the Second Day	426
V. Of the Third Day	428
VI. Of the Fall.....	429
VII. Of the Fire on the East Bank	430

THE ANNALS OF THE AGE 433

The Years GE 1 – 250	434
The Years GE 251 – 500	443
The Years GE 501 – 750	450
The Years GE 751 – 1,000	460
The Years GE 1,001 – 1,250	464

The Years GE 1,251 – 1,500	470
The Years GE 1,501 – 1,750	476
The Years GE 1,751 – 2,000	480
The Years GE 2,001 – 2,250	485
The Years GE 2,251 – 2,500	491
The Years GE 2,501 – 2,750	519
The Years GE 2,751 – 3,000	521
The Years GE 3,001 – 3,250	526
The Years GE 3,251 – 3,500	531
The Years GE 3,501 – 3,750	533
The Years GE 3,751 – 4,000	535
The Years GE 4,001 – 4,250	537
The Years GE 4,251 – 4,500	539
The Years GE 4,501 – 4,603	548
 A GAZETTEER OF THE AGE	 553
 THE APPENDICES	 575
Appendix A. The King, Rìghrean na Cloiche and An Cnoc Ruadh.....	577
Appendix B. The Reverence of the Hearths	585
Appendix C. Reckoning: Years from the Grove, na Bliadhnachan Fada and the Turning Year	591
Appendix D. Peoples: Seann-Dhaoine, the Hill-Folk and the East.....	597
Appendix E. Land and Trade: the Ford, the Roads and the Weather	603

PART ONE

The Grove and the Hill

CHAPTER ONE

Of the Seven Nights

GE I

Chaidh e dhan doire na ghille, is thill e na rìgh. He went into the
grove a lad, and he came back a king.
— said of Ailean Mòr, as the reciters of Dùn ìseal keep it

I

Of the Fires under the Oaks

Coinneach mac Shuibhne tells this, in the years before he grew grey, and Clann na Ceiste¹ have kept his words whole, changing nothing, for they say a true thing need not be improved.

Coinneach was three years younger than his brother, a lad of one-and-twenty that summer, and he had followed him north with a sack of oatcake and a skin of buttermilk that his brother would not eat. He did not know, when he set out, that he would not be let nearer than the edge of the trees.

Ailean had been gone the better part of a year, carrying his six pots on a pole across his shoulders, each with its lid of turf, feeding six fires that had never before burned in one place. Their father asked no questions of him before he went, and none of the household did either, for it was known in Clann na Ceiste, as it had been known since the mason's day, that the coals were not a thing to be asked about. Coinneach had watched him go with the same silence the others kept, had held it two seasons, and then could hold it no longer. He told no one where he was walking, and simply went, north and further north, by the roads his brother must have taken, until on an evening in high summer he came out of birch scrub

1. the Children of the Question

onto a rise above a stand of oaks and saw smoke going up through the leaves in six colours, and knew he had found him.

He came down through the trees meaning to walk straight in, and got no further than the first oaks.

It was not a hand that stopped him, nor a word, though a word came soon enough. It was the ground itself, or the air over it, which changed the way water changes when it goes suddenly from a stream's cold to a spring's warmth, so that a man's skin knows it before his eyes have found any reason. Coinneach stood with one foot already lifted to the next step and could not set it down inside the ring of oaks. He looked and there was Ailean, sitting cross-legged in a clearing with six low fires around him each burning in its own colour, gold and white and a red so dark it looked nearly black, and copper-red, and a fire like beaten silver, and a sixth with no more colour to it than any hearth-flame has, though it stood straighter than any hearth-flame ought to stand. In the middle of the six, on the bare earth, lay a small stone burning with a low light of no colour he could name, for it was every colour at once and none of them would hold still.

His brother sat with his head unturned, and it was the shape beside him that spoke, tall as a standing man and made of the same grey as the smoke that went up past it without disturbing it at all.

"That is close enough," it said, not loudly, and yet Coinneach heard it as clearly as if it had been at his shoulder. "Go back to the trees. Camp there if you will. Come no nearer while the fires burn."

"I am his brother," said Coinneach, because it seemed a thing that ought to be said to whatever this was.

"I know whose brother you are," said the shape, and there was no unkindness in it, only the flat certainty of a being that had watched a very great deal and found little of it needed explaining twice. "That is why you are let stand where you stand, and not sent further off than that. Go back to the trees."

Ailean turned his head then, once, and looked at him across the fires, and Coinneach saw that his brother's face in that light was the same face he had grown up beside, and yet lit from some place behind the eyes as well as in front of them, the way a horn lantern is lit from within, and not merely warmed on the outside by a fire someone else has made. He did not speak. He lifted one hand a little way from his knee, which Coinneach took, rightly, for all the greeting he was going to get, and then his brother's eyes went back to the fires and did not come to him again that night.

Coinneach went back to the trees. He was one-and-twenty years old and he had walked the length of the island on a road with no end that he had been told of, and he sat down under a birch with his sack of oatcake between his knees and did not eat any of it, because eating in front of a fast felt to him like a kind of theft.

He had grown up three years behind his brother in the same house, under the same low roof, and had thought, until that summer, that there was little enough about Ailean he did not already know: which shoulder he favoured carrying a lamb, which songs he sang badly and on purpose to make the younger children laugh, how long he could hold his breath under the mill-pool. Their father had said nothing when Ailean took up the coals; he had only watched him go with the flat, unsurprised look of a man watching a debt come due that he had long known was owed, and had said nothing either when Coinneach, two seasons on, packed a sack of his own and went after him without leave asked or given. What sent Coinneach north, in truth, was simpler than disobedience: a year is a long time for a house to sit waiting on news of one son, and Coinneach had never in his life been good at waiting. He did not know, sitting there, that this was the first of seven nights, or that he would keep every one of them awake, or that the deeds he watched from outside a ring of trees that summer would be the only true account any teller after him would ever have of what was done inside it. He knew only that his brother's face had changed, and that he meant to be there when it changed back, if it ever did.

II

Of the Seven Nights

The vigil within the ring belongs to Sloinneadh a' Chlachair¹ to tell, for Coinneach was never let see it; they keep it word for word, as it has come down from the grove itself, and it is set here as they set it, against what Coinneach watched from the trees.

Ailean sat among the seven fires (the seventh, the stone in the ring's centre, had taken light at dusk when the shape called Coimhdeach na Fine² stooped over it, and burned after that with no colour that could be named, being every colour,

1. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

2. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

and none of them still), and Coimhdeach na Fine stood over him and told him how the watch must be kept.

"Stay with them until they are cold," it said. "Do not leave them, do not sleep far from them, and eat nothing while they burn."

"Why?" said Ailean.

"So that the spirits, being merged, may know one keeper, and the fire go into no hand but the hand that did not leave it."

"And after me?" said Ailean. "Will my children have it?"

Coimhdeach na Fine was a long while answering. The six fires and the seventh burned on between them without a sound, and the smoke of them stood up straight through windless air.

"It will be yours," it said at last, "and no one's after you. Your children will have a little of it, and their children less, as a hearthstone keeps the heat a while when the fire is out; and then your line will not have it, and will forget that it ever had, and the island will call you a tale. But hear this, and keep it. When strangers hold this island, the fire will wake again in your line."

"What strangers?"

"That is not given to me to say."

Then Coimhdeach na Fine went from him, or ceased to be seen, which Sloin-neadh a' Chlachair does not tell apart, and Ailean was left alone among the fires to keep his watch.

He kept it as he had been told. He did not leave the ring, and did not sleep far from it, and ate nothing while the seven fires burned, though he drank from the grove's own spring on the nights the fires stood steady enough to be left a while. The first two nights the hunger in him was a plain, animal thing, no different from any hunger he had carried on any long ride before; by the third it had gone quiet, the way pain goes quiet in a wound that will either mend or kill and has stopped asking a man's opinion on which. On the fifth night he thought he heard voices in the fires, low under the sound the flames made, saying the same words over that he could never afterward recall, only as a rhythm, the way a chant is remembered by its beat after its language is lost; and on the seventh he could not have said, waking or not waking, whether he had slept at all, for the fires gave the same light and the same warmth at the black heart of that night as they had at the first evening's dusk, unspent, unlesened, as if the passing of six nights meant no more to them than the passing of six breaths.

Outside the ring, under his birch, Coinneach kept a watch of his own, with no gods to answer his questions and no fires to warm him and no lid of turf to hold his hunger down. Through the first night he lay on his back and watched the light of the seven fires stand and shift between the trunks, colours he had no names for laid over colours he did, gold on birch-bark, the black-red flickering against a stone he could not see round, and told himself he would sleep an hour and did not sleep at all. By the second night the hunger had settled into a duller ache than hunger, a low ache he had stopped arguing with, and he found he could watch the coloured light for longer stretches without his mind wandering off after food or home or his father's face when he learned where his younger son had gone. By the third and fourth he had stopped counting the nights as nights and begun counting them as fires, one fire more burned down toward whatever it was burning down toward, though from where he lay none of the seven ever seemed to burn down at all.

It was on the fifth night that he first heard the voices.

He was not sure, after, that he had heard anything, and he never claimed more than that he had. They came from the direction of the ring, under the light and the smoke-smell and the small settling sounds any fire makes, two voices or three, pitched too low for words, one of them — he would say this only once, near the end of his own life, to the woman who wrote it down — sounding almost as if it were his brother's, though shaped into a rhythm Ailean had never used in speech, more like a man saying the same word over and over to hold a thing steady in his mind. Coinneach sat up under the birch and listened until the muscles of his neck ached with listening, and heard nothing more he could swear to, and lay back down with the hunger and the cold and the sense, new to him that night, that a thing was happening within the ring of oaks that had no plain edges to it, that could not be watched the way a fight or a birth or a burial could be watched, only felt at, the way a man feels at a wall in the dark.

He did not go nearer. He had been told to keep to the trees, and he kept to them, and that is the whole of what Coinneach mac Shuibhne did for seven nights: he kept to the trees, and did not eat, though no one had forbidden him to, and did not sleep, though no one had asked that of him either, and watched colours he could not name go up through leaves he could, until he no longer knew which watch was his brother's and which was his own.

III

Of the Eighth Night

Here the two tellings run together, for on the eighth night there was a thing that both saw, though neither saw the same thing, and Clann na Ceiste¹ keep both accounts and do not choose between them.

On the seventh night Ailean could not afterward say whether he had slept. The fires had not burned low in seven nights, had shown him no more fuel spent than on the first evening, and had not needed his hand at any of them; and on the eighth night, without warning and without sound, they went out. All seven together. He came to himself, or woke, Sloinneadh a' Chlachair² will not say which, and found the ring of oaks entirely dark, the pots and the pale stone lying grey and cold on the trodden leaves, and himself colder than he had been in any of the nights before, as if the fires had been lending him their own warmth all along and had just then called the loan due.

Outside the trees, at the same hour by whatever reckoning either of them kept afterward, Coinneach saw the dark come down over the grove and felt some weight go out of the night with it, some pressure he had not known was on him until it lifted. He got to his feet. More than once in seven nights he had meant to walk in regardless of what stood there and see for himself what had become of his brother, and each time some pull in the air of the place had turned him back before he had gone three steps. Now, with the fires dead and the grove black as any wood at midnight, he found his feet would carry him no better than before. Standing at the edge of the oaks with his hand on a trunk, he felt the bark shiver, very faintly, the way a held breath shivers a man's chest, and then the grove filled with light.

It did not come up from the ground as the seven fires had, and it was not the colour of any fire he had seen in his life. It came in among the trees the way people come into a hall, many at once, talking low, and it moved. Coinneach saw shapes crossing between the trunks that his mind, afterward, could give no better name than shapes: a big one that laughed without a sound reaching him, one small and quick that he took, for no reason he could give, to be carrying fire in her own two hands, one bent low as though listening at the ground. He never named them, all his life, though others named them for him later out of Aithris a' Chruthachaidh³,

1. the Children of the Question

2. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

and he would not say they were wrong, only that he had not known, standing at the edge of the trees with his hand shaking on the bark, which name went with which shape.

He tried to go in, setting his foot forward the way he had tried every night before it, and his foot would not carry him; this time it was not only the ground that refused him, for his whole body stood at the edge of that light the way a man stands at the edge of a cliff in the dark, knowing the ground is there and not trusting his legs to find it. Once he called his brother's name. Nothing in the light answered him, and after a while the light began to thin, the shapes going from many to few to none, until only the grey stillness of an ordinary wood before dawn was left among the oaks, and Coinneach sat down where he stood, because his legs had at last stopped holding him up, and waited for the sky to go from black to grey in its own time, the way skies do whether gods have walked a wood that night or not.

IV

Of the Warm Arm and the Road South

What was done to Ailean between the fires going out and the light coming in, no one now living was let see; what was said to him, and by whom, and what he answered, Clann na Ceiste³ keep as it was given them, and it is not this telling's place to add to it or take from it.

Dawn found Coinneach still sitting at the edge of the trees with his back against an oak, and the sun perhaps a hand's width up when a figure came out of the grove toward him, walking easily, as a man walks who has slept well and eaten and has nowhere urgent to be. It was a little while before Coinneach's eyes, sore with a week of watching, made the figure into his brother, and longer still before he trusted the making.

He got up. His legs had gone stiff with a night's sitting and he stumbled the first step, and Ailean put out an arm and caught him, the ordinary way an older brother catches a younger one who has stumbled, and it was that arm, closing on his own, that told Coinneach the truth of the night before any word did. It was

3. the Telling of the Making

1. the Children of the Question

warm. Not warm as a living arm is warm, blood-warm, the warmth a man carries without noticing it in himself and only feels in another when the morning is cold; this was warm the way a hearthstone is warm long after the fire has gone out and been swept, a warmth with weight to it, that seemed to come up out of the bone rather than lie on the skin. Coinneach had held his brother's arm a thousand times in one-and-twenty years and he had never felt anything like it, and he did not let go at once, though he knew, holding it, that he ought to.

"You're cold," Ailean said, as if that were the only strange thing about the morning.

Coinneach found he could not, for a space, make any words come. When they came they were not the ones he had spent seven nights preparing. "What happened to you," he said, "in there," and even as he said it he heard how small a question it was for what he had watched from outside the ring.

Ailean looked at him a while before he answered, and something crossed his face that Coinneach, in all the years he told this tale afterward, could never settle on a single word for: not joy, though there was joy in it; not fear, though there was fear in it too; nearer, he came to think in his old age, to the look of a man newly returned from a country whose language he has learned well enough to think in, and cannot just then remember how to render into the one his own people speak.

"They named me king," he said.

That was all. Who had named him, he did not say, though Coinneach, standing there with his brother's warm arm still half in his grip, thought he knew well enough without being told, having watched shapes cross a lit grove all night from the wrong side of its trees. What a king was king of, on an island that had never had one, went unsaid too, and what had been put into him, or taken from him; nor did he ask his brother to swear any silence about it, for he seemed to know already, in some way Coinneach could not follow, that there was no danger of Coinneach's telling more than he had seen, since Coinneach had seen almost nothing at all.

They went back into the ring together, Ailean walking as if the ground of it held no more weight for him than any other ground now, and Coinneach following a half-step behind, still not wholly easy in himself about crossing that line of oaks even with the fires long out and his brother's hand on his shoulder. The six pots lay where they had stood for seven nights, empty and cold, their turf lids scattered where the wind or something less than wind had thrown them; the pale stone that had held the seventh fire lay among them, small and grey and giving off

no more warmth to the eye than any stone off any hillside, though when Coinneach at last made himself touch it, near midday, it was warm too, in the same deep hearthstone way his brother's arm had been. Ailean gathered the six pots onto his shoulder-pole without a word, as though he meant to carry them on somewhere, though he never lit any of the six fires in them again in all his life, and left the seventh stone lying where it lay, uncovered, among the leaves.

They did not go home. Coinneach asked once, that first morning, whether they were for their father's hearth, and Ailean said only that they were going south, and began walking, and Coinneach, having followed him a year's worth of roads already, followed him down this one too.

He did not stop at Na Glinn Àrda², where the households of Clann na Ceiste kept their herds about the crack in the ground that no one living could remember the naming of, though he had kin enough there to have stopped a season among them and been fed and questioned and made much of; and some of those kin, seeing him go by without turning aside, left their own hearths and their own herds and walked out onto the road after him without being asked, the way men will follow a fire seen at night across open country before they have decided in their own minds to go anywhere at all. By the time the grove was three days behind them there were eleven of them walking south with Ailean and his brother, kin near and kin distant, none of them able afterward to say clearly why he had left byre or field to do it, only that the sight of Ailean walking past his own people's gates without stopping had seemed a thing that could not be let go by unfollowed.

V

Of the Kin Who Followed

This part of the road Coinneach told plainly, having been on it himself and needing no fires and no Coimhdeach na Fine¹ to tell it by.

They were an odd company to look at from any rise above the road: a king who had been a king nine days, walking at no great pace and carrying six empty pots on a pole across his shoulder as though they still held cargo worth the carry-

2. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

1. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

ing; his brother a half-step behind him, hollow-eyed from a week without food or sleep and saying little; and behind the two of them, by the time Na Glinn Àrda² were a day's walk gone, eleven more, none of whom had set out that morning meaning to leave home at all.

A woman with a baby on her hip had been driving geese in from a field when Ailean passed her gate; she left the geese to find their own way back and simply fell in on the road, the baby asleep against her shoulder before the first mile was out and no more roused by the change in her life than by any other jolt of the walking. An old man who had buried two wives and outlived a third said, when his daughter asked him where he thought he was going at his age, only that he had a feeling in his chest he had not had since he was a boy and did not intend to argue with it. There was a boy of nine who came because his older cousin came, and a stooped-shouldered woman with a limp who kept pace with the rest of them without complaint or explanation the whole way south, and would not be persuaded home again even when the going grew hard. None of the eleven, asked afterward, could give a better account of why he or she had come than the old man's: a feeling in the chest, not to be argued with.

Ailean spoke little to any of them on the road, and to Coinneach hardly more, though he let his brother walk always at his shoulder and never once told him to turn back, which Coinneach, in the years he had left to think on it, came to count for more than any number of words would have been worth. Twice they slept in the open under no roof at all, and both nights it was noticed, though not spoken of loudly, that the ground near where Ailean lay was warmer by morning than the ground a little further off, warm enough that the heavy dew that greyed the rest of the field left a bare, dark ring around him the size of a sleeping man, as though the ground itself remembered him from the night before it had ever been asked to.

They did not hurry. Ailean walked as a man walks who knows the road will still be there whether he covers it in ten days or twenty, and stopped where there was water and shelter and went on again when he chose and not before, and slowly, day by day, the sack Coinneach had carried north with such care went from full to half-full to empty, shared out among a company that had grown too large for one man's forethought to feed, and nobody starved, and nobody afterward could quite say how that had been managed either.

2. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

Coinneach walked among them the whole way south, and told none of them what he had watched from outside the ring of oaks. He had sworn no oath of silence; he had simply found, trying the words over to himself on the road, that they came out smaller than the thing they were meant to carry, the way a bucket of well-water looks like less once it is out of the well than it did going down for it. He kept the telling instead, turning it over through the long days of walking, fitting it to itself the way a man fits a stone to a gap in a dry wall, testing each piece against what he had truly seen and setting aside what he had only half seen or wholly imagined in the dark under the birch; and it was in this way, walking south behind his brother down a road that had no name yet because there had been no one before them to walk it and give it one, that the first account of the seven nights and the eighth was made, by a man of one-and-twenty who had been let see none of it, and who therefore, of all who ever told it after, was the most careful never to say more than he knew.

CHAPTER TWO

Of the Knapper's Son

GE 1 – 2

*At the flint-pit below Dùn ìseal, where the ground is still pocked
with old workings, the spear-makers tell this among themselves,
and have told it to their sons.*

I

Of the Watch on the Lip of the Hill

The lad's father worked flint in a pit behind the houses, and had worked it there since before the lad was born, so that the boy grew up knowing the smell of struck stone the way another child knows the smell of bread. He was thirteen that summer, old enough to be set to watching and too young for much else, and it was his turn, with three others no older, to sit on the lip of the hill and watch the valley road for cattle-thieves and for worse.

The hill had no name then but the hill. It stood over the meeting of two streams, with byres and forty-some houses scattered along its shoulder and no bank round any of it, for the valleys had never needed one; the worst that came up that road in most summers was a hard bargain over grazing, or a drunk man from the next household with a grievance three years old. The lad sat with his knees drawn up and a spear across them that had been his father's, and had been his father's father's before that, and watched the road go down into the haze where the valley bent west.

He saw them a long way off: a string of figures on the track below the ford, twelve of them by his later count, walking without haste and without the shuffle of people driving beasts. No dust rose with them, for there had been rain three

days before, and no baggage showed on any back that he could see. He watched a while longer than he should have, the way a boy watches something he cannot name a fear for, and then he ran.

He came down through the houses shouting that there were strangers on the road, twelve strangers walking, and by the time he reached the gate of his own house half the hill had heard him and were coming out with whatever lay nearest the door. His father came out of the pit still holding the antler tool he worked with, and looked at his son and then down the road, and said nothing, which the lad took worse than if he had shouted.

The holders of the hill gathered every spear they owned, which came to some sixty, old and new, well-made and poor, and stood in a crowd on the steepest part of the slope, where anyone climbing would have the ground against him. The lad stood among the men with his father's second-best spear, for the best had gone to his uncle, who had a longer reach. He was not told to stand there. No one told him to go home either, and by the time anyone thought of it the twelve had reached the foot of the hill, and it was too late to send a boy anywhere without being seen to do it.

II

Of the Twelve at the Foot of the Slope

The twelve stopped where the ground began to rise, all but one of them, a man the lad's eye kept sliding past and back to, for he stood taller than the rest by a head and something more, though nothing else about him marked him out: no gold, no fine cloth, nothing in his hands. He came on alone, up the grass, at the pace of a man walking to his own door.

The lad said afterward, when he was old and had told the tale more times than he could count, that every man on that slope had meant to throw. He had meant to throw himself, and had thought about the throw the way his father had taught him, weight back, elbow up, and had been glad of the practice. The man came up within a long cast, and then well within an easy one, and the lad did not throw, and could not afterward say why not; only that somewhere between one breath and the next a warmth had come onto his face, as though a door had opened on a kiln a field away, and his arm, which had been ready, simply did not do what he had told it.

Nor was he alone in it. Beside him the eldest of the hill's holders, a man who had led them through two bad winters and a feud with the next valley and had never in the lad's knowing been slow to act, let the point of his spear down into the grass, and then let the shaft go after it, and sat down where he stood with his face in his hands, as a man sits down who has been struck somewhere no wound shows. One by one the rest did something of the kind: let their spears fall, or turned and went back down into the houses without a word to anyone, walking the way a man walks from a hearth he has just been told is not his any longer.

The tall man walked through the middle of them as a man walks through standing barley, touching nothing, looking at no one long enough to be looked back at, and went on up to the crown of the hill, and stood there turning slowly, taking in the valleys on every side as though he were counting them. After a while he called down the slope, in a voice that carried without being raised, for someone to bring him water.

No one moved. The lad found that his legs, which had failed him in one way a few minutes before, were willing enough now, and he went up the hill with the water-skin his mother kept filled by the door, because it was nearer to hand than thinking twice, and because a boy of thirteen does not weigh the same things a grown man weighs.

III

Of the Water and the Spear

Up close the man was less strange and more so both together. His face was a young man's face, unweathered in a way that did not fit a life spent walking hill roads, and the lad, who had an eye for ages from watching his father's customers come and go, put him at four-and-twenty and never once, in all the years he knew him after, found cause to change the guess. His eyes, when they came round to the boy, were patient in a way the lad had no word for then and only found one for much later, when he was old himself and had watched enough patient men. He took the skin and drank, unhurried, and handed it back, and looked at the boy properly for the first time.

"What is your name?"

The lad gave it.

"Is that your father's spear?"

"His second-best," the lad said, before he had decided to say anything at all. "The best went to my uncle."

The man looked at the spear a moment, not long, the way a man who knows tools looks at one that is neither good nor bad. "Take it back to him," he said. "Tell him I shall want a great many more."

That was the whole of it. He turned from the boy and looked out again over the valleys, north and south and along the line of the streams, and the lad went back down the hill with the water-skin empty and the spear heavy in his hand in a way it had not been an hour before, though nothing about the spear had changed.

The houses talked that night as the lad had never heard them talk, in low voices round hearths where the doors were shut earlier than usual, and every household had its own account of the moment its spears had gone down, none quite agreeing with its neighbour's, and none of them, the lad noticed even at thirteen, willing to say plainly that they had been afraid. His father sat a long while turning the spear over in his hands after the boy gave him the king's word, saying nothing, and at last hung it back on its pegs over the door and told his son to bank the fire and go to bed, in the same voice he used on any ordinary night, though the lad lay awake past the last of the talk outside and heard his father still sitting by the hearth when he finally slept.

IV

Of the Households Coming In

What came after was slower than the taking, and stranger in its own way for being slow. Through that first summer and into the next, the households of the valleys about the hill came in to the tall man one after another, a family at a time, like water finding its level with no one to drive it there. No word went out that the lad ever heard of; they simply came, walking up with whatever they thought a king should be given, which varied enormously, for none of them had ever given anything to a king before. Some brought hides. One old woman brought a pot of her own making and nothing else, and the man took it and thanked her by name, though no one had told him her name, and she went home and told everyone who would listen that he had known her before she spoke.

They told him where their grazing ran and asked him to hold the telling of it, for a valley that had quarrelled every spring past memory of the oldest man living had begun, within a season of his coming, to want someone outside every household to say where one man's grass ended and the next man's began. They brought their quarrels too, old ones some of them, older than the lad, disputes over a strip of ground or a dead man's cattle that had gone unsettled so long that both sides had half forgotten what had started them and kept them running out of habit more than grievance.

He heard the first of these on the open ground below the crown of the hill, where the grass was already beaten thin from the households' coming and going, and the lad was there among a crowd of forty or fifty who had come to watch, for there was nothing else that summer worth leaving off work for.

V

Of the First Judgement

The two households in it held land on either side of a strip of pasture between two becks, and each swore the strip for its own, and each brought an old man to say so, and the old men disagreed with each other in exactly the words their fathers were said to have used, so that the lad, listening, had the strange feeling of hearing an argument that had never once changed in forty years.

The king, for so the hill had begun to call him among themselves though no one had heard him claim the word, let both sides finish. He asked one question only, of the elder of the two old men: which household's cattle grazed the strip the summer the boundary stone at the beck's mouth had last been moved. The old man answered without thinking, the way a man answers a question he has never once considered might matter, and in the answering gave away the case he had come to argue, for his own memory put the other household's cattle on the ground in that year, before the stone was moved.

"Then it is theirs," the king said, "and has been since before either of you were troubling your fathers about it. Move the stone back and be done."

That was the whole of the judgement, said as a man says which way the wind is, and it left both households standing where they were for a moment as though a wall they had leaned on all their lives had been taken away without warning. The one that lost the strip went home saying nothing worse than that the old fool had

talked himself out of his own land, which was true and did not comfort him. The one that won it went home quieter than a household should go home from a victory, and the lad's father said, that night, that he had never in his life seen men so glad to be told what to do, nor so frightened of the man who had told them.

Other judgements followed through that year and the next, on smaller matters mostly, a stolen calf, a well two families both claimed to have dug, a marriage promised and not kept, and each was settled in the same handful of words, without appeal and, so far as the lad ever heard, without a single household going back afterward to argue the finding a second time. The valley people began to say among themselves, half in complaint and half in something nearer relief, that a man could no longer nurse a grudge on that hill the way his father had nursed his, for there was somewhere now to take it and be rid of it in an afternoon.

VI

Of the Warmth with No Fire

It was in that first winter, when the snow lay longer on the hill than the oldest people could remember it lying, that the thing happened which the hearths of Dùn ìseal still tell before any other, though the lad himself did not see it and had it only at second hand, from a girl a year or two older than himself who swore to it all her life and was believed.

She had gone out past the houses one clear, bitter night to see to a beast that had strayed near the king's own fire, which he kept apart from the rest and let no one tend, and found herself standing nearer him than she had ever stood, closer than she had meant to come. She told it that she had expected to feel the cold worse there, in the open, away from any hearth of her own; instead she felt warm through, as a person feels warm sitting close by a good fire banked high, though there was no fire near her at all, only the king standing with his back half to her, looking at nothing she could see. Neither of them spoke a word. She stood there long enough to grow uneasy at her own staying, and went back to the beast and the byre, and was warm, she said, the whole walk back, though the night did not warm around her; only she did.

She told it once to her mother and was told to keep it to herself, and did, mostly, until she was old and telling it cost her nothing anyone could use against her. By then half the hill had a story like it, of standing near him on a cold night,

or a hot one, and coming away changed in temperature without a fire to blame; and no one who told such a story could say why they had never thought, at the time, to ask him about it.

VII

Of the Pit and the Word Kept

The word the king had sent back with the lad's spear was not forgotten on either side. Through that autumn the flint-pit behind the houses worked longer hours than it had in the lad's memory, his father and his uncle and two men taken on from a household that had come in late, cutting and knapping spearheads by the score where before they had made them a few at a time, as they were needed and no faster.

The lad was set to help before the leaves were fully down: fetching stone from the outcrop above the pit, sorting the good nodules from the flawed, learning under his father's hand the strike that split a piece clean and the strike that shattered it for nothing. He was not good at it that first year, and his father told him so without unkindness, the way a man tells a boy a true thing he expects him to outgrow. What the lad was good at, from the start, was watching: he had watched the taking of the hill from close enough to remember every part of it, and he watched now, at his father's elbow, the way a spearhead came out of a piece of stone the way a fish comes out of water, all at once and not at all by accident.

Word came up from the king's own steward, before the first snow, of how many heads the pit was to have ready by the turning of the year, and the number was larger than the lad's father had ever cut for one order, larger by a good deal than the whole hill had needed for its own use in a generation. His father took the order without complaint and without haste either, and set to teaching his son faster than he might otherwise have done, for there was more work now than two men and two hired hands could easily carry, and a third pair of hands that could be trusted, even a clumsy pair, was worth the teaching of it.

By the depth of that winter the lad could strike a passable head three times in five, which his father allowed was better than most boys managed in a year, and the lad understood, without being told in so many words, that the pit behind his father's house had become, in the space of one summer and one autumn, the

place spears came from for a king who had said he would want a great many more, and had meant it.

VIII

Of the Ring Pegged in the Snow

The bank was begun in that same hard winter, which surprised the hill more than the king's coming had, for no one builds earthworks in frost if it can be helped, and the ground on the hill's crown was iron by the turning of the year. Yet it was in the snow, not after it, that the king walked the crown of the hill with a bundle of pegs cut from ash and set them himself, one after another, pacing out a line that took in the old byres and left room, he said, for houses that were not built yet.

The households worked it in shifts through the worst of that winter, breaking frozen turf with mattocks that blunted faster than they could be sharpened, and the lad's father sent flint scrapers up to the diggers when the antler picks gave out, so that for a stretch of days the bank of Dùn iséal was cut as much with worked stone as with anything else, an oddness the old people of the hill still mention when the bank is spoken of at all. The lad went up himself on the days his father could spare him, and stood in the line passing frozen clods hand to hand along the ditch, and remembered afterward mostly the cold in his fingers and the steam that stood over sixty or eighty people working close together in the freeze, so that from a little way off the whole crown of the hill seemed to smoke like a fire banked for the night.

The king worked among them on the days he was there, which were not all of them, for he was already riding out to valleys beyond the first ring of them and coming back only every so often; but on the days he set his own hand to the ditch the work went faster, not because anyone slacked when he was gone, the lad's father always said, but because no one wanted to be the one found idle when he came back unlooked-for. By the time the frost broke, the line of the ditch ran round the crown of the hill, a raw scar in the turf a spade deep, marking room, when the last house should be fitted into it, for some forty households. It was a scar and no more. The bank itself, raised to a man's height and closed at its gate, was eight more summers in the building, for the households dug when the graz-

ing and the harvest let them and not otherwise; but the lad always said that the ring was made that winter, in the snow, and that the rest was only earth.

I X

Of Those Who Were Brought Down

It was in the first days after the frost broke that a small company came down out of Na Glinn Àrda¹ to the north, where no one on the hill had thought to look for anyone belonging to the king, for he had never spoken of a household of his own, and the hill had half decided, in the way a hill will decide things without anyone saying them aloud, that he had none. It learned afterward that he had gone north himself in the first autumn, on one of the ridings it had taken for the bringing-in of further valleys, and stayed a month in Na Glinn Àrda with his own, and come back alone to the digging.

There was a woman among them, somewhere in her middle years, with the bearing of someone used to being minded rather than minding, and a girl of some seven or eight years walking close beside her with a child's face set hard the way a child's face sets when it has learned to be careful; and there were others with them, kin and a few hands to carry what little they brought, for they had come a long way and light. The lad, who was at the gap in the new ditch that day mending a hurdle, watched them come up the same track the twelve had come up the summer before, though slower, and with none of the twelve's stillness; the woman looked about her at the new-cut ditch and the raw turf as a person looks at a place they have been told of and find smaller, or larger, or simply other than the telling.

Word went round the hill before the company had reached the gate that this was the king's own wife and his daughter, brought down at last from wherever he had left them before ever he walked south with eleven others and a name the grove had given him; and by evening it was known, the way such things become known on a hill where everyone's business is everyone's, that the woman was called Muireall, and the girl Gormshuil, and that there was a child not yet born who would be born on the hill itself before the year turned again, the first child of the king's blood, it was already being said, to draw breath inside the new ring.

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

The lad did not speak to any of them that day, nor for some while after, for a knapper's son and a king's wife had little enough cause to cross paths on a hill of forty houses. But he remembered, all his life, the particular quiet that fell over the crown of the hill as the small company passed through the gap left for a gate and the households stood back to let them by, the same quiet, though no one on the hill ever said so aloud, that had fallen on the slope the summer before when sixty spears had come down together without a hand raising one of them; as though the hill had learned, in less than a year, to know a thing worth being quiet for when it saw one coming up the road.

The child came before the summer was out, a son, born inside the new ring as it had been said he would be, and the hill took it for a settled thing after that, the way a household takes a roof for settled once the last thatch is laid: that the king had come to stay among them, and had brought what a man brings when he means to stay, a wife, a daughter, and now a son born on the ground he had taken. The lad's father cut a spearhead that week finer than any he had cut that year, for no order and no payment, and gave it to a neighbour to carry up to the king's fire, and would not say afterward why, only that it had seemed to him a thing that wanted doing. Whether it ever reached the king's hand, or what he made of it if it did, the lad never learned; but he kept, until he was an old man teaching the strike to his own grandsons, the plain conviction that some things are given because the giving is owed, and not because anyone is waiting to be thanked for them.

CHAPTER THREE

OF GORMSHUIL AT THE GATE

GE 2 – 106

I

Of the Watching Child

She was eight when the ditch was pegged round the crown of the hill, old enough to be given a task and trusted to see it through, which on Dùn ìseal in those years meant standing at the gate in the gap of the new ditch and counting who came and went, so that her father, who had never asked for a gatekeeper and had never needed one before the ditch was dug, would have someone to tell him at evening whether the day had brought anything worth his hearing.

Gormshuil took to the work the way some children take to a thing before anyone has decided whether it suits them: without being asked twice, and without complaint, and with a memory for faces that her mother said was not natural in a girl her age and was, all the same, glad of. She knew every household on the hill by the second summer, knew which dog belonged to which byre, knew the traders who came up from the valley with hides and the ones who came with nothing to trade and everything to ask. She stood at the gate in all weathers, wrapped in a plaid too big for her that had been her mother's, and watched the ditch deepen under the diggers' mattocks summer by summer, and the raw earth of the bank rise and harden until, in her fifteenth year, it closed at its gate and no longer looked like a wound in the hill.

Her father she saw less than the diggers saw the ditch. He rode out most mornings with a handful of men and came back most evenings, and some months

he did not come back at all, and word of him arrived instead by whoever had last seen him, three valleys off or five, settling a quarrel or riding through country that had not yet troubled itself to send word of quarrels to anyone. When he was on the hill he sat at the crown of it in the low turf-roofed house that had been built for him and was already too small, and heard whoever came to be heard, and Gormshuil, who by nine had worked out that the gate and the hearing-house stood in a line she could watch both from, took to sitting on the bank between the two of them with her knees drawn up, watching her father the way she watched everyone else who came and went, as though he too were someone she had not yet finished learning.

It was in her twenty-fourth year that word came up from the west, carried by a trader with salt fish who had it from a trader with wool who had it from further off still, that a woman called Beathag Ruadh held a hill on the shore of the great lake, a red hill, he said, though no one on Dùn ìseal had seen it, and that she held it of her own right and not of any king's. Gormshuil, sitting on the bank with the fish-trader's words going round the hearing-house like smoke finding a draught, asked her father that evening whether the red hill's woman meant trouble for them. Her father said that a hill a long way off with its own line of holders was no trouble to anyone, and that trouble, when it came, came from nearer at hand and was easier to see coming than a woman on a lake shore three weeks' walk west. She did not understand then what he meant by it. She understood later, when she had learned that her father rarely answered a question with less in it than the question itself had carried.

II

Of Her Mother's Dying

Muireall had never taken to the hill the way her daughter had. She had come to it already a grown woman, with a way of holding herself that the hill's own women, used to going where the work was and standing where it put them, found hard to place. It read as pride to those who did not know her. The truer word for it was the bearing of someone who had once expected her days to be minded by others and had found herself, past the middle of her life, minding her own, and her husband's besides, in a country she had not chosen. She kept the king's house as well as it could be kept with what the hill af-

forded, bore him two sons on the crown of it after Gormshuil, Dòmhnall in the second year of the bank and Fearchar some years after, and grew, through all of it, thinner and greyer at a pace that her daughter, watching everyone from the gate as she watched everyone, was the first on the hill to notice and the last to say aloud.

Muireall died in the twenty-fourth year of the hill, in an autumn that brought nothing else worth remembering, of no sickness anyone could name and no hurt anyone had seen taken. Gormshuil, thirty that year and past the age where a mother's dying is a child's grief only, sat with her the last two nights and heard nothing from her that the hill later thought fit to keep as a saying, only the ordinary things a dying woman says to a daughter who has sat up with her: where a particular comb had come from, whom a particular debt was owed to, that the youngest boy, Fearchar, was to be watched, for he had a temper his brother lacked and would want checking before it found him trouble he could not talk his way out of.

The king came in from the valleys two days after she was put in the ground, and stood by the mound a long while without anyone daring to go near him, and then went into the hearing-house and heard three cases that had been waiting on him and gave judgement on all three before dark, and never, in all the years his daughter afterward kept the gate and watched him come and go, spoke Muireall's name again where anyone could hear it. Gormshuil, who had expected grief from him and got instead the ordinary business of the hill taken up exactly where it had been left, understood only much later, when she had watched him bury more of his own than any one person should have to bury and go on burying them in the same fashion, what the going-back-to-work truly was: the whole shape grief took in a man who could not be seen to carry it the way other men carried theirs. Other men, in time, stopped carrying it. He never would.

III

Of the Hard Winter and the Warm Ground

Two winters later came the hardest anyone then living on the hill had seen, snow lying from before Samhain until past the turn of the year, deep enough in the high folds of the valley to bury a standing sheep to the back, and the byres on the crown of the hill, never built for more than an ordinary cold, began by midwinter to empty of their own accord: not to wolves, for the wolves

that year kept as much to shelter as the cattle did, but to the cold itself, working on beasts that had nowhere warm enough to stand and nothing left under the snow worth pawing for.

The king was in the north that winter, three valleys off and more, holding some quarrel down that had waited three seasons for him and would not wait a fourth, and no word could be got to him and back again before the herds were finished. It was Gormshuil, thirty-three that year and holding the hill for her father as she had by then held it more times than either of them troubled to count, who gave the order to drive what stock still stood down off the crown of the hill and along the frozen valley floor to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹, where the earth steams the year round and the snow, however hard it falls, does not lie.

It was two days' driving, though the springs lie no more than a morning's walk below the hill in summer, through drifts that in places stood higher than the beasts themselves, with men and dogs both worked past what either would ordinarily be asked, and one night spent in the open on ground too cold for anyone to sleep sound, and Gormshuil walked the whole of it on her own feet at the head of the drive rather than ride, for a rider's beast, she said, ate what a walking man's did not, and every mouthful of fodder they carried was owed to the herd and not to anyone's comfort. They came down onto the warm ground on the second morning with the steam rising off the wet grass into air still hard with frost, and the cattle, smelling it before the drovers had done more than see it, went down the last slope at a run that no amount of driving had got out of them in two days of snow.

She lost none. It was said afterward, and is said still wherever the hill's own reciters keep the tale, that no herd of Dùn iséal's had ever gone into a hard winter and come out the other side of it whole, and that no herd did again for a long while after; and it is said too, by those who keep the harder telling alongside the easier one, that Gormshuil came off that drive with two fingers on her left hand that never afterward bent all the way, and never spoke of them, and wore, from that winter to the end of her life, a glove on that hand in company and bare skin only among her own household, where no one thought to remark on it because everyone had always known.

1. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

IV

Of the Gate and the Years Between

her father married again in her thirty-sixth year, a woman of the valleys called Sorcha, younger than Gormshuil herself by a dozen years and more, which the hill noted and did not remark on aloud, for it had by then grown used to noting things about the king's household that it did not remark on aloud. Sorcha kept the house with less of Muireall's stiffness and more of the valley's easy give-and-take, and bore him two sons in turn, Somhairle first and Iain Dubh some years after, and Gormshuil, who might by rights have resented a stepmother younger than herself keeping the house she had half kept herself since her own mother died, found instead that she liked the woman, and that the liking cost her nothing, for by then she had other things pressing on her that a stepmother's presence did nothing to change one way or the other.

What pressed on her was the gate, and had pressed on her since she was eight, and did not let up now that she was a woman grown with a household and children of her own coming on. Her father rode out each spring with the thaw and came back each autumn with the first hard frost, as regular in it as the seasons themselves, and every year that passed, it seemed to Gormshuil watching from the bank where she had once sat as a child, he came back looking less like a man who had spent a winter riding through weather that aged other men, and more, if anything, like the same young man who had walked south so many summers before with a name the grove had given him and nothing else anyone could point to.

She did not speak of it to him, not in those years, for there was no way to raise the matter that did not sound like an accusation of something neither of them had chosen, and she was not, whatever else she was, a woman who raised what could not be answered. She spoke of it once to Coinneach, her father's brother, who had followed him north those first seven nights with food he would not eat and had stayed by him ever after, growing old in the ordinary way while his brother did not, teaching whoever would learn it *Sloinneadh a' Chlachair*¹ as *Coimhdeach na Fine*² had given it to Ailean in the grove, word for word, changing nothing, for he held, and taught Gormshuil to hold after him, that a true thing needed no improving.

"He does not age," she said to Coinneach, on the bank one autumn evening with her father not yet three days back from the valleys and the light going long

and gold across the crown of the hill. "I have watched him thirty years since the grove and he does not age, and I am beginning to."

Coinneach, who by then had gone the colour of ash himself and moved more slowly than he once had, looked at her a long while before he gave her the nearest thing to an answer he ever would. "I was there the night the fires went out," he said. "What came into the grove, I saw. What it cost him, he has never told me, and I have never asked. Between the two of us, niece, that is a fair division of the matter: he keeps what went into him, and I keep from asking. Take the same division for yourself, if you can bear it."

She bore it, because there was nothing else to be done with it, and because Coinneach himself, who had borne it longer than she had and would not live to see how much longer it went on, seemed to think it bearable. He died the winter she turned sixty-one, an old man by then in every particular, the first teller of her father's deeds and the last of those who had stood outside the grove on the first night and could say what the waiting had been like from the near side of it; and Gormshuil, who took Sloinneadh a' Chlachair from him whole in his last winter, the way he had taken it whole from no one but his own memory of the grove, found that she had, without quite meaning to, become the second person on the hill after her father to carry the whole of it in her head.

V

Of the Grandchildren Who Took Him for Her Son

By her sixtieth year Gormshuil's own hair had gone from the black it had been to a grey that no longer surprised anyone who looked at her, and her back, which had straightened proudly enough through her middle years, had begun to take on the particular stoop of a woman who has spent forty summers standing at a gate in every weather the hill could send. Her children by then had children of their own running loose about the crown of the hill, a generation that had never known a Dùn ìseal without its bank and ditch and took the shape of the place for as given as the hill itself; and it was among these grandchildren, more than anyone older and wiser ought to have allowed, that the confusion first

1. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

2. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

took root that would trouble Clann na Ceiste¹'s tellers for as long as they kept the tale.

The king came in at the gate each autumn a young man, unchanged from the young man who had ridden out each spring, and his daughter who met him there was by then old enough to be anyone's grandmother; and the children, who saw the two of them together perhaps a dozen days in a year and had no memory of a time before Gormshuil was old, took the young man at the gate for her son and not her father, and called him so among themselves, and were not, when the mistake was pointed out to them by an elder who had known both from the start, greatly inclined to unlearn it, for the mistake fit what they saw with their own eyes a good deal better than the truth did.

Gormshuil herself never corrected them past the first few times. It was, she told her eldest granddaughter once, easier to let a child believe a small wrong thing that harmed no one than to make her carry a large true one before she had the years to hold it; and besides, she said, and this she said only the once, and only to the girl, and never again to anyone, there were mornings now when she looked at the young man coming up the gate-track with the autumn light behind him and found the mistake easier to bear herself than the truth was, for a mother growing old beside a son who stayed young is only the ordinary sorrow of the world running backward, while a daughter doing the same beside her father has no shape that the world has a name for yet.

VI

Of the Last Autumn

She was eighty-one the autumn she died, an old woman by every measure the hill kept, bent nearly double by then and blind in one eye from a cataract no one on Dùn iséal had the skill to lift, and she had asked, some months before, to be carried to the gate one last time to see the year's herds brought up off the summer grazing, for she said she had watched every herd come up that track for near seventy years and did not care to break the habit on the strength of dying.

Her father was on the hill that autumn, having come in early, before the frost, as though he had known, though no one afterward could say how a man might

know such a thing, or whether he had known it at all, or only chanced to be there. He sat with her the last two nights of her life in the low house where she had lived since her children grew and left it to her, and those who kept watch outside said only that no voice was raised in it, and no weeping either, only the ordinary small sounds of two people sitting together with a great deal between them and very little of it needing to be said aloud after so long.

It was on the second night, near dawn, that she asked him the thing she had carried since the evening on the bank with Coinneach, more than twenty years dead by then, and had never asked her father himself in all that time, for there had never seemed to be a right hour for it and now, she judged, there would be no other hour at all.

"Does it hurt," she said, "to stay young?"

He did not answer her. Those who were near enough to hear said afterward that he sat a long while with her hand in his, the hand with the two fingers that had never bent right since the winter of the warm ground. What he gave her instead, when at last he spoke, was her name, said once, in the way a man says a name he does not expect to have cause to say again. Whether that was answer enough for her, or no answer at all, or something a daughter and a father had settled between themselves long before that night without either needing the words for it, none of those keeping watch outside the house could say, and none of them ever claimed to know.

She died before the light came up fully over the crown of the hill. The king sat by her a night and a day after that, through the whole of the following day and into the second night, and spoke to no one who came to the door, and ate nothing that was brought to him, and when he came out at last it was to see her put into the ground with his own hands helping to lift the turf, which he had done for no one since Muireall and would do, in na Bliadhnachan Fada¹ that followed, for very few others; and he never, from that day to the last day anyone on the hill saw him, spoke his eldest daughter's name aloud again where another ear could catch it, any more than he had spoken her mother's.

It was then, and not before, that the hill understood in full what its own eyes had been telling it for seventy years and its tongue had been too careful, or too frightened, to say plainly: that na Bliadhnachan Fada the king carried were the grove's alone, given once and given whole to the fires that burned in it, and that

1. the Children of the Question

1. the long years of Ailean's kin

they did not pass by blood to a child got before the grove was ever lit, however much of the king's own bearing and will such a child might carry in every other particular. Gormshuil had carried his stubbornness, his stillness under a question he did not mean to answer, and something in the set of her shoulders at the gate that anyone who had watched him stand at the door of the hearing-house would have known at a glance for his; she had not carried the fire, and would not, and the hill, watching her go into the ground an old bent woman beside a father who looked her grandson's age, understood at last what it would mean for every child of his get after her, and for every child not yet got, and fell, for a season, unusually quiet on the matter, the way a hill falls quiet over a thing too large to be talked through in an evening.

VII

Of Dòmhnall Taking the Hill

òmhnall was seventy-four that year, the eldest of the king's children born after the grove and the first child of his blood to draw breath inside the new bank, and he had none of his half-sister's stoop nor any grey in him at all, for he carried what she had not: a young man's face on a man three-quarters of a century old, and a young man's back besides, straight as a stripped sapling, so that those who saw him take up the seat in the hearing-house that his sister had held for near five decades saw, or thought they saw, no change at all, only the same shape of authority moving from one body to another in a manner too smooth to properly mark as a passing.

It was not, for all that, taken lightly on the hill. Dòmhnall had grown up under his sister's watch as much as under either parent's, for she had kept the gate through the whole of his childhood and a fair part of his manhood besides, and he stood at her grave-mound the morning after the turf was laid with an expression that those who knew him best said they had never seen on him before and rarely saw again, and said, to no one in particular, that he supposed he had better learn to count who came and went, since no one else on the hill seemed inclined to teach him and there was no one left alive who had learned it from the very start the way she had.

He took up the hearing-house within the month, for the hill's business did not wait on grief any more than it had waited on the king's grief for Muireall fifty

years before, and the reciters, setting his name down after his sister's in the eldest of the spoken lists, called him third of Rìghrean na Cloiche¹ and left the gap between his naming and hers, eighty years and more by the tellers' later count, standing in the record exactly as long as it had stood in the life of the hill, for that, the reciters held, was itself a kind of truth-telling, and no one who came after them ever thought to shorten it.

1. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

CHAPTER FOUR

OF THE STONES IN THE Valley AND THE CHAIR OF BIRCH

GE 107 – 227

At Dùn ìseal the boundary stones still stand in the grass below the bank, and the holders of the valley tell this against their own name, for it is a telling that gives them no credit.

I

Of the Setting of the Stones

Òmhnaill Clachach had held the hill a little over thirty years when he first thought of the stones, and he thought of them the way a man thinks of a thing he has put off too long, for the idea was old with him already, and it was the quarrels that brought it back each spring, wearing at last through his patience, that gave it a shape worth acting on. He was a son born after the grove, and though he did not yet look it, he had crossed a hundred years, and something in a hundred years of hearing the same two households swear the same strip of grazing to different fences had taught him that a king's word settled a dispute for exactly as long as it took the disputants to forget who had lost.

He came to it standing over Gormshuil's grave one morning in early summer, which he did more often than he told anyone, for she had held the hill before him and he had loved her as a man loves an elder sister who dies old while he stays young, a grief that has no clean place to sit. Two households of the eastern slope

were at their fences again that week, the third time in four years, over a strip of poor grass between two becks that neither side wanted badly enough to fight for and neither would give up for pride. He judged it as his father judged such things, in a sentence, and watched both households go home no gladder than they had come; and it came to him, walking back up to the bank in the last of the light, that his father settled quarrels one at a time because there was always a father to settle the next one, but that a valley needed something that did not depend on a man being there to ask.

He set the stones himself, that summer and into the one after, walking the boundary of every household's grazing with two men to carry and a third to dig, and setting into the ground, at every place the old men of both sides could agree the line had always run, a stone too heavy for one man to shift without help and too plain to be mistaken for anything but what it was. The stones he chose with care, flat-topped things from the outcrop above the flint-pit, and had each one cut with a single mark, not a name, for he did not want the stones to belong to anyone; he wanted them to belong to the ground. It was slow work, for every stone needed both sides' word before it went into the earth, and there were places where the old men could not agree even standing on the very ground, pointing at tussocks that had shifted a hand's width in forty years of frost and thaw and swearing each tussock had been exactly there since before their fathers were born.

By the end of the second summer there was a line of grey stone down the whole of the eastern slope and along the beck to the ford, and Dòmhnall stood at the last of them with turf still fresh at its foot and believed, for perhaps a season, that he had done something that would hold.

II

Of What the Stones Did Not Settle

What the stones did was move the argument, not end it. Within a year the eastern households had stopped quarrelling over where the grazing lay, for that was written now in stone that did not forget and could not be argued with by an old man's memory; but they had begun instead to quarrel over the stones themselves, whether a stone stood a pace to the wrong side of where it should, whether a beck had moved its bed since the setting and left a stone stranded on the wrong bank of its own line, whether a man's grandfather had truly

agreed to a boundary his grandson now swore had been forced on a bad year when the household was too weak to argue.

Dòmhnall judged the first of these himself, in the ninth year of the stones, standing over a marker two households both claimed had been moved in the night, though neither could say by whom, and both swore the beck ran different from where it had run at the setting. He walked the ground a long while before he spoke, and when he did it was to say a thing he had not planned to say: that the stone stood where it had been set, that he remembered setting it himself with his own hands and could point to the exact tussock it had gone down beside, and that the beck, not the stone, had moved.

It was true, and both households knew it was true the moment he said it, for a man with *na Bliadhnachan Fada*¹ does not forget where he put a stone the way an ordinary man forgets, and there was no arguing memory against a man who did not age between the setting and the asking. But he saw, walking home from that judgement, that he had settled the quarrel by being the sort of witness no one else on the hill could ever be, and that when he was gone north, as his father sometimes was, or gone into the ground, as his father was not, the eastern slope would have only the stones themselves to argue with, and stones, unlike a king, cannot be asked which of two stories is true.

He said as much to no one, then. It sat in him the whole of that year, the plain fact that he had traded one kind of quarrel for another and called it a settling because the second kind was quieter and took longer to come round. He kept the stones. He never told the hill that he doubted them.

III

Of the Wars of the Valleys

his father was, in those years, seldom on the hill at all. Rìoghachd Chlann nan Dè¹ that had begun as forty houses inside a single bank had by Dòmhnall's thirtieth year on the hill grown to take in valleys three and four days' walk from Dùn ìseal, brought in, for the most part, by the same warmth that had stilled sixty spears on the first slope; yet not every valley came in warm. There

1. the long years of Ailean's kin

1. the kingdom of the godkin, Ailean's kingdom

were households in the folds of land north and west that had heard what had happened at Dùn ìseal and did not believe it, or believed it and resented it the more for believing, and among those the king rode with few, for he never took a great host anywhere, and what fighting there was, the reciters afterward called Cogaidhean nan Gleann², though it was nothing any teller of true wars would recognise: a burnt byre here, a dozen spears crossed there, three men dead in one valley and none in the next, and everywhere, in the end, the same silence that had fallen on the first hill, sooner or later, in every household the king came to himself.

Dòmhnall did not ride with him in those years, for the hill needed holding and someone of the blood needed to hold it, and it fell to him as it had fallen to Gormshuil before him. He heard Cogaidhean nan Gleann the way the hill heard them, in the words of traders and the sons of households that had come in, garbled a little in the telling, so that the same skirmish might reach Dùn ìseal in three different shapes within a season, each one sworn true by the man who brought it. He learned to listen for what stayed the same under the different tellings, which was always the small thing and never the large: a name, a place, the colour of a wound, and from those he built for himself a truer picture than any single teller gave him, though he never told anyone he did it, being a man who kept his methods to himself the way his father kept his fires.

It was in the eighty-second year of the stones, when Dòmhnall himself had begun to notice that the eastern slope's grandsons called him uncle without knowing quite why, that word came down from the north-west of trouble in a valley whose name he had heard only twice before, where a household under a hard old man called Griogar had turned back two of the king's riders with spears and no words at all. The king went himself with a dozen men, no more, for he never took more than a dozen anywhere he rode himself; and it was there, in a fight Dòmhnall never saw and heard of only after, in the hundred and thirteenth year of his own holding of the hill, that his younger brother Fearchar took a spear through the leg that never healed straight.

IV

Of Fearchar Lamed

2. the king's early wars bringing in the valleys

Dòmhnall was not at Griogar's valley, and no telling that reached him afterward agreed on whether the king himself had been within reach of the blow that laid Fearchar down, though most said he had not, that he had been elsewhere in the fight when it happened and came to his son only after, and knelt by him a while on the trampled ground, and said nothing that anyone standing near enough to hear could afterward report. What is certain, and what Dòmhnall heard from Fearchar's own mouth years later, sitting by him at Dùn ìseal with the birch chair already built and Fearchar's leg already a thing he no longer troubled to hide the shape of, was that the wound should by any ordinary reckoning have killed him, for it took him in the thigh and bled a long while before anyone could stop it, and that it did not kill him, and did not heal straight either, so that he walked the whole long remainder of his years, however many they proved to be, on a leg that bent wrong at every step.

"I asked him once," Fearchar told Dòmhnall, the two of them sitting outside the bank in the last of an autumn evening with the fires being lit below them one by one, "why he let it set crooked, when he can do what he did for you and me both, na Bliadhnachan Fada¹ and all the rest of it, and my leg wanted only a little of the same mending to be as good as it ever was."

"What did he say?"

"Nothing. You know how he answers a question he does not mean to answer." Fearchar shifted his weight off the bad leg, the way Dòmhnall would watch him do ten thousand times more before either of them was done with the world. "I have thought since that he cannot mend a thing that is already done, only keep a thing from being undone. Whether that is true I could not swear to you. He never offered, and I never asked him twice."

Dòmhnall said nothing to that either, for he had wondered the same of na Bliadhnachan Fada in himself, whether they were a mending or only a keeping, and found no more of an answer in himself than his brother had found in their father.

V

Of the Storm

1. the long years of Ailean's kin

The first named storm came in Dòmhnall's seventy-first year on the hill, in a season that had given no more warning than any other autumn, and it broke on Dùn ìseal in the dark of one night with a wind that took the thatch off six houses and laid a seventh flat to its footings, and did not slacken until the second day was well begun. Dòmhnall spent that night going from house to house within the bank with what men he could gather, holding roofs down with ropes and bodies both, and lost no one, which he counted afterward the one mercy the storm allowed him, though he lost, besides the houses, most of the summer's cut hay and two of the flint-pit's best sheds.

The name the hill gave the storm that night, in the fright of it, was lost within a generation, the way such names are, for a storm remembered by its fear rather than by what it did rarely keeps the word fear gave it; but the memory of the naming outlived the name, so that the oldest tellers of the hill still say, when a bad wind comes up, that it is nearly as bad as the one they named and forgot, without any of them able to say what they had called it.

It was traders coming up from the west that winter, driven off their usual road by flooded fords, who brought word that the storm had done worse on the coast than it had done at Dùn ìseal: that the shell causeway the Seann-Dhaoine¹ had built long before any of the hill-folk's grandfathers were born, out at Seann Warr, was broken through in three places and the marsh behind it standing full of lake water that should have been kept out of it, and that the Seann-Dhaoine themselves, whose causeway it was and whose land it flooded, had not come out to mend it. Dòmhnall asked the trader twice whether he had that right, for it seemed to him a strange thing for any people to let stand broken, a causeway being the kind of work a people mends before the frost sets a second time; and the trader, who had walked the broken ends himself and touched the old stone with his own hand, said only that the Seann-Dhaoine had watched him do it from a little way off and said nothing and done nothing, and that he had not liked to ask them why.

Dòmhnall thought about that longer than the news seemed to deserve. He had grown up on tellings of the Seann-Dhaoine as a people who built well and kept what they built, the shell roads and the stone landings older and truer than anything the hill-folk had yet raised for themselves; and a broken thing of theirs left broken sat oddly with him; but he was sixty miles and more from Seann Warr

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

with a hill of his own needing him, and he let it go, as a man lets go a strange thing that is not his to mend.

VI

Of the Household That Stood

There was a household on the western slope, some three years after the storm, that Dòmhnall came, in his own mind, to think of afterward as the first true test of the stones, for it was the first quarrel in his time that was not, at bottom, about grass or a fence-line at all. The household was old on that ground, older than the bank, and its elder, a broad grey man named Labhrainn who had never in his life been asked to give an account of himself to anyone, took it into his head that year that a boundary stone set on his own western fence marked less grazing than his household had always held, and refused outright to stand by the line Dòmhnall had walked forty years before.

It was not, Dòmhnall came to understand over the course of that summer, truly about the ground at all, though Labhrainn argued the ground with more heat each time they spoke of it. It was that Labhrainn had watched, over the forty years since the stones went in, the hill's judgements settle themselves more and more by the stone and less and less by the elder men of each household standing on the ground and arguing their memory against each other, the way it had always been done before Dòmhnall's father took to writing boundaries in rock; and he had come, slowly and without ever quite saying it to himself, to resent a settling that no longer needed his own word to stand.

Dòmhnall judged against him in the end, for the stone was where the stone had always been and Labhrainn's own father had stood by its setting with his own hand on the digging-bar; but he judged it gently, and afterward, rather than let the matter close the way most of his judgements closed, with both sides going home and neither speaking of it again, he rode out himself to Labhrainn's byre the following spring and sat with the old man a whole evening over nothing more than a jug of the household's own brewing, and asked him about the ground itself and what it had carried in his grandfather's time and what it carried now, and let him talk himself through most of an evening about a thing no one had asked him to account for in years.

It did not mend everything between them. Labhrainn never again spoke warmly of the boundary stones, and told his own sons, dying, that a king who needed rock to remember a man's word was a king who did not trust the man; but he never again brought a quarrel against the line itself, and Dòmhnall understood, turning it over on the ride home, that he had not won the old man over so much as given him back, in an evening's listening, a little of what the stone had quietly taken from him.

VII

Of Somhairle Who Took No Share

It was in that same stretch of years that word came up to Dòmhnall of his youngest half-brother, Somhairle, son of Sorcha, who had by then seen some hundred and sixty years and looked, by every account that reached the hill, no more than a boy of fifteen summers, slight and quiet and given to standing at the edge of any gathering rather than in the middle of it. Somhairle had asked their father, so the telling went, not for a share of anything, neither land nor herds nor a place among the holders, but only leave to go and live among the households of Na Glinn Àrda¹, where Clann na Ceiste² kept their herds about the crack in the ground that none of them could name the naming of, and to be counted there as nothing more than one more mouth at one more hearth.

Their father had granted it without, so far as anyone heard, a single word of argument, which struck Dòmhnall, when he heard of it, as stranger than the asking itself, for their father argued little about anything but rarely gave leave so quickly to a son who wanted nothing in return for the giving. Dòmhnall rode up himself, the following autumn, to see his brother settled among Na Glinn Àrda, and found him living in a hearth no larger than any other, tending goats with a household that treated him, as far as Dòmhnall could tell in three days among them, as an odd, quiet, useful boy and nothing more, none of them seeming to know, or to care to know, whose son he was.

"You could have had the hill from me one day," Dòmhnall said to him, the evening before he rode back south, the two of them sitting outside the byre with

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

2. the Children of the Question

the smoke of the household's fire between them and the crack in the ground somewhere off in the dark, silent as it had been silent as long as either of them had heard tell of it. "Or land of your own, wherever you asked for it. Why this?"

Somhairle was quiet long enough that Dòmhnall thought he would not answer, which was a thing, he was coming to notice, that ran in their father's blood more than any of the rest of it. "Someone has to remember," Somhairle said at last, "who everyone is, and whose son follows whose, once there are enough of us that no one hearth can hold the whole of it in one old man's head. I do not want a share, because a man who holds land judges his own kin a little differently than a man who holds nothing but names. I want only to be believed, when I say who someone's grandfather was."

Dòmhnall thought of the stones then, though he did not say so, and of Labhrainn, and of the plain fact that he himself had traded one kind of memory for another and never been sure, since, that he had traded up. He said only that he hoped his brother would be believed, and rode home the next morning turning the thought over the whole way, that his father's line seemed to be filling itself, generation by scant generation, with sons who wanted no share of anything, as though the getting of land had already, this early, begun to seem to some of them a smaller thing than the keeping of a true account.

VIII

Of the Chair of Birch and the Riding North

Fearchar's leg never straightened, and by the thirtieth year after Griogar's valley he had stopped pretending it might, and the household carpenters of Dùn ìseal built him, without being asked, a chair of woven birch with long poles fore and aft so that four men could carry him to the gatherings he would no longer walk to, and he took to it without complaint and, Dòmhnall thought, with something almost like relief, for a man who has hidden a limp for thirty years finds a certain ease in being carried openly instead.

It was at one of those gatherings, in the hundred and fifty-first year of Dòmhnall's holding, with Fearchar set down in his chair at the edge of the crowd and the fires of the bank burning behind them, that Dòmhnall went to his father and asked him for more than the hill.

He had thought long about how to put it, and put it plainly in the end, the way his father answered best. He said that the hill was settled now as settled as stone and habit could make it, that its quarrels had grown smaller than the quarrels of a valley twelve days north where the king's word had never yet reached in any lasting way, and that he, Dòmhnall, had held one hill for a hundred and fifty years and wanted, before his own years grew heavier than they yet felt, to hold ground that was not yet settled at all.

His father heard him out without moving, in the way that had stilled sixty spears on a slope more than two hundred years before, and when Dòmhnall had finished he was quiet long enough that Dòmhnall began to wonder whether he had asked wrongly, or asked for a thing that was not his to ask for.

"The north is not held," his father said at last. "Griogar's valley and the ones like it took a spear of your brother's and gave me nothing back but a name I do not trust yet. Go and hold what has been won there, and what has not been won yet, and do it your own way; I will not tell you the stones you should set."

It was, Dòmhnall understood even as he heard it, both more and less than he had asked for: more ground, and no guidance at all in how to keep it, which was, he came slowly to see over the years that followed, the only kind of gift his father ever gave any of them. He left Dùn ìseal that same season, with a company no larger than the twelve his father had once walked south with, and Fearchar, from the chair of birch, watched him go with the flat, unsurprised look of a man who has already begun to understand that he himself will hold this hill a long while yet, on a leg that never healed and a patience that, unlike the leg, would have to.

The hill took Fearchar for its holder without a word of dispute, for he had sat at its judgements at his brother's side since his wounding and the households knew his voice as well as they had known Dòmhnall's; and the boundary stones of the eastern slope, which Dòmhnall had set with his own hands in the thirty-first and thirty-second years of his holding, stood on into a rule that was not his, arguing, in their own plain way, long after he had ridden north, the case he had made for them before he was sure himself that he believed it.

CHAPTER FIVE

Of the Palisade that Burned Twice

GE 227 – 312

*On An Cnoc Ruadh they still tell this against no one, for it is the
telling that gave them their own list, and a list is a thing worth the
trouble of a fire.*

I

Of the Hill by the Lake

Uilleam Faire was born on An Cnoc Ruadh¹ in the twelfth year of Uisdean Mòr's holding, and grew up believing, as every child on that hill believed, that the water below it had always belonged to his own people and to no one else's. It was an old line, older than any telling the hill-folk of Dùn ìseal kept of themselves, and it did not reckon its years from a grove or a crowning or any king's coming, but from a woman named Beathag Ruadh who had held the hill before any of them were born and had never been anybody's but her own. The tellers of the western lake shore spoke of Dùn ìseal, when they spoke of it at all, the way a man speaks of weather coming up from a quarter he does not much like the look of: something that would arrive whether he watched it or not, and was not yet his trouble.

Uisdean Mòr had held the hill since he was five-and-twenty, a broad, slow-spoken man with a temper that took a long while to rouse and longer to cool, and he was the second name on An Cnoc Ruadh's own list, which the hill kept apart

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

from any other and recited apart from any other. He had grown into the holding the way a man grows into a coat cut a little large for him, filling it out year by year until, by the time Uilleam was old enough to notice such things, no one on the lake shore could any longer picture the hill without him standing on it. It was in the seventeenth year of his holding, when Uilleam was not yet five, that Uisdean set his mind to the ditch.

The neck of the hill was its one weakness, a low saddle of ground where the rise from the lake met the rise from the inland side and a man on foot could walk up either slope without troubling to draw breath. Uisdean had watched that saddle for years the way another man watches a loose tooth, and in the spring of his own son's birth he set every household on the hill to digging it out, a ditch as deep as a tall man and as wide as three men lying end to end, and when the ditch was done he set a palisade of oak along the spoil bank behind it, trunk after trunk driven upright and lashed and packed with clay, until the neck of the hill stood higher and harder than any part of it the lake or the land had made on their own.

Uilleam remembered the finishing of it only as a child remembers a thing too large for him to hold whole: the smell of the sap where the axes had been, the noise the households made when the last trunk went into its socket, his own father lifting him onto a shoulder to see over the heads of the crowd. He did not remember understanding, that day, what the wall was for. He came to understand it slowly, the way a boy comes to understand most of what his elders already know and have stopped explaining: that An Cnoc Ruadh answered to no one, and that a wall was the shape a people gave to that answer when they meant it to hold.

II

Of Growing to the Watch

T

he years after the wall went up were quiet ones on the lake, quiet enough that Uilleam, growing through them, came to think of quiet as the hill's natural weather and trouble as the thing that came from elsewhere, the way his grandmother had once told him trouble always did. He learned to fish the reed shallows below the western slope, learned the lake's moods from a boat before he learned them from the shore, and learned, from his father, who had helped dig the ditch and never tired of saying so, the two things a man of An Cnoc Ruadh¹ was born owing: a debt to the water, which fed them, and a debt to the wall, which kept them theirs.

He came to the watch at sixteen, as most of the hill's young men did, standing his turns along the palisade in the grey hour before dawn and the grey hour after dusk, when the light off the lake made every shape along the far shore worth a second look before a man let it go. It was dull work more often than not, and Uilleam, in those first years, sometimes let his mind wander from the wall to the water and back without ever quite deciding which bored him less. He was not a clever man, by his own account, given to him late in life and never once disputed by anyone who had known him; but he was a careful one, and carefulness, on a watch, outlasts cleverness more often than either is given credit for.

It was on the watch, in his twentieth year, that he first heard the full telling of why the wall stood where it stood and swore to no one but itself, and he heard it from Uisdean's own mouth, for the holder of An Cnoc Ruadh still walked the wall himself some nights, unable, it seemed, to trust entirely to younger legs a thing he had dug with his own hands. Word had come up from the east, Uisdean said, standing beside him in the cold with his breath showing white, that the king of the hill-folk, the one the reciters called Ailean Mòr, had brought in valley after valley to the south and east of Dùn ìseal, not always by asking, and that his blood held na Bliadhnachan Fada² and did not age as other men's did, and that no one who had sworn to him seemed to find a way afterward of unswearing.

"And are we to swear to him," Uilleam had asked, young enough still to ask a question so plainly, "when he comes?"

"He has not come," said Uisdean, and would say no more of it that night, though Uilleam came, turning the night over as an old man, to think his holder had not answered the question so much as set it aside, the way a man sets aside a debt he means to pay but has not yet decided how.

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

2. the long years of Ailean's kin

III

Of the Two Hundred Spears

The king came in the thirty-ninth year of Uisdean's holding, at the end of a summer, and he came the way a change in weather comes: seen a long way off, and unhurried about arriving.

Word ran up the lake shore three days ahead of him, carried by a trader who had passed his company on the inland road and could not say, when pressed, how many spears he had counted, only that he had stopped counting. He came at last along the shore itself in the low light of an evening, some two hundred men on foot behind him, no more armed, Uilleam thought, watching from the wall with the rest of the watch crowded along it, than any company that size would carry as a matter of course; but two hundred men are two hundred men, and the hill had never in Uilleam's lifetime seen so many strangers standing on its own shingle at once.

They camped below the hill, between the water and the rise, and lit their fires, and did what any company of two hundred does at the end of a day's march: ate, and settled their gear, and set their own watch, which Uilleam noted with a watchman's interest was neither larger nor smaller than seemed reasonable for a company expecting no trouble that night. What they did not do was send up any word to the hill at all. No herald came to the ditch to ask leave, or make demand, or say so much as a name. The king's fires burned below them the whole evening, and the hill's own fires burned above, and between the two the neck of the ditch lay dark and empty and, Uilleam thought, watching it, strangely loud with the things neither side was saying.

Uisdean stood on the wall a long while that evening, further along from where Uilleam kept his own post, and said little to anyone who came near him. Uilleam heard afterward, more than once and always secondhand, that his holder had been asked by one of the elder men whether they should send down and ask the strangers' business, and had answered that a man who wanted to be asked his business generally opened with it himself, and that he would not go chasing after an answer nobody below had troubled to offer.

The night held fair and still until well past midnight, and Uilleam, on the last watch before dawn, was among those who saw the fire start.

He said afterward, and said it the same way every time he was asked, for the rest of his life, that he had been looking straight at the palisade when it took, and

had seen no torch, no spark carried on the wind, nothing thrown from below or dropped from above. The wood simply began to burn, along its whole length at once rather than from any one place outward, and the flame it made was low and did not leap the way a fire leaps when it is fed, and it was the wrong colour, a dark shining thing more like the last coal of a hearth banked for the night than like any blaze Uilleam had ever put a name to. He shouted the alarm before he had finished looking at it, and the hill came awake around him in the space it takes a dog to bark twice.

They fought the fire with what they had, lake water carried up in skins and pots and whatever else came to hand, and green hides thrown over the worst of it to smother rather than douse, and by the grey edge of morning the palisade stood black and smoking and mostly whole, for the low strange fire, whatever it had been, had burned slow enough to be beaten, this first time, before it took the timber through. No one came up from the camp below while they fought it, and no one from the hill went down to ask why. When full light came the two hundred spears were still on the shore exactly where they had camped, breaking their fast over their own fires as though nothing along the hill's rim had happened in the night at all.

IV

Of the Long Waiting

Uisdean rebuilt through what remained of that autumn and on into the winter, and he rebuilt, against the plain word of every carpenter on the hill, with green oak.

Uilleam had asked him once, hauling timber up the inland slope with a dozen others in the wet cold of that season, why a man who had just watched seasoned wood burn to the ground chose to set up wood that was worse for burning in its place, and Uisdean had given him an answer that satisfied him at the time and satisfied him less each time he turned it over afterward: that seasoned oak took years to grow seasoned and he did not have years to spare before the frost, and that green oak, whatever its faults, was oak that stood on his own hill and had not been begged, borrowed, or bought from anyone camped on his shingle. It was not, Uilleam came to think, an answer about timber at all.

Below the hill the king's company neither struck camp nor pressed any nearer. They fished the shallows, and mended their gear, and by the second month of that winter had begun trading, in a small and wary way, with households of the hill who found it easier to sell a little salted fish downhill than to carry the same fish a day's walk round the lake to anyone else who might buy it. Uilleam himself sold two baskets of eels that winter to a spearman who paid him fairly and asked no questions he did not want answered, and came away from the transaction unsure, as he said afterward, whether he had done a small treason or nothing at all.

He saw the king twice that winter, at a distance both times, and remembered afterward that there had been nothing about the man, seen from the wall on a grey afternoon, that marked him out from any of the two hundred around him, save that the others moved out of his way without seeming to notice they had done it, the way water moves round a stone in a stream without the stream troubling to remark on the stone. Once he was mending a boat drawn up on the shingle, working the caulking with his own hands like any boatwright's man. Once he was simply sitting, near the water, doing nothing that Uilleam could make out from that distance at all, for the better part of an afternoon, while his company went about their business around him and left him to it.

"He is waiting us out," Uisdean said, the one time Uilleam heard him speak of it plainly, standing on the half-finished wall with the green timber sweating sap in the cold. "He thinks a wall that burns twice is a wall that will not be rebuilt a third time, and he means to be here to see whether he is right."

"And is he?"

Uisdean did not answer that either. He set the last of the green oak into its socket himself, with his own hands, in the worst of that winter's frosts, and the hill took it, watching him do it, as an answer of a kind.

V

Of the King's Frost

Spring came late that year and cold, and by the time the flint-pits were opened again for the season the palisade stood finished, dark green wood weeping sap along every joint, and the households of An Cnoc Ruadh¹ had

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

begun, cautiously, to speak of the whole matter as a thing that had passed. The king's company still camped below, for they had never once struck their tents through the winter, but two hundred men who fish and mend and ask nothing come, after enough months, to seem less like a siege and more like a second, smaller, oddly patient village that had grown up on the shingle without anyone's leave.

It was in the early days of an t-Ògmhios, when the year should by every reckoning the hill kept have been well past any frost, that the cold came down out of a clear sky in a single night and put a white rime on the grass along the whole shore, the kind of frost no one living on the lake had ever known to fall so late in the turning year. The hill's own old women called it, from that morning on, Reothadh an Rìgh², and kept the name whether or not anyone could say with certainty it was fair, for it seemed to them a thing too strange to be weather and not strange enough to be anything they had a better word for.

Uilleam was on the wall again that night, as he had been on the night of the first burning, and he said afterward that he knew, the moment the frost's cold reached him through his plaid, that it was not a night like other nights, though he could not have said, if pressed, what told him so beyond the wrongness of the season itself. He kept his eyes on the palisade the whole watch through, the way a man keeps his eyes on a wound he expects to open again, and so he was looking straight at the green oak, for the second time in his life, when it took.

It went the way Teine a' Chlachair³ had gone and worse, the whole wall alight at once in the same low, dark, shining flame, but the green wood, which should by every carpenter's word have resisted longer than the seasoned timber had, burned instead in what Uilleam swore, to the end of his days, was less time than it takes to say a man's name twice over. He was the first to reach it with water, running the whole length of the wall with a hide-skin held before him, and he threw what he carried into the heart of the worst of it before three other men had so much as reached the ditch; and he said afterward, when asked, and he was asked more times over the rest of his life than he ever tired of answering, that he had done it without thinking at all, the way a man's hand goes to a burn before his mind has finished deciding it is burned.

It did no good. The fire took the new wall as it had taken nothing else that year, and by the time the rest of the households reached the wall with what water

2. the unseasonable frost of early an t-Ògmhios GE 290 on the Red Hill's lake shore, named for the night of the palisade's second burning

3. the mason's fire, the first fire

and hides they could gather, there was nothing left standing worth throwing water at. Uilleam stood at the ditch's edge afterward with the empty skin still in his hand and watched the last of the low dark flame die down into ordinary embers, ordinary at last, the strangeness gone out of it the moment there was nothing left for it to burn, and he never once, from that night to the end of his life, could say for certain whose doing it had been. He had thrown the water himself, with his own two hands, at a fire he could not name and could not explain and could not, in the end, put out; and he carried that half-answered night with him the rest of his years the way another man might carry an old wound that aches before rain, without ever being wholly sure the ache and the weather were truly bound to one another at all.

VI

Of Uisdean Going Down

In the morning Uisdean Mòr came down from An Cnoc Ruadh¹ alone. He gave no order that any man should follow him, and Uilleam, who stood near enough at the gap in the ditch to hear him say it, remembered the words plainly: that this was his own debt and he would carry it down himself, and that the wall, or what was left standing of it, would want every hand that was not his own for the clearing. He went down the inland path rather than the shore path, which struck Uilleam even then as a strange choice for a man walking to a reckoning, until he understood, watching from the wall with the rest of the households crowded along it in the smoking wreck of the morning, that Uisdean had wanted the longer way, the way that gave a man time to decide, step by step, what he meant to say before he arrived at having to say it.

From the wall the distance was too great for Uilleam to hear a word of what passed on the shingle below, and he was honest about that for the rest of his life, never once claiming, as certain other tellers of the tale were happy enough to claim on his behalf, to have caught so much as a syllable of it. What he saw, and swore to, was this: Uisdean coming down onto the stones and stopping twice on the way, as a man stops who is arguing with himself and losing; the king not rising from where he sat on a stone by the water, mending, by Uilleam's guess from the

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

shape of it, some small thing held in his hands; the two of them a long while, neither moving, close enough that their shadows on the shingle nearly touched and did not; and then Uisdean going down on one knee on the wet stones, slowly, the way a heavy man goes down when his own weight has finally decided the matter for him, and putting his two hands out, and the king taking them in his own.

They sat together afterward, the two of them, a good while on the shingle with the wrecked wall smoking above them, and were seen, by those close enough on the shore to see it and not so close as to be sent away, to share out something between them that might have been food and might, from that distance, have been anything at all. Uilleam did not go down. He stood his place on the wall, as he had been told to, and watched his holder eat with the man whose two hundred spears had camped below their hill through a whole winter without once being asked to, and understood, without anyone troubling to explain it to him, that whatever An Cnoc Ruadh had been before that morning, it was going to be a different thing after it.

VII

Of the Two Lists

Uisdean came back up the hill by evening, tired in the way a man is tired after a thing decided rather than a thing done, and called the households together at what was left of the gap in the wall to tell them, in as few words as he ever used for anything, that An Cnoc Ruadh¹ had sworn to the king, and that the king had taken the oath as freely given and asked nothing further of it that day. He did not say, and Uilleam noticed the absence of it even then, that An Cnoc Ruadh had sworn to Dùn ìseal, or to the hill of Rìghrean na Cloiche², or to any name but the king's own; and it was some years before Uilleam came to understand that the distinction, small as it sounded on the evening it was made, was the whole of what his holder had gone down to the shingle to settle.

The palisade was rebuilt a third time, that summer and the next, with seasoned oak at last, for there was no longer any king's company camped below to hurry the choosing of the timber; and it never burned again in Uilleam's lifetime

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

nor, so far as An Cnoc Ruadh's own list has ever had cause to record, in anyone else's. The king's company struck their tents within the month and went east, back the way they had come, and did not return; and the lake shore, which had spent a whole winter watching two hundred strangers fish its shallows and mend its boats, found the quiet afterward stranger, for a season or two, than the company itself had ever been.

An Cnoc Ruadh kept its own list after that, as it always had, and the list said what the hill wanted said and no more: that Uisdean Mòr, second of the list, had built the wall, and lost it twice, and sworn to the king on the third morning of trying. It did not name the fire, or its colour, or the frost that came too late in the year to be trusted, or the man who had thrown the water and never once, in all the tellings he was asked to give, found a way of saying more than he had truly seen. Dùn ìseal's own reciters, when word of the swearing reached them, told the tale fuller, and stranger, and An Cnoc Ruadh never once quarrelled with their telling, which struck Uilleam, hearing both versions set side by side in his own old age, as the strangest part of the whole business: that a hill so careful of its own list should let another hill's tellers keep the truer half of its own story, and never ask for it back.

Uisdean held An Cnoc Ruadh two-and-twenty years after the swearing, until his eighty-seventh year, and died on the hill in his own bed, an old man by any ordinary reckoning, having outlived the fire and the frost and the two hundred spears by a longer stretch than any of them had lasted. Uilleam stood the watch on the wall until he himself was an old man, and told the tale of the burning, when he was asked for it, exactly the same way every time, changing nothing, adding nothing, and ending it always at the same place: that he had thrown the water with his own hands, and did not know, to his dying day, whose fire it was that he had failed to put out.

CHAPTER SIX

OF THE STROKES ON THE MIDDEN STONES

GE 290 – 388

At Seann Chwen the salters still point out the flat stone under the fourth boat-shed and say a hill man once wept over it, though none of them now living saw him do it, and the telling has grown shorter with every hearth it has passed through.

I

Of the Road by Gesture

Dùghall was nine years old the summer his father first let him come the whole way down to the shore rather than turning him back at the last ridge with the pack-ponies to mind, and he remembered afterward, better than he remembered most of that year, the smell of the place before he saw it: salt and rot and woodsmoke, and under those a fourth smell he had no word for and never found one, which he came in time to think of simply as the smell of the Seann-Dhaoine¹, the way a byre has its own smell and a smokehouse its own, and no more to be explained than either.

His father carried hides down that road, cured goat and deer hide from the high pastures where Dùghall's people wintered their herds, and hill cheese pressed hard enough to travel a week without spoiling, and he had carried both for longer than Dùghall had been alive, walking a track that ran three days from the pastures to the coast and three days back, by way of a ford and a wood and a long turn

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

round a bog that swallowed a cart to the axle if a man forgot to keep to the causeway of laid brush. He carried them to trade, and what he traded them for, over a lifetime of the road, was whatever the shore had that the pastures did not: strings of pale shell, salted fish packed in baskets lined with kelp, and hooks and awls of whalebone worked finer than any hill craft could match, though no one on the hill had ever learned how the working was done, only that the Seann-Dhaoine traded them and would trade nothing else half so willingly.

There was no tongue between them. Dùghall's father had walked the road forty years and could no more speak a word of what the Seann-Dhaoine spoke among themselves than Dùghall, watching him that first summer, could speak it himself; and it seemed to Dùghall, young as he was, a strange thing that two peoples could trade across the same stretch of shingle for two generations and never once trouble to learn each other's words for the things they were trading, until he grew older and understood that his father had tried, once, as a young man, and had been met with a courtesy so complete and so unyielding that he had never tried again. The Seann-Dhaoine would take a hide from his hand and turn it over and weigh it with their eyes, and hold up so many fingers for so many strings of shell, and if the count did not please him he could shake his head and hold up fewer fingers of his own until it did; but if he pointed to his own mouth and then to theirs, meaning what word do you call this, they only looked at him, not unkindly, the way a man looks at a child asking something he has decided not to answer, and went on with the weighing.

"They are not unwilling," his father told him, the first night they camped within sound of the sea, with the ponies hobbled and the fire built low against a wind that smelled of nothing Dùghall knew. "I used to think they were unwilling. They are not. They simply do not mean to be understood, and there is a difference between a door shut against you and a door that was never built to open at all."

Dùghall asked him, because he was nine, and had not yet learned the questions a boy holds back from a man three days from home with the whole evening free for talk, whether the Seann-Dhaoine had a king of their own, the way the hill had one, and whether that king was old the way his own king was said to be old and yet not old at all. His father was quiet long enough that Dùghall thought he would not answer, and then said only that no hill man had ever seen anything among the Seann-Dhaoine that looked like a king, or like a hearing-house, or like a bank round a hill; that they lived in stone houses set low against the wind, with roofs of turf grown so thick and so old that from a distance the houses looked like

the ground itself had swelled; and that whatever held them together, if anything held them together at all beyond the shore and the boats and the middens at the backs of their houses, no hill man who had traded with them for two lifetimes had ever come close enough to it to say.

They traded that first summer as they had traded every summer before it, Dùghall standing a little behind his father with the ponies' lead-ropes in his fist and his eyes going everywhere at once: at the low houses with their smoke rising thin and grey from holes in the turf rather than any chimney; at the boats drawn up on the shingle, sewn from planks in a manner no hill boat used, without a single dug timber in them that he could see; at the Seann-Dhaoine themselves, who were neither taller nor shorter than hill folk, and dressed in skins sewn close against the wet, and moved about their work with an unhurried economy that made his father's brisk hill way of doing things look, by comparison, almost wasteful. Nothing about that first summer told him anything was different from the fifty summers that had come before it, or the fifty that his father told him, without much interest, would likely come after.

II

Of the Marks at the Midden's Edge

It was some years later, in the eighteenth summer of Dùghall's own carrying, that he first noticed the stones.

He was seven-and-twenty that year, walking the road on his own for the first time with a string of ponies that was his in all but the naming of it, his father having grown too heavy in the knees for three days of bog-causeway and having handed the road to his son the way a man hands on a thing he is glad to be rid of and sorry to be rid of in the same breath. Dùghall knew the shore by then as well as he knew the high pastures, knew which household traded fairly and which wanted watching, knew the particular stretch of shingle where the whalebone was always best worked and the particular household, three houses back from the water, whose midden ran along the whole eastern side of their turf-roofed house in a long grey ridge of shell and ash and broken bone, taller each year than it had been the year before, the way a midden grows behind any household that has lived long in one place.

What he had not noticed before, or had noticed without troubling to ask himself why it should be noticed at all, was that flat stones stood set on their edges at intervals along that ridge, driven into the ground like small grey teeth, and that each one, when the light fell right across it, showed a mark cut into its face: a single stroke, deep enough to hold shadow, and nothing else. Some stones showed one stroke. A few, further along the ridge, showed two, cut close together as though by the same hand at the same sitting. None showed more than two.

He asked his father about it that autumn, back on the hill with the season's trading told over and counted, and his father said he had seen the stones himself, years back, and had asked a Seann-Dhaoine¹ once, by pointing and by the beginnings of a question he could not finish in gesture, what they were for, and had got nothing for his asking but the same courteous, unyielding look that met every question of that kind. "I stopped asking," his father said. "A man who trades on a shore for forty years learns which of his questions the shore means to answer and which it does not, and he does himself no good going on asking the second kind."

Dùghall went on asking, though only of himself, and the stones stayed in the back of his thought the way a half-heard word stays in the back of a man's thought until he happens on the rest of it. He began, without much deciding to, to count them on each visit, and to notice that the count grew, slowly, by no more than a stone or two in a summer, but steadily, the ridge lengthening a little further each year along the side of the low turf house, and the household living beside it going on with its fishing and its weaving and its unhurried work as though the growing ridge of stones were no more worth remarking on than the growing midden it stood beside.

It was in his six-and-thirtieth summer that he stood longer than he meant to before the ridge of stones and worked out, counting on his fingers the way a boy counts, that there were now eleven of them where nine summers before there had been six, and that no one in the household beside the midden had ever, in all his visits, set a new stone while he was there to see it done. He asked himself, standing on that shingle with his ponies shifting behind him and the tide starting to turn, what manner of thing was counted five at a time in some years and not at all in others, cut once and left, never added to, never changed once cut.

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

He had no answer that summer, or the next, and he told himself, the way his father had told himself before him, that it was a question the shore did not mean to answer, and went on with his trading.

III

Of the Stroke Cut After a Burial

The answer, when it came, came to him unasked, in the way such things most often do.

He was seven-and-sixty that summer, an old man by any hill reckoning, with sons of his own long grown and one of them now carrying the greater share of the packs at his shoulder, and grey enough all through, not only at the temple, that the household by the midden, who had never once in his lifetime of visiting given any sign of marking one hill trader from another, seemed to him, for the first time, to greet him as something other than a stranger, and did it wordlessly, there being still no words between them, in a kind of settled ease, an old woman of the house handing him dried fish before he had finished unpacking, as though the handing were no longer a trade freshly struck but a thing already agreed between them long before, renewed rather than made.

It was on the third morning of that visit, with the mist not yet burned off the water and the household's boats still drawn up rather than launched, that Dùghall woke in the lean-to he was given to sleep in and heard, through the turf wall, a sound he had not heard on that shore before: low voices, several together, rising and falling in a way no ordinary talk of a household's morning work ever took, something with a shape to it, a beginning and a middle he could feel coming though he understood not one word of it, the way a man who cannot read music can still feel a tune reaching for its close.

He did not go out while it lasted, for something in the sound itself told him not to, the same instinct that would have kept him from walking into a hill household's grief before he was asked. It went on the better part of the morning, and when it ended he heard, instead, a single low note, held a long while and let go, and then nothing, and then the ordinary sounds of a household returning to itself: a pot set on a fire, a child's voice, the drag of a boat's keel over shingle as the men of the house at last put out to fish, later than they had ever put out on any morning of Dùghall's eight-and-fifty summers of visiting.

He went out then, and found the old woman who had handed him the fish, sitting alone at the door of the house with her hands still in her lap, and he did not ask her anything, for he had long since learned there was nothing to ask that she would answer; but he looked, without meaning to make a study of it, toward the ridge of stones along the midden's edge, and saw that the newest of them, the twelfth, cut some years before and standing bare since, now carried, beneath its single old stroke, a second stroke, fresh enough that pale stone still showed raw in the groove of it, not yet weathered to the grey of the stroke above.

He stood a long while looking at that stone, the fresh cut and the old one side by side on the same grey face, and it came to him, all at once and entire, the way a thing comes to a man only after his mind has been carrying the pieces of it separately for twenty years without knowing they belonged together: the low voices in the turf house that morning, the single held note let go at the end of it, the boats kept ashore past their hour, and now the fresh stroke cut beneath the old. His own mother's grave-mound came to him then, on the hill, and the stone his father had set at its head with her name scratched into it by a hand that had never learned to cut letters cleanly; and he understood, standing on that shingle with the mist still not fully burned away, that he was looking at the same thing in another people's hand: a household marking, one stroke at a time, the going of its own dead.

A word the hill had begun to use of the king came to him too, though he said nothing of it that day to anyone: something quietly said among those old enough to have watched three holders of Dùn ìseal come and go while the man who crowned each of them stayed exactly as he had always been, that the king did not count his dead the way other men counted theirs, for he had never yet been given cause to stop counting and start remembering instead. Dùghall was no teller and made nothing of the thought beyond turning it once in his own mind and setting it down again, but it stayed with him longer than most of what he carried home from that shore.

He counted the whole ridge again that morning, slower than he had ever counted it before, and found that every household along that stretch of shore kept its own stones the same way, one ridge to a house, and that some stones bore a single stroke only and some bore two or three, cut close together as brothers might be cut close together, and a very few, at the old ends of the oldest ridges, bore strokes enough that he lost the count and had to begin again. He did not ask the old woman anything that day, or any day after, for he understood now, as

clearly as his father had ever understood it without being told, that this was one of the things the shore did not mean to answer by gesture, because it had never been a question that gesture could hold; but he carried the understanding home with him at the season's end the way another man might carry a wound, quietly, and told it, since there was no one living he could tell it to who would understand it better, at his father's grave-mound on the hill, his father being many years in the ground.

His father had told him once, long before, that the shore did not answer that kind of question. Standing at the grave, Dùghall thought his father had been right, and that the shore had answered it all the same, and that the answer was of a kind a man is sorrier to have than to go without.

IV

Of the Grandson and the Fewer Hearths

Dùghall walked that road another four summers after the morning of the fresh stroke, through years in which the hill itself grew busier behind him than it had ever been in his father's time, a king's blood settling deeper into valleys that had known no king at all when Dùghall was a boy, though little enough of that reached him on a road that ran, each summer, the same three days to the same stretch of shingle and the same three days home. He carried the stones with him after that morning the way a man carries a thing he has decided not to speak of past the one telling it needs; he did not mention them again to his sons as they grew old enough to walk the road at his shoulder, for a thing seen once with such plainness needs no repeating, whatever wish a man might have to spare his sons the seeing of it, and he judged that each of them, in his own year, would see the ridges for himself, the way he had, and he judged rightly.

He was one-and-seventy, and had not carried the whole road himself in some summers, when he took his eldest son's boy down to the shore for what both of them understood, without either saying so, was likely to be the old man's last visit to it. The boy was near enough grown to carry his own share of the packs and had been down the road twice before at his father's side, but never yet with his grandfather, and Dùghall had asked for the going the way a man asks for a thing he means to have, plainly, and had been given it without argument by a household

that had learned long since not to argue with him over which of his own wants were worth the arguing.

They came down to the shore on a grey morning with rain not far behind them, and Dùghall, walking the last stretch more slowly than he remembered ever walking it, past the ford and the wood and the long turn round the bog, found the shore quieter than he had ever found it in two-and-sixty years of coming to it. Two of the turf houses nearest the water stood roofless, their thatch long fallen in and not renewed, the walls softening back into the shape of the ground the way an old grave-mound softens; and where he counted, from long habit, the smoke rising from the houses further back, he found himself counting on fewer fingers than the count had ever taken before, four threads of smoke where a man his age remembered counting nine, and no boats drawn up before two houses that he remembered, in his father's day, as always having a boat.

He led his grandson along the shore to the ridge of stones by the household that had first shown him the fresh stroke, all those years before, and found the old woman gone, as he had known she must be gone, and a younger woman in her place who did not know him, or gave no sign of knowing him, though she took the hides from his hands with the same unhurried courtesy her mother, or her mother's mother, had shown his father before either of them was born. The ridge of stones had grown longer still, stone on stone further than Dùghall's eye could easily follow in one look, and near its older end, where the earliest stones stood weathered grey and soft-edged with age, he found gaps in the ground where stones must once have stood and stood no longer, fallen or taken or simply sunk, he could not tell which, into turf that had grown up round the place they had been.

"Count them," he told his grandson, not because the boy could make anything more of the count than Dùghall himself had ever made of it, but because he wanted the boy to have done it once, with his own hand and his own eye, before the old man who had first taught him to look at that ridge was no longer there to tell him to. The boy counted, moving along the stones with his lips working the numbers, and lost the count twice and began again, and came back to his grandfather at last to say that he could not be sure, past a certain point, whether he was counting stones the household still kept or stones that had simply fallen and lay half-buried among the ones still standing, and that either way the number was larger than any number he had learned to hold easily in his head at once.

Dùghall said only that he had found the same trouble himself, the first time and every time since, and that it was, he had come to think, no bad thing for a man to meet a count he could not finish, if the count itself was an honest one. He did not tell the boy, that day or after, all that he had come in two-and-sixty years to guess and never to know for certain: that the smoke he had counted thinner every visit these last ten summers, and the boats missing from before houses that had always kept a boat, and the roofless walls softening back into the ground where households he had traded with all his life no longer answered a knock, seemed to him, taken together with the lengthening ridges of stone, less like a shore that was simply quiet that year than like a shore that was, house by house and summer by summer, running out of itself; for it was not a thing he could prove by any count he knew how to keep, only a weight that had settled on him, walking that grey morning past the fallen roofs, that he had no gesture to put down and no one on that shore who would have understood the putting down if he had found one.

He traded what he had brought, that last visit, for less than he had once traded the same weight of hides for, though whether the shore itself had grown poorer or only that household had, he could not have said; and he walked home the three days with his grandson at his shoulder saying little, the boy carrying, without knowing he carried it, the whole of what his grandfather had carried down that road for two-and-sixty years and never once found a way to set down whole for anyone but himself. Dùghall died on the hill the following winter, an old man by any hill man's reckoning and older than most who walked that road before or after him, and it was his grandson, and not his son, who took up the packs the next summer and walked south alone to the shore, counting the stones at the midden's edge before he traded a single hide, the way the old man had taught him, on a morning grey enough, and quiet enough, that the boy stood a long while at the ridge before he could bring himself to begin.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Of the Tally Wall and the Half-Cut Stone

GE 389 – 590

Of the wall and the stone Somhairle set down only this, and Clann na Ceiste have kept his telling exactly as he gave it, word for word, adding nothing after it and taking nothing away.

I

Of the Road East

Somhairle was three hundred and fifty-one years old and looked a boy of seventeen when his father told him to come down from Na Glinn Àrda¹ and walk the coast road with him.

He had been near two hundred years among Clann na Ceiste² by then, long enough that the reciters no longer marked him out as the king's son so much as the one among them who forgot nothing, and set exact by exact into a boy's memory Sloinneadh a' Chlachair³ from the seven nights forward, the pots left cold under the oaks, the six households that came in first, the storm that broke the shell causeway at Seann Warr and was never mended. He had heard the causeway named a hundred times before he ever saw it, and had not thought, hearing it, that he would.

His father sent no reason with the summons, only a word carried up by a rider that the king rode east in three days and would have his son with him, and Som-

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

2. the Children of the Question

hairle came down off the slab where he had been sitting with old Aonghas going over the drowned years of the third generation, and walked south to the hill without asking why, for asking why was not a thing the king's messages generally rewarded.

They rode with a small company, no more than a dozen, along the road that ran below Dùn ìseal and out past the last of the valley households to the shore, a road Somhairle had walked in the telling many times and now walked with his own feet, noting as he went the things the telling left out: the smell of the bog before the bog was seen, a heron standing so still in a flooded ditch that two of the company took it at first for a grey stone, his father saying almost nothing the whole first day and then, on the second, telling a story about a horse he had once owned that would not cross running water after dark, which had nothing in it of kings or grooves or na Bliadhnachan Fada⁴, and made the company laugh, and Somhairle understood, hearing it, that his father told such stories on purpose, the way a man puts a plain loaf on the table before a feast so that no one goes to the feast too hungry.

Seann Warr stood where the coast road ran out into shingle, a scatter of low turf-roofed houses set back from the water with their smoke going up thin and straight in the still morning, boats drawn up in a line along the strand, and beyond the houses, where the midden ground ran along the whole landward side of the settlement, Balla nan Stràc⁵.

It was not tall. Somhairle had built it taller in his own mind from the telling, the way a boy builds most things he has only heard of, and found instead a course of flat stones no higher than a man's chest, running the length of two hundred paces or more along the midden's edge, each stone set on end and driven into older stones below it, so that the wall was not built so much as accumulated, one course laid on the last the way frost lays itself on a window a night at a time. He walked the whole length of it with his father before either of them spoke, and when he came near enough to see the faces of the stones he understood what he was looking at.

Every stone bore strokes. Some bore one, cut deep and old and softened at the edges with weather; some bore a dozen, cut close together in threes and fours the way a hand cuts fast when the hand does not want to stop; and near the wall's

3. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

4. the long years of Ailean's kin

5. the Old Ones' wall of counting stones at Seann Warr

older end, where the stones stood furthest back and greyest, the strokes ran together into a texture Somhairle could no more count than he could count the grass of a whole field, thousands upon thousands, laid down one household's dead at a time over years past any hill man's reckoning.

"How long has it stood?" he asked, for it was the sort of question the Line trained a boy to ask.

"Longer than the wall at Dùn ìseal," his father said. "Longer, I think, than the grove." He said it without weight, the way he said most things, but he stood a while by the oldest of the stones with his hand resting flat against it, not moving, and Somhairle, watching him, thought for the first time that his father's stillness before a thing was itself a kind of answer, though he did not yet know what question it answered.

The households of Seann Warr, who were Seann-Dhaoine⁶ and had always been Seann-Dhaoine, went on about their morning as the king's company walked their midden's edge: mending nets, gutting fish on flat stones worn smooth with the work of it, a child carrying water up from the strand in a skin bag nearly as big as she was. None of them came near. None of them, so far as Somhairle could see, so much as turned to look, though he did not doubt they had marked every man of the company from the moment the dozen horses came over the last rise. His father had told him once, in Na Glinn Àrda, that the Seann-Dhaoine were not a people who could be asked anything and answered, and Somhairle had taken it then for one more line of the Line, learned and repeated and not much felt. He felt it now, standing at the wall's edge with a whole people's dead cut into stone at his shoulder and not one living soul among them near enough to name a single one.

He set the wall down that night in the words the reciters used, spare and dated and without ornament, the way Coinneach had taught the first of them to set things down: *at Seann Warr the counting stones are built into a wall, some three thousand strokes in all, and the wall grows for many lifetimes*. It was the first thing of his own that Somhairle ever added to the Line, and he kept, all his life afterward, a particular carefulness about it, the way a man keeps a particular carefulness about the first thing he ever built with his own hands, whether or not it stood the straightest.

6. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

II

Of Seann Tarr and the House over the Dead

Nine-and-thirty years went by before Somhairle saw the second of the three shores, and by then he had come into the years where a man of Clann na Ceiste¹ was sent out on his own rather than at his father's stirrup, to keep the lines fresh at the edges of the kingdom where the reciters of Na Glinn Àrda² seldom rode.

He went to Seann Tarr in the north-east on a grey errand that had nothing to do with the Seann-Dhaoine³ at all, a dispute between two hill households over a stretch of grazing that had crept, as such disputes did, further than either household could honestly remember it ever running, and it was only after he had settled the grazing, a half-day's work that left both sides sullen and neither satisfied, which the reciters counted a fair outcome, that he walked down to the shore to see for himself what the tellings said of that coast.

Seann Tarr was a smaller place than Seann Warr, a dozen households at most, set close along a narrow strand under cliffs that kept the worst of the north wind off the boats. Its dead lay under the living rather than apart from them at a midden's edge: a long low house near the shore's centre, older than the houses around it by the settling of its walls, its floor paved with slabs cut and dressed and laid edge to edge, and on each slab, worked into the stone itself rather than merely cut across it, strokes gathered in fives, four upright and a fifth laid across them, the way a boy ties a bundle of rushes.

The house was lived in. A family sat at its hearth when Somhairle came to the door, an old man mending a net, a woman working something at a low bench he could not make out, two children asleep in a corner on a heap of skins, and none of them rose or spoke or gave any sign that a stranger stood in their doorway, though the old man's eyes came up once, held Somhairle's a moment with neither welcome nor refusal in them, and went back to the net.

He did not go in. Standing at the threshold with the smell of peat smoke and fish oil thick in the low room, he understood that he was looking at a household that had built its home upon its own graves and gone on living there generation after generation, the dead underfoot and counted, the living overhead and con-

1. the Children of the Question

2. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

tinuing; no hill custom he had ever been taught by the Line had prepared him for a people who would choose, of their own accord, to keep so close a floor.

He asked no question, for he had learned that much from his father's stillness at Seann Warr. He stood a while at the door and then walked back up to the cliff path, and set the house down that night as he had set down the wall, spare and dated: *at Seann Tarr the counting comes in fives, cut into the floor of a house, and the house is lived in over its own dead.*

III

Of the Thickening

It was two-and-forty years further on, in his four hundred and thirty-second year, that Somhairle first heard from the coast road that something on the three shores had changed, and the word came, of all people, from an ordinary carrier of hides, a man he did not know, met by chance at a ford on the road south, who mentioned it the way a man mentions weather, in passing, to fill a silence while the horses drank.

"The stones are thick this year," the carrier said. "Thicker than I've seen them go in a season, and not at one shore only. I heard the same from a man who walks the Seann Tarr road, and another who does the southern coast. Three shores, all at once, and none of them saying why."

Somhairle rode to Seann Warr within the month, and found the wall grown by more courses in that one season than he remembered it growing across the whole of his own boyhood, fresh stone driven in among the old, strokes cut so close upon each other that in places a man could not set a fingertip between one groove and the next. He rode from there to Seann Tarr and found the floor of the house crowded past what its own slabs could easily hold, new stones laid at the room's edges where no stone had lain before, the family who kept it thinner by two than he remembered them, the old man who had mended the net gone from among them and no one at the hearth to say where.

He sent word to his father, less because the Line required it than because he did not know, that year, what else to do with a thing he could not yet set down as a plain dated fact; and the king came down himself, that summer, to Seann Warr, with no great company this time, only Somhairle and three others, and walked the wall's whole length alone while the rest of them waited at its far end.

Somhairle had seen his father stand still before a thing once, at that same wall, eighty years before. He had not seen him stand as he stood that day, a long while, longer than the walk of the wall itself could account for, one hand flat against the newest of the stones the way another man rests a hand on a sick child's brow, and the light off the water going from morning to nearly noon before he turned and came back down the strand to where his son waited.

"Athair," Somhairle said, for he had not called him father in the ordinary way of the hill since he was young enough to be carried on a shoulder, and the word came out of him now unasked, the way a boy's word comes out of a man when a thing has frightened him and he does not yet know it. "What did you see?"

His father looked at him a moment before he answered, and there was nothing in his face that Somhairle could afterward describe as grief, or fear, or any name a reciter might set down and have another reciter understand; only a stillness gone very deep, the warmth that other men felt from him when he took their hand banked low, like a hearth covered for the night rather than let go out.

"A people counting," he said.

He said nothing more of it that day, or, so far as Somhairle ever learned, to anyone else afterward. They rode back to Dùn ìseal at a walking pace, taking two days over a road they had come in one, for the king set an easy pace and did not press it, and Somhairle, riding at his side, understood without being told that his father would not be asked again, and did not ask.

He set the visit down that autumn in the fewest words the Line would bear him use: *the king comes to the wall at Seann Warr and stands a long while before it. Asked what he saw, he answers: a people counting.* He added nothing to explain it, for there was nothing in him that could explain it, and he had begun, by then, to learn from his father's own example that the plainest telling of a thing a man cannot understand is often the only honest one.

IV

Of the Half-Cut Stone

S

omhairle did not go south to the coast at Seann Chwen until his four hundred and seventy-fourth year, some forty years after the wall at Seann Warr thickened, and he went then only because a carrier's tale reached Na Glinn Àrda¹ of a stone left unfinished, a strangeness even among strangenesses, and the reciters of Clann na Ceiste², who by then kept his three earlier tellings among the oldest of the new lines added since Coinneach's death, judged it a thing that wanted a witness rather than a third-hand telling.

Seann Chwen lay two days' ride to the south and west of Dùn ìseal, a larger settlement than either of the other two shores, its houses set close along a strand backed by low dunes, and Somhairle found it, coming down off the dune road in the low light of an evening, quieter than either Seann Warr or Seann Tarr had been at any season he had seen them: fewer boats drawn up than the strand had room for, fewer threads of smoke than the count of houses would account for, doors standing open on rooms he could see were empty from the road.

The midden's stones stood at the shore's southern end, a shorter ridge than the wall at Seann Warr but no less thick with strokes for its shortness, and it was near the ridge's newest end, where the stone should by every pattern Somhairle had learned from the other two shores have carried its freshest cut, that he found Clach nan Dà Stràc³, the one the carrier's tale had named.

It stood no different from its neighbours to look at from a distance, flat, grey, driven into the ground at the same angle as the rest. Up close, the difference was plain. Two strokes ran clean and deep across its face, finished the way every other stroke on every other stone he had seen was finished, cut with a steady hand that knew where the groove would end before the tool ever touched the stone. The third stroke began beside them, cut perhaps a third of its length, the chisel's own marks still visible along the cut's floor where a practised hand had worked it, and then stopped, mid-groove, as cleanly as a man's voice stops mid-word when something reaches through a doorway and takes the rest of the sentence out of him.

Somhairle knelt by it a long while in the failing light, running a finger once, and only once, along the unfinished groove, though he had been taught by every teller before him that a hill man laid no hand on the Seann-Dhaoine⁴'s stones. He could not afterward say why he did it, only that the stone asked to be touched the

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

2. the Children of the Question

3. the last tally stone of Seann Chwen, left half-cut

4. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

way an open wound asks to be looked at, and he had never in four hundred and seventy-four years learned how to refuse a thing that asked so plainly.

No household stood near enough to the ridge that evening to be asked anything, had asking done any good, and Somhairle did not try. He slept that night in the lee of the dunes with his small company, and in the morning, before he rode north again, he walked the ridge once more from end to end and found no stone cut after the half-finished one, not there, and not, when he sent word in the following years to have the wall at Seann Warr and the house at Seann Tarr both checked again, at either of the other two shores.

He set it down as he had set down the rest, in the fewest words the fact would bear: *at Seann Chwen the last stone is left half-cut, two strokes finished and a third begun and forsaken, the chisel marks stopping in the midst of the cut.*

V

Of the Silence

The last smoke any hill man saw rising from Seann Tarr was seen by the carrier who had first told him of the thickening years before, now grown old on the same road, who came up to Na Glinn Àrda¹ that autumn with a tale of finding the house over the dead standing open, its hearth cold, its net-mending bench bare, and no one, living or otherwise, anywhere along that narrow strand to say where the household had gone.

Somhairle rode down himself the following spring and found the man had told it true. The house stood as the carrier had found it, its roof not yet fallen, its door not yet fallen from its hinges, everything in it left as a household leaves a thing it means to come back to and does not; and along the whole shore, in the dozen houses that had stood there in his own remembering, no smoke rose at all, from any hearth, on a morning cold enough that smoke would have shown a mile off had there been any to show.

There was no need to go that year to Seann Warr or Seann Chwen, for word had already reached him from both that the same quiet had come to each in its own season, in no cause a hill man could point to and name, within the span of a few years of each other, until by his five hundred and thirteenth year, when he set

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

the matter down for what he judged would be the last time, there was no shore on the eastern coast, the north-east, or the south where the Seann-Dhaoine² still kept a fire.

He rode the coast road himself that last year, alone, from Seann Warr to Seann Tarr and down again to Seann Chwen, three shores in one long circuit no reciter before him had ever made in a single season, and found at each the same stillness: middens grown over at their edges where no new stone had been cut to keep the ground bare, boats left to rot on their keels or gone entirely, the low turf houses softening back, roof by roof, into the shape of the ground they had been raised from. No one at any of the three could tell him where a household had gone, for the households who might have told him were themselves gone, and the hill-folk who had traded that coast for generations had, by then, mostly given over walking to shores that no longer answered a knock.

He set down the silence in the same spare hand he had used for the wall and the house and the stone, and it was the shortest of his four tellings: *after Clach nan Dà Stràc³ no work of the Seann-Dhaoine can be dated. Their middens stop growing, their harbours silt, and their strokes are cut no more. How they ended, this telling does not know.* Nothing was put before that last sentence that pretended to know more than it did, though he was asked, more than once in the years that followed, by reciters younger than himself who wanted a fuller answer than the Line was willing to give them. He told them what his father had told him without ever quite saying it in words: that some questions the world does not mean to answer, and a teller does himself no honour going on asking the second kind past the point where asking has anything left to find.

VI

Of Cairistìona

It was in the ordinary run of things, and not by any turning the Line thought worth marking on its own account, that Somhairle came, in his five hundred and forty-second year, to marry.

She was Cairistìona, of a household in Na Glinn Àrda¹ that had kept sheep on the same slopes since before the king ever rode north with the six pots, and Som-

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

hairle had known her the plain way a man of the valleys knows his neighbours, across a dozen ordinary years of gatherings and shearings and the small business of households that live near one another, before either of them thought to call the knowing anything more than that. She was not of Clann na Ceiste², and had no wish to be; she kept sheep, and mended, and sang, when the mood took her, in a low clear voice that Somhairle had once heard carry the whole length of a shearing pen without anyone in it troubling to hush for her, and she asked him, the autumn he finally asked her, why a man who could recite four generations of a stranger's dead without missing a name had taken so many years to find the one of his own worth the asking.

He had no good answer for her, then or later, beyond the true one, which was that the years did not press on him the way they pressed on other men, and that he had let himself believe, without ever quite deciding to believe it, that there would always be time enough later for the things that were not the Line.

They were married at the turn of the year, in Na Glinn Àrda, before the fires of both their households and what reciters of Clann na Ceiste could be spared from the slab, and it was, by every account that reached Dùn ìseal afterward, a plain wedding and a glad one, with nothing in it that wanted setting down for its own sake, and Somhairle set nothing of it down himself, for he had learned by then which of the things that happened to a man belonged to the Line and which belonged only to the man.

He did add, that same winter, one line more to the telling of the three shores, the last he ever added to it, for he judged, turning the matter over by his own hearth with Cairistiona asleep beside him, that a fact once told plainly needed no further ornament, whatever a man might privately go on wondering about it for the rest of his years. He wrote only that the coasts that had once answered a hill trader's knock now answered nothing at all, and that this was the whole of what any teller of the Line, king's son or otherwise, had ever truly seen, and set his hand to it, and added, beneath the last line, nothing more.

3. the last tally stone of Seann Chwen, left half-cut

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

2. the Children of the Question

PART TWO

Salt and the Handful

CHAPTER EIGHT

Of the Old Names

GE 591 – 671

At Seann Skell the boat-menders still say a household came down the river before any of them had a boat to mend, and would not so much as lean a ladder on the old stones to reach their own roof.

I

Of the Word Seann

In the five hundred and ninety-first year of the hill, word went down every valley the king's blood had settled that a son had been born to Somhairle in the high pastures, a boy got on Cairistiona and named Beathan, and that Somhairle meant to keep him there among Clann na Ceiste¹ rather than bring him down to the hill at all. It was carried by no messenger sent for the purpose, only by the ordinary traffic of drovers and salt-carriers who passed word along with everything else they carried, and it reached Iain mac Fhearchair's household on the middle reaches of the Abhainn naomh the same week as the shearing, so that the two things sat together afterward in the memory of that year: the wool piled white on the green, and the news that the long-lived line had another child in it who would, if the pattern held, still be a boy to look at when Iain's own grandchildren were old.

Iain's household had been settled on the river a generation, in a bend where the water ran slow enough for cattle to ford it without swimming, and they knew the coast only at second hand, from traders who came up with strings of shell and salted fish and went back down again with wool and hides, speaking of a shore

1. the Children of the Question

two days further on where a people neither the king's nor any other's had once lived thick along every inlet and left their houses standing when they went. It was in Iain's father's day, or his father's father's, that the hill-folk settling those upper reaches had begun to call the old places by their old names with the plain word for *old* set in front, rather than trouble to make new names of their own or learn what the places had once been called in full: Seann Dunn and Seann Chwen for old places on coasts far off, Seann Skell for the harbour town, whose true name, if the Seann-Dhaoine² who built it had ever spoken one aloud to a hill man, had not come down to anyone still living to speak it back. No one had decided this the way a judgement was decided on the hill. It had simply grown, the way a path grows across a field where enough feet have already gone, and by the time Iain was a grown man with a household of his own it was no more a choice to say *Seann Skell* than it was a choice to say *river* for the water running past his door.

"We keep their names and touch nothing else of theirs," Iain told his daughter Marsaili more than once, when she was young enough still to ask him why, "because a name costs nothing to keep and a great deal to make, and because I have never yet heard of any good coming to a man who took up a thing the Seann-Dhaoine left lying." He said this the way he said most things, without much weight behind it, a rule handed down the way a shape for cutting turf is handed down, useful and unexamined; and Marsaili, born the ninth year after Beathan and growing up on the same bend of river her father had grown up on, took the rule in with her milk and thought no more about it than she thought about the water's own habit of running downhill.

She grew up hearing the coast talked of at the fire the way distant, half-believed places are always talked of by people who have never gone there: the harbour with its old mole running out into the tide, long enough, the traders said, to shelter a dozen boats, though no hill boat had ever tied up along it in living memory; the low round houses set back from the water with roofs of turf grown so old and so thick they seemed part of the ground; and, standing apart from the houses nearer the harbour mouth, a tower of dry stone, squat and windowless but for a slit here and there, that no trader who had ever gone down that road claimed to have set foot inside, or wished to. Iain himself had seen it once, as a young man carrying wool down with his own father, and would say only that he had stood a while looking at it and had felt no wish at all to go nearer, a feeling he

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

could put no better word to than the feeling a man gets standing at the edge of another household's grief, uninvited and better off staying that way.

Marsaili's grandmother, who had come up the river herself as a girl from a household further south and had once, as a young woman, gone the whole way down to trade at the harbour before any hill family lived within two days of it, told a different kind of tale of the coast, less awed than practical: that the Seann-Dhaoiné's houses, whatever queerness clung to the tower, were built no differently in their bones from a hill house, stone and turf and a hearth in the middle, only rounder and lower and set closer to their neighbours than hill custom liked; that the smell of the place, salt and weed and the char of driftwood fires, was the whole of what she remembered as strange about it; and that she had stood once at the harbour mouth and counted eleven boats out on the water at once, drawn each toward a different reach of the tide with no more order to them than a scatter of gulls, and thought, young as she was, that she had never in her life seen so many hands at one work with no one among them giving orders. Marsaili turned that telling over more than the tower's, though she could not have said, even at the time, why one stayed with her longer than the other; only that it seemed to promise something the fireside talk of towers and silence did not: a shore that had once held ordinary lives as well as mystery, boats out at their ordinary work, a people who had risen in the morning to mend nets rather than to be spoken of forever after in a hushed voice by strangers who had never known them.

II

Of the Coming to the Harbour

Marsaili was eight-and-twenty, married four years to Tearlach mac Ghilleonain and mother already to two children with a third on the way, when her father called the household together on an evening in the dark half of the year and told them, without any great preamble, that he meant to move it down to the coast before another winter turned.

The river bend had grown crowded in his lifetime, three households now grazing ground that had fed one comfortably in his father's day, and word had come up, as word always came, that the harbour at Seann Skell stood as empty of hill-folk as it had ever stood, a river-mouth with good landing and no one living close enough to use it. "The Seann-Dhaoine¹ are gone from it entirely," he said, "and have been gone longer than any of us has lived, and I would rather my grandchildren grew up on a shore with fish in easy reach than go on quarrelling over this bend with my brother's sons for another forty years." No one argued the sense of it strongly enough to change his mind, though Marsaili's mother wept the first night over the grave of her own mother, which she would be leaving behind unvisited, and Tearlach said little, being a man who followed where his wife's father led and had long since made his peace with it.

They went down in the early spring of the six hundred and twenty-eighth year, eleven souls and what beasts and goods a scatter of ox-carts could carry, following the Abhainn naomh two days further than any of them had gone before, until the river widened between low banks and the air changed, carrying salt under the green smell of the water the way a distant fire carries smoke before it can be seen. They came out at last above the pool where the river met the tide and looked down on the harbour their traders had spoken of for three generations without any of them having stood where Marsaili now stood: houses roofless and grown over in green, the old mole running out from the shingle in its long low line of unmortared stone, its landward end still dry but its far foot already under the first of the flood tide, exactly as the traders had always said it would be; and set apart from the rest, nearer the harbour's mouth than any house had been built, the tower, grey and blind-walled, with gulls going in and out of the slits in its side as freely as if no one had ever built it and no one had ever left it.

Their first camp that night was pitched on the higher ground behind the old houses, not among them, though the roofless walls would have made a readier shelter than the carts and hides they slept under; and it was Iain who set the rule before anyone else could set it differently, walking the ground himself in the last of the light and marking with a line of stones where a household might build and where it must not, keeping every new wall a stone's throw and more from the nearest standing Seann-Dhaoine wall, and the whole camp further still from the tower.

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

"We will use what is already given to any hand that walks the shore," he told them, meaning the mole, the harbour, the fish that had gone uncaught in it for however many years it had stood empty, "and we will raise nothing of our own against what is theirs, and we will not go into that tower, not to shelter from rain, not to store grain, not for any reason a man can think of on a dry night that will not look a great deal smaller to him on a wet one." The hill kept no law in those years, only the king's own judgements given one at a time on his own hill, and no king's word had ever reached this shore at all. What held here was only Iain's rule for his own household, given the weight an old man's rule carries when no one troubles to test it, and it held, that first season, without a single soul asking why more than once.

They built their first houses that summer within sight of the old ones but never touching them, using timber carried down with the carts and turf cut fresh from the higher ground, and mended the landward stretch of the mole with stones gathered from the shore rather than lifted from the mole, a distinction Iain was careful to draw and careful that his sons and his sons-in-law drew after him: a man might lay a new stone beside an old one, he said, but he would not take an old stone up to make it new, for the taking felt to him a different thing entirely from the laying, though he could not have said in words exactly where the difference lay.

III

Of the Storm and the Cracked Stone

Marsaili's third child, a daughter, was born that autumn in a house not yet a full season old, with the sound of the tide new enough in everyone's ears that her mother swore afterward the child had slept worse for it than either of her brothers had slept for anything in their own first winters; and it was in the deep of that same winter, in the first days of an Fhaoilleach with the year barely turned, that the first great storm out of the west found the harbour and put every soul in it to a test none of them had faced on the river.

It came in the night, as the worst of them do, a wind that rose from nothing in the space of an hour and drove the tide higher up the shingle than the eldest among them, who remembered storms enough from the river years, had ever seen water climb on open coast. Marsaili woke to hear the roof-tree groaning overhead

and Tearlach already up and bracing the door with his own shoulder against a wind that seemed to want the whole house and not merely the roof of it, and she gathered her children into the one dry corner and sat with them through the worst of it not knowing, until daylight came grey and reluctant over a sea still heaving, whether the mole her father had set such store by mending would stand the night at all.

It had not stood whole. The seaward third of it, the oldest stretch and the part no hill hand had touched, lay broken where the worst of the sea had found a weakness the tide alone had never shown, great unmortared stones thrown down and scattered along the shingle like a wall a giant had kicked apart in passing, and the harbour that had sheltered nothing more than a handful of coracles through the autumn now lay open at its mouth to whatever the sea chose to send in.

There was argument that morning, the first real argument the household had had since the leaving of the river, for two of Iain's sons-in-law held that the broken stones, lying now scattered and half buried in shingle rather than set in their old order, were no longer truly the Seann-Dhaoine's wall at all but only stone, ready stone, lying where any hand might lift it and set it again to better purpose than the sea had left it; and Iain, old now and walking the wreck of the mole with a stick he had not needed on the river, heard them out and said no.

"They are broken," he told them, "but they are not ours for the breaking, and a thing does not become mine because the sea has done to it what I would not do myself. If the mole is to stand again it will stand on new stone laid by our own hands beside what is left of the old, the way it stood before the storm, and not built up out of what the storm knocked down." Tearlach, who had held his tongue through the whole of the argument as he generally did, said only, when it was over, that he thought the old man right, though he could no more have said why than Iain himself could, only that it seemed to him a shore a man had only lately come to was no place to start testing which of another people's rules could be broken and which could not, when the people themselves were no longer there to say.

They mended the mole that spring with fresh-quarried stone from the higher ground, a harder labour by far than reusing what lay ready to hand on the shingle, and the work went slower for it, so that it was two summers before the harbour stood sheltered end to end again; but no household on that shore, in all the years

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

Marsaili afterward kept count of, ever again argued seriously for lifting a Seann-Dhaoine stone to lay it elsewhere, whatever state the sea or the years had left it in.

The quarrying taught them things the river had never had cause to teach: which of the higher slopes gave stone that split clean along a true face and which gave stone that shattered wherever it pleased, which carts could be trusted down the steep track to the shingle loaded and which would want a second pair of hands at the tail-rope on the last pitch. Marsaili, carrying her own weight in stone down that track through the whole of the second summer with her youngest strapped across her back, came to know the harbour's ground better in those two years of hauling than she ever came to know the river's, and said once, laughing, to Tearlach, that she had left her father's country to escape one kind of labour and found the sea had simply given her another; and Tearlach, who laughed rarely, laughed at that, and answered that at least the sea's labour ended somewhere a man could see it end, in a mended wall standing plain against the tide, whereas the river's quarrels over grazing ground had never in his lifetime ended at all, only paused between one dispute and the next.

IV

Of the Boats and the Burial

It was in the six hundred and fortieth year, with the mole whole again and three more households come down from the river to join the first, that Tearlach and two of Iain's grandsons built the first boats the harbour had held since whatever craft the Seann-Dhaoine¹ had once kept there, small round-sided hide boats of a kind the hill had always used on lake and river, never before trusted to open tide; and it was Marsaili, not any of the men who had built them, who insisted on being in the first that went out from the mended stone, on a morning calm enough that even Iain, watching from the shingle with the caution of a man who had buried nothing yet to the sea and meant to keep it that way as long as he could manage, allowed that the risk was a small one.

She remembered, all the years she lived after, less of the fishing, ordinary enough once the strangeness of open water under her had worn off in the first hour, than of looking back at the harbour from out past the mole's broken and

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

mended length and seeing, for the first time from that angle, how the shape of the old landing had been made, centuries before any hill hand cut a single new stone for it, by people who had understood the set of the tide and the run of the current well enough that the household's own hurried mending had done little more than follow, stone for stone, a plan already laid down and only needing to be honoured rather than improved upon. She said as much to her father that evening, and Iain, who had spent forty years believing a stone left better than touched, only nodded and said that he had thought something of the kind more than once, standing on the mole at low water, and had never found a way of saying it that did not sound, even to his own ear, more like the Seann-Dhaoine's due than a hill man's.

The boats went out through that whole summer and the years after it, and the harbour that had stood empty across every hill man's lifetime before Iain's began, slowly, to keep the ordinary marks of a shore that was lived on: nets drying, a smokehouse raised for the first catch too large to eat fresh, children set to mind the coracles at low tide the way children on the river had once been set to mind cattle at the ford. It was in the six hundred and sixtieth year, with Iain himself eleven years dead and Marsaili holding the household in his place, that the sea took its first life from among them in earnest, a young man of Tearlach's own house drowned in a squall that came up faster than any boat then on that shore could outrun, and it fell to Marsaili to decide, with no custom of the river to guide her and none of the Seann-Dhaoine left to ask, how a household newly of the sea ought to bury one the sea had taken.

She chose, in the end, neither the river's cairn, which felt to her a landsman's answer to a thing the sea had done, nor any borrowing from what little could be guessed of the Seann-Dhaoine's own way with their dead, of which nothing certain had ever been carried up from that shore but rumour and the strokes on a midden stone two days' walk to the south; she chose instead to bury him on the higher ground behind the houses, within sound of the water but above its reach, with stones set at his head and feet in the plain hill fashion her own mother's grave on the river had worn, and told the household afterward, when one of the younger ones asked why they had not tried the sea itself, that a household new to a shore had no business inventing rites for it before it had lived there long enough to know what the shore would teach, and that the plain way, at least, wronged no one living or dead.

She held the harbour a further eleven years after that burial, long enough to see four more households come down the river to join the first four, long enough

to see her own grandchildren born within sound of the tide who had never seen the river bend their grandfather had left, and long enough to have word reach her, once, of the king himself, riding the coast road in the company of no more than three men and stopping a night, not at her hearth, which never had that honour, but at a household two harbours further south that afterward told and retold the little he had said of Seann Skell: that he had heard the hill was settling an empty shore, and thought it a good thing, and would send no one to tell them how to hold it. It was the whole of what reached her, third-hand and thinner with every telling, and she made no more of it than the household two harbours south had made, save to say, when it was repeated to her at her own fire, that it sounded like a man content to let a shore be filled the way it wanted filling, and that she had never once, in forty-three years upon it, felt the want of any other kind of king.

In her last winter she took to sitting on the shingle of an evening with the mended mole running out dark before her into water gone the colour of the sky, and it was there her eldest daughter asked her once whether she missed the river, meaning the question kindly, as one asks an old woman a question already half answered by the asking of it. Marsaili said that she did not, and that she had come in the end to think of the harbour less as a thing the household had taken up empty than as a thing that had been waiting, stone by patient stone, for hands willing to use it without ever quite believing it was wholly theirs to use. She died in the six hundred and seventy-first year, the first of Iain's line to be buried within sight of the sea rather than beside the river her father had led them away from, and her household laid her, by her own wish given plainly enough beforehand that no one thought to argue it, on the same rise above the shingle where the young drowned man lay, within sound of water that had never, in all her years upon it, told her whether the Seann-Dhaoine had built their harbour for a people not their own to use, or for no reason a hill mind could ever hope to reach.

CHAPTER NINE

OF MÒRAG the hard

GE 672 – 719

At Dùn ìseal the reciters give her the one deed and no other, and say that one is enough to carry a name the length of the list.

I

Of the Hill Without Salt

Mòrag Chruaidh was eighteen years short of four hundred and had held the hill for her father the better part of a generation before she gave the household its first war. Dòmhnall Clachach had ridden north in the hundred and fifty-first year of his own holding to see what could be made of ground his people had only lately come to, and he had been gone, by the time Mòrag's tale properly begins, longer than most of the households below the bank could remember him being present; so that to the children born on the hill in those years the king's blood that sat in judgement there and settled the grazing and heard the quarrels was, from their first memory of it, a tall, dark-browed woman who never once let slip that the hill was not, in the fullest sense, her own.

It was not her own, and she knew it better than anyone said aloud. Dòmhnall held it of the king; she held it of Dòmhnall; and beneath all the holding, further back than any bank or ditch, the hill and the valleys round it were the king's, in the plain sense that he had taken them with his own hand and never once given the taking away. Mòrag judged, and levied, and rode out with a spear at her side when a spear was needed, and slept easier for knowing that whatever she failed to settle could, in the last account, be carried to a man whose years never told on him and whose memory held every name once given him. It was a good arrangement

for a woman with the temper her father's line ran to, and she had never yet found the want in it.

The hill Mòrag held was not the hill her father had taken. The bank her father Dòmhnall had set the boundary stones for still ran round it, but three more rings of houses had grown up outside the first bank in the years since, and the valley road that had once ended at the gate now ran on south and west to a dozen daughter settlements that sent their grazing quarrels up to the hill the same as they had always done, only in greater number and with less patience for waiting their turn. Mòrag heard them in the same low stone hall her father had built, sitting the chair he had sat, and gave judgement in the plain, unhedging way the household had come, over three generations, to expect of anyone who sat it: a sentence, seldom more than a sentence, and the hearing closed. She had grown up watching her father do the same and had never once, as a child, imagined she would be doing it herself before he was dead, or even much aged; it was one of the small, unspoken strangenesses of a household of the king's blood that a holder might sit a chair for a hundred years and more and see her own grandchildren grow grey while she herself was only beginning to feel the first weight of the years in her knees of a cold morning.

She found the want the autumn the hill went without salt.

It was not the first such autumn. Salt was a thing the hill bought or bartered for, brought up from the southern shore by traders who kept the terms of the trade to themselves and raised the price a little each year the hill's herds grew and the hill's hunger for it grew with them; and there had been lean seasons before when a bad crossing or a bad harvest on the trading side left the hill's larders going into winter with meat that would not keep and no way to keep it. What was new that autumn was the manner of the going without. Three separate traders, in the space of one summer, had come up the valley road empty-handed and sworn, each in his own way, that the southern shore had stopped selling; that the folk who worked the salt-scrapes at Baile ghorm had grown proud of what they made and meant, this year, to keep the whole of it for themselves and their own kin along the coast, and had said as much, plainly, to any hill trader who came asking.

Mòrag heard the third of these traders out in the hall her father had built, a low stone room hung with the antlers of beasts long since hunted out of the near valleys, and said nothing for a while after he had finished, turning the matter the way she turned most matters that came to her, slowly and from more than one side before she let herself speak on it. "They have salt and no king," she said at last,

half to the trader and half to herself. "We have a king and no salt. Between us that is no bargain at all, only two households that have not yet learned which one is the stronger."

She did not send to her father in the north before she decided what to do about it, and told herself afterward, when there was time to tell herself anything, that a season's riding would have brought his answer back too late to matter and that a holder who could not judge for herself in her holder's own absence was no holder at all; both of which were true, and neither of which was the whole of why she went. The whole of why she went she kept to herself, then and after, save that once, very old, she told a great-grandchild that she had wanted, that autumn, to know for certain whether the strength that had taken every valley the hill now held had come down to her at all, or had stopped somewhere short of her father's father and left her nothing but the name.

II

Of the Shingle at Baile ghorm

She took eleven men south along a coast track the hill's herders used for driving beasts to the winter grazing, and came down on the salt-scrapes at Baile ghorm in the grey hour before a summer dawn, meaning, she told her own men more than once on the road, to take the salt and nothing more: no house burned, no beast lifted that was not already a working ox needed to carry the load away, no blood shed that the salt-folk did not themselves choose to shed defending it. It went otherwise, as such things generally do once the first spear leaves a man's hand rather than his intention.

Mòrag had never seen the sea before that road brought her to it, and she said afterward, to the one or two she ever spoke to plainly of that morning, that the first sight of it in the grey light, flat and enormous and giving off a smell like nothing the hill valleys had ever taught her to expect, had unsettled her more than the fighting that followed. Her men, drawn from households that drove beasts to the winter grazing within sound of that same shore, took the sight as no more than a familiar landmark reached at last, and it was one of them, a broad, unhurried man named Gilleonan who had made the drive a dozen times and never once thought to raid at the end of it, who first pointed out to her, in a whisper pitched not to carry, the low red glow strung along the strand ahead of them where the salt-

hearths still burned through the last of the night, banked but not let die, exactly as a household bank a hearth-fire it means to want again before morning.

The salt was made in those years over open hearths set along the shingle above the tide line, shallow stone-lined pits kept burning through the drying months while women fed them driftwood and raked the crusting brine, work that blackened the hands and thickened the skin of the forearms in a way Mòrag noticed, afterward, on every salt-worker she ever after had cause to look closely at. The hearths could not be carried off. What could be carried off was what they had already made, heaped in baskets and skin bags under low turf shelters at the shingle's head, and it was these Mòrag's men went for, working fast in the half-light while she herself stood watch at the shelters' mouth with four spears about her and told herself the thing was nearly done.

It was not nearly done. Mòrag stood at the shelters' mouth in the last dark listening to her own men working the baskets free of the turf with a care that struck her, even at the time, as oddly gentle for men in the act of a raid, as though the habit of handling salt without wasting a grain of it had come over them the moment their hands closed on the baskets, whatever else was in their minds that morning. She had told them, on the road down, to take nothing they did not need to carry the taking off cleanly, and she watched them keep that word with a thoroughness that later struck her as almost comic beside what came after: men stepping carefully over a sleeping dog's blanket so as not to wake it, a basket set down and re-tied when its cord slipped, as though the whole enterprise were no more than an ill-mannered borrowing that decent men would see set right before they left.

A dog gave tongue somewhere up the strand before the last basket was clear of the shelters, and the salt-folk came down onto the shingle in twos and threes and then in a rush, men first and then, close behind them, women who had been raking the hearths since before light and came still holding the long wooden rakes they raked with, which proved, in the event, weapons enough at close quarters against men encumbered with baskets. Mòrag's people got the greater part of the salt away up the strand before the fighting closed round them properly, but the getting away cost seven lives on the hill's side before it was done: three cut down on the shingle itself, one taken by a rake-blow to the skull that no one on either side had thought could kill a man and did, two more overtaken on the track above the strand by salt-folk who knew the ground better than any hill man could in the dark, and the last, a boy not yet twenty summers who had begged Mòrag to let

him come because his elder brother was already one of the eleven, drowned trying to swim a inlet he had judged, wrongly, narrower than it was.

Mòrag herself killed no one that morning, a fact she never afterward either claimed as mercy or denied as failure, saying only, when asked directly by one of her own grandchildren many years on, that she had spent the whole of the fighting getting her people and the salt clear of the strand and had had no leisure that morning to keep a tally of who fell to whose hand. What she did do, standing at the shingle's head with the last basket loaded and her own men falling back around her in a ragged line, was turn once, before the light was fully up, and look back down the strand at where her seven lay among stones already dark with more than seawater, and she made, in that turning, the one decision of the whole raid she never afterward doubted: that whatever the hill said of the salt, and whatever the king said when word of it reached him, the seven names would not be let go the way a lost beast or a broken tool is let go.

III

Of the Bank Behind the Shingle

She kept that decision through four days' ride home with the salt on the hill's own carts and her dead carried the shorter way, by boat along the coast to the nearest point a cart track could meet them, and she kept it through the winter that followed, in which the hill ate salted meat again for the first time in two years and no one below the bank asked her too closely what the salt had cost to bring. At the turn of that winter, on the night the hill kept for its dead in the ordinary way, she stood at the fire her father had built the hall's hearth from and named all seven aloud, one after another, in the order they had fallen so far as anyone could tell it: Donnchadh Bàn first, her own father's oldest belted man, who had gone down under the first rush at the shelters' mouth; then the three of the strand; then the two of the track; then, last and youngest, the boy who had drowned asking to be let come. She named them again the winter after that, and the winter after that, until the naming was a thing the hill did every year at the same fire without anyone having to be told to do it, and the reciters keep it still, said each year now by households who know none of the seven by anything more than the name itself.

Word of what had answered her raid reached the hill more slowly, brought up by the same traders who had once brought salt and now, for a season, brought nothing at all. The salt-folk of Baile ghorm, it was told, had lost the raid's night but had not, in the reckoning that mattered to them, lost the salt itself, for salt is a thing the sea goes on making whether or not any given year's hearths stand. What they had lost, and set about mending within the same season, was the manner of keeping it safe: a fire that burns for a season burns in one place, tended by hands that must sleep sometime, and can be come at in the dark by anyone willing to risk the raking-women's rakes. Within two summers of Mòrag's raid the folk of Baile ghorm had raised a low bank of shingle and turf behind the tide line, and inside it had dug shallow clay-lined basins that needed no fire at all, only sun and wind and the slow work of months, the brine thickening on its own where no torch had to be kept burning to give a raider his mark in the dark. It was the first work of its kind the hill-folk had ever heard of, and it changed, within a lifetime, how salt was made the length of that shore; and though none of the tellers who carried the news up to Dùn ìseal ever said so in as many words, every one of them understood, and Mòrag understood best of all when she heard it, that the bank behind the shingle had been raised as much against her as against the sea.

I V

Of the Red Hill and the Pebble Bag

Word of the raid reached the king before word of the bank did, carried, as such things were carried in those years, faster than any single messenger could have carried it, by the ordinary passing of the news from hearth to hearth along the roads Mòrag's own carts had used. He came to Dùn ìseal himself the spring after, riding down out of the north with no great company about him, and Mòrag met him at the gate the way she had met few enough kings' visits in her life, having held the hill so long under her father's long absence that she had half forgotten what it was to stand second to anyone on her own ground.

He heard the whole of it from her own mouth, sitting the evening through in the hall her father had built, and asked few questions, and made, when she had finished, no judgement at all in the sense she had braced herself to hear one. "The south is not mine yet," he said, when she pressed him at last for some word of blame or of praise, one or the other, so that she would know which way to carry

the matter forward. "You took salt from a people who owe me nothing, and lost seven doing it, and they answered you well enough that you will not take salt from them that way again. I will not tell you that was rightly done, and I will not tell you it was wrongly done, because it was neither mine to forbid nor mine yet to avenge." He was warm where his arm brushed hers crossing the hall's threshold, warm the way a hearthstone is warm long after the fire has been let sink, a thing she noticed and did not remark on, having grown up hearing it remarked on by everyone older than herself until the remarking itself had worn thin.

What he did instead of judging was take her west with him, a week's riding and more along tracks that grew narrower and less certain the further they went from the hill's own valleys, through country Mòrag had never had cause to see, low wooded ridges giving way at last to open water that lay so still under the evening light she took it, the first hour she saw it, for a second sky fallen to earth. The king rode the whole way in no great haste and said little of where they went or why, and Mòrag, who had never before travelled at his side for longer than an evening's hearing, came in those days to understand something of what the household meant when it said, of him, that he was easier company on a road than in a hall: he asked after her father's health in the north, and after the boy who had drowned in the inlet, whose name he had already by heart though no one had told it him twice, and once, on the third evening, sang a verse of something in no tongue she recognised, low and to himself, that she never afterward heard him sing again and never once asked him what it had been.

They came at last to the lake shore where An Cnoc Ruadh¹ stood, an old holding of its own line that had never once sworn to Dùn Ìseal and never once needed to, owing the king directly and no one between. Seonag nic Uisdein held it then, of Uisdean Mòr's blood though born, the list already said of her, more than three hundred years after he died, and she met the king at her own gate with a worn leather bag at her belt that Mòrag took at first for nothing more than the ordinary purse a holder might carry to a meeting of consequence.

It was not a purse. Seonag opened it before the king without being asked and weighed it once, twice, in her open palm, her lips moving a little as she did, and said that the bag held one pebble for every household on the hill and along the shore below it, set in when a household was first counted and taken out again, without ceremony, the season a household failed or moved on or was absorbed

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

into another; so that she needed no reciter and no written tally to know, at any hour a man cared to ask her, how many hearths answered to An Cnoc Ruadh, only the weight of a bag she had carried at her own belt since she was a girl learning the count from her mother. The king took the bag from her hands and weighed it himself, the same small motion, and gave it back, and said only that he was content; and it was the whole of the business between them, no more words spent on it than that, though Mòrag, watching, understood she had been brought the whole week's ride west to see it.

She turned the pebble bag over in her mind the length of the ride home, weighing it, she told herself more than once, the way Seonag weighed her own. Seonag held a shore that had never raised a bank against a raid because it had never given the sea's folk cause to raise one; held it, so far as Mòrag could see in the short days she spent at An Cnoc Ruadh's gate, by knowing exactly what she held and claiming not one pebble's weight beyond it. Mòrag had gone south with eleven spears to take what was not owed her and had come home with seven names to carry the rest of her life for the taking of it. She did not, in the years after, ever raise another raid, though she never once said, to anyone who asked her plainly why not, that the pebble bag was the reason.

V

Of the Years That Followed

The years after the raid went the way most years on a settled hill go, told afterward less as a string of single days than as a handful of things a household remembered doing for the first time. Word came up from the southwest coast, in the seven hundred and fifth year, that households at Doire shean had begun firing clay pots in open bonfires, coil upon coil built up and baked hard in a single burning, a craft that within a few lifetimes spread the length of the southern shore and put an end, wherever it reached, to the older habit of carrying water and grain in skins that split and baskets that rotted; Mòrag heard of it from a trader glad, for once, to be carrying news rather than salt, and had two of the first pots brought up to the hill's own hearth, where they sat, chipped and much mended, longer than she herself sat the hill. Eleven years after that, at the landing on the green river now called, by the folk who used it, Cidhe Beag, a boat was hollowed whole from a single oak trunk, long enough to carry six men and

their gear, and sunk at its mooring and left there, the first boat of its kind anyone then living had seen made in one unbroken piece rather than built up plank by lashed plank; and though it lay a long way from Mòrag's own hill and she never once saw it with her own eyes, the telling of it reached her all the same, as the telling of most new things on the island by then reached whoever held Dùn ìseal, sooner or later, by one road or another.

In the meantime the hill went on eating salt bought rather than salt taken, for the traders of Baile ghorm, whatever they thought privately of the household that had raided them, found within a few seasons that a bank of clay basins made more salt than seven hearths ever had, and that a hill with wool or hides to trade was worth more to them standing than raided. Mòrag herself never again sat across a bargaining fire from any of them, holding that a holder who had once taken by the spear had no business haggling afterward as though nothing had passed between the two households; she left the trading to men of her own who had not ridden south with her, and took what salt came up the valley road without asking too closely what price had been struck for it. It was, she told herself, no more than the ordinary distance a holder kept from the ordinary business of her own hill, though more than one of her own household noticed, without ever saying so where she could hear it, that she kept that particular distance more carefully than any other.

She held the hill forty-seven years in all, counting from the raid, and gave it up at last with her strength still whole in her, having judged, as she told the household plainly enough when she told them anything, that a hill was ill served by a holder who stayed past the age when she still had something to learn from it, and that the king's line, by then, had another of its own ready for the holding. The one who came after her was her father's own brother, Iain Dubh, a son of the king himself and older by every reckoning than she was, though he looked, that year, no more than a man in his middle strength beside her own face, which had begun, that year, to show its first lines; and it was Iain Dubh, taking the hill from her hand at the gate in the seven hundred and nineteenth year, who asked her the one question no one else in the household had thought, in all the years since, to put to her directly.

"How did you do it," he said, not naming the thing he meant, because there was only the one thing between them worth asking after, "with eleven spears against a whole shore, and come home with only seven lost?"

Mòrag looked at him a while before she answered, the way she had looked at most things worth the trouble of an answer, and said at last that she did not rightly know how she had done it, only that she had gone down meaning to take salt and had come home understanding that a household's strength was never so plainly its own as it liked to believe, and that the seven she had lost had bought her that understanding at a price she would not, if the choosing were given her again, judge worth paying twice. It was the whole of what she gave him, and the reciters, who kept little enough of her beyond the one deed, kept that answer with it, and no more.

CHAPTER TEN

Of the Shingle at Baile Ghorm

GE 719 – 729

*At Baile ghorm the salt-rakers still tell it as Màiri nan Làn told it,
and add nothing to her telling and take nothing from it.*

I

Of the Pans

Baile ghorm in those years was a scatter of huts behind a shingle bar, and the shingle bar was the reason for everything else. Behind it lay clay basins the salt-folk had dug with their own hands out of the mud a spring tide could no longer reach, and the sun and the slow fires under the basins did the rest, so that what came out at the end of a good week was salt enough to trade the length of the southern shore and some way past it. Màiri nan Làn had raked salt from the time she was old enough to be trusted with the wooden rake and not trusted with anything sharper, and she went on raking it the whole of her life after, and it was this, more than the year she is chiefly remembered for, that filled the greater part of her days: salt, and the sun on the pans, and the particular ache across the shoulders that came from drawing a rake through drying crystal from dawn until the light went.

The salt-folk of Baile ghorm did not then call themselves the king's, and had not, in Màiri's grandmother's time, so much as heard his name spoken with any certainty of what it meant. The hill lay a long way north and inland, a good many days' walking by the tracks they knew, and the southern shore had gone on mak-

ing its own salt and keeping its own dead and marrying its own children into its own households without reference to any hill at all, the way a shore does when nothing has yet come down it hard enough to make reference necessary. Word had come, in the years before Màiri's birth, of a granddaughter of the hill's line who had ridden down with spears and carried off a season's salt in one raid, and lost seven of her own doing it, and the salt-folk had gone back to their pans afterward because there was no other place to go back to. Behind the shingle bar they had raised a low bank in the years just after, a slight thing that would slow a determined raid without ever quite stopping one, and had thought, most of them, that this settled the matter as well as it was likely to be settled.

Màiri's own mother had been a girl at the pans the year Mòrag Chruaidh came, old enough to remember the shapes of the running, though too young to be given a rake she might have to drop and run from, and she had passed the telling to Màiri the way the shore passed everything, at the fire, in pieces, over years, until the child no longer remembered a time before she had known it. Seven of the hill's men had died on the shingle and the track that morning, her mother said, and the salt-folk had counted them where they lay and let the hill carry them home; and Màiri grew up knowing that count as well as she knew her own kin's names, though she had never seen any of the seven living. It seemed to her, hearing it as a child, a settled story with a settled end, a raid that had happened once and would not happen twice, the bank behind the bar built and the account closed. She was thirty-seven before she understood how wrong a child's sense of an ending can be.

It was Iain Dubh who unsettled it again. Màiri knew him only as a name that meant trouble was owed and had not yet been paid, a hill man's name carried south on the same paths that carried salt north, and she was thirty-seven years old, with two grown sons of her own gone to households of their own and a third child still under her roof, on the morning she first saw him with her own eyes. She did not know, raking that morning, that she was seeing the last morning he would ever have.

II

Of the Coming of Iain Dubh

he came the way the other one had come, from the north and inland, with spears enough behind him to make the salt-folk's low bank look exactly as inadequate as it was, and he came, as the first one had, for the salt. The salt-folk had had eight years since Iain Dubh took the hill from his father, eight years of hearing that he was harder even than the woman before him, or easier, or unlike her altogether, for such word travels a long road and grows a different shape at every hearth it passes, and none of it prepared them for the morning the spears actually stood on the ridge above the pans with the light behind them.

Tadhg Garbh was thirty-two that year, a big slow man who had never in Màiri's memory raised his voice at anything, married two years to a woman named Beathag who kept geese behind the huts and was, by every account but his own, a far quicker wit than he was. He had raked salt beside Màiri since they were children too small to be trusted with the rake, and she knew him the way the shore's people knew one another, by his walk before his face, by the particular slowness with which he came to any decision and the particular stubbornness with which he held it once come to. It was Tadhg who stood nearest the gap in the bank when the spears came down off the ridge in the grey hour before the light was fully up, thirty and more of them against the dozen or so men who had reached the gap before the rest of the shore was even roused, and it was Tadhg's spear, thrown last of all among a scatter of others and almost, men said afterward, as an afterthought, that took Iain Dubh through the throat before he had closed half the distance to the pans.

Màiri was not at the gap. She had been raking the pan nearest her own hut, further along the bar, and came up out of sleep-thick confusion at the first shout to find the whole shore already running, men snatching spears from where they leaned against the hut walls, women driving the smaller children back behind the salt-sheds, and she ran with the rake still in her hand for want of anything else to carry, useless as it was for fighting, because it was the thing nearest to hand when the shouting started and she had not thought to set it down. What she saw, coming up onto the higher ground behind the bank, was the fighting break apart the way a flock breaks when a stone is thrown into the middle of it, men running one way and then another, spears thrown and missing and a few finding their mark, and in among them a tall figure that had been walking, not running, at the head of the hill men, going suddenly down onto the wet clay of the nearest pan and not getting up again.

She did not know, in the confusion of that morning, whose fall it was. It was only when the fighting broke off as suddenly as it had begun, the hill men drawing back from the bank in a huddle around the fallen man rather than pressing on for the salt they had come for, and then lifting him between four of them and carrying him away north at a pace that could not honestly be called a retreat and could not honestly be called anything else, that the shore began to understand what had happened; and it was days later, when the first traders came south with the word already travelling ahead of them the way such word always travelled, that Baile ghorm learned the man on the clay had been the king's own son, holder of the hill these eight years past, and the first of Ailean Mòr's children, in all the generations already reckoned there, to die by a spear rather than by the slow ordinary dying that took everyone else.

Seven of the hill's men had died the first time Mòrag Chruaidh came down, and the hill kept their names. Only Tadhg Garbh's spear had found its mark this second time, and no one on Tràigh an t-Salainn¹ died that day at all, which some of the older rakers afterward called a mercy and others called only luck, arguing at the winter fires for years over which word was truer and never settling it.

Iain Dubh had come to the hill at six hundred and seventy-four years old, by the count the reciters kept, a great age by any reckoning but the hill's own, where it made him no more than a man in the middle of his strength; he died at six hundred and eighty-two, on the clay of a pan he had never so much as touched with his own hand, and the list that had until then named only the taking of hills and the giving of judgements set down, for the first time, a year of death that was not also a year of some ordinary failing of the body.

III

Of the Cairn on the Hill

What was done on the hill afterward, Màiri did not see and only heard, the way she heard most things from the hill, thinned by distance and by however many mouths a tale had passed through before it reached Tràigh an t-Salainn¹. It was told that they raised the cairn where Ailean Mòr's own

1. the salt shore

1. the salt shore

eye had chosen the ground, and that Tormod, Iain Dubh's son, stood by it through the raising with a face that gave nothing away to anyone watching, which was thought remarkable in a young man not yet ninety years old whose father had just been carried home dead on a hide.

Tormod had held nothing yet in his own right; he was his father's eldest living son and no more than that, and the hill in those days gave nothing to a man for being a son, only for being chosen, so there was no certainty even at the cairn-side that Tormod would ever hold what his father had held. He was eighty-seven that year, a young man still by the reckoning of his blood, and stood the length of the raising without once being seen to weep, which the traders who carried the tale south thought worth remarking on, though Màiri, hearing it told and told again over the years, came to think it told them less about Tormod's grief than about how little the traders understood of a household that buried its dead expecting, in the ordinary run of things, centuries more of them to bury before its own turn came.

What was certain, and what the salt-folk heard clearly enough even at their distance, was that the king had not been on the hill when his son died, having been away in the north those same weeks settling some quarrel of grazing that no one on Tràigh an t-Salainn ever troubled to learn the particulars of, and that he came home to find the cairn already raised and his son already under it.

It was told that he stood by the cairn three days and spoke to no one the whole of that time, not to Tormod, not to Sorcha's other children, not to the reciters who stood ready, as reciters always stood ready, to add whatever words he cared to give them to the list. On the fourth day he walked off the hill alone, on foot, taking none of his household and no spears at all, and it was some while before anyone understood, from the direction he had gone, that he was walking south toward Tràigh an t-Salainn.

IV

Of the Man on the Shingle

Màiri was raking the third pan from the bar's western end, in the heat of the day when the brine had gone thick and needed turning before it set, and she straightened once to ease her back, the way she straightened perhaps forty times in a working day without ever after remember-

ing any of the other thirty-nine, and saw a man coming along the shingle from the west.

He was alone. That was the first thing she took in, and the strangest, for no one came to Baile ghorm alone who had any better choice, the coast track through the dunes being lonely enough that even traders went it in twos. He walked as a man walks who owns the ground he is walking on, not fast, not slow, and something in the set of his shoulders, though she had never in her life seen him before, told her plainly enough who he must be before any word had passed between them.

She dropped the rake and screamed for the men, and she was not ashamed afterward that she had screamed first and thought second, for it seemed to her the only thing a body could rightly do, seeing what she believed she was seeing come walking toward the pans where his son had died with a spear in his hand not a year past. The men came from the huts at a run, thirty of them and more, snatching up the same spears that had done for Iain Dubh, and made a line across the shingle between the king and the salt.

He came on. He did not slow for the line any more than he had slowed for the empty dunes behind him, and Màiri, standing back from the men with the rake still fallen where she had dropped it, noticed a thing she could never afterward explain to anyone who had not stood where she stood: that the wind coming in off the water was cold on her own face, as a sea wind is cold in that season, and yet the air seemed to sit warm around him the whole way he walked, as though he carried some part of a hearth along with him inside his clothes and none of it showed. She had heard the tale of the shingle raid told back to her often enough by then, in every version the shore's fires had made of it, and none of the tellings had thought to mention the warmth; it was hers alone, kept back the whole of her life for want of a way to say it that did not sound, even to her own ear, like a woman claiming more of the day than she had truly been given.

He wore no hardened hide and carried no spear of his own, only a plain travelling cloak gone dusty at the hem from the dunes, and there was nothing in his dress to mark him for a king rather than any herdsman come down off the hill roads, nothing but the walk and the warmth and the thing in his face that made thirty armed men draw into a line rather than simply stand aside and let a stranger pass.

Tadhg Garbh stood near the middle of the line. Màiri knew him well enough to know the exact look that came over his face as the king closed the distance, a

look she had seen on him only once before, the morning Iain Dubh came down, and she understood without being told that Tadhg had raised his own spear to his shoulder and meant, or half meant, to throw it a second time. She watched his arm come level and hold, and hold, the muscle standing out along it until it shook with the holding, and then watched him lower it slowly and stand looking at the spear in his own hand as if someone else had put it there and he could no longer think why he was holding it at all.

No one else threw. The king walked into the line of them and stopped, close enough now that Màiri could see his face plainly, an ordinary face, she thought afterward, trying to find some grander word for it and never quite finding one that fit better than ordinary, tired about the eyes the way any man's face is tired who has walked a long way and slept little. He looked along the line, face by face, the whole thirty of them, and to each face he gave the same length of looking, no longer at Tadhg Garbh's than at any other, though every soul on that shingle knew by then whose spear it had been. He said nothing at all. The silence went on long enough that Màiri heard, under it, the ordinary small sounds of the shore going on regardless, water working at the shingle, a gull somewhere behind the huts, and thought it strange that the world had not stopped to match the stillness of the men.

V

Of the Double Handful

It was old Mòr, eldest then among the salt-folk, who broke it. She went down on her knees on the wet shingle in front of him, an old woman kneeling before a man who looked, to any eye that did not know better, a full sixty years younger than she was, and she reached into the nearest pan and took up salt in both hands, a double handful, grey with the clay still in it and wet enough to run between her fingers, and held it up to him without a word.

He took it from her hands into his own. He ate a little of it, not much, no more than a man might taste from curiosity, and put the rest of it back into her cupped palms, closing her fingers over it with his own before he let go, so that she was left kneeling there holding salt he had given back to her rather than salt she had first given him.

Then he turned and walked back the way he had come, along the shingle toward the dunes, and no one moved to stop him and no one, Màiri said afterward more times than she could count, felt afterward that there had been any moment in the whole of it when stopping him had truly been a thing within their power.

By evening word had gone the length of the shore that the salt was the king's, though no one could afterward say which of them had first put it in those words, or whether it needed saying at all after what had been seen on the shingle. No blood had been shed that day, the first time in two raids that a day at Baile ghorm had ended with no new name to be kept among the dead, and no payment was ever asked or given for the blood that had been shed before it, not Iain Dubh's, not the seven of Mòrag Chruaidh's raid a generation before. The rakers argued it at their fires for the rest of that winter and on into others, some holding that a man who ate a stranger's salt and gave the rest back with his own hand had shown them the plainest mercy a conquered shore could hope for, and others, Tadhg Garbh loudest among them at first, though he grew quieter on the subject as the years went by, holding that a man who could walk unarmed through thirty raised spears and take nothing but a taste of what he might have taken whole had shown them something a good deal less comfortable than mercy, a proof of a power that made mercy beside the point.

Màiri herself never took either side of it strongly, though she was asked often enough, being the one whose scream had first brought the men running. What she said, when pressed, in the years she had left to be asked, was only that she had stood close enough to see his face when Mòr knelt to him, and that it had not been the face of a man deciding anything in that moment. It had been, she said, the face of a man for whom the thing had already been decided a long way further back than the shingle, perhaps as far back as the cairn on the hill, perhaps further, and that whatever word the rakers wanted to put to it, mercy or the other thing, the deciding of it had happened somewhere she had no way of following him to.

VI

Of Tadhg Garbh's Boat

Tormod came down from the hill himself the following spring, the first time any of his father's blood had set foot on Tràigh an t-Salainn¹ since the

killing, and stood at the cairn the salt-folk raised of their own accord on the rise above the pans, a small thing beside the one on the hill but built with the same care, seven stones for the seven of Mòrag's raid worked in around its base though none of the seven had died in this second fight at all, only Iain Dubh, because the salt-folk had come by then to think of the two raids as one long account and wished the reckoning to sit together. He came with no more than four men, and asked, before he would let anyone lead him up to the cairn, to be shown the pan where his father had fallen, and stood on the clay there a while with his boots sinking into it, saying nothing that Màiri, watching from a little way off, could afterward report with any confidence. Tormod said little that anyone remembered word for word, being still careful with speech in a way his father had never troubled to be, but he swore Tràigh an t-Salainn's peace would hold from his own line as it had held from his father's since the king's coming, asked Tadhg Garbh's name and was given it without anyone thinking to soften the telling, looked a moment at the big slow man who had thrown the spear, and said only that a man defending his own pans with his own hand owed no account to anyone for it. Then he rode north again within the day, and it was the last any of Tràigh an t-Salainn saw of him for a great many years.

Tadhg Garbh lived a year longer, and it was not a year that sat easily on him. He raked salt as he had always raked it and spoke to his household as he had always spoken, but Màiri, working the pans beside him through that last year more often than either of them chose to remark on, saw a man turning something over that he could not set down and could not finish turning. In the spring of the year after the king's coming he took a boat out alone before first light, one of the small hide craft the shore used for the near fishing, and did not come back with the tide, nor with any tide after it. No storm was remembered that night worth the name, and no wreckage of the boat was ever found along that coast, and the salt-folk were left, as they had been left once before, without a settled word for what had happened, some saying the sea had simply taken a tired man home and others saying, more quietly, that a man who has held a spear against the king's own son and thrown it true does not always find it easy to go on living beside the shore where he did it, whatever mercy was shown him after.

Màiri outlived him more than fifty years, and raked salt at Baile ghorm the whole of that time, through summers when the pans ran thick and winters when

1. the salt shore

they scarcely ran at all, and told the tale of the man on the shingle to her grandchildren and their children after her the same way each time, adding nothing and leaving nothing out, until it passed from her mouth into the shore's own keeping and needed no more telling from any one person at all. The bank behind the bar stood as it had always stood, no higher and no lower than the salt-folk had first raised it, and the pans went on giving up their grey harvest to the rake exactly as they had before any king's blood had ever bled onto the shingle beside them, salt drawn from salt water under the same sun, the shore's oldest and least remarkable labour, going on the same the year the king came as it went on every year before and every year after.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

OF the SAND ON the HEARTHS AND the OPENED GROUND

GE 770 – 901

*At the new houses above Cnoc chaol they still measure a child's
growing by Seasaidh's own count: so many years since the sand, so
many since the valley, so many since the stones.*

I

Of the Sand

Seasaidh was seven years old the night the sea came into the house. She had no memory afterward of hearing it come, only of being carried, wet and half asleep, in her mother's arms up a slope she did not know the household owned, while behind them a sound went on that she took at first, muddled with sleep, for wind in a bad season and only later, turning the night over and over across the rest of her life, understood to have been water moving where no water had ever moved in the memory of anyone then living. Cnoc chaol stood, in those years, low along a shingle rise a stone's throw back from the tide line, a scatter of houses no different from a dozen others on that coast, and the sea had kept, for as long as the oldest households could reckon, to a plain and honest habit of coming up the shingle at the flood and going back down it at the ebb, so that no one had thought to ask what the sea might do if it once forgot the habit.

It forgot it that night. There was no storm to give warning of it, no wind worth remarking, only a stillness some of the older folk said afterward they had felt before the water came, a stillness in the air that a few had remarked on at the time and none had known what to make of, and then the sea rose past every mark it had ever left and came in across the low ground faster than a grown man could run from it, taking two households whole and leaving, on every hearth it reached and did not carry away with it, a sheet of grey sand laid smooth as if a hand had smoothed it, a hand's depth thick, and threaded through with the broken shells of creatures no one on that shore had ever pulled up in a net, the shells of water deeper than any of them fished.

Seasaidh's father did not come up the slope with them. She learned this only in the grey hour after, standing in the ruin of what had been the lower houses with the sand already drying pale under the first sun and her mother's hand gripping hers hard enough to hurt, and she did not properly understand, at seven, what the word meant when her mother said it, only that a shape in her life that had always been there was now, without any ceremony to mark the change, not there, and that everyone around her had gone quiet in a particular way that told her not to ask more of it than she had already been told. Twelve of the coast's households were counted dead when the counting was done, a number that meant nothing to her at seven beyond the fact that among them was the shape that had been her father, and that her mother's face, in the days that followed, wore an expression Seasaidh had not seen on it before and would see again, at longer and longer intervals, for the whole of the rest of her mother's life.

The old folk, sifting through what the sand had left standing, found little worth the digging. A quern-stone, a scatter of the small clay counters children played at knuckle-games with, the charred end of a roof-beam still faintly warm where the sand had not quite smothered the last of a hearth-fire before it went out under the weight of the water. No one went back to rebuild on the same ground, though it was, as more than one of the older men said standing on it in the days after, as good a stretch of level shore as the coast offered and would offer again once the sand had settled and grassed over, which in time it did. But there was a fear laid into that low ground now that no amount of good level shore could talk a household out of, and the survivors of Cnoc chaol carried what could be carried up the slope behind the old site, to a shelf of higher ground looking down over the drowned houses, and began again there, in the first weeks with nothing more than what had been snatched up on the way out and what could be

cut and carried in a hurry, and in the seasons after with houses built properly, walls of stone this time where the old houses had been turf and wattle, as if stone alone might argue the sea out of a second visit.

II

Of the Slope

Seasaidh grew up on that slope, in a house her mother and her mother's brothers raised with their own hands in the first winter after the wave, and she grew up, as children do who lose a father too young to properly grieve him, with the loss folded into the ordinary shape of her days rather than standing apart from it: a story told at the fire on certain nights, a silence that fell over her mother at certain turns of the tide, a habit, which Seasaidh kept all her own life after without ever quite deciding to keep it, of counting the households on any shore she came to and reckoning, without meaning to, how far up the ground they stood from the water.

The new houses held. Seasaidh was thirteen, fourteen, old enough to help at the nets and the drying racks, before she stopped waking at every ordinary sound of a high tide working at the shingle below, and older than that again before she stopped, on the anniversary nights the household kept without ever naming them anniversaries, looking down from the new slope at the pale drowned ground below and feeling the particular cold that was not the sea's cold at all. The village above the old site never took a name of its own separate from the name the drowned ground had carried before it, for there seemed to the folk who built it no reason to call the new houses by any word but the word the coast had always used for that stretch of shore, so that Cnoc chaol came to mean, without anyone deciding it should, the slope and not the sand, the living houses and not the dead ones, though every soul who grew up there in Seasaidh's years knew exactly which ground the older word had first belonged to, and pointed it out to their children in turn, low ground, drowned ground, not to be built on.

It was on that slope, in her nineteenth year, that Seasaidh first met Pàl, a quiet, broad-shouldered young man come down with drovers from the inland valleys, wool to trade for salt fish, third son of a household that held grazing two days inland along a river Seasaidh had never seen and could not, that first year, well imagine, a country of grass and slow water and no tide at all to reckon anything by.

He came back the following year, and the year after that with less excuse for coming than wool alone gave him, and by her twenty-second year Seasaidh had agreed, to her mother's mixed grief and relief, to go inland with him and take up a household on ground she had never set eyes on, a decision she thought little enough of at the time, being twenty-two and in that particular kind of love that makes distance feel like nothing more than a thing to be walked through, and understood a good deal better once she had lived some years on the ground she had gone to.

III

Of the Valley

The valley Pål's household held lay a long two days' walk from the coast by the tracks Seasaidh came to know well over the years that followed, a green trough between two low scarps with a stream running the length of its floor and grazing enough on either slope to hold three households in fair comfort, which was, in those years, as much land as any inland household thought to ask for. It had no name of its own beyond what its own folk called it among themselves, the valley, the long field, words that served well enough for people who rarely had cause to speak of it to anyone who did not already know which valley was meant, and Seasaidh, coming to it a coast woman with salt still in the creases of her hands, found it at first a strange, closed sort of country, hemmed in by its own slopes the way the coast was never hemmed, no horizon of open water to look to, only grass and more grass and the stream's steady, unhurried talking.

Love for it came slowly, the way love comes for a thing not chosen for oneself, first through Pål and the children who came after him, four of them living past their first winters out of six born, and then through the valley's own quiet virtues: its shelter from the coast's winds, its grass holding green longer into a dry summer than any pasture she had known as a girl, its stream that never once, in all the years she kept house beside it, rose higher than a channel a child could jump. Seasaidh told her children more than once, meaning it kindly and meaning it, so far as she then knew, truly, that the valley was a safe country, dry-footed, its only weather the ordinary weather of wind and frost and the occasional hard winter that thinned the flocks but never the households.

She was fifty-seven years old, her hair more grey than not and her hands stiffening a little in the cold mornings the way hands do at that age, and her youngest

grandchild not yet walking, when she woke one night in early autumn to a sound she had not heard in fifty years and had never expected to hear again on ground so far from any tide: a long, low groaning, felt through the floor of the house as much as heard, that went on, off and on, through the better part of that night and left, by morning, a crack running clean across the floor of the valley a little below the household's own byre, wide enough in places for a grown man to set his boot into and lose it to the darkness below, and running, as the light came up fully and Pàl and the neighbouring households walked the length of it, further than any of them cared to walk to find its end.

IV

Of the Opened Ground

It was not, that first morning, a thing any of them had words ready for. A storm, a bad winter, even a fire, these were misfortunes the valley's folk had inherited a stock of sayings for, ready-made comfort passed down from households that had weathered the same before them; but no one living in that valley, nor any teller any of them could call to mind, had ever spoken of the ground itself coming open under a household's feet, and the strangeness of it sat on the valley folk for days afterward heavier, in its way, than the plain damage would have warranted on its own, for the crack had taken no life and thrown down no house, only opened, silently and for no cause any of them could name, across ground they had walked without a second thought every day of their lives.

Seasaidh, standing at the crack's edge that first morning with Pàl's hand hard on her arm holding her back from the loose lip of it, felt the old cold come up in her the way it had not come up in fifty years, the exact cold of the slope above Cnoc chaol looking down at drowned ground, and understood before anyone else in the valley said it aloud that this was, for her, the old fear come round again by a different road, the world's ground proving, a second time in one life, less solid underfoot than a person is raised to believe. She kept it from Pàl that morning, for there was, in the moment, no way to say it that would not have sounded, even to her own ear, a stranger claim than the crack itself: that she had felt this exact cold before, on a coast two days' walk away, over water and not over ground at all.

The spring that had, for as long as the household could remember, risen at the valley's upper end and run down along the near slope to join the stream below the

byre, moved in the days after the ground opened, its old channel running dry by inches until within a season it ran altogether elsewhere, breaking out a hundred paces downhill in a new hollow none of them had marked before as ground a spring might choose, so that the valley folk found themselves, in the space of one autumn, relearning a stretch of ground they had thought as settled and as known as their own hands. No house stood near enough the crack to be lost to it, which the valley folk afterward counted a mercy plain enough not to need much saying, the byre nearest it standing a good long stone's throw off and no dwelling closer than that; but grazing was lost along the crack's whole run, sheep would not be driven near it and cattle liked it no better, and for a season and more the valley's folk went about their ordinary work with a wariness that had not been part of the valley's temper before, glancing at ground they had never before thought worth a glance.

Word of it went out along the drover roads the way word of anything went, carried by whoever next had reason to travel, and it was carried, that winter, all the way to the hill, though none of the valley's own folk had thought to send it there on purpose; a drover simply told it at a hearth where it was overheard by a man travelling on to the hill for other business, and he told it again where he next stopped, and so, by the slow accident of ordinary talk rather than by any deliberate asking, the king came to hear of a valley two days inland where the ground had opened and a spring had moved.

V

Of the King at the Crack

he came in the spring following, on foot and with no more than two men behind him, word of his coming reaching the valley only a day ahead of the man himself, which gave the household barely time enough to be afraid of the honour before the honour was standing at their gate. Seasaidh was sixty that year, old enough by the valley's own reckoning to have earned a settled place at any gathering, and old enough, too, to remember plainly enough what a king's coming had meant on the coast in her own girlhood, though she herself, a child then, had never once seen him with her own eyes; and she stood that morning at the edge of the yard with her grown children about her and felt, watching him walk up the last stretch of track from the ford, the same thing every teller she

had ever heard tell of him agreed on and that she had never, until that morning, quite believed simply for having heard it so often: a warmth on the air around him that had nothing to do with the season, felt at ten paces and at five and closer, as though the man carried some small part of a well-kept hearth folded into his ordinary clothes and none of it showed on the outside of him.

He asked to be shown the crack before he would take food or rest, and walked its length with Pål and two of the valley's older men, Seasaidh a little behind them with the rest of the household, and said little as he walked, stopping twice to crouch at the lip of it and look down into the dark the way a man looks into a well he means to judge the depth of, though he let down nothing to measure it by, only looked. He asked how the spring had moved and was shown its new channel, and asked whether any beast or soul had gone into the crack in the season since it opened, and was told, truthfully, that none had, the valley folk having kept clear of it by instinct before anyone had thought to make a rule of keeping clear.

"You have done well enough on your own," he said at last, standing at the widest part of the crack with the two men who had walked it beside him and the rest of the household drawn up a little way off, "better than most would, coming on a strangeness with no one to tell them what it meant." He looked along the crack's run a last time, the way, Seasaidh thought, watching him from where she stood, a man looks at a thing he expects to see again rather than a thing he expects to be done with. "I'll not tell you to fill it in, nor to leave it. The ground will do as the ground does, here as anywhere else I've stood on it. Keep your beasts back, and your children, and build no house nearer it than you'd build to a drop of the same depth cut by a man's own hand, and you'll have done all that wants doing." He said nothing more of it, neither warning nor blessing beyond the plain sense of what he had already said, and Seasaidh, hearing it repeated at valley fires for years afterward in tellings that grew, as tellings do, a little grander with each retelling, thought privately, and said so to her own grandchildren when she was old enough to say what she liked, that the grandest thing in it had been how little he had made of a thing the valley had spent a whole season being afraid of.

He stayed the one night, eating at Pål's own hearth without ceremony and sleeping, so far as anyone in the household could tell, an ordinary man's sleep, and was gone again by the next morning's light, walking back the way he had come with his two men and no more said of the crack than had already been said at its edge. Seasaidh never saw him again in the years left to her, though she heard, as everyone on that road heard sooner or later, of him at other gates, other gather-

ings, other years, always the same face, always the same warmth reported by whoever had stood near enough to feel it, while her own face, and Pàl's, and the faces of every soul she had grown up beside on the coast or married among in the valley, went on ageing the ordinary way faces age, so that by the time she herself was old she had long since stopped finding it strange and had come, instead, simply to expect it, the way a person comes to expect the tide.

VI

Of the White Stones

The crack neither closed nor widened greatly in the years that followed, though it moved, by inches and by seasons, the way such ground moves, a little here after a hard frost, a little there after a wet spring, so that a line drawn along its edge in one year would not quite serve to mark it ten years on. The valley folk kept clear of it as they had from the first, by habit more than by any rule laid down, until Seasaídh, old now, her own children grown and settled with households of their own along the same valley, took it into her head, in the winter of her seventy-seventh year, that habit alone was a poor thing to trust a crack's whole length to, memory being shorter than a valley's life and children being born every year who had not stood, as she had, at the lip of the ground on the morning it first opened.

She began the stones herself, carrying the first of them up from the stream bed one at a time, more than her stiffening hands and her grown children thought wise for a woman of her years, and set them along the crack's outer edge a good stride back from the drop, white stones chosen for their whiteness rather than their size, so that even a child running in poor light might see the line of them and know, without needing to be told twice, where the safe ground ended. Her sons and daughters, seeing what she was at and unable to talk her out of it, took up the carrying themselves before she had done more than the first stretch, and grandchildren after them, so that the work, begun as one old woman's stubbornness, became within a season the whole valley's doing, households from both ends of the settled ground coming to add their own stones to the line until it ran the crack's full length, broken here and there where the ground itself had already made the danger plain enough without a stone to say so.

Pál had died the winter before her seventy-fifth year, an ordinary death of an ordinary old age, and Seasaidh kept the house alone after him with a grandson's family settled near enough to see to her, a life she found, in the telling of it to those same grandchildren, no harder to bear than any other loss a long life brings, having by then buried a father, a mother, and a husband, and having come, in the slow way a person comes to such things, to hold that grief widened rather than emptied a person, leaving room, each time, for one more thing worth minding on behalf of those still to come after.

"The ground keeps its own counsel," Seasaidh was fond of saying to her grandchildren in those last years, over the white stones, "and a wise household keeps a stride back from it"; and the children of the valley grew up, in the years after, knowing the crack the way Seasaidh herself had once known the drowned ground below Cnoc chaol: a plain fact of the country they lived in, marked, minded, and left otherwise alone.

She died in her eighty-second year, in the same house Pál had first brought her to sixty winters before, with her children and most of her grandchildren about her, and was buried on the near slope above the valley within sight, though not within a stone's throw, of the white line she had begun; and the valley folk, telling of her afterward at their own fires, told less often of the coast she had come from or the wave that had taken her father than of the stones themselves, so that within two generations more it was chiefly as the woman who had marked the crack that her name was kept at all, the sand and the drowning folded quietly into an older telling behind it. No house was raised, in all the years that valley folk afterward kept the ground, within a stone's throw of the crack on either side of it, and the white line, mended where frost or flood undid a stretch of it and never once let go entirely to grass, ran the whole visible length of the opened ground, still tended by hands that had never known Seasaidh living, when every soul who had stood at its edge the first morning was gone to the hill's own reckoning of the dead.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Of the Unlit Hearth and the Basket

GE 902 – 1,070

*At Achadh dhìreach the hearths still measure an gual dathach by
the hand Anna nic Coinnich taught them, though most who meas-
ure it now could not say whose hand it was.*

I

Of the Hearth Never Lit

Before there was a household at Achadh dhìreach that anyone now living could name, there was a hearth, and the hearth was never lit.

It stood a little back from where the stream bent under the first rise of ground, laid with the same care any hearth was laid in those years, stones set close and true and a clay lip built up round the fire-bed to hold the ash from spreading. Dry wood lay ready beside it, split fine for a first catching flame, and beside the wood, wrapped in a scrap of hide gone stiff with age, a single sliver of an gual dathach¹, an gual dathach, no bigger than a child's thumb. Whoever laid that hearth had meant to light it. The wood was cut for lighting and the coal was set out for lighting and neither had been touched by fire in all the years anyone afterward dug down to look at them, so that the hearth-stones, when at last a spade turned up their edge in the nine hundred and second year of the king, came up out of the ground as clean of soot as the day they were laid.

No one at Achadh dhìreach in that year could say who had laid it, or why they had gone away before the striking, or where they had gone. The valley folk who

found it were three brothers new to the ground, clearing a strip for barley their grandfather had marked out and never lived to break, and they stood over the buried hearth a long while before any of them would put a hand to the coal, for a coal so old and so untouched seemed to them a thing that had waited on purpose, and a man does not care to be the one who wakes what has chosen, for whatever reason of its own, to go on sleeping.

They left it dark. It is told that the eldest of the three, a man named Griogal, said only that the hearth had been left as it was for a reason a hearth-builder would have known and he did not, and that he would sooner leave a mystery standing than put a flame to one, and his brothers, who had less patience for mysteries generally, agreed with him in this one thing because neither of them wanted, any more than he did, to be the hand that lit a fire someone else had refused. They laid a flat stone over the coal and the wood, and built their own hearth a stone's throw off, in ground that had never held one before, and told their children, as their children told theirs, to leave the old stones be.

By the nine hundred and fifty-sixth year the buried hearth lay three yards down, covered by every season's turf and every year's midden and the slow gathering of a valley floor that never stopped rising under the feet of the people who lived on it, and only the oldest households still troubled to point out, to a child digging where a child ought not to dig, the exact spot where the ground held its secret. It became, in the way of such things, less a fact remembered than a habit kept: no one broke new ground there, though no one any longer troubled to ask why not, and the valley folk who farmed the good soil all round it did so without once feeling the want of the strip they left alone.

II

Of the Measure Nowhere Written

The custom that Achadh dhìreach came at last to keep with an gual dathach¹ did not begin at Achadh dhìreach, and no one there, when it reached them, could have said where it had begun, only that it had reached every

1. the coloured coal

1. the coloured coal

hearth in Na Glinn Àrda² within the space of a very few years, the way a plain sense sometimes travels faster than any single teller can be found to have carried it.

It is told that at a drovers' ford some days off, where beasts were rested on the road to the hill and travellers slept a night or two among strangers before going on, a household new to the ground had burnt more of the coal in one sitting than its neighbours thought wise, warming a sick child through a hard night, and had been watched doing it by three others who came the following winter to see for themselves what a fire fed too generously with an gual dathach would do. Nothing came of the watching that year, nor the year after; but the households of that ford, and then the households near them, and then households further off than any of them had ever traded with directly, took to measuring what they put on a fire by the width of a hand cupped and no wider, a full hand and no more, and kept to it without any one of them being able to say who had first said it aloud or when.

By the thousand and eleventh year, or near enough that no two households at Achadh dhìreach agreed on the count, a full hand had become the whole of the law that any of them knew regarding the coal, and it was law in the plain sense that a stranger travelling from the ford country to Na Glinn Àrda and back again would have found the same measure kept at every hearth along the road, though no king had proclaimed it and no holder of any hill had ever ridden out to enforce it. It sat alongside the old buried hearth in the valley's own reckoning of itself, two things neither explained nor questioned: a hearth once laid and never lit, and a measure everywhere kept and nowhere written, and it was the particular cast of that valley's mind, by the time Anna nic Coinnich was old enough to carry water to her mother's fire, to hold the two as somehow of a piece, as if the unlit hearth had been the first hand's warning and the measured hand the whole valley's late answer to it, though no one then living, and likely no one who had ever lived at Achadh dhìreach, could have said whether the two things touched each other at all outside a child's tidy way of making sense of what she was given.

Anna was born in the thousandth year of the king into a household two fields off from the buried hearth, the youngest of four, and grew up knowing the width of her own cupped hand the way she knew the sound of the stream under the first rise: a fact of the valley so plain it needed no more remarking than the shape of the hills. Her mother measured coal onto the fire from a clay jar kept high on a

2. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

shelf, out of the smaller children's reach, and said the same words each time without seeming to notice she said them, *làn na glaise*, 's *gun tuilleadh*, a full hand and no more, until Anna herself said them without noticing, first to her own younger cousins and later, when she had a household of her own, to children who were hers.

III

Of Achadh dhìreach

She married at nineteen a man named Aonghas, a byreward from the next valley over, and came to keep her own hearth within sight of the old buried one, close enough that on quiet evenings she could stand at her own door and see the flat stone the valley still pointed out to children, greyed now with a lifetime's weather and half sunk into ground that had risen round it a further hand's depth in her own lifetime alone. She raised four children of her own there and buried one, a boy of six years taken by a fever the winter she was thirty, and came in time to be one of the older women of that stretch of the valley, the kind whose hearth other households' children were sent to when their own mothers had no time to mind them, and whose word on the raising of children, and increasingly on other matters besides, carried further than her own household's fence.

The years between were ordinary years, and the valley's own telling of them kept little of their particulars beyond a bare handful: a dry summer that thinned the barley but did not fail it outright; a boundary quarrel between two households over a strip of grazing that Anna's own father, before his death, had helped settle by walking the ground with both parties and marking new stones where the old ones had shifted; a stranger through from the coast one autumn with salt to trade and news of a boat hollowed whole from a single oak, which the valley folk heard with the mild interest they gave most things that happened somewhere else. Achadh dhìreach in those years held some dozen households strung along the stream, no larger a place than it had ever been and in no hurry, so far as anyone there could tell, to become larger, its people keeping cattle and a little grain and the long patience of a valley that had never once, in any teller's memory, been visited by anything worse than weather.

Two households nearer the stream's bend than Anna's own belonged to a man named Eanraig Ruadh and his wife Beathag, who had come to that stretch of ground a generation before Anna's own birth and were, by the time this telling reaches them, well into the years a valley calls old without troubling to count them exactly. Eanraig had buried two wives before Beathag and outlived three of his own children, and had the name, among the younger households, of a man who kept his own counsel and his own hearth hotter than most, being of the kind, not uncommon at any age, who felt the cold in his bones before his neighbours felt it in theirs and would sooner burn a little more than shiver through a long evening. Careless he was not thought. His beasts were well kept, his roof well thatched, and his grandchildren, of whom there were by then a good many scattered among the valley's other households, were spoken of kindly wherever they went, a man careful, by every neighbour's account, in every particular save one. It was only the fire he kept generous, and it was a generosity the valley had grown used to seeing without remarking on it further than to say, now and again, that Eanraig liked his hearth warm.

IV

Of the Basket

The summer of the year one thousand and sixty-six never properly came, the valley said afterward: a cold wet season with a north wind in it that killed two of Eanraig's own lambs before their first shearing and set every household along the stream burning peat in the middle of an t-Iuchar as though it were the wolf-month. Eanraig Ruadh, an old man past any count he still troubled to keep, felt that cold in joints that had troubled him little in warmer winters, and said to Beathag, more than once in the hearing of a grandchild who later told it, that a man his age had earned the right to sit warm through whatever was left to him, and that he did not propose to spend his last winters shivering for the sake of a measure some ford household three valleys off had thought up before either of them were born.

It is not told, and Anna herself, questioned on it by her own grandchildren once she had grown old, would never say she knew, whether Eanraig meant from the first to break the measure outright or only to stretch it a little further each night than the night before, the way a habit is broken most often, by inches too

small for the breaker to notice breaking anything at all. What is told is that on a night early in an t-Iuchar, with the cold still hard on the valley and a wind come round to the north that found every gap in a poorly chinked wall, Eanraig set on his fire, in one going, very nearly the whole of a basket his eldest living son had carried up from the trading he alone regularly made along the ford road, a basket meant, by that son's own account given afterward, to see the household through the better part of the coming year measured out by handfuls and not spent in a single night by a man who had stopped, in his old age, quite believing that the measure applied to him.

Anna was wakened past midnight by a light in the sky the wrong colour for any fire she had ever seen a house burn, a light that stood up over the roofs of the nearer houses in a colour she groped afterward, telling it to her own children, for words to fit and never quite found, saying only that it ran shot through with something beneath the ordinary red-gold of a burning roof, a colour that seemed, she said, to come from further down in the fire than fire usually burned from. She was out of her own house and across two fields before Aonghas had his boots properly laced, and she was not the first there, for households nearer Eanraig's had wakened before her at the sound alone, a sound she never afterward tried to describe with any confidence, only that it was louder, and went on longer, than a roof-fire's ordinary crack and settle.

The house was past saving by the time enough hands had gathered to try. It had gone up whole, roof and walls together, in the time it takes a household to wake and dress and cross two fields, and what the valley folk stood back from, in the end, was a column of flame past any fighting with water carried in pails, the colour of nothing any of them had a word ready for, standing straight up in a windless patch of air though the wind blew hard everywhere else that night, and giving off a heat that drove them back a good ten paces further than an ordinary house-fire would have made them stand. Eanraig Ruadh did not come out of it, nor Beathag, nor a grandchild of six years named Ualan who had been left to sleep the night under their roof while his own mother tended a sick sister two houses off, and the valley folk who stood in the cold that night, watching a fire none of them had ever seen the like of and none of them could get near enough to fight, told each other afterward, in whatever words came to each of them, that they had known, standing there, that they were watching something answer a measure that had been broken, though not one of them, questioned closely by whoever came

after to ask it of them, could say what they meant by the word *answer* beyond the plain fact of the fire's colour and its heat and the three lives it took with it.

The house burned to its stones before the light came up grey over the wet fields, and when the ash had cooled enough for hands to go into it, what the valley folk found at the heart of the ruin was the hearthstone itself split clean through from one edge to the other, a crack a finger's width across running the whole length of it, and the crack, where the ash had been swept back from it, ran with a colour none of the hands that first uncovered it wanted, at first, to put a name to, a slow seep of something neither quite liquid nor quite the ordinary black of a burnt-out fire, the colour, Anna said afterward more than once, of the light that had stood over the roof before any of them reached the house.

V

Of the King's Hand

Word went up to the hill the following morning by the fastest rider the valley could put on the road, and it is not told, because the valley folk who sent him did not themselves know, what word he carried beyond the plain fact of three dead and a hearthstone that would not stop running colour a full day after the fire that cracked it had gone entirely cold. The king came down himself, and came quickly, by whatever road he judged quickest, with no more than two men riding behind him, and stood at Achadh dhìreach before the second evening was out, looking, to the valley folk gathered at a careful distance from the ruin, exactly as he had always looked to every valley he had ever come down to: a big man, plainly dressed, with a warmth about him that those nearest him felt on their faces like a hearth's own heat though the day was cold and he stood some way off from any fire, and no more years on him, so far as the oldest among them could judge, than he had carried the last time any of their grandparents had seen him, which for some of those standing there was longer ago than their own lifetimes reached.

He walked into the ruin alone, past the ring of ash and fallen roof-timber the valley folk had not yet found the heart to clear, and stood over the split hearthstone a long while without speaking, while behind him the whole of Achadh dhìreach that could walk that far stood in the cold and watched him do it. Anna, near the front of that watching, close enough to see plainly what the others fur-

ther back could only half make out, saw him crouch at last and put his open hand flat on the stone where the crack ran widest, over the seep of colour that had not stopped running since the fire went out, and hold it there.

She said afterward, to whoever asked her in the years that followed, that she had expected some manner of struggle in it, a wrestling of some kind between a man's hand and whatever force had cracked a stone and burned a house to its footings in a single night, and that what she saw instead was stranger for being so plain: the king knelt with his hand on the stone the way any man might kneel to warm cold fingers at an ordinary fire, unhurried, his face giving away nothing she could afterward describe as effort, and the colour, under his open palm, went out of the crack the way colour goes out of a coal left to burn down past its last spark, fading first at the edges nearest his fingers and then, by degrees too slow for any single watcher to say exactly when the last of it went, along the whole visible length of the crack, until what was left under his hand, when at last he stood, was a stone greyed through and dead as any hearthstone that had never held more than an ordinary fire.

He turned to face the valley folk then, and it is this part of the telling that Achadh dhìreach kept whole, word for word as near as any single teller could manage it, long after the particulars of the fire itself had softened in the retelling. He did not ask, standing there, who among them had broken the measure, though there were those in that crowd, Anna among them, who believed he already knew it as plainly as if Eanraig himself stood before him to confess it, and he did not speak, either, of the three dead beyond a look toward the ruin that every witness afterward called grave without any of them agreeing on quite what in his face had made it look so.

"The full hand is a good custom," he said, and his voice, Anna said, carried no more weight in it than a man's voice carries saying any plain thing to a gathering of his own people, no raising, no anger she could point to, only a flatness that some of those who heard it took afterward for a kind of tiredness and others took for something nearer to grief. "Keep it. I will not make it a law, for I have made none, and I do not mean to begin with this one. But keep it, all the same, for your own sakes and not for mine, and teach it to whoever is too young yet to have learned why."

He said no more than that, and did not stay the night, though he sent his two men back some days later with grain enough to see the valley's poorer households through a year shortened by the loss of Eanraig's stored barley along with

everything else the fire had taken, and he did not come again to Achadh dhìreach for a good many years after, so far as any teller there afterward troubled to remember, there being, in the plain course of things, no further occasion that called him.

The valley did not build a new house on the ground where Eanraig Ruadh's had stood. What they did, in the following spring, once the ground had settled and the last of the ash had been carried off, was raise a house a little to one side of the old footings, close enough that the greyed and cracked hearthstone still lay within an easy carrying, and set that same stone, whole as the king had left it, as the new house's own hearth rather than break it up for footing-stone or leave it where it lay to be grassed over the way the buried hearth of a hundred and sixty years before had been grassed over in its turn. It was Eanraig's eldest living son who raised that house and who chose, against some counsel that thought it an ill-omened stone to build a fire on, to keep it rather than quarry a fresh one, saying only that a stone the king himself had greyed with his own hand was as safe a hearth as any household in the valley was likely to keep, and safer, by his own reckoning, than one that had never been tested at all; and it was on that same stone, mended nowhere and cracked still, though the crack never widened nor ran with any colour again in all the years anyone at Achadh dhìreach afterward kept a fire on it, that his own children and his children's children, down a good many generations, laid their own fires and measured their own coal by the same full hand the whole valley had kept since before any of them were born.

Anna nic Coinnich lived a further fourteen years after that summer, long enough to see grandchildren of her own grown to households and to sit, in her last years, the same kind of hearth other households' children were sent to when their mothers had no time to mind them, as she herself had once kept for the valley in her middle years. She was asked, more than once by grandchildren too young to have any memory of the fire themselves, why the full hand mattered so much when a household's own fire seemed, to a child's eye, small trouble whichever way it was measured, and she answered them each time, so far as the valley's own telling of her preserves it, the same way and in the same few words, holding out one open palm, cupped, for the child to see the shape of it.

"Làn na glaise," she would say, "'s gun tuilleadh." A full hand, and no more. And when the child, as children mostly did, asked her why a hand and not some other measure, she would only close the hand slowly, as if weighing what it held though it held nothing at all, and tell them that a hand was the one measure every household owned alike, rich or poor, old or young, and that a custom kept be-

cause everyone owned the means to keep it was worth more, in her long experience of the valley's ordinary years, than any law a distant hill might have troubled to write down and send a rider to enforce.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Of the Watchers of the Slab

GE 1,071 – 1,174

In Na Glinn Árda the keepers still say the first watch was kept by a man who did not need to sleep and sat it anyway, so that no one after him could claim the cold had been too much to ask.

I

Of the Line Kept in the Valleys

Na Glinn Árda held no bank and no ditch and no hearing-house, and wanted none, for the households that lived there had never been households in the way the crown of Dùn ìseal understood the word: they did not gather grazing, and they did not marry outward more than they had to, and they kept, from father to son and from mother to daughter, a thing no other valley on the island troubled to keep at all, which was Sloinneadh a' Chlachair¹ entire, every name of it, said the same way twice running or said again until it was. Somhairle had brought it up into the hills himself as a boy of a hundred and sixty who looked fifteen, taking no share of his father's kingdom and asking for none, and by the year this telling opens he had carried it the better part of a thousand years, in a memory that had by then grown old enough to hold more than any one household's business could have put into it.

The valleys knew him for that, and for little else. He was not a lord among them, for Clann na Ceiste² had no lord; he was the one who came round at Beall-

1. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

tainn and at Samhain and sat by whatever fire would have him, and said the Line through from Ailean at the grove down to whoever in the house had been born that year, and let the house correct him if a name had slipped, though no house ever found one that had. He kept, besides the Line, the telling of the coal: how the mason had broken the vein at Tobar dhìreach and the lightning had fired it; how na Seachd Guail³ had been lit one by one down the generations, each by its own spirit; and how an gual dathach⁴ that ran through the rock under the hill country held all seven, though no one, not even Somhairle, who had asked his father once and been given no more of an answer than a look, could say what his father had carried out of the grove.

The slab lay above Tobar dhìreach on a shelf of ground that no household had ever built a byre against, a grey stone longer than a standing man, laid flat by the mason's own people over the broken vein when its fire had burned itself out, as the Line keeps it, with a stain at its lower edge the size of two cupped hands that had never, in all the years anyone kept count of such things, washed paler with any rain. Children were told, and told their own children after, that the stain was the mark of Teine a' Chlachair⁵, which had burned in the vein beneath until there was nothing left in the break for it to burn; whether that telling was truer than any other telling of the stain, Somhairle himself would not say, holding, as he held of most things touching his father's blood, that a thing not given to him to know was not his to guess at aloud.

In the fifth year past Anna nic Coinnich's basket and her cupped hand at Achadh dhìreach, the ground a little below the slab's lower edge began, in a wet spring that brought down more of the hillside than any spring before it, to show a crack no wider than two fingers, running some yards toward the burn and then losing itself in turf that had not moved. It was nothing to trouble a herd over, and no house near it lost so much as a lamb into it in all the years it was watched; but it lay close enough under the slab's own stain that the valleys, who had learned by then to be careful of what the coal-marked ground did when it moved, set a line of white stones along it the way the coast had done at the crack Seasaidh's people knew, and left it at that for the better part of fifty years.

The handful had come up into Na Glinn Àrda⁶ the same road the tale of it had come, carried by traders and by Somhairle's own telling at the fires, and had

2. the Children of the Question

3. the Seven Coals

4. the coloured coal

taken there no differently than it had taken on the crown of the hill: a household that had never lost anyone to the coal took the custom on trust from households that had, and cupped its hand, and burned no more than the hand would hold, and asked no further questions of a rule that answered its own case well enough. Clann na Ceiste had, besides, more reason than most to keep the handful close, for they lived nearer the coal's own ground than any household of the lowlands did, in valleys where a herder turning peat for the winter fire might, on an unlucky day, turn up a vein no thicker than a finger running bright through ordinary black turf, and know, from the telling if from nothing else, to leave it exactly where it lay and cut his peat a spade's length further along.

II

Of the First Turn

It was at Samhain in the eleven hundred and twentieth year that the households nearest the slab, gathered as they gathered every year at Samhain, fell to talking of the crack below the stain, and one among them, whose name the Line does not keep though the deed is kept in his stead, said that a thing close under the coal's own stone ought not to be left with no one minding it through the dark half of the year, the way a fire banked for the night is minded by whoever last built it up. No one could say what the minding was for, nor what it was minding against; but the thing was agreed the way most things were agreed in those valleys, by no one arguing hard enough against it to be worth outlasting, and it was settled that a household would sit by the slab from dusk to dusk, one household at a time, turn and turn again, from that Samhain until the light came back in the spring.

Beathan was among the first six to sit it, and no one thought it strange, for Beathan had by then lived among the herding households of Na Glinn Àrda¹ the better part of five hundred years, looking, in all that time, no more than thirty, and had long since stopped being remarked on for it by anyone who had grown up seeing him about the fires. He was Somhairle's son and the king's grandson, and he took no more of a share than his father did, and he sat his turns the way

6. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

5. the mason's fire, the first fire

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

any household sat them, wrapped in the same plaid, eating the same bannock, minding the same fire built low against the slab's foot so that its light would not run down the crack and its smoke would not hang where a watcher needed clear eyes.

The household whose turn followed his that first winter was a herding family from the shoulder of the hill above the burn, a man called Gilleonan and his wife Ìde, newly married that same autumn and glad enough, in the way of the newly married, of any night that put them alone together away from both their mothers' hearths, whatever the ground beneath them happened to be doing. Gilleonan had heard of Beathan the way every child of the valleys heard of him, as a fact of the place and not a wonder, the way a child hears that the burn runs cold even in summer; but he had never sat a night beside him until the two households' turns fell close enough together that autumn that Beathan, coming up early to see the fire well banked before he handed the watch on, found Gilleonan and Ìde already there ahead of their own hour, neither of them quite willing to say why, both of them glad of an excuse to sit a while longer by a fire that was, whatever else it was, warmer than their own hearth that first married winter.

The watch asked little of the body and a good deal of the patience. A household came up before dusk with peat enough for the night and food enough for two, built the fire low against the slab's own foot the way every watch before it had built it, and sat, turn and turn about within the turn, one waking while the other slept a little if the night allowed it, until the sky over the shoulder of the hill paled enough to call the thing done. There was talking, when the cold did not close a mouth too tight for it, and there was silence, and there was the ordinary work a hand can do sitting down, a distaff or a knife and a stick, and there was the slab, grey and close and no more talkative than any other stone, giving back the fire's low light along its stain and nothing else all night for year upon year. Six other households besides Beathan's and Gilleonan's stood in that first round, a shepherd's widow from above the ford of the burn, a household of basket-weavers who came up from lower in the glen only for their turn and grumbled at the walk every time, two brothers who split every watch between them rather than share it with wives who wanted no part of a cold night on a hillside, and a household so newly settled in the valleys that its turn, the first winter, fell to a woman who had not yet learned the names of half her neighbours and sat it, by her own later telling, more afraid of saying the wrong thing to Somhairle's son than of anything the ground might do. None of the six, in all the years the first round held, saw the

crack do more than it had ever done, which was to lie there, unwidened, and let the frost silver its white stones along with everything else on the hillside; and it became, before the round was five years old, as ordinary a thing on a household's calendar as a lambing or a peat-cutting, a night set aside and kept, without anyone troubling any longer to wonder aloud whether the keeping served any purpose at all.

III

Of Ìde Grown Old

They sat their turn every year after that, as their household's place in the round came round to them, and every year Beathan sat his own turn near enough to theirs, by no arrangement anyone could point to, that the two watches came to be spoken of together, Beathan's and the young herding couple's, as though the valleys had quietly decided the four of them made one turn between them rather than two. Gilleonan filled out through his twenties into the broad, slow-spoken man his father had been before him, and lost two fingers of his left hand to a fall of stone clearing ground the third year of his marriage, and mended, and went on herding with the hand he had left, cursing it only on the coldest mornings; and Ìde bore him three children in the years the crack was watched, two who lived and one who did not, and buried the one who did not on the hillside above the burn with Beathan standing by, silent, at the digging, the way he stood by at every digging in that country, for it was known among the households, though never said to his face, that a grave dug with the king's grandson standing over it was a grave a family need not fear would be disturbed.

In the ninth winter of their marriage a hard season drove wolves down off the high ground closer to the fires than any household there had known them come in living memory, and a pack of them was heard about the shoulder of the hill on three nights running while Gilleonan's turn stood at the slab, near enough that Ìde kept the youngest child inside her plaid the whole night through rather than let him sleep the arm's length away he usually slept. Beathan, whose own turn fell two nights after theirs that round, walked up a day early with a spear he did not often trouble to carry, and sat the intervening nights himself so that Gilleonan's household need not; and when Gilleonan protested that the turn was his to keep and not another's to take from him, Beathan told him only that a spear that had

once turned back worse than wolves without being thrown could turn back wolves easily enough, and that Gilleonan's children had more need of a living father than the crack had of a second watcher that season. The wolves came no nearer than the sound of them, in the end, and drew off with the thaw as they had come with the frost; but it was the nearest the watch ever came, in all the years Gilleonan's household kept it, to guarding against a thing that could be named and fought, and the valleys told it after as the one winter the watch had proved good for something, whatever they made of the rest.

Once, and once only, in the fourteenth year, a light was seen along the crack that none of the six households on watch that season could afterward agree on the colour of: two said it was no more than the fire's own glow caught oddly in frost-mist, and two said it ran along the white stones themselves rather than above them, low and brief, gone before a third watcher roused from dozing could open his eyes on it, and the last two said only that they had seen nothing and doubted anyone else truly had. Somhairle, told of it at the next Bealltainn, asked each of the six alone and apart from the others, the way he asked when a thing wanted testing rather than repeating, and set down in no telling that has come to us any conclusion beyond the plain fact that six watchers had seen five different things, or four, or none, depending which pair was asked; and the valleys, who had little patience for a wonder that told four tales at once, let the matter drop inside a year and never raised it again in Ìde's hearing, nor, so far as the Line keeps, in Beathan's.

By the twentieth winter of the watch Ìde's hair had begun to go the iron grey her own mother's had gone at the same age, and by the thirtieth it was white, and her hands, that had once threaded a needle by firelight without troubling to hold it close, now held their needlework at arm's length and squinted at it all the same; and Beathan, sitting his turn beside hers as he had sat it every year since their first married winter, looked across the low fire at her some nights and found himself unable to say, watching her face against the slab's grey bulk, whether thirty years had passed since he first knew her or three, for his own face in the water of the burn told him nothing that thirty years ought to have told a man, and hers told him everything.

She never asked him the thing every other soul in the valleys learned young enough not to ask. She had her own guess, and kept it, the way her household kept most of its guessing, close and unspoken; but she told her grandchildren once, in a winter she was still strong enough to sit her own turn, that she had sat

thirty years beside a man who had not aged a season in all of them, and that the strangest part of the whole business was how little strange it had come, after the first few winters, to feel.

It was in the twentieth winter of the watch that Somhairle gave Beathan Sloinneadh a' Chlachair¹ whole, the same season his own hair, which had held black far past the age when any other man's would have turned, began at last to silver at the temple, the first sign the valleys had seen that even a son born after the grove would grey in the end like other men, though slower than any of them. He gave it to his son the way it had been given to him, by the fire, twice through without a name out of place, and told him afterward, in the only words the Line keeps of that giving, that a thing carried this long by mouth alone had better be carried by more than one head before the head that held it went into the ground; and Beathan, who had by then sat more winters at the slab than any man then living except his father, took the Line the way he had taken the watch, without asking why it should fall to him and not another, only that it had. He said nothing of the giving to Gilleonan or to any other household of the round, holding, as his father held, that the Line was a matter for Clann na Ceiste² alone and the slab a matter for whoever sat by it, and that the two, though they lived in the same valleys, need not be carried by the same conversation.

IV

Of the Question Gilleonan Asked

By then every household in the round had its own guess, held loosely and traded at the Samhain fire the way a household trades any tale it does not quite believe and cannot quite let go of. The basket-weavers from lower in the glen held that the crack led down to wherever the coal itself had first come to rest, and that the stone had been laid over it by hands older than the Line, to keep the coal from being carried off whole by whoever might otherwise have found it. The shepherd's widow held, more darkly, that something of the sìth's own company lay under it, sleeping rather than dead, and that the watch was kept lest it wake unminded; and she would say no more of it than that, however pressed,

1. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

2. the Children of the Question

holding that a thing said too often aloud grew truer for the saying whether or not it had been true to begin with. The two brothers who split their turns held no view at all beyond the wolves and the cold, and said so bluntly whenever the others fell to guessing, which did nothing to stop the guessing but gave it, each time, someone to argue against. Somhairle, asked more than once to settle the matter with whatever the Line might know that the households did not, always answered the same way: that his father had given him the Line entire and had never once, in all the tellings, given him a reason for the slab, and that a son did not improve on what a father had chosen not to say.

It was Gilleonan himself, old by then in the ordinary way, his beard gone the same white as his wife's hair and his bad hand stiffer every winter than the last, who asked the thing at last, in the thirty-ninth year of the watch, on a night colder than most, with the fire burned low on purpose against the frost and the two of them alone at the slab while Ìde kept the house with a grandchild too young yet to sit a turn.

"I have sat here since I was a young man with two hands," Gilleonan said, holding up the maimed one to the firelight without complaint in it, only a kind of tiredness that came from further back than the cold, "and my father thought the crack worth minding before ever I sat by it, though he never said against what. You have sat it longer than any of us, Beathan, longer than my grandfather was alive to sit anything. Tell me plainly, for I am old enough now to be told plainly if there is a plain thing to tell: what is it we are watching for?"

Beathan was a long while answering, not from any wish to keep the thing back, for he had turned the same question over in his own mind more nights than Gilleonan had years to have asked it in, but because the honest answer, when it came, was smaller than a man who had given forty winters to a watch deserved.

"I do not know," he said at last. "My father does not know, though he has asked his own father, and been given no more than a look for the asking. I have lived in these valleys since before your grandfather's grandfather, Gilleonan, and I have watched the same crack you have watched, and it has never widened, and it has never closed, and nothing has ever come out of it nor gone down into it that any of us here have seen with our own eyes. I sit because the sitting was agreed, and it seemed to me, when it was agreed, no worse a way to spend the dark half of a year than any other. If there is a thing under that stone worth watching for, I have not been shown it, and I will not pretend to you now, after what your hand

has cost this watch and what your wife's hair has cost it, that I know a reason I do not have."

Gilleonan took that the way he took most things, without complaint and without much surprise, for he had half expected, asking it, that the answer would be no bigger than the one he got. "Then we watch for nothing," he said, "and call it something, because a fire kept for nothing is harder to keep than a fire kept for a reason, even a false one."

"We watch," Beathan said, "because the ground moved once where the coal's own stain lies, and because a household that has watched forty years does not like to be the household that stopped the year before the thing it watched for finally came. That is not nothing, Gilleonan, whatever else it is."

They said no more of it that night, nor, so far as the Line has ever kept, any other night after; but it is told that Gilleonan sat his turns the four winters he had left in him with no less care than he had given the first, and that he taught the asking, if not the answer, to his grandchildren, so that the households of Na Glinn Àrda¹ came in time to hold it as a settled thing among them that the watch was kept without knowing why, and that the not-knowing was no shame to anyone who had sat it.

V

Of the King's Night at the Slab

The king came up into Na Glinn Àrda¹ once in those years, in the eleven hundred and sixtieth winter, a year to the season after Gilleonan had asked his question of Beathan at the low fire, riding alone as he rode when he rode at all by then, and found the turn that season fallen to Beathan's own household and to a family new to the round, and sat down among them at the slab with no more ceremony than any traveller taking a place at a fire not his own. He said nothing of why he had come, and the households, who had long since learned not to press him for reasons he did not offer, asked him nothing. He sat the whole night through, wrapped in a plaid a herding wife had lent him without knowing whose shoulders it went round, and watched the same grey stone and the same

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

thin crack the valleys had watched for forty winters, and when the light came up grey over the shoulder of the hill he rose, and thanked the household for the fire, and rode back down toward Dùn Ìseal without having said, in all those hours, a single word touching the thing that had brought him.

It is the only night Sloinneadh a' Chlachair² keeps of the king sitting a watch he had not been asked to sit, in a place that was not his own hill, among people who owed him no turn and had not looked for him. Whatever he had come to watch for, or to see, or only to sit beside a while before riding back to a hill full of quarrels no one else could settle, the households of Na Glinn Àrda never learned; and it is remembered of that night, when it is remembered at all, for the plain fact of it and no more, the way the valleys had by then learned to keep most things that came to them without an answer attached: that he came, and sat, and said nothing, and went away again, and the crack beneath the stone lay as it had always lain, neither wider nor narrower for the king's own night beside it.

Word of it reached Gilleonan's household within the day, the way word of anything touching the slab travelled fast in those valleys whatever else travelled slow, and Gilleonan, hearing it, said only that a man who did not know the answer to a question and a king who would not give one amounted, between them, to much the same silence, and that he was glad, all the same, to have asked his while there was still a Beathan to ask and not merely a slab to ask nothing of. He died three winters after, in the ordinary way at last, of no more than the years finally catching a body that had outrun most men's a long while, with Beathan sitting the last night of it beside his bed as he had sat so many nights beside his fire; and Ìde, who kept the house and the watch some years longer, told her grandchildren at every Samhain that the question her husband had asked was the one true thing anyone had ever got out of that stone in all the years it had been sat by. It had been asked plainly and answered plainly, she said, and a plain asking and a plain answer were more than most things in this world could claim between them. She sat her own last turn the winter her legs at last refused the climb, carried up by a grandson on a sledge and set down beside Beathan at the fire she had first sat beside as a bride glad of any excuse to linger from her own cold hearth; and the round went on after her without either of them, household following household as it had followed for fifty years and would follow for a hundred more, the crack lying under its white stones exactly as it had always lain, and the slab

2. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

grey and silent above it, and no one, by the time this telling closes, any nearer an answer than Gilleonan had been the night he asked for one.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Of Salt For Wool

GE 1,174 – 1,273

*At the ford it is still said that the water remembers two men better
than it remembers any king, though neither of them was one.*

I

Of the Hill Without Salt

Raghnall Ceannfhionn was four hundred and fifteen years old the summer he first rode down to look at his grandfather's salt-kists and found three of the six empty and the other three going the same way, and he was, by the reckoning of Dùn ìseal, still a young man; his hair was the fair, pale colour that had given him his name from a boy, and it had not so much as dulled in all the years he had held the hill for the king, which by then was the better part of two hundred years, though no one troubled any longer to say when the holding had begun, only that it had, the way a river is said to run and not to have started running.

The hill in those years wanted for nothing that grass could grow. Dòmhnall Clachach's grandsons and Fearchar's, and Raghnall's own sons besides, had between them more sheep on the slopes above Dùn ìseal than any household could shear in a season without borrowed hands, and more wool piling in the byres each spring than the weavers could work before the next clip came down on top of it; a man could walk from the gate to the high pasture and never be out of sight of fleece, grey and black and the pale undyed white that the hill favoured, and think, if he had never travelled, that wool was the one thing the world was short of nowhere. What the hill did not have, and had never had in any quantity a

household could keep a winter on, was salt. What little came up from the coast came dear, carried on the backs of traders who took as long over the hills as the weather let them and charged for every mile of it, and a bad autumn for the traders was a hungry spring for anyone who had salted less meat than the winter asked of him.

It was old Gormshuil's stores Ragnall had opened that morning, or what had once been hers and had passed, kist and key, through Dòmhnall and down to him with the rest of the holding, and it was the sight of them near empty, when he had thought there was salt enough laid by for two winters yet, that put the thing in his mind properly for the first time, though he had known the shape of it since he was a boy young enough to still be growing. He stood in the low stone room a long while with the lid up and the smell of brine gone stale in his nose, and thought less about the salt than about a five days' ride to the west, on the shore of the lake, there sat a hill that had salt in plenty from the pans of its own western shore, and sheared no wool worth the name, and that the two hills had sworn to the same king for close on nine hundred years and had never in all that time sent so much as a basket the one to the other.

He rode to Dùn ìseal's own gate the same week and put it to the king plainly, the way he had learned to put things to him, which was without wrapping. "An Cnoc Ruadh¹ has salt it doesn't want and we have wool it does. Let me go and settle it. They are both yours; I will only be doing what you'd do yourself if you rode there."

The king was mending a bridle at the time, sitting on the low wall by the well with the leather across his knee and an awl in his hand, and he did not look up from it for the length of Ragnall's whole speech, which was simply how he attended to most things that were not directly in front of him, and no unkindness. When he did look up it was to say, "They are both mine. I will not do their talking." And then, before Ragnall could take that for a refusal and go, he added, in the same flat voice he used for everything, "You can do it, or it can go undone. It makes no difference to me which."

It was as close to a blessing as the king's kin had learned to expect from him on such matters, and Ragnall, who by four hundred years old had long since stopped waiting for a warmer one, took it as such and rode home to choose his company.

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

He had asked, before he left the well, whether the king would send word ahead of him, a name or a token An Cnoc Ruadh would know for the king's own, and the king had said no to that too, in the same flat way. "If they'll take wool from you for what it is, they'll take it. If they need my name on it first, it was never worth carrying." Ragnall had ridden away turning that over more than he turned over most of what the king said to him, for it seemed to him, on the road west, less a refusal than a kind of trust laid on him sideways, the way the king laid most things he meant to matter: never handed over outright, only left within reach of a man willing to pick it up and carry it himself. The hill was fifty-five miles from An Cnoc Ruadh by the straightest road a horse could keep to, and the ford lay some forty-three of those miles out, nearer the lake than the moor, at a crossing neither household had built and neither, so far as Ragnall could learn, had ever needed to ask the other's leave to use.

II

Of the Wading at the Ford

he took nine men with him and no more, for a company of any greater size would have looked, on a road that had never in living memory carried the hill's spears anywhere near the lake shore, less like a settling of business than a raid got up in wool merchants' clothing, and Ragnall had no wish to be met at the water by men already counting his numbers against their own. It was a five days' journey by the shortest road he knew, west and a little south, over the moor where Dòmhnall's boundary stones still stood in their quarrelling rows and down through country the hill's shepherds walked every summer without ever once, so far as Ragnall could learn by asking, having spoken a word to the households on the far side of it. Word had gone ahead of him by a faster rider all the same, for An Cnoc Ruadh's own herders had eyes, and by the fourth day Ragnall's company was passing through country where children stood well back from the road to watch them go by and said nothing to anyone until they had passed.

They came down to the ford on an evening of early summer, the river low and clear over its stones the way it ran in that season before the autumn rains filled it, wide enough at that crossing that a man standing in the middle of it could not

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

easily be reached from either bank without getting wet to do it, which was, Ragnall thought afterward, very likely why it had been chosen for whatever had been settled there before his own people ever came to it, though he never learned what that earlier use had been, if it had one. On the far bank, drawn up along the shingle in a loose line that was trying not to look like a line, stood a company near the size of his own, and at the front of it, alone a pace ahead of the rest, a broad, weathered man past his middle years whose name the reciters of neither hill, then or after, ever troubled to set down, though both lists kept the deed whole. Whether the omission was the man's own choosing, a holder who wanted the meeting remembered and not himself, or only an accident of two households each waiting for the other to ask first and neither ever doing it, no one now living could say, and it had not seemed, at the time, worth anybody's asking.

The two companies looked at each other across the water for longer than was comfortable, long enough that one of Ragnall's own men muttered that they might as well make camp and settle it in the morning, and it was the river, running loud enough over its stones to cover any silence a man cared to stand in, that made the waiting bearable at all. Then Ragnall walked his horse to the edge of the shingle, dismounted, handed the reins to the man beside him, and walked into the ford alone, without spear or shield, his cloak gathered up out of the water in one fist and the cold of it climbing his legs with every stride until it stood at his knees in the middle of the crossing, where he stopped.

He had thought, walking out, that he might have to stand there some while before the other made up his mind to answer it, and braced himself for the discomfort of the water without complaint, since a man who has asked another to trust him ought at least to be cold about it himself; but An Cnoc Ruadh's holder was already moving before Ragnall had properly settled his feet on the gravel, wading out with the unhurried step of a man crossing his own dooryard, no cloak held up, no ceremony made of the wet, until the two of them stood face to face in the middle of the river with the current pulling at both their legs and nine men on either bank watching close enough to see, though not to hear.

What passed between them the reciters give short, not, Ragnall thought later, because there was more to it that had been lost, but because there had truly been little enough said, the whole of it fitting easily inside the time it takes cold water to numb a man's shins past feeling them. The hill would send wool, come the autumn shearing and every autumn after, and take salt for it, measured out however the two households agreed a fair measure was; neither would bring spears to the

ford again, not that year nor any year after, so long as both sides held to the bargain; and if either hill's people broke faith with the other over the trade itself, it was the two hills' own quarrel to mend and none of the king's, since he had said as much himself and meant it. An Cnoc Ruadh's holder put this last part to Ragnall almost as a question, watching his face for whether the king's own grandson would balk at being told his grandfather's word bound him, and Ragnall, who had heard the king say it to his own face not ten days before, only said that it did, and that he for one was glad of it, since a bargain a man had to keep because no one bigger would keep it for him was worth a great deal more to him than one he could run crying to the hill about. At that the older man laughed, once, short and surprised, as though he had not expected the king's blood to say a true thing about its own blood so readily, and put out his hand.

They clasped arms in the water, each man's grip made clumsier than it should have been by the current and the cold and by hands too numbed for a proper hold, and waded back each to his own bank without either of them once looking round to see whether the other made it, which struck Ragnall, drying his legs by a fire someone had got going with more speed than the evening strictly needed, as a kind of trust in its own right: that a man could turn his back on you in the middle of a river and not trouble to look and see you weren't drowning behind him.

III

Of the Ground the Water Never Dried

The wool came that autumn as promised, and the salt in return, and if either side thought it had been cheated in the weighing neither said so loudly enough for it to reach the other hill's ears, and by the second year no one on either bank had troubled to ask whether they ought to meet again, only where and when, as though the question of whether had been settled for good in that one cold crossing and needed no further deciding. Ragnall did not go himself every year; there was a hill to hold and quarrels enough on his own side of the moor to keep a man from five days' travel each way whenever the wool was ready, and after the third meeting he sent his eldest son in his place more often than not, and after the sixth he sent whoever of his household happened to be free of other business, for the ford by then wanted less a king's grandson to stand in it than it

wanted someone, anyone, of the hill's own blood or trust, to be there at the appointed time with the wool loaded and the scales honest.

It was the honesty of the scales, more than anything either holder had said in the water that first evening, that Raghnaill came, as the years went on, to think had made the thing hold. A trade that cheats slowly dies slowly and no one troubles to mourn it; this one, weighed fair on both banks from the first autumn, grew instead the way a well-tended thing grows, without anyone deciding it should. By the fourth or fifth year traders who were no part of either household had begun coming down to the ford on the appointed days with flint from the eastern diggings and dried fish off Tràigh an t-Salainn¹ and pots thrown by potters neither hill had ever heard of, setting their goods out on the shingle a little apart from the wool and the salt as though asking permission of a custom not yet old enough to have a name for what it permitted; and no one turned them away, for turning a man away from a bargain that cost the hill nothing to allow was not a thing either Raghnaill or An Cnoc Ruadh's² holder, nor after him his own son who took up the same watch, could see the sense of.

In the thirty-fourth year of the ford's meetings, which the reciters of Clann na Ceiste³ mark by counting back from a thing that happened rather later and is easier to fix a year to, a young man of the hill and a young woman of An Cnoc Ruadh's people, who had between them done no more over three or four autumns than stand near enough to each other at the weighing to be remarked on by both their mothers, were married on the trodden ground, with both banks' households standing for it and the river running past unconcerned a few strides off, and it was the first marriage the ford ever gave anyone, though the reciters differ, as reciters will, on whether it was also the least remarkable, since by then half the young people on either bank had begun finding reasons of their own to be at the crossing on the appointed days whether they had wool or salt to weigh or not. Raghnaill was there for that one, an old custom of his own by then, to see the ford give something back besides trade; and standing a little apart from the crowd of both households mixed together on ground that had been nothing but shingle and cold water thirty-four years before, he found himself thinking, not for the first time and not for the last, that a thing agreed between two men standing waist-

1. the salt shore

2. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

3. the Children of the Question

deep and shivering had somehow, without either of them meaning it to, become a thing that no longer needed either of them at all to keep it going.

There was one year, the eleventh or the twelfth of the meetings, that the wool came down thin and poorly washed, a bad clip after a wet shearing season, and An Cnoc Ruadh's people, who had weighed fair salt against fair wool every autumn before that one, said plainly at the ford that they would not weigh the same measure of salt against wool that stank of the fleece still on it. Ragnall was away in the north that year; his son stood on the hill's side of the scales and heard it, and who rode home afterward expecting, by his own later telling, to be sent straight back to the king to ask what was to be done about a bargain the west meant to break. Ragnall heard him out and asked only one thing in return, which was whether the wool truly was as poor as An Cnoc Ruadh said. His son allowed that it was. "Then they're not breaking the bargain," Ragnall told him. "They're keeping it exactly as it was made, which was fair wool for fair salt, and this year we brought them the wrong half of it." He sent his son back the following spring with a better clip and, besides it, enough extra fleece to make up what the thin year had shorted them, and said nothing to the king about any of it, there being nothing in it that wanted a king's settling; and An Cnoc Ruadh, for its part, never afterward pressed harder than a fair measure asked, nor did the hill ever again send down wool it had not first looked over with its own hands. It was the nearest the ford's custom ever came, in Ragnall's lifetime, to being tested, and it held by nothing written and nothing sworn beyond the two hills' own wish to keep being able to trust each other the following year, which Ragnall came in time to think was worth a good deal more than anything a law could have bound them to.

IV

Of Murchadh Gearr on the Salt Road

An Cnoc Ruadh's holder who had waded out that first evening held it a further twenty years and some, and was followed by a son and then, the son dying young of no more than an ordinary fever, by a grandson who held it only a little while before the hill passed, by whatever reckoning the west kept of such things, to a kinsman of the old holder's line named Murchadh Gearr, a short, thick-set man with a laugh too big for the size of him, who came to the ford

for his first weighing already known on both banks as a man who walked everywhere he might as easily have ridden, on the grounds, he said, that a holder folk could see coming a mile off on his own two feet was a holder they trusted more than one who appeared among them suddenly from horseback, as though he had something to hide in the arriving.

He took the habit further than any before him. Every year from the salt-pans of Baile ghorm down to the ford, the length of what the traders by then had begun to call Rathad an t-Salainn¹ without any of them quite remembering who had first called it that, Murchadh Gearr walked it on his own feet in the weeks before the autumn meeting, stopping at every household along it whether they had wool or salt to send that year or not, eating what was set in front of him and asking after names he plainly already knew the answers to, so that by the time he came down to the water there was not a child on the road who could not say they had seen An Cnoc Ruadh²'s holder pass, on foot, in the flesh, with his own eyes. Some of the older folk of both hills said he did it only for the love of being seen doing it, which was likely true and no fault in a man; others said, and this too Ragnall came to think likely, that a holder who let the folk forget him between one autumn and the next was a holder whose word, when it came time to weigh salt against wool, carried less than a stranger's, and that Murchadh Gearr, whatever his vanity, had understood that plainly enough to walk fifty miles a year rather than risk it.

Ragnall himself, by the year Murchadh Gearr first walked the road, had held Dùn iséal the better part of three hundred years, and looked, so far as anyone below sixty could judge such a thing by eye, no older than the fair-headed young man who had waded into the ford at four hundred and fifteen; his own children by then had children with grey coming into their hair, and those children in turn were bringing wool to the ford themselves without any memory of a time the crossing had not been kept, so that to them the ford was simply a thing the world had always had, the way a hill has always had a river running past it, and not a bargain their grandfather's grandfather had once stood shivering in cold water to strike. It was a strangeness Ragnall had grown used to without ever quite growing easy in it, watching a thing he remembered making pass, year on year, out of anyone's living memory of its making and into the kind of fact a child simply knows without being told when he first learned it.

1. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

2. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

V

Of the Trodden Ground

he came down to the ford himself for the last time in his hundredth year past the wading, an old habit more than a needed one by then, since the meeting by that year ran on custom thick enough that neither hill's holder needed stand in it to see it kept faith. It was a cool morning with mist still lying along the water when he arrived, the shingle already crowded with more traders and more households than he could remember it holding even ten years before, wool and salt and flint and pots and dried fish all laid out in their long accustomed rows, children of both banks running between the stalls in a way that made no distinction any longer between the hill's side of the water and An Cnoc Ruadh's, and somewhere among the crowd, though Ragnall did not trouble to seek him out, Murchadh Gearr's big laugh sounding over the general noise the way it always did.

He stood a while on the bank, at the same stretch of shingle, near enough as made no difference, where he had stood before wading out the first time, and looked at the ground the ninety-nine autumns since had worn bare and hard of any grass, packed down by so many feet coming and going that it held, even in the wet of that morning, no mud to speak of, only a smooth dark path running down to the water's edge on both banks alike, wider now than any road the hill could show. It came to him, standing there, as an old thought finally said plainly, the way a thing known a long while sometimes waits years for its own saying, that the ground under his own feet would go on being trodden by feet that had never known his name and would not miss the knowing of it, long after the last of the people now crossing it had gone the way of everyone but him and the man mending a bridle by a well who had told him, on a morning near a hundred years gone, that the settling of it was Ragnall's to make or leave unmade and no business of his own either way. The king would outlast the ford, Ragnall thought, the way he had outlasted the grove and would outlast whatever came after the ford too; and Ragnall himself, four hundred and fifteen years old the day he first stood shivering in that water and near five hundred and fifteen the morning he stood dry-shod on its bank watching strangers weigh salt against wool without so much as a glance toward the old man who had once made the weighing possible, under-

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

stood, with no particular grief attached to the understanding, that he would be gone from the ford a long while before the ford was done with anyone.

He did not say any of this to the men who had ridden down with him, nor to his own son, who found him some while after, still standing on the same stretch of shingle and asked, not unkindly, whether he meant to stand there all morning or come and see the year's weighing properly begun. Ragnall said that he was coming, and went, and put his hand once, briefly, to the packed dark earth of the trodden ground before he did, the way a man touches a doorpost on his way out of a house he does not expect to enter again by the same door; and the ford, which had by then long since stopped needing either hill's holder to keep faith with the other, took no more notice of the gesture than the river had taken, all those years before, of two men wading back to their own banks without once looking round to see whether the other had made it safely home.

PART THREE

The Far Shores and the Name

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

OF THE WESTERN SHORE AND THE AMBER BEAD

GE 1,274 – 1,440

*At the western Seann Skell the amber-drillers still say a woman
carried the finest stone any of them ever found the whole length of
the island on foot, and gave it away before she had gone a mile
back the way she had come.*

I

Of the Bay of Hawks

In the twelve hundred and seventy-fourth year of the hill, three households that had grown too many mouths for the grazing above Baile ghorm took their cattle and their looms and their children and went west, over the spine of the island and down through country no hill family had settled before, until the ground fell away under them and they stood looking at open water for the first time in their lives. They built where a stream came down to a curve of grey sand under a headland thick with gorse, in the round manner of the hill, turf-roofed and set back a little from the tide, and they fished from the shore with lines and baskets and did not put out boats, for none of them had ever built one and none of them trusted the water enough to learn. The bay took its name, in the way places took names on that coast, from what a man first saw standing on the headland looking down at it: a pair of hawks working the updraught off the cliff face, hanging so long on one spot of air that the man who told of it afterward swore they had not moved a feather the whole time he watched.

It was the first hill household on that shore, though not, the old wrack-gatherers of the strand would tell you, the first household of any kind, for the low grassed-over shapes further round the headland had held roofs once, and the middens under them, when a spade turned one up, gave back shell and bone gone the colour of the ground itself. The three households let those middens lie. They had come down out of hill country too poor to bring more than they carried on their backs, and a heap of old bones was no poorer a neighbour than the wind. No one among them could say who had raised those roofs or why the roofs had come down, and no one asked twice, for the second asking got no more answer than the first and only put a chill on the fire it was asked beside.

The crossing itself was told for two generations after as its own small history, though it took the three households no more than nine days on foot with their beasts loaded and their children carried the last of it. They had gone by Rathad na Spor¹ as far as it ran west, then off it along a drover's track that ran out into heather with no path left in it at all, over a spine of hill where the wind never once let up, day or night, and down at last through a birch wood into ground softer underfoot than any of them had walked since leaving the valley they were born in. The eldest of the three households, a woman near her ninetieth year named Beathag, walked the whole of it on her own two feet and would take no one's arm, and said, when they came out at last above the bay and saw the water, that she had not believed until that moment there was so much of it in the world, more than any river or loch she had ever heard sung of. She lived eleven years more on that shore and was the first hill-folk buried within sound of that particular tide.

Flòraidh was born into the second of those three households, eleven years after the crossing, in a winter when the sea froze white with salt-rime along the tideline and her mother said afterward that she had come squalling into a world already half turned to stone. She was a middle child among five, neither the eldest who would hold the house nor the youngest who would be petted for it, and she grew up the way middle children on a poor shore grow up, finding for herself the one thing in the house nobody else wanted and making it hers.

1. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

II

Of the Amber and the Wrack

The thing nobody else wanted was the wrack line after a westerly gale, when every other child on the bay went straight for driftwood and the gulls' eggs in the gorse and left the weed itself, black and stinking and thigh-deep in places, for whoever cared to turn it over. Flòraidh turned it over from the time she could walk without falling, at first for nothing more than the shells and the drowned crabs a smaller child could carry home for the pot, and then, the summer she was nine, for a lump of something the colour of cold honey that her fingers found half buried in a raft of bladderwrack and would not let go of even when the tide came back for it.

Her mother knew the stuff at once, though she had never in her own life found a piece worth keeping. The old people of the bay called it sun-stone or sea-stone, and said, without much conviction, that it wept out of trees that had stood somewhere in the world before the world was as it now was; it warmed in the hand faster than any true stone should, and when rubbed hard against wool it would lift a hair or a scrap of down off the ground and hold it there, dancing, for longer than any child who tried it could sit still and watch. It washed up seldom and only after the worst weather, thrown loose from some bed the sea kept far out and gave up nothing about, and a lump the size of a thumb-joint was talked of on the bay for a season.

Flòraidh's find that ninth summer was the size of a hen's egg, the largest anyone on that shore had seen brought in whole, and her mother would not let her keep it raw. There was an old man three houses along, blind in one eye from a spark struck off a flint, who had learned from a trader out of the eastern hills how a hole could be worked through a piece of sea-stone with a flint point and wetted sand and more patience than most men owned, so that a cord could be run through it and the thing worn rather than merely kept in a pouch to be taken out and admired. He worked at Flòraidh's egg-sized lump through the better part of a winter, a little each evening by the fire, turning the drill between his palms while she sat and watched and learned, without being taught in any way she could have named afterward, the weight of hand that kept a flint point true and the weight that snapped a good stone in two for nothing. By the time the hole ran clean through, front to back, no wider than a strand of wool, she was old enough to

hold the drill herself on the next piece, and old enough, too, to understand that she had been given a craft rather than a favour.

She grew up the length of that shore known for it: the girl who did not mind the stink of the wrack, who could tell by the smell of the weed alone, before her hand had touched a thing in it, whether a gale had brought anything worth the walk. Traders who came down Rathad na Spor¹ with baskets of pots and strings of shell for the coast learned to ask for her by name rather than knock at any door at random, and went away with beads worked to a finish no other hand on that bay gave them, paying in salt or wool or, once, in a knife of southern flint that Flòraidh's father wore at his belt the rest of his life and was buried with.

Her elder sister, who would hold the house after their mother, thought the whole business beneath a grown woman's time, and said so at every hearth-telling until the saying wore smooth from repeating; her two younger brothers thought it a fine excuse to spend a morning at the tideline instead of at the byre, and were sent home more than once with nothing to show for it but wet feet and their sister's amusement, for the wrack did not give itself up to a boy hunting driftwood with half his mind on his supper. Only her father never asked why she troubled with it, holding, as he held of most things, that a craft which fed itself and asked nothing of the byre was a craft worth leaving be. He was a quiet man who had come west already grown, in the first crossing, and remembered the hill valleys of his own boyhood well enough to tell of them but never troubled to wish himself back among them; it was he who first walked the strand with her after the worst gales, saying little, carrying whatever she found until her own arms could not hold more, and it was from him, more than from the blind drill-master, that she learned the patience the work wanted.

There came a summer, the year she turned sixteen, when no gale worth the name touched that coast from Bealltainn to Samhain, and the wrack lay thin and ordinary the whole season through. Flòraidh took to walking further than she had ever walked before, past the headland and along strands no household of the bay had troubled to search, on the reasoning, which she could not have argued for aloud, that a sea too idle to throw anything ashore near home might yet have thrown something further off where no one thought to look. She found little enough for her trouble that year, a few small pieces no better than what any child brought in, but she came to know the whole coast within two days' walk of the

1. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

bay by its own name, before and after that, by the shape of its rocks and the run of its currents, in a way that would matter to her later more than she then knew.

III

Of the Bead and the Road

The finest piece she ever drew from the wrack came to her in the thirty-first year of the hill households on that shore, out of a storm that took the roof off two houses and left the whole strand for half a mile heaped with weed a man could have got lost in. It was larger than the egg of her ninth summer by half again, the colour of a full winter sun through cloud, with a cloudiness deep inside it like smoke caught the instant before it thins, and no crack anywhere in it that her eye, or the old drill-master's, now three years dead, could have found. She worked the hole through it herself over four evenings, slower than she had ever worked a stone before, and when it was done she strung it on nothing, for a while, only kept it wrapped in wool in the box where she kept her mother's few beads of shell, and did not know, or would not say, what she meant to do with it.

Her mother knew. There had been talk on the bay for some years, carried up Rathad na Spor¹ and back down again by traders, of a meeting each summer at a ford far to the east, between the hill and the holders of a red rise of ground called only An Cnoc Ruadh², where salt from the southern pans was traded for wool and for everything else besides, and where, it was said, the king himself came and walked among the stalls, though what he did there nobody on that shore had ever heard told plainly, only that no one who had stood near him at it came away with quite the same telling as the man beside him.

"Carry it there," her mother said, turning the bead once in the firelight before she gave it back. "A stone that size, off this shore, should be seen where the whole of the hill can see it, and not sit in a box behind my loom until one of your own children breaks it playing."

The trading party that would carry her east was five years in the gathering, for no household bound so far went empty-handed and the bay's own wool and worked stone took that long to grow to a load worth the road; Flòraidh kept the

1. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

2. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

bead wrapped through every one of those years rather than send it ahead with a smaller party she trusted less. She was five-and-twenty by the time the party was ready, and had never in all that waiting gone further from the bay than Rathad na Spor's first bend. She went with a trader's party that left the western Seann Skell at the turn of summer, six households' worth of wool and hides and worked stone loaded on eleven pack-beasts, and walked the length of the island in the company of people she had known a month, sleeping under whatever roof would have a trader's party or, twice, under no roof at all with the stars thick enough overhead that she lay awake past exhaustion only to look at them. The amber travelled wrapped in the same wool it had always known, in a pouch she kept against her body under her clothes rather than trust to any pack, and touched it through the cloth most nights before she slept, the way another woman might have touched a charm.

The road took them up through hill country greener and better watered than her own coast, past herds larger than the whole bay could have grazed in a lifetime and byres built four-square in a manner her father's people had never troubled to raise on the poor ground of the west. At a crossing where a swollen burn had to be forded waist-deep, the party lost a full pack of hides to the current before a young man travelling with them, a boat-mender's son bound the same way to sell his father's work, went in after it and came out grinning and blue with cold, holding the pack over his head and the hides inside it dry. Flòraidh thought little enough of him at the time beyond the ordinary gratitude of a woman whose own pack had ridden the same beast, though she would remember, years after, that he had laughed at the cold rather than cursed it, and that this had seemed to her, without her quite deciding why, worth remembering.

Twice the party fell in with other travellers bound the same way, once a family of An Cnoc Ruadh kin driving cattle down for the same gathering, and once a lone drover who said nothing of himself at all and left before dawn each morning ahead of everyone else, so that Flòraidh never learned so much as which coast he called home. By the third week the country had opened out flatter and busier than anything her eye had known, smoke rising from more hearths in a single valley than her whole bay held households, and on the last evening before the ford itself, from a rise in the road, she saw the fires of the gathering laid out below her like a second sky come down to rest on the ground, more lights together than she had ever in her life seen in one place.

IV

Of the Ford and the Man Who Bought Nothing

She came down to the ford on the fourth day of the gathering, footsore and burned dark by three weeks of open road, into a noise and a press of people greater than anything the bay had ever shown her: pens of sheep bleating against the lowing of penned cattle, the knock of a flint-knapper's hammerstone somewhere behind a line of tents, salt stacked in baskets taller than a child, and everywhere the particular high chatter of people haggling in a dozen accents of the same tongue. She had thought, walking the last mile of the road, that she would know the king the moment she saw him, by some mark or blaze she could not have named; instead she stood a full morning at the edge of the trading ground before anyone told her that the tall man in plain wool, moving slowly along the line of stalls with his hands loose at his sides, was the one she had come to see.

He bought nothing. She watched him the better part of an hour, at first from a distance and then, drawn closer than she had meant to go, from near enough to have touched his sleeve. At a stall of southern pots he turned one over in his hands, weighed it, set it down exactly where it had stood. At a rack of worked flint he stopped longer, running a thumb along an edge without testing its keenness the way any other man on the ground would have. He asked the price of nothing, offered nothing, and yet the stallholders straightened when he came near and settled again, slower, when he had gone on, as though the ground had held its breath under him and only now let it go. His face gave his years away no more than a hearthstone gives the years of the fires it has carried, smooth and unlined as a man of five and twenty summers, though he had the stillness of someone who had stood in that exact spot, or one very like it, more times than he cared to count, and found each time something worth the standing. No torque, no dyed cloth marked him, nothing a poor household could not have put on its own back for a feast day, and yet the crowd gave way from him a full arm's length on either side without any of them seeming to notice they had moved, the way water gives way round a rock in a burn without the burn troubling to ask why.

A stallholder near her, an old salt-woman down from the pans with a face gone the colour and grain of driftwood, caught Flòraidh staring and leaned to say, low, that the king had walked that same ground every gathering since the ford was first agreed, and had never once, in all the tellings she knew, been seen to buy so

much as a bannock off any stall on it. "Some say he has no need of what we sell," the woman said, "and some say he buys everything already, in some coin none of us would know how to weigh, and needs nothing more from us than the standing and the looking. I have sold salt on this ground thirty summers and I could not tell you which of the two is truer, and I have stopped asking."

Flòraidh had meant to lay the bead quietly in the old ground at the meeting-place, among the other small offerings that travellers left there without much ceremony, a scrap of ribbon or a worked bone tucked under a stone, and go home again with a tale to tell rather than a gift given by hand. Her nerve failed her for that and gave her something else instead. When the king passed within an arm's length of her, she found the pouch already open at her breast and the bead already out and held up on her flat palm before she had decided to do either.

He stopped. He looked at the bead a long moment, and then at her, in a way that made her feel, for the length of that look, entirely known, though she had never in her life stood before him. His hands did not come up to take it.

"Where does the sun-stone wash," he asked her, "on your shore?"

"After a westerly," she said, her voice steadier than she had thought it would be. "Only after a westerly, and only the worst of them."

He nodded, as though she had confirmed something rather than told him anything new, and looked once more at the bead without touching it. "Keep it," he said. "Lay it in the ground here yourself, with your own hand, where you meant to. A thing carried the length of the island should be laid by the one who carried it, not passed off to another hand at the last step of the road."

She did as she was told, kneeling at the old ground among the ribbons and the worked bones while he stood by and watched, and when she rose he was already three strides off among the stalls again, buying nothing, looking at everything, and no one near enough to her afterward could tell her with any certainty whether he had smiled before he turned.

She stayed three days more at the ford after that, sleeping in the trader's tent among the wool bales and walking the trading ground each morning half hoping and half dreading to see him again, though she never did; he was, the salt-woman told her, as likely to be seen at the far end of the ground haggling in spirit if not in coin over a beast he had no wish to own as he was to vanish entirely for the length of a day and be found again at dusk sitting alone by the river with his boots off, and no one on the ground troubled him either way. On the second of those three days the boat-mender's son sought her out where she sat mending a strap, and

asked, plainly enough that she laughed before she answered, whether a woman who had spoken with the king himself had any words left over for an ordinary man; she found, turning the question over afterward on the long road home, that she had rather more than she had expected.

V

Of the Years the Bay Was Told Of

She walked home by the same road she had come, in a trader's party bound the other way, and told the tale of the ford so many times over the following winter that her younger brother swore he could have told it in her voice without her in the room, down to the very words of the salt-woman she had spoken to only the once. The boat-mender's son followed her west the next summer with two of his father's finished boats loaded on a cart drawn by a beast he had traded three years' labour for, and asked her father for her outright, standing in the yard with his boots still crusted from the road, in a manner the bay found so forward that it was talked of nearly as much as the bead had been. She married him that autumn.

They raised three children on that shore over the years that followed, in a house built nearer the water than her mother's had been, for her husband held, as boat-menders will, that a house too far back from the tide was a house always walking to its work. None of the three ever brought home a stone from the wrack worth a telling of its own, though all three learned the drill at her knee exactly as she had learned it at the blind man's, turning the bow between their small palms under her eye until she judged the weight of their hand true; and her eldest daughter, in her own old age long after this telling closes, would teach the same craft in turn to a granddaughter of Flòraidh's who never once heard her grandmother's own voice. Flòraidh herself gathered the wrack every westerly gale of her life until her knees would no longer take the wet stones, and after that walked the strand anyway, some evenings, with a stick, looking rather than gathering, for she said the looking had always been half the pleasure and she saw no cause to give it up before the walking failed her too.

She died in her sixty-eighth year, in a mild autumn with the wrack lying quiet and unbroken along the whole strand, her husband four years dead before her and her children grown with households of their own up and down that coast.

She was buried, at her own asking, facing the water rather than the headland, so that whatever came in on the tide would come in past her; and for a full year after, it is told, no household on that bay let a westerly gale pass without someone walking down at first light to see what it had brought, half in the old habit of the work and half, though none of them put it in so many words, in case it had brought something meant for her.

It is told on that shore, too, of other things of those years, carried back to it the way all news of the wider island came, by traders and by the boat-menders who took after her husband's trade and travelled further with it than he ever had.

The households at Cala nan Taighean Cruinne¹, near enough An Cnoc Ruadh² to pay it salt, had begun in Flòraidh's own middle years to pay it and to be counted among An Cnoc Ruadh's households, as every household within a hard day's walk of a hill holding had by then come to do without any word from Dùn ìseal telling them to. No one could afterward point to the year it started or the household that started it; it was said only that one autumn the custom was new and the next it was old, the way a path across a field is new one season and worn the next without anyone marking the day the first foot crossed it.

Cattle were walked up Rathad na Spor³ itself, the length of it, into the north-west, to a green rise called Cnoc ghorm where until then the people had lived off seal and fish and deer and had never kept a beast on a tether in their lives. It took three summers of driving small herds up by stages, resting them at every burn the road crossed, before a herd stood there large enough to be called a herd rather than a curiosity; and the first calves born on that rise were watched over by the whole settlement in turn through their first winter, the way a stranger's child new to a household is watched, given the warmest corner of every byre and the first cut of every store, until they had proved themselves, calving in their turn and standing the cold as well as any beast bred to it, no stranger thing after all.

And in the north-west, on a rise above a firth wide enough to lose a fleet in, a long-house was raised the length of forty paces, byre and hall under the one roof, greater by half again than any roof the age had yet put up, timbered with wood carried down from Rathad na Spor's own hills and roofed with turf cut a whole season in advance and dried under cover so it would not sag with its own wet weight. Word of its raising travelled Rathad na Spor and down the coast within

1. the round-house harbour paying salt to the Red Hill (burg 26 in this age)

2. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

3. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

the year, and for a season it was spoken of on Flòraidh's own shore as the boat-menders spoke of a hull built beyond the ordinary run of hulls, admired by people who would never see it and never quite believed by all of them either.

It stood four winters before a spark from an untended hearth-fire took the thatch of the byre end in the small hours of a still night, and though every soul under that roof got out alive, the hall end burned with it before the byre's own beasts, driven out bawling into the dark, could be turned back to help beat down the flame. The household that had raised it raised it again on the same footing before the following winter closed in, for the ground, they said, had proved itself good ground, whatever the fire had proved about the roof; and it stood after that the way most things on that coast came, in the end, to stand: mended, and carrying its scorch mark where anyone who cared to look might see it, waiting, though none of that household would have said so aloud, for whatever the next spark might prove of it too.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

OF the Rope's End

GE 1,441 – 1,540

*At the moor of the eastern Toll-dubh the covering stone is still laid
the same way it was laid in her father's father's day, and the house-
hold that lays it will tell a stranger only that it was Iseabail's way
before it was theirs.*

I

Of the Household at the Shaft's Mouth

The household that kept the eastern Toll-dubh had by then held it four generations without ever once finishing the work their own great-grandfathers had begun, for the shaft the old diggers had sunk into that level moor, straight and smooth-walled and reaching down past any depth a stone dropped from the lip would answer for, had long since stopped being a work in anyone's hands and become instead a thing only kept, the way a grave is kept, or a hearth that has not held a fire in a generation is kept swept all the same. The old plaited cords the first diggers had worn through hung yet inside the house's own door, two lengths of dark hide gone stiff with age, and a stranger coming to that threshold, seeing them hung where another household would have hung a net or a snare, learned soon enough not to ask after them twice, for the first asking got a plain enough answer and the second got only a look that closed the matter.

Iseabail was born into that household in the fourteen hundred and thirtieth year of the hill, the elder of two children, a dark, quiet, watchful girl who from her earliest years had a way of standing at the edge of any gathering with her arms folded and her eyes going from face to face that made the older women of the

moor say, half in fondness and half in something nearer unease, that she watched a room the way her family's shaft watched the sky, taking everything in and giving nothing back. Her brother Eachann came five years after her, born loud where she was quiet, quick to laugh and quicker to dare, the kind of boy who could not pass a height without wanting to know what stood at the top of it nor a hole without wanting to know what lay at the bottom, and who by his tenth year had already been pulled twice from trouble a more careful child would never have found: once from a sea-cave the tide had near closed on him, and once from the roof-tree of the byre, where he had climbed to see, he said afterward, whether a man standing on it could see as far as Rathad na Spor¹.

Their father kept the shaft the way his own father had kept it before him, laying the flat covering stone loosely over its mouth at the first hard frost of every year and lifting it again when the days had lengthened past the shortest, a custom carried on with no more ceremony than swinging a byre door was carried on, and no more explaining given to a child who asked after it than the plain fact that the stone kept a wandering beast or a careless foot from the lip through the months no one went down to trouble it. He told his children, as his own father had told him, that the digging had stopped generations back when the lamp let down on its cord showed no more of the walls than a small patch no wider than two hands held apart, the rest of the depth standing dark above and below it alike, and that a stone let fall after that had given back no sound of striking anything at all, though a household had stood listening a long while to be sure of it. He told them, too, and told it more than once, for it was the one part of the telling he seemed to want driven in past all forgetting, that no one had gone down since, and that no one, so far as the household's own memory ran, had any cause to.

Eachann heard this the way he heard every closed door in his short life, which was as an invitation rather than a warning, though he was careful enough, even as a boy, not to let his father see the shine that came into his eye at the telling of it.

II

Of the Boy Who Would Not Let It Be

1. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

The boy grew up circling that stone the way another boy might circle a girl he meant, in time, to speak to. He was forbidden the moor after dark from an early age, on no account explained to him beyond his mother's flat word that the moor at night was no place for anyone, and he kept, on the whole, to that forbidding, being fonder of his own bed than of any mystery enough to give it up entirely; but by day, through the years the covering stone stood lifted, he found reasons to be about the shaft's mouth that his elder sister, watching from a little way off with her arms folded in her old fashion, came to know for what they were without his ever once telling her plainly. He would lie flat on the moor grass with his head and shoulders out over the lip, calling down into the dark to hear how long his own voice took to come back to him, which by his own reckoning, kept in his head across three summers of trying it, was longer each year than the year before, though Iseabail told him more than once that a boy's memory of an echo was no more to be trusted than a boy's memory of a fish he had nearly caught. Every trader who came up the moor track he asked whether any other household, anywhere the trader had walked, kept a shaft like theirs, and grew quieter, not louder, each time the answer came back that none did, or that if any did the trader had never heard tell of it, as though the shaft's very rareness were argument enough for going down into it that his sister could see building in him long before he found the words to put it to their father plainly.

He put it to their father plainly in his fifteenth year, standing at the covering stone on a spring morning with his hands laced behind his back the way he stood when he wanted to seem more grown than his years, and asked to be let down on the old cord to see for himself what four generations of the household's own telling had never once claimed to know. Their father said no, without heat and without more explaining than he had ever given the shaft's own silence, and Eachann, to his credit and his sister's mild surprise, let the matter lie unspoken between them for the better part of two years after, though Iseabail, who watched him still the way she watched most things, never once believed the wanting in him had lain down with the asking.

Their father died in the fourteen hundred and fifty-first year, of no more than an ordinary fever that took three others on the moor that same wet spring, and the covering stone passed, along with the rest of the small holding, into the keeping of Iseabail and Eachann together, she twenty-two by then and he seventeen, both of them grown enough by the moor's own reckoning to be answerable for a household's custom without any elder standing over them to enforce it. It was the

first winter the stone was laid by their own two hands alone, and Iseabail, laying it with her brother that first hard frost, felt him watching the dark gap it covered a moment longer than the laying asked for, and said nothing, for there was, by then, nothing left to say that had not already been said and let lie.

III

Of the Rope's End

He asked her in the spring, when the stone had been lifted again and the moor had begun to green, not their father, who was a year in the ground by then and past asking anything of, and not any elder of the moor, for there was none left near enough to their holding to have the right of it, but Iseabail herself, standing at the shaft's mouth on a still morning with the old cord already coiled over one shoulder, the longer of the two hanging by the door, tested that same dawn for any rot the years might have worked into the hide and found, by his own report of the testing, sound. He did not ask leave so much as tell her plainly that he meant to go down, that the household's own cord was strong enough for it and had been proved so a hundred times over in the diggers' own day, and that a household which kept a wonder at its own door and never once looked into it was keeping, by his reckoning, nothing at all worth the keeping.

She told him no, in near enough her father's own words, and watched the telling glance off him the way it had glanced off their father two years before. What she had never told him plainly before, she told him then: that she had dreamed twice that winter of the shaft with no bottom to it at all, only dark going down forever, and had woken both times with her heart going hard enough to wake beside it; and Eachann, who loved his sister and did not, in the ordinary run of things, make light of what troubled her, said only that a dream was a dream and a shaft was a shaft, and that he would rather know, and be wrong to have looked, than spend the rest of his own life circling a stone the way he had circled it as a boy.

She held the rope in the end because there was no one else on the whole of that moor she would have trusted to hold it for him, and because she had long since understood, watching him these seven years and more, that a no from her would only send him down some day with no one holding it at all, which

frightened her a good deal more than the holding did. The two of them went out on a clear morning in the fourteen hundred and fifty-second year, the two of them alone, with the cord looped twice about a stake her brother had driven the evening before into ground he had tested for its firmness with his own full weight, and a second cord besides, shorter, tied about Eachann himself under his arms in the manner the old telling said the first diggers had tied it, so that a fall would catch him rather than drop him clean.

He went down slowly at her paying-out, calling up to her at first in the old way he had called down as a boy, to test how long his voice took returning, and she answered him each time to know that the answer still reached him; but the calling grew further between as the cord ran out, and then stopped altogether a good while before the cord did, not through any fright in his voice, for the last of it she heard was steady enough, but simply because the distance, she thought after, had grown too great by then for a voice to carry either way without more shouting than either of them had thought, standing at the lip that morning, they would need. She stood alone at the stake with the cord running taut and cold through her two hands, feeling for its own small movements the way a fisher feels a line, and it seemed to her, though she never afterward could put a plain shape to the feeling nor swear to anyone that it was more than her own fright working on her, that the cord went, for a time near the very end of its length, curiously light in her hands, as though whatever hung on it had ceased, for those moments, to need the holding at all.

How long she stood there she could not have said, asked closely afterward, before the cord's weight came fully back into her hands and she felt, at last, the three short tugs he had promised her beforehand would mean he was ready to be drawn up. She drew him up alone, hand over hand at the stake, in a labour that left the skin of both her palms raw for a fortnight after, and did not stop nor rest the drawing once begun, for she had promised herself, standing at that lip with the cord gone light in her hands, that she would not let go of him for want of her own strength before she had seen with her own eyes what had come up out of the dark on the end of it.

He came up alive. He came up whole, with no mark on him beyond the ordinary chafing the cord had worked at his sides, and stood on the moor grass blinking in a morning light no brighter, by any telling, than the light he had gone down under, and said nothing at all for the length of time it took her own hands to stop their shaking. When at last he spoke it was only to ask, in a voice she did not at

first know for his own, whether she was hurt from the drawing, and to take the raw of her palms into his own two hands and look at them a long while before he let them go.

She asked him, that same morning and every day for a long while after, what he had found at the rope's end. He never told her. He did not refuse her plainly, nor grow angry at the asking, nor once, in all the years the asking went on, give her cause to think he punished her with the silence for any fault of hers; he simply did not answer, turning the question aside each time with some small word about the cold down there, or the dark, or nothing worth the telling, in a manner so mild and so unshaken that she came, in time, to believe he had decided the not-telling before ever he was drawn back up, the way a man decides, going into deep water, how far out he means to swim before the water has told him anything of its own mind.

They laid the covering stone that same autumn and never lifted it again with any thought of going down after it. Within the year the household's own custom, which had stood four generations as a silence about a thing merely closed, hardened into something nearer a law that Iseabail herself set, without meaning to set anything so grand as a law, simply by telling every soul who asked after the shaft, traveller and neighbour and, in time, her own children, that the household went down into Toll-dubh no more, and would go down no more, and that whoever came after her might keep the stone or let it lie as their own conscience answered for, but that no cord of that house's plaiting would go over that lip again while she herself had breath to forbid it. No one on that moor, in all the years the telling of it ran, ever went down again.

IV

Of the Question She Carried

She married, two years after, a man of a neighbouring holding who had courted her patiently through the very years the asking of her brother went unanswered, and who never once, in all the years of their own marriage, asked her to make her brother speak where she herself had failed; and she raised three children on that moor within sound of the same stone her father and his father had laid before her, teaching them, as she had been taught, to leave a thing closed that a household's own telling said was closed, though she taught it, her

own children said, with a plainer weight in the telling than her father had ever put into it, as a woman teaches a lesson she has herself paid a full price to learn rather than one merely handed down.

Eachann never married. He lived on the moor within sight of his sister's own holding the whole of his life, keeping a small flock and mending the cords and creels of anyone on that stretch who asked him, a quiet, steady, well-liked man whom the moor came in time to call by no other name than Eachann Ròpa, the name settling onto him so gradually that neither he nor his sister could afterward have said which year it first was spoken to his face rather than only behind it. He bore the name without complaint and, so far as anyone on the moor ever saw, without any particular pride in it either, the way a man bears a scar got young that has long since stopped hurting and become simply a mark he answers to.

Iseabail asked him the question, in one shape or another, at every gathering of their two households across thirty years and more, at weddings and at burials and at the ordinary suppers a brother and sister keep between them when there is nothing pressing to say, and he turned it aside each time in the same mild way, until the asking itself became, between them, less a question in earnest than a kind of greeting the two of them kept up out of habit, the way another family keeps a joke worn smooth from telling; and yet she never, in all those years, stopped meaning it plainly beneath the habit, and he, she came to believe, never once mistook her meaning for less than it was, however lightly either of them wore the asking by then.

V

Of the Hut and the Lake

There reached her, in the years her own children were growing, two tellings from other parts of the hill's country that she heard only as a traveller's news carried up the moor track, and neither of which she ever once, in her own telling of them after, set beside her brother's silence or asked to be read as answering it, for she had learned by then, better than most, how little good came of laying one unclosed thing over another for no better reason than that both were dark.

A herding family new to the hills where the shape called Marbh-bheò¹ was oldest told of lit an open fire against the custom that country kept, being strangers to it and slow, as strangers often are, to weigh a neighbour's fear as heavily as their own comfort; and word came up the moor track, some years after, that the family's hut had been found standing with its fire still burning on the hearth and not a soul of the household anywhere about it, near or far, then or ever after, though every household within a day's walk had turned out to search the ground twice over. Iseabail heard the telling at a summer gathering, from a trader who swore he had it from a cousin who had helped in the searching, and thought of her brother's own silence not at all that evening, only of the hut standing open with its fire untended, and said, when her own children asked her plainly whether the two things were the same kind of dark, that she could not tell them so, not having stood at either mouth of it herself, and that a woman did well not to guess at a neighbour's mystery only for having one of her own.

The second telling came in the years her hair had begun to grey, of a scatter of platforms built out over the shallows of a lake far to the north-west, homes raised on stilts above the water by households that had kept them, by all report, three generations and more without trouble; and it was told that the platforms burned in a single night to the waterline, the charred piles left standing bare in the shallows after, with no household of that lake troubling, from that night forward, to build there again. This too reached Iseabail only as a tale carried by traders, and this too she kept apart in her own mind from anything of her brother's, though she noted, to herself and to no one else, that the island seemed in those years to be keeping a good many silences at once, each its own, none of them, so far as she could tell, speaking to the others.

VI

Of Her Own Ending

She lived to see her own grandchildren grown and her brother's hair, like her own, gone entirely white, the two of them old together on the same stretch of moor they had been children on, the covering stone still lifted each spring and laid each autumn by hands that were, by then, mostly her own chil-

1. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

dren's rather than hers or Eachann's. He died first, in the fourteen hundred and ninety-ninth year, in his own bed, of no more than the ordinary failing of a long life well spent, sixty-four years old and easy in his going, by every account his own household gave of it afterward; and Iseabail, sitting with him the last night, asked him once more, more for the old habit's sake than for any hope she still held of an answer, whether he meant to leave the moor with the question still hers alone to carry. He smiled at that, she told her own children after, in the way he had always smiled at the asking, and said only that some things were carried better than they were told, and that she had carried this one a long while now without it once breaking her, which was, he thought, answer enough to give her of what kind of thing it was, if not what the thing itself had been.

She never told her children, at the end, that she believed him, nor that she did not; only that she had stopped, some years before his dying, asking the question to be answered, and asked it after only to hear him turn it aside once more in the old familiar way, the way a woman keeps a worn path across a field long after the errand that first wore it has been forgotten. She died in the fifteen hundred and tenth year, eighty years old, in the same house her father had died in, with the covering stone lying undisturbed on the moor a little way off exactly as she had left it every autumn of her life, and was buried, at her own asking, within sight of it, so that whatever her own eyes had never been let see might, at the least, go on lying within her sight for as long as sight was any use to the buried.

The stone stands there yet, lifted every spring and laid every autumn by a household that keeps the custom now with no more reason given than that it was Iseabail's way before it was theirs, and no cord has gone over that lip from that day to this.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

OF BEITRIS AND THE GREY WINTER

GE 1,541 – 1,746

*At Muileann leathan the weavers still leave one thread of the warp
uncut at Bealltainn, and say only that it was Beitris's custom be-
fore it was theirs.*

I

Of the Lamps, the Traps and the Standing Frame

In the fifteen hundred and sixty-second year of the hill, a household of Caol leathan set a hollowed stone on its hearth-ledge with seal oil in the hollow and a wick of moss laid along the rim, and lit it, and found that it gave a small steady flame that made almost no smoke and needed no wood at all. No one on that shore had lit anything but a hearth before. The stone was passed from hand to hand at the next gathering of the households, turned over, sniffed, held up and admired the way a new thing is admired before anyone has decided whether to trust it, and within three winters every house on that stretch of coast kept one burning through the dark months by its bed-place, where a hearth's heat would have been wasted and its light had never reached. The old people said the light was too small to be worth the oil it drank. The young people, who slept nearer the door where the hearth's glow had never quite reached them, said nothing at all and kept their lamps lit.

Down the coast at Caol fhiadhaich, in much the same years, the households of the river-mouth drove a fence of woven wattle out into the ebb where the salmon

ran, angled so that a fish coming down on the falling tide was herded rather than caught, penned at last in water too shallow to turn in. The first fence took two households the better part of a season to stake and weave, and washed out twice before the third setting held; but the line of stake-holes it left in the mud, once cut, was used again every year after by whoever held that stretch of bank, so that a channel first fished by a man's grandmother was fished in the same channel, by the same worn holes, by his own grandchildren, and no one troubled to ask any more whether the holes could be moved to better water, for the fish, it seemed, had long since learned the fence was there and came down anyway.

It was at Muileann leathan, in the north, that the standing frame was first raised, some sixty years after Caol leathan lit its first lamp. Cloth on Dia-thìr had until then been twined by hand, a slow business worked in the lap or against a knee, a length grown a finger's width an evening if the light held and the worker's back did not give out first; the frame stood the warp upright instead, weighted at the foot with loops of fired clay so that the threads hung taut of their own weight rather than needing a hand to hold them so, and a worker could stand at it, pass the weft through with both hands free, and beat it home with a wooden sword faster than any lap-work had ever gone. The clay weights themselves, when a house burned or fell in, lay afterward in rows on the floor exactly as they had hung from the warp, and anyone digging into an old house-floor at Muileann leathan finds them still in their rows and know, without being told, that a loom had stood there and fallen straight down when the roof gave out above it.

There was, in those same years, a further thing begun that no teller has ever put a name or a face to. Someone, on some shore no reciter can point to first, began to cut a mark on a fixed rock at the line the highest tide reached, and to cut another beside it at the next high tide, and the next, until a row of marks ran up the rock face at intervals no fisherman's ordinary carefulness would have asked for; a fisherman need only know that the tide is coming or going, and does not, as a rule, care by how much more this month's flood beats last month's. Whoever began the cutting cared. The marks kept no other record than themselves, told no story a listener could follow, answered no question anyone thought to ask of them; and yet the habit spread, in the way a habit spreads on an island where everyone's business becomes everyone else's within a season, until more than one shore kept its own rock and its own count, and no household that kept one could have said, if asked, what it was counting toward.

These four things, the lamp, the fence, the frame and the mark on the rock, belong to no single teller and no single hearth; they are given here together because a chronicle that told each on its own night would tell four small things and miss the one large thing they say together, which is that in those years the hill-folk had begun, without any king's word and without any law, to make for themselves the ordinary furniture of a settled life: light apart from fire, food taken by cunning rather than by chasing, cloth grown fast enough to clothe a household without breaking the maker's back over it, and a way of setting a mark against the world's slow changes so that a change too slow for any one life to see could, all the same, be seen. None of the four made anyone rich. None of them was decreed. They simply were, one year, where they had not been the year before, the way the hill's whole way of living had come to be everywhere at once out of no single mouth's saying so.

II

Of the Weaver

Beitris was born at Muileann leathan in the sixteen hundred and seventieth year of the hill, into the third household to raise a standing frame on that stretch of the northern stream, and she grew up under the shadow of her mother's loom the way another child grows up under a father's boat or a father's nets, knowing the smell of wet wool and hot stone before she knew much else. Her mother worked a frame with two others of the household in a shed built onto the north side of the house, out of the wind, and Beitris was set to carding before she could properly hold the comb, and to the spindle before she was tall enough to reach the frame's upper bar without a stool under her. By her twelfth year she could spin a thread even enough that her mother stopped checking it against her own; by her twentieth she had her own frame, raised in the same shed against the wall her mother's stood against, and a name on that stretch of the stream for cloth that lay flatter and held its dye better than any other hand's.

She was a tall woman, black-haired, with hands that by her thirtieth year had gone hard and quick at the knuckle the way a weaver's hands go, and a face that people who did not know her called plain and people who did know her called honest, which came, most who had dealt with her agreed, to much the same thing said two ways. She was not, in her own household's telling, a woman who went

looking for anything beyond the shed and the stream and the yearly walk down to the salt gathering with the household's cloth loaded on two pack-beasts; she went because the household's cloth had to be carried somewhere to be traded, and she carried it herself rather than trust the carrying to a brother who could not tell a well-set warp from a badly one, and that was the whole of her reason, or so she told it afterward, more times than she can have believed it herself by the end of the telling.

Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹ in those years drew households from every part of the hill's growing country, and the king walked it, as he had walked it since the first summer it was agreed, buying nothing that anyone at Muileann leathan could remember him buying, looking at everything with the same unhurried attention a man gives ground he means to farm rather than ground he is only passing through. Beitris had seen him at a distance twice before, in the ordinary way anyone who came to the ford enough summers running saw him, a tall plain-dressed man the crowd gave way from without seeming to notice it had moved; she had never spoken near him, had never particularly wished to, and would have said, asked beforehand, that a weaver's business at the ford was with the salt-traders and not with kings.

It was her cloth that brought him to her stall the summer she turned nineteen, not her face nor her name, which he did not yet know. He stopped at the length she had laid out on the trestle, a bolt dyed the deep blue-black that only the northern lichen gave, and ran two fingers along the selvedge the way he ran a thumb along a flint edge, testing nothing a stallholder could see him testing, and said, after a silence long enough that the woman at the next stall had time to nudge her neighbour and nod toward him, that he had not seen cloth lie so flat off a frame in longer than she would believe if he told her the number of years.

"It is the weights," Beitris said, because it was the truest answer and the only one she had ready. "Clay, fired hard, and hung even. A frame that is not weighted even pulls the warp crooked, and a crooked warp makes crooked cloth no matter how straight the hand that works it."

He asked her, then, whether she had made the weights herself, and she said she had, her mother having taught her the firing of them along with everything else the shed held; and he asked whether the shed at Muileann leathan could be found again by a man who did not know the stream well, and she said, drily, that a shed

1. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

with three looms in it and the whole household's washing hung to dry beside it was not commonly mistaken for anything else on that stream, whoever was looking for it. It is the only exchange between them that any teller at Muileann leathan claims to have had whole from a witness who stood near enough to hear it, and the weavers of that stream have told it, ever since, near enough word for word, adding nothing and, they say, taking nothing away.

III

Of the Wedding and the Grey Winter

he came to Muileann leathan himself the following spring, with no more company than two men leading spare horses, and stood in the shed a full morning watching Beitris work a frame while her mother, who had by then guessed a good deal more than her daughter had told her, kept the rest of the household well away from the door on one excuse and another. What passed between them in that morning no teller has ever claimed to know; what is told is that he left before noon, and that Beitris did not touch the frame again that day, and that within the year she had gone south to Dùn iséal as his wife, in the sixteen hundred and ninetieth year of the hill, the household at Muileann leathan keeping her old frame standing in the shed against her return, which some of them, in the early years, still half expected.

She wove at Dùn iséal as she had woven at Muileann leathan, raising a frame of her own in a shed built to her asking on the south side of the king's house, and the hill's women, who had twined their cloth by hand or worked smaller frames copied badly from travellers' tellings, came to her in twos and threes to learn the standing weights properly set, so that within a handful of years the craft had spread from her own shed to a dozen others on the hill without her troubling to teach it as a teaching, only as a woman teaches a neighbour who stands and watches long enough. She did not hold herself above the hill's other wives for being the king's; she held herself, if anything, rather below them in her own reckoning, being a weaver's daughter among households that could trace their blood, some of them, back to the six pots under the oaks, and she never once, in any telling that survives her, put on airs a weaver's daughter had no true right to.

In the tenth year of her marriage, in a winter that began no differently than any winter she had known on the hill, the king's hair went grey.

It went in a single season, not thinning first the way an ordinary man's hair thins toward grey over years of small changes no one notices until they are done, but all at once, dark to grey between one moon and the next, as though a frost had come down on him the way frost comes down on bracken, browning it all at one stroke rather than leaf by leaf. He said nothing of it, and no one at Dùn ìseal that winter was fool enough to ask him plainly what had brought it on, though it was noticed, and talked of low at every hearth on the hill, that he did not sit as still that winter as his custom was, and was seen more than once standing alone at the bank in weather no sensible man stood out in for pleasure. The grey did not go on. It came that one winter, took him entirely, and stopped, so that from that season to the end of any telling that reaches so far, he wore the one grey and no more of it, neither balding nor whitening further as an ordinary man's grey goes on to do, a man who had aged, once, exactly as far as one winter would carry him and then stood still again.

Beitris never asked him the cause of it either, not that winter nor after, though she was near enough to him, by then, that a lesser woman might have thought the asking her right. She told her own mother once, years later, on one of the two visits she ever paid back to Muileann leathan, that she had lain awake more nights that winter than she had lain awake in the whole of her life before it, though not from any fear of him, for she had none; only from a plain unwillingness to close her eyes on a man whose face had changed in his sleep once already and might, for all she then knew, change again before morning. It did not change again. By spring the grey had settled into him the way a colour settles into dyed wool, and the hill, which had talked of little else through the dark months, found other matters to talk of by Bealltainn and let this one rest, as a hill will.

Murchadh was born five years after, her only child by him and, as it happened, the only child either of them would raise together to see him grown, a black-haired boy from his first hour with his mother's hands already showing in the shape of his own small ones, quick fingers that closed round whatever was put into them and would not easily be made to let go. He was given his father's warmth from his first winter, though no one on the hill ever said so plainly in his hearing; the women who nursed him alongside their own children remarked only, low, that he ran hot for an infant and slept sound through cold that had other babies crying half the night, and left it at that, the way the hill had learned to leave a good many things at that.

IV

Of the Rock at Ros dhomhain

In the eighteenth year of her marriage, with Murchadh not yet three and already walking further than his mother thought wise, the king took Beitris west with him, the two of them and the boy and a small household of the king's own choosing, to a harbour on a wide sea-loch called Ros dhomhain, where a fisher's household had lately begun to cut a mark against the tide on a boulder in the harbour mouth, in the same manner as the first mark cut, years before, on some rock further south whose keeper no one at Ros dhomhain had ever met. Word of the first rock's marks had travelled up the coast the way such word travelled, by trader and by kinsman visiting kinsman, and a young keeper at Ros dhomhain, hearing of it, had gone down to his own harbour mouth and begun a rock of his own, cutting the marks at what he judged, by ear and by memory of the telling, to be the same spacing as the first, though he had never seen the first rock with his own eyes and could not have said, pressed on it, how he knew the spacing to copy rather than invent his own.

The king stood before that second rock the better part of an afternoon, in much the same stillness Beitris remembered from the ford, running a finger down the row of cuts without pressing hard enough to mark the stone further, and said, when at last he turned from it, that whoever had carried the habit up this coast had carried a thing worth more than the fish it never counted. Beitris, standing by with Murchadh's small hand in hers, asked him plainly what he thought the marks were for, since no keeper of either rock had ever given her a straight answer to the question.

"For whoever comes after and wants to know how far the water has climbed," he said, "though I do not think the man who cut the first mark knew that was his reason, any more than the man who cut this one knows it now. A thing can be worth doing before anyone has worked out why."

It was, Beitris told her mother on the second of her two visits home, the longest single answer she ever had from him on any matter that was not a household's grazing or a stranger's quarrel, and she carried it the rest of her life the way another woman might have carried a gift he had given her outright. She watched the keeper's daughter, a girl not yet ten, standing at her father's elbow that same afternoon with the same unhurried attention the king himself gave the rock, and thought, though she said this to no one for years, that the habit of watching

closely was its own kind of inheritance, passed from a father's hand to a child's eye with no more ceremony than the standing frame had passed from her own mother's shed to her own.

They stayed at Ros dhomhain the better part of a month, longer than the king's business at any one harbour commonly ran, and Beitris wove nothing the whole time she was there, content, for once, to sit on the harbour wall with Murchadh and watch the boats come in on the tide the rock had been cut to measure, the first true idleness, she said afterward, she had allowed herself since she was old enough to hold a comb. It did not last. Within the year she had a frame standing again, this time in a shed at Dùn ìseal built larger than the first to hold two more of the hill's women who had come, by then, to learn from her rather than merely to borrow her pattern of weights; and the harbour at Ros dhomhain kept its rock and its keeper's line long after the king and his household had ridden east again, the marks creeping upward summer on summer at a pace too slow for any one watcher to swear to, though every watcher who kept the count across two generations or more could point to the difference and say, plainly enough, that the water stood higher on the stone than it had at the first cutting.

V

Of the Names She Was Given

Beitris aged as her own mother had aged, and her mother's mother before that, in the ordinary way of a woman born after the grove but not born of the king's own blood: slowly at first, so slowly that Murchadh, growing through his own first thirty years faster in every visible way than his mother grew old in any of them, did not remark it; and then, past her fiftieth year, more plainly, her black hair going the iron-grey of an ordinary long life rather than the single frost-stroke that had taken her husband's, her hands stiffening at the knuckle past what even a weaver's hard use could account for, her back bending a little at the frame where it had once stood straight through a full day's work without complaint. She kept the loom to the end, working shorter lengths in her last years and letting the younger women she had taught finish what her own hands could no longer hold taut, and she never once, in any telling the hill kept of her, spoke of the difference between her own slow going and her husband's

stopped years as anything but the plain order of things, no more worth resenting than the tide is worth resenting for going out.

It was in her seventieth year, with Murchadh a grown man of thirty-five already spoken of on the hill for the north he meant one day to hold, that she asked him, on an ordinary evening with nothing in it to have prompted the question beyond her own long turning of it, whether he would forget her once she was gone the way a man forgets an old winter's cold once summer has come round again properly.

He did not answer at once, which was, by then, no more than his ordinary way with any question that mattered to him; and when he did answer, he gave her a name rather than any plain word either way. He said it quietly, the way a man says a name he has said to himself many times and rarely aloud, and then he said another, and then a third, and Beitris, listening, understood before the fourth name that he was giving her every wife he had had before her, in the order he had had them, going back further than any list the hill itself had ever troubled to keep whole.

She tried, at first, to hold the count on her fingers, the way she had counted threads on a warp her whole life without thinking about the counting; she lost it somewhere past the second hand, the names coming steadier and more quietly than she could keep pace with, some she half knew already from the hill's own old tellings, Muireall and Sorcha among the first of them, and others she had never once heard spoken in all her years on the hill, names that belonged, she understood as he went on, to wives the hill itself no longer kept any memory of at all, buried and mourned and forgotten by every mouth but his own. He did not hurry through them, and he did not slow for effect either; he said each one the way a man reads a tally he has read to himself so many times that the reading has stopped being an effort and become instead a kind of breathing. When he had done, he said nothing further, no word of what the naming meant or did not mean, and Beitris, who had asked the question hoping for comfort and had been given instead something closer to the truth than comfort commonly is, found that she no longer wanted an answer to the question she had actually asked. She had her answer. It was that he would not forget her, because he had not forgotten any of them, and that this was, for a man built as he was built, neither a kindness nor a cruelty but simply the shape of the thing, the way a warp holds every thread it was ever strung with whether the weaver remembers stringing each one or not.

She died four years after, in a mild autumn with the harvest well in and nothing wrong with her that any teller ever named beyond the plain wearing-out of a life lived its full ordinary length, in her seventy-fourth year and Murchadh's thirty-ninth, a black-haired man who looked, to any stranger who did not know his true years, no older than fifteen summers past his boyhood, standing at her graveside with a stillness that the hill, watching him, took at first for a young man's want of understanding and only slowly came to read as something nearer his father's own. The king buried her with his own hands, as he had buried Muireall and Sorcha before her and would bury few enough others after, and sat by the turned earth a night and a day, and spoke, in all that time, only once, low enough that only Murchadh, kneeling near, ever claimed to have heard it: that a warp holds what it is strung with, and that he had never yet had to learn a cloth again from the beginning. He said nothing further of her after that day to any ear the hill's tellings reach, any more than he had spoken again, in all the years since, the names of the wives who came before her.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Of the Flint Road

GE 1,747 – 1,892

At Cnoc àrsaidh the flint-pit keepers still let the first flake of a new working go free to whoever asks for it, and say only that it was a promise once made to a king's son.

I

Of the Road He Chose

For sixteen years after his mother was put into the ground at Dùn ìseal, Murchadh sat in the hall his father kept and watched the hearth-smoke go up through the same hole in the same roof it had gone up through every evening of his life, until, in his fifty-fifth year by his own true count, he found he could sit there no longer. No stranger meeting him on the road would have set him past a young man grown, and the hill had begun, in the way a hill will, to speak of him a little uneasily behind his back, careful of him the way people are careful of a thing they do not yet know how to hold. Beitris's only living son, and the only child either of his parents had raised to see grown, he was; and a hill that had buried one wife of the king after another without much trouble found it did not, after all, know quite what to do with a prince who showed no sign of being buried himself.

So he told his father he meant to go north with the flint-carriers, giving no better reason than that he wished to see the pit the grey flakes came out of, which was true as far as it went and left out the larger part of the truth, that he wished, for a season or two, to be a man doing a man's ordinary work among men who did not watch him for signs. His father heard him out standing at the door of the

hall with the low warmth he carried with him into every room he stood in, and said only that a road was a road and Murchadh was free of it as any man was, and that he should mind, going north, that the households up there judged a stranger only by the work in his hands, whatever blood ran under it, which was, Murchadh understood even then, as near to a blessing as his father commonly gave.

He went out that summer with a train of carriers bound for Cnoc àrsaidh in the north-west, the only hill on Dia-thìr that gave good flint, a grey stone that flaked clean and held an edge no other stone on the island matched, and had been scraped at, by the time Murchadh first saw it, in shallow workings older than any single household's memory could account for; the deep pit was opened only in his twenty-first summer in the north, and he carried some of its first loads south himself. It was a wound in the hillside as much as a working, a hollow of raw earth and broken stone with years of chippings banked round its lip like the tide-wrack round a shore, and the men who worked it, stripped to the waist in all weathers, greeted the carriers with the particular rough courtesy of men who know their stone is wanted and mean to be paid fairly for the wanting. Murchadh took up a carrier's yoke among them without a word of who he was, and no one at Cnoc àrsaidh troubled to ask; a strong-backed stranger who worked a full day without complaint was welcome on that hill whoever had got him, and it was three seasons before the first man there learned, from a trader passing through, whose son he had been carrying flint beside.

On his way north that first summer he came down through Ros dhomhain, where his mother had once stood on the harbour wall with him small at her side and watched the boats come in on a tide the rock in the harbour mouth had been cut to measure. The rock stood where it had always stood, and the keeper's line of cuts had crept a hand's width further up the stone since he had last had it pointed out to him as a child, so slowly that no single year's mark could be told from the year before or the year after, and only the whole row together said plainly that the water climbed. He stood before it the better part of an hour, in a stillness the keeper's grandson, watching him from the harbour steps, took at the time for no more than a traveller resting his legs, and said nothing of what he thought there to any man on that coast.

The keeper himself, an old man by then and glad of company, came down at last to stand beside him and named the marks off one by one without being asked, this one cut in a hard winter, this one the year the salmon failed, this one the year

his own father died and he had cut it crooked for grief and never straightened it. Murchadh asked him whether he minded that the sea seemed, by his own rock's telling, to be climbing toward his door a little further with every generation that kept the count.

"I'll not live to see it reach the door," the keeper said, "and my grandson's grandson can mind it then, if minding does any good by that time. A man keeps the rock he's given to keep. What the rock says is its own business." He looked at Murchadh a while longer than the words needed, as a man looks at a stranger he half-recognises and cannot place, and said no more, and Murchadh, who had not given his name at the harbour and did not give it then, thanked him and went on north before the light failed.

He walked the last stretch to Cnoc àrsaidh alone, by a hill road he had never travelled before, sleeping the two nights under nothing but his own cloak and a dry bank, and came down into the flint country on the third morning with his boots worn through at one heel and no coin on him beyond what a carrier travelled with, which he judged, rightly, to be the surest way of arriving anywhere on the island unremarked.

II

Of the Flint Road and Ailig Spor

The road the carriers wore between Cnoc àrsaidh and Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹ ran the length of the island's northern quarter and back, a season's walking each way with a laden yoke, and it was on that road, over years rather than seasons, that Murchadh, thirty years into his carrying, came to know Ailig Spor, born at a household by a shallow river-crossing in Rathad na Spor²'s northern flats and grown to a carrier himself before he was twenty. Ailig was a short thick-armed man with a laugh that carried further than his voice had any right to and a memory for a joke told once ten years before that he would produce again, word for word, at the one moment it would do the most damage to whoever it was aimed at; he took to Murchadh from the first season they walked together, not knowing or, once he did know, much caring who Murchadh's father

1. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

2. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

was, and told him so plainly the first time another carrier tried to make something of it.

"A yoke doesn't care whose back it's on," Ailig said, "and neither do I. You carry your share or you don't, and so far you carry it."

It was, Murchadh told his father years later, the truest thing anyone outside the hall had ever said to him, and he kept Ailig's friendship the whole of the years the road gave them, walking the same stretches season after season until the track between Cnoc àrsaigh and that crossing, worn already by generations before either of them was born, sank a full yard below the level of the ground on either side of it, so that a man walking it in a low sun cast no shadow beyond its banks, and a stranger cresting the rise above it for the first time was, more than one carrier swore, apt to mistake the whole line of it for a dry ditch dug on purpose rather than a road worn by nothing but feet and yokes and the years. Murchadh and Ailig walked that sunken stretch together more times than either ever troubled to count, Ailig always a half-step ahead on the narrow going and always, without being asked, dropping back to walk level with Murchadh again once the road widened, a small courtesy neither of them ever spoke of and neither ever failed to keep.

It was on that same stretch, in a winter neither of them ever forgot, that a late storm came down off the sea with no more warning than an hour's dropping wind and caught their gang two days from any household with shelter enough for a full yoke-line. The snow came sidelong and did not let up through a whole night and the better part of the following day, and it was Ailig, not the eldest carrier of the gang nor the one who had walked the road longest, who thought to have every man dig into the sunken road's own bank rather than try the open ground above it, packing the yokes across the top of the cut for a roof and the men beneath them for warmth, so that the gang came through the storm with nothing worse than cold fingers and one man's frost-nipped ear, where an older carrier swore afterward they would have lost two or three had they tried to walk on through it. Murchadh dug beside him the whole of that night without once being told to, and it was there, packed shoulder to shoulder under the borrowed yokes with the snow hissing along the bank above their heads, that Ailig first asked him, not who his father was, for by then half the gang half-knew that already and said nothing of it out of the same rough courtesy that had first welcomed him, but only whether he meant to walk the road all his days or whether some other life was waiting on him somewhere further south.

"I don't know that any life is waiting on me anywhere," Murchadh said, "further south or otherwise."

"Then you're luckier than most of us," Ailig said, "and needn't tell me why, if you'd rather not," and turned over and slept, or seemed to, and Murchadh lay a long while after listening to the wind and thought that of all the answers he might have been pressed for on that road, that was the gentlest any man had ever let him off with.

It was on that same circuit, some years after, that an old keeper of the Cnoc àr-saidh pit-mouth, a man both of them had known the whole of their carrying lives, died in his own bed in the ordinary way of an old man whose work is done, and the two of them walked out from his burying together saying little, until Ailig, turning a half-charred stick in the embers of that night's fire rather than looking at Murchadh as he said it, spoke first.

"I've buried my own father," Ailig said, "and I'll own the ground took no more care over him than it took over that old keeper today, for all the years he gave the pit. A household forgets a man within three generations and calls the forgetting respect."

"Your father had a household to stand over him at the end," Murchadh said, "which is more than some are given."

"It is," Ailig said, "and I'll not say it isn't worth the having. I only say a man ought not to look for more from the ground than the ground has ever given anyone." He threw the stick into the fire whole and said nothing further, and Murchadh, who thought of his own mother's grave more often on that road than he ever told Ailig, found there was more truth in the saying than either of them was minded to sit with that night, and let the fire burn down without adding to it.

III

Of the Years Between

The years went as years go on a road walked often enough that the road becomes its own kind of calendar, marked less by seasons than by which stretch had washed out that winter and needed re-cutting, which household along it had a new roof up since the carriers last passed, which old man at which hearth had died and which son now sat in his place at the door when the

yoke-gang came through. Ailig married a woman of a household by that same crossing in his thirtieth year and brought two sons and a daughter up on flint-carrying wages, all three of them walking the near stretches of the road themselves before they were grown, and Murchadh stood godfather, in the plain way the hill kept such things, to the eldest of the three, a boy who grew, in his turn, to carry a yoke as unremarkably as his father had.

It did not escape the households along that road, in time, that Murchadh walked it decade upon decade with no more sign of the years on him than a carrier three seasons in shows on his first walking, and there were carriers, as the decades wore on, who would not share a fire with him for reasons they gave badly and mostly did not give at all; but Ailig never once, in all the years the road gave them, asked Murchadh the plain question every other man on that circuit sooner or later wanted to ask, and Murchadh, for his part, never once offered him an answer unasked, which both of them, without ever saying so to each other, understood to be the whole of the arrangement between them and the better part of why it held.

"You'll bury me on this road one day," Ailig said to him once, an ordinary evening with nothing in it to have prompted the saying, the two of them sitting out the last of a fire on the sunken stretch below Cnoc àrsaidh. "And you'll walk on with the next lot the season after, same as you walked with me."

"I'll bury you wherever your own people want you buried," Murchadh said, "and I'll walk the road a good while less easily after, whatever lot I walk it with."

Ailig laughed at that, the big carrying laugh that had first drawn Murchadh to him on a road neither of them had walked together yet, and said no more of it that night, and it was the only time in all their years that either of them came so near the question and let it lie unasked.

Murchadh's godson, the eldest of Ailig's three, grew from a boy who ran errands between the carriers' fires to a man walking a yoke of his own, married in his turn, and buried his own father's father, a keeper of that crossing whom Murchadh had known as a young man on his first summer north; and it was watching that ordinary chain of burying and marrying and being born again go round three and four times over on the one road that taught Murchadh, more plainly than any word his father had ever given him, what it was his father's own long life must look like from the far side of it, a single unmoving figure watching a whole hillside of households rise and fall around him like grass under a wind he himself never felt. He had not thought, going out with the carriers at fifty-five,

that he was choosing his father's road as much as escaping his father's hall; by the time the thought came to him plainly, on a spring morning watching his godson's own son toddle after the yoke-gang with a play-yoke of bound sticks across his small shoulders, it had already been true a long while.

I V

Of Ailig Spor's Death

Ailig aged as an ordinary man of the hill ages, slowly through his middle years and then, past his sixtieth, faster than either of them liked to remark on, his back bending under a yoke it had carried without complaint for forty years, his laugh coming a little shorter of breath each season though it lost none of its carrying power to the end. He gave up the road in his sixty-fourth year, handing his yoke to his youngest son and taking instead the lighter work of a keeper at the Cnoc àrsaidh pit-mouth, tallying what came out of the ground rather than carrying it away, and Murchadh, who could by then have claimed a dozen honest reasons to walk the far circuits instead, found himself somehow always coming back through Cnoc àrsaidh at the turn of a season, to sit an evening at the pit-mouth with a man grown grey and slow where he himself had not changed at all.

He was sixty-eight, and had been four years a keeper and not a carrier, when he did not wake one autumn morning, found by his own daughter with no mark of pain on his face and nothing in his last evening's talk, by her account, to say he had known it for his last. Murchadh was two days' walk south at the time, on the near stretch of the road with a fresh gang of young carriers who scarcely knew his name, and did not hear of it until a rider caught him up on the third day; he turned back at once, walking the two days north in one, and stood at the graveside among Ailig's grown children and grandchildren with a face the household, watching him, read for the first time as something nearer his own father's stillness at a grave than any young man's want of understanding, though none of them, then or after, ever said so to him plainly.

He stayed at Cnoc àrsaidh the better part of a month after the burying, walking the pit-mouth alone in the evenings where Ailig had sat tallying, and told the keeper who took Ailig's place that the pit should go on giving its first flake of any new working free to whoever asked for it, as it always had, and that he would see

to it himself, from whatever he had, that the custom did not lapse for want of a man to keep it; which the pit-keepers of Cnoc àrsaidh have done, by their own telling, from that year to this, though most of them, asked why, can no longer say more than that it was a promise a carrier once made and that no one since has troubled to unmake it.

V

Of the Bird Carved at Àth mhòr and the Wolves of Tobar fhiadhaich

he walked on alone after that, taking whatever gang would have him and giving no household of the north cause to remark on him beyond his usual steady carrying, and the years he walked without Ailig beside him seemed to him, though he never said as much to any living soul, longer than all the years he had walked with him put together. The road threw off paths of its own into every household that wanted flint, and it was on the longer of these circuits, far east of the pit, that he came, in his hundred and forty-eighth year, to Àth mhòr, where a young man of that household was cutting a hawk into the lintel over his father's door, wings closed and the head turned back over the shoulder as though it had heard something behind it and had not yet decided whether to fly. The carver worked at it through three evenings after the day's work was done, by firelight and by the little seal-oil lamps that had by then reached even that far corner of the north, and would say, when Murchadh asked him plainly why a hawk and not some other bird, only that the shape had come to him whole one night and would not leave him alone until he had cut it. It was, so far as any carrier ever heard tell afterward, the first bird cut into wood or stone on the whole of Dia-thìr, and Murchadh, standing in the doorway's shadow with a full yoke still on his shoulders, thought it a strange, small, patient thing to have watched come into the world, and wished, walking on, that Ailig had lived to see it, for it was the kind of small thing his friend had always had more patience for than most men gave him credit for.

At Tobar fhiadhaich, many years on, in his hundred and eighty-fifth year, he came upon a household burying a wolf. It lay on its side in a grave dug to a man's depth, its legs drawn up under it as a sleeping wolf draws them, and the house-

hold stood about the grave in the ordinary hush of a burying, an old woman among them saying over it words Murchadh did not know. He asked her, once the earth was turned in, why a wolf and no other beast was laid so, and she looked at him a long while before she answered, the way a person looks at a stranger deciding how much of the truth is worth the giving.

"The wolf keeps its own dead," she said. "We have found them at it, on the high ground, more times than I could tell you and told no other soul but the household. A creature that will not leave its own to the crows has earned better than the ditch from us, whatever a stranger thinks a wolf is owed."

Murchadh said nothing for the whole walk back down to the road, thinking of an old carrier put into ground that had taken no more care over him than it took over any other man, and of a friend of his own put into ground with more grief over him than either of them had ever let on to expect, and could not, that evening, have said with any certainty which of the two ways of being buried he thought the better bargain.

VI

Of the Asking and the Refusal

he came south to Dùn ìseal the following spring, in his hundred and eighty-seventh year and looking, to any stranger's eye, no more than a well-set man in his middle life, and asked his father, plainly and without the long working-up to it that another man might have thought the asking deserved, for the north to hold as his own: the whole stretch of country Rathad na Spor¹ ran through and beyond it, from Cnoc àrsaidh to Àth mhòr and Tobar fhiadhaich and the households between, which he had walked, by then, more times than any man living and knew, he said, better than any man living knew it.

His father heard him out in the same low warmth with which he heard every asking, standing at the same door of the same hall he had stood in the day Murchadh first told him he meant to go north with the carriers, and was a long while answering, long enough that Murchadh let himself believe the answer he wanted was coming.

"The north is Dòmhnall's to hold," his father said, "and has been these sixteen hundred years and more, by my giving and his own good keeping of it. I will not

take a share from a man who has kept it well to give it to a son who has only walked it, however far he has walked."

"I have walked it further than Dòmhnall has ridden it," Murchadh said, and heard, saying it, how much of his mother's plain temper and how much of some other temper entirely had gone into the saying.

"That may be true," his father said, "and it changes nothing I have said. A share given is a share I do not take back for a better claim that comes after it, or no man on this hill would ever again trust a giving of mine to hold. Ask me for the north when Dòmhnall no longer holds it, and I will hear you as I heard him."

He gave no other reason, and Murchadh, who had walked half the length of the island more times than he could number without once being told by any keeper or carrier or grieving daughter that his asking was unwelcome, found in his father's plain refusal the first thing on the whole of that long road that had ever been flatly refused him. He stood a while longer at the door before he answered, and told it afterward as the hardest work he ever did to hold his voice as level as his father's own.

"Then I have walked it for nothing," he said.

"You have walked it for itself," his father said, "which is the only reason walking a road has ever been worth a man's while, and the only reason I ever gave you leave to go. If you went out looking for a hill at the end of it, that was your own asking of the road, and not mine, and not the road's."

Murchadh had no answer ready for that, and gave none, and his father did not press him for one, only stood a moment longer in the doorway with the same low warmth he had stood there with the day his son first went out, before turning back into the hall to whatever business the hall still held for a man who did not age. Murchadh said nothing further that evening, and rode out again within the week without asking a second time, north by the road he knew better than any road on the island, past the sunken stretch below Cnoc àrsaidh where a keeper's grandson still gave away, at Murchadh's own standing order, the first grey flake of every new working to whoever came asking for it; and it is told, by those few at Dùn ìseal who claimed afterward to have marked it, that he rode out that year with a face his father's household had not seen on him before, neither the young man's face he had worn going north the first time nor the stillness he had worn at Ailig Spor's grave, but something nearer pride than either, and, close under the

1. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

pride, the first grievance the hill ever had cause to lay at a son of Ailean's own naming.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

OF the HUNGRY YEARS

GE 1,893 – 2,020

*At Dùn ìseal the grain-keepers still cut their tally by the count
Sileas Bhàn left them, and say so, though none now living remem-
bers why the count runs the way it does.*

I

Of the Store within the Bank

Sileas Bhàn had held the hill the better part of four hundred years before the grazing failed her, and in all that time the list that kept her name had asked nothing more of her than that she go on holding it. She was of the king's blood, the eighth name in the list of those who had held Dùn ìseal, counting the king who took it first, and she had come to the hill already old enough in her own reckoning that the households below it had stopped remarking on her face and begun instead to measure their own lives by the fact that hers did not change; a woman married under her rule and buried under it still, and Sileas no greyer for the burying.

She was a plain holder, by every account the hill has kept of her: quarrels judged the way her father's father's fathers had judged them before her, a turn taken at Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹ each summer, no law made and none broken. If any household asked what Sileas Bhàn had done with her four hundred years, the honest answer, and the only one anyone at Dùn ìseal troubled to give, was that she had done what was asked and nothing more.

The store within the bank was not her own thing. It had stood since Dòmhnall's day, cut into the earthwork itself on the sheltered side, three pits lined with withies and clay against the damp, and it had been filled in good years and drawn down in poor ones for longer than any single holder's memory could account for by itself; but no one before Sileas had ever emptied all three pits to the withies in a single winter, and no one, in the telling that came after, ever forgot that she was the one who did.

The winters before it had been ordinary winters, the summers ordinary summers, and no household on that ground, going into the spring of her three hundred and ninety-third year, had any reason to look at the sky over the high pastures with more than a farmer's usual wariness. The failure began in that spring, a spring so wet the high pastures would not dry enough to carry the flocks before Bealltainn, the rain coming in off the west for the better part of two months with hardly three dry days running between one soaking and the next, and by midsummer the grass that should have stood to a man's knee lay flattened and yellow, rotted at the root from standing water no one had seen the like of. Sileas rode the near valleys herself that year, as she had never troubled to before, and found households already killing beasts they would ordinarily have kept through the winter, for want of anything to feed them; and she gave the order, without asking leave of anyone, that the store within the bank should be opened to every household of the hill's own ground by the count of mouths at its hearth, whatever the size of its herd.

Grain had come out of those pits before, in earlier lean years. This was the first time it had come out by that measure, and the households said so at the time, some of them with more thanks than others; a household with sixty beasts and four children found itself given no more than a household with four beasts and four children, and the man who had the sixty beasts rode up to the hill to say so to her face.

"You have taken from me and given it to a man who kept nothing," he said, standing in the yard with his hat still on, which was itself a kind of insult and both of them knew it.

"I have taken nothing from you," Sileas said. "The grain in that pit was put there against a year like this one, by every household on this ground together,

1. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

yours no less than his. It belongs to the year that made it needful, and to every hearth the year touches."

He kept his hat on to the end of it and did not ride up again, and by the second winter of the grazing's failure the households had begun, without any further order from her, to bring their own surplus to the pits before she asked for it, the way water finds the lowest ground without being told to.

The opening of the pits itself she never forgot, though nothing about it was remarkable to anyone who watched. Two men of the hill's own household went down into each pit in turn with baskets, working by the light let in through the mouth of it, and came up smelling of wet withy and old clay, a smell that clung to a man's clothes for a day afterward and that every household on that ground learned, that year, to know from a distance before the cart carrying the grain was near enough to see. Sileas stood at the mouth of the first pit herself while it was opened, though there was no custom that asked it of her, and watched the level of grain in the baskets against what she remembered of the year it went in, saying nothing to the men below her, only counting.

By the second year the hunger had eased enough that a household or two began, on their own accord and without her leave, to bring back into the pits a little more than the pits had given them the winter before, a kind of paying-forward that no one had asked for and that Sileas let stand without remark, for she judged, rightly as it turned out, that a custom left alone to grow its own root held firmer than one she might have ordered into being.

II

Of Baile chrom

The grazing came back within three years, as such failures generally did on that ground, but the hunger it started did not stop at Dùn ìseal's own valleys, and the worst of it, when it came, came far off, on the north-western coast, at a scattering of hearths the hill-folk called Baile chrom for the crooked shore it sat on.

Word of it reached Sileas the way word of most far things reached the hill in those years, slowly and by more than one mouth, each mouth a little more certain of what it had heard than the one before it: that the fish had failed there two seasons running, that the household stores had gone to bark and boiled seaweed be-

fore the second winter was out, that the dead were being laid in doubled rows because the ground could not be dug fast enough to keep pace with them, and that nothing so bad had ever, in any telling the coast itself kept, been tied to one place before.

The king rode north-west himself with the first grain that could be spared, in the last month of that same year, taking a road that had never carried him before and that the pack-horses found harder going than any road nearer the hill; he was gone the better part of a season, and no teller who rode with him ever said afterward what he found at Baile chrom when he came to it, only that he came back grey about the mouth in a way that had nothing to do with his hair, which had not changed, and that he gave no order when he returned beyond telling every hill of the kingdom to look to its own stores before the next storm season, and not to wait for hunger to ask first.

Sileas did not go with him. She held the hill in his absence, as she had held it through every absence of every king before this one that the list remembered, and she sent after him what her own stores could spare, three cartloads of grain and a herd of goats too small to be missed from the near valleys, with instruction that they were to go wherever along that coast was worst served and not to Baile chrom alone, for she had heard, by then, that the crooked shore was not the only hearth burning low. The cartloads reached the coast a full month behind the king's own grain, and by every count that ever came back to the hill, they were not wasted.

The man who drove the foremost cart was still telling of it at Dùn ìseal's own hearths years afterward, an old carter by then and glad of an audience, and Sileas herself sat through the telling more than once without saying she had heard it before. He told of hearths with no smoke over them that a passing man took at first for empty houses, until a dog came out from under one to bark at his horses, thinner than any dog he had ever driven cattle past; of a woman standing at her own door who would not take the grain into her hands until he had counted it out to her in front of her neighbours, for fear, she said, that a neighbour might call a full measure given behind a closed door a lie about by evening; of the grave-rows themselves, which he had seen from the road and would say no more about than that they ran two deep where at any other season they would have run one, and that he had made the sign against ill luck three times passing them and been glad of the horses' pace picking up of their own accord once the graves were behind. It was the doubled grave-rows of Baile chrom, more than anything the king himself

said of that ride, that the hill-folk kept afterward as the measure of how bad a hunger could be tied to one place; and it is told that from that year forward, no household within a day's ride of Dùn ìseal let its own store run below a season's worth of grain again, whatever the grazing did, for fear of being asked one day what had become of it.

III

Of Achadh shean

The eastern springs failed differently, and slower, and it took longer for anyone at Dùn ìseal to believe what the households of Achadh shean were telling them.

The first word came the year the wells there ran a hand lower than any digger's memory reached, which nobody thought worth a rider's time; the second came the year after, when the wells ran lower still and a shepherd's boy walked the whole way to the hill on his own two feet to say the upper field banks had cracked from the dryness, banks his own grandfather had raised and that had never once, in three generations of telling, cracked from anything but frost. The boy had walked the better part of three days to bring the word himself rather than send it by a rider who might, he said, get the shape of the cracking wrong in the telling, and he stood in the yard at Dùn ìseal with his feet raw through worn shoes and would not sit down to eat until he had said his piece through to the end. Sileas had him fed and his feet looked to before she asked him anything further, and sent him home again on a borrowed pony rather than his own two feet, which the boy's household spoke of for longer, in the years after, than they spoke of the drought itself.

Sileas sent no grain east that year, for there was, as yet, no hunger to send it against, only dry ground and a boy's report; but she sent a rider to look, and the rider came back saying the springs of Achadh shean had not merely run low, they had stopped, the whole visible flow of them, at a season when they had never in living telling stopped before.

By the third dry year the field banks east of the springs stood forsaken, the barley in them dead in the row and never cut, and the households that had worked that ground for longer than the list could reckon by name walked off it and cut new fields on another line, lower on the slope, where a smaller spring still ran thin

but steady. They took nothing from the old banks with them but their own tools and the stones of their own hearths, and left the dead barley standing where a passing rider could see it for years after, going grey and then black with the weather, a field of dead grain kept upright by nothing but its own roots long after the households that had planted it were gone.

The moving itself took the best part of a month, one household at a time rather than all together, for no household would leave its own hearthstone cold a day longer than it had to before the new one was laid and lit; a woman of that ground, carrying her own infant on one hip and a bundle of tools on the other, was heard by more than one neighbour to say, passing the old banks for the last time, that the ground had given her mother's mother a living and given her nothing, and that she owed it no more grief over the leaving than a hall owed a guest who had stopped setting a place at the table. The saying went round the new fields for a season or two and then, as such sayings did, stopped being anyone's in particular and became simply a thing that was said of Achadh shean, by people who could no longer have told a stranger who had first said it.

Sileas rode out to see it herself once, in the last year of the drought, and stood a while at the edge of the forsaken banks with the rider who had brought her the first word of it two years before, and neither of them said much. The rider asked her, at last, whether she meant to have the banks pulled down, since no one would work that ground again while the springs stayed dead.

"No," she said. "Let them stand. A bank tells a household what the ground once gave, and what it stopped giving. That is worth more standing than pulled down."

The banks stood. They are standing yet, by every account that has come down of that coast, grown over now with gorse and bramble in lines a stranger would take for nothing more than the shape of an old hedge, though the households of Achadh shean, cutting their new fields lower on the slope, have never once forgotten what the old lines mark.

IV

Of the Deed and the List

It was in her five hundred and sixth year, with the drought at Achadh shean not yet a season closed and the grave-rows of Baile chrom forty winters be-

hind her, that Sileas Bhàn asked the king, at Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹ of that summer, for a thing no holder of the hill before her had ever troubled to ask for.

The ford that summer ran low and clear over its stones, the way it always ran in a dry year, and the households had pitched their fires further back from the water than usual for want of the shade the willows gave closer in; salt and wool and dried fish changed hands as they always did, and a marriage or two was agreed on the trodden ground, and nothing about the day marked it out from any other gathering Sileas had sat in her four hundred years, until the crowd thinned toward evening and the cook-fires began to smoke low and steady into a sky gone the colour of a hearth's own embers. She had watched the king greet the households at the river as he greeted them every summer, no different to look at than he had been the first year she herself came down to the ford as a girl of thirty, and when the crowd had thinned she asked leave to walk with him a way along the bank, which he gave her without asking why.

"Dòmhnall set the boundary stones," she said, when they were far enough from the fires that no one else could hear the shape of it. "Fearchar rode with the valleys and was lamed for it. Uisdean burned a palisade twice and built it a third time. Mòrag raided Tràigh an t-Salainn² and kept the names of her dead. Iain Dubh died on the shingle for it. Raghnaill waded the ford and made peace with An Cnoc Ruadh³ that has held ever since. Every one of them has a deed the list keeps by. I have held the hill through a bad spring, a coast's worth of hunger I could only watch from too far off to mend, and a drought I answered with a rider sent to look at dry ground. When the list comes to my name, what will it say I did?"

The king walked on a few paces before he answered her, his eyes on the water rather than on her face, in the way she had noticed, over four hundred years, that he looked at most things he meant to answer plainly.

"It will say you held," he said. "That is not nothing, Sileas. Clachan Dhòmhnail⁴ only moved the quarrels they were meant to end. Uisdean's palisade burned twice before it held once. Mòrag's raid cost seven lives to answer a want that a fair season would have answered for nothing. Every deed the list keeps was also a thing that might have gone the other way, and some of them did, before they went the

1. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

2. the salt shore

3. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

4. the boundary stones of Dòmhnall Clachach

way the list remembers. You gave grain by the mouth and not by the herd, and a man in a temper rode up to tell you so to your face, and the households have kept your measure since without being told to. Carts went a coast's width from your own ground to a hunger that was never yours to answer, and you did not wait to be thanked for sending them. A dead field stands at Achadh shean because you let it, so that a household two hundred years from now will know what its own ground once gave. That is the deed, Sileas. Clachan Dhòmhnaill and Mòrag's raid were each one thing done once; yours was four hundred years of not failing, in a country where failing was always the easier road."

"That is a hard thing to put in a list," she said.

"Most true things are," he said. "The list is not troubled by that. It will put it in four words, the same four it has kept for every holder who did not fail: she held the hill. I have never asked the list for more than that of anyone, and I will not begin with you."

She said nothing further to him about it that evening, and the reciters, when the telling of that summer's gathering came down to Dùn ìseal, kept nothing of the walk along the bank at all; but it is told, in the hill's own keeping rather than the reciters', that Sileas Bhàn never again asked what her deed would be, and that in the four years left to her holding, she gave out grain, judged quarrels, and rode to look at dry ground exactly as she had before, without troubling herself further over what the list would say of any of it.

V

Of the Giving of the Hill

S ileas gave the hill to Tormod Liath in her five hundred and tenth year, on a morning in early spring with the near valleys still carrying the last of that year's snow on their northern faces and the yard at Dùn ìseal churned to mud by every household on the ground that could send even one pair of feet to stand in it. The giving followed the shape every holder before her had given it who was not carried out of the hall feet first: standing before the assembled households, in the same plain wool she judged quarrels in, and saying that the hill was his to hold now, and that she would answer no more quarrels from that day, and that the store within the bank was to be counted before witnesses that same week so that the new holder took it up knowing to the basket what stood in it.

Tormod was a son of Iain Dubh, born in her own father's time, a broad quiet man of thirteen hundred and seventy years who had spent the better part of them at the hill's own margins rather than at its centre, minding cattle on the poorer ground to the north and asking the hill for nothing beyond what any household asked of it. He took the giving without ceremony beyond what the custom itself required, knelt to Sileas in the mud of the yard though she waved him up again before his knee had properly settled, and told the households, in his first words as their holder, that he meant to change nothing about the store within the bank, for he had watched it feed two hungers in his own lifetime from the outside and saw no reason a new holder should improve on a measure that had already held. It was the longest speech anyone at Dùn ìseal had yet heard out of him, and the last of any length for some years after.

Sileas did not go far. She took a house in the near valleys, within a morning's ride of the hill, and kept a small garden there that asked less of the ground than a herd would have, and more than once in the years that followed a household came to her own door rather than the hill's, out of old habit, to ask a judgement she no longer had any right to give; she sent them back to Tormod every time, and told no one, in all the years the sending went on, what it cost her to do it. She never told the households that the rule they kept about the grain-pits, the one about the mouth and not the herd, had been hers and no one else's before it was theirs; it did not occur to her that it mattered whose it had first been, once it was kept without her having to ask for it. When at last her own reciters set down what the list would carry of her holding, they gave her the four words the king had promised her at the ford, no more and no fewer: she held the hill. The withy-lined pits are cut to her measure in that country still, and the households that fill them and empty them by turns have long since stopped asking after the woman who first ordered it so.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Of the Eight Winds and Tormod the Grey

GE 2,021 – 2,210

At Ceann leathan the boat-builders still touch the third stone from the landward end before they step aboard, and none of them, asked why that one, can tell you more than that it is always the third.

I

Of the Hill Given Over

Tormod was the son of Iain Dubh, who had died on the shingle at Baile ghorm with a salt-man's spear in him and been carried home to the cairn his own people raised. Tormod had been a boy of eighty-seven when that news came up from the coast, old enough to stand at the front of the crowd and young enough that the older men put their hands on his shoulders rather than asked anything of him, and he had grown to a man's full years, and then past them, on a hill that had already buried one holder younger than himself and gone on to a woman who was not of his line at all before it came round to him.

Sileas Bhàn gave the hall over to him in the one thousand three hundred and seventieth year of his life, a great age for any man not of the king's own body, and yet the merest span beside hers, for she had held Dùn ìseal through years when the grazing failed two summers running and the store within the bank was opened to every household that had none of its own, and she had done it, the tellings say, with no deed to her name greater than that she had held and not let go. She did not die when she gave the hill over. She went to live among her own kin in the val-

ley below the bank, and was there still, an old woman among older kin than herself, when Tormod's own hair began at last to go the colour it would keep for the rest of his days on the hill.

He came to the hall a man past a thousand years old and looking, those who saw him say, no more than forty, dark-haired still, broad through the shoulders as his father had been broad, and he took up the holding the way a man takes up a tool that has been left lying about for some time and finds, turning it over, that it still answers to the hand. The failed years were behind him. He set himself, in his first seasons, to putting right what the hunger had let go: the bank mended where two winters of neglect had let the ditch silt and the palisade lean, the boundary marks between the hill's own fields and the households' walked and set again where a season of each man taking what he could had blurred them past any two neighbours agreeing. He judged as his grandfather the king had judged, in a sentence, standing, and went back to his mending. It was the small, unglamorous work of a man putting a house in order rather than any deed fit for a telling, and the tellers of Dùn ìseal, pressed for a first act of Tormod's holding, will generally say only that the hill stopped losing ground and start their story somewhere further on.

II

Of the Winds Given Names

It was in his thirty-seventh year on the hill, by the count his own household kept, that word came up from the coast of a thing done among the boat-crews that no one holding land had asked for and no one holding land could stop, being a thing of speech and not of law. Na h-Ochd Gaothan¹ of the year, that every sailor from Bàgh an t-Seabhaig² to the eastern cape had always known by their feel and their season without troubling to call them anything beyond "the one that blows off the ford" or "the one that brings the fish in," had been given names, all eight together, in one telling, by a man or a woman no one afterward could put a face to.

How it was done, and by whom, is not agreed between the coasts that tell it. At Tràigh an t-Salainn³ they say it was an old woman of no family, blown off

1. the eight named winds

course in an open boat and put ashore half-drowned, who named the winds one after another as she came to herself by the fire, the way a fevered person names the dead; that the fisherfolk who pulled her out were no reciters and wrote nothing of it down; yet every one of them who heard her went home with all eight names whole in his head and never afterward forgot one. At Ceann leathan they say there was no woman and no boat, only that the names had always been there, waiting under the tongue the way a word waits before a child is old enough to need it, and that all that happened in that year was that the whole coast began, on the same tides, to say them aloud where before they had only felt the winds without naming them. Tormod himself, asked once by a trader who wanted Na h-Ochd Gaothan' names written on a hide to carry inland, said that he did not know where they had come from and did not think it a question a landholder was fit to answer, the sea and its winds belonging to those who lived on it and not to those who held ground above the tideline.

What can be said plainly is this: before that year, Na h-Ochd Gaothan went unnamed on every coast of Dia-thìr that any telling reaches. After it, every coast used the same eight names, in the same order, for the same winds, and no coast since has changed one of them, though what the names themselves mean, if they ever meant anything beyond the wind each stands for, is dark even to the sailors who say them oftenest and could, any one of them, tell you at a glance which wind was rising and which was dying by the smell of the air alone.

A carrier of the hill's own salt, a man named Fearchar Gobha who ran the road between Dùn ìseal and the coast twice in every month of his working life, brought the eight names up to Tormod himself within the year, having heard them first at the fair from a crew he had never met before and never met again. He had gone down to the strand meaning only to trade, he told Tormod, and had come away with eight words in his mouth that he had not owned when he went down, said in an order he found he could not say them out of even when he tried it as a jest, the way a man cannot say the days of a week backward without stumbling. Tormod asked him to say them once more, standing in the hall with the fire between them, and Fearchar said them, and Tormod said nothing for a while after, and then only that a landholder had no business owning what belonged to the sea, and sent Fearchar back to his road with a measure of grain for his trouble and no more said on it. It is the one telling of that year that gives Tormod a voice at all in

the matter of the naming, and it gives him, as the tellings of that hill are generally content to give him, very little.

III

Of the Stones at Ceann Iethan

The stones came after the names, and came, unlike the names, from a place and a hand that the tellings agree on. Ceann Iethan stands on a point where the coast turns, a long low finger of rock run out into water that is calm on one side of it and broken on the other, and the boat-crews of that shore had always put out from the calm side and come home to it, so that the point itself was, before anything was set upon it, already a place where every crossing began and every crossing that went well was seen to end.

In the thirty-seventh year after the naming, the households of that point set eight standing stones in a ring on the seaward end of it, each a man's height or better, and gave one to each of the eight named winds, so that a sailor going out could lay a hand on the stone of the wind he wanted and, the telling has it, ask it for that wind and no other. Whether the wind ever came for the asking is not a thing any telling troubles to say either way; what is told is that the custom held from that year, and holds still on every coast that has heard of it, and that no sailor of Dia-thir, however far past believing in the working of it he may claim to be over his own hearth, has ever been known to walk past the ring at Ceann Iethan without laying a hand on one stone or another as he goes down to his boat.

The setting of the stones is remembered, unlike the naming, as the work of named hands: three brothers of the point, Aonghas, Dùghlas and Ailig mac Torcaill, who quarried the eight stones from a single outcrop above the landing rather than bring them from elsewhere, reasoning, Dùghlas is said to have said, that a stone that had always stood on that point would know its own wind better than a stone dragged in from a hill that had never felt sea air. It took the three of them the better part of two years to cut and drag and raise all eight, and the ring was not set true at the first standing: the stone of the wind that blows hardest off the open water was found, after one bad winter, to have settled crooked in ground softer than the rest, and had to be dug out and reset on a footing of smaller stones packed beneath it, which is why, of the eight, it alone stands markedly straighter

and newer-looking than its fellows, a thing every boat-builder on that coast can point to and none of them, until told, ever thinks to ask the reason for.

The wind-names crossed water in their own time, forty years on. Eilean fhada, the long island that lies off the northern cape and takes the worst of every storm that comes down out of the grey mist to the north before the mainland feels it, kept no stones and had no point shaped for a ring of them, but its people cut the eight names as notches into the rock of its highest ground, one notch facing each way the wind could come from, so that a man caught on the height in weather too thick to see the coastline by could still lay his hand along the rock and find, by the run of the cuts under his fingers, which way he stood. The notches are there yet, cut deeper by every generation that has found them worn shallow and cut them again, and no one on that island now living remembers a time when the eight ways were reckoned by anything else.

IV

Of the Heirs He Buried

Tormod had married in his three hundredth year, long before he held the hill, a woman of a household under the eastern shoulder of Dùn iséal named for nothing that survives beyond her own children's naming of her as their mother, and she gave him three sons before she died an old woman in her own right, having lived out a full span and never seen any of the three grow older to look at than a young man.

That eldest son died first, in the thirtieth year of Tormod's holding, a man of eleven hundred years worn out at last by na Bliadhnachan Fada¹ that had carried him further than any man not of the king's blood could go, and Tormod stood at the burying dark-haired still, and heard himself named by his own son's children as their grandfather's father, which none of them, being young, thought strange, not having any other grandfather's father living to measure it against.

The second son, who had never cared for the hill's holding and had spent his whole life on the western grazing with the sheep his brother thought beneath him, died sixty years after the first, an old man himself by then, and was buried, at his own asking made long before, on the slope where he had herded, with a cairn

1. the long years of Ailean's kin

no larger than any shepherd's. Tormod rode out to see it raised and stood by it a long while, and was heard to say only that a man ought to be let choose his own ground if nothing else was left him to choose, which the tellings of the western slope have kept ever since as though it were a judgement, though it answered no dispute and settled no grazing; it was simply the thing he said, standing there, and it stuck to the place the way such things do.

The third, the youngest and the one Tormod had thought might outlast him if any of the three could, having been the strongest as a boy and the last to grey, died in the hundred and seventieth year of his father's holding, having lived to see his own grandchildren's children and having asked his father, near the end, propped up in the same bed he had been born in, whether it hurt, being left each time. Tormod sat with the old man's hand in his own hand, which the tellings note was by then the smoother of the two hands in that room by a very great margin, and told him no. It was the only lie the tellings ever charge against him, and they charge it gently, being of the opinion, most of them, that a man burying his third son has earned the right to one.

By the time the third son was in the ground, Tormod Liath had held Dùn ìseal longer than any holder before him whose length is remembered at all, and the hill had begun, without anyone deciding it should, to reckon its own age by how long Tormod had held it rather than by the year, the way a household with a very old grandmother will say "since before Granny's time" of anything far enough back, meaning nothing more precise than a long while.

V

Of the Second Bank

It was in the year the hill's people count as his hundred and fifty-third that Tormod set the second bank, the one that still stands outside the first and gives Dùn ìseal the ground it needed once its granaries had grown past what the old ditch could shelter. He set it the way his father's brother Dòmhnall had set his boundary stones, walking it himself before he asked a spade of anyone else, pacing the line in the frost of two winters running until he was satisfied it took in the low ground by the spring without giving up the height that mattered for a watch-fire, and only then calling the households in to dig.

They dug through a spring and a summer, households that had never worked a spade together before finding, as households will, that the ones who talked least worked longest, and the bank went up doubling the hill's ground within it, so that Dùn ìseal from that year held near a hundred houses inside its earth where forty had stood before, with room, Tormod said when they asked him why so much more than they yet needed, for what would come after him, though he did not say, and none of them thought to ask, what he reckoned that to be.

VI

Of the Grey

he went truly grey in the years the second bank was going up, not all at once as the king himself was said, in an older telling that had reached even that hill by then, to have gone grey in a single winter and no further, but slowly, the black going out of his hair the way colour goes out of cloth left too long in the weather, so slowly that no one household could have said which season it had happened in, only that a man they remembered dark was, some years on, a man they could not remember dark at all.

By his hundred and seventy-fifth year of holding he was grey through, brows and beard with the rest, and stooped a little at the shoulder where he had once stood straight, and the young of the hill, who had never known him any other way, took him for what he plainly appeared: the oldest man on Dùn ìseal, older, they said among themselves, than anyone could well remember, older than the second bank he had raised with his own hands, older, some of the very young said, than the hill itself. It did not trouble him to be thought so, and by the reckoning that matters to the tellings that keep this he was in fact the oldest living thing on that ground bar the oaks of the grove he had never once travelled north to see; he wore the age the young gave him the way a man wears a coat cut generously, room enough in it for a frame he had never quite grown into.

VII

Of the King at the Gate

he was an old man by every mark anyone on the hill could read, in the hundred and ninety-third year of his holding, when the king came in at Dùn Ìseal's gate one spring morning with no more than four of his household about him and no word sent ahead, as he did from time to time on no season anyone could predict, to see how a hill he had given into other hands was being kept.

Tormod came out from the hall to meet him bareheaded, as every holder of that hill had always come to meet him, and went down on one knee in the mud of the gateway the way his father Iain Dubh had gone down before him, and the king put a hand under his arm, as he always did, to raise him before the knee had fully bent, an old habit of his that the hill's people had long since stopped remarking on. It was only when Tormod was upright again, an old grey man more than fifteen hundred years old steadied by the arm of another, that the gathered household of the hill, watching from the gate and the bank above it, saw the two of them standing side by side in the one morning light: the king, grey-headed but unlined, no more than forty by the only measure any of them had ever been given to judge a man's years, and beside him the oldest man any of them had ever known, kneeling to him, and being raised by him, as a son might be raised by his father, though every soul on that hill knew, without anyone troubling to say it aloud, that it stood the other way about: that the unlined man had buried Tormod's father and the mother who bore Tormod, and had stood at every such gate on the island always the same age, while the sons and grandsons and great-grandsons he raised from the mud went grey and old and were carried to the cairn in their own turn.

One of the household who watched from the bank that morning was a girl of nine or ten, a granddaughter of Tormod's second son and so already three generations down from the old man in the gateway, and she is remembered, in the one telling that troubles to name a witness at all, as having asked her mother, in a voice not lowered as much as it should have been, why the young man was letting the old one call him nothing more than what a stranger might be called at a gate. Her mother said nothing there, in the crowd; she took the girl home and told her that evening, by the fire, what every household on that hill already knew and few of them said outright even to their own children until a child's own question forced the saying: that the young man was the king, that he did not age as other men aged, and that the old man he had raised out of the mud was the girl's own great-grandfather, who had held that hill longer than her mother's mother could remember any other holder of it.

None of the young who watched that morning had words ready for what they were looking at. It had been true of every holder before Tormod and would be true of every holder after him, and had been said, in one shape or another, at every gate on the island where the king had ever stood; but it is the tellings of Dùn ìseal in particular that keep the picture of that one spring morning, the old grey man on his feet again with the king's hand still under his arm a moment longer than it needed to be, because it was at Dùn ìseal, in the years just after, that the young first began to say aloud the thing their grandparents had only ever thought.

VIII

Of the Name They Gave Themselves

By Tormod's hundred and ninety-first year of holding, the two thousand two hundred and first year of the hill, the children of that generation had begun, without any elder telling them to, calling themselves by a name none of their grandparents had used for themselves. Hill-folk was true enough of where they lived and said nothing of what they were. Clann nan Dè¹ belonged by then to a handful of families near Na Glinn Àrda² who traced their blood straight back to the grove and would not have thanked a Dùn ìseal fisherman's son for claiming it alongside them. The children took Dia-thìrich instead, the people of Dia-thìr, and gave the island the same name in the same breath, Dia-thìr and no other word.

No one now living, and no telling that reaches this far back with any confidence, can say whose mouth said it first, or whether it was said first at Dùn ìseal at all rather than carried there already made from An Cnoc Ruadh³ or the ford or some hearth further off that kept no memory of having coined it. What is agreed is only that it did not arrive as a law or a naming ordered by any holder, king or otherwise; it arrived the way the wind-names had arrived a hundred and fifty years before, all at once and everywhere, so that within a generation of children the old words for what they were had gone out of use among the young without ever being forbidden, and the elders who still said hill-folk out of habit found themselves, more and more, being gently corrected by their own grandchildren.

1. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

2. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

3. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

Tormod heard it first, the tellings say, from a boy of perhaps seven, one of the households settled along the new ground the second bank had opened, who told him plainly, when the old man asked what clan he belonged to, that he was Diathèreach, and that everyone was, and seemed puzzled that so old a man should need telling. Tormod, who was by then further past a thousand years of life than any of his own three dead sons had lived altogether, said only that it was a good enough name for a good enough island, and let the boy go back to his play; and that, so far as any telling of that hill preserves, is the whole of what the ninth of Rìghrean na Cloiche⁴ ever said, for or against, on the matter of what his people had decided, of their own accord and without asking him, that they were.

4. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

OF the FORBIDDEN MARRIAGE and the TRENCH

GE 2,211 – 2,327

I

Of Ealag and Torcall Tochlair

This is told at Dùn ìseal by the hearths that still keep the shape of the old spring, though the two households that once stood there are long since gone into other names.

Ealag was born in a household under the eastern shoulder of Dùn ìseal, the fourth of six, in a year when the hill's flocks did well and nobody troubled to remember which year that was by any other mark. Torcall was born two households over, the son of a man who gathered an gual dathach¹ where it showed in the peat-banks and stream-cuts of the hills and was called Tochlair for it, the digger, a name that stuck to the boy before he had dug so much as a post-hole. The two families kept sheep on the same slope and drew water from the same spring, and the children of both ran together from as far back as either of them could afterward call to mind. Neither could say when it had started, only that it had always been so.

There is a telling, kept longer in that house than most of the rest, of the two of them as children no higher than the sheep-pen rail, caught out in a storm on the open hill with the flock scattered and no grown person near, and Torcall standing over Ealag with his own coat pulled off and held above her head against the rain

1. the coloured coal

until his father found them both wet through and laughing under it, the coat long since useless and neither of them minding. Whether it happened as the telling has it, or happened at all, no one now living can say; but it was told at both hearths for years afterward, by the mothers of the two children to each other, as proof of a thing neither household thought it needed proving.

They grew up counting each other's sheep by the ear-notch without being asked, and knowing which of the two spring paths the other would take of a morning by nothing more than habit, and by the time they were old enough to be spoken of for marrying, the whole slope had long since stopped thinking of them as two people who might or might not be joined and thought of them instead as a thing already joined, waiting only for its proper words.

By the time Ealag was grown enough to be spoken of for marrying, nobody on the hill thought to ask whether she and Torcall would be given to each other. It was taken for a settled thing, the way the path from the spring to the houses was taken for a settled thing, worn in by so many feet that no one remembered the first of them. Torcall asked her outright at the shearing in the year she turned sixteen, standing in wet wool to the elbows with the whole slope watching, and she laughed at him for asking what everyone already knew, and said yes in front of forty people, and that should have been the end of the matter and the start of another.

Word went between the two households in the old way, an elder of each sent to the other's hearth with a measure of salt, which is accepted or is not. Torcall's mother carried the salt across herself, being a woman who trusted nothing she had not done with her own hands, and she was not gone long. She came back with the salt still in its cloth and her face set in a way her son had not seen it set before, not at his father's dying, not at any hard winter.

"They will not have it," she said.

"Which of them said so?"

"All of them. The old man spoke for the rest, but I watched their faces, and none of them thought he spoke wrong."

Torcall went himself the next day, to hear it said to his own face rather than carried to him at second hand, and the elders of Ealag's household gathered in their doorway to tell him so, all of them together, as if one alone could not be trusted to hold the line against him. He asked why. He asked it plainly, the way a man asks the price of a thing before he buys it, expecting a plain answer back.

"It cannot be," said the eldest, a woman named Beathag who had held that household longer than Torcall had been alive.

"Cannot, or will not?"

"It cannot be," Beathag said again, as though the words themselves, said twice, were an answer, and turned back into the house.

He went to Ealag's father next, and her father would not meet his eye, and he went to two of her uncles, and they said the same three words between them and would say no more, and in the end he stood in the yard with the sheep moving round his legs and understood that no one on that hill was going to tell him why, because either none of them knew, or all of them had sworn not to say, and there was no way from where he stood to tell one from the other.

He tried the oldest woman of his own household too, thinking that if the refusal came of some old quarrel it might be known on his own side of it as well as the other, but his grandmother only shook her head at him and said that she had never heard the two families named together in any grievance in all her years, not over grazing, not over water, not over anything a person could point to, and that this was the strangest part of it to her: a refusal with no history behind it that she had ever been told of, standing as flat and as final as one with forty years of bad blood at its back.

Last of all he went to Ealag, at the spring, in the evening, when the water was the colour of the sky and there was nobody else to hear them.

"Do you know why?" he said.

"No," she said. "I asked my mother. She held my two hands in hers and told me it was not a thing I would ever be told, not by her, not by anyone living, and that I was to stop asking, because asking would not open it and might close other doors besides. Then she cried, which I have never seen her do, not once, not at any burying."

"That is not a reason."

"No," Ealag said. "It is not."

They stood a while at the spring without more to say, because there was nothing further to be got from either side of it, no thread that would not come away loose in the hand for the pulling. Of the true cause the households never spoke again in either of their lifetimes, and no telling that has come down from that hill has ever named it; it is set down here only as it stands, refused and unexplained, because that is how it stands in every version the reciters keep. Already, in those years, the Dia-thìrich had begun to order themselves by blood in ways that ran

deeper than any one match or any one grudge, long before the vein gave them further cause to reckon who was kin to whom; and whatever lay beneath the refusal of Ealag and Torcall, it lay in that older ordering, and was not brought out into the light for either of them to see.

II

Of the Marriage at the Ford

Ealag was given instead to a household of the ford, where salt had first been traded for wool in the days of Ragnall Ceannfhionn, and where households gathered every year for the fair in the same season the shearing had been held on the hill. Her husband was a fisher of the shallows there, a quiet man named Donnchadh who had asked for her honestly and without knowing, when he asked, that there had ever been another asking before his. She went to him in the year she turned seventeen, the two thousand two hundred and twenty-fourth year of the hill, the spring after the refusal.

She was married at the ford itself, in sight of the water, with the households of the ford standing about her on the bank in their fair-day cloaks and the salmon running so thick that season that two boys were sent to keep them from the shallows where the feet of the guests would trouble the fishing later. Donnchadh gave her a comb of horn he had carved himself through the winter evenings, clumsily, so that one tooth was shorter than the rest, and she wore it every fair-day after for the whole of her marriage, the short tooth catching on her hair in a way she never had mended. She did not weep at her own wedding, though she had wept twice in the week before it, alone, at the spring on the hill where no one from the ford could see her; and she came to her husband's house that evening dry-eyed and quiet, and was, by every account that survives of her, a good wife to him from the first night to the last, whatever else she carried that he did not ask after.

She did not tell him of Torcall Tochclair until they had been three years married, and when she told him he said only that it explained a look she sometimes had at fair-time, and never asked more, which she was grateful for the whole of her life after.

It was at that same fair, some years on, that she first heard a thing recited that had not been recited before. The ford had long drawn every kind of household to its yearly gathering, to trade salt for wool and wool for whatever the sea brought

in, and it had always been a place where matches were spoken of and made, the elders of one hearth walking across to another with their measure of salt as Torcall's mother had once walked. But in that year, and it is remembered as the first year, before any match was spoken a household stood up and gave its line: the names of its dead, back seven generations, father to father and mother to mother, said aloud in the hearing of the whole fair, so that anyone who knew of a blood too close, or a blood forbidden for some reason nobody living could give, might speak before the salt was carried across. It began, so the telling goes, with a household that had been burned once already by a match no one had thought to question until it was too late to unmake, though whose household that was the tellers no longer agree.

Ealag stood in the crowd at the ford and heard the lines given, one after another, seven names back on each side, fathers answering fathers and mothers answering mothers, and she thought of Beathag in the doorway saying *it cannot be* and giving no seventh name, no sixth, no first, nothing a listener could have weighed. She thought that if such a reciting had stood between her and Torcall, the whole hill would have heard whatever it was that only the old people knew, said aloud where it could be judged, rather than kept behind four shut mouths. She said as much to Donnchadh that evening, and he said that a thing kept behind shut mouths might be kept there for good reason as easily as bad, and she said she supposed that was true, and neither of them believed it entirely.

The reciting at the ford held from that year on, and other fairs along the coast took it up after, until it was a common thing at any gathering where a match might be made: the households of the common people giving their lines aloud, seven names back, the same distance An Clachair's own line was said to keep, though no common household claimed kinship with that older line, only the same caution about it. It is the oldest tally of ordinary blood that the island keeps outside the king's, and no single telling of it has come down whole; each hearth kept its own seven names, and when a hearth failed the names failed with it.

III

Of the Trench at the Black Hill

1. the Mason, Neachdan, who broke the vein

Torcall Tochclair did not marry. He gathered the coal as his father had, a few handfuls a season from the banks where it showed, and by all accounts he did it well and without complaint, but something in him had gone restless in a way that gathering what the hills let fall could not answer. He began to ask the older diggers, on the walk home from the peat-banks of an evening, whether the vein under the mountain was the only coal the island held, and the older diggers, who had asked the same question themselves in their own youth and had it answered by their own fathers' silence, told him what they had been told: that the vein chose where it lay, and had not chosen to lie twice.

Torcall was not a man the answer satisfied. He had a brother, Lachann, younger by five years and easier in his temper, who had never much minded being told a thing and made to let it stand, but who loved his brother more than he minded being talked into things, and when Torcall began to speak of a black hill in the east where the ground had a look about it he had heard described by traders from that coast, Lachann said he would go and look with him, if only to see him satisfied and brought home again.

Lachann had a wife of his own by then and a daughter not yet walking, and he told his wife he would be gone a season, no more, and was gone the better part of four years, coming back only twice in that time to see the child grow, once when she could stand and once when she could run from him laughing across the yard and had to be caught. He never complained of the distance in any telling that has come down, and the diggers who worked beside him at the black hill said afterward that he sang more than any of them at the trench face, old songs of the hill country sung in the wrong place, which made the other three laugh at him and made the work go easier for it.

They went east together in the dry season, with two other diggers who had grown as restless as Torcall on less cause, to the black hill, a rise of empty ground in the east, named already for the darkness of its soil before ever a pick touched it. They opened a trench along its shoulder with picks and fire-cracked stone, the same way a well is sunk, working by turns through the wet months and the dry, cutting down through soil the colour of char into rock that gave off no smell of coal and no shine of it either, only a grey stone that came away in slabs.

It was in the fourth year of the digging, in the two thousand two hundred and sixty-seventh year of the hill, that the trench wall gave. There had been rain enough that season to loosen what the diggers had already undercut more than they knew, and the fall came without any of the small warnings that a careful dig-

ger learns to read, no trickle of loose stone beforehand, no settling underfoot. Lachann was at the face with one of the other two men when the wall came down; Torcall was above, hauling a basket up on the rope, and heard it rather than saw it, a sound he said afterward he had no word for and never tried twice to find one. He dug with his hands until the others came running with tools, and dug after that too, long past when digging could do any good, and had to be pulled bodily away from the fall by three men before he would stop.

Lachann's wife came out to the black hill herself when word reached her, walking the whole distance with the child on her hip, and stood at the trench a long while without speaking to anyone, and went home again three days later with a handful of the char-black soil tied in a cloth, which she kept at her own hearth for the rest of her life and would let no one touch but herself. She did not blame Torcall to his face, then or ever, though it is told that she never again asked after him by name, and spoke of him only, when she spoke of him at all, as her daughter's uncle at the black hill.

Lachann was buried on the black hill, at the mouth of the trench he had died beside, because Torcall would not have him carried elsewhere, and the other man's people took him home to be buried among his own. Torcall did not go home. He built himself a turf shelter at the trench's edge and stayed there through the winter that followed, and when the diggers who had come with him packed their tools and went back west to the hills, he did not go with them. Word of it reached Ealag at the ford by way of a trader who had stopped at the black hill and seen him there, a man sitting alone by an open trench with his dead brother in the ground a few feet off, still saying, when anyone asked him why he stayed, that the coal was there to be found and he meant to find it.

IV

Of the Stone That Would Not Break

he was not, in the end, the only one who tried. Word of the black hill's trench had gone about the island in the years it was being dug, as word of any strangeness does, and it woke in other places the same restlessness it had woken in Torcall: if coal could be looked for in the east, it could be looked for anywhere, and more than one household elsewhere on the island took up picks in those years with the same hope Torcall had carried east with him.

The largest of these second attempts was made some distance from the black hill, on rising ground the diggers judged as like to the mountain's own shoulder as any ground on the island could be, by folk who had heard of Torcall's trench but not of Lachann's death, or had heard of it and judged the risk worth taking regardless. They shored their trench with timber where Torcall's had gone unshored, having heard enough of the black hill by then to take that much warning at least, and they set watchers on the lip of the cutting in turns through every shift, and for all their care the ground gave them nothing to watch for. They dug two full seasons, deeper by the end than Torcall's own trench had gone, through soil and then through a bed of common grey stone that gave way at last to more of the same stone beneath it, unbroken, ordinary rock going down further than any of them had tools or patience to follow.

The leader of that digging, a man whose name has not come down with the rest of the telling, was said to have gone down into the cutting himself on the last day and struck the grey stone three times with his own pick before he would call the work done, as if the stone might yet answer a fourth household where it had refused three years of others; and when it did not, he climbed out, and told the rest to bank their fires, and the digging at that hill ended there. They struck at it a while longer out of stubbornness more than hope, and then they stopped, because there is only so long a household can feed itself on the hope of what a hillside has not shown it, and this hillside, in the end, showed them nothing at all.

It was from that failure, more than from Torcall's trench, which after all had found nothing but had not yet been called finished, that the saying began to travel the island: that the vein under the mountain was alone of its kind, that no second coal lay waiting anywhere else to be found by whoever dug hardest for it, and that the stone the second diggers had struck was proof of it, a stone that would not break because there was nothing under it to break for. Some said *gual dubh*¹ itself had chosen its one place in the world the way *na Seachd Guail*² of the old tellings were said to have chosen theirs, and that a stone unwilling to give up anything was simply the island's way of saying the choice had already been made and was not to be argued with by picks.

No one tried a third opening in that age. No elder of any hearth is remembered forbidding it outright; the will for it went out of the island unasked, the way the will for a bad match goes out of two families once the salt has been

1. the black coal, of earth

2. the Seven Coals

carried and refused, each hearth coming to the same mind alone and none of them saying so aloud.

V

Of the Vein That Chooses

Torcall Tochclair stayed at the black hill for the rest of his years, and never took a wife, and never went back to the hills, though he sent word west now and then for tools he could not make himself. He kept the trench open well past the point any sensible digger would have let it fill with rain and go back to grass. Closing it, he told the few who still came to ask him, would mean agreeing that Lachann had died for nothing, and that he would not do. A small household grew up around him at the black hill's foot in his old age, folk who came for one reason or another and stayed because the ground was as good as any and the man at the trench asked nothing of them; by the time he was old it was Torcall's hill to those who lived near it, or Cnoc na Claise¹, which is the name the households about it keep.

Ealag lived out her years at the ford, and raised three children with Donnchadh the fisher, and grew old in a house within sound of the ford where the lines were recited every year at the fair, seven names back on either side, a custom that had not existed when she was a girl and that she had, in her own quiet way, watched into being. Her own children were given without trouble, in their turn, to households of the ford and the coast about it, their lines recited plainly and answered by no objection from anyone, and she stood in the crowd for each of their weddings with the same short-toothed comb in her hair that Donnchadh had carved her, worn nearly smooth by then with handling.

In her last years she would sometimes walk down to the ford at fair-time and stand at the edge of the crowd to hear the reciting, and those who knew her story, which by then was most of the ford's households, said she listened harder than anyone else there, though whether she was listening for Torcall's line, or for her own, or only for whatever answer the world had never given her, none of them could have said, and she never told them. She died at the ford in the two thousand three hundredth year of the hill, in her own bed, with her children about her, an

1. the hill of the first trench for another vein (burg 198 in this age)

old woman who had asked one honest question in her youth and had gone the whole of her life afterward without an answer to it.

Of Torcall it is told that he died at the black hill some years after her, in the two thousand three hundred and eighteenth year, and was buried beside his brother at the trench's mouth, and that the small household he had gathered kept the ground and did not fill the trench in even then, though nothing further was ever dug from it. What the two of them, Ealag and Torcall, might have made of each other's later lives, had the salt been carried and accepted instead of refused, is not a thing any telling of this age presumes to say. The reciters who keep the story end it always the same way, with the same words the elders of the two households were said to give and no others: that the vein chooses where it lies, and that the choice was never anyone's to make but its own.

PART FOUR

The Lot and the Saying

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

OF the SHARING before the STORMS

GE 2,328 – 2,390

An làmh a roinneas, cha teirig i; an làmh a dh'fhalaicheas, falbhaidh

i. The hand that shares does not fail; the hand that hides must go.

— said at Dùn ìseal after the sharing, and after nothing else

I

Of the Custom that Had No Beginning

No one at Dùn ìseal could say who first brought grain to the bank before the storms, or in what year, or why. The telling only holds that in one year a household with more than it needed carried the surplus to the hall and set it down before the holder without being asked, and that the households with less were glad of it, and that the year after, another household did the same, unbidden, because the first had. By the time it was a custom no one living remembered it not being one.

It was not a law such as the reciters kept at the ford, cut into no stone and sworn to no name. It asked only this: that before the season of the black-wind storms, when the boats came in for good and the passes closed and a household's stores were what they would live on until the grass came back, whoever had more than enough should say so, and bring it in.

Tormod Liath, who held the hill in those years and had held it longer than any before him, let it be done in the open. At the gathering of Samhain the households brought their surplus within the bank: grain in skins, dried fish strung on

rods, salted meat in its own fat. It was weighed by the count of mouths in each house and given back out, so that every hearth went into the dark months even. A household that brought little because it had little lost nothing by it. A household that brought little because it had kept more back lost the thing it had kept, once, and after that lost more.

It is told that in the third year of the custom a woman of the shore households, whose net had taken more mackerel than her family could eat or smoke before it turned, carried three baskets of it up to the bank herself rather than let it spoil unshared, and that Tormod came down from the hall to help her set them down, an old grey man carrying fish like any hand of the household. After that the custom needed no one to ask.

There was no cutter's mark for it, no knotted cord to count it by, and no word among the Dia-thìrich for the thing itself; it was known only as the sharing, or the bringing-in, or, among those who did it least willingly, the asking, though no one asked, and that was the whole of its strength. A household that gave more than its share got back no more than any other; a household that gave nothing because it had nothing was not shamed for it, and a holder who tried to shame such a household was, in the one telling that gives the case, made to bring his own surplus in double the next year by the plain silence of his neighbours, without a word said against him that any reciter kept.

For thirty years and more it went so, and the island beyond the hill knew little of it, for it belonged to Dùn ìseal and its valleys and had not yet gone out along the roads the way the lot and the cup would go out after it. Elsewhere households still hoarded against the storms as they had always done, burying what they could not eat, and thought no worse of themselves for it. A household that dug a floor-pit in those years did so as its grandfathers had, against wolves, against a bad neighbour, against nothing it could have named; it was only where the sharing had come first that a hidden pit became a different thing, without the digger changing a stone of it.

II

Of the House at Àth shean



th shean stood where Rathad an t-Salainn¹ forded the shallow river below the hill, a scatter of houses on the near bank with byres cut into the slope behind them, no different from a dozen fords like it save that its ground was good for barley in a wet year and bad in a dry one, and that its households answered to Dùn ìseal the way the near valleys did.

Beasag was born there in the household of a man whose name the hill's own telling does not keep, only that he was a careful man, close with what was his, and that his neighbours called him so without meaning it as praise. He had built his grain pit himself, lined with hurdles and roofed with turf, under the floor of the byre where the cattle stood over it in winter and no stranger would think to dig; and he had built it before ever the sharing custom came down the valley to Àth shean, in the years when a hidden store was only good sense and no one asked a man to open his floor to his neighbours.

By the time Beasag could walk, the sharing had come to Àth shean too, carried down by households that had seen it done at the hill and thought it good, and her father brought his share to the bank each year with the rest, a little less than his neighbours guessed he had, though none could have said by how much.

She grew up knowing the pit the way a child knows the shape of a house without being told its walls have a name. Her father lifted the third flagstone from the door on nights when the household ate better than its neighbours, and laid it back after; and long before Beasag had words for understanding it, she understood that this was not spoken of outside the walls.

She remembered it best as a smell before she remembered it as a thing: the byre at night smelled of cattle and old rushes and, on those nights, for a little while, of turned earth and grain-dust, and under it the tallow smoke of the one lamp her father allowed himself for the lifting. He never spoke while he did it. He knelt on the flag beside the third stone with a length of ash wood for a lever, and worked it up an inch at a time so that it made no more noise going than a cow shifting its feet, and he never once, in all the years she watched him from the loft ladder with her chin on the top rung, looked up to see whether she was there. She thought, when she was very small, that this was a game fathers played, a secret kept the way a secret is kept from younger children about a feast day; it was some years before she understood that it was kept from the ford as well as from her, and some years more before she understood what that meant.

1. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

"A careful man keeps his own counsel," he told her once, the only time he ever spoke of it to her directly. It was said, on that one occasion, of a neighbour who had asked him plainly, at the ford, whether his barley had come in as thin as everyone else's. "What a man has under his own floor is between him and his floor." She was young enough then to think it a kind of wisdom, the way a child takes most of what a parent says for wisdom until the day it stops sounding like any.

Her mother had died birthing the last of Beasag's brothers, three winters before this telling opens, and after that the house was her father's and his alone to keep as he judged fit; and what he judged fit was to keep more back each year, a little at a time, the way a man tests how far a rope will stretch before it breaks. He was not unkind to his children. He fed them well in years others went hungry, and thought, in his own reckoning, that this was the whole of what a father owed.

III

Of the Lean Year

The storm season that came in the forty-ninth year after the custom began was the leanest Àth shean had known. The grazing had failed the summer before along the whole of the near valleys; the barley came in thin and short-headed; and the fishing boats, which in a poor year on land could always be sent out again for what the sea still gave, lost three weeks running to a wind that would not turn.

Beasag was seventeen that year, old enough to be sent to the bank at Dùn iséal with the household's share and to see with her own eyes what a lean year looked like gathered in one place: baskets half the height of other years, byres led up with cattle too thin to slaughter, old people who came to stand by the bank and be counted though they had nothing to bring. She saw the division made by the count of mouths, saw a widow with four children carry home more than she had brought, saw a household of two old men carry home less; and she understood, watching it, what her father's floor held that these people did not have.

She saw one thing more that day that stayed with her longer than the counting itself. A boy not much younger than her own brother stood near the bank with an empty sack over his shoulder, waiting his household's turn, and when the measure was poured into it he stood a moment holding the weight of it in both arms, where the other children ran home with theirs at once, and laughed, once,

at nothing anyone else could see; and an old woman beside Beasag said, not unkindly, that it was the boy's first winter with a full belly in it, and that he did not yet trust it to last the walk home. Beasag thought of her father's pit, deep and dry and dark under the byre floor, holding more than that boy's whole sack twice over, and said nothing, then, to the old woman or to anyone.

She said nothing that year. It was not in her, yet, to say it. She told herself, walking home behind her father and brother with the household's own thin share on her back, that it was not her floor and not her word to give, and that a daughter did not measure her father any more than a son did; and she went on telling herself so through the winter that followed, a winter in which Àth shean buried two of its old people and her own house ate meat twice a week and bread every day, and no one at her hearth asked why, because no one at her hearth wanted to know the answer badly enough to ask.

But the year had marked her, and she went home turning it over the way a stone is turned over in a pocket, worn smooth by handling before it is ever thrown. She began to watch her father's face when he counted the household's share into the skins for the bank, and to notice what he set aside first and did not put in, and to reckon, as well as a girl of seventeen could reckon, how many mouths at Àth shean had gone hungrier that winter than they need have, for the sake of what lay under three courses of turf beneath the byre floor.

Her elder brother, who slept in the loft above the byre and had grown a man's shoulders that year, knew of the pit as she did and had made his own peace with it long before; it was their father's floor, their father's grain, and a son did not measure his father. He told her so plainly enough, the once she tried to speak of it to him, and after that she did not try again with him.

IV

Of the Telling

She told it at the ford rather than the hill, and to a woman mending net on the bank rather than to any holder, in the first mild days after the storms broke, when Àth shean's household came down to the water again to see what the winter had left of the boats. The woman's name is not kept in the hill's telling, only that she was old enough to have buried a husband and a son that same winter, and that she asked Beasag, in the way of an idle question between

neighbours who have both come through a hard season, whether her father's byre had fared as thin as the rest of the ford's.

"No," Beasag said, before she had thought whether to answer at all, and then, because the one word sat badly on its own, "there's a pit under the floor. There has been since before the sharing came to us. He never brought it all in."

The woman went on with her mending for a moment as though she had not heard, the way people do when a thing is too large to take in at the speed it was given. Then she asked, quietly, whether Beasag was certain, and Beasag said she was, for she had watched her father lift the flag with her own eyes more winters than she could count; and the woman put down her net and looked at her a long while before she said anything more.

"You know what this will cost him."

"I know."

"And you still say it."

Beasag gave that one no answer. The hill's telling holds, in the one line it gives to the moment itself, that she stood on the bank with the wind off the water in her face and found, turning the words over once they were out, that she felt lighter for having said them than she had felt in a long time, and that this frightened her more than her father's anger would, when it came.

She did not tell it to bring trouble on her father. She told the truth of what she said afterward, when she was made to say it again before others, in a plainer way: that she had been asked, and that she had grown tired, some time in that lean winter without her quite marking the day it happened, of watching her neighbours go thin while her own house did not, and that once the word was out of her mouth she found she did not want it back.

The woman told her own household, as neighbours do, meaning no more harm by it than Beasag had meant in the telling; and from there it went the short way a thing goes in a scatter of houses at a ford, hearth to hearth, until it reached Àth shean's own holder, who sent word up to Dùn ìseal, because a matter under the sharing custom was not his to judge alone.

Tormod Liath was an old man by then, older than any who had held the hill before him, and it is told that he heard the matter out in silence and asked only one question of the men who came to lay it before him: whether the girl had told it of her own will, unbeaten and unbribed. When they said she had, he nodded once, as a man nods at something he expected, and sent them to open the floor.

They found the pit as she had said it would be, lined and roofed and dry, and in it grain enough to have fed two households through the lean winter that had just passed, kept whole while the hall counted out its shares by the mouth. Her father did not deny it when they brought him before the holder's man at Àth shean. He said only that it was his own pit, dug with his own hands before ever the custom came to the ford, and that a man's floor was his own to keep as he judged.

The holder's man told him that the pit was his, and always would be; the grain in it was the households' now, by the custom the ford had kept for fifty years, and the household that had hidden it from the sharing would keep nothing at Àth shean past the day. Until dark he might take from his own house what he and his children could carry on their backs, and no more, and be off the ford's ground by morning.

Before the man turned to go, Beasag's father asked who had told it, though he must already have guessed, for there was no one else in the house who had known where the pit lay and lived to speak of it besides his own children. The ford kept no custom of naming the teller to the one told on, for fear of what might follow such a naming in a house before it was even emptied, and he got no answer to it. But he looked at Beasag across the yard as the man spoke, once, and she did not look away from him, and it is told that this was answer enough for both of them, and that no more words passed between father and daughter on the matter, that day or any day after.

V

Of the Road

Beasag walked out with her father and her brother and the two younger children in the last light of that day, each of them under as much as they could bear: a folded hide, a cooking pot, what grain had not gone into the pit, a spindle, a knife, the small things a household gathers in a generation and cannot leave behind though it can carry almost none of them. No one at Àth shean came out to see them go, though she felt, walking the lane between the houses, that every door had someone standing just inside it.

Her father did not speak to her on the road, that night or the next, and it is not told in the hill's own telling whether he ever did again as they had spoken be-

fore. Her brother walked beside her without a word either way, carrying more than his share and setting his own pace to hers when the youngest flagged, which was the only kindness either of them had it in him to give just then.

They slept the first night in the open, under a hedge-bank within sight of Àth shean's own smoke, because the youngest could go no further, and Beasag lay awake listening to her father's breathing on the far side of the fire and could not tell, in the dark, whether he slept or only lay still. In the morning he was up before any of them, and led them east without a word about which way, as though the road had always run only that one direction and none of them had ever thought otherwise.

They went east, the way households went who could not or would not hold ground close under the hill: past the near valleys, past the last of the bank-ditches Tormod's line had thrown up, out to where the vein under the mountain gave way to common rock and the king's blood held no hall and claimed no grazing. They walked eleven days by Beasag's later count, though she owned that she had lost the true tale of them somewhere past the sixth, footsore and thin-shod, sleeping under whatever bank or overhang the evening found them near, eating the grain they had carried at half what they would have eaten it at home, because none of them yet knew how far east they would need it to last. There were households there already, scattered and thin on ground poorer than Àth shean's, who had gone east a generation before for their own reasons and asked no questions of those who came after with the same look about them. Beasag's father built a house on a slope above a stream with no name that she was ever told, and did not build a pit under its floor, though whether that was shame or only that there was nothing left worth hiding, she never said, in all the years the ford afterward kept her name.

It is told that she stayed east of the vein the whole of her life, and raised her own children in a house with no door to any stone, and that whenever travellers came through from the hill she would ask them, before any other news, how the sharing had gone that season, and whether any household had been found keeping back; and that she never once said why she asked, though everyone she asked already knew.

VI

Of the Hill in Its Old Age

Tormod Liath held the hill twelve years more after the matter of Àth shean's pit, into the last winter of his life, by which time his hair and beard had gone the colour of the stone the reciters named him for and his hands shook at the cup though his judgment did not. He had outlived three heirs of his own body before that, and buried each one himself at the bank he had built, and it was said of him at the end that no one now living at Dùn ìseal remembered a holder of the hill who was not Tormod.

He died in his own hall, in his sleep, with no wound and no fever on him, in the three hundred and eightieth year of his holding, and the hill mourned him the length of a season, for there was scarcely a household on it whose grandfather he had not judged.

The holding of the hill passed, as the list gives it, to Eilidh Ghlas, of the king's own blood, who had lived three hundred and forty years in the valleys under Dùn ìseal without any thought, her own telling says, of ever holding anything but her own hearth. She took up the hill in the year of Tormod's death, and the sharing custom with it, and it is told that the first thing she did, before the bank was even swept for the season's grain, was to send to Àth shean and ask after the pit under the byre floor that everyone at the ford still called by the name of the man who had dug it, though he had been gone from the ford for twelve years and more.

She was answered that the pit stood empty, and had stood empty since the day it was opened, for no household at Àth shean since had cared to dig one of its own; and it is told that she said only that this was well, and asked nothing further about it, then or after.

Eilidh had come to the hill an old woman already in the world's reckoning, though young beside Tormod's long holding, and those who had known her in the valleys said she brought to the hall a plainer hand than his: she weighed the sharing herself in the first years rather than leave it to a steward, and stood at the bank through the whole of the counting even in wet weather, so that no household could say the hill judged them from indoors while they stood wet outside it. Of the man who had gone east with his children she asked nothing more than the one question, and the ford's telling, which watched her closely those first seasons the way a ford watches any new holder, set that down as neither harshness nor forgiveness, but only as the manner of a woman who had watched the custom work for sixty years before it was ever hers to keep, and saw no cause to remake it.

Under her the sharing went on as it had under Tormod, brought in and weighed and given back by the count of mouths, and no household at Dùn ìseal

or Àth shean was ever again found keeping a floor that lied about what lay beneath it. The house east of the vein, and the woman who had opened her father's pit with a word at a riverbank, the hill's own telling does not follow further; that thread Àth shean kept for itself, and told, when it told it at all, in its own words and not the hill's.

OF EILIDH THE GREY AND THE BOY WHO WENT

GE 2,391 – 2,402

An gille a dh'fhalbh, cha tàinig e dhachaigh na aon fhear. The boy
who went did not come home the same man. — An Cnoc Ruadh's
own telling, of a fosterling it never named

I

Of Eilidh's Two Sons

Eilidh Ghlas had held the hill a year when her elder son was born to her a second time in the telling, though he was the elder by birth from the first: for a mother of the king's own blood counts a child twice, once for the bearing and once for the year the world takes notice of him, and the ford did not take notice of Calum Ciar until his mother stood at the bank in the first sharing of her own holding and he stood a pace behind her right shoulder, dark-haired and watchful, and someone said, low, that here was the next one. He had not chosen it, and his mother had not pointed him out; a boy standing where an heir stands is heir enough for a ford to see, and after that no one at Dùn ìseal thought to look for another when they spoke of who would hold the hill when Eilidh was gone from it, however many hundred years that might be.

He was close with his mother in the way of a first child who remembers, or believes he remembers, a time before any other claimed her hand. Calum Ciar rode with her on the counting days and lifted the grain-skins himself beside her; and Eilidh, who did the same herself through every wet season rather than leave the

weighing to a steward, thought this a good likeness and said so to no one but her own held silence. Of her younger son there is less to be told, and what is told belongs less to him than to the household that raised him, which is the way of An Cnoc Ruadh's own list when it comes to speak of him at all.

He was born in the fourth year of his mother's holding, in a wet spring when the river at Àth shean ran high enough to float the ford-stones, and no reciter troubles to give the day, for no reciter of Dùn ìseal ever gave him a day for anything, first or last. He was smaller than his brother had been, and quieter, and grew, in the few years the hill's own telling allows him before it sends him from it, into a boy who watched more than he spoke and who followed the dogs about the yard more readily than he followed the men to the bank. Eilidh loved him, it is told, exactly as she loved his brother, for she had held enough seasons of counting by then to know that a hand which gives one child more takes something from the other that no gift repays. But she watched him, in the years he was old enough to be watched, with a plainer eye than she watched Calum Ciar, the way a holder watches a field that will not be sown this year and studies it all the same.

It was Eilidh's own mother, dead these many years before, who had first spoken of fosterage to her as a girl, in the valleys under the hill, long before either of them thought Eilidh would ever hold anything: that among the households of the near valleys, when a family had more than one son and land enough for only one to inherit, the younger was sometimes sent to kin at another hearth to be raised, so that he might grow up loved and useful in a house that was not waiting for him to die or go, and so that the house he left might have one less mouth counted against its portion and one less claim laid against its bank when the holder's time came. It was a custom of ordinary households, not of the hill, and Eilidh had turned it over in her mind through all the years of her own holding without doing anything about it, the way a woman turns over a thought she is not yet ready to act on, until the year her younger son was six years old and stood in the yard one evening watching his brother ride out with the men to see the boundary stones renewed, and did not ask to go, and did not seem to mind that he had not been asked.

She watched him from the hall door a long while that evening. It is told that she said to her steward, who stood by her, that a house with only one door out of

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

it was no house for a second son, and that the steward, not understanding her, asked which door she meant, and she did not answer him.

She sent, in the spring of the following year, word to An Cnoc Ruadh.

There had been peace at the ford for longer than either hill now living could number by its own holding: the meeting first made between Raghnaill Ceannfhionn and a nameless holder of the west had held through every holder after, salt and flint and wool changing hands where it had first changed hands, marriages agreed there that neither hill's own custom would have made alone. But peace between two hills that owe fealty to the same king and nothing to one another is a thing kept fresh each generation by an act, not by the mere absence of a quarrel, and it had occurred to Eilidh, turning the old custom of the valleys over in her mind, that no act keeps a peace so well as a child sent to be raised inside it. She did not put this to her steward, or to anyone at Dùn ìseal, as a matter of the kingdom; she put it, when she put it to anyone, as a mother's plain wish that her younger son should learn a trade that was not waiting for an inheritance to be idle in, and An Cnoc Ruadh's salt and its boats and its far sight of the western sea were as good a trade as any a boy of the king's blood had ever been given. Both things were true. The hill's own reciters, in the years after, chose to keep the second and let the first go, as reciters will when a mother's plain wish makes a better telling than a holder's policy, though no one now living can say which she weighed heavier the evening she sent the word west.

Calum Ciar, when he heard of it, asked his mother only whether he too would be sent somewhere, and was told no, that the hill was his and would stay his, and he was satisfied, or seemed to be, and never again in the hearing of the hill's own telling spoke of his brother's going before it happened or after. It is told, though not by the hill's own reciters, that on the morning his brother left he stood at the gate a long time after the party was out of sight down the valley road, and that when a groom asked him if he would come in out of the wind he said he was only counting how many days it would be fifty miles there and fifty back, which is a strange thing for a man of a hundred and fifty, who looked a youth of twenty, to trouble himself with unless he means, by counting, to make a thing feel nearer than it is.

Eilidh herself did not stand at the gate. She walked with the party as far as Àth shean, a morning's distance, and there, where the road turned west and her own road turned back to the hill, she knelt to her younger son's height the way Rìonach would kneel to it again four days later, and told him three things, which the

hill's own reciters have kept whole, though nothing else of that parting: that he was not sent away for any wrong of his, that An Cnoc Ruadh would be as much his home as this one had been for as long as he needed it to be, and that she meant to see him grown, and did not doubt the years the king's blood was given would hold long enough for it. None of the household walking behind her ever said she had wept at the parting, and she did not look back down the road once she had turned her own horse toward the hill, though the steward riding beside her said afterward, to no one who ever troubled to repeat it further than his own hearth, that she was silent the whole ride home in a way he had not known her to be silent before or after.

II

Of the Road West

The boy went with two of his mother's household, a man called Donnchadh who had walked Rathad an t-Salainn¹ before and a woman called Rìonach who had kin at Àth shean and would turn off there, and he went on his own feet, for Eilidh had said that a boy fostered ought to arrive on the legs that would carry him the rest of his life at An Cnoc Ruadh² and not on a horse he would have to send home again. It was fifty miles and more from Dùn ìseal to An Cnoc Ruadh by Rathad an t-Salainn, west by south along the shoulder of the near valleys and down through country he had never seen, and it took the three of them the better part of a week's walking, sleeping the first two nights at households of the near valleys that Donnchadh knew by name and the rest under whatever roof or bank offered shelter, for Rathad an t-Salainn in those years had shelters built along it at a day's walk apart, low stone huts with a hearth-place and nothing else, raised by no one household but kept swept by whoever passed last.

He carried the shape of that week with him more than its particular days: the valleys giving way by evening stages to country that ran flatter and wetter, reed beds where herons stood so still he took them for dead trees until one moved; a night at a shelter where rain came through a gap in the roof onto Rìonach's sleeping place and she only laughed and moved her blanket, saying a roof that never let

1. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

2. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

rain through had never had a family under it; a day when Donnchadh, for no reason the boy could see, stopped on the road and looked a long while at a low green mound off to the south of it, and would not go nearer, and would not say why, only that it was older than the road and older than the salt trade and best left to whatever kept it. He asked Rìonach about it that evening and she said only that there were places on the island Seann-Dhaoine³ had left, and that a wise traveller let them lie the way he let a wasp's nest lie, out of no fear of any particular sting, only a plain sense that some things were not made for a man's curiosity to test.

Rìonach turned off for Àth shean on the fourth day, and it is told that she knelt to the boy's height before she went and told him that a household that took him in for a season, or a decade, or the rest of his growing, was not the household he had come from, and that this was a kind of doubling rather than a loss, the way a river that forks becomes two whole rivers, neither one lessened by the other; and that he would find, if he let himself, that he had two homes rather than half of one. He did not understand her then, or said he did not, though he remembered the saying well enough to repeat it, unprompted, many years and many miles from that road.

The land changed again on the fifth day: the reed country gave way to a wider sky and a smell the boy had never smelled before, which Donnchadh told him was the sea, though they were still some miles from any shore he could see, and told him also that what he was smelling under the sea was salt, and that where they were going the salt came from a lake and never from the sea at all, which the boy found so strange a thing to be told that he made Donnchadh say it twice.

They came down to the western lake shore on the sixth evening, with the light going long and gold across water that lay flat as a held breath, and a hill rising low and red-earthed on its far side with smoke standing straight up from it in the still air, and Donnchadh stopped where the road first showed it and said that was An Cnoc Ruadh, and that its line had held the lake shore before ever the king came down from the grove, and that the boy would do well to remember, walking in, that this was a hill with its own long life and its own long pride and no cause whatever to feel itself the lesser of the hill he had left.

3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

III

Of the Household of Lachlann Ruadh

Lachlann Ruadh held An Cnoc Ruadh¹ in those years, a broad, red-bearded man not yet forty, who had come to the holding young by the death of an uncle with no children of his own and had held it since with a hand that Eilidh's own steward, hearing of him later, called plain in the same word he used of Eilidh, though the two had never met. He met the boy at the gate of the hill himself rather than sending a steward to do it, with his daughter Peigi at his side, a dark, quick-eyed girl some years the elder, who looked the fosterling over with the frank, unhurried attention of a child assessing a new dog brought into a yard she considered her own, and said, before her father could say anything, that he was thin for a king's son and she supposed they would have to feed him.

Lachlann laughed at that, a big sudden laugh, the sound, the boy soon learned, of the whole household settling, and said that Peigi was to be told he was no king's son and no king's grandson either, but a boy of the ford's people come to learn a trade, the same as she would tell any fosterling from any hearth, and that if she called him otherwise even once more he would hear of it. Peigi said nothing to that, which the boy learned soon enough was her way of agreeing to nothing and losing no ground by it, and took his one bundle from him without asking and carried it in herself.

The household he found within the gate was smaller than his mother's hall and louder, a red-earthed yard with byres on two sides and a hall low and long, full, in the evenings, of more voices at once than he had ever heard indoors. Lachlann kept no steward apart from himself for the small business of the hill, weighed the salt tallies with his own hand at the season's end the way Eilidh weighed the grain, and ate at the same board as his household rather than above it, a plain oak table scarred along one edge where, Peigi told him with some pride, her grandfather's grandmother had once split it testing whether it would take an axe blow without cracking through, and it had not cracked through, and the mark was kept.

They gave him work before they gave him a name for himself, which suited him, for he had never much wanted the one he had. He carried water the first weeks, and mucked the byres alongside boys his own age who did not know or

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

greatly care whose son he was, and slept in the loft above the hall with three other fosterlings and two of the household's own younger sons, in a row of straw that Peigi ruled over, by common consent of the loft, as absolutely as her father ruled the hill below. She was not gentle with him, in those first months, in any way that a reciter would trouble to soften in the telling: she corrected his speech of An Cnoc Ruadh when it slipped into the hill-talk of Dùn ìseal, laughed without much mercy the first time he fell into the lake wading for reeds, and once, when he cried in the loft at night in the second week and thought the others asleep, said nothing at the time but the next morning set herself beside him at the water-carrying without being asked and stayed there the whole of that day and most days after, which was, in its way, the kinder of the two responses and the one he remembered longer.

By the second year he had stopped thinking of the loft as a strange bed and started thinking of his own hall at Dùn ìseal, when word of it reached him, as the place his mother was rather than the place he lived; and it is told, though only by An Cnoc Ruadh's own reciters and in a single line that the hill of Dùn ìseal has never troubled to dispute or confirm, that Lachlann Ruadh came to think of him, within a few years, less as a hostage of peace than as a son the sea had lent him, and treated him accordingly, teaching him himself the reading of weather off the lake and the working of the salt-rakes, skills he might as easily have left to a steward and did not.

Word travelled between the two hills that season and the next along Rathad an t-Salainn² itself, carried in the mouths of the carriers who walked it, for no household of either hill troubled to send a letter where a spoken word would do as well and travel as far. The boy learned, in this way and no other, that his brother had been given the judging of the near valleys' boundary stones that year, a small trust but the first of its kind, and that Calum Ciar had settled a dispute between two herders over a shifted marker with a plainness their mother was said to have approved of; and Calum Ciar, in the same way and by the same road, learned that his brother had grown a hand's breadth since the spring and had been let out on the lake in a boat for the first time and had come back wet through and pleased with himself. Neither brother sent more than that. An Cnoc Ruadh's telling is careful to say this was no coldness between them; it was only that two brothers, the one a boy and the other long grown though he looked a youth, living fifty

2. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

miles apart had, with each season, less to say that a carrier's memory could hold whole, and more that belonged only to the hearth where each now slept.

Eilidh herself came once, in the third year of the fostering, on no business but the seeing of him that she had promised at the ford, and stayed four days at An Cnoc Ruadh as Lachlann's guest rather than as any holder visiting another's ground, sitting at the same scarred board the household ate from and asking after the tallies and the weather no differently than she asked after her son. It is told that when she left, the boy walked with her as far as the lake's western point, the furthest edge of ground the household called its own, and that she told him there, out of Lachlann's hearing, that she did not intend to come again for some years, out of no want of missing him, only a plain knowledge that a boy who watched the road too often for his mother's coming would never quite finish becoming An Cnoc Ruadh's own; and he understood her, this time, without needing Rìonach's river to explain it to him, and did not watch the road after that, or not so that anyone at An Cnoc Ruadh ever caught him at it.

IV

Of the Lake and the Name Not Kept

The salt of An Cnoc Ruadh¹ did not come, as the boy had first thought when Donnchadh told him so on the road, from the sea at all, though the sea lay close enough to smell on any west wind; it came from the shallow western reach of the lake, where the water stood warm and still in the summer months and drew down in a dry year until its margin turned white with a crust that the household raked into baskets and carried up to dry on stone platforms above the shore. It was slower work than sea-salt and finer for it, prized on Rathad an t-Salainn² of the ford above the coarser grey stuff of the tidal pans, and the raking of it was a skill An Cnoc Ruadh kept jealously among its own households and taught to no fosterling until it judged him ready, for a rake dragged wrong through the crust broke it into the mud beneath and lost a season's crust to nothing.

He was eight years old, in the third summer of his fostering, when Lachlann himself put a rake into his hands for the first time and stood behind him on the

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

drying platform to show him the turn of the wrist that lifted the crust clean without breaking it into the black mud under it, a turn Lachlann said had come down in his own family longer than An Cnoc Ruadh's own list could count, mother's hand to daughter's hand and, where there was no daughter, father's hand to whatever child stood nearest and willing. The boy broke the first three strokes of crust into the mud as any beginner did, and Lachlann said nothing but only turned the rake a little in his own grip to show the angle again, and by the fourth stroke he had it, a full clean sheet of white lifted whole onto the rake's flat and held there, and Peigi, who had come down to watch with no pretence that she had come for any other reason, said that was better than she had managed her first year and she would not have believed it of him.

It is a small thing to be given the first time a boy rakes salt without breaking it, and no reciter of Dùn ìseal has ever thought it worth the keeping; but An Cnoc Ruadh kept it, in its own way, the way An Cnoc Ruadh kept most things that mattered to it and let the hill of Rìghrean na Cloiche³ keep the rest. The peace of the ford held, those years, without a word said of it at either hall; Rathad an t-Salainn ran as it had always run; and if any at Dùn ìseal wondered, in the wet seasons when word came west and east along the road with the salt-carriers, whether the boy sent away at six was thriving where he had been sent, the answer that came back, carried in a salt-carrier's mouth rather than in any letter, was only that he was well, and growing, and had taken to the lake.

An Cnoc Ruadh's own list, in those years, began a habit it would keep the rest of Lachlann Ruadh's holding and after: when the reciters spoke of him, weighing his years against his father's and his father's father's, they had taken to adding, more often than not, a second name after the first, so that he was Lachlann Ruadh and, in near the same breath, Lachlann an Altraim, Lachlann of the fostering, until in time the second name outran the first in the mouths of those who had never known him by any other, and the list, kept by rote from reciter to reciter, began to give the one where it might once have given the other. No one at An Cnoc Ruadh could afterward have said the day the habit started, only that it had, sometime in those years the boy grew from six to eight and learned the turn of a salt-rake on the lake shore under Lachlann's own hand, and that once started it was never afterward unsaid.

Of the boy's own name in those same years, the hill's own telling, both the hill of Rìghrean na Cloiche and An Cnoc Ruadh after it, keeps nothing at all. His

mother's name for him was spoken daily by the household that raised him, kept whole in every hearing; it is only that neither list, in the long custom that grew up around the two of them, ever troubled to set it down, An Cnoc Ruadh because he was not yet its own and the hill of Dùn ìseal because he was, by then, no longer entirely theirs to claim. So he passed into both tellings, and out of them, as he had come, without one, called only the fosterling by the hearth that kept him and, more rarely as the years went on, the boy who went by the hearth that had sent him.

2. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

3. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

OF OIGHRIG'S LOT AND THE STONE CUP

GE 2,403 – 2,408

Chan e mo làmh-sa a th' ann, ach làmh gach teallaich. It is not my
hand; it is the hand of every hearth.

— Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill, at the grinding of the cup, as the hearths
of Tobar dhìreach keep it

I

Of the Turns that Wore Thin

This is told at Tobar dhìreach by whoever sits the night watch, and has been told so long that the telling has worn as smooth as the slab itself.

For as long as anyone at Tobar dhìreach could reckon, the slab had been watched by households in their turn, one family a night, drawn from a list that the eldest of the hill kept in her head and nowhere else. It had begun, so the old ones said, in the dark of a Samhain so far back that even the list-keepers before this one could not put a year to it: a scatter of families who lived near the crack in the ground had taken, without any word said over it, to sitting by the stain in the stone a household at a time, watching for they knew not what. No one had ever seen the slab do anything. It lay grey and split-veined in its clearing, cold to the hand in every season, with the one dark stain at its lower edge that no rain had ever washed paler, and generation on generation had sat by it through the short nights and the long ones and gone home in the morning with nothing to tell.

By the year the families met to change the custom, the list had grown past what any one head could hold true. Thirty-one households stood on it, scattered

from the near slopes to a full day's walk east, and the eldest who kept it, a woman named Beathag who had held the list eleven years and outlived two husbands doing it, had begun to lose the order of it the way a rope frays first at the place it is handled most. A household from the far end of the valley had come two nights running the summer before, thinking its turn was owed, and found no one else at the slab either night, the family before them having gone home a day early on the strength of a different memory of the order entirely. Nothing had come of the gap. Nothing ever came of any night at the slab, watched or not. But it sat wrong with the hill-folk that a thing so old should be let go untended even by accident, and it was Beathag herself, in the year of her own eldest son's death, who said at the Samhain gathering that she would keep no more lists, and that the hill had better find another way.

They met at the slab itself to talk it over, as such things were talked over on the hill, standing in the clearing in the last mild days before the dark half of the year, thirty-odd households or their heads, with children running at the clearing's edge and old men leaning on staffs and a wind coming down off Na Glinn Àrda¹ that smelled already of the winter behind it. Some wanted the list kept by two heads instead of one, so that memory might check memory. Some wanted no watch at all, arguing, not for the first time and not to be the last, that a stone which had done nothing in a thousand years of watching was unlikely to begin now for want of a night's neglect. It was an old man near the front, whom the telling does not name, who said at last that if the trouble was that no head could hold thirty-one households fairly in order, then perhaps no head should try, and that the thing should be given to chance instead, the way a household chose which child herded the goats on a wet morning: by lot, one keeper at a time, until that keeper's own life gave the place up.

The hill settled such matters by silence, as it always had. The silence held long enough that the old man took it for agreement, and no one afterward said he had read it wrong. Before the light went that day it was settled between them, without any of them quite deciding when the deciding had happened, that a single keeper would be chosen from among all the households by lot, would keep the slab alone or with whatever kin wished to sit by her, and would go on keeping it until death or infirmity called for another lot to be drawn.

Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill stood near the back of the gathering that day with her shawl pulled over her head against the first spits of rain, three-and-thirty years

old and thinking, so far as the telling lets her think anything at all in that hour, of nothing more than whether her own turn at the slab fell that week or the next. Her household was among the thirty-one. She had sat the night watch herself perhaps a dozen times since she was old enough to be trusted not to fall asleep against the stone, and had seen, on every one of those nights, exactly what every watcher before her had seen: a slab, a stain, a silence, and morning.

II

Of the Lot

The lots were drawn a fortnight later, at the next full dark, because a fortnight seemed to the hill-folk long enough to be fair and not so long that anyone would forget the agreement had been made. A leather bag was found, old and much mended, that had once held a household's spindle-whorls and now held one white pebble marked with a single scratch and thirty small dark stones that were not. Beathag herself, freed at last of the list she had kept eleven years, held the bag closed in both hands until every household had sent forward the one member the lot would fall on, by whatever rule of age or standing each house kept for such things; Oighrig's father, a herder of the near slopes named Dòmhnall who owned no more of the hill than any other man of that name and was kin to none of the old kings, sent his daughter forward because she was neither his eldest nor his youngest and it had fallen to her by a rule of his own that he never explained to anyone, least of all to her.

It rained that night, a fine soft rain that put no one off standing in the clearing, and the slab shone black with it under the last light. Oighrig stood in the ring of thirty-one with her hood down around her shoulders because the hood caught the rain worse than her hair did, and watched each in turn go forward, put a hand into the bag Beathag held, and draw out a stone. She had counted, without meaning to, that she stood eleventh from the front, and had spent most of the wait working out from the rate the others drew and were disappointed that there was no way to know, from a stone already drawn, whether the white one had gone before her turn or not.

When her turn came she put her hand into the bag the way she had put it into every dark bag of grain or wool her whole life, without ceremony, and felt the

stones knock cold against her knuckles, more of them than she had expected for how few households remained undrawn, and closed her fingers on the first one they found. She brought it out already knowing, from the shape of it under her thumb before she ever opened her hand, that it was not like the others; the mark ran deep enough to catch a nail.

It is told that she stood a moment with her fist closed and the rain running off her knuckles, and that the two women nearest her, who had already seen the white edge of it between her fingers, said nothing to hurry her, out of a courtesy the telling does not explain and does not need to. When she opened her hand at last, Beathag saw it first of anyone, and let the empty bag fall to her side, and said only, "That's it, then," in a voice with no more weight in it than if the matter had been who carried water that week.

No one cheered, for it was not a thing to cheer, and no one wept, for it was not yet a thing to weep over either. An old woman near her touched Oighrig's shoulder once, the way a hand is laid on a shoulder at a grave rather than a wedding, and stepped back into the ring. Oighrig looked at the pebble a long while in the failing light, turning it so the scratch caught what was left of the day, and then at the slab itself, grey and rain-black in the clearing where it had lain since before her grandmother's grandmother watched it, and put the stone into her belt, where the hill's own telling says she carried it the rest of her life.

She walked home behind her father that night without either of them saying much, and it was her father, not she, who broke the silence somewhere along the track, saying only that he had not looked to send a daughter of his to a stone for the rest of her days when he sent her forward that evening, and had not looked, either, to be asked by every stranger on Rathad an t-Salainn¹ for the next forty years whether he was kin to the king because he shared a name with the king's own son who held the north. It was the first either of them had said aloud of a thing that would follow her the whole of her keeping: that hill-folk who did not know the near slopes heard "nic Dhòmhnaill" and thought at once of Dòmhnall Clachach, third of Rìghrean na Cloiche², who held the north those very years and was, by every account the reciters kept, no kin at all to a herder of Tobar dhìreach's low pastures. Oighrig herself had to say it plainly more times than she troubled to count, to travellers who came up the valley expecting to find the old

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

1. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

king's blood keeping the slab and found instead a herder's daughter with wet feet and no patience for the question: her father was Dòmhnall the herder, no more and no less, and the name had never carried further than that.

III

Of the House with the Door to the Slab

The families raised her a house before the year was out, on the clearing's edge where the ground rose just enough to keep it dry, of the same turf and stone as any hill house save that its door was set to face the slab and no other way, so that whoever slept in it woke each morning looking straight along the floor at the stone she had drawn for. It was, so far as anyone on the hill could say, the first building on all of Dia-thir raised for no reason but to stand near the vein, and it stood so plainly for that one purpose that even children who had never been told so understood it at a glance, the way a child knows a byre from a house without being told which beasts live in which.

Oighrig moved into it in the first hard frost of that winter, and found the sitting harder alone than it had ever been in turn with her own household beside her. The nights of a shared watch had passed in low talk and the passing back and forth of a skin of buttermilk and the small complaints of people who would be gone home by morning regardless of what the night gave them. A keeper's nights, she found, ran differently. She sat them mostly by herself those first months, for though her own kin and any others were welcome to sit with her and often did in the early evenings, none of them slept there, and by full dark she was alone with the slab and whatever wind came down off Na Glinn Àrda¹, and no list to check the next night against, only the one long unbroken watch that had no end she could see from where she sat.

She was not unhappy in it, the telling is careful to say, though it does not say she was happy either. That first winter gave her time to notice things about the slab that thirty-one households taking turns for a thousand years had somehow not troubled to set down in any telling she had ever heard: that the stain at its lower edge was darkest in wet weather and paled, though it never wholly vanished, in a dry summer; that the stone held the day's warmth an hour or two longer than

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

the ground around it in autumn and lost it faster in spring, as though its temper ran contrary to the world's; that a hare had made its form under the slab's overhanging lip and raised two litters there in the years Oighrig watched, undisturbed by whatever the stone was or was not. None of this, she told the few who asked her directly, amounted to an answer to anything. She had sat by the slab longer now than any single household of the old rota ever had at a stretch, and had seen, she said plainly to a traveller who pressed her on it one spring evening, no more of what the stone was for than the traveller himself had seen, standing in the clearing a single afternoon.

What she had begun to see, by the second year of her keeping, was a different trouble altogether, and one nearer her own hand to mend. The handful of coal that each household of the near valleys burned in its own custom, the small ration of the vein's an gual dathach² that a family measured for itself against the cold, was measured by nothing more exact than the cup of whatever hand did the measuring that year, a mother's palm or a grandfather's or a growing son's, so that one household's handful ran near double another's without either house meaning to cheat its neighbour of anything. It had never much mattered while the custom was young and the vein plentiful and no keeper stood over the counting of it. It mattered more, Oighrig came slowly to think, sitting alone by the stone through the second dark half of her keeping, now that the slab had a single keeper whose word the hill was beginning, without quite meaning to, to ask after on other matters too.

IV

Of the Cup Ground to Her Hand

She went to Niocol Snaidhear in the spring of her third year, a man of the near slopes some ten years older than herself who had worked stone since he was a boy old enough to hold a hammer without dropping it on his own foot, grinding querns and hearthstones and, once, a trough for a household too grand for a wooden one. He kept a low shed at the edge of his own ground with a bench worn white at one end from decades of the same motion, and Oighrig found him there of a wet afternoon with a half-finished quern between

2. the coloured coal

his knees and stone dust in the creases of his hands that no washing ever wholly got out.

She did not, by her own account afterward, come to him with much of a notion of what she wanted, only a trouble she had turned over enough nights by the slab to have worn its shape smooth. She set her own right hand on the bench before him, cupped as if to catch water poured from a height, and told him she wanted a cup ground of grey stone that would hold exactly what that hand held and no grain more, so that whatever household measured its handful against it would measure the same as every other household on the hill, and none would ever again burn double its neighbour's share by the accident of whose palm did the measuring.

Nicol looked at the hand a long while before he answered, turning it a little under the shed's poor light, and said at last that a hand was not a thing to copy in stone the way a quern's face was copied from another quern; a hand curled differently full than empty, and differently cold than warm, and he would need, he thought, more sittings of her than she would likely have patience for before he was done. She told him she had nothing but patience, now, and came back to the shed eleven times that summer and into the following one, each time setting her hand to the bench in the same attitude, cupped, fingers a little curled, while he worked a lump of the grey stone down with chisel and rubbing-stone and, in the last weeks, nothing but a wetted thumb and infinite slow patience of his own.

Two cups cracked in the grinding before the third one held. The first split along a vein no eye had seen in the raw stone, in the last week of shaping, and Nicol swept the pieces into a corner of the shed without a word Oighrig heard him say about it, and began again from a fresh block the following morning as though the loss cost him nothing, though she noted, and said later that she had noted, that his hands shook a little at the first cuts of the new stone in a way they had not shaken at the last cuts of the old one. The second held longer, near to finished, before a blow struck a shade too hard opened a hair-crack across its base that would have let the coal run out one grain at a time, worse than no measure at all; that one he kept on the bench through the whole of the third cup's grinding, turning to it now and then as a man turns to a mistake he means to learn the whole measure of before he lets it go.

The third cup he fitted to her hand again and again through that second summer, grinding a hair's width here, a hair's width there, until it sat in the hollow of her palm the way, so the telling says, an egg sits in a nest that has been shaped

around it and no other. It was smaller than either of the two that had cracked, and darker in the stone, veined faintly white through its base, and cold in the hand even on a warm day the way all the vein's stone ran cold, and it held, when she filled it once with water to be sure, exactly what her one hand held cupped, and no more.

It is told, though the telling itself allows that no one but Oighrig could have known whether she truly said it or the words only settled onto her afterward the way words settle onto anyone whose life the hill comes to measure by, that she stood in the shed with the finished cup in her hand and said to Niocol, who had by then spent the better part of two years of his working life on the shape of her one hand, that the stone held the hand of every hearth on the near slopes, hers no more than any woman's who would ever fill it. Niocol, whom the telling gives no word of his own in reply, is said only to have gone back to his bench and begun, without being asked, on a second cup, meaning it from the first stroke to be a copy and not an original, for he had already understood, before she ever said as much to him plainly, that one keeper's cup in one keeper's house would settle nothing for households that could not walk to Tobar dhìreach and back inside a winter's day.

V

Of the Copies

Word of the cup went out along the near valleys faster than any single teller could account for having carried it, the way word does travel when it answers a trouble every hearth already knew it had without having words for it. Within the year, stone-workers at three other places had heard enough of the shape and the reason to ask for cups of their own ground against it: a woman at Àth gharbh, where the ford crossed Rathad an t-Salainn¹ and half the near valley's flint passed through on its way south; an old man at Achadh dhìreach, whose own hearthstone still bore, though few remembered why, a long-healed crack where a fire had once run colour under the king's own hand; and a household at Cnoc chaol, a full day's walk east of the slab, on ground poor

1. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

enough that its people had less coal to measure than most and cared more than most, for that reason, that the measuring be exact.

Oighrig walked to each in turn over the space of a year, carrying the first cup wrapped in wool in a satchel she would let no one else carry for her. In the two years of its making she had grown into the habit of having it always at her own hand, and trusted no other hand to keep it safe on the road. At Àth gharbh the stone-worker ground her copy against Oighrig's own in three sittings, quicker than Niocol had managed the first, for she had his cup before her the whole time to measure against rather than a hand alone; at Achadh dhìreach the old man took longer, being slower now in his hands than he once was, but got there in the end with his grandson holding the light for him through the last evenings; at Cnoc chaol the household set two of its own young people to the grinding turn and turn about, and finished theirs inside a single season, being, as Oighrig said afterward with something that in a less careful woman might have been taken for pride, the quickest hands of the four though the last to begin.

Each copy she filled with water against the first before she would call it done, pouring from one to the other on a flat stone in the open air where any of the household could watch and see for themselves that the levels matched to a hair, and where they did not match she said so plainly and sent the worker back to the wheel, twice at Achadh dhìreach and once, to the grandson's very open disappointment, at Cnoc chaol. No cup left her hand called finished until it held water level with the first, and none of the three stone-workers, whatever else the telling says of them, is recorded arguing the point with her once she had shown them the difference with their own water and their own eyes.

VI

Of the Meeting of the Cups

The four cups were brought together at last in the last mild days before the dark half of the year, on a stretch of open moor between Àth gharbh and Tobar dhìreach where a spring rose clear and cold out of a bed of grey stone and ran a little way before losing itself again in the heather. It had no name before that day that any telling keeps. Oighrig had chosen it, so far as she chose anything about the meeting rather than let the four keepers of the cups choose it between them, because it lay roughly equal walking from all four places and be-

cause the spring gave water enough and to spare for whatever filling and comparing the day required, and because, she said to more than one who asked her why there and not somewhere nearer the slab, a measure that was to belong to no one house had no business being fixed on any one house's ground.

They came in the cold clear morning of a day the hill-folk would go on keeping, in one way or another, for as long as the custom of the coal lasted: the woman from Àth gharbh with her cup in a bag of oiled hide against the damp; the old man from Achadh dhìreach carried in a cart the last mile by his grandson, his own legs no longer equal to the walk though his hands had lost none of their sureness; the two young people from Cnoc chaol, who had walked through the night to be there by first light and showed it in the set of their shoulders; and Oighrig herself, with the first cup, the one that had cost Niocol two broken stones and the better part of two years, wrapped as always in its wool.

They set all four on a flat stone at the spring's edge, side by side in the low light, and filled each in turn from the same water, and passed each cup along the line of four for every hand there to weigh in turn, a courtesy none of them had been asked to keep, kept without discussion, as though the measure required the handling of every hand it would ever serve before it could be trusted to serve any one of them alone. The water stood level in all four to the eye of everyone who looked, and to the more careful eye of Niocol, who had walked up from his own ground to see the meeting though none of the day's work was left for him to do, and who said only, when asked, that he could find no fault in any of the four and would say so to anyone who doubted him.

It is that place the hill has called, from that morning on, Coinneachadh nan Cupan¹, though nothing marks it beyond the flat stone and the spring that still rises there for whoever comes to fill a fifth cup against the first four, should one ever need making, or a broken one ever need replacing against the whole line of them. The families of the near valleys and the far, from the slopes above Tobar dhìreach to the poor ground at Cnoc chaol, took the four cups home with them that evening each to its own place, and from that year the hill-folk measured the coal of their handfuls by one measure and not by the accident of whichever hand did the measuring, a thing so small in the telling of it and so large in the daily life of every hearth that touched it that the hill's own reciters, when they came at last to set the year down, gave it no more than a line: that in the years of Oighrig's

1. the meeting of the cups

keeping, the hills came to measure with one measure, and had not measured otherwise since.

OF the Coal that Went Home

GE 2,409 – 2,416

Chaidh an gual dhachaigh. The coal went home.
— the households near the slab, of the coal Gilleasbuig took, as the
hearth of Tobar dhìreach still say it

I

Of Gilleasbuig's Turn

Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill kept the slab for the rest of her life, as the lot had given it her, and the rest of her life was shorter than anyone at the clearing had looked for. She came back from Coinneachadh nan Cupan¹ on the moor in the dark of the year with a cough the wind had put into her on the walk, and would not lie down for it, and sat her nights at the stone as she had always sat them; and before the turn of the year she died in Taigh na Lice² with the door open on the slab, as she had asked, and the first cup in her hand. The families buried her at the clearing's edge, the first keeper by lot to be buried by the stone she had kept, and said afterward that six years had been time enough for her to give the hill the one measure, and not a season more. But the bag of pebbles was filled again, one marked among the rest, and passed hand to hand among the households who stood the watch, and it was a man named Gilleasbuig Beag, of a family

1. the meeting of the cups

2. the house of the slab at Tobar dhìreach

that had come to the near valley only in his father's time, whose hand came out holding the white stone.

Giorsal Bhàn stood in that ring with the rest of her household the day the lot fell to him, a young woman not yet thirty with a husband two years married and no child yet at her skirts, and she remembered after, though it meant nothing to her at the time, that Gilleasbuig had gone pale rather than glad when he opened his hand and saw what was in it, the way some men do at good news as readily as bad, and that his wife beside him had laughed once, sharply, and then put her hand over her own mouth as if the laugh had got out before she meant it to. He was a broad, quiet man who cut good hazel withies and mended a roof as well as any three men on the near slopes, and no one standing in the clearing that day would have named him first, or last, among those it might fall to. That was the whole of the custom's mercy and its whole danger both: that the stone did not choose by what a household already knew of a man.

He kept the watch as any keeper kept it, through that first winter and on into the summer, sitting the cold nights at the slab with whichever of his own kin cared to sit beside him, walking the clearing at first light to see that nothing lay disturbed, carrying water up from the spring for whoever came to fill a cup against Oighrig's. Giorsal's own household lived near enough the clearing that she saw him often in those years, going to and from his own door with an axe or a creel on his back like any other man of the hill, and she thought no more of him than she thought of any neighbour whose turn had fallen on him rather than her.

It was in the first summer of his keeping, a lean one on the near slopes with the grazing thin and the stores stretched further than any household liked to see them stretched, that a woman of Gilleasbuig's own kin, going into his house on some other errand while he was from home, found a basket set back under the bed-place with a cloth over it, and lifted the cloth thinking it food, and found instead a basket of an gual dathach³, broken small, more than any hand could have gathered by accident and more, by a long way, than the handful any hearth was allowed. She did not touch it. She put the cloth back as she had found it and left the house and told no one that day, being kin to him and slow to believe her own eyes; but she told her husband before she slept, and by the third day it was known past any hope of its being unknown, the way such things always were on the near

3. the coloured coal

slopes, where one door stood close enough to the next that a secret kept in one house was a secret only until the wind carried a word of it as far as the well.

II

Of the Judgement at the Slab

The families sent for Gilleasbuig to come to the clearing on a morning when the frost still lay white in the shadow of the stone and had not yet burned off the open ground where the sun reached it, and he came, and Giorsal, standing near the back of the gathering with her husband's arm through hers against the cold, thought afterward that she had never seen a man walk so far to reach so short a distance. He did not deny it when it was put to him. He stood with his hands loose at his sides, not folded, not fisted, and said only that the basket was his and the coal in it was his, taken by his own hand from the crack he was set to watch, and that he had meant, when he took it, to use it against a winter he could see coming a long way off, for a mother of his who was old and slept cold, and for nothing else that he would name.

No one at the clearing that morning doubted that this much was true. It was the *use* of the coal that shook them, not the greed of it, for there was no greed to be seen in a man who had taken it to warm an old woman's bones and not to sell it on any road; and it was for that reason, more than any other, that the judgement took as long as it did, the families standing in the cold arguing among themselves in low voices while Gilleasbuig waited in the middle of them and said nothing further, as if the matter had already left his hands the moment the cloth came off the basket.

It was an old woman of Cnoc chaol, who had walked the better part of a day to be at the judgement because her own household held one of the four cups and felt the matter touched her as nearly as it touched the slab's own valley, who said at last what none of the near families had quite been willing to say first: that the coal was not Gilleasbuig's to spend on any love, however true, because it had never once, since the crack was first watched, been any single household's to keep behind a cloth under a bed. The custom had never asked a keeper to love the vein less than his own kin. It had only ever asked him to hold nothing of it back from every hearth that had a claim on the handful, his own included, and take no more for one house's fire than the vein gave to any other's.

They sat him at last under judgement the way the hill had always judged such things when a household was put out for hoarding grain against the storm-sharing: by the silence that follows, once every voice in the clearing has said its piece and no voice rises after to say different. The silence held long enough that morning, with the frost gone from the open ground and the sun well up, that there was no mistaking it for anything but agreement. Gilleasbuig was told he would be rowed out to Eilean chrom, the low island that lay off the near coast with nothing on it a household could live from, and left there without a boat to bring himself back in; and the coal, the same voice went on, once the old woman of Cnoc chaol had named the island, would go neither to any fire nor back into any basket a living hand might carry home, but would be carried instead to the slab's own edge and given back to the ground it had come from.

Gilleasbuig said one thing more before they took him down to the shore, and it was the only thing Giorsal, standing near enough by then to hear it plainly, ever heard him say with any heat in his voice at all: that his mother would sleep cold that winter whichever way the judgement fell, whether the coal burned in her hearth or lay under a stone she would never see, and that he did not understand what the stone gained by having it back that the old woman did not lose by going without it. No one answered him. It was not, Giorsal thought afterward, a question the clearing had ever troubled to answer, and perhaps for that reason no one there was willing to invent one on the spot, with the man standing before them waiting to hear it.

III

Of Eilean chrom

They rowed him out in the afternoon of that same day, three men of the near households taking one boat between them with Gilleasbuig sitting in the stern and saying nothing more the whole crossing, by the telling of the men who were there and told it after. Eilean chrom lay low and treeless a short pull off the coast, grazed once by nobody's sheep and fished by nobody's nets even before that day, a spit of grass and grey rock with a spring at its middle that never failed and nothing else on it a person could live from beyond what the tide gave up. They put him ashore on its lee side, where the landing was easiest, and pulled the boat back out into open water while he stood on the shingle and watched

them go, and none of the three who told it afterward could agree on whether he had raised a hand to them or not, though all three agreed he had not called out.

Giorsal did not see the crossing herself. She heard it told twice over in the days after, once by one of the three oarsmen at his own door and once by his wife, who repeated it word for careful word as if the repeating were its own kind of keeping. But she saw the fire.

It stood on Eilean chrom's low rise that first night, small and steady against the dark water, and half the near coast came out to its own doors to look at it, some out of pity and some out of nothing kinder than the wanting to see a thing everyone else was seeing. It burned again the second night, smaller, Giorsal thought, though she could not have sworn to it across that distance and in that light. On the third night it was there again at dusk, no more than a coal's worth of red low down near the shingle, gone before the deepest part of the dark, and after that no one on the near coast, watching night after night through a week and then a month of watching, ever saw a fire on Eilean chrom again.

No boat went out to it. The judgement had left him there without one, and no household, whatever it felt in its own heart about the man or the coal, was willing to be the one to row out and learn for certain what three nights of fire and no fire after meant. Eilean chrom stood empty from that season on, ungrazed and unfished, the way it had stood before Gilleasbuig was put on it and the way, so far as Giorsal Bhàn ever lived to see, it went on standing after. Children on the near coast were told, in time, not to ask about the island with the spring on it, and most of them grew up asking anyway, the way children always did about the one thing they were told not to, and were given the same short answer each time: that a man had kept the watch there once, and did not keep it well, and that no one had gone near the island since, and no one would.

IV

Of the Second Lot and the Basket Unburned

The basket itself came to the slab's own household before the month of the fires was out, carried by the same kin who had first lifted the cloth from it, set down just inside the door of Taigh na Lice¹ the way a thing is set down

1. the house of the slab at Tobar dhìreach

that no one wants to be the one to have carried the whole way in and put where it belonged. It sat there through the rest of that season under its own cloth, and every household near the crack knew it was there, and not one of them, in all the low talk that ran up and down the near valley in those weeks, ever proposed that it should be burned. It had not been theirs to burn before Gilleasbuig took it, and his taking it had not made it burnable; if anything the judgement had settled, past any further arguing, that it never would be.

The lot for a new keeper was drawn within the same season, at the clearing, in the same bag of pebbles that had given the stone to Oighrig and then to Gilleasbuig, and this time it was Giorsal Bhàn's hand that came out of the bag holding the white stone. She had stood at enough of these drawings by then, her own household near enough the crack that she was seldom far from one, to know what was expected of whoever the lot found; what she had not known, until she felt the pebble cold against her palm and understood from the faces around her before she had properly opened her own hand what it was, was how little warning the stone gave before it changed a life. Her husband put his arm round her the way Gilleasbuig's wife had once nearly laughed; Giorsal did neither. She looked at the stone a while, the way Oighrig was said to have looked at hers years before, and then closed her hand on it and said she would keep it.

She moved into Taigh na Lice at Tobar dhìreach before the month was out, her husband and, before long, a first child with her, and took up the night-watches and the water-carrying and the weighing of cups against her own the way every keeper before her had taken them up. But the basket was hers now too, set inside the door under its cloth, and she found in the first weeks of her keeping that she could not walk past it without her eyes going to it, the way a sore tooth draws the tongue whether the tongue means to go there or not.

It was on a still evening near the year's turn, with the frost already down and the last of the light going grey over the clearing, that she lifted the cloth herself and looked at what was under it: broken coal, small pieces, no different to the eye from any handful any hearth on the near slopes was owed by right, and yet made wrong, entirely and past mending, by nothing more than whose hand had gathered it and how. She thought of Gilleasbuig's mother sleeping cold that winter regardless, as he had said she would; she thought of the fire on Eilean chrom, three nights and then none; and she understood, kneeling there with the basket open in front of her in the last of the light, that there was only the one

place left on the whole island where that coal could go that would not make a liar of the judgement that had sent a man to an island without a boat over it.

V

Of the Coal that Went Home

She carried the basket to the slab's own edge on the first clear morning after, kneeling on the same cold ground where she had knelt through half a year of night-watches by then, and set it down beside her, and began to lay the coal back under the stone's lower lip, piece by piece, pressing each fragment into the dark gap where the slab met the earth until her fingers found the give of the loosened soil and the piece would sit and hold. It was slower work than she had looked for. The gap ran narrow in places and wide in others, and more than once a piece she thought settled worked itself loose again when she reached for the next, so that she had to go back and press it in a second time, and a third, before it would keep. She worked through most of that morning and came back to finish it the next, the basket half empty and then near empty and then, on the second day, holding nothing at all.

No one had told her to do it that way, piece by piece with her own two hands rather than tipped out all at once the way a lazier keeper might have emptied it and called the matter closed. She did it slowly because it seemed to her, kneeling there with the cold coming up through the ground into her knees the way it must have come up through Oighrig's, that a thing taken wrongly, however small each piece of it, ought at least to be given back with the same care it had been taken with, if not more; and because, though she never said this to anyone in so many words, she wanted, when it was done, to be able to say truly that her own hand had put every last piece of it back where it belonged, and not merely that the basket had been emptied.

It is from that unhurried morning, and the second morning after it, that the hearths near the slab keep the four words that are still said of the whole matter, short enough that a child can carry them whole after hearing them once: that the coal went home. Giorsal Bhàn never claimed to have made the saying herself, and by her own telling, given late in her life to whoever asked her about those years, she could not afterward say for certain who had said it first, in her hearing or out of it; only that by the following summer it was already going round the near valley

as if it had always been there, the way the truest sayings on the hill always seemed to arrive already old.

VI

Of Calum Ciar and the Lot at Dùn ìseal

Word of the judgement, and of what the new keeper had done with the basket after, travelled Rathad an t-Salainn¹ and Rathad na Spor² both before that year was out, and reached Dùn ìseal in the mouth of some traveller or other long before any of the households near the slab thought to send it there on purpose, for the crack had never asked the hill of Rìghrean na Cloiche³ for leave to judge its own. It was two summers later, by Giorsal's own reckoning, that Calum Ciar himself came up the valley to the clearing, the elder son of Eilidh Ghlas and eleventh to hold Dùn ìseal under the king, a broad grey-eyed man well past his hundred and fiftieth year who carried himself, even walking alone and unarmed among households that owed him no more than any household owed the hill, as a man used to being listened to.

He did not come, he said, standing where Gilleasbuig had once stood to hear his own judgement, to question what had been done to Gilleasbuig or where the coal had gone after; both, he allowed, had been done as the custom asked, and he had no quarrel with either. What he asked was smaller, and larger, both at once: that the next time the bag of pebbles was filled, it should be filled and drawn at Dùn ìseal, in his own sight, so that the hill that held the grazing and called the gatherings and answered to the king for both might see with its own eyes that the lot which decided who kept the vein was drawn as honestly as the lot which had once, in Oighrig's year, decided the same thing at the clearing.

Giorsal stood near enough that day to see his face while the families gave him their answer, and she thought, though she never said so where it might travel back to Dùn ìseal, that he had not looked for the answer he got. The households near the crack held their silence the way they had held it over Gilleasbuig, long enough and level enough that there was no mistaking it, and it was the same old woman of Cnoc chaol, grown older still, who said at last what the silence had already said:

1. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

2. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

3. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

that the lot had been drawn at the slab since the custom first began, and would go on being drawn there, in the sight of whoever near the crack cared to stand and watch it, and that Dùn ìseal's sight, however honestly meant, was not a thing the vein had ever asked for or needed.

Calum Ciar heard it out and did not argue it there in the clearing, which Giorsal set down afterward, when she spoke of that day at all, as the one thing in his favour that she never forgot. He thanked the families for hearing him and went back down the valley the way he had come, and it was only later, from travellers again rather than from any word Dùn ìseal troubled to send the slab, that she learned he had carried the same question on to the king himself, at the ford that same summer where the two hills met each year over salt and wool.

VII

Of the Unwritten Line

What passed between Calum Ciar and the king at the ford, Giorsal Bhàn never heard first-hand, and neither, so far as she ever learned, did anyone near the slab; it came to the near valley the way most things from the ford came to it, worn a little smoother with every mouth it passed through on the way. But the words that reached her, and that she went on repeating to whoever asked her of it in the years after, in nearly one shape from the first telling to the last, were these: that the king had heard Calum Ciar out as the families at the clearing had heard him out, without anger and without haste, and had said at the end of it only that the slab was older than the hill, and older than the grove where he himself had first been crowned, and that he would not overrule a thing that old for the asking of a man not two hundred years in the world.

Calum Ciar went home from the ford, the telling said, and asked nothing more of it. The lot went on being drawn at the slab, as it had been drawn for Oighrig and for Gilleasbuig and for Giorsal herself, and no household near the crack ever again heard Dùn ìseal ask to stand over the bag of pebbles while it was filled. The hill ruled the grazing in those years, and called the gatherings, and answered for both to the king; the keepers ruled the vein, and answered for it to no one the telling could name, not even, when it came to it, to the king himself. It was a line drawn nowhere on any stone and sworn to in no words either side troubled to write down, and it held, so far as Giorsal Bhàn lived to see it hold, for

every year of her keeping after; and when she was old, and her own knees had begun to fail her on the path up from the spring, she told whoever sat with her at the last of her watches that she had never once, in all her years at the slab, seen a holder of Dùn ìseal come up the valley to ask it a second time.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

Of the Black Wind and the Five Fires

GE 2.417 – 2.420

Chunnaic mi an teine, is thàinig mi dbachaigh. I saw the fire, and I
came home.

— said of the eastern fire at Cuan ruadh, by more than one who
came home by it

I

Of the Wind that Took the Thatch

It came up out of the south-east in the black hour before a morning that never properly broke, and the fisher-folk of Cuan ruadh, who had weathered every wind the sea sent them with names for most and respect for all, had no name ready for this one until it was gone and they needed one to speak of it by. It struck the coast in the first days of an Gearran, in weather that had given no more warning than a wrongness in the swell the evening before, a heave that ran against the wind rather than with it, which the older boats' captains read and put their craft up on the shingle a full tide early for no reason they could afterward explain better than that the sea had looked wrong to them.

By midday it had stripped the thatch from every roof between Cuan ruadh and Ceann chiar, a stretch of coast a long day's walk and more, and driven three boats that had not been hauled high enough onto the rocks below the headland, and flattened, in one household's near ruin, a drying-rack hung with the better part of a season's salted fish that the sea took back grain of salt and flake of flesh together before anyone could reach it. The wind did not merely blow; it took, the

way the old tellings say a wolf takes and not merely eats, choosing what it wanted and leaving the rest broken in the road. Children were carried indoors and held there bodily by mothers who could not otherwise keep them from the doorway to watch it. An old woman of Ceann chlar, who had seen eighty winters on that coast and outlived two husbands lost to lesser storms than this one, said afterward that she had heard the wind speak, though she would not say in what tongue, and no one on that coast ever doubted she believed it, whatever the rest of them made of the claim.

It blew out by the second dusk, going as suddenly as it had come, and left behind it a coast without roofs enough to shelter half the households that had had them two days before, granaries opened to the sky, and boats that would need a full season's mending before they swam again. Of Cuan ruadh's own eleven boats, four were fit for nothing but firewood, and a fifth would need a new keel before it saw water. The fishing that fed the coast through the dark months, which had never in living memory failed outright, failed that winter before it had properly begun, for a coast with half its boats broken and half its granaries roofless could neither catch nor keep enough against the cold.

It was the eldest folk of that coast, remembering other winds with other names and no name for this, who first called it A' Ghaoth Dhubh¹, for the sky it left behind was the colour of a smoored hearth for three days after, ash-dark from horizon to horizon though not a cloud stood in it, the way a fire's smoke hangs low over a valley long after the flame that made it is out. No reciter of the hill ever came to set the name straighter, and the coast never asked for a straighter one. It has been A' Ghaoth Dhubh on every tongue that has spoken of it since, the eldest storm whose name the coast still keeps whole, and every wind that has struck that shore in all the years since has been measured against it and found lesser.

No one of that coast died in the wind itself, a mercy the tellings are careful to set down plainly, for a wind that could take a roof whole could as easily have taken a life, and every household on the shore has its own small telling of how it came to be spared: a door that held when a neighbour's did not, a child called in from the shingle a breath before the worst of it struck, a boat left one turn later than it should have been on a rota that no one afterward could say why it had fallen out that way. What the wind took instead, it took slowly, through the winter that followed and not in the day itself: a season's food, a season's shelter,

1. the Black Wind

and, for more than one household, the last of a fishing life that a lost boat and a maimed hand between them made too hard to carry on. It was the winter after the wind, and not the wind's own day, that the coast came to reckon as the harder half of what A' Ghaoth Dhubh cost it.

II

Of the Winter the Custom Reached the Coast

What saved Cuan ruadh that winter, when its own granaries lay open to the weather and its own boats lay broken on the shingle, was a custom the coast had never troubled to take up on its own account, having never before needed it. The sharing had begun generations before at Dùn ìseal, in the valleys under the hill, a grain-year's surplus carried in at Samhain and given back out by the count of mouths so that no household went into the dark months harder than its neighbour; and it had gone out from the hill slowly, the way such things go, along the roads that carried salt and flint and wool between one valley and the next, taken up first by households that had seen it worked at the hill and thought it good, then by households that had only heard of it and thought it good enough to try.

By the year of A' Ghaoth Dhubh¹ it had reached, by whatever crooked road a custom travels, the settlements of that same coast north and south of the worst of the wind, Ceann chiar among them, and the inland valleys a day and more west of Cuan ruadh, households that grew barley and kept cattle on ground the coast had none to spare for, and knew nothing of storms that struck from the sea because their own hills stood between them and the worst of the weather. Word of what the wind had done to the coast reached those valleys within the week, carried by a trader who had meant to buy salt fish at Cuan ruadh and found instead a shore of broken boats and bare roof-trees. It was those settlements and valleys, with no word sent down from Dùn ìseal at all, that first sent grain east to a coast most of their own households had never set eyes on.

It went first as a scatter of single acts, one household sending what it could spare because a neighbour had told it what the trader said, and another following because the first had; and it was only in the second month of that winter, when

1. the Black Wind

the scatter had grown too large for any one household to account for on its own, that the valleys' own holders sat down together and agreed, in words close enough to the hill's own custom that whoever named it first is not remembered, to send it on as the hill would have sent it, weighed by the count of mouths at Cuan ruadh and given without asking what any one household there had managed to save from the wreck of its own store. Grain came down on carts and on the backs of the valleys' own cattle, salted meat in skins, wool enough to card and weave new roofing against the winters still to come, and none of it came with any reckoning kept of who at Cuan ruadh had lost the most and who the least, for that was not how the custom had ever been kept at the hill, and the valleys, having taken it up, kept it whole.

No household of that coast is known to have starved that winter, and the tellings of Cuan ruadh, when they came at last to set the year down, gave the custom no grander name than the coast's own folk gave it: the bringing-in, as it was called wherever it went, or, among the plainer-spoken, only the help, without further word for what it was or where it had first been thought of. It is told that not every household on that coast learned the custom's name or its origin that winter or ever after; it is told that every household learned, before the spring tide, that the grain had come, and had been fair, and had been enough.

III

Of Lileas, Who Watched the Boats Come In

Lileas of Cuan ruadh was one-and-twenty that winter, the second daughter of a household that fished the water off the headland in a boat her father had built with his own hands and lost, along with two fingers of his left hand taken by a line under strain, on the second day of A' Ghaoth Dhubh¹. She had grown up on that coast knowing the sea the way a hill-child knows weather, by the smell of it before it showed itself and by what her elders' faces did when they looked at it, and had spent every autumn of her life since she was old enough to be trusted on the shingle watching for the boats to come home before dark, a habit the whole coast kept without troubling to call it anything, because a coast that fishes for its living watches its own boats home as a matter of course.

1. the Black Wind

That winter, with her father's hand still healing crooked and the household's boat six weeks from swimming again, she had less to watch for than she was used to, and more time on the shingle than the work of the house strictly needed of her; and it was in that idle watching, as she told whoever asked her how the thing began, that she first came to notice what the coast had never troubled to put into words before: that a boat coming home in failing light, even a boat whose captain knew every rock of that shore by feel, ran a different risk in the last stretch before the beach than in all the miles before it, because the land, once the sun was down, gave a returning boat nothing to steer by but memory and the sound of the surf.

She had heard, from a trader who had come through with grain that same winter, of a fire kept somewhere on a headland of the western coast, built for a purpose she did not then understand well enough to repeat correctly to her own household, and had turned the tale over more than once through that long, roofless, half-fed winter without doing anything about it beyond turning it over, for it was, she said afterward, a stranger's tale of a stranger's coast, and she saw no reason a headland of Cuan ruadh needed anything a western headland had thought worth doing.

What changed her mind, so far as the telling of it can be trusted, was neither the trader's tale nor any single storm, but the ordinary run of that whole hard winter, watching boat after boat come in later than she liked in light that was worse than she liked, and reckoning, each time, how much of what she watched for on the shingle she could not in truth see at all once the light had gone, and how much she was only listening for and hoping. A coast that watched its boats home by daylight had never needed more than eyes for it. A coast whose boats, mended late and fished hard to make up a lost season, were coming home later and later into the dark as the days shortened toward midwinter, needed, she came slowly to think, something the eye alone no longer served.

IV

Of the Fire She Kept on the Eastern Cape

She put it first to her own household, over a meal thin enough that winter that no one at the board had much appetite for argument, and her father, whose hand had healed crooked enough that he no longer trusted it fully on a line in rough water, was the first to say he saw no harm in it and perhaps

some good, if she meant to do the work of keeping it herself and did not look to the rest of the household to carry wood up a headland on top of everything else the winter already asked of them. It was agreed, in the plain way such things were agreed on that coast, without any vote taken and without anyone troubling to write the agreement down anywhere but in the memory of the household that made it: Lileas would keep a fire on the cape east of the village, in her own household's turn, and any other household that wished to share the carrying of wood, or the watching of it through a night, was welcome to, and none was asked to.

The cape stood a stiff climb above the village, a shoulder of bare rock with nothing on it before that winter but sea-birds and the low scrub that grew wherever the salt wind let anything grow at all, and it took her and her younger brother the better part of a month of short winter days to carry up enough driftwood and cut peat to keep even a modest fire burning through a single long night, let alone through the run of nights a whole storm season might ask for. She built the fire first in a shallow pit scraped into the bare rock, walled on the seaward side with stones carried up one and two at a time from the shingle below, so that the wind that would have scattered an open fire in an hour instead drove the flame and the smoke both out toward the water, where any boat looking for it would see it best.

The first nights she kept it alone, sitting by it through the dark with a skin of water and whatever her mother could spare from the household's own thin table, watching the black water below for a shape that did not come, for no boat of Cuan ruadh's own crippled fleet was out on the worst of those first nights to need finding by anything. She kept it anyway, through nights that gave her nothing back for the keeping but cold hands and a fire that burned down faster than she had reckoned it would, and it is told, though the telling allows this much may be kindness rather than plain memory, that more than one household of the village climbed the cape those first weeks with no boat of their own out at all, only to sit an hour with her and see for themselves what she was about, and went down again having seen nothing but a woman and a fire and the black sea giving back no more than its own darkness.

It was her brother, keeping the fire with her on a night neither of them afterward could put a precise date to, who first said aloud what neither had quite let themselves say before: that if the fire served no boat that winter, it would have cost them a month's wood and nothing more, and that a month's wood was a thing the household could bear to lose against the chance, however small that first

winter made it look, of a night when it would not be wasted. Lileas kept the fire the rest of that season on no better reasoning than her brother's, and no worse, and told anyone who asked her why she troubled with it exactly that: that it cost little enough to keep, and might cost the coast a boat and its crew if it were not there the one night it was needed.

V

Of the Fires that Answered It

Word of the fire on Cuan ruadh's cape went along the coast roads that winter and the next the way word of any new thing travels among people who talk to strangers at every ford and market, faster and further than the fire's own small light could have carried it, and by the second winter after A' Ghaoth Dhubh¹, three other coasts had heard enough of it, and had troubled enough over their own boats in their own bad weather, to want fires of their own.

The northern point took to it first, where the coast turned hardest and the currents ran fastest against a boat trying to make the shore in the dark. The households there raised a fire on ground that had, without anyone quite planning it that way, already been scorched black for longer than living memory by shore-fires kept for other reasons in other ages; theirs burned steadier than Cuan ruadh's Teine a' Chlachair² had, for they had Lileas's own year of trial to learn from before they ever laid their own wood, and never once let it fail through a whole storm season once it was begun. The cape north-east of that, where the passage in toward the deeper water ran narrow enough that a boat astray by even a boat's length could find rock instead of channel, was next: a man named Seathan mac Pheadair took the fire's keeping on himself much as Lileas had, alone at first and then with kin who came to share it, and cut, on a stone at the fire's edge, one stroke for every boat he ever saw pass safe by his flame, a tally that within a few years had grown longer than any one telling has troubled to count out in full.

Last of the four to be built, and by every account the surest of them, was the fire of the southern cape at Tobar dhearg, raised on a mound of stacked stone breast-high rather than a scraped pit as Cuan ruadh's first had been, so that the

1. the Black Wind

2. the mason's fire, the first fire

flame stood clear of the spray even in the roughest weather. The coast's own reciters were already saying, before the mound was finished, that with Cuan ruadh's fire and this one and the two between them, and the older fire that had burned so long on the Baile chrom headland in the north-west that no one living could say when it was first lit, the sea round the whole island now had five points of flame to answer it in the dark, cape answering cape the length of the coast, so that a boat lost in a storm off any shore of Dia-thìr had, for the first time within any telling's memory, a fire somewhere within its sight to steer toward. It was from that reckoning, made first by a reciter of Tobar dhearg who never troubled to give her own name to the saying, that the coast came to call them together the five fires, and has called them so on every telling since.

None of the four newer fires were kept the same way twice; each coast built its own to its own ground and its own weather, and none of the tellings that keep them troubles to say one was better tended than another, save that Cuan ruadh's was first, and Lileas its first keeper, a fact the coast has never once let a traveller forget, whatever else about that hard winter has worn thin in the telling.

VI

Of the Boat that Came Home by It

It was in the third winter of the fire's keeping, on a night that gave no more warning than A' Ghaoth Dhubh¹ had given, that the fire did the one thing every night before had only promised it might. A boat out of a village two coasts north of Cuan ruadh, blown far off its own water by a wind that had turned three times in an afternoon and given its crew nothing steady to read, came upon full dark with a failing wind, a following sea it did not know, and a coastline it could no longer place by any mark its captain trusted.

Lileas was on the cape that night with her brother and, for once, her father, whose hand had healed well enough by then to carry wood if no longer to trust a line, and it was her father who first saw, or thought he saw, a shape against the last grey of the water that was not quite the shape of a wave. He said nothing at first, for a fisherman who cries a boat where there is none costs his household nothing but a wasted watch, but he set more wood on the fire than the night's cold alone

1. the Black Wind

called for, and it burned up bright and high enough that within a little while none of the three of them any longer doubted there was a boat out there, low and struggling, working hard against a sea that wanted to put it onto rock rather than sand.

What the boat's own captain said afterward, to anyone who asked him in the villages he touched for the rest of his working life, was that he had given the coast up for lost an hour before, was steering by nothing better than the set of the wind against his face and a growing certainty that the next thing his keel touched would be stone, and had seen, low on the black land ahead of him, a single point of fire where he had expected nothing at all: no village lit for a feast, no house left burning by carelessness, nothing he could account for by any tale he knew of that shore, only a fire burning high and steady on a headland with no house near it that he could see. He steered for it because he had nothing better left to steer for, and found, coming in under it at last with his boat still whole and his crew all breathing, a beach he did not know and three figures on the cape above him who came down the path with torches to help him haul his boat clear of the tide before he had so much as told them his own name.

He told Lileas, once he had breath enough to tell her anything, that he had not known the fire was kept for boats like his until he was already steering for it, and asked her, in the plain way of a man who has just been given his life back and does not yet know how to speak of the size of the gift, why a coast that had never seen him before would keep a fire burning all a hard winter's night for a boat that might never come. She told him, in words the coast has kept ever since as near to what she said as any telling of a moment like that can promise to be, that the fire was kept for whichever boat needed it, on whichever night it came, no more for him than for any other, and that this was the whole of the reason for it and had been from the first cold night she carried wood up the cape alone and found nothing there to answer her but her own fire and the dark. He slept that night, and three nights after while his boat was made fit to sail home in, in the household that had fed most of that coast through the winter of A' Ghaoth Dhubh and had lit, out of that same winter's need, the first of the five fires that now stood along every shore of Dia-thìr the sea could reach in the dark; and it is that fire, burning on the cape above Cuan ruadh through every storm season since, that the coast's own tellers point to first, of all the five, whenever they are asked which one began it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

OF ANNDRA BREAC

GE 2,421 – 2,423

Cha do thàinig sinn; bha sinn ann. We did not come; we were here.
— cut on Calbh Cnoc ghorm, and spoken at the ford from the year
after Anndra Breac

I

Of the Watch at Seann Skell

Four men kept the tower at Seann Skell that autumn, as four had kept it every autumn since the hill-folk first put a roof back on Seann-Dhaoine¹ old watch-stones and set a household there to mind the western water: the island had no enemy worth the name; a coast that watches its own sea is a coast that is never taken wholly by surprise, and the hill-folk had learned that much from every people whose ruin they had walked through on the way west. The tower stood at the northern shoulder of the bay, round-walled in stone older than any teller could put an age to, and from its top a watcher could see the whole reach of water from the last rocks of the point to the grey line where the sea gave up and the sky began.

It was Tormod Chaol who saw it first, in the last light of a day that had already turned the water the colour of a knife, and he did not at first believe what his own eyes told him, for a man does not, seeing such a thing for the first time, trust himself over the water he has watched every evening of his working life without seeing anything stranger than a whale or a drifting spar. What rose off the point, a long way out and low against the light, was a back, dark and wet and shining, longer by

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

half than any whale he had ever helped haul ashore or heard sung of by men who had, and it came up slow, the way a thing comes up that has all the time in the world and no fear of anything the shore can do to it, and went under again without breaking the water into foam, as a stone goes under that is let down rather than thrown.

He called the other three up from the fire below, and by the time they had climbed the narrow stair and crowded the parapet the water had gone flat and grey and empty again, giving nothing back but the ordinary chop of an ordinary evening, and for a moment each of the four half hoped, in the private place a man keeps such hopes, that he alone had seen nothing and the others would say so. None of them said so. Each had seen enough, in the last of the light, to swear afterward to a length, a colour, a manner of going under, and no two of their four tellings agreed in every particular, as no two tellings of a fast and half-seen thing ever do; but all four agreed on the two matters that mattered, that the back was long as three boats laid end to end, and that whatever wore it was not a whale, for a whale blows before it goes down and this had made no sound at all, only the low hiss of water closing over something that did not choose to be heard.

Word of it went down to the households below before the four had so much as come down from the tower, carried by the youngest of them, who could not keep it to himself the length of the stair, and by the time the tale had gone twice round the bay it had grown a head and a neck that none of the four had sworn to and lost nothing of the length they had. The old women of Seann Skell, who kept between them more tellings of the western water than any four men had years to have heard, said only that the sea had shown itself before to watchers who had the luck or the misfortune to be looking at the right hour, and would show itself again to others after these four were dust, and that a wise household neither doubted the watchers nor put out a boat that evening on the strength of the doubting. It is the first sighting the tellers ever tied to a place a man could point to and a count of men who could be asked, and it went into no telling grander than the bay's own, until a man who had never climbed that tower came to hear of it the following spring, at a gathering fifty miles from any water Tormod Chaol had ever wetted his feet in.

Tormod Chaol himself kept, for the rest of that autumn, a shorter watch and a longer silence than the other three, climbing the tower each evening at the hour the light had caught the thing and standing at the parapet a while after his turn was properly done, though he never again saw anything the water gave back but

the ordinary chop it had always shown him before that one evening. Asked, in his own old age, whether he wished he had never climbed the stair that night, he would say only that a man who has seen a thing the sea does not commonly show cannot afterward unsee it, and that he did not know whether that was a burden or a gift, and had stopped trying to decide which.

II

Of the Planks on the Western Sand

It was that same season, before the tale of the tower had properly finished going round the bay, that the wrack along the coast south of Seann Skell began to give up planks the like of which no household there had cause to build or buy. They were narrow, shaped with a care no coracle or hide-boat of the island's own building troubled to spend on a plank that would be under water half its life anyway, and stitched rather than pegged, sinew or cord drawn through holes bored close along each edge in a line as even as a weaver's selvage, so that a length of two boards lashed together lay along the sand like something sewn rather than built. No two pieces that washed in over that season matched exactly, as though the sea had broken up more than one hull and scattered the wreckage of each the length of the shore before any of it came ashore, and no household along that coast, asked afterward, could say it had lost a boat of its own building answering to any of the pieces, nor lacked a man, woman or child it could not account for among its own dead and living both.

That last was the part the coast turned over longest, more even than the planks themselves. A wreck without a body is not, on that coast or any other the tellers knew of, an ordinary wreck; the sea that breaks a boat commonly keeps something of what was riding in it, a length of rope still knotted to a thwart, an oar with a hand's wear worn into the grip, or, in the worst weathers, worse than an oar. What came ashore that season was wood alone, stitched wood broken small, and not one scrap of anything that had ridden in the wood, no cord that was not ship's cord, no tool, no bone, nothing a household could grieve over or bury, only planks enough, gathered and laid out along one low wall by a fisherman with more curiosity than most, to account for at least two hulls and perhaps three, and no drowned man's face to put to any of them.

The fisherman's name was Micheil Beag, a name half the coast bore by then, and it was he who first thought to walk the whole stretch of shore a second time with the planks already laid out, matching what he found against what he already had, the way a man pieces a broken pot back together to see what shape it kept before it broke. He got, by the end of that walking, two lengths of hull curved enough to show him the shape of the boats they had come from, narrower and longer in the beam than anything built on that coast, built for open water rather than the close fishing the coast's own boats were cut for, and he said so to anyone who would listen, at the tower, at the shore households, and later, because he was a man who liked an audience more than most, to a teller who had come that way with nothing better to do that season than listen to whatever the western coast had to tell him.

The teller's name was Anndra Breac, and he listened to Micheil Beag's planks the way he had, by then, taken to listening to everything that coast had to offer him, turning it over for longer than the matter seemed at first to deserve.

III

Of Anndra Breac, Who Made a Telling

Anndra Breac was three-and-forty that year, a teller by trade in the loose way the word was used on that coast, meaning a man who carried news and old tales both from household to household in exchange for his supper and a place by the fire, welcome everywhere and rooted nowhere, with no wife the tellings ever named and no household of his own beyond whichever one had last fed him. He had walked the western shore, on and off, for the better part of twenty years, and knew its households, its old wrecks, its half-forgotten burial mounds and its Seann-Dhaoine¹ ruins better than most men born to any one of them, for a man who belongs everywhere a little comes in time to know a coast the way its own people, each rooted to their one stretch of it, rarely trouble to learn the whole.

He had heard, over those twenty years, a great many tellings of where the hill-folk had come from, most of them agreeing on nothing beyond the plain fact that Ailean Mòr had walked out of a grove at Doire ghlas with a warmth in him no

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

man before or since had carried, and had gone south to take a hill, and that everything else the coast's own households believed of their own beginnings before that grove was a scatter of half-tales that no two households told alike: that the hill-folk had always been on the island, as the elders of Cnoc ghorm held and had carved into a stone before any teller now living had learned his trade; that they had come up out of the bare ground in the first spring after the world was made; that they had walked dry-shod over a sea-floor since drowned, from a shore no one now living had seen. Anndra had carried all three tellings in his own head at different times without troubling to choose between them, the way a man carries several coins of different mintings without asking which is truest, for a teller's business, as he understood it, was to carry a tale, not to settle it.

What the planks on Micheil Beag's wall did, over the weeks Anndra spent going back to look at them, was give him a fourth telling he had never carried before, and one he found, turning it over by whatever fires would have him that autumn, that he could not afterward put down. A boat, he came to think, watching the low light catch the stitched seams Micheil Beag had laid out for him a third and a fourth time, is not a thing a people builds to walk out of the ground with, nor a thing a drowned road leaves behind it. A boat is a thing built by hands that already knew water, built to be lost on water, and two or three boats broken small enough to leave nothing whole but their planking, with not one body to grieve, argued to his mind a crossing rather than a wreck close to shore, made once, long before any telling now kept remembered it being made, over water wide enough that whatever the sea did to the hulls and the people both, it kept what it took and gave back only wood.

He did not, by his own account afterward, come to the thought all at once, nor with any confidence he was right; he came to it slowly, the way a man comes to trust a bridge he has crossed several times without it giving way, and he tried it out first on Micheil Beag himself, who heard it out, turned it over as long as Anndra had, and said at the end of it only that he did not know, which was, from a man who knew that shore's wrecks better than any other living soul, as near to agreement as Anndra was going to get from anyone that season. He tried it next on two or three households up and down the coast who had known him twenty years and would hear him out on the strength of that alone, and got from most of them the same careful not-knowing, and from one old woman of a household near Seann Skell, who had heard every telling the coast possessed and outlived most of the tellers who carried them, a long look and the single remark that a tale

a man cannot leave alone is a tale worth telling somewhere it will be properly heard, whatever comes of the telling.

One household alone turned him from its door over the telling before he had carried it further than the shore, a fisherman near Caol bheag who kept the old carving of Cnoc ghorm's saying cut small into his own lintel, as a few households of that coast did, and who told Anndra plainly that a man who came to his hearth to say the hill-folk had crossed a sea from somewhere was a man who might as well tell him his own father was a stranger, and would find no meal and no bed under that roof for the saying. Anndra took the door shutting on him without argument, as he had, by his own account, taken every door shut on him in twenty years of walking for one telling or another, and thought no more of it than he thought of a wet night with no roof at all, until the same closing came at him from every door at once the following spring.

It was the watchers' back in the western water, more than the planks, that gave Anndra the shape the telling finally took, for a coast that had just seen, with its own four pairs of eyes, a thing long enough and strange enough to argue for a sea with room in it for things no teller had words ready for, was a coast that would hear a tale of a long crossing without laughing him off its threshold before he had finished the first sentence of it; and by the turn of that year Anndra Breac had a telling whole in his head, worked and reworked by a dozen firesides until the words came to him without his troubling to reach for them, in which the hill-folk had not always stood on the island nor come up out of its ground nor walked over a drowned sea-floor, but had crossed the sea in boats, once, out of some shore no living telling named, and had lost more of themselves to the crossing than any telling now kept remembered losing, and had come ashore few and had grown many.

IV

Of the Ford

he carried the telling east that spring, the length of the island, to the yearly gathering at the ford, where the hill's own holder and An Cnoc Ruadh's met each year to settle what wanted settling between the two, and where,

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

over the generations since Ragnall Ceannfhionn first waded that water to talk salt for wool, every kind of household on the island had come to bring its own business, its own goods, and, more than either, its own news, so that a teller with a telling worth hearing could be sure of a crowd there such as no single coast, however long he walked it, would ever give him.

He waited, as the custom of that gathering ran, until the business of the day was done and the fires of evening lit, when tellers of every kind took their turn by whichever fire would have them, and when his turn came he chose the largest fire he could get a footing by, well clear of the small fires at the edge of the crowd, close enough to the king's own fire that men of the hill and men of An Cnoc Ruadh both stood within easy hearing of him. The telling came out as he had shaped it through the winter, plainly and without apology: the crossing, the loss, the coming ashore of few where many had set out. By every account that has come down of that evening he told it well, with the ease of a man who has said a thing to himself so many times by so many firesides that the words no longer cost him anything to find.

The crowd did not hear him out to the end. It began, as such things begin, with one voice from somewhere near the back of the gathering, an old man of a hill household who called out that no teller with any claim to his trade told the households of Dia-thír that they had come from anywhere, for they had not come, they had always been, and Calbh Cnoc ghorm² said so in words cut there before any living grandfather was born; and where one voice led, in a crowd already restless with a full day's business behind it and drink enough in it to loosen tempers that might otherwise have kept their own counsel, others followed fast, until Anndra's own voice, still carrying the last of his telling, could no longer be heard over the shouting that had risen to drown it. He did not, by every account, raise his own voice to match theirs, nor try a second time to finish what he had begun; he stood where he was until it was plain to him and to everyone else that no more of the telling would be heard that night by anyone who wanted to hear it, and then he stepped back from the fire and left the crowd to its shouting.

What followed, in the way of such gatherings, was less a judgement than a driving-out that no one household troubled to claim as its own doing: households that had fed him gladly enough on his way east that spring would not have him at their fires that night nor the next morning, and by the time the gathering broke

2. the column at Cnoc ghorm

and the households went their own ways home, it was understood on every road out of the ford, without any one voice having said it in so many words, that Anndra Breac was not to be fed at a hill hearth again, nor given a place by any fire that called itself of Dia-thìr's own telling, for the rest of whatever years the sea or the road left him. No one struck him. No one needed to. A teller lives by welcome, and the ford that evening withdrew his, coast by coast, faster than any single household could have managed alone, and by the following spring there was not a hearth from the eastern cape to the western shore that would own to having fed him since.

V

Of the King, Who Laughed and Then Was Quiet

The king had stood the length of the telling at his own fire, near enough to hear all of it before the shouting rose, and those who stood nearest him that evening told afterward, each in his own words but all agreeing on the shape of it, that he had laughed, once, short and low, at some point in Anndra's telling that none of them could afterward agree on exactly, a man's low private laugh rather than any mockery meant to carry, the kind a man gives a jest that has caught him by surprise rather than one he saw coming and braced against. He did not join the shouting when it rose, nor did he move to still it, standing where he was with the firelight on him while the crowd did the driving-out it did without any word from him one way or the other; and when it was done, and Anndra had stepped back from the largest fire to find no smaller one that would take him either, the king was seen to be quiet, in the particular way those who had watched him thirty years and more knew to read as more than ordinary silence, a stillness that sat on him the rest of that evening and did not lift with the fire's dying.

He said nothing of it that night to anyone who left a telling of what he said, and nothing the next day either, by any account that has come down; and it is told, though the telling allows this much may owe more to the shape a tale takes in the mouths that carry it than to any one witness's sworn word, that a woman of his own kin asked him once, some time after, plainly, whether the teller had spoken true, and that he answered her only that he had heard a great many tellings of where his own people came from in all his own years, and had never yet

troubled to choose one over another, which she took, as she told it after, for neither a yes nor a no but a door he did not mean to open for her that day.

Whatever the laugh had been, and whatever the silence after it was, the king made no move that spring, nor any spring after, to call Anndra Breac back to a hearth, nor to still the coast that had driven him from one; and the households that had shouted him down took his silence, as households will, for the answer that suited each of them best.

VI

Of the Saying Spoken at the Opening

The gathering that met at the ford the following spring opened, for the first time within any telling's memory, with a saying spoken aloud before any business of salt or wool or marriage was so much as raised: the words cut on Calbh Cnoc ghorm¹, which the people of that hill had kept by mouth across more generations than any one line could count, spoken now not as a thing believed quietly in each household's own heart but as a thing said together, aloud, at the start of the year's meeting, by whoever stood nearest the fire when the crowd had gathered and the business was ready to begin. We did not come; we were here. No one teller is remembered as the first to have said it that spring in place of any other opening; it is told only that it was said, and that it was said again the spring after, and every spring after that, until no household coming to the ford could remember a gathering that had opened any other way, and the saying that had stood carved on a stone at Cnoc ghorm for longer than any living telling could account for became, from that year, a thing spoken at the opening of every gathering the ford ever held, a rule of the telling and not only a belief held apart in each hearth's own quiet keeping.

Of Anndra Breac himself, after that first spring, little more is told with any certainty. He was seen that same year along the western shore south of Seann Skell, walking the strand below the tower where Micheil Beag's planks still lay against the wall he had stacked them on, though whether he stopped to look at them again no teller who saw him passing troubled to ask him, and none who saw him that day spoke to him or was spoken to, for the coast that had fed him gladly

1. the column at Cnoc ghorm

twenty years running had by then taken up, coast household by coast household, the same closed door the ford had shown him first. He walked on south along the strand and did not look back at the tower nor at the man who watched him go, and it is that walking, and no other end to it, that the western shore's own tellers kept of him: a man going on along an empty beach in the direction the tide was running, out past the last household that would have fed him and on toward whatever shore lay beyond the one the tellings could still follow him to. No teller of that coast, then or after, claimed to have fed him again, nor buried him, nor marked where he stopped walking; and none, asked why the coast let a man who had first given them their fourth telling of themselves go so unremembered afterward, ever gave an answer better than that a coast which will not keep a tale will not trouble long over the man who carried it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

Of the Fosterling's Return

GE 2,424 – 2,428

Dh'fhalbh e 'na ghille; thàinig e dbachaigh 'na dhuine. He went a boy; he came home a man. — the salt-road's own telling, of the fosterling never named

I

Of the Paired Marks at Ros dhomhain

This is told at the river-mouth below An Cnoc Ruadh¹, where the rock still stands and the marks are still read, though few now living can say which keeper cut which.

He was thirty years old that spring and had raked salt on the lake shore since he was eight, and it did not occur to him, walking down to the river-mouth on an ordinary morning to see what Seònaid Mhòr had done to the tide-rock, that he was walking toward the last four years he would spend calling An Cnoc Ruadh his only home. Seònaid was his own age within a season, a broad, quiet woman who had kept the rock since her mother's hands grew too stiff for the chisel, and she had taken, that year, to a habit no keeper before her had troubled with: where every mark since the rock was first cut had recorded the one thing a keeper thought worth recording, the high water that crept a little further up the stone with every generation that watched it, Seònaid cut two strokes for every tide instead of one, a mark for the water's highest reach and, beside it, a shorter mark for its lowest ebb.

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

"One tells you the sea is rising," she said, when he asked her why, crouched at the rock with her chisel still in her hand and salt dust white on her knees. "It says nothing about how far it falls back. I want both told, so whoever reads this after me has the whole of it and not the half that frightens."

He turned that over as he walked back up to the drying platforms, the way he turned over most things Seònaid said, slowly and more than once. It was, he thought, a small enough change to a stone that had stood plain and single-stroked since before either of them was born, and yet it was the kind of change that An Cnoc Ruadh's own people, unlike the hill of Rìghrean na Cloiche² fifty miles east, seemed to make without asking leave of anyone: a woman decided a thing was worth doing more fully than it had been done, and did it, and the doing became, within a season or two, simply how it was done. Her pairs could be read that year and every year after; the keepers who came to the rock once she was gone went back, in time, to the single stroke, finding the doubled work more than the plain record needed, but no reciter of that shore ever troubled to say her pairs had been wrong to make. They were only, in the end, more than the custom wanted kept.

II

Of the Third Rock at Inis thais

Word of the paired marks went along the coast road the way most things went along that coast, in a carrier's mouth rather than in any letter, and reached Inis thais, two days' walk to the south-west round the shoulder of the lake, before the season was out. He never learned who first told it there, or whether the telling that reached Inis thais even kept the doubling that made Seònaid's marks worth remarking on; what came back to Ros dhomhain, the following year, was only that the households of Inis thais's own harbour had begun cutting marks of their own on a rock at their own harbour mouth, at the same spacing Seònaid used, though none of them could say why that spacing and no other, since none of them had ever troubled to ask the keeper who had first thought of it or the reasons she gave for the width between one mark and the next.

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

It struck him, when the word came back, as a strange way for a thing to travel: not as an idea carried whole, with the mind that made it still attached, but as a bare fact of practice, a spacing on a stone, taken up by people who kept the habit and lost the reasoning behind it in the same crossing. Three rocks stood, by then, along that shore and the next, cut at the same interval and read by three different hands, and no one at any of the three harbours could have told a stranger why the interval was what it was, only that it had always, within any keeper's memory, been kept so. He said as much to Seònaid once, sitting with her at the river-mouth while she cut a mark he had watched her cut a hundred times before, and she only shrugged and said that most customs, if you dug down far enough under them, turned out to have started the same way: someone thought a thing worth doing, and enough people agreed without ever quite saying so aloud, and after that it was a custom and no longer a thought, which was, she said, the whole of how anything at An Cnoc Ruadh¹ or anywhere else on the island ever came to be done at all.

III

Of the Landing of Laid Stone

The river-mouth itself changed under his own hands that same year, more than the tide-rock ever had. An Cnoc Ruadh's boats had put out from an open shingle beach since before Lachlann Ruadh's grandmother's grandmother held the hill, hauled up above the tide-line each evening on rollers cut fresh from whatever driftwood came to hand, a way of landing that worked well enough in fair weather and cost a boat or a bruised shin in foul; and it was Peigi Dhubh, not her father, who first said aloud, at the household's board one wet autumn evening, that a hill whose whole wealth now travelled by water deserved better than a beach any winter tide could rearrange without asking.

Lachlann agreed readily enough, being by then a man past sixty who had grown willing to let his daughter's plans stand alongside his own, and the work went to every household of the hill that could spare a season's labour from the salt-rakes: stone carried down from the low quarry above the lake, laid course on

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

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course at the river-mouth where the fresh water of Loch chrom met the tide coming up from the sea, until by the second summer there stood a landing a boat could come alongside at any state of the water without a single hand needed to haul it clear of the mud. He worked the stone himself through most of that second summer, his hands grown hard with salt-rake work but new to the different ache of setting a course of laid stone true, and it was there, more than at any tide-rock or salt-pan, that he came to think of himself as a man of An Cnoc Ruadh's own building rather than a boy the hill had merely taken in.

It was the hill's first way onto open water that did not depend on a beach's mercy, and word of it travelled, as the marks had, along every road the salt-carriers walked: that An Cnoc Ruadh now had a landing of laid stone at its own river-mouth, and boats out of harbours further down the coast began, within a few years, to put in there themselves rather than carry on to the open beaches beyond, so that the houses that had stood scattered along that shore for longer than any list could number began, almost without anyone deciding it should be so, to draw in closer round the landing and the rock together, until the scatter had become, by the time he was thirty-four, something a stranger walking down from the high road might have called, without much argument from anyone who lived there, a town: some sixty houses, by the count Seònaid kept as carefully as she kept her tides, standing round the tide-rock and the stone landing both, its people fishing now from boats of their own building rather than working the shallows on foot as their grandparents had.

IV

Of Lachlann's Dying

Lachlann Ruadh had held An Cnoc Ruadh¹ only a little while when the boy first came to it at six, a broad man just past forty then, and he held it four-and-twenty years more after, through the boy's whole growing and the raking of a hundred seasons' salt, until the winter the stone landing's second course was laid, when a chill he took wading the shallows to set a boat right settled in his chest and would not lift with the spring. He was five-and-sixty years old, which the household reckoned, when they spoke of it at all, an age past complaint for a

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

man of no king's blood who had spent his whole life wet to the knee in salt water and cold wind off the lake; but it came hard all the same, in the way any death comes hard to a household that has never known its holder any other way, and the fosterling, sitting with the rest of the hall through the last of it, found himself grieving a man not his own father with a plainness that surprised him more than the grief itself.

Lachlann said little, in his last days, that An Cnoc Ruadh's own reciters ever troubled to keep whole; what they did keep was a single evening near the end, when Peigi sat by him with the salt tallies still in her hand from the day's weighing, and he asked her, not for the first time that season, whether she meant to send the fosterling home once she held the hill in her own right, and she told him she had not yet decided, and he said, in words the hearth still repeats though no one now living heard them first-hand, that a fostering kept a season too long stopped being a kindness to either house and became only a habit no one had troubled to end, and that she should not let her own fondness for having him about the place be the reason the peace of the ford went one day longer without its proper marking. He died within the month, in the same red-earthed hall he had been born in, with Peigi's hand in his and the fosterling standing at the door among the rest of the household who had no closer claim on the bedside than the years they had given the hill.

V

Of Peigi Dhubh's Holding

Peigi took the hill at forty years old, the same plain, dark, quick-eyed woman who had told him, at the gate on his first evening there, that he was thin for a king's son and she supposed they would have to feed him, grown now into a holder her father's own steward said kept the tallies straighter than Lachlann ever had and forgave a bad season's raking no more readily than he had. She held it the way she had done everything since childhood, without ceremony and without much patience for anyone who expected one; the household's own telling of her taking the hill runs to a single line, that she sat down at the board the morning after her father's burial and asked for the tallies before she

asked for anything else, and no one at An Cnoc Ruadh¹ ever thought to ask her to do it any other way.

It was the better part of a year before she said anything to him of what her father had asked her, on the last evening he had strength to ask it, and when she did she said it plainly, the way she said most things, walking with him along the new stone landing in the last light of an evening in his thirty-second year: that her father had been right, and that a fostering kept past its season served neither hill, and that she meant to send him home before the year turned, with as much salt as a household could carry as gift and not as trade, so that Dùn ìseal would know An Cnoc Ruadh sent him back with honour and not merely let a hostage of peace go once he had grown too old to trouble keeping. She watched his face while she said it, in the frank way she had watched him at the gate four-and-twenty years before, and told him afterward, though only once and never again in his hearing, that she had put off the saying of it longer than her father would have liked, because the hill had grown used to him in a way no one at An Cnoc Ruadh had troubled to put into words until the words were needed.

VI

Of the Leaving of the Red Hill

he spent the last month before the train set out doing the ordinary work of the hill as though nothing were ending, raking salt at the drying platforms beside rakers he had taught himself, setting a last course of stone at the landing that he would not be there to see finished, for Peigi had said plainly that she wanted no long leave-taking made of it, that a man who knew he was leaving in a month worked worse in that month than a man who did not, and the hill had salt to rake whether or not one of its own was about to walk fifty miles east and not come back.

Seònaid came to him the evening before the train left, at the tide-rock rather than at the hall, and cut, while he watched, one more pair of marks on the stone, though the tide that evening called for none, a high stroke and a low stroke set close together at the rock's edge where no keeper after her would think to look for a reading. She told him, when he asked what they were for, that she had not de-

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

cided, only that the rock had marked every tide of his years on that shore and she saw no reason it should not mark the last evening of them as well, whatever the water was actually doing. He did not know, walking away from the river-mouth that night, whether to call it a kindness or only Seònaid's own plain way of saying a thing she would not otherwise have troubled to say aloud, and decided, by the time he reached the hall, that it was likely both.

Peigi herself walked with the train no further than the gate, which surprised no one who had known her a season, and gave him, in place of any long farewell, the same flat, appraising look she had given him as a boy of six arriving thin and friendless at that same gate four-and-twenty years before. She told him the salt was weighed true and the beasts were sound and that An Cnoc Ruadh¹ would hear, by whatever road word travelled, how he did; and then, because she had never in her life been a woman to let a silence do work a sentence could do better, she said that her father had been right to send him, and righter still to wait as long as he had waited, and that neither hill would ever trouble to thank her for either, which was, she said, exactly as holding a hill ought to go.

VII

Of the Road East

he went with three of An Cnoc Ruadh's own household and a train of pack-beasts loaded with salt enough to weigh down a lesser hill's whole season's store, walking east along Rathad an t-Salainn², the road that had carried him west at six years old on his own two feet, and it struck him, somewhere on the second day, that he remembered almost nothing of that first crossing beyond the shape of it: a woman named Rìonach who had knelt to his height and spoken of forked rivers, a low green mound Donnchadh would not walk near, the smell of the sea reaching him before any sea he could see. He looked for the shelters along the road that Donnchadh had slept them under and found most of them standing still, kept swept, as they had always been kept, by whoever passed last, and slept in one of them himself on the third night with a strange, quiet satisfaction in finding the road had not changed while he had.

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

2. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

The near valleys came up on the fifth day, country he had crossed as a child without troubling to look at it closely, and he found himself now noticing what a fostered boy of six had had no eye to notice: the boundary stones his brother, he had heard, once judged a quarrel by; the households that sent their surplus east at Samhain and never asked what came back to them in a lean year; small plain customs, kept without law, that he had grown up thinking belonged only to An Cnoc Ruadh's own shore until he saw, walking through them himself, how far they ran. He came in sight of Dùn ìseal on the seventh evening, the hill standing up dark against a sky gone gold the way he had been told, twenty-four years before, that An Cnoc Ruadh would stand against its own western light, and found he did not know, walking up the last stretch of road, whether the hill ahead of him was the home he was coming back to or another hill he was only passing through on the way to some third place he had not yet found.

VIII

Of the Brother Who Did Not Know Him

Calum Ciar met the party at the gate, for Eilidh, who had given the hill into his hands some years before, was at the far end of the valley that evening, and it fell to her elder son to greet whatever An Cnoc Ruadh¹ sent east. He looked the fosterling over, salt-carriers and pack-beasts and all, with the plain courtesy a holder's son owed any train that came in under a gift-load, and asked, when the greetings were done, which of the household he might be, for a face burned dark by lake wind and a way of standing learned on An Cnoc Ruadh had left nothing in him that his brother's eye could fasten on as kin. It is told, and the hill's own reciters do not trouble to soften it, that the fosterling stood a long moment in the gate saying nothing at all, watching his own brother wait for an answer to a question that should never have needed asking, before he told him plainly who he was; and that Calum Ciar's face did something then that no one standing near enough to see it ever troubled to name, somewhere between shame at not knowing and a plainer grief at how completely a boy could be lost to a household that had never once stopped loving him.

Eilidh knew him before he had crossed half the yard. She came to the hall door when word reached her that An Cnoc Ruadh's train was in, and she looked at the

man coming up from the gate, salt-dark and grown a head taller than the boy she had knelt to at Àth shean four-and-twenty years before, and said his name, the one name she had never stopped using though no reciter of either hill had ever troubled to write it down, before he had said a single word to tell her who he was. She wept then, which the hill's own telling allows her, being by that year past caring what a hall full of her own household thought of her weeping, and held him a long while at the door before she would let anyone, even her elder son, come near enough to greet him in turn.

IX

Of the Songs Sung at the Pans

he stayed the winter at Dùn ìseal and rode down, before the spring turned, to see the salt-pans at Baile ghorm, for it was there, among rakers who worked salt the sea-shore way and had never learned the lake-shore turn of the wrist Lachlann taught him at eight years old, that he found himself, one evening at their fires, teaching what the household at Ros dhomhain had taught him without meaning to teach anything at all: a refrain An Cnoc Ruadh's own rakers sang at the crust, four short lines whose meaning even An Cnoc Ruadh's own eldest could no longer wholly give an account of, though every hand on that shore had sung it at the raking since before Seònaid's grandmother's grandmother kept the tide-rock. He sang it for the Baile ghorm rakers as Peigi's own household had sung it for him, and one of them, an old woman who had raked that shingle sixty years, wrote nothing down, for no one at Baile ghorm troubled to write a working song down, but she kept the four lines whole from that single hearing and taught them to her own daughter's daughter before she died, so that the song ran on at the sea-shore pans as it had always run at the lake, in a tongue near enough the island's own that a raker of Baile ghorm could sing it without knowing she sang words An Cnoc Ruadh itself could no longer wholly construe.

Salann geal, an cuan dorcha, Làmh a' snìomh 's a' cur air ais, Dachaigh ann an gach gràinne, Cha chaill an fhairge a càs.

What could be made of it, An Cnoc Ruadh's own eldest said when he asked them, before he ever carried it east, was something of white salt and a dark sea, of

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

a hand that turns and gives back what it takes, of a home held whole in every single grain; the fourth line no keeper of that shore, in all the years anyone could ask after, had ever managed to render the same way twice, and some said only that the sea does not lose what is its own, and others that the sea does not count the cost of its own losing, and no one thought either wrong enough to correct the other. It did not trouble him, singing it at Baile ghorm's fires with rakers who had never set foot on the western lake shore, that the song's own meaning had worn thinner than its tune; a thing four generations of hands had sung at the same work needed, he thought, no more warrant than that.

He was thirty-four years old that spring, and stayed at Dùn ìseal the rest of his mother's life and some while after, neither holding the hill nor troubling anyone with a wish to, a man of the king's own blood who had gone west at six and come home at thirty grown, by every account, more An Cnoc Ruadh's than his own mother's hill had ever managed to make him in the six years it held him first. Rìghrean na Cloiche²' own list, when the reciters after Eilidh came to set down her reign and her sons in order, gave Calum Ciar his place among the holders as it gave every holder before him; of the one who had gone to An Cnoc Ruadh and come back with salt in his hands and a song no one could wholly construe, it set down nothing at all, no year of birth and no year of death, no reign and no deed with a date fixed to it, so that a stranger reading the list a hundred years after would have found no trace that Eilidh Ghlas had borne more than the one son. It was An Cnoc Ruadh's own telling, not the hill of Rìghrean na Cloiche, that kept what little of him is kept at all: the boy who went, it says still, at every hearth that sings the salt refrain without knowing whose hands first carried it home, and did not come back the same man, and was never, by either hill's own reckoning, given a name.

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

PART FIVE

The Great Gathering

OF THE PANTHER ROAD AND THE EDGE OF THE WOODS

GE 2,428 – 2,460

Nuair a philleas na cait, philleas an cuideachd leotha. When the cats
turn back, wise hands turn back with them. — said of the passes,
after Iain Buachaille

I

Of the Bone Pipes and the Turning of the Cats

At the southern skirt of Cnoc àrsaidh, where Rathad na Spor¹ ran down off the high ground and lost itself among the last of the birch before the grazing opened out, there lived that year a man named Gilleonan, who had no craft the households about him could put a plainer name to than the making of small useful things out of whatever came to his hand, and who that winter came to hand on a heap of hollow bird-bones left over from a winter's snaring and took a notion, turning them over by his own fire of an evening, to bore holes along the length of the longest of them and see what came out of blowing across the end. What came out, after a week of ruined bone and burnt fingers and more silence than sound, was a thin high note that carried further than any voice raised across an open field, and by the second week he had bored four holes rather than one and could raise and lower the note as he pleased, and by the third the children of

1. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

every household near enough to hear him practising had taken to gathering at his door of an evening the way children gather at any door where something new and strange is being made. No one before him is remembered to have made a thing on Dia-thìr that could be played rather than merely blown, and the pipes he cut that winter out of hollow bird-bone are the oldest instruments the island's tellers count, and Gilleonan, asked in his own age how he had come to think of it, would say only that a bone with a hole through it already wants to sing, and a man with enough patience and enough ruined bone will find where the rest of the holes belong.

It was in that same season, while Gilleonan's thin note was still new enough to draw children from three households at a call, that the word came down from the passes above Cnoc àrsaidh that the great cats were turning back on Imrich nam Pantar² before ever they reached the foothills. Every year of any household's memory the cats had come down out of the high ground with the last hard frost of the spring, in ones and twos and sometimes in a string of them following the same worn track a day or two apart, crossing the passes on their own road as they had crossed them since before any teller's grandfather had words for a beginning, and going on south to whatever ground held them through the cold months, and every year the herders of the hill households that lay along that road kept their beasts well clear of it while the crossing lasted, for a cat on the move wants nothing of a man or his cattle and will do neither harm if neither stands in its way, but a cat turned or crowded is another matter, and no household along Imrich nam Pantar needed telling twice why the custom stood as it stood. That year the cats came as far as the narrow throat of the highest pass and no further, three of them seen by different watchers on three different days, each pausing at the same turn in the rock, each looking down the long fall of ground toward the foothills a while before it swung about and went back the way it had come, and by the fourth such turning the households nearest the pass had stopped waiting to see whether a fourth cat would finish the crossing and had begun instead to ask each other what a cat knows about a coming winter that a man does not.

The old answer, given by every old woman and old man who had outlived enough winters to be asked, was that a cat which will not cross into ground it has crossed every year of its own life is a cat that already knows the ground it is leaving is the kinder ground that year, and that a household which reads the turning

2. the panthers' crossing

aright and lays in double against a winter no cat will risk crossing into does better than a household that waits for its own eyes to be sure. The households along Imrich nam Pantar that year laid in double: double the dried fish, double the stored roots, double the cut peat and the split wood, working through the whole of that summer and autumn at a pace that left little time for anything but the storing, so that by the time the first true frost came down off the high ground behind the cats that had not come, every hearth within a day's walk of the pass had more laid by than it had ever laid by before against a winter that had not yet shown its own face. The winter that followed was as hard as any teller then living had words to measure it by, snow lying on ground that commonly saw none, and the burns running thin and slow under rims of frost, and it is told, though no single teller claims to have counted it exactly, that not one household along Imrich nam Pantar that had laid in double against the cats' own reading of the season went hungry before the thaw, while further east, where the cats' turning had been heard of only as a tale carried late and thin, more than one household came near the end of its own stores before the ground softened again.

II

Of Iain Buachaille and the Cattle in the Passes

Not every household along Imrich nam Pantar¹ heeded the cats that year, and the households of Muileann bhàn, a scatter of byres and huts set along the last good grazing before the ground climbed into the passes proper, were among those that did not, or that heeded too late to matter. The grazing about Muileann bhàn had run thin that spring before ever the cats were seen turning, the winter before having left the lower slopes bare and slow to green, and the herders there had already begun, before the first cat was so much as spoken of, to eye the high meadows inside the passes themselves, ground no household of that stretch had grazed within living memory because it lay along the cats' own road and the custom forbade it for the length of the crossing season, whatever grass stood ungrazed there while the custom held.

Among those herders was Iain, son of Iseabail of Muileann bhàn, three-and-twenty that spring and already known along that stretch of the road for a temper

1. the panthers' crossing

that took slights to the household's grazing harder than most men took slights to themselves, a fault his own mother had despaired of curing in him and had mostly stopped trying to. When word came down that the cats had turned back a second time at the throat of the pass, Iain heard in it a chance too good to waste, for a road the cats have given up crossing, he said to whoever would listen at his own hearth and at two or three neighbouring ones, is a road with nothing left on it to fear, and grass standing ungrazed a day's drive above Muileann bhàn while his own household's beasts grew thin below was a waste no custom, in his reckoning, had any business asking a hungry household to keep. His mother told him plainly that a custom kept by every household along that road since before her own grandmother's day had not likely been kept so long for no reason at all, and that three turnings of the cats in one season meant, to her mind, a road with a fourth turning still owed it, not a road with nothing left on it to fear. Iain heard her out, as a son will hear out a mother he does not mean to obey, and two mornings after went up into the passes with four other men of the household and near forty head of the household's thinnest cattle, meaning to graze them a week on the high meadows and bring them down fattened before the cats' season was out.

They had the cattle up and grazing by the second day, on grass richer than any of the five men had seen standing anywhere below the passes that whole dry summer, and for three days more nothing troubled them but the cold, which came down harder each night than the last, and the wind off the high rock, which none of them had properly dressed against, having gone up in the light gear of men driving cattle a short way rather than men meaning to camp a week among stone. It was on the fourth night, with the fire burned low and two of the five men asleep and Iain himself keeping the first watch more from restlessness than any sense that watching was needed, that the panthers came down on the herd, a whole string of them together, the last and largest cats of that year's crossing, driven onto the road at last, the tellers say afterward, by a hunger of their own that the turning back had only put off and not ended. Iain heard the cattle before he saw anything, a sound no herder mistakes for any other sound cattle make, and had the other four on their feet and the fire built high before the first cat broke into the firelight after a beast at the edge of the huddled herd, and what followed, by Iain's own telling of it afterward, he could give no clean account of, for a night fight with cats among cattle in the dark leaves a man with pieces of what happened and no whole cloth to lay them in: a beast down and screaming, a shape low and fast crossing the firelight, his own spear thrown and lost, and then the

ground going out from under him as he threw himself sideways from a claw he never afterward could say he truly saw coming, his leg twisting under him against a stone he had not known was there, and a white pain up through the hip that put him on the ground for the rest of that night no matter how the fight round him went.

By first light the cats were gone, south along their own road as though the night's killing had settled whatever debt they had come down to collect, and the five men counted, in the grey after, thirty head of the household's forty taken or scattered beyond finding, and Iain unable to stand on the leg that had gone from under him in the dark. They carried him down off the high ground on a hide slung between two spear-shafts, the other three driving what was left of the herd before them, and it was three days before any of the five was fit to speak much of what the night had cost, and longer than that before Iain's leg, set as well as the household's own healing hand could set it, showed any household at Muileann bhàn what it had truly cost him: a leg that healed crooked at the hip no matter how it was bound, that shortened against its fellow by the width of two fingers by the time the swelling was fully down, and that left him, from that winter on, a man who walked with a stick and a roll to one side for every step he took, in a household of herders where a man's legs are as much his living as his hands. His mother said nothing to him of the custom he had broken, then or ever after that she is remembered to have said, and Iain himself said little of that night to anyone for a long while, beyond the plain account any household along that road would ask of a man who had lost it thirty head, and it was left to the road, over the seasons that followed, to turn what had happened to him into the shorter saying it kept: that the cats had turned back three times that spring to tell every household along the road what one household had not troubled to hear the first time.

III

Of the Gatepost Sign and the Boats Named for Wind

It was in the years just after, while Iain was learning to make a lame man's work of a whole man's trade, that the custom the households of Muileann bhàn had broken began, further south, to be kept in a new way that no household along Imrich nam Pantar¹ had thought to keep it before. At Baile

dhomhain, where the grazing lay well clear of the passes but where the crossing season still shaped the year as surely as it shaped it anywhere the cats' own road ran, the households took to cutting a mark into the gatepost of every byre and yard at the season's start, a short straight cut no deeper than a knife needs to make its point, and scraping it away again at the season's close, so that a man riding through Baile dhomhain in the crossing months could read at a glance, gate by gate, which households stood mindful of the season and which did not trouble, and a household whose gatepost went uncut two years running found itself, without any word said outright, asked fewer favours and lent fewer beasts than a household that kept the mark faithfully. No household before that is remembered to have cut a sign for a season rather than for an event, a birth or a death or a boundary settled, and the mark at Baile dhomhain, plain as it was, is counted the first the island kept for nothing more than the turning of the year.

Further north, where the coast ran along the mouth of the river the fishing households called simply the blue water, the households of Caol bheag came in those same years to a custom of their own that answered no cat's road but the same restless weather that governed every boat on that stretch of coast. Each household there had long since taken to naming its boats, as households everywhere name the things they build with their own hands and trust their lives to, but it was at Caol bheag that the naming first fixed on the winds a boat was built and blessed to fish in, so that a boat built for the wind out of the north bore a north wind's name and was held unlucky if put out under any other, and a boat that went down under its own true wind was never, by the custom that grew up there, given its name again, for a name once drowned was held to carry the drowning with it into whatever boat next wore it. The fishing households up and down that coast came in time to know each other's boats as much by name as by build, and a man newly wed into a household there learned the winds' names for boats before he learned much else of his wife's own kin, for a boat wrongly named, in the reckoning of that coast, was a debt a household paid for sooner or later, whatever the weather did or did not do to collect it.

IV

Of the Wind-Stone and the Broken Grave

1. the panthers' crossing

At Seann Chwen, midway along the same stretch of high ground Imrich nam Pantar¹ crossed, there stood, older than any household near it could put a beginning to, a low grey boulder cut about with marks no living hand had made and no living eye could read whole, the same close, careful, patient marks Seann-Dhaoine² had left on stones the length of the island wherever the ground stood high enough and bare enough to take a chisel, and it was on that stone, in the years after Iain's leg had set crooked, that a cutter of that household first set one of Na h-Ochd Gaothan³' names beside the older marks, in the plainer, broader cuts the hill-folk's own chisels made, so that the boulder came to carry, on the one face, both a telling no living hand could read and a telling any household passing could read at a glance. Few stones on the island came to bear the marks of both peoples so close together, for the households that raised their own signs commonly chose ground Seann-Dhaoine had left bare, out of a wariness that had less to do with any harm believed to lie in the older marks than with a plain unwillingness to set a new thing hard against an old one nobody living could account for; the cutter at Seann Chwen, asked why he had chosen that stone over any bare boulder near it, said only that the wind-name wanted a stone already old, and the oldest stone he knew stood already there.

A day's walk south of Seann Chwen lay the old burial ground the households of that country had kept, in one fashion or another, longer than any single line among them could claim to have kept it alone, a wide low field thick with thorn and bramble where the dead of a dozen households lay under cairns of every age from freshly turned to grass-grown past finding, and it was in those same years that a family newly settled nearby, kin to none of the households that already had dead lying there, took on the clearing of the thorn from the older rows, cutting it back each spring so the cairns beneath could still be found and the paths between them still be walked, though they laid none of their own dead among the ones they tended, having none yet to lay, and meant, by their own account, only to keep a ground that plainly wanted keeping and had no one household whose plain business it was. They kept it faithfully enough that within a few years no household of that country thought to clear the thorn any longer, trusting the keeping to the family that had taken it up unasked, and it was diggers of that same family, cutting a new row further back than any row before it had reached, who

1. the panthers' crossing

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

3. the eight named winds

broke one spring into a grave older than any they had themselves opened, lined on every side with cut slabs set close and true in a manner no household of that country built its own graves in, a manner the diggers knew at once, without needing to be told, for the manner of Seann-Dhaoine. They closed what they had opened as carefully as they had opened it, moving the new row a spear's length further off rather than cut any nearer, and no digger of that ground, then or after, is remembered to have tried that older grave a second time, the family's own reckoning being, as the eldest of them put it, that a ground kept for the dead does not want its keepers asking after graves it was never given to keep.

V

Of the Pilgrims and the Child Lost at Cnoc bheag

East of Seann Chwen, where the ground fell away into woodland thick enough that no household had yet cleared more than its own edge, there stood a stretch of forest the hill-folk had long held sacred without any household near it being able to say plainly when the holding had begun or why that wood rather than any other had been set apart from the ordinary clearing and grazing every other stretch of woodland on the island was put to sooner or later. In the years after the wind-stone was cut at Seann Chwen, people from households that had never before troubled to walk so far began coming to the edge of that wood in small numbers, singly and in pairs, to sit through a single night at the line where the trees began without ever passing in among them, keeping a small fire that burned itself out before morning and going home again at first light with nothing to show for the walk but whatever the night had given them to carry back. No household could say who had begun the walking, nor what any single pilgrim hoped to find at the wood's edge that could not as well have been sought at his own hearth, and the pilgrims themselves, asked, gave answers as various as the households they came from, though most agreed on this much: that a night spent at the edge of that wood, awake and watchful and asking nothing of it, left a man quieter than the same night spent anywhere else was likely to leave him.

Further east again, past a stretch of country still mostly given over to grazing, lay another wood held sacred in the same fashion and for the same unremembered reasons, and it was at the edge of that wood, some years after the pil-

grims had begun sitting at the first, that settlers newly come down from An Cnoc Ruadh¹ raised the earliest house of what would grow, in the years that followed, into a small settlement of its own at Cnoc bheag, taking their timber, as the custom of that country already held for ground so near a sacred wood, only from the far side of the river that ran between the settlement and the trees, and never from the unclaimed wood, however near and however tempting its unfelled timber stood. The settlement grew slowly, a house and then two and then a handful more over several years, each household keeping, without needing to be told twice, the same line the first house had kept between its own clearing and the trees, a line marked at last, once enough households stood there to agree on marking it, by a row of unhewn stones set at the wood's edge from the river to the higher ground, a line no child of that settlement was raised without being told, before it was told much else, never to cross.

It was past that line, in the year the settlement had grown to six houses, that a child went missing, a boy not yet seven summers old, last seen by his own mother at play near the stones and next seen by no one at all, though the whole settlement and every household within reach of the news spent three days searching the wood as far in as any of them dared go, calling his name through undergrowth thick enough that a man three strides off could not always be seen, let alone a boy small enough to have gone to ground under any fallen branch or into any hollow the wood offered him. Iain, near six-and-forty that year and walking still with the stick and the roll to one side that the panthers had left him three-and-twenty years before, was among the searchers who came from Muileann bhàn and the country about it to help hunt a wood he had never before had cause to enter, a lame man's search being slower and shorter-ranged than a whole man's but no less willing for that, and it was Iain, by more than one account, who first said aloud what every searcher among them had by the third day begun privately to think, that a wood no household of that country would fell timber from nor build a house nearer than the far bank of its own river was not, whatever the boy's own mother might in her grief still hope, a wood that gave back what it had taken, and that a search which had by then gone three days past the line of stones without one sign of the child was a search that had done, and would go on doing, everything a search could rightly be asked to do. The searchers stopped at the line of stones on the evening of the third day, no one among them commanding it, each in his own

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

time and by his own reckoning coming to the same stopping as Iain had spoken first, and the boy was never found, in that wood or any other, and no teller of that country, then or after, ever laid the stopping at the searchers' own door, for a wood held apart from every other wood on the island for reasons no living household could name was, in the plain reckoning of that country, no wood a man could be blamed for failing to bring a child safely out of.

VI

Of the Warm Springs

Iain carried the leg the panthers had left him for seven-and-twenty years after that first night in the passes, through the raising of his own household and the burying of his mother and the long slow work of teaching younger men of Muileann bhàn a herder's trade he could no longer himself practise at more than half a whole man's pace, and in all that time he tried, as any man in his place tries, every cure his own household and every neighbouring one had ever heard spoken of: bindings of every plant the hill country grew that anyone claimed had ever eased a joint, a winter spent wrapping the leg each night in hide soaked warm from the fire, a season's walking on a crutch cut shorter than his stick to see whether the leg, forced to bear more of its own weight, might in time straighten, which it did not. By the year the boy was lost at Cnoc bheag he had stopped, by his own later account, expecting any cure at all, and had come to think of the leg the way a man comes in time to think of any hurt that has outlasted every hope of mending it, as simply the form his own life had settled into and would go on wearing until it wore him out.

It was four years after the search at Cnoc bheag, in a spring when the leg had begun to pain him worse than it had in a long while, the cold and the wet of that season finding every old crookedness in it that fair weather let him mostly forget, that a neighbour of his, back from a journey south for reasons of the neighbour's own, told him of a warm water that rose from under the mountain a long way off, ground his own kin had once passed through and camped a night beside, water that came up out of the rock already heated and pooled shallow enough for a man to sit in it, and that more than one traveller resting there had come away saying the water had eased an old hurt no ordinary washing ever touched. Iain heard the telling the way he had by then learned to hear most tellings of cures he had not

himself tried, without much hope and without much unwillingness either, and said nothing of going for the better part of that year, until the leg's own pain, worse that spring than any spring before it, gave him less to lose by the walking than he had ever before reckoned he had.

He went that same summer, on the stick he had carried seven-and-twenty years, a journey of many days for a whole man and a great many more for a man who could put no real weight on one leg, staying at whatever households along the way would have a lame stranger by their fire a night, and came at last to the warm water on an evening when a handful of other travellers were already camped about it, some there, as he learned by their own telling round the shared fire that night, for the same hope that had brought him and some merely to rest a night on a long road elsewhere. At first light the next morning, before the others were properly stirring, he eased himself down into the water onto a shelf of rock the water covered to the waist, and sat there a long while, by his own account longer than he had meant to, the heat working into the crooked hip in a way no binding or wrapping he had ever tried had come near to matching, and when at last he rose to climb out he found, standing on the rock in the cool morning air with the water running off him, that the leg under him held its own weight in a way it had not held it in seven-and-twenty years, not straightened, for no water on the island could undo what a night of panthers had done to the bone, but eased past whatever had kept it locked and grinding at every step, so that he walked the length of the pool's edge and back again without once reaching for the stick he had set down on the rock beside him.

He stayed three days more at the warm water, going into it each morning and each evening, and walked home to Muileann bhàn, by every teller's account of it since, on his own two legs and without the stick he had carried south, a journey that took him near half the days the same road had taken him going, a lame man's walk cut down, near enough, to a whole man's pace. His own household, seeing him come up the last rise toward the byres without the roll to one side they had watched him walk with for seven-and-twenty years, took him at first, more than one of them said after, for some other traveller entirely, a man of Iain's own build and no more, until he was near enough to call his own name across the yard and be known by his own mother's grandchildren, who had never in their own short lives seen him walk any other way. It is that walking, and not the water, that the tellers of that country kept as the whole of what happened at Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹ that year, a herder who came to them lame and walked home from them whole, and it stands, of every cure any teller of Dia-thìr has since claimed for that water, the oldest and the first, told wherever the springs themselves are told of, in words that have changed little from the plain shape Iain's own household first gave them: that he came lame, and he walked home.

VII

Of the Hollow Man and the Covered Hearth

In the years just after, two herders of a household near the hills where Marbh-bhed¹ was oldest told of, driving cattle home later than they had meant to and caught by full dark still some way off, saw a shape walk the ridge above them with no breath showing in the bitter cold, though every breath of their own hung white before their faces the whole way down, and neither of the two, by their own telling after, could say the shape had done anything at all beyond the walking, no word spoken, no hand raised, nothing but a going along the ridge line at a man's own ordinary pace until the dark or the ground took it out of their sight. They had lit no fire that evening, having pressed on for home rather than camp so near those hills after dark, and it was that, the telling holds, and no virtue of their own, that let them come home at all to tell of it, for every older telling of that shape

1. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

1. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

agreed on the one plain rule any household near those hills kept without needing telling twice: that a fire lit on those slopes after dark was a fire Marbh-bheò came to, sooner or later, and a household that lit one did not always sit by it undisturbed until morning.

It was in those same years, spreading out from those same hills toward the settlements that lay nearer the eastern woods, that a new manner of hearth began to be built in household after household, a fire pit dug below the level of the floor and roofed over with a low stone lid that could be drawn across at need, so that a household could bank its coals for the night and cover them close, leaving no open flame nor rising smoke for anything abroad in the dark to be drawn toward, and wake in the morning to coals still live enough to be raked open and blown to flame again with no fresh striking of fire needed. The covered hearth spread faster among the households nearest those hills than anywhere else on the island, and it was there, before it was anywhere, that the custom hardened at last into something near a law that every household on those slopes kept whether or not it had ever seen anything walk a ridge in the dark: that no open fire was lit there after nightfall, coal-banked or covered or none at all, a rule no council had made and no holder had set his hand to, kept simply because every household near enough to those hills to be asked had, sooner or later, heard from some neighbour's own mouth a telling near enough to the two herders' to want no fire of its own left open to whatever the telling was a telling of.

Iain Buachaille lived on at Muileann bhàn many years after his own walk home from the warm water, on legs that carried him, to the end of his days, further and more evenly than any household there had thought, in na Bliadhnachan Fada² of his lameness, he would ever walk again, and it was said of him along that stretch of Imrich nam Pantar³, for as long as any household there kept the saying, that he alone among the men who had broken the custom that hard year had lived to be mended of what the breaking cost him, though no teller of that country ever claimed the mending answered the breaking, nor said the cats had given him back what they had taken, for a leg does not forget, whatever ease the warm water worked into it, the night it was first twisted under a man in the dark, and Iain himself, asked in his own old age whether he still felt the passes in bad weather, would say only that he did, and that a man who has walked home once from a

2. the long years of Ailean's kin

3. the panthers' crossing

hurt he had stopped hoping to be rid of does not, after that, trouble much over what a little weather still asks of him.

CHAPTER THIRTY

OF THE RINGS UNDER THE Oaks

GE 2,461 – 2,600

Sheas an darach mus do sheas sinne; seasaidh e às ar dèidh. The oak stood before we stood; it will stand after us. — said of the grove at Doire ghlas, as the households that ring it keep it still

I

Of the Middens and the Strait

This is told among Clann na Ceiste¹, who kept the years of the settling the way they kept everything: by mouth, in Somhairle's own words, passed down through his line long after his face had begun to change.

Somhairle was two thousand four hundred and twenty-three years old in the spring the covered hearth reached the last households of the near valleys, and he had by then stopped counting his years in the ordinary way, the way Clann na Ceiste counted a herdsman's or a raker's, because a century for him had come to feel no longer than a season felt for them. He kept the Line whole in his own head, every name his father had given him and every name added since, and he kept, besides the Line, a habit that was his alone among the king's blood: he walked. Where Dòmhnall had ridden north to hold what was won, and Iain Dubh had ridden south to lose his life on a shingle beach, and the rest of his brothers and sisters had taken hills or given them up, Somhairle went on foot, slowly, from one new roof to the next, and looked, and said little, and was, by the

1. the Children of the Question

time this telling begins, known at every threshold of the island as the king's son who came and sat by the fire and asked nothing and took no share.

It was on such a walk that he came first to Caol mhòr, on the narrow water where Seann-Dhaoine² had once heaped their middens high along the strand, shell on shell for longer than any teller could reckon. The households that settled there in his two thousand four hundred and twenty-fourth year built their walls, when they built in stone at all, from the midden, prising loose what the tide had not already carried off; but they would not turn a stone that still showed a mark, whether cut by a hand or worn by nothing but weather, and set those aside in a low unmortared line along the shore instead, so that a stranger walking the strand a hundred years on would find two kinds of wall standing side by side, one raised by the living and one left standing by people who had chosen not to disturb what they did not understand. Somhairle asked an old woman there, raking limpets from among the shells, why they troubled to sort the marked stones from the plain ones when no one now living could read either. She said only that a mark was a mark, whoever cut it, and that a wall built careless of what it stood on had no business standing long; and Somhairle, who had heard Seann-Dhaoine' silence answered a hundred ways by a hundred different households in his four and twenty centuries of walking, thought hers as good an answer as any and better than most.

He went from there along the coast road to Baile chrom, where households out of Cnoc ghorm had come down some years before to work ground the older settlement had let lie fallow since a bad season none now remembered clearly, and found the resettling further along than the last word of it had told him: byres roofed, a well dug and lined, children old enough to be sent for water without a grown hand beside them. The headman there, a broad quiet man called Donchadh Ruadh, walked him round the bounds himself and showed him where the old field-marks still stood under the new grass, half sunk, half grown over, and said that his own grandmother had told him whose hands first set those stones though she had never once said the name aloud, only that the ground remembered its first ploughing whether or not the people who ploughed it were remembered with it. Somhairle set nothing of that into the Line, for Clann na Ceiste kept the Line before every small saying that crossed a walker's path; he car-

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

ried this one with him all the same, turning it over on the road the way a man turns a stone he means to look at again by better light.

II

Of the Salt Road and the Rebuilt Wall

Rathad an t-Salainn that ran from the pans at Baile ghorm to the north-west had, by Somhairle's two thousand four hundred and thirtieth year, been walked so long and by so many feet that its last unbroken stand of scrub, a thicket of thorn and low birch that had turned every laden cart a half-day out of its way for as long as the road had run, was cut through at last by carriers weary of the going round it, and Muileann àrsaidh stood at the road's end after that a full day nearer the salt than it had ever been before. The millers there kept no count of who had swung the first axe into that thicket, for a dozen hands had reason to want it gone and none troubled to claim the doing of it alone; what they kept, and what Somhairle heard told at their own hearth, was that the thicket had stood since before the eldest living miller's grandfather's day, and that its going felt to some of the older households less like a road cleared than like a boundary taken down, though none of them could say clearly what had stood on either side of it worth calling a boundary.

Further east, on ground no household of the king's blood had ever held a share of, the settlers pushing toward the rising country raised the first turned bank east of the old workings, at Dùn thais, in the same year the millers cleared their thicket, digging a ditch and setting the spoil up behind it the way Rìghrean na Cloiche' own hill had long since taught every settling household to do, without any word sent from Dùn ìseal telling them to do so and without any word sent back once it was done. Somhairle stood on that bank himself, some years after, and found it a smaller, rougher thing than his father's hill, no more than a shoulder-high ring of earth round a scatter of low houses, but built, he thought, by people who had watched the king's hill from a distance long enough to know a bank kept a herd in and a raider out better than any number of dogs, and had built one of their own the first year they had hands enough to spare for it.

Fire did the clearing at Achadh chaol, where the ground lay heavy with scrub too old and too green to be cut by axe alone; the households there burned it back

a field's width at a time across three dry summers, and ploughed the black ground while the ash was still warm in it, and got, the first year, a crop the older fields further west had not equalled in a generation. Cuan ruadh, on the eastern coast A' Ghaoth Dhubh² had stripped bare not many years before, set the last course of its rebuilt wall the same season, stone laid to the eaves the whole circuit of the settlement, the first roofs on that coast built to stand against wind rather than merely to be raised again after it; and Cathair fhada, further south, opened a well within its own bank the same year, so that a siege of weather, if it came again as A' Ghaoth Dhubh had come, need not send the whole household down to the shore for water while the wind still had teeth in it. At Caol ruadh, on the narrow strait where the current ran strong enough to carry a badly set net clean out to open water, the fishers took to marking the deep channels with woven buoys tied to stones, a small thing, Somhairle thought when he heard of it, but the kind of small thing that spread from one strait to the next the way An Cnoc Ruadh's paired tide-marks had spread, carried in a carrier's mouth and taken up by people who never asked who had thought of it first.

He asked the folk of Caol ruadh, once, sitting with the fishers over their evening catch, who had first thought to tie the woven buoys over the deep water, and got the same answer he had grown used to hearing everywhere he asked such a question: no one could rightly say, only that a boy had tied the first one two or three summers back after losing a net to the current, and that the next household to lose a net had tied one too, and after that it was simply how a net was set on that strait, the way a boat was rowed with the current or against it, and not a thing anyone thought to credit to a single pair of hands. It struck Somhairle, hearing it, as much the same shape of story he had heard told of the paired marks on the tide-rock at Ros dhomhain, a custom that had spread the same way, from one keeper's trouble to every household's taking-up of it, and he began, walking on from Caol ruadh, to keep a private reckoning of his own of how many customs on the island had grown that way, out of one household's trouble and every household's willingness to take up what worked without asking who had thought of it first: more, he judged, before he had gone very much further, than his father had ever once had to command.

He walked among all of these in the years his brothers and sisters held or lost their hills, and he came, in time, to think of the island less as his father's kingdom,

1. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

2. the Black Wind

which the reciters at every gathering still called it, and more as a great many small kingdoms of one custom each, none of them written anywhere, all of them somehow agreed to by people who had never sat in council to agree to anything.

III

Of the Word from the North

Word reached him at the slab, where he still kept his own turn among the households that sat out the dark half of the year with Beathan, that families out of the near valleys had begun that autumn to come down to Doire ghlas and build there, in the grove, under the very oaks his father had set the six pots beneath on the night of the seven fires. It was told to him plainly, by a herdsman's wife who had no notion what the grove meant to the man she was telling, that the new households liked the ground for its shelter and its old cleared paths, and that they had already begun marking timber for the first of the new byres.

Somhairle said nothing to her of what she had told him, and sat out the rest of his turn at the slab as he always did, but he left Na Glinn Àrda¹ within the week, alone, on foot, walking north by the same road his father had walked south on with eleven of his kin behind him near two thousand five hundred years before, though the road had long since worn wider and straighter than the track Ailean had first taken. It was sixty-five miles from the hill of Rìghrean na Cloiche² to the grove, a walk of four days at the pace Somhairle kept, and he spent much of it turning over, as he had turned over Donnchadh Ruadh's word about the ground remembering its ploughing, whether he had any right at all to want the grove kept as it had stood on the one night that made it matter to him, when every field and every wall he had walked past for four and twenty centuries had been let become whatever the people living on it needed it to become.

IV

Of the Road North

3. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

The road ran through country Somhairle had walked so many times that he no longer needed to look at it to know what lay round the next turning, and yet he found, walking it that autumn with a purpose he had not carried on any of his earlier crossings, that he saw it as if new: the boundary stones Dòmhnall had once set with his own hands, still standing where quarrels had been settled in Somhairle's own boyhood; the wide trodden ground where the salt-carriers rested their beasts each evening, worn bare of grass by feet that had crossed it for longer than any single generation could account for.

He slept the first night in a herder's shelter kept swept, as every shelter on that road was kept swept, by whoever had passed it last, and shared bread with a family driving cattle down from the high pastures before the weather turned, who took him, from his plain dress and his slow speech, for nothing more than an old walker of no particular house, and told him freely what they would not have told a man they knew for the king's own son: that they thought the settling gone further and faster than any of them liked, fields opened where their grandparents' grandparents had grazed without a fence between one household's beasts and the next, and no one, king or otherwise, troubling to say whether that was a good thing or a bad one. Somhairle said only that he had walked the same roads a long while and thought most changes looked worse from close by than they read afterward from a little distance, which was as near to an answer as he ever gave anyone who did not know who was giving it.

He came to Doire ghlas on the evening of the fourth day and found the households further along than the herdsman's wife's telling had prepared him for: a dozen houses already roofed, more staked out in a rough ring, and among the oaks, cut low into the bark of three of the oldest trunks in the grove, the fresh white marks that meant a tree was chosen for the axe.

V

Of the Marks on the Old Bark

he stood a long while before the nearest of the three marked oaks, a tree with a girth no four men could have spanned with linked arms, its bark grey and split with age in a way that put him, though he did not say so to anyone that evening, in mind of nothing so much as his own father's hands, which had held their warmth through two thousand four hundred and seventy

years without once showing a single line of age. The households working nearby knew him for the king's son who walked and asked nothing, and one of the settlers, a lean, quick-spoken man called Fearchar mac Ailig who had come down from the near valleys with the first families that autumn, walked over to see what held him so still and told him, when he asked, that the oldest trees gave the best timber for roof-beams, being straight-grained where the younger growth still twisted, and that the households meant no disrespect to the grove in cutting them, only good sense in building.

"It is a fair grove for building in," Fearchar said, "sheltered from three winds and with good water below it, and we are grateful for the finding of it, whoever cleared the paths through it before us." He did not know, and Somhairle did not tell him, whose hands those paths had first been trodden by, or what had stood in the ring of oaks he was measuring for beams on the one night that ring had ever held its full seven fires at once.

Somhairle asked him, then, plainly, whether the household would spare the three oldest trees and take their timber elsewhere, and gave, when Fearchar asked him why, the only reason that was wholly his own to give: that his father had set six pots under those particular trunks once, long before Fearchar's grandmother's grandmother was born, and that Somhairle, who asked nothing of any household on the whole island and took no share of anything the king held, asked this one thing of this one household, for this one grove, and would ask it of no other. He did not say the word grove meant to Clann na Ceiste¹, or name the seven fires, or tell Fearchar what the Line said had moved between the trunks on the eighth night; he gave the household the plainest telling he could make of a thing that was not, at its root, plain at all, and left the rest to whatever weight his own asking carried.

VI

Of the Oaks Left Standing

Fearchar carried the asking to the rest of the household that same evening, and it is told at Doire ghlais still, in the plain way the settlement kept most of its own small history, that there was little argument over it: the three

1. the Children of the Question

trunks were old enough that felling them would have cost more labour than younger growth close at hand, and a request from the king's own son, however oddly reasoned, was not a thing a settling household weighed lightly against a morning's easier cutting. The white marks were cut away from the bark within the week, and the beams for the first byres came instead from a stand of younger oak a short walk to the east, straighter in the grain and easier to the axe than Fearchar had first thought the older trees would be, so that the household lost, in the end, less by the sparing than it had feared to.

The three oaks stood after that at the centre of the new settlement rather than at its edge, for the houses went up in a rough ring around them the way the households had first laid out their stakes, and within a generation the ring had a name among the people who lived inside it, though not one that named the grove's older meaning: they called it, simply, the ring under the oaks, for the three trunks that stood taller than any roof raised near them and gave a shade in summer no roof could match. No teller at Doire ghlas, in all the years after, ever set down why those three trees and no others had been spared when every household around them cut freely; the reason lived only in Somhairle's own telling, kept by Clann na Ceiste¹ the way they kept everything, by mouth, apart from anything the settlement itself kept of its own founding.

Somhairle stayed at Doire ghlas the better part of that autumn, sitting some evenings at Fearchar's own hearth and some at others, watching the ring of new roofs rise round the old ring of oaks, and it was there, more than at any slab in Na Glinn Àrda² or any bank raised against a storm, that he came to think the settling of the island had worked out, without any law behind it, the very thing his father never troubled to write down for anyone: a thing worth keeping got kept, in the end, because enough people, asked plainly and given a reason that cost them little, found they had no strong wish to refuse it, though no king had ever told them they must.

VII

Of the Lines in His Face

1. the Children of the Question

2. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

he was walking south again, back toward Na Glinn Àrda¹, in his two thousand four hundred and thirty-fifth year, when a woman selling cheese at a roadside stall in the near valleys looked at him a moment longer than a stranger usually troubled to and asked, not unkindly, whether he had been unwell that season, for there were lines about his eyes that had not been there, she thought, the last time he passed her stall. Somhairle had heard such things said before, in jest, by people who took his slow way of speaking for an old man's caution and forgot, a breath later, that they had ever thought it; but he stopped that day at a still pool a little further on and looked at his own reflection for longer than he had troubled to look at it in decades, and found, when he looked closely, that she had told him true. There were lines at the corners of his eyes that had not been there when Beathan was born, and the grey that had stood at his temples a thousand years unmoving creeping now into his beard, so that a stranger might, for the first time in two thousand four hundred and thirty-five years, have taken him for what he actually was: a man growing old, slowly, the way his father never would.

He told no one of it at first, not even Beathan, who still sat out his own turns by the slab in Na Glinn Àrda and had not, so far as Somhairle could tell, begun to age at all; but Beathan noticed it himself before the year was out, coming upon his father unexpectedly at the slab one evening and stopping in the doorway a moment before he crossed it, the way a man stops when a familiar face shows him something he was not looking for. Neither of them spoke of it that night, or for some while after, for Clann na Ceiste² were not a people who troubled a thing with words before the thing had finished happening to them; but it is told, among the few who kept that particular winter's telling whole, that Somhairle sat later that season at the fire with a young cousin of Beathan's wife, newly come into the household, who did not know him and took him, from his grey beard and his slow way of sitting, for an old man of no particular importance among the king's blood, and that Somhairle let the mistake stand a full evening without correcting it, listening to her talk of the settling further north as though he had walked none of that ground, and finding in the listening a quiet he had not expected the ageing to bring him.

It was Beathan who finally asked him of it, the following spring, sitting together at the slab through a night neither of them was properly owed by the custom,

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

2. the Children of the Question

the young households having gone home early with a storm coming on. "You are changing," Beathan said, plainly, the way his father had taught him to say most things. "I have watched every face in Na Glinn Àrda change, mother among them, and I never once thought to watch yours." Somhairle answered that he had not thought to watch it either, and that he did not know why it should begin now, in his two thousand four hundred and thirty-sixth year, when it had not begun in his first thousand, and that he supposed the not-knowing was itself a kind of answer, of the sort Clann na Ceiste had always been given and had always kept without asking for better. Beathan sat with that a long while, turning it the way his father turned most things, and said at last only that he was glad, whatever it meant, that his father would grow old among them rather than remain forever the one face at every hearth that time did not touch; and Somhairle, hearing it, thought it the truest thing either of them had said to the other in some decades.

He kept the Line whole in his own head still, every name his father had given him and every name added since Doire ghlas took its own new name, and he went on walking, in the years that followed, from settlement to settlement across the widening island, though a little more slowly each year, and a little more often now stopping, on a road he had walked a hundred times before, simply to sit a while and watch new roofs going up round trees his father's own hands had once passed under, unremembered by anyone building beneath them but the one man on the whole island whose own years were, at last, beginning to run out the ordinary way.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

OF MURCHADH IN THE NORTH

GE 2,601 – 2,999

Cha bhi cnoc aig neach ach fhad 's a their an Rìgh e. No one holds a hill longer than the King says he does. — said in the northern plain, of every holder since Murchadh

I

Of the Spring That Never Freezes

Murchadh was the ninth of the king's sons, and the one the king sent north to the plain with nothing more than his own name to hold it by, and he was eight hundred and ninety-six years old the spring he rode out of Dùn ìseal with sixty households at his back and a strip of the northern plain in his keeping that no one before him had troubled to settle beyond its edges. He had his mother's black hair still, and would keep it long after the households he led north had buried three generations of their own greying, for he was born after the grove like his father's other sons, though already, in that ninth century of his life, the first grey had begun to show at his temples, faint as frost on a north slope, so that the older men riding with him took it for a kind of promise, that whatever else he was he would not outlast them by so many lifetimes that they need never learn the shape of his death.

The ground he was given had one thing on it worth the naming, a spring on a low rise above the plain that ran clear and full through every winter the households there could remember, never once skinned with ice though the standing

pools about it froze hard enough to bear a man's weight from Samhain to the first thaw. Murchadh had heard of it from a herdsman before he had ever seen it, and when he came to it at last, in the fifteenth year of his holding, he stood over it a long while without speaking, watching the water break the crust of frost at its lip and run on regardless, and it is told that he said only, to the men beside him, that a household built round a thing that did not freeze need never again reckon its water against its wood, and that this was worth more to men in that country than any wall.

He raised his own hall there that same year, timber and turf as every hall on the island still was raised, and called the place for its size before it had earned the name, Baile Mòr mhòr, the great big town, which the households about him took at first for a joke against the six poor roofs then standing and kept afterward without irony once the joke had come true under them. By the time Murchadh's own hair had gone properly grey, in the fourth century of his holding, Baile Mòr mhòr stood eighty houses about the spring, byres and workshops and a granary raised on stones against the damp, the largest place built in that generation anywhere north of An Cnoc Ruadh¹, and the households of the plain came to it at every gathering-tide the way lesser streams come down into a river, bringing wool and hides and the grey flint of Cnoc àrsaidh to trade against salt carried up from the shore.

He did not call himself a king there, nor one of Rìghrean na Cloiche², nor anything the households of the south would have known the word for. He called himself, when anyone asked, a man holding ground his father had given him, and left it at that, and the plain took to calling him the same, Murchadh a chumas am Blàr, Murchadh who holds the plain, until the longer telling wore down to the shorter one and he was simply Murchadh Mòr, the name his own great size and his father's habit of naming things large had between them settled on him before he was two hundred years into the holding.

II

Of the Rough Ground and the Boar-Thickets

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

The plain did not fill all at once, and what filled it, in the years after Baile Mòr mhòr stood entire, filled it the way water finds the low ground first and the high ground after, household following household along whatever line of easy walking or standing water led them on.

North-east of Murchadh's spring the ground rose rough and stony, fit for little but sheep, and it was sheep the households there kept from the first year they broke ground, calling the place Baile gharbh for the roughness under it, and sending their wool south along the coast road to Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹ every year rather than north to Murchadh's own granary, for the coast road was the shorter way and the ford took wool as readily as the plain did. West of the spring, along the coast where the old thickets still stood thick with thorn and rowan, the boars ran heavier and meaner than anywhere else the island's herders knew, and the households that settled there, at a place they called Baile fhiadhaich for the wildness of it, hung the tusks of the biggest boars over their doors the way other households hung a fox's brush, and ate boar at every feast the way the southern shore ate fish, until it was said, half in mockery and half in plain fact, that a man from Baile fhiadhaich could be known by his gait before he opened his mouth, from a lifetime of walking ground a boar might break from at any step.

Further round the coast, on a harbour the old maps of that country did not trouble to name, households took up an anchorage beside a stone landing built by hands none of them could put a name to, older than any wall standing near it, and used the landing as it stood without mending a stone of it, out of a caution common enough among the island's settlers wherever Seann-Dhaoine²' work still stood, that a thing built by hands so long silent was better left as it was found than corrected by hands that did not understand it. They called the place Cuan shean, the old bay, for the landing rather than for themselves, and it grew slowly at first and then, once the fish proved good off that coast, faster than either Baile gharbh or Baile fhiadhaich, until within two centuries it had its own small fleet and its own small quarrel with Murchadh's granary over which of them the coast road properly served.

Murchadh rode the round of these three settlements once in every decade of his early holding, less often as the decades lengthened into centuries and the ride came to feel shorter to a man for whom a decade was no longer than a season had once been to the men riding beside him. He judged what needed judging, a

1. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

boundary dispute at Baile gharbh over a well two households claimed by the same spring, a quarrel at Baile fhiadhaich over whose dogs had put up whose boar, and settled each the way his father settled such things at the ford, by hearing both sides through and giving the ground to whichever household had been longer on it, without troubling to write the judgment down anywhere but in the memory of the households who had heard it given.

III

Of Eithne and of the Sons

In the hundred and second year of Murchadh's holding, in the north, word came south to Dùn ìseal that the king had another daughter, born to a wife of the near valleys whom the reciters afterward remembered chiefly for a quickness of tongue that her daughter kept whole. They named her Eithne, and she was born in the year the households of Dùn ìseal count as two thousand seven hundred and three of the grove, a hundred years after Murchadh had ridden north with his sixty households, so that by the time she was grown enough to be spoken of as anything but a child she was already a stranger to the plain her half-brother held, and knew him, when she did come to know him, chiefly by his size and by a certain slowness of speech that she took, in her own quickness, for stupidity, and was some centuries in unlearning.

Murchadh himself, in that same span of years, had begun a household of his own sons, eleven of them born to two wives over the better part of three centuries, the first in the hundred and nineteenth year of his holding and the last so long after the first that the eldest of the eleven had grey in his own beard before the youngest had his first tooth. He gave each of them, as they came of an age to want it, a corner of the plain to hold under him rather than a share of his own hall, for he had learned, watching his father give and take back the whole island by the same rule, that a son set to holding a corner of ground learns the weight of it faster than a son kept idle at his father's own hearth, and every one of the eleven, in his turn, learned it. The eldest, a broad, slow-spoken man the plain came to call Aonghas an Spuir for a spur of high ground he held above the river, held it so well and so long that his own son after him held it in turn without any word from Murchadh needed to confirm it, and it was that steady holding, more than any of

the louder ones, that Murchadh, grown old himself in the holding, came to think the truest mark of a household settled for good.

Eithne, for her part, grew into a woman as quick as her mother had been and quicker than most of her father's blood troubled to be, and when she went out from Dùn Ìseal at last, in her hundred and forty-fourth year, she rode west to the ground below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹, a broken watch-tower Seann-Dhaoine² had raised and long since let fall, where a scatter of households had lately settled and asked, having heard she was of the king's blood and quick with a judgment, that she stay among them a season and help them lay out their fields before the ploughing quarrels set in that every new settlement seemed heir to. She stayed the season, and then a decade, and then simply stayed, taking no stone from the ruin above the houses though it stood the nearest quarry to hand, out of the same caution the households of Cuan shean had shown their own old landing, and the place grew up round her the way Baile Mòr mhòr had grown up round Murchadh's spring, its own households naming it, within that first year and out of no more than hope for what it might become, Cathair mhòr, the great city, though it was then no more than a dozen roofs below a broken tower. It was hers in all but the naming even once the naming was done, and she held it, in her own right and without asking her half-brother's leave, for longer than either of them then reckoned that either of them had left to hold anything.

IV

Of Dùn chrom and the Bank That Faced Two Ways

Midway between Murchadh's plain and the hills where the vein ran, on rising ground that looked one way toward An Cnoc Ruadh¹ and the other toward the passes, households raised in the two hundredth year of Murchadh's holding a banked fort they called Dùn chrom, the bent fort, for the shape the ditch took following the ground rather than any straighter plan a surveyor might have set on it. It was built, from the first spade of earth turned, by two kinds of household at once, herders come up out of the plain who wanted the bank to face south against no threat any of them could name but old habit,

1. the watch-fort ruin

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

and herders come down from the hills of the vein who wanted it to face north against the cold winds off the passes rather than against any enemy at all, and the two parties, neither willing to give way to the other and neither troubling, in that easy generation, to make a quarrel of it, simply raised the bank both ways, a long crooked earthwork that curved to answer both wants at once and satisfied neither party fully, so that the fort stood from its first year with a name that fit it in more ways than the households who gave it ever meant.

It stood so, its bank facing both ways and troubling no one, only a little while, until the second year of its standing, when the holder its households had by then settled on, a stone-faced man named Ruadhan Beag, fell into a quarrel with the holder of Dùn thais, the older bank a day's walk to the south, over which way a bank ought properly to face when the ground it stood on gave a household the choice, and neither man, once the quarrel was well begun, could remember afterward which of them had started it or over what actual grazing or water it had first been raised, only that it had grown, over two winters of hard words carried back and forth by herders neither man had sent as messengers but who carried the words all the same, into something large enough that both sent to Murchadh at Baile Mòr mhòr to settle it before it grew larger yet.

Murchadh rode to Dùn chrom himself, in his own one thousand and ninety-seventh year, a season he remembered afterward, by his own account to his sons, chiefly for the cold of it, and stood on the bank between the two holders and asked each in turn to show him what harm the other's bank had ever done him, and neither could show him any harm at all, only the discomfort of a ditch that answered a want its own household no longer entirely remembered wanting. He told them, at the end of a long morning's hearing, that a bank built to face two ways had stood its first winters without falling to either enemy the two builders had once feared, and that this seemed to him a better argument for the bank than either holder had yet made against it, and he left the ditch as it stood and rode home, and the quarrel, having been heard rather than settled, wore thin over the following year the way most such quarrels did on that plain. Neither side yielded it. It simply grew too old to feed, once a season had passed without blood in it, and neither holder could find the heart any longer to keep it warm.

V

Of Beathan at the Slab

It was in the two hundred and third year of Murchadh's holding, while the quarrel of the banks was still fresh enough in the telling that herders carried it as news rather than as an old tale, that word reached the north of a death far to the south that touched Murchadh's own house not at all and yet was carried up the plain, from household to household, with a weight the quarrel of the banks never had.

Beathan, son of Somhairle, who had sat his nights among the herdsmen at the slab since before Murchadh was born and had grown old in the sitting the way none of the king's other blood then living had yet grown old, died that winter at Tobar dhìreach, in his own two thousand two hundred and thirteenth year, the oldest death any household on the island could then remember among the king's kin, and word of it went out from Na Glinn Àrda¹ the way a stone dropped in still water sends its rings, further than any messenger could ever have travelled on his own legs. Murchadh had met him only twice in his own long life, both times briefly, at gatherings neither man had come to for the other's sake, and knew him chiefly by the Line he kept whole in his own head and by a certain slowness of speech the households of Na Glinn Àrda shared and the plain's own quicker talkers found strange in a man of the king's blood.

What the plain took from the death, more than the man himself, was the number, two thousand two hundred and thirteen years, said aloud at every hearth that winter the way a weight is said aloud when it is finally lifted and known, and the households of Baile Mòr mhòr, hearing it, looked at Murchadh, then not yet eleven hundred, and did their own reckoning under their breath, and some among the oldest of them began, that winter, to speak for the first time of what it might mean for a household to outlive not only its own holder but the holder's holder too, a thing none of them had yet seen done on the plain and all of them, without saying so aloud, understood they eventually would.

VI

Of the Holy Hill, the Red Well and the Marsh Houses

Further south and east of Murchadh's own ground, in the years the plain came to call the settled years, three more places rose that the reciters after-

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

ward set beside Baile Mòr mhòr, Baile gharbh, Baile fhiadhaich, Cuan shean and Dùn chrom in the long telling of how the north filled.

On a hill whose spring the households that came to it found already good and whose name, Cnoc naomh, the holy hill, they found already given, by whom or for what reason none of them could learn from any teller then living, a settlement grew that kept the name and never troubled the why of it, taking the hill's own holiness, whatever its cause, as a fact of the ground the way they took its water and its grazing, without asking more of it than it gave. On the southern cape, where the keepers of a beacon fire had for generations kept watch over water thick with wrecking rocks, households built at last round a well whose water ran faintly reddish from the rock it rose through, and called the place Tobar dhearg for the well's own colour, and it grew, in time, into the greatest place on that whole coast, its beacon burning nightly for boats that had learned, by then, to look for it. And between Tobar dhearg and the older Seann Skell to its west, on ground too low and wet for any sensible household to choose first, a settlement rose whose first houses stood on driven piles over standing marsh water, moved afterward, once the piles proved the ground beneath them firmer than it looked, onto solid footing a spear's cast inland, and kept, even after the moving, the name the marsh had first given it, Muileann naomh.

None of these three troubled Murchadh's own holding directly, lying as they did beyond the edge of the plain he had been given, but the plain's own tellers folded them into the same telling all the same, for it was in those years, the reciters afterward agreed, that the whole northern half of the island passed from a scatter of households each alone on its own ground into something that could be spoken of, at last, as settled, place answering place along roads that had grown, without any single hand laying them out, from nothing more than the paths households wore between one hearth and the next.

VII

Of the Valleys Given and Taken Back

In the two hundred and ninety-ninth year of Murchadh's holding, word came north from Dùn ìseal, this time carried by two riders sent for the purpose rather than by herders passing news from one household to the next. The message they carried, given to Murchadh in his own hall at Baile Mòr mhòr be-

fore the fire had properly warmed the men who bore it, was that the king was taking back the western valleys of the plain, the poorer, wetter ground toward the coast that Murchadh had held longest of all his father's gifts, and giving them instead to a young grandson of An Cnoc Ruadh¹'s own line, a man Murchadh had met perhaps three times in his life and could not, that evening, entirely call to mind the face of.

He did not argue it. He asked the riders only whether his father had given a reason, and they told him, as plainly as they had been told to tell it, that the king had said no more than that the valleys had grown crowded enough to want a nearer hand than a hand at Baile Mòr mhòr could give them, and that this was reason enough, from that hand, for anyone on the island to accept without further asking. Murchadh sat with it a long while after the riders had eaten and gone to their beds, turning it the way his own father was said to turn most things, and told his eldest son, the broad quiet man who held the spur above the river, that he had held those valleys for the better part of three hundred years and felt, losing them, less the loss of the ground itself than the loss of the particular quiet they had given him, a corner of his holding he had never had to think hard about because it had never once given him trouble, and that this, he supposed, was as fair a payment as any holder on the island ever got for three hundred years of a thing going well.

His son asked him whether he would send word south asking the reason plainer, or asking to keep even a corner of the valleys for his own line's sake, and Murchadh told him no, that his father gave and took back by a rule none of his children had ever yet seen written down or heard spoken plainly, and that the rule, so far as twelve hundred years of watching it worked on his own household and on every household he had ever heard tell of, came to this: that a man held what he was given for exactly as long as the giving served, and no longer, and that arguing the rule had never once, in any telling Murchadh knew, changed what the king in the end did. The valleys passed to An Cnoc Ruadh's grandson before the season turned, and the plain, within a year, had stopped speaking of it at all, the way a wound stops being spoken of once the scar has set, and Murchadh's own household held what remained to it, the spring, the granary, the eleven sons each settled on his own corner, without any further word from the south for the better part of a century.

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

VIII

Of the Summons

It was in his own one thousand two hundred and ninety-fourth year, so near the close of the settled years that the plain had by then almost forgotten there had ever been an unsettled time, that Murchadh received the second summons of his life to leave his own hall and ride south, the first having been the summons that sent him north to begin with, near four hundred years before.

The riders who brought it this time were of the king's own household, sent for the purpose, rather than herders carrying word between one household and another the way the quarrel of the banks had travelled. The word they carried was short and gave no more reason than the taking of the valleys had given: that the king would hold a gathering at the ford of the salt and the wool, in the coming year, greater than any gathering the ford had yet seen, and that every holder of every share of the island, near or far, was to come to it and bring what of his own blood cared to stand with him. Murchadh asked the riders, as he had asked the riders who brought the valleys' taking, whether his father had said why now and not some other year, and got, this time, no answer at all beyond a shrug that told him the riders knew no more of the why than he did.

He sent word that year to each of his eleven sons on their own corners of the plain, to Baile gharbh and Baile fhiadhaich and Cuan shean, to the holder now settled at Dùn chrom in Ruadhan Beag's place, and south to Eithne below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹, that the king had called a gathering and that whoever of the north's blood meant to be counted in it should be ready to ride before the spring turned. Most answered that they would come. A few, the households furthest north whom five hundred years of settling had made, by slow degrees, more the plain's own people than the king's blood at all, sent back only that they would send what they could and stayed where they were, and Murchadh, hearing it, found in himself neither the will nor, he told his eldest son, quite the right to press them further, for a household that had held its own corner of ground for five generations without once needing the king's hand to settle anything on it had earned, he thought, the right to decide for itself how far south its own feet still owed the walking. He rode for the ford himself that spring with sixty of his own household behind him, the same number, though none of the same men, that

1. the watch-fort ruin

had ridden north with him at the holding's beginning, and did not yet know, riding, how many of his own blood he would find waiting there before him, nor how far south the ford truly lay from a life spent, by then, four centuries in the same one plain and close on thirteen hundred years in the world.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

Of the Great Gathering at the Ford

GE 3,000

At An Cnoc Ruadh this is kept as the old woman's own telling, carried down by her daughter's daughter to the reciters there, and by them to the reciters of the ford.

I

Of the Road Down

She was nine years old that summer, and she had never gone further from An Cnoc Ruadh¹ than Ros dhomhain across the lake, where her mother traded cheese for grain twice in a year. So when her mother told her they would walk to the ford for An Cruinneachadh Mòr², and sell salt there for the length of three days, she thought at first that a great gathering must be a kind of market larger than the one at the mill, and nothing more.

They went down with six households of the lake shore, each with a cart or a laden pony, and the salt wrapped in sacking against the damp and packed so carefully that her mother would not let her sit near it, for fear a wriggling child might loosen a cord. The road ran fourteen miles from An Cnoc Ruadh to the ford, easy walking for anyone grown, and they did it in a day, resting once at noon by a stream where the ponies drank and the women unwrapped bread and dried fish and ate standing, watching the road both ways out of habit rather than fear. It

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

2. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

was on that road, past the second bend from the lake, that she first understood the size of what she was walking toward. Other households were on the road too, coming down from the hills to the north of the lake shore with pigs on a string and dogs that would not stop barking at the pigs, and further on a family from the west went by driving two carts heaped with hides and coils of worked leather, seal-skins among them, and one old man walking beside the second cart who nodded to her mother without a word, as people did to strangers they expected to meet again before the week was out.

By the time the ford came in sight, in the low light of that evening, she had counted more strange faces on that one road than she had seen in her whole life at An Cnoc Ruadh, and she gave up counting after that, because the ground below her, where the river widened and shoaled between two long green banks, was already dark with people and fires, further than she could see in the dusk, and more were still coming in on every road that led to it.

Her mother took her wrist then, and did not let go of it again for three days.

The ground the salt-traders used lay downstream of the ford, a wide flat shelf of turf between the water and the alder scrub, and it was there her mother's people made their fire that first night, among others of the lake shore and the pans of the south coast who knew each household by its salt before they knew it by its name. Upstream, where the river ran faster over a bed of clean gravel, was a second ground the girl did not understand until later, kept clearer than the rest and walked over by fewer feet, as though the grass there knew something the grass downstream did not. Beyond that again, on the far side where the bank rose in a low shoulder before the trees began, lay a third ground given over to the northern households and the households of the west, who set their pig-pens and their leather-stalls in orderly rows the salt-traders never quite managed among themselves.

By the second morning the three grounds had run together at their edges until nobody rightly knew any longer which bank was whose, and a child sent to fetch water might come back an hour later having made two new friends and lost the path to her own fire twice over. The girl was sent for water twice that morning and came back late both times, and her mother did not scold her for it, being too busy with her own trading to notice how late was late.

That first full day, before ever the king came down, was market enough on its own to fill a child's head for a year. Potters from the north-west had carried down whole stacks of grey ware nested one inside another on a single cart, and a man from further west than the girl had ever heard named traded three strings of am-

ber, worn smooth by the sea and drilled through for the wearing, for a winter's worth of salt her mother would not have parted with for less. Wool went from hand to hand in raw fleeces and in cloth already woven, flint from Cnoc àrsaidh changed owners twice before noon, and somewhere among the fires a family of Tràigh an t-Salainn³ sang the old four-line refrain of the pans, over and over, to nobody in particular, the way people sing a thing they have always sung rather than a thing meant to be listened to. Marriages were spoken of that day as freely as salt was, two households from opposite ends of the crowd sitting down together over a shared fire to weigh what a match between their children might be worth to each in a few years' time, in grazing or in grandchildren, and the girl heard more than one old woman remark, watching such a pair of households talk, that the ford had made more marriages than it had ever made kings.

It was toward evening of that first day that she heard the word said which she carried away more clearly than any other from the whole gathering, though she did not understand it then and was not sure she understood it fully even in her own old age. An old reciter of the hill, sitting with others of his kind at a fire near the upstream ground, said to those around him that this was the three thousandth year since the grove was lit, and that word of it had gone out along every road on the island that summer for that reason alone, so that people had come from coasts that had never troubled to send anyone to an ordinary gathering. The girl did not know what a grove had to do with a king, or what a thousand years was worth beside nine, and let the words go by her the way she let most talk of the reciters go by her; but she remembered, long after she had forgotten a great deal else that a child forgets, that the old men at that fire had spoken the number the way her own grandmother spoke the number of a bad winter, as a thing to be marked rather than a thing to be explained.

II

Of the Man Who Came Like a Herdsman

It was on that second morning, with the sun not yet clear of the eastern trees, that a stillness went through the crowd on the upstream ground the way a wind goes through standing barley, bending it all one way before anyone has

3. the salt shore

felt a breath of it themselves. The girl was standing with her mother at the edge of the salt-traders' ground, both of them for once not haggling over anything, and she saw the bending before she understood its cause: old men who had been sitting all morning got to their feet without being asked; a woman with an armful of wool let the wool fall and did not stoop for it; two boys wrestling in the mud stopped mid-throw and stood apart from each other, looking the same way.

He was coming down the hill road from the west with a handful of others, dressed as any herdsman dresses for a day's walking, in undyed wool with mud to the knee and a plain staff in his hand that he was using as a walking-stick and nothing more. The girl, craning past her mother's shoulder, was disappointed. She had heard the word king used all her nine years the way other children heard the word storm, as a thing that came from a distance and changed everything it touched, and she had built in her own mind a man taller than any man, crowned in something that caught the light. The man on the hill road was younger-looking than her own father, and no taller, and carried nothing that caught the light at all.

Then the crowd opened for him.

It opened the whole way down to the river, though nobody called out and nobody pushed, a channel opening through several thousand people before he reached it, the way standing water parts before the bow of a boat without any hand rowing the boat aside. The girl watched the faces as he passed rather than the man himself, because the faces told her more than he did: the old people, who she had thought nothing frightened, stepped back from that channel with their eyes down in a way she had never seen an old person step back from anything, and one old woman near her, whom she did not know, put both hands over her own mouth and said nothing at all, though her eyes were wet.

It was the faces that frightened the girl in the end, more than the man, and once she was frightened of him she found she could not look away from him for the rest of that day.

III

Of the Hands Between His Hands

he went down through the channel the crowd had made and out into the middle of the ford, where the water came only to his knees though it ran fast there over clean stone, and he stood, and waited, with the herdsman's

staff still in his hand as though he might yet have some flock to see to before the day was out.

The holder of the hill of Rìghrean na Cloiche¹ came out to him first, wading in from the upstream bank with his cloak gathered up over one arm, and put both his hands between the king's two hands, the way a man puts his hands into water he means to drink from cupped, and the king closed his own hands over them a moment and let them go, and spoke a few words to him the girl was too far off to hear. The holder waded back with the front of his clothes wet to the chest where the current had caught him despite the gathering of his cloak, and nobody on the bank laughed at him for it, though a boy near the girl started to and was stopped by his own mother's hand on his shoulder before the laugh was fully out of him.

After the hill's holder came the holder of An Cnoc Ruadh², a young man the girl's own mother knew by sight and called out to once, softly, before catching herself, for such a day called for no shouting across the crowd. He was a smaller man than the hill's holder, narrow through the shoulder, and he went into the water more carefully, as though he did not trust the current the way the other had, and when he came out from the king's hands he looked, the girl thought, smaller still, though she could not afterward say what had made him look so.

Then came the holder of Tràigh an t-Salainn³, an older woman with grey plaited into her hair, whom the girl's mother did know well, having traded salt with her own people for two summers running, and after her the holder who spoke for the northern plain, and after him the holder who spoke for the households of the west; and each one waded out in turn, put hands between the king's hands, and waded back soaked to the chest or higher, and stood afterward among their own people a little apart from everyone else, the way a person stands apart who has just come from somewhere the others have not been.

Five went out and five came back, and the girl counted them on her own fingers without meaning to, the way she counted anything that happened five times running, and thought when the fifth had waded back that the day's strangeness must surely be finished.

Her grandmother, who had come up beside her by then, told her the names of the five as they went, in the low running voice old people use for things they have watched happen many times before: the hill's own holder that year, a grave, care-

1. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

2. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

3. the salt shore

ful man the list would keep no separate count of once his turn was done; An Cnoc Ruadh's young holder, new enough to his own hall that half the crowd still called him by his father's name before catching themselves; the woman of Tràigh an t-Salainn, whom the girl's mother traded with every summer and had never once, in all that trading, mentioned held anything grander than a stretch of clay pans; and the two who spoke, in their turn, for the households of the northern plain and of the west, neither known to the girl by more than the word holder. Her grandmother named none of the five by any longer telling, and the girl understood even then, young as she was, that these were people whose whole worth to the reciters lay in the one wading and no more, the way a stone's worth to a wall lies in its standing and not in where it was quarried.

It was not the day's strangeness, either, that was finished.

For a little while after the fifth holder had waded back to the bank, nothing more happened, and the crowd, which had gone still for the wading, began to find its voice again in low murmurs and the shuffling of feet, the way a gathering does when it senses more is coming and cannot say what. Someone near the girl asked whether that was the whole of it, and someone else answered, in the flat certain tone people use when they are guessing and do not want it known, that it could hardly be the whole of it, for the king himself had so far done no more than stand there and receive what was brought to him, and a gathering did not walk days from every coast of the island only to watch five strangers get their clothes wet. The girl's mother, close enough by then to hear this exchange, said nothing to it either way, but drew her daughter in against her side and kept both hands on her shoulders, the way she held her at the edge of deep water, or at a cattle-fair when the beasts were being driven through, as though she too expected more to come and wished to be sure of where her own child stood when it came.

IV

Of the Rings in the River

They came down from the upstream ground where the grass grew clean and little walked-over, and the girl had thought until that morning that the upstream ground was kept clear for some purpose of the reciters', a place for their fires and their reckoning apart from the crowd. She understood only when they began to come down, more of them than she could easily count, and more

behind those, that the upstream ground had been kept clear all along for this, and for nothing else.

They were not all of an age, and that was the second thing that struck her, once the first shock of their numbers had passed. Some among them looked old, bent a little at the shoulder and slow on their feet, and she took these at first for the eldest of the family, until her grandmother, standing near her by then with the rest of the household, told her low that it ran backward: that the oldest of the king's children looked the youngest of any of them, and the ones with grey in their beards and stiffness in their knees were commonly the youngest born, grandchildren and great-grandchildren counted in mere centuries rather than in the thousands the eldest carried. The girl could not fit this into her head all at once, and did not try very hard; she only watched.

They went into the river in rings around him, the way water rings out from a stone dropped into it, the nearest ring made up of faces she thought at first must be his brothers and sisters, for they stood closest and moved with the most ease, though her grandmother said afterward that these were his children, the ones born earliest, in the first centuries of his reign, and that one bent, dry-faced old man among them, who took his place at the king's left hand as though the place belonged to him by long custom, was in fact among his eldest living sons, older by the reckoning of years than any grandfather the girl had ever heard named, though he stood in the water no straighter than any old man stands. She learned afterward, from a woman of the ford who knew the lines by heart, that this was Somhairle, keeper of the lines among his own people in Na Glinn Àrda¹, two thousand nine hundred and sixty-two years old that summer and looking, by every account she ever heard after, every year of it.

Beyond that first ring stood a second, younger to look at and yet, her grandmother said, coming after in the order of birth rather than before, and among these a tall grey-haired man whom people on the bank pointed out to each other by name, Murchadh, who held the northern plain for his father and had eleven sons of his own scattered among the rings further out; he stood a head taller than most around him and looked, the girl thought, no older than her own uncle, though the woman who knew the lines said he had passed his twelve hundredth year that same season. Further out again, near the edge of the innermost crowd, was a young woman who laughed at a word said to her by the man beside her, no

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

more than three hundred years old and looking a girl of twenty, whom the same woman named Eithne, and said she held ground below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire² and had a temper her father was said to find diverting rather than troublesome.

Ring beyond ring they went into the water, until the girl lost count of the rings themselves and could only see that the whole width of the ford between the two banks was full of them, standing thigh-deep and waist-deep according to where the river bed dipped, and that the water was piling up visibly behind their legs where so many bodies broke its running, so that the ford above them ran higher and slower than it had run all that summer, and below them ran lower and quicker, as though the whole river had been made to answer for a moment to the people standing in it rather than the other way about.

Somewhere in the middle of that long standing, a boy of her own age pushed in beside her at the bank's edge, a stranger to her, from one of the households of the west by his dress, and asked her, in the plain way children ask each other things at a gathering where every face is new, whether all of that in the water was truly one family. She said she did not know, though her grandmother had just told her so, because it did not feel to her like a thing that could be answered yes or no in a single word; and the boy, considering the rings a while longer himself, said only that his own father had eight brothers and sisters and he had thought that a great many until that morning, and after that the two of them stood together and watched without talking further, the way children will share a silence when a thing is too large for either of them to explain to the other.

The reciters on the near bank began then to say the names.

They said them in order, the eldest first, working outward ring by ring the way the family had gone into the water, and the girl heard names go by all that afternoon that meant nothing to her, sons and daughters and grandchildren and the grandchildren of grandchildren, some given a single word of what they held or had done and most given nothing but the bare name and the name of the parent before it. The sun crossed the whole sky while the reciters spoke, and still they were not through the rings nearest the far bank when the light began to go gold and then to go grey, and word came along the bank at last, passed mouth to mouth the way word travelled in that crowd, that the reciters had reckoned some four hundred of his blood standing in the water that day, and that they did not

2. the watch-fort ruin

expect, when they began the telling again the next gathering, to be able to say the number had not grown since.

Watching him where he stood at the centre of it, unmoving while ring after ring of his own children and grandchildren stood in the cold water around him, the girl came slowly to a thought she never afterward heard put better by anyone older than she was that day: that he could not know all their names himself, any more than she could have named every pebble on the shore of the lake at home, and that this did not trouble him half so much as it seemed to trouble the reciters, who kept glancing toward him as though checking their work against some standard only he could set and would not.

Once, while the naming went on, she saw him turn his head and look a long while at a young woman standing in one of the outer rings, near the far bank, a woman no different to the girl's eye from a dozen others near her, dark-haired and quiet-faced and dressed as plainly as anyone in the water that day. He looked at her the way a man looks at a face he has met before and cannot place, turning it over, and the girl, young as she was, understood that look better than she understood anything else that happened at the ford that summer, for she had worn it herself more than once trying to place a face from Ros dhomhain among a crowd of strangers. The woman did not seem to notice him looking, or if she did, gave no sign of it, and after a while he turned back to the reciters and the look was gone from his face as though it had never crossed it.

V

Of Those Who Did Not Come

It was some while into that afternoon, with the names still being said and the light not yet failing, that the girl heard her grandmother say to another woman of An Cnoc Ruadh¹, in the flat voice people use for a fact rather than a complaint, that no one had come that year from east of the vein.

The other woman said she had noticed the same, and that it was the second gathering running that the east had sent no one, and the two of them turned the matter over a little longer, wondering aloud whether the households there had trouble with their own harvest, or a grudge with some family of the northern

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

plain, or simply no salt worth carrying so far when they had none of their own to trade for it. Neither of them arrived at an answer, and neither seemed troubled by the lack of one; and within the hour the girl heard the same two women laughing together over a joke a trader from the south had made about his own mule, the matter of the east's absence set down as easily as it had been picked up, the way a stone is set down that a walker has turned over once in passing and found nothing under.

The girl herself gave the matter no more thought than her grandmother had, being nine, and being far more taken up with the rings in the river and the names still being said than with anyone who had chosen to stay away from them. It was only in her own old age, telling this same gathering to her own daughter's daughter at An Cnoc Ruadh, that she found herself dwelling on that hour longer than the rest of the day's telling seemed to want, turning over what it might mean that a whole coast of the island had gone unremarked at the one gathering every other coast walked days to reach; and even then she came to no answer either, and told it to her granddaughter only as it had come to her, a fact set beside the rest of the facts, with the day fine and the crowd content and nobody at the ford, that year, troubled enough by an absence to spoil an afternoon over it.

She asked her grandmother once, years and years after, whether anyone had ever gone east of the vein to ask why its people kept away, and her grandmother, by then old and stooped herself, said only that she had never heard of anyone troubling to, for the households there owed nothing to the ford and the ford asked nothing of them, and a debt that runs neither way is rarely chased down by either side of it. It was as much of an answer as the girl ever had, and she gave it to her own granddaughter in turn exactly so, no fuller than she had received it.

VI

Of the Warm Water

The light was nearly gone from the sky, and the reciters' voices had gone hoarse with the saying of names, when the king spoke a few words to those nearest him in the water, too low for the bank to hear, and the rings began at last to break apart and wade back to the shore, ring by ring in something like the order they had gone in, though by then the light was too poor for the girl to be sure of it. She watched the crowd of them come up out of the river and scatter

along both banks to their own fires, laughing now some of them, and calling to children left behind on the grass, ordinary people again once they were out of the water, mothers wringing river-water from their children's clothes and grandfathers complaining of the cold in their old joints, until it was hard to believe, watching them settle to their suppers, that they had stood, not long before, in rings four hundred strong around a man who had buried wives by the score and did not age.

When the ford was empty at last of everyone but himself, he stood there alone a while in the dusk, in the middle of the river where the current still ran a little high from so many legs having broken it all day, and did not come out at once, the way a man lingers in a doorway after everyone else in the room has already gone to bed.

The girl's mother had let go of her wrist by then, caught up in some last trade of salt for wool with a woman of the northern plain before the light failed entirely, and the girl had wandered, without meaning to wander far, to the very edge of the downstream ground, where the bank sloped low enough that the water came almost to the toes of her shoes. She was the nearest person to him on that whole stretch of bank, closer by twenty paces than anyone else left out in the dusk, and she stood there and watched him standing in the river the way she might have watched a heron stand in shallow water at evening, still, waiting on nothing she could name.

Behind her the fires were being built up for the night, and somewhere among them she could hear the salt-song being sung again, the same four lines she had heard sung all that first day, and further off a man laughing at something his own child had said, and under all of it the ordinary evening noise of several thousand people settling to their suppers within call of a river; and she remembered afterward how strange it had seemed to her, even at nine, that so much ordinary noise could go on so close behind her while the one man in front of her stood as still in the water as if the whole gathering had already gone home and left him there alone on purpose.

The water going past her own feet, she found when she crouched to trail her fingers in it, was warm, warm as the bath water her mother heated over the fire on a winter evening, though the day had not been especially hot and the river above the ford ran cold enough at that season to numb a foot left in it too long. Downstream of him, where the current carried past the place he stood, a thin mist rose off the water in the last of the light, the way steam rises off a spring on a cold morning, and hung there over the ford a little while before the evening air took it.

Her feet never went in past the ankles. She was nine years old, and her mother would have called her back before her knees were wet, and besides, some part of her, young as she was, understood without being told that the warmth in that water was not a thing meant for wading in. She crouched instead at the very edge of it, in the last light, with her whole hand under the surface where it ran warmest, and stayed a long while after he had at last waded out on the far side and gone up into the dark among his own fires, watching the mist thin and vanish over water that was already, by the time her mother came looking for her, beginning to run cold again.

To the end of her own long life she told it exactly so: that the river that evening had been warm as a bath round the king standing in it, and that downstream of him, in the last of the light, it had smoked like a spring.

Of Somhairle's Grave

GE 3,001 – 3,030

*Clann na Ceiste say the Line was given whole to one who was not of
Somhairle's own blood only once in all the age, and that this was
the once.*

I

Of the Child Who Counted Names

iorbhail was born at Tobar dhìreach some ten years before An Cruinneachadh Mòr¹, in a house two hundred paces below the slab, and she was not three years old before the households of Na Glinn Àrda² had begun to remark on her the way a valley remarks on any child who does a thing early: she could say her own line, mother to grandmother to great-grandmother, four generations back, before she could reliably tie her own shoe, and she said it, her mother told the fire more than once, the way another child said a rhyme it liked the sound of, for the pleasure of the saying and not because anyone had asked her twice.

Somhairle heard of her the way he heard of most things in the valleys, late and sideways, from a herding woman who mentioned the child to him at a Bealltainn fire as an oddity worth a laugh, no more; and he might have let the matter lie there, as he had let a hundred smaller oddities lie in na Bliadhnachan Fada³ he had gone round those fires, had he not, some months after, sat an evening at the same

1. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

2. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

3. the long years of Ailean's kin

house himself and heard the girl, then five, correct her own grandmother on the order of two cousins' births without being asked and without seeming to know she had done anything worth remarking. He watched her a while after that without saying why he watched, the way a man watches a colt in a field before he has decided whether it is worth the breaking, and he came to no such decision aloud for some years more.

She was seven when he first sat her down by the slab, on a morning her mother could never afterward say he had asked for in so many words, only that he had come to the door and said the child might walk up with him if her mother had no need of her that morning, and her mother, who like every household in the valleys had long since stopped questioning what Somhairle wanted with an hour of anyone's time, had let her go. He gave her nothing that first morning but the names of the slab, what it was and where its stain came from and why no household built a byre against it, told the way he told any child the same thing, in the plain voice of a man handing over a fact rather than a mystery; and he sent her home before noon with nothing more asked of her than that she come again if she cared to.

She cared to. She came again the next week, and the week after, walking up the two hundred paces on her own once her mother judged the path safe enough for a child that age, and by the time she was ten the valleys had begun to say of her, in the flat way they said such things, that she went to the slab the way another girl went to the burn for water, as an errand too ordinary to remark on twice. What passed between the old man and the child on those mornings was not, in those first years, the Line, for Somhairle held, as his own father was said to have held before him, that a thing given too soon to too young a head is a thing given badly; he gave her instead the small tellings that ringed the Line the way bark rings a tree, the tale of na Seachd Guail⁴ and how each was lit, the tale of the crack and its white stones, the names of the watch-households back three rounds, small enough matters that a wrong word in the telling cost nothing worse than his patient correction and a telling again.

II

Of the Years Before the Fire

4. the Seven Coals

Beathan's son sat the watch those years as his father had sat it before him, and as his father's father had before that, a broad quiet man the valleys had stopped, long since, remarking on for anything but the ordinary steadiness of a household that kept its turn without complaint; and he watched the old man take up the girl the way a man watches a neighbour's matter, closely enough, but from outside the fence of it. It was known in the valleys, though never said outright at any fire Diorbhail sat by, that the watch and the reciting had always run in different hands, the one kept by whoever of Somhairle's own blood cared to sit it, the other given to whoever of Clann na Ceiste's wider households could carry it best; and if Beathan's son thought once or twice, in those years, that the reciting might in time have come to his own house rather than a stranger's, he gave the thought no more room than a man gives a draught under a door he has learned to live with, and sat his own turns at the slab with no less care for the not having it.

Diorbhail turned twelve, and then fifteen, growing tall and quick-tongued in the way of a child raised half by her own mother's hearth and half by an old man's patient repetitions, and Somhairle, who by then had begun himself to feel the years in his hands on the coldest mornings, though he said nothing of it to anyone, gave her, a little at a time, the outer branches of the Line: the households that had married into the king's blood and out of it again, the names the Line kept only because a marriage had once touched them and then let them go. She learned quickly, and corrected him twice in those years on a name he had himself begun to give wrong, both times a small slip of an ordering he had held the same way for centuries and had, without noticing, let time wear at like a stone worn at by the same running water; and both times he thanked her plainly and set the name right in his own next telling, without any shame in the setting right that she could ever afterward remember seeing on his face.

There was a boy of the basket-weavers' household, a cousin of hers by the shoulder of the hill and no relation at all by the Line, who went up with her twice that same year out of plain curiosity and came away both times saying he could make no more sense of it than of the crack under the slab, and would rather learn to weave a creel that held water than a string of names he could not use to catch so much as a fish; and Diorbhail, who liked him well enough at the ordinary fires, found she had no answer for him either, beyond that the names had never once, in all her going up, felt to her like a weight she was made to carry, only like a shape

she already knew the feel of before she was given the words for it. He went back to the baskets, and neither of them thought the less of the other for the going, and it became, as such partings do in a small country, only one more fact of the valleys: that the slab took some and let others alone, and asked no household to explain which was which.

By her sixteenth year she had begun, without being told to, to test her own memory against the households' own telling of themselves at the ordinary fires, asking an old woman for her mother's mother's name before anyone had thought to volunteer it, and setting it beside what Somhairle had already given her to see that the two held together; and twice in that testing she found a small gap, a name a household kept differently from the way the Line kept it, and brought both tellings up to Somhairle rather than choose between them herself, for she had learned early that a gap brought to him whole was worth more than a gap already guessed shut. He heard her out both times without hurry, turned the two tellings over against what his own father had given him, and settled each in its turn, once for the household's telling and once for the Line's, explaining to her afterward, so that she would know the reason and not only the answer, why the one had held truer than the other.

It was in her eighteenth year that the valleys first heard him say, at a Samhain fire with the whole round of watch-households gathered close against the cold, that he did not know how many more Samhains he would sit among them, said in the plain voice he used for any fact and not as a thing wanting comfort in return; and the households, who had never in living memory heard him say such a thing, fell quiet round the fire the way a gathering falls quiet when an old man says a true thing nobody present is ready to hear said aloud. Diorbhail, sitting that night at the edge of the fire's light with the other young of the round, heard it and understood, better than most of the children beside her, what the saying meant for her own two hundred paces up the hill each week, though she said nothing of it that night to anyone, and went home and lay a long while awake before she slept.

III

Of the Line Given Whole

he gave it to her whole in her twentieth year, on a night in the dark half of that year when the watch-household's fire was banked low against the

slab's foot and Beathan's son sat that turn, close enough to hear what passed between them though he had not been asked to and did not ask afterward what he had heard. Somhairle had told her, some days before, only that she was to come up after dark and to eat well before she came, for the thing he meant to give her that night would want the whole of a night to give and take no shorter telling than that; and she had gone up her two hundred paces with her heart going harder than the climb alone accounted for, not from fear of the thing coming to her, for she had known for some years now what was coming to her, but from the plain weight of being the one it was coming to.

He began, as his own father had given it to him and as he had given it to Beathan before her, with the grove and Ailean at the fire that did not go into any other hand, and worked forward from there, generation on generation, wife on wife and child on child, the short lines and the long, the ones who had died before their fathers and the ones the Line kept only as a bare name and a bare year because no telling had come down with anything fuller; and he said it through once without a pause long enough to let her ask a question, the way it had always been given, twice through and no name out of place, and only at the second telling did he stop, here and there, to let her say a stretch of it back to him and hear for herself where her own memory had already caught it and where it had not.

The night ran long past the middle of its dark, and Beathan's son fed the fire twice more than his own turn usually asked of it, saying nothing, only watching the old man's mouth working through names that had, by his own reckoning, been said at that same slab longer than any watch-household's memory reached back; and when at last Somhairle came to the end of the second telling, to her own name set at the foot of it, he sat a while without speaking at all, his hands loose over his knees, and told her only, in a voice gone hoarse with the length of the saying, that she had it now the way he had had it, and that what she did with it from that night forward was hers to answer for and no longer his.

She walked home in the grey of the morning with the whole of it turning over in her own head, generation on generation, the way a person walks home turning over a weight they have only just learned they are strong enough to carry; and it is told, though the Line does not keep who first said it, that from that morning the households of Na Glinn Àrda¹ began, without any of them quite deciding to, to bring their own children's names to Diorbhail at the fires rather than to Som-

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

hairle, the way a valley turns by degrees from an old well to a new one dug beside it, the old well no less good for the turning, only no longer the one a hand reaches for first.

IV

Of the Withering

The years after that giving were kinder to no one's hands than the years before them, least of all to Somhairle's own. His face, which had held the same lines for so many centuries that the valleys had stopped remarking on it the way they had stopped remarking on Beathan's son's steadiness, began at last, in the seasons after the great giving, to fall in the way a fruit falls in that has been kept a season past its ripeness, the skin drawing close over the bone beneath it until an old woman of the watch-households, seeing him at a distance one Bealltainn, said to her own daughter, not unkindly, that he had come at last to look like nothing so much as a withered apple left too long on the sill; and the saying, once said, travelled the valleys the way such sayings do, and stuck to him the way a byname sticks to a face that has worn the same look too long to shed it, until the households spoke of him by it as easily as they spoke of the slab.

He kept coming to the fires all the same, though slower on the path than any of them had known him, leaning at last on a stick a herding boy had cut him from the hazel above the burn, and he sat still through whole tellings without correcting a word, listening to Diorbhail say back to him a branch of the Line he had given her years before, nodding when she had it right and saying nothing at all when, once or twice, a small thing had shifted in her keeping that had not been in his; for he had come, by then, to hold that a Line kept forward by a living mind was worth more than a Line kept exact by a dying one, and he let her small changes stand without troubling either of them with the correcting of them.

Beathan's son watched the old man fail with the plain grief of a household that has sat beside a fire so long it has stopped imagining any other arrangement, and did for him, in those last seasons, what no one asked him to and he never named aloud: walked up before each Samhain to see the path cleared of the season's first fallen branches so an old man's stick would not catch on one in the dark, and sat longer at the slab on the nights Somhairle came up to it than his

own turn strictly asked of him, so that there would always be a fire built up and someone by it if the old man wanted company on the climb down.

It was in the last of those years that Somhairle told Diorbhail, at a fire with no one else near enough to hear it, the one thing his own father had never told him: that he did not know, himself, what waited for a man of the grove's own blood who had never taken a wife of the king's giving nor a share of the king's kingdom, once his own years ran out; that his brothers and sisters who had taken wives and shares had each, in their dying, been carried into some telling that named them by their hall or their household, and he had no hall and no household to be carried into, only the slab and the Line and the valleys that had let him sit their fires the better part of thirty centuries without once asking what he was to them beyond a teller of names. Diorbhail had no answer for that either, being twenty-eight by then and no wiser in such matters than he was, and she told him only that the valleys would know what to make of his going when it came, the way they had always known what to make of everything else that came to them without warning, and he laughed at that, the first time she had heard him laugh in some years, and said she had more of Clann na Ceiste¹ in her than her own mother's line accounted for.

V

Of the Grave

he died at Tobar dhireach in her thirty-fifth year, in the season the valleys keep for turning peat, and it is told that Beathan's son found him at the slab in the grey of a morning, sitting against the stone the way he had sat against it a thousand mornings before, his stick fallen just out of reach of the hand that had held it, and no mark on him anywhere that anyone could point to, only the stillness of a man who had finished a long day's walking and sat down at last to rest from it. Word went down from the valleys before noon that same day, carried by a boy on the fastest pony the round could put under him, and it went, as such word had always gone in that country, straight to Dùn ìseal and to no other hall first. He had lived two thousand nine hundred and eighty-seven years, by

1. the Children of the Question

Sloinneadh a' Chlachair's own counting, and died before his father all the same, as every child of the grove would in the end.

The king came up from the kingdom on the third day, on foot the last two miles of it though he had ridden the rest, and the old people of Clann na Ceiste² stood about the grave they had by then already dug, close by the slab on the side away from its stain, and looked at the two of them, the father with his straight back and grey hair and the son laid out in his shroud with a face like a withered apple, and none of them, not even Somhairle's own reciters, could find a word worth saying into that silence. Diorbhail stood among them with the whole of the Line sitting in her own head the way it had sat there fifteen years now, and found that she too had nothing to say, though she had, an hour before, half believed there would be some line of the telling that would rise up in her and fit the moment; there was none, and she let the not-having-one stand rather than force a thing that did not want forcing.

The king put his son into the ground himself, kneeling at the grave's edge in the plain herdsman's clothes he had worn, by every telling that has ever come down of him, since long before Diorbhail's own grandmother was born, and he did the work with his own two hands the way any household buried its own dead in those valleys, taking no help offered him though three men of the watch-households stood ready to give it. Then he sat down on the turf beside the closed grave with his arms round his knees, like a boy, and stayed there. The households drifted back toward their own fires as the light went, one by one and then in twos, until only Beathan's son and Diorbhail were left standing near enough to see him, neither of them willing to be the one who went first, and it was full dark before one of the older reciters, sent up at last by the others waiting below, went to him and asked whether he would come in to the fire.

"I have buried a wife in every century," said Ailean Mòr, "and a son before this one; and I shall bury them all. That was the bargain. I did not know it was the bargain when I made it."

He said nothing further that the Line has kept, and after a while he rose of his own accord and came down to the fire the reciter had asked him to, and sat among the households of the round until the grey of the next morning, saying little, listening more than once to Diorbhail say back a stretch of the Line at another's asking, and once, when she came to Somhairle's own name set near its

1. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

2. the Children of the Question

middle, closing his eyes a moment the way a man closes his eyes against a light too bright to look at straight, though the fire that night gave no more light than any other fire.

VI

Of the Keeping

he went back down to the kingdom within the week, and the valleys of Na Glinn Àrda¹ closed over the going the way water closes over a stone dropped into it, quickly on the surface and slower underneath, where the households went on for years after speaking of the old man's dying at odd hours, over a distaff or a half-turned peat, the way a household speaks of a thing it has not finished carrying yet. Beathan's son took up, without any household troubling to make it a formal thing, the watch at the slab as his own to keep entire, the way his father had kept it before Somhairle's giving had ever divided the watching from the reciting between two hands; and no one asked him whether he minded that the reciting had gone, these fifteen years past, to a household not his own, for by then it had long ceased to be a thing anyone in the valleys thought worth asking after.

Diorbhail kept the Line the way she had been given it, whole and by mouth, adding to its foot each year the names the fires brought her and setting nothing down on any leaf or hide that a fire or a flood might one day take from her, for that was the way it had always been kept and she had been given no reason, in all her years at Somhairle's own knee, to keep it any other way. She said it through, twice each Samhain as he had said it, to whichever of the watch-households cared to sit and hear the whole of it rather than only their own branch of it, and she took, from the households of Na Glinn Àrda and from Dùn ìseal both, no share of anything for the keeping, holding, as Somhairle had held before her and told her plainly enough in her twentieth year that she must go on holding, that a Line taken up for a share was a Line a household soon began to shape toward that share, and that the valleys had kept theirs unshaped this long only by keeping it, and its keepers, apart from any hall's giving.

By the year the reciters set at the close of that decade the households of Na Glinn Àrda had stopped, in their ordinary speech, calling her the girl who had

learned it from Somhairle, and had begun instead to call her only the reciter, the way they had once called him only the keeper of the slab, a name worn down at last to the office and away from the person who had first worn it; and it is told that when a stranger came up the two hundred paces one Bealltainn some years after, asking whether the old man who kept Sloinneadh a' Chlachair² might be found at the slab, Diorbhail answered him herself, in the same plain voice Somhairle had used for any fact worth handing over and no other, that the keeper he asked for had gone into the ground some years since, and that the Line he had kept was kept still, by her own mouth now, and by no hall's leave.

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

2. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

OF the STONE at CEANN leathan

GE 3,031 – 3,495

*This is kept at Ceann leathan among the wrestlers themselves,
passed hand to hand at the fires the night before the contests, and
carried down to the ford by whichever of them walks there after.*

I

Of the Southern Shores

In those years the south filled slowly, the way a shallow dish fills last from a jug poured too fast. Households came down to Ceann mhin within sight of Làrach an Dùin¹ on its headland, and built their houses with their backs to it and their doors to the sea, and would not climb the path up to the broken walls even to gather the good stone lying loose there for the taking. An old woman of that shore was heard to say that a wall raised by hands other than one's own kept its own quarrel, and no one troubled to ask her whose quarrel she meant.

Further round the coast the south had its own old harbour, unnamed by Seann-Dhaoine² who first laid its stones and unrenamed by the Dia-thìrich who took it up after them, so that it was known only as the southern Seann Skell, the old landing. Within a few generations of its resettling it was the busiest quay on that whole shore, boats going out with the tide and coming home heavy, and the hook-makers there shaped bone hooks faster than the fishing wore them out.

1. the fortress ruin

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

Achadh shean had stood empty since the long drought, its fields cracked and its old well silted to mud, and when households came back to it they did what the ones before had not: they sank a new well first, deep into the rock, before they broke a single furrow, and planted only after the water had held through a dry summer. The well did not fail them again in all the years of that age, and the households there told it as a lesson to their children long after the reason for the telling had gone out of most other memories: dig first, plant after.

On the eastern cliffs a scattering of houses grew up at Inis mhin, where the birds nested in their thousands on ledges no goat could reach, and the people there lived as much by egg and feather as by anything grown in the ground, and carried baskets of down and quill inland to trade for grain and salt. And on the high ground above the upper waters, where the rivers that fed half the south had their beginning, households settled at Muileann chaol around a fold built for cattle in bad weather, a low stone pen with a turf roof over one corner of it, nothing more. A cairn was raised there for each head of a household who died, on the slope above the fold, one stone laid at a time by whoever had known the dead, until by degrees the slope came to have as many small heaps of stone on it as the fold below had cattle in a good year.

East again, past the middens of an older ruin the settlers called Seann Dunn and never dug into, calling the ground around it empty though it plainly was not, Baile Mòr ruadh grew up in the shadow of nothing at all, a broad red-earthed rise with no history that its own people troubled to ask after. And inland from all of these, on the eastern hills, stood Làrach an Teampaill³ that no one built and no one claimed, which the Dia-thìrich of that country passed without stopping, taking no stone from it though its stone was as good as any other for a house wall, until a path had worn round it at a careful distance, as a stream wears round a rock it will not cross.

These were the years, too, in which the island lost the last of the king's first sons. Fearchar Bacach, who had held Dùn ìseal for the king long before and had gone lame in Cogaidhean nan Gleann⁴ so long before that no one living remembered him whole, died in his own bed in the year three thousand one hundred and forty of the grove, having carried his lameness near three thousand years and lived three thousand one hundred and thirty years in all. His house mourned him quietly, the way a fire is kept without anyone remarking that it is being kept.

3. the temple ruin

4. the king's early wars bringing in the valleys

His brother Dòmhnall Clachach, who had been sent north out of that same hill the year Fearchar took it, and had grown old in the north country among people who called him only the stone-cutter's son and did not trouble themselves with what he had once been, died there in the year three thousand three hundred and ten, at three thousand three hundred and eight years of age, the elder of the two brothers by eight years at birth and by a hundred and seventy-eight at death. Word of it came south slowly, as word from the north always did, and reached Dùn Ìseal a full season after the burying, so that Fearchar's house heard of their kinsman's death only after they had already marked, without knowing it, the anniversary of it.

A boy of Inis mhin once climbed down past the ledges after eggs and did not come up again by dusk, and the whole small settlement went out along the cliff-path with torches half the night calling his name into the wind, until they found him wedged on a shelf below the highest nests, unhurt but too frightened to climb either way, and had to lower a rope woven that same hour out of whatever cord the households owned. After that the cliffs were never worked alone, by custom rather than any law laid down, two to a rope always, one above and one below, and the old woman who had led the search with the loudest voice that night was, for the rest of her life, asked her advice on every matter to do with the birds, whether or not it had anything to do with ropes.

At Làrach an Teampaill on the eastern hills a shepherd once let his flock wander too near the fallen stones while he slept in the sun, and woke to find every sheep standing stock still along the outer edge of the worn path, none of them grazing, none of them crying, simply standing, as though some line had been drawn there that even beasts without words for it knew better than to cross. He drove them home without letting them so much as put a hoof past the path's edge, and told it after as the day his sheep had more sense than he did, and few who heard it thought he was wrong to say so.

Between these two endings, in the south, a son was born to the king in the year three thousand two hundred and four, and named Ìomhar, and called Dearg for the colour that came into his hair as a boy, redder than his father's or any of his brothers'. He grew up about the southern shores and the eastern marches with no love of the hill and no patience for lists and lots, and was already, before he had lived his first century, known along that coast for asking, wherever he went, whether a man might not simply be given ground and left alone to hold it,

without a share given him and taken back again by a father who never explained the giving.

II

Of Alasdair, Son of Torradh

Among the households of the southern shore that came down to settle near Clachan nan Gaoth¹ at Ceann leathan, there was a man named Torradh who had two daughters and, late in his life, one son, born in the year three thousand three hundred and eighty, whom he named Alasdair. The boy grew large from his first years, in the plain way some children do, not sickly and not clever with his hands at any trade his father tried to teach him, so that Torradh in the end gave up trying to make a potter or a net-mender of him and let him run with the cattle instead, where his size was no hindrance and his slowness with words no shame.

By the time he had seen twenty summers Alasdair stood a head above every man of that shore and most of the women too, and had the kind of strength that came without his seeking it, so that he broke more than one tool in his father's shed simply by using it as another man would, and had to be told, more than once, to set a thing down gently rather than merely set it down. He was not quick-tempered. If anything he was slow to anger past the point most men would have reached it, and slower still to use the strength he had against another person, having learned early, from the one time he had shoved a boy his own age in a boyhood quarrel and put him in the dirt six feet off, that his own arm did not know its own weight the way other men's did.

It was Clachan nan Gaoth that first gave him somewhere to put it. The eight stones stood in their ring on the point above the harbour, weathered and grey, said by the old people to mark Na h-Ochd Gaothan² and set there before anyone now living could say by whom, and below the ring, on the flattest ground of the headland, was held every year a contest of falls and grips and the lifting of stones that drew men down from half the southern coast to try each other, and drew everyone else to watch them try. Alasdair went to it first as a boy at his father's

1. the ring of eight wind-stones at Ceann leathan

2. the eight named winds

heel, carrying water for the older men between falls, and went to it next as a competitor before he had grown his full height, and put three grown men in the dirt in his first year at it, to his own evident surprise and everyone else's.

His mother, who had thought her one son would follow his father into the boats like her own brothers, gave up any such hope the year he came home from the shore with a net he had meant to mend torn clean through where his own hands had pulled the cord too hard, and told him, not unkindly, that the sea would have no use for arms like his and he had best find somewhere that would. It was his father, in the end, who walked him up to Clachan nan Gaoth one autumn and stood him at the edge of the ring to watch the contests through from first light to last, more to give the boy somewhere to be than from any thought of what would come of it.

He lost some years too. He was thrown twice himself, once by a smaller man from the southern Seann Skell who knew a trick of the hip that Alasdair had never troubled to learn, and once by his own overreaching, catching his foot on a stone half-buried in the turf and going down under his own weight before his opponent had done more than raise his hands. But he won more often than he lost, and by the time he had seen his tenth gathering he was known the length of that coast simply as Alasdair Làidir, Alasdair the Strong, a name given him by other men rather than claimed by himself, which was, among wrestlers, accounted the only kind of name worth having.

III

Of the Stone That Would Not Be Lifted

Every contests ended the same way, once the falls were done and the light had begun to go out of the day: with Clach a' Neirt¹. It lay at the point where the headland narrowed to a lip of bare rock over the sea, a black boulder half again as broad as a man was tall, smooth on every face as though the sea had shaped it, though the sea at that height had not touched it in the memory of anyone's grandfather. Every year, at the close of the contests, whoever had won the falls that day was given the first try at it, and after him whoever else cared to, and every year, for as long as the telling went, it did not move.

1. the black boulder of the Ceann Iethan contests

Men had strained at it until the veins stood in their necks. One, in the years before Alasdair was born, had put his back into it so hard that something in his back gave way before the stone did, and he never walked upright again after, and the stone was left alone for two whole gatherings out of respect for him before anyone tried it again. Torradh himself had put a shoulder to it once, as a young man, and told his son afterward that it had felt, for the length of one long breath, as though he had set his shoulder against the headland rather than against any stone lying on it.

In the year three thousand four hundred and three, Alasdair Làidir won the falls at three-and-twenty, the youngest man in memory to take every bout of the contests from first light to last, and by custom the first try at the stone was given him. He set his hands to it, braced his feet in the turf worn bare by every year's failed lifting before his, and heaved until the sky went dark at the edges of his sight and his own breath roared louder in his ears than the sea below him. The stone did not stir. He stepped back at last, his hands scraped raw, and said, to no one and to everyone, that he did not think any man born of a woman would ever lift it, and sat down hard on the turf to get his wind back.

It was then that a stranger came forward out of the crowd along the edge of the ring.

He was a big man, though not so big as Alasdair, grey through the hair and the short beard he wore, dressed as plainly as any herdsman of that coast and carrying nothing that marked him as anyone in particular, a stick in one hand that he set down in the grass before he came to the stone. No one on that headland knew his face, though a good half of every crowd at Ceann leathan was strangers from somewhere else on the coast, so his being unknown troubled no one at first. He looked at the stone a while, the way a man looks at a thing he means to lift rather than a thing he merely means to try, and then he set his hands to it much as Alasdair had, low and wide, and lifted it.

He did not strain as Alasdair had strained. The stone came up off the turf as though it had been waiting only to be asked properly, and he held it a moment at the height of his knees, black and dripping the loose soil of centuries from its underside, before he set it down again, not with the crash and grunt every failed heave before it had ended in, but gently, the way a man sets down a sleeping child he does not wish to wake, so that it settled into the print it had worn in the turf without so much as a thud.

The whole headland had gone silent. Even the sea below seemed, to more than one who told it after, to have gone quiet for that one breath.

Alasdair, still sitting where he had dropped to get his wind, found his own voice before anyone else's. "Who are you?" he said, or something near it, for by his own account afterward the words came out of him before he had decided to speak them at all.

The stranger looked at him, and there was nothing unkind in the look, nor anything proud in it either, only the plain regard one man gives another after a day's work shared rather than a contest won and lost. "A traveller," he said. "No more than that."

"You lifted it," Alasdair said, getting to his feet, though he came up more slowly than he had ever come up from anything in his life. "No one lifts it."

"It only wanted lifting properly," the stranger said, and there was, in that, the ghost of something that might have been dry humour in another man, though his face gave little enough away to be sure of it. "You had the strength for it yourself. You set your hands too high."

"Will you give your name to the reciters?" someone called from the crowd, for by custom whoever lifted the stone had his name taken down and carried to every gathering after, to be spoken before the falls began each year until another man matched him.

The stranger picked up his stick from the grass. "I have no name that would mean anything carried," he said, "and I would take it kindly if none of you troubled to carry one for me." And with that he turned and walked off the headland the way he had come, unhurried, and was lost among the fires and the crowd before anyone thought to follow him, though half a dozen young men swore afterward that they had tried.

Alasdair stood by the stone a long while after the stranger had gone, and put his own hand flat on the print it had left in the turf, which was, he said later, warm, though the day had been no warmer than any other autumn day on that coast and the stone itself, when he touched it, was cold as any stone taken from the sea.

IV

Of the Years That Followed

The tale went along that coast quickly enough that first winter, told at every fire from Ceann leathan to Achadh shean and back, and for a season or two it was told much as it had happened, a grey stranger, a stone lifted and set down gently, a name refused. But tales worn between enough fires wear smooth the way Clach a' Neirt¹ itself was smooth, and within a few years some tellers had made the stranger taller, some had him lift the stone one-handed, and one teller at the southern Seann Skell, drunk on someone else's beer, swore the stranger's hands had glowed like coals in a hearth while he held it, which no one who had stood on the headland that day would allow, least of all Alasdair, who took to correcting that particular embellishment wherever he heard it, more sharply each year he heard it repeated.

He did not lift the stone himself again after that year, though he tried twice more before he gave it up, telling his own sons, when he had them, that a man who has once seen a thing done properly does not care to go on failing at it in front of witnesses. He married a woman of Achadh shean, Mòr, whose people kept the new well, and had three children by her who lived and two who did not, and went on winning the falls at Ceann leathan on and off for another five-and-twenty years, until a younger man's hip-trick put him in the dirt for good and he took, after that, to carrying water at the edge of the ring the way he had once carried it for the men before him, an old joke he made of it himself before anyone else could.

His eldest son, born the summer after the stranger's visit and named Torradh for his grandfather, grew up hearing the tale so often at his own hearth that he could recite it in his father's voice before he had seen ten summers, and did once, to a fire full of his father's own friends, word for word down to the setting-down of the cup, until Alasdair laughed so hard at hearing himself mimicked that he could not finish his own supper, and told the boy afterward that he had got the throat-clearing wrong but the rest near enough right to trouble him. That son took no interest in the wrestling himself, having his mother's build rather than his father's, and went instead to keep bees on the ground above Achadh shean, but he told his father's tale to his own children in turn all the same, throat-clearing and all, long after the man who cleared it that way was in the ground.

He never stopped telling of the stranger, though. Younger men at the fires learned to recognize the particular way he set down his cup and cleared his throat

1. the black boulder of the Ceann leathan contests

before he began it, and some of them, as the years passed, took to finding some other fire to sit at when they saw him settling into the telling, having heard it enough times that they could have told it themselves, word for word, without being there at all.

V

Of the Ford

In the year three thousand four hundred and fifty, old now and slow in the hip himself, Alasdair Làidir walked north from Ceann leathan to Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹ for what he told his wife would likely be the last time his legs allowed him the road. The ford by then drew households from every coast of the island, its ground long since parted by custom into three, the salt people downstream, the hill people upstream, and the flint people on the rise beyond the river, more crowded each year than the year before, so that a man could stand at its edge of an evening and hear a dozen different accents of the same tongue called across the water at once.

The ground he walked to reach it had changed since he had last made the journey as a younger man, houses standing now where he remembered only open pasture, and twice he lost his own bearings on a road he had walked a dozen times before, until a girl minding geese by the wayside set him right again, unable herself to say how long the new houses had stood there, having been born among them and knowing no other way of it.

He found a fire of strangers that first night, southern men mostly, a few of them young enough to have been born after the year of the stone, and when the talk turned, as talk at a fire will, to feats of strength and stones no one could lift, he told it as he always told it: the ring at Ceann leathan, his own failed heave, the grey stranger stepping out of the crowd, the stone set down gentle as a sleeping child, the name refused.

Most of the young men at that fire heard him out politely and said nothing after, in the particular silence people keep for an old man's tale they do not believe and do not care to argue with. One of them, bolder or drunker than the rest, asked him outright whether he was certain it was not merely a strong man he had

1. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

seen, dressed plain and travelling light, and not any stranger worth remarking twice.

But an older woman at the same fire, grey herself and further travelled than any of the young men there, said she had heard the very same tale told at a fire near the southern Seann Skell thirty years before, near enough word for word as Alasdair told it now, from a different mouth entirely, a woman who swore she had stood on that same headland the very year it happened and seen the stone set down with her own eyes. She said this without taking a side in the matter one way or the other, only setting the fact down beside the doubt, the way a stone is set down that a walker has turned over once and found something curious under after all.

Alasdair said nothing further to the young man who had doubted him, only reached for a stick and settled the fire, the way a man does who has told a thing often enough to know that the telling itself is worth more to him, by then, than whoever happens to believe it. He sat a while longer at that fire, an old man among strangers at the edge of a river crowded with more people than he had ever seen in one place outside the ring at Ceann leathan, and watched the flames a long time before he went to his bed that night, thinking, he told his wife afterward, of nothing in particular, only of a stone set down gently on a headland forty-seven years gone, and of hands that had known, better than his own ever had, exactly how much weight they carried.

PART SIX

CATRÌONA MhÒR and the Ford

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

OF THE GREEN AXES AND THE MOOR

GE 3,496 – 3,999

*Tuagh uaine, air uaigh; cha do bbuail i riamh, is cha bbuail i tu-
illeadh.* A green axe, on a grave; it never struck, and it will strike no
more. — said of the axes, wherever one is laid

I

Of the Axes That Were Never Swung

In those years there came out of the north-west a fashion the households of every other coast were slow to understand and quick to want: axes of a green stone, ground and polished until they held a shine no flint or common rock could hold, cut at a single quarry above Àth àrsaidh and carried from there in packs on men's backs, in baskets on ponies, in the bottoms of boats going the long way round by sea when the land road was closed with snow. They were beautiful, and they were nearly useless. A green axe would take an edge finer than any grey one, and lose it faster, chipping at the first knot in a green log, and every household that owned one soon learned to keep it from the woodpile and give it, instead, to the dead: laid whole across the chest in a grave, or set under the corner-stone of a new house where no floor would ever wear it, a thing too fine to spend on work and too dear to leave undone something with.

Ìomhar Dearg was two hundred and ninety-two years old the autumn he first held one, at a wake in the north where an old man of the household was given his green axe to carry into the ground with him, and Ìomhar, who had already buried

more kin of his own than he cared to count on days when the wind sat wrong, turned the thing over in his two hands before it went under the turf and found himself, not for the first time in his life, wanting a use for a thing everyone else was content to spend on the dead. He was the king's own son, one of the youngest of them then living, and he had grown, in nearly three centuries of watching households rise and fall and rise again about him, into a man who liked a thing to earn its keep before it earned its grave. He asked the old man's son, plainly, whether he might have one cut for himself, to carry and use every day until it broke, since none of his own kin were close enough to burying to need it spent that way.

The son said he might ask at the quarry itself, and so Ìomhar did, walking the length of the north-west coast that same winter to stand at Àth àrsaidh among the chips lying knee-deep about the cutters' huts, green dust on every threshold and every child's bare foot for a mile round. The cutters heard him out, and one of them, an old woman who had worked the stone longer than anyone else living there, told him plainly that no axe of that green stone had ever been cut to be swung, only to be shown, and that a man who wanted an axe to fell a tree with had best go to any flint-knapper on any common coast and leave the green stone to the graves it was already promised to. Ìomhar did not press her further. He had asked, and been answered, and he was old enough in the ways of the island's small customs to know that a custom held by an entire quarry's worth of households was not one man's argument to win in an afternoon.

He took her advice all the same, and had a knapper of the ordinary grey stone shape him an axe before that same winter was out, plain-hafted and quick to dull, which he used and had reground and used again for the better part of forty years until the head cracked at last on a root he had misjudged, and he buried that one himself, when it broke, in the same ground he had first turned it, judging that a tool which had earned its whole life in use had earned, too, the same rest the green stone was given for having earned none of it at all.

II

Of the Quarry Forsaken and the Moor That Came Down

The quarry at Àth àrsaidh did not last out his own lifetime's watching of it. Within fifty years of that winter the households who worked it, and traded in nothing else besides, found the seam of the true green stone running

thinner year on year under their own cuts, whatever they tried of following it deeper or sideways along the hill, until the day came, in the year three thousand five hundred and forty-seven, that the last cutter of the old skill died without having taken an apprentice, his own sons having gone to herding rather than stone in a decade when the stone itself had stopped paying for the teaching of it. The chips lay knee-deep still, and would lie so for longer than any teller then living could foresee, but no new axe came out from among them after that year, and what had been made before it went on being buried, one grave and one corner-stone at a time, until the graves of the whole north-west coast held between them more of the green stone than the quarry itself had ever held ground still uncut.

It was in those same decades, the tellers of the north say, that the winters themselves began to lengthen, though no single year could be named as the one where it started. The oak that had stood since before any household's grandfather began, about Doire ghlas and the low ground north of it, to fall back from ground it had held without contest for longer than the reckoning went, and heather and birch and the soft grey moss of the bogs came up in its place, spreading south a little further with every generation that did not trouble to burn it back. The groves that gave the whole north its many names built on the word doire, the oak-grove, shrank to the sheltered valleys where the wind could not reach them, and stand there yet, and the households of that coast told it to their own children simply as the time the winters began to run longer than a man's memory could hold two of exactly the same length together.

Ìomhar passed through that country more than once in the years the moor was taking it, an old man to look at by then though his own years ran further than any household he passed could reckon, and remarked once, to a woman of Doire ghlas who gave him a night's shelter and asked nothing of his name in return, that a country changes its face the way a man does, slowly enough that no one living in it sees the day it happens, and only a stranger returning after a long absence can say plainly that the thing before him is not the thing he left. The woman answered that she had been born among the heather herself and had never seen an oak-grove larger than the one behind her own house, and did not know, until he told her, that the ground under her own byre had once stood thick with trees a man could not see through. Ìomhar said nothing further on it. He had learned, of the moor as of the green axes, that a change too slow for one life to feel is not a grief to the life living in the middle of it, whatever it might be to a life old enough to remember the ground before.

III

Of the Stepping-Stones and the Drowning at the Ford

The households along Abhainn fhionn had for as long as anyone's telling went crossed the river where they could, at a shallow bend below the willow flats, wading it in low water and going the long way round by the upper shallows when the water ran high, and it was in this same stretch of years that a family of that stretch, tired of wet feet and lost baskets, began laying flat stones across the shallowest crossing, one at a time as each summer's low water allowed the laying, until within two generations a man could cross the whole width of the river dry-shod, stone to stone, in every season but true flood. It was the first crossing of any river on the island made by hand rather than found by wading, and households from three days' walk in either direction came to see it before they believed the telling of it, and went home to lay stones of their own wherever their own rivers ran shallow enough to try.

No such stones were ever laid at the fords of Abhainn chaol, further south, where the river ran narrower and the ground on either bank rose steep enough that no household troubled to build what the current would only carry off again at the first spring spate. It was at those same fords, in the year three thousand six hundred and eighty, that a party of twelve crossing with salt on their backs, bound for the upland households that paid well and asked no questions of a trader's route, were taken by a spate that came down without the warning a slower rise would have given them, rain having fallen three days running in hills the fords themselves could not see. Ìomhar was two days' walk south of the fords when word reached him, carried by a boy on a pony who had been sent, he said, to fetch anyone of standing who might know what should be done with twelve bodies and no household near enough to claim more than two or three of them as its own dead.

He came as fast as the road allowed, and it was not fast enough. By the time he stood on the bank of Abhainn chaol the water had dropped back to its ordinary height, running clear and shallow over stones that gave no sign at all of what they had carried through them three days before, and the households of both banks had already done what could be done: five bodies found and given to their own kin, four more found further downstream and given, since no one closer could be found to claim them, to the nearest household willing to dig, and three never

found at all, the river having taken them wherever a river takes what it does not choose to give back.

He walked the bank a while before he would let himself be led to the graves, looking for some sign of the crossing itself, the salt-baskets, a length of rope, a shoe, and found nothing the river had troubled to give back beyond a single pack-strap caught on a root a half-mile down, empty, the buckle still fastened as though the shoulder it had crossed had simply stepped out from under it. A woman of the upland households, come down to claim one of the four unclaimed dead as near enough kin to bury properly, told him that the twelve had crossed at that ford every season of her own life and her mother's before her, and that she did not think any of them had so much as looked upstream at the sky before they went in, the rain of those three days having fallen on hills none of them could see from the water's edge. Ìomhar asked her whether the households of that ford had ever thought to watch the upper hills for exactly such a rain. She said they had not, until that year, and that they did now. Ìomhar stood at the water's edge a long while, an old man of the king's own blood who had come two days too late to be any use to the living or the dead, and said, to the household elder who had walked down with him, that he had crossed rivers enough in his own centuries to know that a ford is a debt every household pays sooner or later, and that the only mercy in it was that this one had been paid all at once rather than one drowned traveller at a time across a hundred years. The elder answered only that no household on either bank had crossed those fords in the wet season since, and none has crossed them so in any year told of after.

IV

Of the Twenty-Two Marks, and the Ground That Would Not Sit Still

Further round the coast, at Ceann chiar, the households rebuilding after A' Ghaoth Dhubh¹ that had scattered their roofs a generation before set, in the year three thousand seven hundred and twenty-six, a stone in the midst of their new-laid houses and cut on it a mark for every house the wind had taken: two-and-twenty marks, plain strokes in a plain row, no names beside them, for the

1. the Black Wind

households that raised the stone held that the dead of one wind were better counted together than singled out one from another, a wind having taken no more notice of who it took than a wave takes of which shell it turns. Ìomhar saw the stone some years after it was cut, on a journey east that had no other purpose than his own restlessness, and stood before it counting the marks himself, twice, as though a third count might make the number smaller than the first two had left it, which it did not.

It was a restless country in those years in more ways than the wind alone. A summer came, in that same stretch of seasons, when the rivers of the eastern plain ran so low that the households of Dùn ìseal and Muileann bhàn drove their cattle to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh² to drink rather than lose them to a stream too thin to serve a herd, and the surplus each household had kept against exactly such a year held long enough that not one death was counted for the thirst of it, which the households themselves accounted, once the rains came back, less a mercy of the weather than a debt the sharing custom had quietly paid on their behalf. The sea, too, came in again over the low ground at Cnoc chaol, a second wave lesser than the first the coast still told of, and found the new houses standing higher on the slope than the old ones had stood, so that this time the water took only empty byres and left every hearth it reached for standing dry above it. And further west the old crack in the ground that no household there had ever fully trusted moved again in its sleep, as the reciters of that coast liked to say of it, shifting the spring back uphill and breaking the line of white stones that marked the danger in two places, so that the households had to walk out with fresh stone and lay the line again exactly as their grandmothers had laid it the first time, no wiser for the moving than their grandmothers had been, only more patient.

At Cnoc bheag, on the bank of Abhainn ìseal, households settled that same generation a short walk from the standing stone the place had already borne a name for, and set their own houses, without any law telling them to, so that no door among them faced the stone directly, a custom no one could afterward say who had begun but that every household coming after kept without question, the way a custom of that kind is kept once the first house has set the pattern for every house built after it. And on the lower reaches of the same river, at Inis bhàn, the households that lived by the seal-rocks off the river mouth settled their own quarrel over them the plain way island custom settled most such things: one rock

2. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

to a household, taken in its turn, and a rock taken out of turn was, by every teller's account of that stretch of coast, the commonest cause of hard words between neighbours who agreed, on every other matter, rather better than most. Ìomhar was shown the turn kept for it once, a tally of notched sticks held by whichever household's turn had last passed, and asked the man who showed it to him what was done when two households both swore, in good faith, that the turn stood with them. The man said that the elders of both households sat down together at the tally and counted the notches aloud from the first stick to the last, and that this had settled every such quarrel so far without needing anyone to raise a voice past the counting, which he offered, Ìomhar thought, with more quiet pride than the small matter seemed at first to deserve, until he considered how many quarrels on other coasts never came to a tally at all.

V

Of Niall, Born to Raonaid

Ìomhar had a half-sister he loved better than any other of his father's many children, Raonaid nic Ailein, a daughter of the king born to a wife of the eastern shore a hundred years before Ìomhar himself, and married, long before this telling reaches her, to a man of the king's blood by the line of Fearchar Bacach, a quiet herder of the river-lands below Dùn ìseal whom the eastern shore knew better by his flocks than by his name. It was Raonaid's house, more than any house of his own, that Ìomhar came back to between his wanderings, and her hearth he sat longest at, for she had the gift, rare among the king's children, of asking a man where he had been without asking him why.

Her son Niall was born in the year three thousand seven hundred and three, in that house on the eastern shore, with the midwife's fire built up high against an autumn that had come in colder than the last three running, and Ìomhar, by then close on five hundred years old, held the boy the first evening of his life and told his sister afterward that he found in him more of her own quickness in the eyes than of anything he recognised from the long line on either side. Niall grew laughing from his first year onward, the kind of child who found the small mishaps of a household, a dropped pail, a goat loose in the wrong field, a neighbour's dog barking at nothing, funnier than most children found anything at all, and it was said of him even before he had seen ten summers that a fire with Niall at it was a fire

that stayed lively past the hour it would otherwise have gone quiet. He was the king's grandson by his mother and of the king's blood again by his father, and he learned to say both lines before he could say much else; the household laughed to hear a child of five tell a stranger at the door that he was owed twice.

Ìomhar watched the boy grow with the particular attention of a man who had already watched a great many children grow and outlive him, and told Raonaid once, on an evening when Niall had run the length of the yard three times over some joke of his own making that no one else quite followed, that he did not know yet how long the boy's years would run, and that he had decided, for his own part, not to trouble himself asking it aloud where the boy might hear the asking and grow strange about it before he had any cause to. He had a son of his own by then, Dùghall, born to him in the year three thousand nine hundred by a wife of the river-lands whom the tellings do not name, a grave, red-haired child with none of his cousin's laughter in him; and it was Niall, not his own boy, that the eastern shore came to think of as Ìomhar's shadow on the road.

VI

Of the Share Ìomhar Asked For

It was in the year three thousand nine hundred and sixty, Niall by then a young man of two hundred and fifty-seven years who looked a youth of twenty, and already known the length of the eastern shore for the same laugh he had carried since the yard, that Ìomhar went up to the king himself and asked, plainly, for a share of his own: not the wandering right his blood had always given him to sit at any hearth on the island and eat from any household's table, which he had used all his long life and never once needed to ask twice for, but ground with a hill on it, held in his own name and passed, when his own years ran out, to whichever of his children the custom favoured. He had never asked such a thing before, in nearly eight hundred years of watching households given their ground and their grazing and their rights of way while he himself held nothing but the wandering right that came to him by blood alone, and he told the king, standing before him on the hill with his sister's son Niall a little apart, laughing quietly with one of the king's own grandsons over some jest of the road, that a man who had buried strangers at fords he came too late to and counted marks on stones cut

for other households' dead had come, in his own slow way, to want a piece of ground that answered to his own name before it answered to anyone else's.

The king heard him out the way he heard out most such askings, without haste and without the warmth some visitors expected of him and did not always get, and gave him, before the day was out, the river-grazing on the eastern marches, ground between the last settled households and the open country beyond them, thin soil but good grass along the water, and told him only that a share given was a share that could be taken back, as every share on the island had always been and would go on being, and that Ìomhar, of all the king's own blood, understood that condition better than most men his ground might have gone to instead. Ìomhar said he understood it, and thanked him, and took his household, with his sister's laughing son riding along for the pleasure of the road, and went east to see the ground for himself before the season turned.

He stood on the river-grazing at the end of that same day, the light going long and gold across the water the way it goes in the last hour before a clear autumn evening turns cold, and looked east along the river toward ground he had not yet walked and households he had not yet met, thin grass under his own two feet for the first time in nearly eight centuries of walking on ground that answered, always, to some other name than his. He did not know, standing there, what would come up that river out of the east in the years his own line had still to run, only that the ground he stood on faced that way and no other, and that he had asked for it himself, wanting a thing at last that would need his own name spoken over it before anyone else's blood could rightly claim it back.

The green axe he had turned over at a wake near five centuries before came back to him that evening, too fine to spend on any wood it might have cut and given, instead, to the ground. His own grey axe was long since buried too by then, worn to a stub and cracked at the haft, spent to the last year it had in it before he let it go. Standing on grass no one else yet held, he judged a share of ground a different order of thing from either: too plain to fear the wearing, too lasting to wear away in one man's using of it, a thing that would go on answering to a name, his own or his son's or a name not yet given, for as long as any household troubled to keep the custom that had granted it. That, he thought, was longer than any axe of any stone, green or grey, had ever been asked to last.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

OF DÙN dhearg

GE 4,000 – 4,324

This is kept at Dùn dhearg's own hearths, east of the vein, as a plain account of how the double bank came to stand, and how, once only, its people carried salt home from a fire that was not their own.

I

Of the Fields East of the Vein

In those centuries the eastern country filled the way water fills a shallow pan set out in rain, from a hundred small runnings that no one troubled to trace to their source. At Achadh mhòr, under Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹, a household cleared and banked the widest field any of that country had yet cut from the rough, and set the bank on the bones of an older wall whose builders none of them could name and none thought to ask after; the field grew wheat enough, in a good year, to feed three households where before there had been land for none. Down at the lake shore An Cnoc Ruadh²'s own people drew their boats up at Baile ghlas in sheds of stone and turf built low against the wind, and it became, before the eldest of that first crew were dead, the harbour An Cnoc Ruadh fished from oftener than its own strand. In the north, at Achadh naomh, the settlers led water round a spring in channels of their own digging rather than over it, and fenced the spring before they had raised a single house, so that a stranger

1. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

2. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

coming on the place for the first time might have thought the water, and not the people, was what had been settled there.

Further east and north the coast was harder and the land behind it thinner, and the households that took it took to the sea instead. At Caol gharbh, on the rough strait, they went out in boats of skin stretched over bent wood, and buried their paddles beside their dead as other households buried a spindle or a hoe, so that a man might go into the ground with the one tool his hands had known best. Under the dark oaks of Doire chiar, a morning's walk inland, pigs ran loose in the wood all summer and were driven out to the fallen acorns each autumn by boys too young yet to be trusted with anything that could bite back, and the smoke of that place hung low and blue among the trunks from one year's end to the next. And where the Abhainn ìseal ran down past the black hill of the old trench toward the sea, a landing grew up at Caol shean that took in salt and fish and seal-skins from the coast and sent them on inland, into the keepers' country and beyond it, so that a thing caught in a net one morning off the northern skerries might lie, within the month, on a hearth three days' walk from any smell of salt water.

None of these households owed anything to the hill at Dùn ìseal, and few of them had ever seen the man who held it, though all of them had heard of him, the way a man far inland hears of the sea: as a fact rather than a sight. They were of Clann nan Dè³, as every household on the island was, sprung of the same first fires as the king's own kin, and no less sure of it for having no drop of his blood in them. They kept the handful at Samhain as every hearth on Dia-thìr had come to keep it, low and dark and burned all at once by agreement rather than by any law, and they shared before the storm season as every coast did, mouth for mouth, without a written word behind either custom. What they did not do, east of the vein, was send anyone to be counted, and no one from Dùn ìseal came east to count them.

At Caol shean, in the years before the double bank went up, two households fell out over a stretch of the river landing that each claimed to have cleared first, and there being no lot to settle it and no keeper nearer than the slab in Na Glinn Àrda⁴, three days' walk and more, the households of the landing sat down together and heard both sides out at one fire until the sky went grey, and gave the disputed ground at last to neither family outright but to the landing, to be used by whoever had a boat drawn up that day and no other claim on it. It held so ever

3. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

4. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

after, and the two households that had quarrelled over it were, within two generations, so thoroughly mixed by marriage that no one at Caol shean could any longer have said where one family ended and the other began, which some of the older tellers held had been the landing's own quiet way of finishing what the quarrel had begun.

It was said among them, at fires from Caol shean to Doire chiar, that the coast beyond the vein had had rulers enough of its own, and that a ruler who did not grow old was no bargain merely for being strong. Travellers brought word west to east the way water finds its own low ground: of a hill held near four hundred years by one grey man who had outlived three heirs of his own house; of a hill-holder in the middle country who had wanted, before she died, some deed to set beside the holding, some mark or stone that said the land was hers past her own lifetime, and had been told, gently and finally, that the holding was the deed and there was no other; of grandmothers who governed their own great-grandmothers' grandmothers, looking, the whole while, no older than a woman of thirty summers. None of it was told as complaint exactly, for none of those tales touched Dùn dhearg's own people, who had never been ruled by any of them. It was told, rather, as a reason already half made before the reasoning began: that a bank raised by one's own hands, and held by whoever's hands raised it, answered to no list and needed none.

So it was that in the year four thousand two hundred and seventy-four of the Grove, the households east of the vein put up, without asking leave of anyone, a fort with a double bank at Dùn dhearg, on rising ground above the river, and dug its ditch deep enough that a man standing in it could not see over the rim, and set the second bank a spear's throw beyond the first so that an enemy who won the outer ditch had another to take before he had won anything at all. Rìghrean na Cloiche's⁵ own list, recited at the ford, gave the fort no holder's name, for it had none that any list would keep; it said only, of that whole country, that Dùn dhearg did not come to the gatherings.

II

Of Ailis

5. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

Ailis was born at Dùn dhearg in the year four thousand two hundred and forty, thirty-four years before the double bank went up, into a household that had already made its choice about the hill at Dùn ìseal without troubling to say so aloud. Her father cut turf for the first bank with his own hands when she was still too small to carry water to the diggers, and she grew up knowing the ditch before she knew the sea, playing along its lip with the other children of that country until an elder cuffed them back from the edge for the dozenth time and told them, not unkindly, that a fort dug to keep other men out was no fit place to break a child's neck in.

She had heard the old tales as every child east of the vein heard them, at hearths where the telling passed from a grandmother's mouth to a granddaughter's before either of them had thought to ask who had told it first: of a king who did not grow old, west beyond the vein, who had buried a wife in every hundred years of his life and never once forgotten her name; of a gathering held once, so long past that it was already a thing out of an old song rather than a thing anyone living had seen, where the king's whole kin had stood in rings about him at a river ford and the reciters had gone from dusk to sunrise naming them. Nobody at Dùn dhearg could say how many years had gone over that gathering by the time Ailis was grown, only that it was a great many, and that no one now living, east of the vein or west of it, had stood at that ford as anything but a teller's word.

Once, when she was no more than ten, a trader out of the west came through Caol shean's landing with cloth to sell that no one east of the vein had woven, and sat by the household fire that night answering the children's questions until the older folk grew tired of listening and went to their beds. He had stood, he told them, at the very gate of the hill at Dùn ìseal, and had seen with his own eyes a man come in at it who looked no older than the trader's own son, and been told by everyone about the gate that this was the same man who had held that hill since before any wall now standing on it was built. Ailis asked him, before her mother could hush her, whether it did not frighten the man's own children to grow old beside a father who did not, and the trader said he supposed it must, though he had never troubled to ask any of them outright, not wanting, as he put it, to spoil a fair trade in cloth by putting a bad question to it. She turned the thought over for years after, that a household might be built and outlived by its own maker the way a house of turf is built by hands that will crumble before the turf does.

She married a net-mender of Caol shean when she was two-and-twenty, and went to live a season on the river landing before she and her husband came back inland to Dùn dhearg, where the fort's ditch by then had a bank on either side of it and houses growing up thick along the inner slope. Three of her children lived, and one did not; that one she buried, as her own mother had taught her, with a small cup of salt at its feet, for the road, though no one in that country could have said any longer where the custom had first been learned or from whom.

Her husband was a quiet man, better with a net than with words, who took some years to grow used to a wife more curious about a river she had never seen than about the one that ran past their own door, and who told her once, not unkindly, that a woman might spend a whole life wanting a thing and be none the worse for never getting it. She answered that she had noticed as much of other people's wanting, and saw no reason it should hold true of her own.

In her middle years she was known along that stretch of the eastern coast less for any one deed than for a kind of restlessness that her neighbours took, by turns, for wisdom and for a nuisance: she asked, of every trader who came through Caol shean's landing, what the ford was like now, and how far it lay, and whether the king still sat among his own kin at it as the old tellings said, and she went on asking whether anyone troubled to answer her or not.

III

Of the Double Bank

The digging of the double bank was the largest work Dùn dhearg's people had ever done together, and it settled, without any law behind it, the shape their custom would take from then on. Every household that meant to live inside the banks sent hands to the digging in proportion to the mouths it meant to feed there, an old man of that country keeping the count on a knotted cord much as the salt-folk kept their counts at the ford, though no one at Dùn dhearg had ever seen a salt-folk's cord to copy it from. When the ditch was done and the inner bank raised and turfed, the ground within it was shared out the same way, by households and not by favour, and a household that had sent three grown hands to the digging took no more ground than one that had sent three, whatever its standing had been before the digging began.

Not every household came to the digging willingly. One family on the northern edge of that country, holding good grazing already and wanting no ditch across the middle of it, sent word that they would keep to their own ground and let the rest dig as they pleased. No one from Dùn dhearg rode out to make them, there being no one with the standing to ride out on any such errand; instead the households already committed to the digging simply left that family's ground outside the second bank when the time came to draw it, so that within a generation that family found itself living, by its own choice and no one else's law, outside the shelter its neighbours had raised, and quietly asked, at last, to be let in on the same terms as everyone else, hands sent late being reckoned, by the same rough justice, at somewhat less than hands sent early.

Ailis's own household took a strip along the eastern slope, above the spring that fed the fort's own well, and it was there her husband died at last, an old man by any island's reckoning though not by the reckoning of the hill west of the vein, and was carried out and laid on the slope above the houses among the others of that place, with his own net-needle set in the ground at his feet.

The fort held its handful at Samhain as every hearth in that country did, each household burning its own measure in the dark of the year, and Ailis, growing old herself now, was one of the elders who walked the ring of houses on that night to see that no fire was lit before its neighbour's, the way the custom asked, though no one east of the vein could have named the keeper who had first drawn that lot at the slab, so far off and so long ago had that custom been made. It struck her once, walking that ring with a torch in the cold, that Dùn dhearg kept every custom the hill folk kept and owed the hill nothing at all for keeping them, and she said as much to the elder walking beside her, who only grunted that a custom belonged to whoever kept it and not to whoever had thought of it first, and went on with the walking.

IV

Of the Seal-Skins and the Ford

In her eighty-first year, in the year four thousand three hundred and twenty-one, Ailis told her eldest son that she meant to see the ford before she died, and would go herself if no one else would carry her.

She had said it before, at intervals, for the better part of sixty years, and her son had learned to let it pass him like weather. This time she did not let it pass. She had put by, over three winters, a store of seal-skins taken off the rocks below Caol gharbh, more than her own household needed and more than any one trader passing through Caol shean's landing had offered a fair price for, and she said now that she would carry them west herself, to the ford, and trade them there for salt, since the salt-folk's pans lay nearer the ford than any coast of her own, and since, she said, she had asked after that river long enough that she meant to stand in it once before her legs gave out under her for good.

Six went with her in the end: her son, two of his own grown children, and three others of that country curious enough, or fond enough of the old woman, to make the walk. They went the road west from Dùn dhearg past Caol shean and Doire chiar, over ground none of them had ever crossed before, sleeping at other households' hearths some nights and in the open on others, until on the fifth day they came down out of hill country into a valley crowded with more people and more fires than any of them had seen gathered in one place in their lives.

The road surprised them before the ford did. Twice in the first two days they were taken in by households who had never heard of Dùn dhearg and had to be told, at some length, that a country lay east of the vein at all, and that it kept its own bank and its own hearths and owed nothing to any hill; and once, on the third night, they slept at a house whose grandfather remembered, or said he remembered, a telling of An Cruinneachadh Mòr¹ held in the three-thousandth year of the Grove, though he could not himself have been born within a thousand years of it, and had it, he admitted freely, from his own grandmother, who had had it from hers. Ailis's son found it a strange thing, that a tale should be handed down mouth to mouth for so many lifetimes among people with no long-lived blood in them at all, and said so to his mother; she told him only that a good tale outlasted whoever had first the wit to tell it, which was, she said, no different east of the vein than west of it.

By the fourth day the road had thickened with other travellers going the same way, salt-carriers and wool-carriers and once a whole household driving cattle before it, and Ailis's small party fell in among them without any of the strangers troubling to ask where they had come from, so that by the time they came down into the valley of the ford they were only one more thread in a great deal of foot

1. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

traffic, unremarked, which suited the old woman, she said afterward, better than being remarked upon would have.

The ford itself was nothing like the ford of the old tellings, or it was exactly like it and larger than any telling had prepared them for; Ailis, standing at the edge of that crowd with her bundle of skins on her back, could not afterward have said which. The salt people held the ground downstream and the hill people the ground upstream, as the tellings said, and beyond the river the flint people had their own crowded rise, and among them all, moving without any mark to set him apart from another herdsman, was a big grey-haired man that half the crowd would not look at directly and the other half seemed not to notice at all. Ailis looked at him a long while from where she stood and said nothing of it to her son, who had not yet seen him and would not, for the whole of that gathering, quite believe which man among the crowd he had been.

They were taken, in the end, to a woman not much past two hundred years of age, young by the reckoning of that blood though old by any other, who was named to them at the fire as Catrìona, of the king's own line, though she did not yet hold the hill herself and would not for some years after. She heard Ailis out with more patience than the old woman had expected of anyone born to that blood, asking where Dùn dhearg lay and how the double bank had been raised and whether the fort answered to anyone at all, and Ailis told her, plainly, that it answered to no one, and had been raised for that reason among others.

It was there, at that same fire, that one of the king's own blood, a red-haired man more than a thousand years old who held river-grazing on the eastern marches, looked over the seal-skins Ailis had carried the length of the island on her own back and asked Catrìona, in a voice not troubling to be quiet, whether she meant to trouble over ground for people who would all be dead, every one of them, inside a single lifetime of his own. He did not say it unkindly so much as carelessly, the way a man remarks on weather he has stopped noticing, and called them, in that same breath, the short-lived, a name that went round the fires of that gathering for some years after among those of the blood, though never once, so far as the tellings east of the vein remember it, in Catrìona's own mouth.

Ailis's son, hearing it, opened his mouth to answer the red-haired man in kind, but his mother put a hand on his arm before he could, and it was she who spoke instead, telling the red-haired man, plainly and without heat, that she had walked five days to stand at that river and did not mean to spend any part of the little time she had left in it arguing with a man who would have five hundred years to

be sorry in, should sorry ever occur to him. Some at the fire laughed at that. The red-haired man said nothing further to her, and turned his attention back to his own grazing and his own grievances, which, it was plain even to a stranger from the east, ran a good deal deeper than any quarrel over seal-skins.

Catriona did not answer him directly. She looked at Ailis a moment longer, at the seal-skins and the old woman's hands and the six who had come with her, and said only that the far bank of the river had room enough on it for one more fire, and that Dùn dhearg's people might have ground there, this year and every year after, if they cared to come to it. No oath was asked of them in return, and none was offered.

V

Of the Salt Carried Home

They traded the seal-skins for salt on the far bank through that same evening, more salt, by weight, than any household of Dùn dhearg had carried home in living memory, and slept that night on ground that was, for the first time, theirs by nothing but a woman's word and their own presence on it. Ailis walked down to the river before she slept, and stood in the shallows a while with her skirts held up out of the water, an old woman alone at the edge of a crowded ford in the dark, and told no one afterward what she had thought while she stood there, only that the water had been colder than she expected and that she had stood in it longer than she meant to all the same.

They went home the way they had come, six going out and six coming back, with salt enough on their backs to see three households through a hard winter and word enough to keep every hearth from Dùn dhearg to Caol shean talking through it. No oath had been asked of them at the ford and none had been given, and the elders of Dùn dhearg, hearing it told, agreed among themselves, without needing to say so twice, that this suited them exactly as it stood: ground held and no word owed for the holding of it, which was, when it came down to it, no more nor less than the double bank had been built to be.

Ailis lived three years more after that journey, long enough to tell it herself at her own hearth a good many times, adding, each time she told it, some small thing she had forgotten the time before: the weight of the seal-skins going west and the lightness of them coming back; the grey-haired man in the crowd whom half the

gathering would not look at; the red-haired one's word for her own people, which she came, in the telling, to say without any bitterness in it at all, as if a name given in scorn by a stranger who would outlive her ten times over was no great matter to carry home, set beside a river stood in once and salt enough for the winter.

She died in her own house on the eastern slope of the double bank in the year four thousand three hundred and twenty-five, eighty-five years old, with her net-mender husband's needle already long in the ground above her and her own place made ready beside it. Her grandchildren, when they were old themselves, still told of the seal-skins and the ford and the woman of the king's blood who had given them ground without asking anything back for it, and some of them told, too, in a lower voice and less often, of the word the red-haired man had used, the short-lived, which stayed at Dùn dhearg's hearths long after the man himself and everyone who had heard him say it were gone into the ground the same way Ailis had gone: at their own pace, in their own time, owing nothing to anyone for the manner of it.

The double bank stood after her as it had stood before her, and the ground on the far side of the river stayed Dùn dhearg's, without oath, without law, and without any name of a holder for Rìghrean na Cloiche¹ own list to keep.

In the years after, when a trader passing through Caol shean's landing asked, as travellers will, whether the fort's people ever meant to send word to the hill and be reckoned among the king's own households at last, the answer given him, by more than one household and always in near enough the same words, was that Dùn dhearg had gone to the ford once, on its own feet and by an old woman's own wanting, and had come home again with salt and no master, and saw no cause to make the journey a second time on any other errand.

1. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

Of the Two Lists and the Asking of the Nine

GE 4.325 – 4.390

*This is kept at Dùn ìseal's own hearth, by the reciters who took it
from Eòin Beul-binn's own mouth before he died, as the telling of
the last of Rìghbrean na Cloiche.*

I

Of the Last Fields and the Last Fords

In the years after Ailis of Dùn dhearg was laid on her own slope, the hills went on filling the way a cup fills that no one is watching: a household here, a ford crossed there, and no one able afterward to say which handful of years had done it. In the south-eastern hills, where wild cattle came down to drink at a stony crossing, a household settled by the ford and took the calves born on the near bank for its own, rearing them apart from the wild herd until, within three generations, the cattle of that ford were spoken of the length of the coast as the best in those hills; the ford came to be called for the cattle, Àth fhiadhaich, the ford of the wild kind. On the Abhainn fhionn, people out of An Cnoc Ruadh's own country found an old landing worn into the bank, stones set for a boat's keel by hands none living could name, and built their houses about it and called the place for what they had found, the ancient headland. In the damp north-west a household drained a hill with ditches dug by their own hands, and the ditches carry water still, though the diggers' own names are forgotten; and on the

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

Abhainn ghorm in the north-east, a household built its houses in two rows facing each other across a single trodden way, the first street any teller remembers on Dia-thìr, though none of them thought of it as a street, only as a convenient way to borrow fire from a neighbour without crossing open ground in the rain.

Further south a house was raised with its walls limed white from the burnt shell of the old middens along that coast, and the place took its name from the lime before the household that raised it had a name of its own; and on the far eastern shore, where the coast bent back on the sea and the geese came down in their season, a household settled the last ford of the age, the easternmost hearth then burning on the main island, and went out after the geese in boats no larger than a man could carry on his back.

None of this made a chapter in any list. Rìghrean na Cloiche²’ own roll, which named every household that came in to Dùn ìseal to be counted, gave no room to a ford where the cattle were good or a lime-white house on a southern plain; it named holders, and marriages, and deaths, and left the filling of the island to be told, if it was told at all, at the hearths that did the filling. It is only because those hearths went on telling it, generation on generation, long after the households had forgotten which of their own great-grandmothers had first driven a stake into that particular ground, that any of it is known now.

II

Of Catrìona

Catrìona was born at Dùn ìseal in the year four thousand one hundred of the Grove, granddaughter’s granddaughter of a granddaughter of the king, though by then no one at the hill troubled much to count the degrees; she was of the blood, and that was the whole of what anyone needed to know of her standing. She grew up on the hill in na Bliadhnachan Fada¹ the list does not trouble to fill, when the king himself was oftener at it than any holder, and she was already an old woman by the reckoning of any hearth outside her own blood, and still young by the reckoning inside it, when the holding of Dùn ìseal came to her.

2. the Stone Kings; lit. ‘the kings of the stone’

1. the long years of Ailean’s kin

She had a memory that the hill-folk who came to be judged by her called, half in wonder and half in complaint, a curse to any man who hoped his grandmother's dealings had been forgotten. A household's line she could give back seven names without pausing to think, the marriages and the deaths and which strip of grazing had gone with which daughter, and she used the gift the way her grandfather's grandfather had used the water at the taking of the hill: not to threaten, only to be exact. A man came to her once complaining that his neighbour had moved a boundary stone in the night, and she told him, before he had finished the complaint, that the stone in question had already been moved twice before in his own grandfather's day, and each time by his own family, and asked him whether he wished the full account read out at the ford that summer or would rather let the stone lie where it now stood. He let it lie.

She took the hill formally in the year four thousand three hundred and forty-seven, in her two hundred and forty-seventh year, the twelfth to hold it of Righrean na Cloiche² line and, though none of them yet knew it, the last whose name would go into that roll at all. She did not think of herself as an ending; the tellings give her, in those early years, no thought beyond a woman with a great many households to keep straight in her head, and she set about doing it with the same flat patience she brought to everything else.

That same season, at An Cnoc Ruadh³, a young man named Seumas took up the holding his own line had kept since the palisade first burned and burned again in Uilleam Faire's day; he was seven-and-twenty, the last name An Cnoc Ruadh's own spoken roll would carry, though he no more knew it than Catriona knew hers. He and Catriona had never met before that year. They would meet within it, across a fire at the ford, and neither of them, so far as anyone at either hill ever heard either of them say, thought anything of the meeting beyond the ordinary business of two neighbours who had never before had cause to sit down together.

III

Of the Two Lists

It had never before been done, in all the years Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹ had drawn the hill people and the salt people and the flint people together, that

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

the whole roll of Rìghrean na Cloiche² and the whole roll of An Cnoc Ruadh³ should be spoken out in the one place on the one night, first name to last, each list heard entire by ears that had heard the other list entire as well. Whether it was Catrìona's own wish, in her first summer of holding, to have her name set down properly beside the men and women who had held the hill before her, or whether it was only that the two rolls had grown long enough by then that the idea of hearing them side by side had occurred to more than one mind at once, the tellings do not agree, and no one troubled, at the time, to ask.

The reciter of Dùn ìseal stood first, a man called Eòin, whom the hill-folk knew for the sweetness of his voice long before they knew him for anything else, and he gave the roll from its beginning: Ailean Mòr and the bank he raised in the snow; Gormshuil at the gate, greying while her father came in each autumn no older than her own sons; Dòmhnall Clachach and his stones that only moved the quarrels they were meant to settle; down through Mòrag the Hard and Iain Dubh brought home from the shingle at Baile ghorm and Tormod Liath who went truly grey and Eilidh Ghlas who sent her younger son west unnamed, and Calum Ciar, who had asked that the lot be drawn in his own sight and been refused, the refusal spoken as plainly as the granting of anything else would have been. When Eòin came at last to Catrìona's own name he said it, once, and sat down, and she felt, sitting where every eye at that fire could find her, every face at the ford turn toward her at once, the way a field of standing barley turns all together when the wind changes.

Then a woman called Ùna stood for An Cnoc Ruadh, and gave that roll in its turn: Beathag Ruadh who had first held the red earth by the lake; Uisdean who rebuilt the palisade through a whole winter under the king's own eye; Seonag nic Uisdein, who weighed her pebble bag before the king and was set into the roll, as every holder of that line was set, "after her father"; Lachlann an Altraim, who took in a fosterling with no name and sent him home again grown; down to Seumas, who had taken the hill that same season and now sat across the fire from Catrìona listening to his own name spoken for the first time in a roll rather than merely in his own household. By the time Ùna had done, the sky over the river had gone the grey that comes before the true grey of morning, and the children of

3. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

1. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

3. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

both crowds were long asleep in heaps against their mothers' knees, and no one now living could say, the tellings admit plainly, how many hours the two rolls together had taken, only that it was the whole of one night.

The king sat among the listeners the entire while, his cloak drawn round him against the river's damp, saying nothing and asked nothing, one more grey-haired man among a crowd of grey-haired men, until Eòin came to his own name in its place near the beginning of the roll and some of those nearest him, glancing sideways as a person will at a thing he is not sure he ought to be looking at, saw him smile. A man hearing his own name read out among four hundred others he had buried or begotten or both is, by any account, a small enough matter. It was told after, at more than one hearth, as though it had been a large one, and Catrìona, asked about it in her own middle years by one of her grandchildren, said only that she had seen it too, and that it was the one time in all her years of holding the hill that she had seen him smile at hearing anything said of himself.

IV

Of the Cord and the Districts

It was in those same years that Catrìona set her own people to counting the households of the hills plainly, a knot to a hearth, on a cord kept at Dùn ìseal for that purpose and no other. She did it, she told those who asked, because she found she could no longer carry the whole tally in her own head as her grandmother's grandmother once had, the hills having grown past the reach of any one memory, however good; and having said so once, plainly, she never troubled to explain it further to anyone who asked twice. The cord grew through her years of holding until it bore, by the reckoning of those who came after and counted the knots themselves, some nine hundred of them, the largest count made on Dia-thìr in that whole age. The king's own kin were not upon it. There was no counting them any longer by then, the tellings say, and no one at Dùn ìseal thought to try.

In the same years Luchd-faire na Lice¹, who for generations past had been drawn by lot from the households nearest the crack in Na Glinn Àrda², began to be drawn instead from every part of the hills, a household of the far south or the

1. the keepers of the slab, chosen by lot

2. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

eastern marches standing as good a chance of the lot as a household that had lived its whole life within a day's walk of Tobar dhìreach. Catrìona neither ordered this nor opposed it; it happened, the tellings say, the way water finds a wider bed when the narrow one has filled, and by the middle of her years the keepers had settled at nine, one drawn for each of nine districts of the hills that no one had ever formally marked out on the ground but that every household somehow knew the edges of, the way a family knows where its own dooryard ends without a stone to show it. The nine met at the slab only when one of their number died and a new lot had to be drawn, and at no other time; the rest of the year each kept the custom in their own country and answered to no one for it.

Tobar dhìreach, where Taigh na Lice³ stood over Somhairle's own grave, came in these years to be a place people walked to for its own sake and not only on the business of a lot, households arriving from country so far off that their own grandparents had never heard the crack under the slab so much as mentioned at a neighbour's hearth. What they came to see, when asked, none of them could very well say. They came, and stood a while, and went home again, and the keepers let them, asking nothing of them and offering nothing beyond the standing there.

V

Of the Handful That All Burned Together

The measured handful of an gual dathach¹, kept since Anna nic Coinnich's own day at Achadh dhìreach, had by Catrìona's years spread to every hearth in the hills without ever once being written into a lot or a judgment; it was simply done, everywhere, in the dark turning of the year, each household burning its own small share, measured in a copy of the stone cup Niocol Snaidhear had shaped near two thousand years before, on the one night that every other household in reach of it also burned. No one had commanded that the nights should agree. They had come to agree the way neighbours come to rise at the same hour who have no bell between them but the same rising sun, each household watching for the first low dark flame on the nearest hill and lighting its own the moment it saw it, until across the whole breadth of the hills the fires

3. the house of the slab at Tobar dhìreach

1. the coloured coal

went up within the same short hour of the same dark night, and stayed low, and went out together before the next dawn. That night had, by then, a name of its own among the hill-folk, Oidhche na Glai², and it fell at Samhain, which has been Oidhche na Glai² ever since.

Only one household, in all the country the handful had come to reach, would not burn it at all. They were of the line of Torcall Tochclair, who had dug for another vein near the black hill in the east near two thousand years before Catriona's own birth, and whose brother had been crushed there along with another digger when the ground gave; Torcall's own household had stayed by the open trench long after the vein was given up, holding the ground where the two men died as their own, and their descendants, asked why they would not burn the handful with the rest of the hills, gave no single answer twice. Some said the coal had already taken what it meant to take from that family and would get no more of it burned or unburned. Others said only that a household that had stayed where it was told to leave saw no reason to start keeping customs it had never been asked to keep in the first place. Catriona, hearing of it, sent no one to compel them, and no one at the slab suggested that she should; the household went its own way in this as it had gone its own way over the trench, and the hills, having no law to press against it, let it.

VI

Of the Column and the Old Middens

In the seventeenth year of her holding a hand went out from Catriona's own hill to Cnoc ghorm, where Calbh Cnoc ghorm¹ stood with its marks worn shallow by the weather of an age no one could number, and recut the grooves along their old lines so that the words should not be lost to the rain. Whoever the hand belonged to left no name behind, only the work; and some who came after, comparing the cut marks against tellings of how Calbh Cnoc ghorm had once run, held that a single stroke had changed in the recutting, though none of them could ever agree which stroke it was, or prove that any had changed at all. Calbh Cnoc ghorm stood after that as it had stood before, telling whoever could read it

2. the night of the handful, Samhain

1. the column at Cnoc ghorm

only that the people who raised it had always been there, in words that every gathering at the ford still spoke aloud at its opening.

Further east, at the household places about Seann Dunn, a family digging a new house-floor into the shoulder of an old midden struck, not two spans down, a row of flat stones each cut with a single stroke, set upright in the old refuse the way a hearthstone is set, and knew them at once, from tellings that had reached even that far corner of the hills, for the tally stones of the people who had once lived along that coast and counted their own dead upon them. They did not take the stones for their own use, nor break them up for the new floor, though it would have cost them less labour to do either. They set the stones back in the order they had found them lying, as near as memory and care could manage it, and built their house-floor a little further along the shoulder of the midden instead, losing a morning's digging for the sake of ground that had, by then, no living person left to claim it.

Along the south-eastern coast, in those same years, the custom grew of rowing the newly dead out to Eilean iséal rather than burying them on the mainland shore, a custom no one at those hearths could say for certain they had learned from anyone rather than come to on their own; some held it was taken from the graves the old coast people had left on the low island across the strait, and others held that a low island surrounded by water was simply where any sensible coast puts what it does not wish disturbed, whether the thought had first come from a stranger's grave or from a fisherman's own good sense. Both might have been true at once, or neither; the tellings, for once, let the question stand without troubling to settle it.

And out past the same coast, on Eilean chrom where Gilleasbuig Beag had been rowed and left with no boat to bring him back, no household in all those years put out a boat to fish its waters, though the fishing there was said to be as good as anywhere on that shore. His fire had been seen three nights running from the mainland, the tellings say, in the first year after he was left, and then no more; and whether that had been a true fire or only three nights of a frightened coast seeing what it feared to see, no one now living could settle either, and the island stayed unfished, empty, and left alone.

VII

Of the Asking of the Nine

In the twenty-ninth year of her holding, in the year four thousand three hundred and seventy-six, the nine of Luchd-faire na Lice¹ came up together across the trodden ground of the ford while the gathering stood at its fullest, salt-carriers and wool-carriers and flint-carriers all about them, and stood before Catrìona where she sat among her own kin, and asked to be heard.

She knew them, all nine, before any of them had said a word; she had held their lines in her own memory since before any of the nine now standing there had been drawn by lot at all, and she named the eldest of them, who had come forward to speak for the rest, by his own line seven names back before he had finished bowing to her. He did not seem surprised by it. He had likely expected nothing less.

What they asked was this: that their charge over the slab, the lot, and the handful be declared before the whole gathering, spoken out as plainly as the two rolls had been spoken the year of her own taking, so that it should stand fixed past any doubt, and so that no king who came after her should ever again think, as Calum Ciar had thought once, that the slab was a thing to be reached for by anyone who held Dùn ìseal, or ask that the lot be drawn in his own sight as though the sight of a king could weigh upon a stone that had lain over the vein since before the grove was planted.

Catrìona looked at them a long while and said nothing at first, and the old keeper, mistaking the silence for a hearing not yet finished, opened his mouth to say more. She looked past the nine of them while she considered, out over the whole crowded ground of the gathering, the salt people on their own bank and the hill people on theirs and the flint people crowded on the rise beyond the river, every one of them, so far as she could tell from where she sat, waiting on nothing more urgent than the next trade or the next marriage to be agreed at that year's fires, none of them, she was fairly sure, aware that nine old men and women stood asking her, at that moment, to fix something that had never yet been fixed.

"Not this year," she said.

The old keeper's mouth, already open to press the matter, stopped where it was.

"Ask me again," Catrìona said.

She gave them, in the whole of it, neither a refusal nor a consent, and the nine went back across the trodden ground to their own fires by the slab's own country

1. the keepers of the slab, chosen by lot

to wait, as keepers had waited on lots and on kings for longer than any of the nine then living could have told her, without complaint, and without any sign that they took her answer for anything other than exactly what it was: an answer given, and a door left standing as it had stood before, neither opened wider nor shut.

VIII

Of Her Growing Years

She held the hill a long while after that night at the ford, longer than any single reign the hill-folk outside her own blood had known, though shorter, by a very great deal, than the reigns of the blood who had held it before her. Eòin, whose voice had carried the whole roll of Rìghrean na Cloiche¹ across one long night at the ford, died in his eightieth year, an old man by any measure the hills themselves would use, and was carried to his own household's ground with no more ceremony than any other hill-folk death; and Ùna, who had answered him roll for roll out of An Cnoc Ruadh²'s own line, followed him within two years, in her seventy-third, so that within a short span both voices that had first spoken the two rolls whole were gone from the hills that had heard them, and the telling of that single night passed, from then on, at second hand.

Catrìona herself went on a good while past either of them, keeping her households in her head as she always had, judging a boundary stone here and a marriage there with the same flat exactness she had brought to it from her first year of holding. It was in her two hundred and eighty-ninth year that the sickness came on her that would not leave again, a slow failing that those about her on the hill first took for nothing more than the ordinary tiredness of a long-held office and then, watching it deepen through one whole turning of the seasons, could no longer mistake for anything but what it was. She kept her seat at Dùn ìseal through it as long as she was able, still hearing what was brought to her, still able, when a household came before her with some quarrel over a strip of grazing, to give its whole line back seven names without having to be reminded of a single one of them.

The nine keepers, hearing that she had grown ill, sent no word asking again. They had been told to ask her again, and an asking made of a woman too worn to

1. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

answer it plainly would have been, in the reckoning of that country, no true asking at all; and so they waited still, by their own slab, in their own nine districts, keeping the custom she had neither fixed nor unfixed, exactly as they had kept it before she was ever asked, and exactly as they would go on keeping it after.

2. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

Of the Shares Counted

GE 4,391 – 4,549

This is told at Dùn ìseal, among the households that camped nearest the hill in those years, as Niall Òg was said to have told it himself in his own age, laughing, before he had any cause to stop laughing at it.

I

Of the Hill Left to No One

Niall Òg was six hundred and eighty-eight years old, and looked, by the reckoning of the ordinary households camped that season at the foot of the hill, no more than a young man come newly into his strength, when Catriona Mhòr died at Dùn ìseal in her two hundred and ninety-first year and Rìghrean na Cloiche¹ ended with her.

He had neither claim on the hill nor any close standing to bring one; he went up with his mother because every soul of the king's blood within three days' walk had come, and staying away would have drawn more remark than coming did. He remembered afterward how many of them there were: cousins he had met at a dozen gatherings and cousins he had never met at all, old ones bent nearly double and young ones who did not yet know how old they would live to be, every last one of them able to say the two names of the line they stood on, and the second of the two always Ailean's. They stood in a great loose ring below the hill's own bank while the households that served the hill went in and out with water and bread for whoever asked it, and the king sat on the turf inside the bank with his

1. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

back very straight, as he had sat, the old tellings said, in the first winter of the hill, and heard every claim that was brought to him.

There were more claims than Niall could ever afterward number, try as he did, more than once, to make the count come out the same way twice. Some came with a line traced back seven generations and a piece of the hill's own turf held out on an open palm, as if the ground might speak for them on its own account. Some came with nothing but their own two names said plainly, trusting the two names to be claim enough. One old woman, whom Niall's mother pointed out to him under her breath as kin of Murchadh Mòr's line and therefore, by the fashion of the day, owed more courtesy than most, came leaning on two sticks and said only that she had outlived every rival claim she had ever had, and that this ought to count for something even if nothing else about her did. A man of Tràigh an t-Salainn's own cousinage, three lines removed but proud of every yard of the distance, brought his infant daughter up in his arms and held her out toward the king as his whole argument, saying nothing else at all. The king heard them all out with the same still face, and it was Niall's mother who named the trouble in it afterward: watching him hear any single claim, she said, no one standing near enough to see his face could tell whether it moved him, because his face gave the same account of a claim that moved him as of one that did not, and there was no reading behind it from the outside.

When the last of them had spoken and the light was going off the hill, the king stood up from the turf, and Niall's mother took his arm hard enough to hurt, though he did not understand until later that this was because she, too, did not know what was coming. The king said that he had heard every claim brought to him, and that he judged none of them better than another, because none of them was better than another; that Catrìona Mhòr had been the last of a line that had begun the day he himself first walked up that slope, and that a line was not a thing a man could hand from one stranger's palm to the next merely because the palm was open. He said he would give the hill to none of them. He said he would hold it himself, as he had held it before Gormshuil first took it up in his name, and that he would go on holding it for as long as it pleased him to.

Then he walked up into the hill's own house and did not come out again that evening, and the kin stood a while longer in the failing light not quite believing that this was the whole of what they had come to hear, and then began, in twos

and threes, to go back to their own fires, and Niall's mother did not let go of his arm the whole way down.

"He has never done that before," she said, when they were far enough from the hill that she judged it safe to say anything at all. "Given nothing. Not to anyone."

"Perhaps there was no one worth giving it to," Niall said, because he was young enough still to say a true thing plainly without weighing first what it would cost him to have said it.

His mother looked at him a long moment in the dusk, the way a woman looks at a child who has said something cleverer than she expected of him and is not certain yet whether to be pleased or afraid. "Perhaps," she said. "Or perhaps he has looked at every one of us and found that giving is the one thing left he has not yet tried keeping back."

II

Of the Marriages Made for a Share

Niall did not understand, for some years after, what his mother had meant by that, and by the time he did understand it he had come, without quite noticing the coming, to be a part of the thing.

It began, so far as anyone afterward could point to a beginning, with a marriage. In the fourth year after Catrìona Mhòr's death a young man of one of the smaller lines, whose own hold on the kingdom amounted to grazing on the northern skirts of nobody's particular attention, married a woman three lines removed from the king on her mother's side and two on her father's, a match that would have raised no eyebrow at all in an ordinary year, since the two of them had known each other since childhood and were, by every account, well suited. What raised the eyebrow was the manner of the asking: the young man's own father stood up at the betrothal fire and said, in so many words, that the marriage joined two claims that might one day be worth more joined than either was worth alone, should the king ever be brought to naming an heir after all, and that he for one meant his son's children to stand as near the front of that reckoning as five lines instead of three could put them.

No one had ever said such a thing aloud at a betrothal fire before. The thought was old; what was new was the saying of it, and the profit in the saying. There had always, before, been a king who might yet live another thousand years

and give and take back shares as the fancy or the need took him, and little enough profit in marrying for what a man might never live to see given out at all. Now there was a king who had refused to give anything, and a hill held in a hand that no one could say would ever open again, and the old unspoken thought became, within that single season, a thing spoken plainly at every fire that had two unmarried children of the blood between them.

Niall watched three more such marriages made before he was two hundred years further into his own life, each one a little more openly reckoned than the last. The second joined a household holding good river-grazing to one that held none but had, on its own side, a claim traced through four generations of daughters rather than sons, which some of the elder kin said counted for less and some said counted for more, and no one on the hill that year could point to any custom, old or new, that settled the question either way. The third was broken off within the month, when the bride's own grandmother discovered a nearer claim on her groom's side that she judged would weigh the marriage's whole worth downward rather than up, and said so at the man's own hearth in words plain enough that the match did not survive the telling of them. By the time Niall was of an age to be thought of as a match himself, no one troubled any longer to pretend that a marriage among the king's own blood was made for anything but the shares it might one day gather in one house. He was asked, more than once, by aunts and great-aunts who meant it kindly, whether he had given thought to which of his cousins' lines ran nearest the front of the reckoning, and he laughed at every one of them, honestly at first and then, as the years went on, because laughing had become the answer expected of him and he had found no better one to give in its place.

It was in those same years that the first valley changed hands by the king's own word rather than by death or marriage: a household that had held good grazing on the western slopes for eleven generations was told, without explanation given beyond what the king himself troubled to give, which was none, that the grazing was wanted for another line, and that they would remove themselves and their herds to ground of equal size two valleys over before the winter closed the passes. They went. No one on the hill that year could say why that household and not another had been chosen to lose what it held, and the king, asked directly by the household's own eldest whether some fault of theirs lay behind it, said only that a share given was a share that could be taken back, and had always been so, and that nothing about the taking back was new even if the households had grown unused

to seeing it done. It was the plainest word he gave on the whole matter in all the years Niall watched it unfold, and it satisfied no one, least of all the household that had lost the western slopes for reasons it never learned.

III

Of Raonaid's Share Taken Back

Niall's own mother, Raonaid nic Ailein, held through those years a stretch of river-meadow below the hill that had come to her from the king's own giving so long before that not even she could always give the whole of its telling at one sitting. She was herself the king's daughter, though by then so many generations stood between the fact and the memory of it that most of the households camped near the hill knew her only as an old woman of the blood who kept good meadow and asked little of anyone, and it was a long while before Niall understood that his own claim, when the aunts spoke of reckonings and frontings, ran doubled through her and through his father both, a thing that made him, without his ever asking for it, one of the names spoken of at other households' own betrothal fires in the same careful voice his own father had once used of somebody else's son.

She died in her own house on the river-meadow in the year four thousand four hundred and eighty, having lived, by the count the reciters kept for her afterward, one thousand three hundred and eighty years. Not long before the end she told Niall that the span had simply come to be the shape her life had taken, the way a river takes the shape of the ground it is given and does not ask whether another ground might have made it run differently. She had stopped some centuries back, she said, asking whether it was a long life or a short one, since the question had no one left living to compare it against who had not asked her the same thing first.

The king came down to the river-meadow himself when word reached him that she was failing, and sat with her the better part of a day and a night, as the tellings said he had sat once with Gormshuil at the gate and once with Somhairle in Na Glinn Àrda¹. What passed between them in the house no one who was not in it ever learned; she died within the week and never spoke of it, and he never

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

spoke of any of them once they were in the ground. Niall stood outside through most of that night with his own wife beside him, and neither of them went in. He said afterward that he had wanted to, once, badly enough to put his hand on the door, and had taken it away again unopened, judging without needing to say so to his wife that the room held a conversation a good deal older than anything he himself had a part in.

His mother spoke to him alone the following morning, when the king had gone back up to the hill and the house was quiet again but for the two of them. She told him she had asked her father, in the night just past, whether he grieved the same grief each time or whether it wore differently with practice, the way a callus forms where a tool is held often enough, and that he had answered only that he did not know, because he had never yet finished grieving any one of them before the next was laid on top of it. "He did not say it unkindly," she told Niall, "only plainly, the way he says everything. I asked him because I wanted to know whether I ought to be sorry for him as well as for myself, in whatever time I have left to be sorry for anyone. I could not get an answer out of him either way, and I have stopped minding that I could not."

Within the month of her burying the king sent word to the river-meadow that the grazing his daughter had held was wanted elsewhere, and that Niall, as her nearest of that line, should remove his own household from it before the next season's herds came down. He did not say where the grazing was wanted, or by whom, and Niall, standing before him at Dùn ìseal to hear the word given in person, found that his own mouth had only the one shape left in it after a hundred aunts had asked him the same question a hundred different ways: he laughed. The loss itself did not strike him as funny. Laughing had simply become, over so many years of the same reckoning put to him in so many forms, the only answer his own mouth still knew how to make in the king's presence, whatever the question happened to be that season. The king looked at him a moment with an expression Niall could not afterward name, and said only that he was glad someone in the family still found some of it amusing.

"Someone has to," Niall said, "or we should all of us have gone mad reckoning it long before now."

"Some of us have," the king said, and did not say which of them he meant, and turned to the next matter waiting for him, which was, that season, always another claim, another marriage, another valley wanted elsewhere.

IV

Of Niall Sent East

It was some forty years after his mother's death, in the year four thousand five hundred and twenty, that the king called Niall to him at Dùn ìseal and gave him an errand that had nothing to do with any share at all, which was, Niall said afterward more than once, the first time in a great while that anyone of the king's own house had asked something of him that was not a reckoning of some kind.

"You will go east of the vein," the king said, "to the fort they have raised there, and tell its holder that I bid him and his households come in to me at last, as every other coast of this island has come in, in its own time and its own way."

Niall asked why he, among all the king's kin nearer the front of whatever reckoning was being made that season, should be the one sent on such an errand, and the king said, plainly, that he wanted a messenger the east would not mistake for a claim: that a man sent to ask for nothing more than the coming-in, and known through every fire on the hill for asking nothing of anyone on his own account beyond a laugh, was less likely to be taken for the leading edge of a conquest than a man who held ground and wanted more of it. Niall thought this a fair enough reckoning, and said so, and went.

He went east by the long road the king bade him take, round by the households of the eastern marches so that the whole country should know a messenger was riding, and crossed the vein on the third day of it, over ground that grew stonier and less kept the further east he rode, past the last of the households that answered to Dùn ìseal in anything but name and into a country whose hearths he did not know and whose faces did not know him. He slept the first of those eastern nights at a household that fed him without asking who he was or where he rode, and the second at another that asked at once, plainly, and fed him no worse for the asking, telling him only, when he had answered, that he was welcome at their fire but that the fire owed his errand nothing on its own account. Children ran out along the road to look at his horse, which was of a taller island stock than the east bred for itself, and one boy walked alongside him the better part of a morning asking whether it was true that a man of the king's own house never grew old, and whether Niall himself was such a man, and looked plainly disappointed to be told that Niall was not, though not so disappointed that he stopped walking beside the horse until his own mother called him in for his dinner.

He came, on the fifth day, to the double bank of Dùn dhearg standing on its rise above the river, its ditch cut deep enough that a man standing in it could not see over the rim, exactly as the tellings west of the vein described it and exactly as none of those tellings had prepared him to find it: larger, and better kept, and fuller of people going about their own business without the smallest sign of having heard that a messenger of the king's own house was riding up their own road to speak with them. He counted three separate knappers' floors busy within the outer bank alone before anyone troubled to ask his business, and a granary raised on stone legs against the damp that he judged, from the width of it, held grain enough to see the whole fort through two bad harvests running, and it came to him, riding in past all of it, that he had ridden east expecting to find a grievance nursed in poverty, and had found instead a country that wanted nothing from the hill because it had, by its own hands, gone some way toward needing nothing from anyone.

They brought him, without much ceremony and less delay, before a man named Fearghal Donn, who held the fort in those years and had held it, by his own account, since before he was old enough to have chosen the holding for himself, having had it laid on him the way a family's oldest son is laid with a family's oldest debts. Fearghal was forty years old that season, by his own country's ordinary count, a broad quiet man with a scar along one forearm that he did not offer to explain and Niall did not ask after. He heard Niall out standing in the open ground within the fort's own bank, with a good part of the household gathered near enough to hear every word of it, which Niall understood, before Fearghal had finished hearing him, to be no accident at all.

V

Of the Word Sent Back

"**T**ell your king," Fearghal Donn said, when Niall had given the whole of his errand plainly, word for word as the king had given it to him, "that we have raised this bank with our own hands, on ground none of his own blood ever set foot on before we did, and that we have neither asked leave of Dùn ìseal to raise it nor owed anyone west of the vein so much as a handful of salt for the raising. Tell him we have heard, from every trader who ever crossed the vein either way, what it is to be one of his own kin: to marry for a share and count

another man's years against your own and wait a thousand of them, if it comes to that, for a hill that is never given after all. We have no wish to be counted among you."

Niall said that he had come to ask a coming-in, not a submission, and that the king had put no oath into the errand at all, only the asking.

"Then tell him," Fearghal said, "that the asking is answered. We will not come in. We have our own bank and our own dead in it, and we mean to keep both without any man's leave, west of the vein or anywhere else."

There was more said between them that afternoon, none of it, by Niall's own account afterward, either angry or unkind; Fearghal Donn gave him food and a bed for the night as any household on the island would have given a traveller, king's messenger or none, and asked him, before he rode out the next morning, a good many plain questions about the hill and the king and the manner of life west of the vein, listening to the answers with the same close attention he had given the errand, so that Niall came away from Dùn dhearg less certain than he had ridden in that the man who held it thought ill of the king so much as he thought the whole arrangement not worth the joining. He rode home with nothing to carry but the bare word, and gave it to the king plainly, as he had been asked to give it, standing again on the turf below the hill's own bank where he had once stood as a boy of six hundred and eighty-eight to hear Catrìona Mhòr's claimants turned away one by one.

The king heard the word and said nothing for a long while, looking east past the vein toward ground Niall knew he had never in all his years troubled to cross himself, and then said only that he had not looked for any other answer, and thanked Niall for the carrying of it, and turned to the next matter waiting for him.

It was not the last word from the east, though it was the last the king troubled to ask for. Within a season word came west, by traders and not by any messenger sent for the purpose, that the households about Dùn dhearg had begun keeping their own spears closer to hand than they had ever kept them before. No quarrel had broken out among themselves to account for it, and the traders who carried the word could not say what quarrel, whose, the spears were being kept ready against; only that they were being kept ready, and that the keeping of them had become, in the space of that one season, a plain fact of the country the way the double bank was a plain fact, needing no more explaining than the bank did. Niall heard the word at Dùn ìseal among a dozen other pieces of news that season, a

bad harvest on the northern plain, a marriage broken off over a reckoning gone sour, a fourth household removed from ground it had held a hundred years to make way for a fifth; and he found, turning it over afterward at his own hearth, that this was the one word among them all he could not laugh at, though he could not have said, if anyone had asked him that year, exactly why a gathering of spears at a fort three days' ride east should have struck him differently from anything else the kingdom had counted and recounted in the whole of his own long lifetime.

The king, so far as anyone at Dùn ìseal could see, did nothing about any of it: no word sent east again, no muster called west of the vein, no change at all in the plain round of a man who held a hill in his own hand and heard whatever claims and reckonings the day brought him. He sat on the turf as he had sat since Ca-trìona Mhòr's death, and the kin went on counting their shares and marrying for them around him, and the spears gathered, slowly, at Dùn dhearg, the way a river gathers behind a dam it does not yet know is a dam at all.

Of the Tents in the Valley

GE 4,550 – 4,603

This is kept in Na Glinn Arda among Clann na Ceiste, who had it first from Gille-Bride himself, in his own age, before he was old.

I

Of the Eve as It Stood

In the year four thousand five hundred and fifty the island stood as it had stood, by then, for longer than any one household could remember it standing otherwise. The handful was kept at every hearth from the northern capes to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹, each burning its own small measure in the dark of the year and none troubling another with the manner of the burning. Luchd-faire na Lice² were nine, as they had been nine since the lot was last drawn, and the sharing before the storms was kept on every coast that had a boat to share it from, and the saying cut long before on Calbh Cnoc ghorm³ was spoken aloud, plainly and without dispute, wherever two or three of the blood or of the common households came together at a fire: *we did not come; we were here*. None of it had been set down as law. No oath had been sworn over the vein, and no oath had been asked. The king held the hill in his own hand, as he had held it since Ca-trìona Mhòr's death took the last of Rìghrean na Cloiche⁴ list out of the world,

1. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh
2. the keepers of the slab, chosen by lot
3. the column at Cnoc ghorm
4. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

and his kin waited about him, patiently or less patiently as it suited each of them, for shares that were not yet given and could not yet be counted.

It was a few years before this, in the year four thousand five hundred and forty-three, that a son was born in Na Glinn Àrda⁵ to Gille-Bride of Somhairle's line. The child was called Ceallach, after no one that the mother could name, and he was a quiet child, slower to walk than others of that blood and slower still to run, though when he did at last run he ran, his father said, watching him cross the floor of the high valley on legs that had taken the better part of two years to trust themselves, as though he meant to make up in a single afternoon what he had been given late. It was told back afterward, when the boy was grown into whatever he grew into, that this had been the first sign anyone in Na Glinn Àrda troubled to remark on: that the years were coming down faster in him than they had in his father, and faster in his father than in the father before that, a shortening that no one in the valleys named aloud, because there was no cause yet to name it, and because the years a man had were his own business until the manner of his dying made them everyone's.

Gille-Bride was by then the seventh of Somhairle's line after Beathan, a man past a hundred years of his own, a big quiet man who kept to Na Glinn Àrda among Clann na Ceiste⁶ and went down into the lower country only when the asking or the giving of some particular thing required it of him. He held no hill and claimed no share, and it was said of him, by those few of the king's blood who troubled to think of him at all, that he had got the family's patience and none of its hunger, which some of them meant as a compliment and most did not. His own father, an old man then in the second century of his life, came down from the upper valley to see the child that same autumn with a gift of worked flint in a bag on his back, and sat with the boy on his knee by a low fire while Gille-Bride told him, in the flat voice of a man reciting a thing he had said to himself too many times already to feel much about it any longer, that the fever which had taken two of his own brothers young had not touched this one, and that the boy, if the years ran true, might see out the whole of whatever remained to the line before they ran out altogether.

"They will run out," the old man said. It was not a question.

"They will," said Gille-Bride. "Not in me. Perhaps not in him. In someone."

Clann na Ceiste, who kept Na Glinn Àrda about the slab and had kept them since the keepers were first chosen by lot, took little account of the king's kin's

counting of years, having little enough occasion to count their own beyond the ordinary span of a life and a death, and it was one of their number, an old woman who had sat that year's watch at the slab and walked down afterward to see the new child for herself, who said to Gille-Brìde what he came, in time, to think of as the truest word spoken over the boy in the whole of his infancy: that a child born short-lived among the long-lived would grow up knowing early a thing neither his father's people nor hers had ever needed to learn until late, how much of a life could be made to matter in however much of it a body was given. Gille-Brìde kept that word to himself and did not repeat it to his own father, judging that an old man newly certain his line was running out wanted no philosophy laid over the plain fact of it, however kindly meant.

He watched the boy grow through his first years, and found the child each season a little further from what he had expected and a little nearer to something he had no word for yet: quiet where Niall Òg's blood ran loud, careful where Ìomhar's ran quick to grievance, watching the fires of a hearth that was not his own the way a man watches a thing he has been told he will not keep for long, though no one, least of all the boy, had yet told him any such thing in so many words.

II

Of the Father's Three Hundred and Eighth Year

Gille-Brìde's father died at Samhain in the year four thousand five hundred and ninety-nine, in his three hundred and eighth year, which was fewer years than his own father had had, and far fewer than the six hundred his grandfather had counted, and fewer by a long way than the plain thousand-odd of the generations further back still, whose names Na Glinn Àrda¹ kept only as a list recited at a fire and not as men anyone living had known. He died as most of that line had learned, by then, to die: without illness, without a wound, simply slower each year at rising from his own hearthstone until one morning he did not rise from it at all, and the household found him sitting upright with his eyes shut and his hands folded as though he had meant, at the last, to make as little trouble of the thing as a man could.

5. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

6. the Children of the Question

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

Gille-Bride stood at the burying, and it was there, standing over the turned earth with Ceallach a solemn boy of six-and-fifty years holding his hand, that he first heard the word going about the fires that the kin of the king's own blood were, at long last, coming down out of their scattered holdings to gather in the valley below Dùn ìseal, each with tents and a fire of its own and a steward set over its own people, to wait there upon whatever the king should say of the shares that had gone uncounted since Catrìona Mhòr's death. It was said as news, and said, too, with the particular relish that news of the king's kin always drew from households that were not of it: that after so long a waiting, some matter or other was at last to be settled, or at least to be waited for in one place instead of many.

"You should go down and see it," said an old woman of the burying party, who had no love for the king's blood and every love for a spectacle involving it. "It will not come again in your lifetime, whatever it comes to."

"It may not come to anything," Gille-Bride said, "in my lifetime or another's."

But he thought of it walking back up into Na Glinn Àrda with the boy's small hand still cold in his from the graveside, and he found that the old woman's word had lodged in him in a way her spectacle had not: not the gathering itself, which he had little enough curiosity for, but the plain, strange fact that after so many hundreds of years of a hill held quietly by one old man who asked nothing of anyone, the kin should choose, now, to come down and sit under it and wait.

It was in that same season, though the news of it was slower reaching Na Glinn Àrda than most news of the king's own household, that word came of another death nearer the vein than the hill: Fearghal Donn, who had held Dùn dhearg since before Niall Òg was sent to him with a message and sent back with nothing, died in his own bed at the fort in the year four thousand five hundred and seventy, an old man by the reckoning of the common blood though he had never claimed any other, and left the fort and its long unsettled quarrel with the hill to a son grown to manhood inside that quarrel and knowing, by his own later account, no time before it. The households east of the vein buried Fearghal Donn as they had buried Ailis two generations before him, without word sent to Dùn ìseal and without any expecting one to come back, and his son Artair took up the holding of the fort in the same season with no more ceremony than his father had used to take it up before him, and was heard to say, at the burying itself, that he meant to hold what his father had held and ask nothing further of it until the day the hill asked something of him first.

III

Of the Tents and the Steward to Each Line

They began coming down in the summer of the year four thousand six hundred and one, household by household and line by line, no single word sent out to call any of them, each deciding on its own that the waiting had gone on long enough to be done nearer the hill than far from it. Murchadh Mòr's people came from the northern plain in a column that took the better part of three days to pass any one point on the road, eleven sons' worth of grandsons and their own grown children driving cattle before them and carrying, some said, more tent-cloth on their backs than the valley below Dùn ìseal had ever seen brought to one place at once. Eithne's people came from the plain below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹ with less show and no less certainty, her own knot-keeper walking at the head of them with the household's cord wound about his arm as though he meant to be seen keeping count of every soul who set foot on the new ground, which he did, from the first day to the last. Ìomhar Dearg came from the eastern marches with his own household and a grievance he had been nursing, by then, for the better part of a hundred years, over grazing along the river that he judged his by use if not yet by any word of the king's, and he pitched his tents nearer the vein than any other line thought wise, which was, everyone agreed, exactly like him.

Niall Òg came laughing, as he had come laughing to every gathering of his life, claiming through both his mother's blood and his father's a share no one else troubled to dispute with him in the open, though more than one household said behind its own hearth-smoke that a claim made through two lines at once was, by the same reckoning, no more than half a claim doubled, and worth exactly what a claim through one line was worth and not a grain more. An old white-haired daughter of the king's own body came too, older than Eithne by some centuries, and pitched her tent apart from the rest with a small household of her own, and was seen at no fire but her own for the better part of that first summer, which some read as grief for shares long since given and taken back, and others read as nothing more than an old woman's wish to be let alone in her own tent for once in a very long life of not being let alone in it.

And Sìne nan Snaidhm came down from the hill as the household's own knot-keeper, claiming no ground of her own, carrying Sreang nan Teallach² that had

counted every soul under the king's roof for longer than any single line's memory reached, and she walked the new valley in its first weeks the way she had always walked the hill, checking each new tent against the cord in her hands and each steward's tally against her own, so that within a season there was not a fire pitched in that valley, of the king's blood or of any household following it down, whose count she did not keep somewhere on the knots she carried.

A steward stood over every line by the second summer, a man or a woman set by each household, holding no ground the king had given and holding no lordship over any but its own, only charged to speak for it at the common fires and see that its own people did not go hungry or unhoused while the waiting went on, which by then had gone on long enough that the valley below Dùn ìseal had come to look, from any rise above it, less like a gathering that would soon disperse and more like a town that had simply forgotten, or declined, to raise walls around its own fires.

IV

Of Gille-Bride Come Down

Gille-Bride came down himself in the last summer of it, the year four thousand six hundred and three, more out of the same plain curiosity the old woman at the burying had first put in him than out of any claim of his own, for he had none, and wanted none. He walked the two days out of Na Glinn Àrda¹ with Ceallach beside him, a young man now of sixty years and already, though neither of them said it aloud, walking a little more slowly than a man of sixty of the older reckoning ought to have walked, and they came down over the last rise together at evening and stood a while looking at what the valley below Dùn ìseal had become.

He had not seen a gathering of that size in his life, and said so. Fires ran the whole length of the valley floor as far as the last light let him see, more of them than he could have counted in an evening's standing, and the smoke of them lay along the ground in the still air the way mist lay along a river at dawn, so that the tents seemed to rise straight out of it rather than to stand upon the grass. He

1. the watch-fort ruin

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

found Murchadh Mòr first, an old grey giant of a man surrounded by sons and grandsons who all shared his own build about the shoulders, holding forth to a knot of them about grazing rights on the northern plain in a voice that carried the length of three tents in either direction without troubling to be raised for the purpose. He found Eithne after him, seated outside her own tent with her knot-keeper beside her going over the day's tally by firelight, and she greeted Gille-Bride with the particular courtesy of a woman who had long since stopped expecting to be surprised by anything a gathering of her own kin might produce.

Ìomhar Dearg he found arguing, as he had somehow known before he found him that he would be arguing, with a steward of one of the common households over the exact reach of the river-grazing he claimed, a dispute that had, by the sound of it, been running since the first week of the gathering and showed no sign of any conclusion either man expected to reach that night or any other.

"It was given me by the king himself, six hundred years since," Ìomhar was saying, loud enough that half the fires nearest his own could follow the argument without troubling to walk to it, "and I have grazed it every year since without asking leave of any steward set over any household that came to this valley after I did."

"It was given you the near bank," the steward answered him, patient in the particular way of a man who has said the same thing many times before and expects to say it many times again, "and you graze the far one besides, and call the difference nothing because no one has yet troubled to measure it."

"Then measure it," said Ìomhar, "and we will see whose nothing it is." Neither man moved to fetch a rope or a rod to do any such measuring, and Gille-Bride, passing on beyond the firelight, judged that neither man expected the other to, and that the dispute itself, rather than its settling, was what each of them had come down into the valley to keep alive.

Niall Òg he found laughing at someone else's fire, as ever, telling some tale of Rathad an t-Salainn² to a ring of younger cousins who had not heard it before and would, by the look of them, be glad enough to hear it again; and when he saw Gille-Bride standing at the fire's edge he broke off long enough to call across to him, cheerfully, that a man of Somhairle's line who came down into the valley with no claim to press was either the wisest soul in it or the only fool who had not yet worked out what he was owed, and that he, Niall, had not yet decided which,

2. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

and would let Gille-Bride know when he had. Gille-Bride said only that he was content to be thought either, so long as no one troubled to settle the question that same evening, which made Niall Òg laugh again and turn back to his cousins and his tale.

The old white-haired daughter he saw once at a distance, sitting alone outside her own tent with her hands folded, and did not go to her, judging rightly, he thought, that she wanted no company that evening and would not thank a near-stranger for offering it.

It was Sìne nan Snaidhm who found him in the end, coming along the fires with her cord wound about her wrist as she went, and she stopped when she saw him and looked at him a long moment before she spoke, as a woman does who is putting a face to a name she has heard and not yet seen.

"You are of Somhairle's line," she said. "The one who keeps to Na Glinn Àrda."

"I am," he said.

"Your name is not on any cord I carry," she said, not unkindly, "because you have asked for no ground and no share, in all these years, from anyone who might have given you one."

"I have not," he agreed.

"Then you are the only soul in this valley tonight of whom that can be said," she told him, and went on with her counting, leaving him to think, as he stood there among the fires of a gathering he had wanted only to see, that she had not meant it as praise and had not meant it as blame either, only as the plainest fact she knew about him, set down the way she set down every other fact that came to her along the cord.

Word ran through the valley that same week, from fire to fire faster than any steward could carry it formally, that *Sluagh an Ear*³ had begun to move. It had been gathering at Dùn dhearg, by all the telling that reached the western fires, since the spring of that year, under Artair, the same son of Fearghal Donn who had taken up his father's holding thirty years and more before with the plain word that he would ask nothing of the hill until the hill asked something of him; and it was said, by those who claimed to know his mind and by those who only claimed to know his household, that the hill's own moving that summer, the king going down at last among his people after so long a stillness, was the very thing Artair

3. the host of Dùn dhearg and the eastern households

had told himself, thirty years before, that he was waiting for. What Sluagh an Ear meant to do once it had gathered, no one in the valley below Dùn ìseal could say with any certainty, and the tellers who claimed to know said different things depending on which fire they sat at, so that by midsummer there were as many accounts of the east's intent going about the valley as there were fires to tell them at, and most of the households simply went on with their own waiting and let the accounts settle themselves, or fail to, as they would.

V

Of the King's Answer

It was the king himself who settled the question of his own household's part in it, and he settled it, as he had settled most things in his very long life, without asking anyone's leave to do so and without troubling to explain himself past the plain fact of the doing. He came down from Dùn ìseal on a morning near the end of that same summer with a handful of his own people about him, no more than would fill three tents, and word went round the valley before he had gone a mile that the king was going to meet the east himself, and that every line camped along that valley floor meant, upon hearing it, to follow him within a day or two, once tents were struck and stewards set to keep the ground, once this or that last matter of a household's own was seen to.

Gille-Bride stood at the edge of Murchadh Mòr's fire that morning and watched the king go down the valley on foot among his handful of household, a grey-headed man with a young man's face, walking at a pace that did not look, from where Gille-Bride stood, like the pace of a man who expected to be followed soon or gladly. He went to the king before he had gone far, not knowing himself quite why he did it until he had already done it, and asked him plainly whether he, too, should come down to the ford with the rest.

The king stopped and looked at him a while, the way a man looks at something he has not troubled to look at closely before and finds, on the looking, not unfamiliar after all.

"You are Somhairle's," he said. It was not a question either.

"I am what is left of that line that still walks Na Glinn Àrda¹," Gille-Bride said, "and asks nothing of anyone."

"Then go home to them," said the king. "Whatever comes of this, it will want telling afterward by someone who was not in it, and your people have always been better at the telling than the coming."

Gille-Bride said nothing more to that, because there was nothing in it that asked for an answer, and the king went on down the valley among his handful of household, and did not look back, and every line behind him along that valley floor went on saying, at its own fire and in its own time, that it would follow him in a day or two, as each of them had been saying since the news of the east's moving first ran the length of the tents.

Murchadh Mòr said it that same evening, standing at the edge of his own fire with a grandson on either side of him, that he would bring his own people down within the week once the cattle were seen to; and Eithne said it more quietly to her knot-keeper, who set it down on the cord as though a word of intent were as good, for her purposes, as a soul already counted; and Ìomhar Dearg said it loudest of all, to no one steward in particular, that he would follow the king to the ford himself and see the matter of the river-grazing settled once and for all where it could be settled by more than argument, though which matter he meant by that, the grazing or the gathering of spears at Dùn dhearg, he did not trouble to say, and no one troubled to ask him. Niall Òg said it laughing, as he said everything, and the old white-haired daughter said nothing at all that anyone at any fire heard her say, and struck her own tent two days later to pitch it again in the upper camps, apart from the noise of the rest, and did not come down from them.

Sine nan Snaidhm alone said nothing of following, because it was no part of her charge to follow the king anywhere; her charge was the cord, and the cord stayed at Dùn ìseal, in the hands of whichever household the king left behind him to keep the hill while he was gone, and she was seen, in the days after his going, walking the emptying rows of tents with the same care she had walked them full, as though a valley half-struck were no less hers to count than a valley pitched from end to end.

Gille-Bride took the boy Ceallach by the arm that same afternoon and turned north, back up out of the valley of tents and its smoke lying low along the grass,

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

toward Na Glinn Àrda where no ground was claimed and no share waited to be counted, and he did not look back either, though he thought, walking, that he would remember the smoke of that valley for whatever years were left to him, however many or few they proved to be against his father's three hundred and eight, and that someone, as the king had said, would have the telling of what came after, and that it would not, after all, be him who came to it, only him who walked away from where it was about to happen and carried the boy home.

CHAPTER FORTY

OF the FORD below Dùn dhearg

GE 4,603

It is the tellers of the east themselves who give this best, for they had cause to remember it, and the telling that follows keeps closest to the account of a lad who stood in it, sixteen years old and the youngest spear of his household, whose own name the east never troubled to keep.

I

Of the Camp under Artair mac Fhearghail

They came down to the river in the last days of an Lùnastal, the whole strength of the country east of the vein, household by household, until the fires along the east bank ran for the better part of a mile and a boy standing at one end of them could not see the far end for smoke. Artair mac Fhearghail held Dùn dhearg that year, an old fort's holder grown grey in a country that had never sent a name to be recited at any ford, and it was under his word, more than any other's, that the households had come down at last, though he himself said afterward that no one word of his had done it: the thing had been three generations gathering, like water behind a bank nobody built on purpose, and he had only stood where the bank happened to break.

The lad's household came with the rest, twenty-some strong counting the old women who would not be left behind and the boys too young yet to carry a spear who came anyway to mind the fires. His father had cut turf on the second bank at

Dùn dhearg the year it went up, and had told him since he could walk that no household east of the vein owed the hill at Dùn ìseal so much as a good morning, let alone a season's labour or a daughter in marriage; and the lad had grown up on that telling the way he had grown up on his mother's porridge, without ever once asking where the grain in it had come from.

Word had run down from the west all that summer, the way water finds its own low ground without anyone digging it a channel: that the king's own kin, greedy for the shares that would fall open when the old man went at last into the ground like other men, had begun to count each other's herds and each other's daughters with an eye that liked what it counted less each year; that the king held the hill at Dùn ìseal alone now, giving it to none of his blood, and sat on it the way a man sits on a coal he does not mean to hand to his neighbour's fire; that he had sent to Dùn dhearg once, some seasons back, bidding the households come in and be counted at last, and been sent an answer that owed him nothing and never would. Fearghal Donn had given that answer before his son was born, and Artair mac Fhearghail told it again at the fires the night the host came down, so that even those too young to remember the sending of it should know exactly what had been said and to whom.

"We told him we would keep our own bank," the old holder said, turning a coal over with a stick so that the good side of it faced up, "and that a hill across the vein was no more to us than a story is to a man with his own field to plough. That was the answer. It has not changed since, and I see no cause in eighty years to change it now."

Someone asked, from further back at the fire, whether it was true the king did not age, and whether that made him something other than a man that a host of ordinary spears might reasonably hope to bring down.

"He is flesh," Artair said, and did not raise his voice to say it, which was more frightening, the lad thought afterward, than if he had shouted it. "Whatever else he is, under the grey hair and the years, he is flesh, and flesh comes to an end somewhere. I have not lived sixty years east of the vein to tell my own grandchildren that a man cannot be met."

They had been told the king was coming east at last with his kin, meaning to hold the ford against whatever the east chose to do about it, or to be met at it and answered plainly one way or the other after three generations of silence; and the host had come down to the river in the dark before the first morning meaning to

hold it first, on the strength of numbers alone, three thousand spears and more against however many the old man's kin thought fit to bring.

His mother had not come down with the rest of the household, being past the age for it and no fonder of rivers than her son's father was fond of words, but she had stood at the door of their house the morning they left and told him, plainly enough that he still had the whole of it by heart years after, that a fight three generations in the gathering was not a thing one lad's caution or one lad's daring would settle either way, and that his business in it was to come home again, and that she would hear no telling of the ford from him that did not end with him standing at that same door to give it. His father had said nothing to that, being a man who left the giving of instructions to his wife and the keeping of them to himself, but he had put his own hand once, briefly, on the back of the lad's neck before they took the road east to the river, which was as much as the lad had ever known him to say on any subject at all.

The lad slept badly that night, if he slept at all, between his father's back and the noise of a country's worth of neighbours settling their gear along a riverbank none of them had camped on before, and he remembers, of that whole night, mostly the cold that came up off the gravel through the ground and the sound, endless and low, of the river below the camp, which none of them yet knew to listen to.

II

Of the Man Alone at the Ford

In the grey light before sunrise the lad woke to find the mist lifting off the water in ropes, and the west bank, which the host had gone to sleep expecting to see thick with the king's kin and their households and the spears of the hills mustered against them, empty.

There was one man on it.

He sat on a flat stone at the head of the ford with a spear laid across his knees, and there was no one else with him: no household, no fire, no line of spears drawn up at his back. The lad looked up and down the far bank for the rest of them, the way a man looks twice at a gate he expects to find shut and finds standing open, and found nothing but turf and the track going up from the ford toward the vein and toward Dùn ìseal beyond it, empty in the thinning mist.

Word went along the fires quicker than any man could carry it on his own two feet, the way such word always does: that the king had come ahead of his kin with a handful of his own household, and had sent that handful back up the road again in the night; that his kin, for all their coming in with tents and stewards two summers past, had not come to the ford at all, each house waiting on the others, each afraid that while its own spears stood at a river its cousins' spears would be settling accounts on its own hills behind its back. They had already begun, it was said, to quarrel over what the old man would leave, before he had left anything.

Nobody in the host of Dùn dhearg believed it at first. Then, all down the bank at once, as such things happen, everybody did, and a shout went up along the whole mile of fires that startled birds off the river a long way downstream.

The man on the stone stood.

The lad had heard all his life, at hearths from Caol shean to the double bank, how the king was said to be a big man, and found, looking across the water at him in the grey of that morning, that the king was not big as he had pictured him, and was bigger. He came down to the water's edge without hurrying and stood there with the spear held loose in one hand, and the grey of his hair was the only grey thing on that whole far bank of green turf and dark river-stone; and the lad, who had a spear of his own in his fist and three thousand spears at his back, felt something come across the water to him that he could only afterward liken to the warmth off a kiln a long way from the fire, and was afraid of it, and could not have said why he was afraid, since the man had not moved to threaten anyone and stood, if anything, unnaturally still.

Artair mac Fhearghail came down the bank to where the lad stood with his father, and looked a long while across the river before he spoke.

"He has left his kin behind him and come to the water alone," the old holder said, half to himself. "Either that is a great courage, or he does not believe we will come at him at all. We had best show him which of the two he has misjudged."

III

Of the First Day

The first rush went into the ford at sunrise, before the mist was fully off the water. Two hundred went in together, or near it, with a roar that the lad felt in his chest before he heard it as words, and the shallow water broke

white round their knees as they crossed; and the king went into the river to meet them without any haste that the lad could see, wading out from his stone until the water was at his thighs, and the front of the rush reached him about the middle of the ford, where the gravel drops and the current runs strongest.

The lad was young yet and had been kept back with the boys who minded the fires, so he watched the whole of it from the bank, and he said afterward, more than once, that he could not rightly tell what he had seen, only what came after it. The king did not fight the way the lad had watched men fight at a boundary quarrel or a cattle-raid, one man squared against another and then a third coming up behind the first. He fought, the lad said, the way a river fights a bank: one continuous taking-away of whatever came against him, no single blow answered by a single blow, so that spears went into the place where he had stood and found him already somewhere else, and men went down round him in a ring in the shallow water, and the ring did not close because there was no man left near enough to close it. The current below him ran red before the rush had been in the water the length of time it takes to say a short prayer, and the rush broke on him the way a wave breaks on a rock too old to be moved by any one tide, and what was left of it came back across the ford in worse order than it had gone in.

The king waded back to the west bank and sat down again on his stone, and did not seem, from that distance, so much as out of breath.

A cousin of the lad's mother, a big quiet man who had carried a spear at every boundary dispute the eastern country had seen in twenty years and never once come home from one with so much as a scratch to show for it, had gone in with the first rush and had not come out of the river at all, neither on his own two legs nor carried by anyone else's, and it was some while before anyone at the fires could say for certain into which of the several places a man might vanish in a press like that he had gone. His wife asked after him at every fire down the bank before noon, and was told, at each one, only that no one had seen him fall, which was not the same as being told he had not, and by evening she had stopped asking and sat instead with her children at her own fire, watching the water.

They came at him again before midday, in smaller lines this time, testing the water above and below the main crossing where the channel ran deep enough to swim a man off his feet, hoping to come at him from the side while the ford held his eye; and he was there before each line reached the bank, wherever there was, so that a household that had planned to cross unseen a spear's cast upstream found itself, instead, wading back through its own dead not a quarter of an hour after it

had gone in dry-shod. By early afternoon they had begun throwing spears from the bank rather than closing with him at all, a whole season's work of the spear-makers spent inside two hours, and the lad heard men say, at the fires that dusk, that some of those throws had struck him true and did not seem, from what could be seen at that distance, to matter to him one way or the other.

At dusk the host drew back from the water to its own fires, as a beaten thing draws back to lick whatever can be licked, and counted its own losses, and did not care for the count. The king walked back to his stone in the last of the light and sat, and the lad, who had gone down near the water's edge with two other boys to fill a skin, saw him kneel at the river's lip and wash his hands in it before he went back to sitting, the way any man washes his hands after a day's hard work, and found that stranger than anything else he had watched that whole day.

IV

Of the Second Day

By the second morning the dead had begun to dam the ford.

They lay so thick at the shallows below the crossing, where the current dropped them, that the water backed up behind them and spread wide over the gravel on either side, slow and red and warm where the day before it had run cold and clear; and the men of the east, coming down to the water that second morning, found they must climb over their own dead to reach any part of the river shallow enough to cross at all, which no household among them had ever had to do at any ford before, salt or fresh.

The lad went into the water on the second day, being older by one day and one night than he had been the first, and thought himself no longer a boy to be kept at the fires. He remembered afterward very little of it in order: the cold of the river round his legs and then, further out, a warmth in it he had not looked for, as though he waded into the outflow of a spring rather than the same current that had run cold past his own feet the evening before; a grey-browed face above him, closer than he had ever thought to stand to it, neither angry nor gentle, only still, the way a deep pool is still; and a hand taking the spear out of his two hands the way a mother takes a knife from a child too small yet to be trusted with the edge of it, without violence, almost without haste, as if the taking cost the hand nothing at all. After that he was on the east bank again, face down in trampled mud

with the noise of the river in his ears, and it was some while before he understood that he was not among the dead damming it, only close to being.

He lay there the better part of that day, coming to himself in pieces, and heard the rushes go into the water without him, one after another, from before noon until the light began to fail, and heard them come back each time in smaller numbers than they had gone in with.

That second night the host of Dùn dhearg met at its fires, all of it that could still stand, and there was less shouting in that meeting than there had been the night before, and more silence. Men who had spoken loudest of holding the ford two nights before sat now with their eyes on the ground between their own feet, and one, a holder of grazing along the northern edge of that country who had lost two sons to the river in as many days, said outright that he did not care any longer what the king's kin did or did not do with their shares, and that he would take what was left of his own household home to bury its dead in its own ground rather than add a third son to the river's count.

Nobody answered him with anger, that being a grief no man at those fires could fairly grudge another. Artair mac Fhearghail let him finish, and let the silence that came after him sit a while before he spoke at all, which the lad thought afterward had been its own kind of answer.

Some others said, plainly, that the thing should be let go: that a river ford was no prize worth the whole strength of the east country, and that they should take what remained of their spears home to their own hills before there were none left to take home at all. It was Artair mac Fhearghail, sitting with his own spear laid across his knees the way the man on the far bank had laid his, who answered it at last with the only counsel anyone in that gathering had to set against it.

"No one man can hold a ford forever," the old holder said, and his voice did not rise for this any more than it had risen the morning before. "Whatever he is, under the years and the grey hair, he told me himself, before any of us came to this water, that he is flesh, and flesh comes to an end somewhere, the same as the sea comes to an end of a cliff, given water enough and time enough. We have given him two days of the one. Let every spear the east has go into that river together on the third day, and go on going in, and not draw back for anything short of his falling, and we will come, between us, to the end of him, because there is no other counsel here that does not end in going home with nothing, which I for one will not carry back to my own hearth while I have legs to stand at a ford on."

Nobody spoke against it after that, though a good few, the lad among them, said nothing for it either, only sat with their own thinking. It was, as Artair had said, the only counsel anyone had, and a host with nothing else to hold onto took it the way a drowning man takes whatever piece of wood comes past him, without asking first whether it will bear his weight.

V

Of the Third Day

On the third day every spear the east country had went into the river together, at first light, before the mist was off the water, and did not come out of it again by twos and threes as they had the two days before, but stayed in, wave folding over wave the way the tide folds over a rock at the turn, however far back the rock throws each wave that reaches it.

The lad went in with the rest, being neither dead nor so wounded that his father's household would let him stay dry-shod while every other household sent its whole strength; and he found the water above his waist that morning where the dead of the two days before had dammed it higher than any ford on that river had ever stood, red through and through and warm as a bath left too long on the fire, and it stank in a way he never after smelled without the whole of that day coming back to him whole. He was far back in the press and saw the king himself only in glimpses, over the shoulders and between the spears of the men ahead of him: a grey head standing in the middle of a river with the whole strength of a country closing on it from three sides at once, and the strength breaking round that one head and closing again behind it the way a rising tide breaks round a sea-rock and closes behind, over and over, the whole day long, while the sun went from behind them to overhead to behind the west bank.

By the afternoon there was a light on the water where the king stood, low and close along the river's surface, of no colour the lad had a word for, dark and shining together the way no true fire is, so that where it touched the current the current gave off a kind of steam though the day was warm and windless; and men near enough to be within it, coming back afterward to the bank too spent to go in again, said among themselves, low, that they had seen in it every colour there was and none of them, and would say no more than that however they were pressed, then or after.

The king's kin did not come. Whatever else was true of that day, that was true of it entire: no household from Dùn ìseal, no spear of the hills, no rider on the western track. Twice that afternoon a cry went up along the host that dust had been seen on the road down from the vein, and twice men turned to look, some with hope of relief for the old man and some with dread of it, and both times the dust proved to be nothing but wind lifting the dry summer's dirt off a track that no one at all was riding down. The east had the ford and the river and the whole strength of the man in it entirely to answer for, and by the second false cry no one troubled any longer to turn and look.

At sunset he was still standing, in the middle of the ford, the host round him on every side and the dead round him higher than his own knees, and the river going over the dam of them in a low red fall where the shallows had been. He was not beaten. The lad, looking across at him in the last light with what strength he had left in his own legs, was as sure of that as he was sure of anything that whole day: that not one man of the whole east country had beaten him, and that no one man among them, not Artair mac Fhearghail himself with sixty years' grievance behind his arm, could have. It was only that there was no end to the men coming at him, and there was, somewhere in him however deep it was hidden, an end; and between those two facts, and nothing else, the whole of that third day turned.

VI

Of the Fall

he fell in the dark of the third night, and no man afterward could say which spear had done it, or from which household it had come, and no household of the whole east country would let it be said, then or later, that the blow had been its own. It is told that when he went down the light went out of the river all at once, the way a coal goes out when a bucket of water is thrown square onto it, and that the water, which had run warm through three days no matter how cold the nights between them, ran cold from that hour, cold enough that men standing in it felt it turn under their own legs and cried out at the change before they understood what the cry was for.

The host stood a long while in the dark water after that, not knowing, for what felt the longest stretch of the whole three days, what it was that it had done, or what a man was meant to do next having done it; and some began to weep

where they stood, waist-deep in a cold river in the dark, and could not afterward have said why they wept, since it was the very thing the whole east country had crossed three days of blood to bring about. Artair mac Fhearghail himself, who had spoken the counsel that sent them in on the third day and would carry that all his life whichever way the telling of it went, stood longest of any of them at the place where the king had gone down, saying nothing, until two of his own household came into the water after him and led him out by the arms as a man leads out an old horse that has stood too long in a flooded field and no longer trusts its own legs to find the bank.

They drew him out of the river at last onto the west bank, to the flat stone where he had sat the first grey morning of it, and laid him there. He lay on his back with his eyes open to the last of the stars going out overhead, and his face, when they brought a torch near enough to see it by, was the face of a young man, unlined, with nothing in it that had not been there, by every telling anyone could set against it, in the grove itself at the very beginning of things. Word went afterward, from those closest to Dùn Ìseal, that the mason's own line, which keeps the years of its dead beside their names, gave his as four thousand six hundred and twenty-six; that he had been king since the grove and had never once given it up in all that span; and that no man now living, east of the vein or west of it, had taken it from him with his own single hand, however many hands together had done, between them, what no one of them alone could have.

Before the dawn a saying went along the whole east bank, fire to fire, the way such sayings do when a thing has happened too large for any one teller to carry alone:

Cha do leag aon duine e; leag an sluagh uile e. No one man brought him down; the whole host brought him down.

VII

Of the Fire on the East Bank

The lad had waded out of the river some while before that saying reached his own fire, and sat by it wrapped in a dead man's cloak because his own had gone into the water with him on the second day and never come out again, too spent to feel the cold he must have been sitting in, and too spent, for a long while, to speak at all.

The men about that fire had been three days at a ford that had cost the east country more of its own blood than any raid or any famine any of them could tell of, and they wanted, as men will after such a thing, to have some word of it from someone who had been close enough to bring one back; and since the lad was known to have gone into the river both on the second day and the third, and to have come out of it alive both times, they asked him, when he had got his breath and a little of the fire's warmth into him, what the king had been like, close to.

The lad did not answer at once. He turned the question over the way a man turns a coin he is not sure he has been given the right change in, weighing what there was to say against what there was no way of saying, three days and a whole country's dead against a boy of sixteen sitting at one fire among a mile of them.

"He was warm," the lad said at last, and that was all he said, and he looked into the fire rather than at any of the men who had asked him, and none of them pressed him further for more, that night or, so far as the east country's own telling goes, on any night after it.

PART SEVEN

The Annals of the Age

THE YEARS GE 1 – 250

28 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 1 — *The vigil and the crowning* (Doire ghlais). Ailean keeps watch by the seven fires for seven nights, fasting, a night for each coal. On the eighth night the coals are cold, and Caoran comes into the grove with the Tuath Dè about him. He names Ailean Rìgh Chlann nan Dè¹, king of the godkin, and puts into him the power that was in the coals. Of that power Ailean tells no one while he lives.²

28 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 1 — *Coinneach follows his brother north* (Doire ghlais). Coinneach mac Shuibhne, unable to wait out a year of silence, sets off after his brother with a sack of oat-cake and a skin of buttermilk, following the roads he judges Ailean must have taken toward the grove of Doire ghlais.³

28 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 1 — *The camp beyond the oaks* (Doire ghlais). Coinneach comes within sight of the seven fires at Doire ghlais and finds he cannot cross into the ring of oaks. Coimhdeach na Fine⁴ allows him to camp at the tree-line and no nearer, and he keeps his own vigil there through the seven nights of his brother's watch.⁵

28 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 1 — *Voices heard on the fifth night* (Doire ghlais). On the fifth night of the vigil Coinneach hears, low under the sound of the fires, what he takes for voices, one of them shaped almost like his brother's speech though fallen into a rhythm Ailean never used. He never swears to more than that he heard something.⁶

28 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 1 — *The grove fills with light* (Doire ghlais). On the eighth night, when the seven fires go dark together, Coinneach watches the grove of Doire ghlais fill with a light that is not firelight, and sees shapes moving among the oaks. His feet will not carry him past the tree-line to follow them.⁷

28 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 1 — *The six pots left cold* (Doire ghlais). At dawn the six pots that carried Ailean's fires north are found lying empty on the leaves of Doire ghlais, their turf lids scattered, and the pale stone that held the seventh coal lies among them, giving no light but warm to the touch.⁸

1. king of the godkin, the first king's style

2. ← Leads to *Coinneach follows his brother north*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1; ⇌ At the same time *The camp beyond the oaks*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1; ⇌ At the same time *Voices heard on the fifth night*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1; ⇌ At the same time *The grove fills with light*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1; ○ Same place *The six pots left cold*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1; ← Leads to *Coinneach finds his brother warm at dawn*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1; ← Leads to *"They named me king"*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

3. ← Follows from *The vigil and the crowning*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

4. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

5. ⇌ At the same time *The vigil and the crowning*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

6. ⇌ At the same time *The vigil and the crowning*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

7. ⇌ At the same time *The vigil and the crowning*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

8. ○ Same place *The vigil and the crowning*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1** — *Coinneach finds his brother warm at dawn* (Doire ghlas). Ailean walks out of the grove at morning and catches his stumbling brother by the arm. Coinneach feels a warmth in it like a hearthstone long after the fire is swept, and knows before any word is said that the night has changed his brother.⁹
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1** — *"They named me king"* (Doire ghlas). Ailean tells his brother only this much of the night in the grove: that he has been named king. He says nothing of who named him, of what a king might be king of, or of what was put into him, and Coinneach asks no further, having seen enough from outside the trees.¹⁰
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1** — *The brothers turn south* (Doire ghlas). Ailean gathers the six empty pots onto his shoulder-pole, leaves the pale seventh stone lying uncovered among the leaves of Doire ghlas, and sets out south with his brother, never lighting the six fires again.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1** — *Ailean passes Na Glinn Àrda*¹¹. Ailean walks south past the households of Clann na Ceiste¹² in Na Glinn Àrda without turning aside to any hearth, though he has kin enough among them to be fed and questioned there.
- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1** — *Eleven kin walk south with him*. Households of Clann na Ceiste¹³ near Na Glinn Àrda¹⁴ leave byre and field to follow Ailean south, eleven in all, none able afterward to give a better reason than a feeling not to be argued with. The king shares out Coinneach's sack among them on the road.
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1** — *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings* (Dùn ìseal). Ailean Mòr, crowned in the grove, comes down to the hill where Dùn ìseal now stands and takes it, and brings the households of the valleys about it under his hand: the first kingdom of the godkin. How he won, none who stood against him could say. He throws up the hill's first ring of bank. He is king from that day until his death, and gives the kingship to no one. With him opens the eldest of the spoken king-lists, afterwards called Rìghrean na Cloiche¹⁵, which names those who held the hill; it gives no lengths of reign, and it is older than the name Dia-thìrich.¹⁶
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1** — *The bare ring in the frost*. Twice on the road south the company sleeps in the open, and both mornings the frost that silvers the field leaves a bare, warm ring the size of a sleeping man where Ailean lay, as it did at his feet in the grove.¹⁷

9. ← Follows from *The vigil and the crowning*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

10. ← Follows from *The vigil and the crowning*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

11. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

12. the Children of the Question

13. the Children of the Question

14. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

15. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

16. → Caused by *The brothers turn south*, 6 an Lùnastal, GE 1; → Caused by *Ailean passes Na Glinn Àrda*, 7 an Lùnastal, GE 1; → Caused by *Eleven kin walk south with him*, 8 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

17. ⇌ At the same time *The vigil and the crowning*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 1** — *Coinneach keeps the first telling.* Walking south behind his brother, Coinneach turns over what little he saw from outside the ring of oaks and fits it into an account he is careful never to swell beyond what he truly witnessed, the seed of the telling Clann na Ceiste¹⁸ keep of the seven nights.¹⁹
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1** — *The lad who brought the water* (Dùn ìseal). The knapper's son of Dùn ìseal is sent to the hill's crown with water for the man who has just taken it unopposed, and is asked his name and whether the spear he carries is his father's best. Told to take it home and to tell his father the king will want a great many more.²⁰
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 1** — *The valleys come in to the hill* (Dùn ìseal). Through the first year the households of the valleys about Dùn ìseal come in to the king one after another, unsummoned, bringing hides, pots, and whatever else they judge fitting, and with their gifts their grazing and their old quarrels, for a telling to be held over them.²¹
- 17 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 1** — *The first judgement on the hill* (Dùn ìseal). Two households of Dùn ìseal bring before the king a strip of pasture each has claimed for a generation. He asks one question, of whose cattle grazed it before the boundary stone was last moved, and gives the strip back in a sentence. Neither household ever brings the matter before him again.²²
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1** — *The king's order to the flint-pit* (Dùn ìseal). The flint-pit behind the houses of Dùn ìseal is set, on the king's own word, to cut spearheads by the score rather than as they are needed, the first order of its kind on the hill. The knapper's son is set to the work alongside his father before that year's leaves are down.²³
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1** — *The warmth with no fire* (Dùn ìseal). In the first hard winter on the hill, a girl of Dùn ìseal stands near the king's own untended fire at night and finds herself warmed through though no flame burns close enough to account for it. She keeps the telling to herself for years before it is believed.²⁴
- 30 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2** — *The line of the bank pegged in the snow* (Dùn ìseal). In the depth of the same winter the king walks the crown of Dùn ìseal setting ash pegs with his own hand, marking a line that takes in the old byres and ground for houses not yet built. The households break the frozen turf along it through the worst of the frost.
- 29 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2** — *Flint tools finish the bank's ditch* (Dùn ìseal). When the antler mattocks digging the new ditch at Dùn ìseal blunt faster than they can be sharpened in the frost, the flint-pit sends up scrapers of worked stone to finish the work, so that the hill's first bank is cut as much with flint as with iron.

18. the Children of the Question

19. ¶ Legacy *The vigil and the crowning*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

20. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings*, 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

21. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings*, 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

22. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings*, 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

23. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings*, 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2** — *Muireall and Gormshuil brought to the hill* (Dùn ìseal). As the frost breaks a small company comes down from Na Glinn Àrda²⁵ to Dùn ìseal: Muireall, the king's wife, and Gormshuil, his young daughter, with a few kin and hands beside them. The hill, which had thought the king had no household of his own, falls quiet to let them through the new gate.
- 1 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2** — *Dòmhnall born within the new bank* (Dùn ìseal). A son is born to Muireall inside the finished bank of Dùn ìseal, the first of the king's children to draw breath on ground he holds, and the hill takes it as a settled thing that the king has come to stay among them.
- 7 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2** — *A spearhead given for nothing* (Dùn ìseal). The knapper cuts a spearhead finer than any he has made that year, for no order and no payment, and sends it up to the king's fire on the birth of the king's son. He will not say why, only that the giving seemed owed.
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 9** — *The bank of Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). The first earthwork is raised on the hill at Dùn ìseal: a single bank and ditch, enclosing room for some forty houses. It is the oldest defended place of the hill-folk.²⁶
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 9** — *Gormshuil set to keep the gate* (Dùn ìseal). A child of eight, Gormshuil is given the gate of the new bank to watch, and takes to naming every face and dog on the hill so her father will have someone to tell him at evening what the day brought. The habit holds her the rest of her life.²⁷
- 4 AN CÈITEAN, GE 10** — *Fearchar born on the hill* (Dùn ìseal). A second son is born to the king within the new bank of Dùn ìseal and named Fearchar; he is the first of the king's children to open his eyes on the hill itself, and will hold it for his father in his time.²⁸
- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 18** — *Beathag Ruadh of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Ruadh holds the hill where Cathair dhearg now stands. With her opens a second spoken list, kept in the west. The Red Hill list and the list of the Stone Kings make no mention of each other until late in both.²⁹
- 6 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 18** — *Word of the red hill's woman* (Dùn ìseal). A salt-fish trader carries word up to Dùn ìseal of a woman holding a red hill on the shore of the great lake in her own right, answering to no king. Gormshuil asks her father whether it means trouble; he tells her trouble comes from nearer at hand.³⁰

24. ← Follows from *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings*, 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

25. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

26. → Caused by *The line of the bank pegged in the snow*, 30 an Giblean, GE 2; → Caused by *Flint tools finish the bank's ditch*, 29 an Cèitean, GE 2; ⇌ At the same time *Gormshuil set to keep the gate*, 4 an t-Samhain, GE 9.

27. ⇌ At the same time *The bank of Dùn ìseal*, 4 an t-Samhain, GE 9.

28. ← Follows from *The bank of Dùn ìseal*, 4 an t-Samhain, GE 9.

29. ⇌ At the same time *Word of the red hill's woman*, 6 an Dàmhair, GE 18.

30. ⇌ At the same time *Beathag Ruadh of the Red Hill*, 6 an Dàmhair, GE 18.

7 AM MÀRT, GE 24 — *Muireall's dying words* (Dùn ìseal). In her last two nights Muireall speaks to her daughter of small things, a comb, a debt owed, and warns that her youngest son Fearchar has a temper that will want watching before it finds him trouble he cannot talk his way out of.³¹

10 AN DÙHLACHD, GE 24 — *The king hears three cases the day Muireall is buried* (Dùn ìseal). Two days after Muireall is put in the ground the king comes in from the valleys, stands by the mound, then goes into the hearing-house and gives judgement on three waiting cases before dark. He does not speak her name again where any ear can catch it.³²

1 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 27 — *Gormshuil nic Ailein* (Dùn ìseal). Gormshuil nic Ailein, the king's daughter, holds the hill of Dùn ìseal for her father while he rides beyond it, and the list names her second of the Stone Kings; she is the first woman named in any list on Dia-thìr. She was born before the grove, and has none of the long years. One deed is told of her: in a hard winter she moves the herds of Dùn ìseal down to the warm springs and loses none.

³³

21 AM MÀRT, GE 27 — *The drive to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh*³⁴ (Dùn ìseal). With the hardest winter in living memory emptying the byres and the king three valleys off, Gormshuil drives the standing herds two days through drifted snow to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh, walking the whole way herself so no beast's fodder is spent on a rider. She loses none.³⁵

16 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 27 — *The two fingers that never bent again* (Dùn ìseal). Gormshuil comes off the winter drive with two fingers of her left hand frozen stiff, and wears a glove over them in company from that year to her death without ever speaking of how they were got.³⁶

18 AN GEARRAN, GE 30 — *The king weds Sorcha* (Dùn ìseal). Ailean takes a second wife, Sorcha, a woman of the valleys younger than his own eldest daughter, and the hill notes the matter and does not remark on it aloud, as it has grown used to doing with the king's household.³⁷

23 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 33 — *Coinneach's counsel on the bank* (Dùn ìseal). Gormshuil tells Coinneach that her father does not age while she has begun to grey. He tells her what he saw the night the fires went out in the grove, and counsels her to keep from asking her father what it cost him, as he has kept from asking these thirty years.³⁸

31. ⇔ At the same time *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings*, 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

32. ⇔ At the same time *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings*, 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

33. → Caused by *Muireall and Gormshuil brought to the hill*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2.

34. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

35. ← Follows from *Gormshuil nic Ailein*, 1 am Faoilleach, GE 27.

36. ⇔ At the same time *Gormshuil nic Ailein*, 1 am Faoilleach, GE 27.

37. ⇔ At the same time *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings*, 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

38. ⇔ At the same time *The vigil and the crowning*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 38** — *Somhairle born* (Dùn ìseal). Sorcha bears the king a son, Somhairle, in the thirty-eighth year after the grove, the first child of Sorcha's line to be counted among those got after the grove.³⁹
- 20 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 40** — *Beathag Ruadh dies on An Cnoc Ruadh*⁴⁰ (Cathair dhearg). Beathag Ruadh, who held An Cnoc Ruadh by the lake before any of the valleys came in to the king, dies an old woman in her own hall, unsworn and unbeaten; her household keeps the palisade after her and the lake shore does not change its ways for her going.⁴¹
- 22 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 45** — *Iain Dubh born* (Dùn ìseal). A second son of Sorcha's, Iain Dubh, is born to the king on the hill, the youngest of Ailean's children to be reckoned among Rìghrean na Cloiche⁴² in his turn.⁴³
- 19 AM MÀRT, GE 55** — *Coinneach dies, Sloinneadh a' Chlachair*⁴⁴ passed whole (Dùn ìseal). Coinneach mac Shuibhne dies an old man, the first teller of the king's deeds, having taught Gormshuil Sloinneadh a' Chlachair word for word as Coimhdeach na Fine⁴⁵ gave it in the grove. She is, after her father, the second on the hill to carry the whole of it.⁴⁶
- 18 AN GEARRAN, GE 60** — *The grandchildren take the king for her son* (Dùn ìseal). Gormshuil's own grandchildren, seeing the king young at the gate each autumn beside a bent grey grandmother, take him for her son rather than her father, and she lets the mistake stand rather than make them carry a harder truth too young.⁴⁷
- 7 AM MÀRT, GE 76** — *Gormshuil's deathbed question* (Dùn ìseal). On the second night of her dying Gormshuil asks her father whether it hurts to stay young. He does not answer her in words, and says her name once instead, the way a man says a name he does not expect to say again.⁴⁸
- 5 AN GIBLEAN, GE 76** — *Gormshuil dies* (Dùn ìseal). Gormshuil nic Ailein dies an old woman of eighty-one, the king's eldest daughter and second of Rìghrean na Cloiche⁴⁹. He sits by her a night and a day and helps lift the turf over her with his own hands, as he did for no one since Muireall.⁵⁰

39. ⇌ At the same time *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings*, 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

40. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

41. ← Follows from *Beathag Ruadh of the Red Hill*, 6 an Dàmhair, GE 18.

42. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

43. ⇌ At the same time *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings*, 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

44. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

45. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

46. ← Follows from *The vigil and the crowning*, 28 an t-Iuchar, GE 1.

47. ⇌ At the same time *Gormshuil nic Ailein*, 1 am Faoilleach, GE 27.

48. ← Follows from *Gormshuil nic Ailein*, 1 am Faoilleach, GE 27.

49. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

50. ← Follows from *Gormshuil nic Ailein*, 1 am Faoilleach, GE 27.

- 17 AN GIBLEAN, GE 76** — *The hill understands na Bliadhnachan Fada*⁵¹ (Dùn ìseal). Watching Gormshuil, who carried her father's stubbornness and stillness but not his years, put into the ground beside a father who looks her grandson's age, the hill understands at last that na Bliadhnachan Fada are the grove's alone, and pass to no child got before it.⁵²
- 16 AN CÈITEAN, GE 76** — *Dòmhnall takes the hill* (Dùn ìseal). Dòmhnall Clachach, seventy-four and looking a young man still, takes up the hearing-house his half-sister held since the grove, and says he supposes he had better learn to count who comes and goes, since no one is left who learned it from the start as she did.
- 3 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 107** — *Dòmhnall Clachach sets the boundary stones* (Dùn ìseal). Dòmhnall Clachach, a son of the king and third of the Stone Kings, holds the hill after Gormshuil and sets marker stones along the valley below it to part the grazing of Dùn ìseal from its neighbours'. Some stand yet, and are argued over yet.⁵³
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 107** — *The old men disagree at the setting of the stones* (Dùn ìseal). As Dòmhnall Clachach walks the eastern boundary with his stone-setters, the old men of neighbouring households cannot agree, standing on the very ground, where a line has always run, for the becks have shifted and their memories have not moved with them.⁵⁴
- 23 AN GEARRAN, GE 115** — *A grazing quarrel judged by the stones* (Dùn ìseal). Two households dispute a marker on the eastern slope, each swearing it stands to the wrong side of the old line. Dòmhnall Clachach settles it from his own memory of the setting, and both sides go home certain, for the first time, that a stone remembers better than a grandfather.⁵⁵
- 21 AN CÈITEAN, GE 116** — *Dòmhnall doubts his own stones* (Dùn ìseal). Walking home from the judgement at the marker, Dòmhnall Clachach understands that he has settled the quarrel only because his own long memory outlasts any old man's, and that the stones, once he is gone from the hill, will have no one left to ask which story is true.⁵⁶
- 22 AN GIBLEAN, GE 142** — *Griogar's household turns back the king's riders*. In a valley to the north-west a hard old man called Griogar meets two of the king's riders with spears and no parley, the first household in years to refuse the king's word outright rather than simply keep clear of it.⁵⁷
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 147** — *The first named storm*. A tempest comes so great that the eldest spoken king-lists give it a name. The name is lost; only the memory of the naming remains.

51. the long years of Ailean's kin

52. ← Follows from *Gormshuil nìc Ailein*, 1 am Faoilleach, GE 27.

53. → Caused by *Dòmhnall born within the new bank*, 1 an t-Iuchar, GE 2; ⇌ At the same time *A spearhead given for nothing*, 7 an t-Samhain, GE 2; → Caused by *Dòmhnall takes the hill*, 16 an Cèitean, GE 76.

54. ← Follows from *Dòmhnall Clachach sets the boundary stones*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, GE 107.

55. ¶ Legacy *Dòmhnall Clachach sets the boundary stones*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, GE 107.

56. ¶ Legacy *Dòmhnall Clachach sets the boundary stones*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, GE 107.

57. ← Follows from *Dòmhnall doubts his own stones*, 21 an Cèitean, GE 116.

- 28 AN GEARRAN, GE 147** — *The shell road broken* (Seann Warr). The storm breaks the shell causeway of Seann Warr in three places and floods the marsh behind it with lake water. The Seann-Dhaoine⁵⁸ do not mend it, and the broken ends may be seen still.
- 8 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 147** — *Storm damage within the bank of Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). The first named storm strips the thatch from six houses of Dùn ìseal and levels a seventh to its footings. Dòmhnall Clachach spends the night holding roofs down with rope and his own weight, and the hill loses its summer hay and two sheds of the flint-pit, but no one within the bank.⁵⁹
- 30 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 148** — *Word of the broken causeway reaches Dùn ìseal* (Seann Warr). Traders driven from their usual road by flooded fords bring Dòmhnall Clachach word that the shell causeway of Seann Warr stands broken in three places, and that the Seann-Dhaoine⁶⁰ have watched it stay broken through a winter without coming out to mend it.⁶¹
- 25 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 160** — *Labhrainn refuses the boundary of his western fence* (Dùn ìseal). Labhrainn, elder of an old household on the western slope, refuses the line his own father stood by at its setting, the first quarrel in Dòmhnall Clachach's time that is fought not over ground but over a settling that no longer needs an old man's word to stand.⁶²
- 27 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 161** — *Dòmhnall sits an evening with Labhrainn* (Dùn ìseal). After judging against him, Dòmhnall Clachach rides out to Labhrainn's byre and sits a whole evening over the household's own brewing, asking not about the stone but the ground itself, and gives the old man back in listening something the stones had quietly taken from him.⁶³
- 4 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 189** — *Fearchar Bacach lamed in Griogar's valley*. Riding with a dozen men against the household that turned back his riders, Ailean Mòr's son Fearchar takes a spear through the thigh that will not heal straight, though the wound should by any ordinary reckoning have killed him.
- 6 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 200** — *Somhairle asks to live among Clann na Ceiste*⁶⁴. Somhairle, a son of Ailean Mòr some hundred and sixty years old and looking fifteen, asks his father for no land and no herds, only leave to live among the households of Na Glinn Àrda⁶⁵ and be counted a single mouth at a single hearth.⁶⁶

58. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

59. ⇌ At the same time *The first named storm*, 30 am Faoilleach, GE 147.

60. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

61. ← Follows from *The shell road broken*, 28 an Gearran, GE 147.

62. ↓ Legacy *Dòmhnall Clachach sets the boundary stones*, 3 an Dùbhlachd, GE 107.

63. ← Follows from *Labhrainn refuses the boundary of his western fence*, 25 am Faoilleach, GE 160.

64. the Children of the Question

65. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

66. ← Follows from *Fearchar Bacach lamed in Griogar's valley*, 4 an Lùnastal, GE 189.

- 8 AN GIBLEAN, GE 201** — *Somhairle tells Dòmhnall why he wants no share.* Visiting his brother in Na Glinn Àrda⁶⁷, Dòmhnall Clachach is told that Somhairle wants to be believed when he names whose son follows whose, once the kin have grown too many for any one hearth to hold the account, and that a man who holds land judges his own kin differently.⁶⁸
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, GE 210** — *The chair of woven birch is built for Fearchar (Dùn ìseal).* The household carpenters of Dùn ìseal build Fearchar Bacach a chair of woven birch with long carrying-poles, unasked, so that he need no longer hide the leg that never set straight, and he takes to being carried with something like relief.
- 9 AN GEARRAN, GE 225** — *Uisdean born on An Cnoc Ruadh⁶⁹ (Cathair dhearg).* A son is born by the lake shore to a household of An Cnoc Ruadh's holding line and named Uisdean; the watch on the palisade marks his birth with a fire on the point, as it marks every birth in that hall.⁷⁰
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, GE 227** — *Fearchar Bacach (Dùn ìseal).* Fearchar Bacach, the lame, a son of the king lamed in his father's wars, holds Dùn ìseal under the king after the storm and after Dòmhnall Clachach, and is carried to the gatherings in a chair of woven birch. He is the first ruler on Dia-thìr remembered for a hurt.⁷¹
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 227** — *Dòmhnall asks his father for the north (Dùn ìseal).* At a gathering below Dùn ìseal, Dòmhnall Clachach asks Ailean Mòr for ground still unsettled rather than the hill he has held a hundred and fifty years. His father grants him the north and no guidance in how to keep it.⁷²
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 227** — *Fearchar Bacach holds Dùn ìseal as Dòmhnall rides north (Dùn ìseal).* Dòmhnall Clachach leaves Dùn ìseal with a company of twelve, and the hill takes his brother Fearchar, already sitting its judgements from the chair of birch, for its holder without a word of dispute.⁷³
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 250** — *Uisdean Mòr takes An Cnoc Ruadh⁷⁴ (Cathair dhearg).* Uisdean, five-and-twenty, takes up the holding of An Cnoc Ruadh on the western lake shore after those before him, an old line owing nothing to Dùn ìseal or to any king of the hill-folk.

67. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

68. ← Follows from *Somhairle asks to live among Clann na Ceiste*, 6 an t-Iuchar, GE 200.

69. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

70. ← Follows from *Beathag Ruadh dies on An Cnoc Ruadh*, 20 am Faoilleach, GE 40.

71. → Caused by *Fearchar Bacach lamed in Griogar's valley*, 4 an Lùnastal, GE 189; → Caused by *The chair of woven birch is built for Fearchar*, 7 an Cèitean, GE 210.

72. ← Follows from *Fearchar Bacach*, 27 an Giblean, GE 227.

73. ← Follows from *Fearchar Bacach*, 27 an Giblean, GE 227.

74. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

THE YEARS GE 251 – 500

- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 262** — *Uilleam Faire born on An Cnoc Ruadh*¹ (Cathair dhearg). A boatwright's son is born on the lake shore in the twelfth year of Uisdean's holding, and grows up believing, as every child of that hill does, that the water below it has always belonged to his own people alone.
- 25 AM MÀRT, GE 267** — *The households dig the ditch across the neck* (Cathair dhearg). Every household of An Cnoc Ruadh² turns out to cut the ditch across the low saddle of ground where the hill's rise meets the land, and to raise the oak palisade on the spoil bank behind it.
- 29 AM MÀRT, GE 267** — *Uisdean Mòr of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Uisdean Mòr, second of the Red Hill list, digs a ditch across the neck of the hill where Cathair dhearg now stands and sets a palisade on it. In his time the palisade burns twice and is twice rebuilt.³
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 282** — *Uisdean tells the watch why the wall stands* (Cathair dhearg). Walking the palisade by night with the young Uilleam Faire, Uisdean speaks of na Bliadh-nachan Fada⁴ of the king and of the valleys brought in to the south and east, and does not say whether An Cnoc Ruadh⁵ will swear when its turn comes.
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 289** — *The king's company camps unannounced on the shore* (Cathair dhearg). The king comes west along the lake shore with some two hundred spears at the end of a summer, camps below the hill, and sends up no word of his business to Uisdean or to any of An Cnoc Ruadh⁶'s households.
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 289** — *The first burning of the palisade* (Cathair dhearg). On the last watch before dawn the new palisade catches along its whole length at once in a low, dark, shining flame that no one on the wall can trace to any torch or spark. The hill beats it out by morning with lake water and green hides.⁷
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 289** — *Uisdean rebuilds with green oak* (Cathair dhearg). Rather than wait out a season for seasoned timber, Uisdean sets the households to rebuilding the palisade at once with green oak cut from his own hill, against every carpenter's word of how badly it will burn.⁸

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

2. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

3. → Caused by *Uisdean Mòr takes An Cnoc Ruadh*, 31 an Lùnastal, GE 250; ⇌ At the same time *Uilleam Faire born on An Cnoc Ruadh*, 5 an t-Ògmhios, GE 262; → Caused by *The households dig the ditch across the neck*, 25 am Màrt, GE 267.

4. the long years of Ailean's kin

5. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

6. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

7. ← Follows from *Uisdean Mòr of the Red Hill*, 29 am Màrt, GE 267.

8. ← Follows from *Uisdean Mòr of the Red Hill*, 29 am Màrt, GE 267.

- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 289** — *The king's spearmen trade through the winter* (Cathair dhearg). Neither striking camp nor pressing nearer the wall, the king's company fishes the shallows and mends its gear through the winter, and trades salted fish and small goods with households of the hill who find it easier than the long carry round the lake.
- 2 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 290** — *Reothadh an Rìgh*⁹ (Cathair dhearg). In the early days of an t-Ògmhios, when the year should long since have been past any frost, a single clear night puts a white rime on the whole shore. The hill's old women name it from that morning Reothadh an Rìgh.
- 7 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 290** — *The Red Hill bends the knee* (Cathair dhearg). Ailean Mòr comes west to the Red Hill, where the palisade of Uisdean Mòr has twice burned. Uisdean comes down to the lake shore and kneels to him. The Red Hill keeps its own holders and its own list, and swears to the king and not to Dùn ìseal; so neither list names the other.¹⁰
- 20 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 290** — *The second burning of the palisade* (Cathair dhearg). On the night of Reothadh an Rìgh¹¹ the green oak takes in the same low, dark flame as before, and burns in less time than seasoned wood had, leaving nothing standing for the households to save.¹²
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 290** — *Uilleam throws the water and never learns whose fire it was* (Cathair dhearg). Uilleam Faire is first to the second fire with a hide-skin of water, and throws it into the worst of the blaze without saving a hand's-breadth of the wall. He carries the question of whose fire it was the rest of his life.¹³
- 20 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 290** — *The king's company departs east* (Cathair dhearg). Within the month of Uisdean's swearing the king's company strikes its tents and goes back east the way it came, and does not return to the lake shore.¹⁴
- 21 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 290** — *Dùghall first walks the whole road to the shore* (Seann Chwen). Dùghall, nine years old, is let walk the whole three days down to the Seann-Dhaoine¹⁵'s shore with his father for the first time, rather than being turned back with the pack-ponies at the last ridge. He learns the trade is carried by gesture alone, in silence kept on both sides.¹⁶

9. the unseasonable frost of early an t-Ògmhios GE 290 on the Red Hill's lake shore, named for the night of the palisade's second burning

10. → Caused by *Uisdean tells the watch why the wall stands*, 19 an Lùnastal, GE 282; → Caused by *The king's company camps unannounced on the shore*, 19 an Lùnastal, GE 289; ⇌ At the same time *The king's spearmen trade through the winter*, 16 an Dàmhair, GE 289; → Caused by *Reothadh an Rìgh*, 2 an t-Ògmhios, GE 290.

11. the unseasonable frost of early an t-Ògmhios GE 290 on the Red Hill's lake shore, named for the night of the palisade's second burning

12. ← Follows from *Uisdean Mòr of the Red Hill*, 29 am Màrt, GE 267.

13. ⇌ At the same time *The Red Hill bends the knee*, 7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 290.

14. ← Follows from *The Red Hill bends the knee*, 7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 290.

15. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

16. ⇌ At the same time *Uisdean Mòr of the Red Hill*, 29 am Màrt, GE 267.

- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 290** — *Mòrag born to Dòmhnall Clachach*. A daughter is born to Dòmhnall Clachach in the north country he was given, and is named Mòrag; she is the first of the king's grandchildren to carry na Bliadhnachan Fada¹⁷, and grows up hard-handed among people who call her father only the stone-cutter's son.¹⁸
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, GE 291** — *The palisade raised a third time in seasoned oak* (Cathair dhearg). With no company camped below to hurry the choosing of timber, An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁹ rebuilds its wall a third time in properly seasoned oak. It never burns again in Uilleam Faire's lifetime.²⁰
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, GE 291** — *Dùn ìseal's reciters tell the swearing fuller than An Cnoc Ruadh²¹'s own list* (Cathair dhearg). Word of Uisdean's kneeling reaches Dùn ìseal, whose reciters tell it with the fire, the frost and the shingle scene kept whole, fuller than An Cnoc Ruadh's own spare list ever names it. An Cnoc Ruadh never quarrels with their telling.²²
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, GE 296** — *Dùghall's father gives up asking* (Seann Chwen). Dùghall's father tells his son that he tried, once, as a young man, to learn a Seann-Dhaoine²³ word for the goods they traded, and was met with a courtesy that would not be moved. He has not asked again in forty years, and tells Dùghall which questions the shore means to answer.²⁴
- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 300** — *The road passes to Dùghall* (Seann Chwen). Dùghall's father, too heavy in the knees for the bog-causeway, hands the whole carrying road to his son. Dùghall walks it alone that year with a string of ponies his in all but the naming, three days down to the shore and three days back.
- 31 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 308** — *Strokes on the midden stones* (Seann Chwen). The Seann-Dhaoine²⁵ begin to cut single strokes on flat stones set at the edges of their middens, one stone to a household. The strokes are not the script. They are simpler: a mark, and then another.²⁶
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 308** — *The strokes on the midden stones are first counted* (Seann Chwen). Dùghall, three-and-twenty, notices that the flat stones set at the edge of one household's midden carry cut strokes, one or two to a stone, and that their number has grown by a few since he first began to notice them. He can get no answer to what they are, by word or by gesture.²⁷

17. the long years of Ailean's kin

18. ← Follows from *The Red Hill bends the knee*, 7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 290.

19. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

20. ¶ Legacy *The Red Hill bends the knee*, 7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 290.

21. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

22. ♦ Fulfils *The Red Hill bends the knee*, 7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 290.

23. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

24. ⇌ At the same time *Uisdean Mòr of the Red Hill*, 29 am Màrt, GE 267.

25. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

26. → Caused by *The road passes to Dùghall*, 22 an t-Ògmhios, GE 300.

- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 310** — *Dùghall carries the question home unanswered* (Dùn ìseal). Dùghall tells his father what he has seen at the midden's edge. His father says he saw the same stones himself, years before, and had already judged them a question the shore did not mean to answer, and had stopped asking it.²⁸
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 312** — *Uisdean Mòr dies on An Cnoc Ruadh*²⁹ (Cathair dhearg). Uisdean dies in his own bed on the hill in his eighty-seventh year, two-and-twenty years after the swearing, having outlived the fire, the frost and the king's two hundred spears.³⁰
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 348** — *The counting of the dead begins*. The Seann-Dhaoine³¹, whoever they were, who built Làrach an Dùin-fhaire³² and Làrach an Dùin³³, begin to keep count of their dead. They keep it before ever there were Dia-thìrich to take up the custom.
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 348** — *A household mourns behind a wall of turf* (Seann Chwen). Dùghall, come down to the shore in his sixty-seventh year, wakes in the night to low voices shaped like no ordinary talk, and to boats kept ashore past their hour. He does not go out while it lasts, having learned from the hill's own griefs not to.³⁴
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 348** — *A fresh stroke is cut beneath an old one* (Seann Chwen). The morning after the low voices, Dùghall finds a second stroke cut fresh beneath the single old one on the newest of the midden stones, and understands, all at once, that the Seann-Dhaoine³⁵ mark the going of their own dead the way a hill household marks a grave.³⁶
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 348** — *Dùghall counts every ridge on the shore* (Seann Chwen). Dùghall walks the whole shore that morning and finds every household keeps its own ridge of stones the same way, some bearing a single stroke, some bearing more than he can easily count. He carries the understanding home and tells his father, who is glad, at the last, to have the answer he had stopped seeking.³⁷
- II AM FAOILLEACH, GE 349** — *Dùghall keeps the counting stones from his sons* (Dùn ìseal). Dùghall says nothing more of the midden stones to his sons as they take up the road at his shoulder, judging that each will come to the ridge himself in his own year, as he had. He judges rightly.³⁸

27. ← Follows from *Strokes on the midden stones*, 31 an t-Iuchar, GE 308.

28. ¶ Legacy *Strokes on the midden stones*, 31 an t-Iuchar, GE 308.

29. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

30. ¶ Legacy *Uisdean Mòr of the Red Hill*, 29 am Màrt, GE 267.

31. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

32. the watch-fort ruin

33. the fortress ruin

34. ← Follows from *The counting of the dead begins*, 29 an Lùnastal, GE 348.

35. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

36. ↔ Answers *The counting of the dead begins*, 29 an Lùnastal, GE 348.

37. ← Follows from *The counting of the dead begins*, 29 an Lùnastal, GE 348.

38. ¶ Legacy *The counting of the dead begins*, 29 an Lùnastal, GE 348.

- 4 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 352** — *Dùghall takes his grandson down for the last time* (Seann Chwen). One-and-seventy, and carrying the road no more himself, Dùghall takes his eldest son's boy down to the shore, both understanding without saying so that it is his last going. He finds two houses fallen roofless and fewer threads of smoke than he has ever counted there before.³⁹
- 2 **AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 352** — *The grandson counts the ridge and loses the count* (Seann Chwen). Dùghall sets his grandson to count the stones of the oldest ridge, and the boy loses the count twice among stones fallen and half-sunk in the turf. Dùghall tells him it is no bad thing to meet a count a man cannot finish, if the count is an honest one.⁴⁰
- 1 **AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 352** — *Dùghall trades for less on his last shore* (Dùn ìseal). Dùghall trades what hides he carried for less than the same weight once brought, and walks the three days home with his grandson bearing, unknowing, the whole weight of what the old man had carried down that road alone for two-and-sixty years.⁴¹
- 30 **AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 352** — *Dùghall dies on the hill* (Dùn ìseal). Dùghall Ceannaiche dies on the hill that winter, an old man by any hill reckoning, and it is his grandson who takes up the packs the next summer and walks south alone, counting the midden stones before he trades a single hide, as the old man had taught him.⁴²
- 3 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 389** — *The tally wall of Seann Warr* (Seann Warr). At the eastern Seann Warr the counting stones are built into a wall, each cut with its strokes, some three thousand strokes in all. The wall grows for many lifetimes.⁴³
- 3 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 389** — *The king rides east with Somhairle to Seann Warr* (Dùn ìseal). The king summons his son down from Na Glinn Àrda⁴⁴ and rides the coast road east to Seann Warr with a small company. Somhairle, three hundred and fifty-one years old and near two hundred years among Clann na Ceiste⁴⁵, sees the shore he has only ever heard recited.⁴⁶
- 3 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 389** — *Somhairle first sees Balla nan Stràc*⁴⁷ (Seann Warr). At the midden's edge of Seann Warr, Somhairle walks the whole length of the counting stones with his father and finds them built into a wall past any easy counting, the oldest courses run together into a single grey weight of strokes.⁴⁸

39. ← Follows from *Strokes on the midden stones*, 31 an t-Iuchar, GE 308.

40. ↓ Legacy *The counting of the dead begins*, 29 an Lùnastal, GE 348.

41. ← Follows from *Strokes on the midden stones*, 31 an t-Iuchar, GE 308.

42. ↓ Legacy *Strokes on the midden stones*, 31 an t-Iuchar, GE 308.

43. ⇌ At the same time *The king rides east with Somhairle to Seann Warr*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, GE 389; ⇌ At the same time *Somhairle first sees Balla nan Stràc*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, GE 389; ⇌ At the same time *The king's stillness at the wall*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, GE 389.

44. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

45. the Children of the Question

46. ⇌ At the same time *The tally wall of Seann Warr*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, GE 389.

- 3 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 389** — *The king's stillness at the wall* (Seann Warr). The king stands a long while at the oldest of the tally stones with his hand flat against it, and tells Somhairle only that the wall has stood longer than the bank at Dùn iséal, and perhaps longer than the grove. He says no more of it that day.⁴⁹
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 389** — *Somhairle sets Balla nan Stràc*⁵⁰ *in the Line* (Seann Warr). Somhairle adds his first telling of his own to Sloinneadh a' Chlachair⁵¹: the wall at Seann Warr, some three thousand strokes, grown over many lifetimes. It is the first fact he ever sets down unaided, and he keeps it carefully all his life.⁵²
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 428** — *The count at Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). The counting comes to Seann Tarr in the north-east. There the stones are cut with strokes in fives and set in the floor of a house, and the house is lived in over its own dead.⁵³
- 2 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 428** — *Somhairle finds the house over the dead at Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). Sent north on a grazing dispute, Somhairle walks down to Seann Tarr and finds a household living in a long low house whose floor is paved with dressed slabs cut with strokes in fives. He does not enter, and sets the custom down without asking after it.⁵⁴
- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 470** — *A carrier brings word the strokes run thick* (Seann Warr). A carrier of hides tells Somhairle at a ford, in passing, that the tally stones are cut thicker that year than any season he has known, and thicker at all three shores at once. Somhairle rides to Seann Warr and Seann Tarr within the month and finds it true.
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, GE 470** — *The bad years in the counts* (Seann Warr). The tally stones at Seann Warr, Seann Tarr and Seann Chwen thicken together: more strokes to each stone, more stones to each course. Death comes on three coasts at once. What it was the strokes do not tell.⁵⁵
- 6 AN GIBLEAN, GE 470** — *The king's one visit to the wall* (Seann Warr). The king rides to Seann Warr with a small company and walks Balla nan Stràc⁵⁶ alone, his hand against the newest stone for the better part of a morning. Asked by his son what he saw, he answers only, "A people counting," and speaks of it to no one again.⁵⁷

47. the Old Ones' wall of counting stones at Seann Warr

48. ⇌ At the same time *The tally wall of Seann Warr*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, GE 389.

49. ⇌ At the same time *The tally wall of Seann Warr*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, GE 389.

50. the Old Ones' wall of counting stones at Seann Warr

51. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

52. ← Follows from *The tally wall of Seann Warr*, 3 an t-Ògmhios, GE 389.

53. ⇌ At the same time *Somhairle finds the house over the dead at Seann Tarr*, 2 an t-Iuchar, GE 428.

54. ⇌ At the same time *The count at Seann Tarr*, 2 an t-Iuchar, GE 428.

55. → Caused by *A carrier brings word the strokes run thick*, 9 am Faoilleach, GE 470; ⇌ At the same time *The king's one visit to the wall*, 6 an Giblean, GE 470.

56. the Old Ones' wall of counting stones at Seann Warr

57. ⇌ At the same time *The bad years in the counts*, 6 an Giblean, GE 470.

I AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 470 — *Sombairle sets the thickening in the Line* (Seann Warr). Sombairle records the king's visit to the wall in the fewest words the Line will bear: that the king stood long before it and, asked what he saw, said only that he had seen a people counting. He adds no explanation of his own.⁵⁸

58. ← Follows from *The bad years in the counts*, 6 an Giblean, GE 470.

THE YEARS GE 501 – 750

- 5 AN CÈITEAN, GE 510** — *The half-cut stone of Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). At the Seann Chwen near Cuan dhearg the last tally stone is left half-cut: two strokes finished, a third begun and forsaken. The chisel marks stop in mid-groove.
- 29 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 512** — *Somhairle finds Clach nan Dà Stràc¹ at Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). Word of an unfinished stone reaches Na Glinn Àrda², and Somhairle rides two days south to Seann Chwen, quieter than either shore he knew. He finds the newest tally stone left with two strokes finished and a third abandoned mid-groove, the chisel marks stopped clean.³
- 27 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 530** — *The last smoke seen at Seann Tarr* (Seann Tarr). The carrier who first brought word of the thickening finds Seann Tarr's house over the dead standing open and cold, its hearth unlit, the household gone without any sign of where. Somhairle rides down the following spring and finds the whole shore silent.
- 7 AN GEARRAN, GE 551** — *The Seann-Dhaoine⁴ fall silent*. After the half-cut stone no work of the Seann-Dhaoine can be dated. Their middens stop growing, their harbours silt, and their script is cut no more. How they ended no telling knows.⁵
- 7 AN GEARRAN, GE 551** — *Somhairle rides the three shores in one circuit* (Seann Warr). In a single season, the first any reciter has made the round, Somhairle rides from Seann Warr to Seann Tarr and down to Seann Chwen and finds all three the same: middens grown over, boats rotted on their keels, turf houses softening back into the ground.⁶
- 25 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 551** — *Somhairle sets down the Silence* (Dùn Ìseal). Somhairle enters the shortest of his four tellings in the Line: that after Clach nan Dà Stràc⁷ no work of the Seann-Dhaoine⁸ can be dated, their middens stop growing, their harbours silt, and how they ended, the telling does not know.⁹
- 4 AN GIBLEAN, GE 560** — *The hill-folk find the coasts wholly empty* (Seann Warr). By this year no hill trader who once walked the three shores still finds a fire lit on any of them. The households who might have answered a knock are themselves gone, and carriers give the roads over to shores that no longer answer.¹⁰

1. the last tally stone of Seann Chwen, left half-cut

2. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

3. ⇌ At the same time *The half-cut stone of Seann Chwen*, 5 an Cèitean, GE 510.

4. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

5. → Caused by *The last smoke seen at Seann Tarr*, 27 an Lùnastal, GE 530; ⇌ At the same time *Somhairle rides the three shores in one circuit*, 7 an Gearran, GE 551.

6. ⇌ At the same time *The Seann-Dhaoine fall silent*, 7 an Gearran, GE 551.

7. the last tally stone of Seann Chwen, left half-cut

8. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

9. ← Follows from *The Seann-Dhaoine fall silent*, 7 an Gearran, GE 551.

- 3 AN CÈITEAN, GE 580** — *Somhairle weds Cairistiona* (Dùn ìseal). Somhairle marries Cairistiona of Na Glinn Àrda¹¹, a shepherding household's daughter of no house of Clann na Ceiste¹², before both their fires at the turn of the year. He sets nothing of the wedding itself in the Line, judging it a thing that belongs to the man and not to the telling.¹³
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 591** — *Word of Beathan's birth reaches the river households* (Dùn ìseal). News that Somhairle and Cairistiona have a son, Beathan, and that the boy will be kept among Clann na Ceiste¹⁴ in the high pastures rather than brought to the hill, travels down every settled valley by the ordinary traffic of drovers and salt-carriers. It reaches Iain mac Fhearchair's household on the Abhainn naomh the same week as the shearing.
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 591** — *The hill-folk of the upper Abhainn naomh first say Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Iain mac Fhearchair's generation on the river inherits, without ever deciding it as a household, the custom of naming the Seann-Dhaoine¹⁵'s old places with the plain word for old set before them. Seann Dunn, Seann Chwen and Seann Skell pass into ordinary speech as though no other names had ever been possible.
- 8 AM MÀRT, GE 591** — *The old names kept* (Seann Skell). The hill-folk keep the names of the Seann-Dhaoine¹⁶ places and set before them only their own word for 'old': Seann Dunn, Seann Chwen, Seann Skell and the rest. They turn nothing into their own tongue, and the roots of those names are not understood.¹⁷
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, GE 595** — *Iain forbids his household the tower before any of them have seen it* (Seann Skell). Iain mac Fhearchair, recalling a single visit to the coast as a young man, tells his daughter Marsaili and the rest of his household that no good comes of taking up what the Seann-Dhaoine¹⁸ left lying, and names the tower at the harbour's mouth as a thing never to be entered, years before the household has any plan of settling near it.¹⁹
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, GE 620** — *Three river households crowd one bend* (Dùn ìseal). Grazing on the middle Abhainn naomh, held by one household in Iain's father's day, now feeds three grown from it, and the quarrels over the bend grow more frequent than the grass allows for. Iain begins to speak of the empty coast as a way out of them.
- 15 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 627** — *Iain calls the household to the coast* (Dùn ìseal). On a dark-half evening Iain mac Fhearchair tells his household plainly that he means to move it to the empty harbour at Seann Skell before another winter turns, judging a shore with good landing and no claimant better than another forty years of quarrelling over the river bend.

10. ¶ Legacy *The Seann-Dhaoine fall silent*, 7 an Gearran, GE 551.

11. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

12. the Children of the Question

13. ¶ Legacy *Ailean Mòr, first of the Stone Kings*, 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1.

14. the Children of the Question

15. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

16. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

17. ⇌ At the same time *Word of Beathan's birth reaches the river households*, 3 am Faoilleach, GE 591; → Caused by *The hill-folk of the upper Abhainn naomh first say Seann Skell*, 26 am Faoilleach, GE 591.

18. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

19. → Leads to *The old names kept*, 8 am Màrt, GE 591.

- 11 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 628** — *The old landings taken up* (Seann Skell). Families of the hill-folk come down the Abhainn naomh and settle in the empty river harbour at Seann Skell, using the old mole and mending none of it. They are not known to have dwelt by the water before.²⁰
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 628** — *Eleven souls come down the Abhainn naomh* (Seann Skell). Iain mac Fhearchair's household, eleven souls with ox-carts and what beasts they can drive, follows the Abhainn naomh two days further than any of them has gone, and comes out above the tide to find the harbour at Seann Skell standing exactly as the traders had always described it: empty, the old mole running into the flood, the tower blind-walled by the water.²¹
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 628** — *Iain marks the ground and forbids the tower again* (Seann Skell). Before the household sleeps its first night at the harbour, Iain walks the ground himself and sets a line of stones marking where a house may be built and where it must not, keeping every wall a household's length from the nearest standing Seann-Dhaoine²² wall and the whole camp further still from the tower.²³
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 628** — *The household mends the mole with stone it did not take* (Seann Skell). The household repairs the landward stretch of the old mole with stone gathered fresh from the shore, never lifting a stone already laid by the Seann-Dhaoine²⁴, a distinction Iain draws carefully and his children keep after him without ever quite putting into words.²⁵
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 629** — *A winter storm breaks the seaward mole* (Seann Skell). In the first days of an Fhaoilleach a storm out of the west drives the tide higher up the shingle than any of the household remembers from their river years, and breaks the oldest, untouched stretch of the mole, scattering its stones along the shore.²⁶
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 629** — *Iain refuses to build with the broken stone* (Seann Skell). Two of Iain's sons-in-law argue that stone the sea itself has thrown down is no longer bound by the household's rule against taking up Seann-Dhaoine²⁷ work. Iain refuses them, holding that the storm's breaking gives the household no claim the storm did not also give, and the mole is mended instead with new-quarried stone.²⁸

20. → Caused by *Three river households crowd one bend*, 19 an Giblean, GE 620; → Caused by *Iain calls the household to the coast*, 15 an t-Iuchar, GE 627.

21. ↔ Answers *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

22. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

23. ← Follows from *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

24. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

25. ← Follows from *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

26. ← Follows from *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

27. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

28. ← Follows from *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 631** — *The mole stands whole again* (Seann Skell). After two summers of quarrying and hauling stone down from the higher ground, the mended mole stands sheltered end to end, and no household on that shore again seriously argues for lifting a Seann-Dhaoine²⁹ stone to lay it elsewhere.³⁰
- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 640** — *The first hill-folk boats put out from Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Tearlach mac Ghilleonain and two of Iain's grandsons build the first boats the harbour has held since it was last worked, small hide craft trusted for the first time to open tide, and Marsaili herself goes out in the first of them on a calm morning her father judges safe.³¹
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 640** — *Marsaili sees the mole's true shape from the water* (Seann Skell). Looking back at the harbour from beyond the mole's mended length, Marsaili understands for the first time that the household's hurried repairs had done little more than follow, stone for stone, a plan the Seann-Dhaoine³² had already laid according to the set of the tide, and tells her father so that evening.³³
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 640** — *Tormod born to Iain Dubh* (Dùn ìseal). A son is born to Iain Dubh at Dùn ìseal and named Tormod; he grows slowly, as the grove's grandchildren grow, and will stand at his father's cairn a young man of eighty-seven still holding nothing of his own.³⁴
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 649** — *Iain mac Fhearchair dies at the harbour* (Seann Skell). Iain mac Fhearchair, who led his household down from the river and set the rule against touching what the Seann-Dhaoine³⁵ left standing, dies at Seann Skell eleven years before the sea takes its first life among his people, and his daughter Marsaili holds the household in his place.³⁶
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 660** — *The sea takes its first life at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). A young man of Tearlach mac Ghilleonain's house drowns in a squall too sudden for any boat then on the shore to outrun. It falls to Marsaili, with no river custom and no Seann-Dhaoine³⁷ left to ask, to choose how a household newly of the sea should bury one the sea has taken.³⁸
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 660** — *Marsaili chooses the plain burial* (Seann Skell). Marsaili buries the drowned man on the rise above the shingle in the plain hill fashion of her mother's grave on the river, judging that a household too new to the shore has no business inventing rites for it, and wronging no one, living or dead, by the choice.³⁹

29. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

30. ¶ Legacy *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

31. ¶ Legacy *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

32. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

33. ← Answers *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

34. ← Follows from *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

35. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

36. ← Follows from *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

37. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

38. ← Follows from *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

39. ← Follows from *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 664** — *Word of the king's word reaches Marsaili third-hand* (Seann Skell). A household two harbours south tells and retells what little the king said of Seann Skell in passing, riding the coast road with three men: that he had heard the hill was settling an empty shore and thought it well, and would send no one to tell them how to hold it. Marsaili hears it thinned by retelling and asks for no more of it.⁴⁰
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 670** — *Seonag born on An Cnoc Ruadh*⁴¹ (Cathair dhearg). A daughter is born to the holder of An Cnoc Ruadh and named Seonag; she learns the tallies of the salt before she can reach the drying-platform, and will carry a pebble bag for them all her life.⁴²
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 671** — *Marsaili nic Iain dies at Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Marsaili, who led the household's boats before any other hand had proved the harbour safe and buried its first drowned man in the plain hill way, dies the first of her father's line to be laid within sight of the sea, on the same rise above the shingle as the young man who went before her.⁴³
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 672** — *Mòrag judges the empty salt trade a war in waiting* (Dùn ìseal). Mòrag Chruaidh hears the third salt-trader in a summer return empty-handed from the southern shore and judges aloud, in her father's hall, that a household with salt and no king and a household with a king and no salt cannot go on as they are, and resolves to go south herself rather than wait a season for word to reach Dòmhnall in the north.
- 6 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 672** — *Eleven spears go south by the drovers' track* (Baile ghorm). Mòrag takes eleven men south along the coast track the hill's own herders use to drive beasts to winter grazing, telling them on the road that the raid is to take salt and nothing more: no house burned, no beast lifted beyond a needed ox, no blood shed that the salt-folk do not themselves choose to shed defending it.
- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 672** — *Mòrag Chruaidh and the salt-flats raid* (Baile ghorm). Mòrag Chruaidh, the king's granddaughter and fifth of the Stone Kings, raids the salt-pans on the southern shore at Baile ghorm, which do not yet own the king, and carries off the salt. It is the first war in either list. Seven fall on the hill side, and the number is kept.⁴⁴
- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 672** — *Donnchadh Bàn falls at the shelters* (Baile ghorm). Donnchadh Bàn, Mòrag's father's oldest belted man, is the first of the seven to fall in the raid on the salt-scrapes at Baile ghorm, cut down at the mouth of the turf shelters as the salt-folk come down onto the shingle.⁴⁵

40. ⇄ At the same time *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

41. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

42. ← Follows from *Mòrag born to Dòmhnall Clachach*, 12 an Dùbhlachd, GE 290.

43. ↓ Legacy *The old landings taken up*, 11 an Dùbhlachd, GE 628.

44. → Caused by *Mòrag judges the empty salt trade a war in waiting*, 3 am Faoilleach, GE 672; → Caused by *Eleven spears go south by the drovers' track*, 6 am Faoilleach, GE 672; ← Leads to *Donnchadh Bàn falls at the shelters*, 9 am Faoilleach, GE 672; ← Leads to *Mòrag turns back once on the strand*, 9 am Faoilleach, GE 672.

- 9 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 672** — *Mòrag turns back once on the strand* (Baile ghorm). With the salt loaded and her people falling back up the strand, Mòrag turns once before full light to look at her seven dead among the stones, and resolves that their names will not be let go the way a lost beast or a broken tool is let go.⁴⁶
- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 672** — *The seven of the raid named at the hill* (Dùn ìseal). At the turn of the winter after the raid, on the night the hill keeps for its dead, Mòrag stands at her father's hearth and names all seven who fell at Baile ghorm aloud, in the order they fell, beginning the naming that the hill goes on keeping at the same fire every year after.⁴⁷
- 12 AN GEARRAN, GE 683** — *The salt-pans of Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). Shallow clay basins are made behind a shingle bar at Baile ghorm, the first salt-works of the island. From this time their salt is found in the hill settlements.
- 11 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 683** — *The salt-folk raise a bank behind the pans* (Baile ghorm). Within two summers of Mòrag's raid the folk of Baile ghorm raise a bank of shingle and turf behind the tide line and dig shallow clay-lined basins inside it, a means of making salt by sun and wind alone that needs no fire a raider can find burning in the dark.⁴⁸
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 685** — *Word of the bank reaches the reciters as an answer* (Dùn ìseal). Traders who carry the first news of the clay basins up the valley road to Dùn ìseal understand, and say to each other more freely than they say to Mòrag herself, that the bank behind the shingle was raised as much against the hill's spears as against the sea.⁴⁹
- 13 AM MÀRT, GE 694** — *Seonag of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Seonag nic Uisdein holds the Red Hill. The list sets her 'after her father', as it sets every holder of Uisdean Mòr's line, though she was born more than three hundred years after he died. It is told that she counted her people by pebbles in a bag, one to a household, and knew by the weight when a household was gone.⁵⁰
- 13 AM MÀRT, GE 694** — *The king hears the raid from Mòrag's own mouth* (Dùn ìseal). Riding down to Dùn ìseal with a small company, the king hears the whole of the salt raid from Mòrag herself and tells her plainly that the south is not yet his to forbid or to avenge, neither blaming nor praising what she has done.⁵¹

45. ← Follows from *Mòrag Chruaidh and the salt-flats raid*, 9 am Faoilleach, GE 672.

46. ← Follows from *Mòrag Chruaidh and the salt-flats raid*, 9 am Faoilleach, GE 672.

47. ↓ Legacy *Mòrag Chruaidh and the salt-flats raid*, 9 am Faoilleach, GE 672.

48. ← Follows from *The salt-pans of Baile ghorm*, 12 an Gearran, GE 683.

49. ↓ Legacy *The salt-pans of Baile ghorm*, 12 an Gearran, GE 683.

50. ⇌ At the same time *The king hears the raid from Mòrag's own mouth*, 13 am Màrt, GE 694; ⇌ At the same time *Mòrag rides west to An Cnoc Ruadh*, 13 am Màrt, GE 694; ○ Same place *Seonag weighs the pebble bag before the king*, 13 am Màrt, GE 694.

51. ⇌ At the same time *Seonag of the Red Hill*, 13 am Màrt, GE 694.

- 13 AM MÀRT, GE 694** — *Mòrag rides west to An Cnoc Ruadh*⁵² (Cathair dhearg). The king takes Mòrag with him on the long ride west to An Cnoc Ruadh, saying little of his purpose, so that she comes to the lake shore not knowing why she has been brought, only that she has been brought to see something.⁵³
- 13 AM MÀRT, GE 694** — *Seonag weighs the pebble bag before the king* (Cathair dhearg). Seonag nic Uisdein meets the king at her own gate and weighs the worn bag that holds one pebble for every household of An Cnoc Ruadh⁵⁴'s shore, and the king weighs it after her and says he is content, the whole business settled without a word of tribute asked or given.⁵⁵
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 694** — *Mòrag rides home weighing a different holding* (Dùn ìseal). On the road back east Mòrag turns Seonag's pebble bag over in her mind against her own eleven spears and seven dead, and never again raises a raid, though she never tells anyone plainly that the pebble bag is the reason.⁵⁶
- 11 AN GIBLEAN, GE 705** — *The first pots at Doire shean* (Doire shean). Pots of coiled clay, fired in open bonfires, are first made at Doire shean on the south-west coast. Within a few lifetimes the whole southern shore uses them.
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, GE 705** — *Two of the first pots reach Dùn ìseal* (Doire shean). A trader carries word of the new coiled clay pots fired at Doire shean up to Dùn ìseal, glad for once to be carrying news rather than salt, and Mòrag has two of the first pots set on her own hearth, where they outlast her holding of the hill.⁵⁷
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, GE 716** — *The dug-out at Cidhe Beag* (Cidhe Beag). A boat hollowed from a single oak trunk, long enough for six, is sunk and left at the landing on Abhainn uaine now called Cidhe Beag. No older boat on Dia-thìr is known in its whole shape.
- 20 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 716** — *Word of the dug-out at Cidhe Beag reaches the hill*. Word of the oak dug-out sunk and left at the landing at Cidhe Beag, the first boat of its kind hollowed whole rather than built plank by plank, reaches Mòrag by the same slow road that carries most new things to whoever holds Dùn ìseal, though she never sees the boat itself.⁵⁸
- 1 AN GEARRAN, GE 719** — *Iain Dubh takes the hill from Mòrag's hand* (Dùn ìseal). Mòrag gives up Dùn ìseal to Iain Dubh, a son of the king older than she is by every reckoning but younger to look at, judging that a holder is ill served by staying past the age when she still has something to learn from the holding.

52. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

53. ⇌ At the same time *Seonag of the Red Hill*, 13 am Màrt, GE 694.

54. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

55. ○ Same place *Seonag of the Red Hill*, 13 am Màrt, GE 694.

56. ¶ Legacy *Seonag of the Red Hill*, 13 am Màrt, GE 694.

57. ¶ Legacy *The first pots at Doire shean*, 11 an Giblean, GE 705.

58. ¶ Legacy *The dug-out at Cidhe Beag*, 10 an Cèitean, GE 716.

- 2 AM MÀRT, GE 719** — *Iain Dubh asks Mòrag how she did it* (Dùn ìseal). At the gate on the day he takes the hill, Iain Dubh asks Mòrag the one question no one else in the household has put to her directly, how she went south with eleven spears against a whole shore and came home with only seven lost, and she answers him as plainly as she is able.
- 31 AM MÀRT, GE 721** — *Màiri bears the seven names of Mòrag's raid* (Baile ghorm). As a child at Baile ghorm, Màiri nan Làn learns the seven names kept from Mòrag Chruaidh's raid on the salt-pans a generation before, said slowly at the fire the way a thing is said that must not be said carelessly, and takes the telling for a settled account, its ending already closed.⁵⁹
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 727** — *Iain Dubh killed* (Baile ghorm). Iain Dubh, a son of the king and sixth of the Stone Kings, goes down to raid the salt-pans as Mòrag Chruaidh had done, and is slain on the shingle at Baile ghorm. He is the first of Ailean's children to die by a spear. The list says only that he was brought home.⁶⁰
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 727** — *Iain Dubh comes down to the salt-pans at dawn* (Baile ghorm). Iain Dubh, sixth of Rìghrean na Cloiche⁶¹ and eight years holder of the hill, rides south to Tràigh an t-Salainn⁶² as Mòrag Chruaidh had once done, and comes on the pans at Baile ghorm in the grey hour before full light, with more spears behind him than the shore's low bank was ever built to answer.⁶³
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 727** — *Tadhg Garbh's spear kills Iain Dubh* (Baile ghorm). In the fighting at the bank's gap, Tadhg Garbh of Baile ghorm throws a spear among a scatter of others thrown at the same moment, and it alone finds its mark, taking Iain Dubh through the throat before he closes half the distance to the pans. He is the first of Ailean Mòr's children to die by a spear.⁶⁴
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 727** — *The hill men carry Iain Dubh home* (Baile ghorm). The hill spears draw back from the bank around their fallen lord rather than press on for the salt, and carry him north at a pace no one on the shore is willing to call a retreat, though it can honestly be called little else.⁶⁵
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 727** — *Baile ghorm learns whose son fell on its clay* (Baile ghorm). Days after the fighting, traders carrying word south tell the salt-folk that the man who fell on the pan's clay was Iain Dubh, holder of the hill and Ailean Mòr's own son, and that no man of the blood has ever before died by a spear.⁶⁶

59. ¶ Legacy Mòrag Chruaidh and the salt-flats raid, 9 am Faoilleach, GE 672.

60. → Caused by *Iain Dubh takes the hill from Mòrag's hand*, 1 an Gearran, GE 719; → Caused by *Iain Dubh asks Mòrag how she did it*, 2 am Màrt, GE 719; ← Leads to *Iain Dubh comes down to the salt-pans at dawn*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727; ⇌ At the same time *Tadhg Garbh's spear kills Iain Dubh*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727; ← Leads to *The hill men carry Iain Dubh home*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727; ⇌ At the same time *Baile ghorm learns whose son fell on its clay*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727.

61. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

62. the salt shore

63. ← Follows from *Iain Dubh killed*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727.

64. ⇌ At the same time *Iain Dubh killed*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727.

65. ← Follows from *Iain Dubh killed*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727.

- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 727** — *Iain Dubh's cairn raised on the hill* (Cathair dhearg). Tormod, Iain Dubh's eldest living son, stands the whole of the cairn's raising without being seen to weep, a young man of eighty-seven still holding nothing in his own right, while the king is away in the north settling a quarrel of grazing.⁶⁷
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 727** — *The king comes home to a cairn already raised* (Cathair dhearg). Ailean Mòr returns from the north to find his son already under the cairn, and stands by it three days speaking to no one, neither Tormod nor the reciters who stand ready to add his words to the list.⁶⁸
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 727** — *The king walks south alone* (Cathair dhearg). On the fourth day the king leaves the hill on foot, alone, taking no household and no spears, and walks the old track through the dunes toward Tràigh an t-Salainn⁶⁹, so that it is some while before anyone understands where he is bound.
- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 728** — *The king at Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). Ailean Mòr comes down alone to the shingle at Baile ghorm where his son was slain. The salt-folk come out against him with spears, and none strikes. They bring him the salt of the pans, and the southern shore is his. No blood is shed there, and none is paid.⁷⁰
- 14 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 728** — *The salt-folk raise spears against him* (Baile ghorm). Màiri, first to see the man alone on the shingle, screams for the men before she can put a name to what she sees. Thirty and more come running with the same spears that killed Iain Dubh, and make a line across the shore between the king and the pans.⁷¹
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 728** — *Tadhg Garbh lowers his spear a second time* (Baile ghorm). Tadhg Garbh raises his spear to his shoulder as the king closes the line, holds it until his arm shakes, then lowers it and looks at it in his own hand as though someone else had given it to him.⁷²
- 7 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 728** — *Mòr gives the double handful of salt* (Baile ghorm). Old Mòr of the salt-folk kneels on the shingle and holds up a double handful of wet salt from the nearest pan. The king takes it, eats a little, and closes her fingers back over the rest before he lets go and walks away north the way he came.⁷³
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 728** — *Tràigh an t-Salainn⁷⁴ called the king's* (Baile ghorm). By evening word runs the length of the shore that the salt is the king's, though none can afterward say who first put it in those words. No blood is shed that day, the first time in two raids Baile ghorm's dead need no new name kept.⁷⁵

66. ⇄ At the same time *Iain Dubh killed*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727.

67. ← Follows from *Iain Dubh killed*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727.

68. ← Follows from *Iain Dubh killed*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727.

69. the salt shore

70. → Caused by *The king walks south alone*, 16 an Dùbhlachd, GE 727.

71. ← Follows from *The king at Baile ghorm*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 728.

72. ← Follows from *The king at Baile ghorm*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 728.

73. ⇄ Answers *The king at Baile ghorm*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 728.

74. the salt shore

- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 728** — *The salt-folk raise their own cairn for Iain Dubh* (Baile ghorm). The salt-folk of Baile ghorm build a small cairn of their own on the rise above the pans, working in seven stones for the seven of Mòrag Chruaidh's raid though none of the seven died in this second fight, having come to think of both raids as one account.⁷⁶
- 20 AM MÀRT, GE 729** — *Tormod comes to the shore and absolves Tadhg Garbh* (Baile ghorm). Tormod rides south with four men to stand at the new cairn and see the pan where his father fell, asks Tadhg Garbh's name without anyone softening the telling, and says a man defending his own pans with his own hand owes no account for it.⁷⁷
- 18 AN GIBLEAN, GE 729** — *Tadhg Garbh rows out and does not return* (Baile ghorm). Tadhg Garbh takes a hide boat out alone before first light one spring morning and does not come back with the tide or any tide after. No storm is remembered that night, and no wreckage of the boat is ever found.⁷⁸
- 26 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 741** — *Seonag of An Cnoc Ruadh⁷⁹ dies* (Cathair dhearg). Seonag nic Uisdein, who met Mòrag Chruaidh with a bag of pebbles and not with spears, dies on An Cnoc Ruadh in her seventy-second year; the salt tallies she kept go to her heir whole and without a stone out of place.⁸⁰

75. ← Follows from *The king at Baile ghorm*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 728.

76. ¶ Legacy *Iain Dubh killed*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727.

77. ← Follows from *Iain Dubh killed*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727.

78. ¶ Legacy *Iain Dubh killed*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 727.

79. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

80. ← Follows from *Seonag of the Red Hill*, 13 am Màrt, GE 694.

THE YEARS GE 751 – 1,000

- 27 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 760** — *Raghnall born to Fearchar Bacach* (Dùn ìseal). A son is born to Fearchar Bacach at Dùn ìseal, fair-headed from his first day, and is called Ceannfhionn before he is called anything else; he grows up with the hill's wool about him and no salt to cure its mutton.¹
- 2 AM MÀRT, GE 777** — *The sea drowns the low houses of Cnoc chaol*. In the night the sea rises past every mark it has kept on the coast at Cnoc chaol and comes in over the low houses, taking twelve of the shore's dead and leaving a sheet of grey sand a hand thick over every hearth it does not carry away, threaded with the shells of deep-water creatures no net there has ever brought up.
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 777** — *The wave at Cnoc chaol* (Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol²). The sea comes far inland over a village on the site of Cnoc chaol and leaves a sheet of sand a hand thick upon its hearths, with the shells of deep-water creatures in it. The village is not rebuilt on the same ground.³
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 777** — *Seasaidh's father is counted among the drowned*. Seasaidh, carried up the slope at seven years old by her mother, learns in the grey hour after the wave that her father is not among those who reached higher ground, one of twelve of Cnoc chaol's dead counted when the counting is done.⁴
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 777** — *The old ground at Cnoc chaol is left unbuilt*. The old folk of Cnoc chaol sift the sanded ruin for what is worth digging out and find little; no household chooses to rebuild on the drowned ground, level and good as it is, and it is left to grass over.⁵
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 778** — *The survivors of Cnoc chaol build on the slope*. The households of Cnoc chaol carry what can be carried up the slope behind the drowned ground and build again there in stone rather than turf and wattle, keeping the old name of the coast for the new houses and pointing out the low ground to their children as ground not to be built on.⁶
- 15 AN GEARRAN, GE 792** — *Seasaidh goes inland to Pàl's valley*. Seasaidh, twenty-two years old, leaves the coast that raised her to take up a household two days inland with Pàl, a drover's son, in a green valley walled by low scarps that she has never seen and cannot yet well imagine, having known until then only tide and shingle.⁷

1. ← Follows from *The king at Baile gborn*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 728.

2. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

3. → Caused by *The sea drowns the low houses of Cnoc chaol*, 2 am Màrt, GE 777.

4. ← Follows from *The wave at Cnoc chaol*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 777.

5. ← Follows from *The wave at Cnoc chaol*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 777.

6. ¶ Legacy *The wave at Cnoc chaol*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 777.

7. ← Follows from *The survivors of Cnoc chaol build on the slope*, 23 an t-Sultain, GE 778.

30 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 827 — *The ground opens below Pàl's byre* (Gleann na Scoltaidh⁸).

In the night a low groaning felt through the floor of the house opens a crack clean across the floor of the valley a little below the household's byre, wide enough in places for a man to lose his boot to the dark below, running further than any of the valley folk cares to walk to find its end.

5 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 827 — *The ground opens at Cill gblas* (Scàineadh Cill gblas⁹). A crack a man could fall into opens across the valley at Cill gblas, and a spring moves a hundred paces downhill. The hill-folk bank the crack with stones and build on neither side of it.¹⁰

5 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 827 — *The valley's spring moves to a new channel* (Gleann na Scoltaidh¹¹). The spring that has risen at the valley's upper end for as long as the household remembers runs dry by inches through the season after the ground opens and breaks out afresh a hundred paces downhill, in a hollow none of the valley folk had marked before as ground a spring might choose.¹²

28 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 827 — *The valley folk keep clear of the crack by instinct* (Gleann na Scoltaidh¹³). No house stands near enough the new crack to be lost to it, and the valley folk, without any rule laid down to tell them so, drive their beasts wide of it and warn their children from it from the first season, a wariness settling over ground that had never before asked for one.¹⁴

4 AM MÀRT, GE 828 — *Word of the opened ground reaches the hill* (Gleann na Scoltaidh¹⁵). A drover's telling of the crack, carried without any deliberate sending along the ordinary roads of trade and overheard at a hearth by a man travelling to the hill on other business, comes at last to the king by the same slow accident that carries most word to him.¹⁶

2 AN GIBLEAN, GE 830 — *The king walks the length of the crack* (Gleann na Scoltaidh¹⁷). The king comes on foot with two men to Pàl's valley and walks the crack's whole length with the household, crouching twice to look down into it though he lets nothing down to measure its depth, and asks whether any beast or soul has gone into it since it opened.¹⁸

8. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

9. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill gblas'

10. → Caused by *The ground opens below Pàl's byre*, 30 am Faoilleach, GE 827; ⇔ At the same time *The valley's spring moves to a new channel*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 827.

11. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

12. ⇔ At the same time *The ground opens at Cill gblas*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 827.

13. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

14. ← Follows from *The ground opens at Cill gblas*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 827.

15. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

16. ← Follows from *The ground opens at Cill gblas*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 827.

17. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

18. ← Follows from *The ground opens at Cill gblas*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 827.

- 1 AN CÈITEAN, GE 830** — *The king forbids nothing at the crack* (Gleann na Scoltaidh¹⁹). Standing at the widest part of the opened ground, the king tells the valley folk he will neither have the crack filled nor leave it, only that they keep their beasts and children back from it and build no house nearer it than they would to a drop of a man's own cutting.²⁰
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 847** — *Seasaidh begins the line of white stones* (Gleann na Scoltaidh²¹). In her seventy-eighth year Seasaidh carries the first white stones up from the stream bed herself and sets them a stride back from the crack's edge, choosing them for their whiteness so a child running in poor light may see the line and know where the safe ground ends.
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 847** — *The fault-line kept clear* (Cill ghlas). A line of white stones is laid along the old crack at Cill ghlas, and for the rest of the age no house is built within a stone's throw of it. Part of the line remains.²²
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 847** — *The valley finishes the line of stones* (Gleann na Scoltaidh²³). Seasaidh's children and grandchildren take up the carrying before she has finished the first stretch, and households from both ends of the settled ground add their own stones until the white line runs the crack's full length.²⁴
- 3 AN GEARRAN, GE 852** — *Seasaidh dies above the valley she marked* (Gleann na Scoltaidh²⁵). Seasaidh dies in her eighty-second year in the house Pàl first brought her to, and is buried on the near slope within sight, though not within a stone's throw, of the white line she began; the valley keeps her name chiefly as the woman who marked the crack.²⁶
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 860** — *No house is raised within a stone's throw of the crack* (Gleann na Scoltaidh²⁷). The valley folk who come after Seasaidh mend the white line where frost or flood undoes a stretch of it and never let it go wholly back to grass, and for the rest of the age no household raises a roof within a stone's throw of the opened ground on either side of it.²⁸
- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 902** — *The unlit hearth*. In a single dwelling a hearth is laid and never lit. Peat keeps it by chance. It is the eldest sign that someone here chose not to burn what could easily have been burned.

19. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

20. ¶ Legacy *The ground opens at Cill ghlas*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 827.

21. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

22. → Caused by *Seasaidh begins the line of white stones*, 22 am Faoilleach, GE 847.

23. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

24. ← Follows from *The fault-line kept clear*, 3 an t-Sultain, GE 847.

25. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

26. ¶ Legacy *The fault-line kept clear*, 3 an t-Sultain, GE 847.

27. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

28. ¶ Legacy *The fault-line kept clear*, 3 an t-Sultain, GE 847.

- 19 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 902** — *A cleared strip at Achadh dhìreach turns up an unlit hearth* (Achadh dhìreach). Three brothers new to the ground at Achadh dhìreach turn up, clearing a strip for barley, a long-buried hearth laid true and never lit, its wood cut for a first flame and a sliver of an gual dathach²⁹ set unburned beside it; they leave it as they found it and build their own hearth a stone's throw off.³⁰
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 956** — *Peat over the unlit hearth*. The house of the unlit hearth lies under three yards of peat, its hearth laid with dry wood and a slip of the coloured coal beside it, none of it burned. Whoever laid it went away and did not come back to light it.³¹
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 956** — *The unlit hearth passes out of living memory* (Achadh dhìreach). By the fifty-fourth year after its turning-up the buried hearth at Achadh dhìreach lies three yards under a valley floor's slow rise, and only the oldest households still trouble to show a child the exact ground to leave unbroken, no longer able to say why, only that it has always been so kept.³²
- 19 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,000** — *Anna nic Coinnich is born at Achadh dhìreach* (Achadh dhìreach). Anna nic Coinnich is born the youngest of four into a household two fields from the valley's old buried hearth, and grows up measuring an gual dathach³³ by her own cupped hand as a plain fact of the valley, no different to her than the shape of the hills.³⁴

29. the coloured coal

30. ← Follows from *The unlit hearth*, 2 an Dàmhair, GE 902.

31. → Caused by *A cleared strip at Achadh dhìreach turns up an unlit hearth*, 19 an Dàmhair, GE 902.

32. ¶ Legacy *Peat over the unlit hearth*, 31 an Dàmhair, GE 956.

33. the coloured coal

34. ← Follows from *The unlit hearth passes out of living memory*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, GE 956.

THE YEARS GE 1,001 – 1,250

- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,011** — *The measured handful* (Àth gharbh). In all the hill settlements a custom takes hold that no fire shall have more of the coloured coal than one cupped hand can hold. It is nowhere written and everywhere kept. From it the Small-Burning Law of the Holy Age is made.
- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 1,011** — *The measured handful reaches every hearth of Na Glinn Àrda*¹ (Àth gharbh). The custom of the full hand, kept first by a few households at a drovers' ford after a sick child was warmed too generously, spreads within a few years to every hearth of Na Glinn Àrda, nowhere written and nowhere proclaimed, so that a stranger travelling the road finds the same measure kept from one end of it to the other.²
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 1,019** — *Anna nic Coinnich marries Aonghas of the next valley* (Achadh dhìreach). Anna nic Coinnich, nineteen years old, marries Aonghas, a byeward of the next valley, and keeps her own hearth within sight of the old buried one at Achadh dhìreach for the rest of her life.³
- 24 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,030** — *Anna nic Coinnich buries a son* (Achadh dhìreach). Anna nic Coinnich, thirty years old, buries a son of six years taken by a winter fever, one of the ordinary griefs of a valley the tellers otherwise remember for little beyond its dry summers and its settled quarrels.⁴
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,066** — *The basket burning at Achadh dhìreach* (Achadh dhìreach). A household at Achadh dhìreach burns a whole basket of the coloured coal at once, knowing nothing of what it holds. The house burns down with three within, and the hearth-stone is found cracked through and running with colour. Ever after the tellings use it to show why the handful is kept.⁵
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,066** — *Eanraig Ruadh burns a whole basket of an gual dathach*⁶ (Achadh dhìreach). Eanraig Ruadh of Achadh dhìreach, old and feeling the winter's frost in his bones, sets very nearly a whole basket of an gual dathach on his fire in a single night rather than measure it by the full hand, having come, by his own account given beforehand, to doubt the measure applied to a man his age.⁷

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

2. ← Follows from *The measured handful*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 1,011.

3. ← Follows from *The measured handful reaches every hearth of Na Glinn Àrda*, 4 an t-Sultain, GE 1,011.

4. ← Follows from *Anna nic Coinnich marries Aonghas of the next valley*, 26 am Faoilleach, GE 1,019.

5. ⇌ At the same time *Eanraig Ruadh burns a whole basket of an gual dathach*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,066; ← Leads to *The house of Eanraig Ruadh burns with three within*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,066.

6. the coloured coal

7. ⇌ At the same time *The basket burning at Achadh dhìreach*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,066.

- 7 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,066** — *The house of Eanraig Ruadh burns with three within* (Achadh dhìreach). The house of Eanraig Ruadh at Achadh dhìreach goes up whole in the night in a flame shot through with a colour none of the valley folk have a word for, and burns to its stones before morning with Eanraig, his wife Beathag and a grandchild of six years named Ualan within it.⁸
- 21 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,066** — *The hearthstone of Achadh dhìreach cracks and runs with colour* (Achadh dhìreach). When the ash of Eanraig Ruadh's house is cool enough for hands to search it, the hearthstone at its heart is found split clean through, a finger's width of colour seeping slowly along the crack a full day after the fire itself has gone entirely cold.⁹
- 27 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,066** — *The king lays his hand on the cracked hearthstone* (Achadh dhìreach). The king comes down to Achadh dhìreach within two days of the fire and kneels alone over the split hearthstone, laying his open hand across the running crack until the colour fades from it by degrees and the stone is left grey and dead as any ordinary hearth-stone.
10
- 23 **AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 1,066** — *The king names the full hand a good custom* (Achadh dhìreach). Standing before the valley folk of Achadh dhìreach, the king names the full hand a good custom and bids them keep it for their own sakes, saying plainly that he will make no law of it, having made none of any custom before.¹¹
- 24 **AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 1,066** — *The king sends grain to Achadh dhìreach* (Achadh dhìreach). The king sends two men back to Achadh dhìreach with grain enough to carry the valley's poorer households through a winter shortened by the loss of Eanraig Ruadh's stored barley along with the rest of his house.¹²
- 10 **AM MÀRT, GE 1,067** — *The greyed hearthstone is kept for a new house* (Achadh dhìreach). Eanraig Ruadh's eldest living son raises a new house a little to one side of the burnt footings at Achadh dhìreach and sets the greyed, still-cracked hearthstone as its own hearth rather than break it up or leave it, judging a stone the king himself had greyed the safest hearth the valley was likely to keep.¹³
- 9 **AN GEARRAN, GE 1,070** — *Anna nic Coinnich teaches her grandchildren the full hand* (Achadh dhìreach). Anna nic Coinnich, keeping in her old age the kind of hearth other households' children are sent to, answers her grandchildren's asking why the measure matters by cupping one hand open before them and saying the words her own mother said before her: làn na glaise, 's gun tuilleadh, a full hand and no more.¹⁴

8. ← Follows from *The basket burning at Achadh dhìreach*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,066.

9. ← Follows from *The basket burning at Achadh dhìreach*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,066.

10. ↓ Legacy *The basket burning at Achadh dhìreach*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,066.

11. ↓ Legacy *The basket burning at Achadh dhìreach*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,066.

12. ← Follows from *The king names the full hand a good custom*, 23 an t-Samhain, GE 1,066.

13. ↓ Legacy *The basket burning at Achadh dhìreach*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,066.

14. ↓ Legacy *The measured handful*, 5 an Lùnastal, GE 1,011.

- 11 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 1,071** — *The ground cracks below the slab at Tobar dhìreach* (Tobar dhìreach). A wet spring brings down more of the hillside above Tobar dhìreach than any spring before it, and a crack no wider than two fingers opens in the turf below the old stained slab, running toward the burn before losing itself in ground that has not moved.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1,071** — *White stones laid along the new crack* (Tobar dhìreach). The households of Na Glinn Àrda¹⁵ set a line of white stones along the crack below the slab's stain, as the coast has done at the crack Seasaidh's people watch, and build no byre against the ground it crosses.
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,120** — *The watchers of the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). Families near the crack take turns to sit by the slab laid over it, a household at a time, through the dark half of the year. What they watch for, none ever says.¹⁶
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,120** — *The households agree to sit the slab in turn* (Tobar dhìreach). At the Samhain gathering the households nearest Tobar dhìreach agree, with no one arguing hard enough against it to be worth outlasting, that a household will sit by the slab from dusk to dusk, turn and turn again, through the dark half of every year from that Samhain on.¹⁷
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 1,121** — *Beathan first sits by the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). Beathan mac Shomhairle, already some five hundred years old and looking a man of thirty, sits among the first six households to keep the new watch, wrapped in the same plaid and eating the same bannock as any herding household of Na Glinn Àrda¹⁸.¹⁹
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,121** — *Gilleonan and Ìde keep their first turn* (Tobar dhìreach). A newly married herding couple of the shoulder of the hill above the burn, Gilleonan and Ìde, keep their household's first turn at the slab the same winter the watch is agreed, and come to be spoken of, for the decades after, in the same breath as Beathan's own turn.²⁰
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,130** — *Wolves come down close to the slab watch* (Tobar dhìreach). A hard winter drives wolves nearer the fires of Na Glinn Àrda²¹ than living memory holds, and Beathan sits two of Gilleonan's household's nights himself, spear in hand, so that Gilleonan's young children need not lose a father to the season's watch.²²

15. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

16. → Caused by *The ground cracks below the slab at Tobar dhìreach*, 11 am Faoilleach, GE 1,071; → Caused by *White stones laid along the new crack*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 1,071; ← Leads to *The households agree to sit the slab in turn*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120.

17. ← Follows from *The watchers of the slab*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120.

18. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

19. ← Follows from *The watchers of the slab*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120.

20. ← Follows from *The watchers of the slab*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120.

21. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

22. ← Follows from *The watchers of the slab*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120.

- 13 AN GIBLEAN, GE 1,135** — *A light disputed along the crack* (Tobar dhìreach). Six watchers on duty by the slab give six differing accounts of a light seen, or not seen, along the white stones one frost-misted night, and Somhairle, questioning each apart from the others, sets down no conclusion beyond the plain disagreement.²³
- 12 AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,140** — *Somhairle gives Beathan Sloinneadh a' Chlachair*²⁴ *whole* (Tobar dhìreach). In the same season his hair first silvers at the temple, Somhairle gives his son Beathan Sloinneadh a' Chlachair entire, twice through by the fire without a name out of place, so that the telling may be carried by more than one head.²⁵
- 14 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,159** — *Gilleonan asks Beathan what the watch is for* (Tobar dhìreach). Old and white-bearded, Gilleonan asks Beathan plainly, after forty years of sitting the slab beside him, what the households have been watching for; Beathan answers that he does not know, and never has.²⁶
- 15 AM MÀRT, GE 1,160** — *The king sits a night at the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). The king rides up into Na Glinn Àrda²⁷ alone, unasked and unlooked-for, and sits a whole night among a household keeping its turn at the slab, watching the same grey stone and the same thin crack the valleys have watched for forty winters, and says nothing of why he came.²⁸
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,163** — *Gilleonan dies* (Tobar dhìreach). Gilleonan dies in the ordinary way at last, three winters after asking his one question of Beathan, who sits the last night of it beside his bed as he sat so many nights beside his watch-fire.²⁹
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 1,171** — *Ìde sits her last turn at the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). Carried up the hill by a grandson on a sledge when her own legs no longer make the climb, Ìde sits her last turn beside Beathan at the same fire she first sat beside as a bride fifty winters before.³⁰
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,174** — *The empty salt-kists at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Ragnall Ceannfhionn, opening the salt-kists his grandfather the king left him, finds three of six near empty and thinks for the first time in earnest of the salt running to waste in An Cnoc Ruadh³¹'s pans while his own hill wears wool it cannot use fast enough.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,174** — *The king declines to speak for either hill* (Dùn ìseal). Ragnall asks the king to settle salt with An Cnoc Ruadh³² on his behalf. The king answers that both hills are his and he will not do their talking, and leaves the settling to Ragnall to make or leave unmade.

23. ← Follows from *The watchers of the slab*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120.

24. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

25. ← Follows from *The watchers of the slab*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120.

26. ← Follows from *The watchers of the slab*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120.

27. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

28. ← Follows from *The watchers of the slab*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120.

29. ← Follows from *The watchers of the slab*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120.

30. ← Follows from *The watchers of the slab*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,120.

31. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

- 10 AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,175** — *Raghnall Ceannfhionn makes peace* (Fèill Muileann òg³³). Raghnall Ceannfhionn, seventh of the Stone Kings, meets the holder of the Red Hill at the ford where the fair of Muileann òg is held now, and they agree on salt for wool. Both hills are the king's, and neither is the other's. Both lists tell of the meeting, and in neither is the other named before it.³⁴
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,175** — *Raghnall rides west with nine companions* (Dùn ìseal). Raghnall takes nine men, no more, so the company will not be taken for a raid, and rides the five days' road to the ford, the first of the hill's blood to travel so near An Cnoc Ruadh³⁵'s country since Uisdean knelt to the king.³⁶
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1,179** — *Strangers first set out goods beside the wool and salt*. Traders with no part in either household begin bringing flint, dried fish and pots to the ford on the appointed days, setting their wares apart from the wool and salt. Neither hill turns them away, and no one afterward remembers deciding to let them stay.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,186** — *An Cnoc Ruadh³⁷ refuses a poor clip*. After a wet shearing season the wool comes down thin and unwashed, and An Cnoc Ruadh's people will not weigh full salt against it. Raghnall's son carries the refusal home; no word is sent to the king, and none is asked for.³⁸
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 1,187** — *The short year is made good without a law*. Raghnall sends a better clip the following spring with fleece besides to make up the short year, and neither hill presses harder than a fair measure again. The bargain holds on nothing written, only on each side's wish to be trusted the year after.
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 1,208** — *The ford gathering* (Fèill Muileann òg³⁹). The meeting at the ford becomes a yearly gathering. Salt, flint, wool, dried fish and pots change hands there, and marriages are made. No meeting-place on the island has been used longer without a break.⁴⁰
- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1,208** — *The first marriage of the ford*. A young man of the hill and a young woman of An Cnoc Ruadh⁴¹'s people, remarked on for three autumns' standing near each other at the weighing, are married on the trodden ground with both banks' households standing for it, the first marriage the meeting ever gave anyone.⁴²

32. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

33. the fair at Muileann òg

34. → Caused by *The empty salt-kists at Dùn ìseal*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,174; → Caused by *The king declines to speak for either hill*, 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,174.

35. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

36. ← Follows from *Raghnall Ceannfhionn makes peace*, 10 an Cèitean, GE 1,175.

37. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

38. ← Follows from *Raghnall Ceannfhionn makes peace*, 10 an Cèitean, GE 1,175.

39. the fair at Muileann òg

40. → Caused by *Strangers first set out goods beside the wool and salt*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, GE 1,179; → Caused by *The short year is made good without a law*, 5 an t-Sultain, GE 1,187.

41. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

42. ← Follows from *The ford gathering*, 29 an t-Samhain, GE 1,208.

2 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 1,215 — *Murchadh Gearr born* (Cathair dhearg). A son is born to a kinsman's household of An Cnoc Ruadh⁴³'s old line and named Murchadh; short in the leg from boyhood, he is Murchadh Gearr to the lake shore long before he holds anything there.

⁴⁴

10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,235 — *The unnamed holder of An Cnoc Ruadh⁴⁵ dies* (Cathair dhearg). An Cnoc Ruadh's holder who first waded to meet Ragnall in the water dies after sixty years and more keeping faith at the ford, and is followed by a son who does not hold long, and then by a grandson.⁴⁶

12 AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,240 — *Murchadh Gearr comes to An Cnoc Ruadh⁴⁷* (Cathair dhearg). Murchadh Gearr, a kinsman of the old holder's line, comes to An Cnoc Ruadh after a grandson's short holding, and is known from his first weighing at the ford as a man who would rather walk a road than ride it.

31 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,247 — *Murchadh Gearr of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Murchadh Gearr holds the Red Hill after Seonag and keeps the peace of the ford. It is told that he walked the salt road himself every year, to be seen upon it.⁴⁸

15 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1,247 — *Murchadh Gearr walks Rathad an t-Salainn⁴⁹ to be seen*. Murchadh Gearr walks the whole of Rathad an t-Salainn on his own feet in the weeks before every autumn meeting, stopping at every household on it, so that no child between Baile ghorm and the ford grows up without having seen An Cnoc Ruadh⁵⁰'s holder pass in the flesh.⁵¹

43. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

44. ← Follows from *The first marriage of the ford*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, GE 1,208.

45. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

46. ¶ Legacy *Ragnall Ceannfionn makes peace*, 10 an Cèitean, GE 1,175.

47. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

48. → Caused by *Murchadh Gearr comes to An Cnoc Ruadh*, 12 an Cèitean, GE 1,240.

49. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

50. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

51. ← Follows from *Murchadh Gearr of the Red Hill*, 31 an Dàmhair, GE 1,247.

THE YEARS GE 1,251 – 1,500

- 9 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,260** — *Children of both banks cease to be told apart.* By this year the children who run between the stalls at the ford on the appointed days make no distinction between the hill's side of the water and An Cnoc Ruadh¹'s, the meeting by then older than any living memory of its making.²
- 24 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,273** — *Raghnall's last morning at the ford.* In his hundredth year past the wading, Raghnall stands once more on the bank where he first crossed, looks on ground worn bare and hard by ninety-nine autumns of trade, and understands he will be gone from the ford long before the ford is done with anyone.³
- 2 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,274** — *Hill-folk on the western shore* (Ros bheag). Households from the hills settle the bay at Ros bheag, the first of their kind on the west coast. They build in the hill manner, round and turf-roofed, a little back from the beach, and fish from the shore and not from boats.⁴
- 2 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,274** — *Three households settle Bàgh an t-Seabhaig⁵* (Ros bheag). Three hill households too many for the grazing above Baile ghorm cross the spine of the island and settle a curve of grey sand under a gorse headland on the west coast, the first hill-folk household on that shore, building round and turf-roofed and fishing from the beach with lines and baskets rather than boats.⁶
- 2 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,275** — *Beathag walks the whole crossing and is the first buried by that tide* (Ros bheag). Beathag, eldest of the three households that cross to Bàgh an t-Seabhaig⁷, walks the nine days on her own feet in her old age and dies eleven years after seeing the water for the first time, the first of the hill-folk buried within sound of that particular shore.⁸
- 7 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,280** — *Murchadh Gearr dies* (Cathair dhearg). Murchadh Gearr, who walked Rathad an t-Salainn⁹ every autumn so that no child on it grew up without seeing An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁰'s holder, dies in his sixty-sixth year; the road's households, hearing of it, leave a handful of salt at their doors for a night.¹¹

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

2. ¶ Legacy *The ford gathering*, 29 an t-Samhain, GE 1,208.

3. ¶ Legacy *Raghnall Ceannfhionn makes peace*, 10 an Cèitean, GE 1,175.

4. ← Leads to *Three households settle Bàgh an t-Seabhaig*, 2 an Dàmhair, GE 1,274.

5. the Hawk bay

6. ← Follows from *Hill-folk on the western shore*, 2 an Dàmhair, GE 1,274.

7. the Hawk bay

8. ← Follows from *Hill-folk on the western shore*, 2 an Dàmhair, GE 1,274.

9. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

10. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

11. ← Follows from *Murchadh Gearr of the Red Hill*, 31 an Dàmhair, GE 1,247.

- 5 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,285** — *Flòraidh born at Bàgh an t-Seabhaig*¹² (Ros bheag). Flòraidh is born at Bàgh an t-Seabhaig in a winter hard enough to freeze salt-rime along the tideline, the middle child of five in the second household of the crossing, to a father who came west already grown and a mother who keeps his people's old telling of the hill valleys.¹³
- 10 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,294** — *Flòraidh finds her first amber in the wrack* (Seann Skell). At nine years old Flòraidh pulls a lump of amber the colour of cold honey from a raft of storm-wrack and will not let the returning tide take it back, the find that sets her apart on a shore where sea-stone washes up seldom and is talked of for a season when it does.
- 8 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,295** — *Flòraidh learns the drill* (Seann Skell). A blind drill-master three houses along works a hole through Flòraidh's find over a winter of firelit evenings, and she learns from him, more by watching than by being taught, the weight of hand that keeps a flint point true against amber and the weight that snaps a good stone in two.
- 13 **AM MÀRT, GE 1,302** — *Traders learn to ask for Flòraidh by name* (Seann Skell). Traders on Rathad na Spor¹⁴ come to ask Bàgh an t-Seabhaig¹⁵ households for Flòraidh by name rather than knock at random for worked amber, and go away with beads finished better than any other hand on that shore gives them, paid in salt, wool, and once in a knife of southern flint.
- 11 **AN GIBLEAN, GE 1,305** — *A storm brings the great amber piece ashore* (Seann Skell). A gale that takes the roofs off two houses at Bàgh an t-Seabhaig¹⁶ leaves half a mile of strand heaped with wrack, and out of it Flòraidh draws the largest piece of amber the shore has ever given up, half again the size of her first find and clouded like smoke inside.
- 8 **AN GEARRAN, GE 1,306** — *Amber from the Hawk bay* (Seann Skell). Amber is gathered from the wrack on the strands of the Hawk bay and drilled for stringing; lumps of it lie in the middens below Seann Skell. A bead of the same amber lies in the oldest ground of the ford gathering, carried there the length of the island.¹⁷
- 24 **AN GEARRAN, GE 1,310** — *Flòraidh sets out for the ford with the amber bead* (Seann Skell). At five-and-twenty, on her mother's word that so fine a stone should be seen where the whole hill can see it, Flòraidh leaves the western Seann Skell with a trader's party of six households bound the length of the island for the yearly gathering at the ford, the bead carried in a pouch against her body rather than trusted to any pack.¹⁸

12. the Hawk bay

13. ← Follows from *Beathag walks the whole crossing and is the first buried by that tide*, 2 an Dàmhair, GE 1,275.

14. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

15. the Hawk bay

16. the Hawk bay

17. → Caused by *Flòraidh finds her first amber in the wrack*, 10 an Cèitean, GE 1,294; → Caused by *Flòraidh learns the drill*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,295; → Caused by *Traders learn to ask for Flòraidh by name*, 13 am Màrt, GE 1,302; → Caused by *A storm brings the great amber piece ashore*, 11 an Giblean, GE 1,305.

18. ← Follows from *The ford gathering*, 29 an t-Samhain, GE 1,208.

- 23 AN GIBLEAN, GE 1,310** — *Flòraidh sees the king buy nothing at the ford.* At Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹⁹ Flòraidh watches the king move slowly along the trading ground for the better part of an hour, weighing pots and running a thumb along flint edges, buying nothing and asking the price of nothing, while the crowd gives way from him without seeming to notice it has moved.²⁰
- 22 AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,310** — *Flòraidh's bead laid at the ford.* Flòraidh holds out the amber bead to the king as he passes, and at his word kneels and lays it herself in the old ground of the ford among the ribbons and worked bones other travellers have left there, the finest stone the western strand ever gave up set down the length of the island from where the wrack cast it up.²¹
- 26 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 1,311** — *Flòraidh weds the boat-mender's son* (Seann Skell). The boat-mender's son who saved a pack of hides from a swollen ford on the road east follows Flòraidh west the next summer with two finished boats on a traded cart, asks for her outright in her father's yard, and marries her that autumn.²²
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 1,347** — *The first houses at Cathair dhombhain* (Cathair dhomhain). Round houses are built by the harbour where Cathair dhomhain now stands, near enough the Red Hill to pay it salt. The Red Hill list counts them among its holder's households.²³
- 3 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 1,347** — *The round-house harbour begins paying salt to An Cnoc Ruadh*²⁴ (Cala nan Taighean Cruinne²⁵). The households at Cala nan Taighean Cruinne, where the king's blood first came down to the sea, begin paying their salt to An Cnoc Ruadh rather than keeping it among themselves, a custom that takes hold within a season with no word sent from Dùn Ìseal to start it.²⁶
- 25 AM MÀRT, GE 1,352** — *Flòraidh dies on the western shore* (Seann Skell). Flòraidh dies in her sixty-eighth year in a mild autumn with the wrack lying quiet along the whole strand, four years a widow, and is buried at her own asking facing the water rather than the headland, so that whatever comes in on the tide comes in past her.²⁷
- 25 AM MÀRT, GE 1,379** — *Cattle in the north-west* (Cnoc ghorm). Cattle come to Cnoc ghorm in the north-west, where the settlements had lived on seal, fish and deer. The herds must have been walked up the flint road.²⁸

19. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

20. ← Follows from *The ford gathering*, 29 an t-Samhain, GE 1,208.

21. ← Follows from *Amber from the Hawk bay*, 8 an Gearran, GE 1,306; ← Follows from *The ford gathering*, 29 an t-Samhain, GE 1,208.

22. ← Follows from *Flòraidh's bead laid at the ford*, 22 an Cèitean, GE 1,310.

23. ← Leads to *The round-house harbour begins paying salt to An Cnoc Ruadh*, 3 an t-Sultain, GE 1,347.

24. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

25. the round-house harbour paying salt to the Red Hill (burg 26 in this age)

26. ← Follows from *The first houses at Cathair dhombhain*, 3 an t-Sultain, GE 1,347.

27. ← Follows from *The round-house harbour begins paying salt to An Cnoc Ruadh*, 3 an t-Sultain, GE 1,347.

- 25 AM MÀRT, GE 1,379** — *Cattle walked to Cnoc ghorm* (Cnoc ghorm). Small herds driven up Rathad na Spor²⁹ by stages over three summers bring cattle for the first time to the green rise of Cnoc ghorm in the north-west, where the people have lived on seal, fish and deer, and the first calves born there are watched through their first winter by the whole settlement in turn.³⁰
- 24 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,416** — *The long-house at Cathair gheal* (Cathair gheal). A long-house forty paces long, with byre and hall under one roof, is built on the rise at Cathair gheal. It is the greatest building of the age in the north-west. Twice it burns, and twice it is rebuilt on the same footing.³¹
- 24 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,416** — *The long-house raised at Cathair gheal* (Cathair gheal). A long-house forty paces long, byre and hall under one roof and greater by half again than any building of the age, is raised above the firth at Cathair gheal, timbered from Rathad na Spor³²'s own hills and roofed with turf a season dried, and is spoken of the length of the coast within the year.³³
- 17 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,420** — *The long-house at Cathair gheal burns the first time* (Cathair gheal). A spark from an untended hearth catches the byre-end thatch of the great long-house at Cathair gheal in the small hours of a still night; every soul under the roof escapes, but the hall burns with the byre before the driven-out cattle can be turned back to help beat down the flame.³⁴
- 19 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,421** — *The long-house at Cathair gheal is raised again* (Cathair gheal). The household of the burned long-house at Cathair gheal rebuilds it on the same footing before the next winter closes in, holding the ground proved good whatever the fire proved of the roof, and the building stands after that mended, its scorch mark left for anyone to see.³⁵
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,430** — *Iseabail born at the shaft's moor*. Iseabail is born into the household that keeps the eastern Toll-dubh, the elder of two children, a quiet and watchful girl who grows up among the old plaited cords still hanging inside the household's own door from the diggers' day.³⁶
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,435** — *Eachann born*. Eachann is born five years after his sister Iseabail, a loud, quick, daring child who cannot pass a height without wanting to know what stands at the top of it, nor a hole without wanting to know what lies at the bottom.³⁷

28. ← Leads to *Cattle walked to Cnoc ghorm*, 25 am Màrt, GE 1,379.

29. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

30. ← Follows from *Cattle in the north-west*, 25 am Màrt, GE 1,379.

31. ← Leads to *The long-house raised at Cathair gheal*, 24 an Gearran, GE 1,416.

32. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

33. ← Follows from *The long-house at Cathair gheal*, 24 an Gearran, GE 1,416.

34. ← Follows from *The long-house at Cathair gheal*, 24 an Gearran, GE 1,416.

35. ← Follows from *The long-house at Cathair gheal*, 24 an Gearran, GE 1,416.

36. ← Follows from *The long-house at Cathair gheal*, 24 an Gearran, GE 1,416.

37. ← Follows from *Iseabail born at the shaft's moor*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,430.

- 20 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,445** — *Eachann first asks to be let down.* At fifteen, Eachann asks his father plainly to be let down the household's own shaft to see what four generations of telling have never claimed to know, and is refused without more explaining than the shaft's own long silence has ever been given.³⁸
- 18 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,451** — *The father of Iseabail and Eachann dies.* The keeper of the eastern Toll-dubh dies of an ordinary fever that takes three others on the moor that same wet spring, and the covering stone passes to his two children, Iseabail twenty-two and Eachann seventeen.³⁹
- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,452** — *A youth let down into Toll-dubh* (Toll-dubh). A youth is let down on a rope of plaited hide into the eastern Toll-dubh, to the rope's end. He is drawn up alive and never tells what lay at the bottom. No one goes down again in this age.⁴⁰
- 21 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,452** — *A youth let down into Toll-dubh.* Eachann is let down on the household's own plaited-hide cord into the eastern Toll-dubh, to the rope's end, while his sister Iseabail holds it alone at the stake; she draws him up alive, her palms raw from the labour, and he never once tells what he found.⁴¹
- 15 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,453** — *No one goes down Toll-dubh again.* Iseabail lays the covering stone that autumn and tells every soul who asks after it that the household goes down into Toll-dubh no more; the shaft is not opened again by any hand of that moor in this age.⁴²
- 13 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 1,454** — *Iseabail marries.* Iseabail marries a man of a neighbouring holding who had courted her patiently through the years her brother's silence went unanswered, and raises three children on the same moor within sound of the covering stone.⁴³
- 12 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1,460** — *Eachann earns the name Ròpa.* The moor comes, gradually and without any one year's telling saying when it began, to call Eachann by no other name than Eachann Ròpa, a byname he wears the rest of his life without complaint or particular pride in it.⁴⁴
- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,489** — *A fire lit in the Doire uaine hills* (Marbh-bheò⁴⁵ Doire uaine). A herding family, new to the hills, lights an open fire at Doire uaine against the custom. Their hut is found empty, the fire still burning. Thereafter the covered hearth is kept more strictly.⁴⁶

38. ← Follows from *Eachann born*, 8 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,435.

39. ← Follows from *Eachann first asks to be let down*, 20 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,445.

40. ← Leads to *A youth let down into Toll-dubh*, 21 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,452.

41. ← Follows from *A youth let down into Toll-dubh*, 21 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,452.

42. ← Follows from *A youth let down into Toll-dubh*, 21 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,452.

43. ← Follows from *No one goes down Toll-dubh again*, 15 an Dàmhair, GE 1,453.

44. ← Follows from *Iseabail marries*, 13 an t-Samhain, GE 1,454.

45. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

46. ← Leads to *A fire lit in Marbh-bheò's hills*, 19 an Lùnastal, GE 1,489.

- 19 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,489** — *A fire lit in Marbh-bhedh's hills*. A herding family new to Marbh-bhedh's hills lights an open fire against the custom of that country; their hut is found afterward standing with the fire still burning and not a soul of the household anywhere about it. The telling reaches Iseabail as a traveller's news.⁴⁸
- 8 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,499** — *Eachann Ròpa dies untold*. Eachann Ròpa dies in his own bed of the ordinary failing of a long life, sixty-four years old and easy in his going, and tells his sister on the last night only that some things are carried better than they are told.⁴⁹
- 9 AM MÀRT, GE 1,500** — *Sileas born of the king's blood* (Dùn ìseal). A daughter of the king's blood is born in the valleys under Dùn ìseal and named Sileas, pale-haired from the cradle; no one at her naming thinks of her as a holder of the hill, and she grows up minding grain-pits and not judgements.⁵⁰

47. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

48. ← Follows from *A fire lit in the Doire uaine hills*, 19 an Lùnastal, GE 1,489.

49. ← Follows from *A youth let down into Toll-dubh*, 21 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,452.

50. ← Follows from *A fire lit in the Doire uaine hills*, 19 an Lùnastal, GE 1,489.

THE YEARS GE 1,501 – 1,750

- 7 AN GIBLEAN, GE 1,510** — *Iseabail dies within sight of the stone*. Iseabail dies at eighty in the house her father died in, and is buried, at her own asking, within sight of the covering stone she laid every autumn of her life over the question she carried and was never given the answer to.¹
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,525** — *The lake dwellings burn* (Loch chrom). The platforms on Loch chrom burn to the waterline, and the charred piles are left standing in the shallows. No one builds on the lake again in this age.²
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,525** — *The lake dwellings burn on Loch chrom*. The platforms built out over the shallows of Loch chrom burn in a single night to the waterline, the charred piles left standing bare in the shallows after; no household of that lake builds there again. The telling reaches Iseabail, by then grey-haired, as a trader's tale.³
- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,562** — *Seal-oil lamps at Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). Stone lamps with a hollow for seal oil and a wick of moss are used at Caol leathan. They are the first light on Dia-thìr that is not a hearth, and they give little smoke.⁴
- 22 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,562** — *The first seal-oil lamp at Caol leathan* (Caol leathan). A household of Caol leathan sets a hollowed stone with seal oil and a wick of moss on its hearth-ledge and lights it, the first light on the coast that is not a hearth; within three winters every house on that stretch keeps one burning through the dark months.⁵
- 27 AM MÀRT, GE 1,598** — *The fish-traps of Caol fhiadhaich* (Caol fhiadhaich). Wattle fences are staked across the river-mouth at Caol fhiadhaich to trap salmon on the ebb. The same line of stake-holes is used again and again through the rest of the age.⁶
- 27 AM MÀRT, GE 1,598** — *The fish-fence staked at Caol fhiadhaich* (Caol fhiadhaich). Households of the river-mouth at Caol fhiadhaich stake a fence of woven wattle out into the ebb to herd salmon on the falling tide; the fence washes out twice before the third setting holds, and the line of stake-holes it leaves is fished again every year after.⁷
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1,610** — *Mòrag Chruaidh dies* (Dùn ìseal). Mòrag Chruaidh, who named her seven dead at the hill's fire and never raised another raid, dies in her thirteen hundred and twentieth year; the naming of the seven goes on at the same fire after her, and her own name is added at its foot.⁸

1. ← Follows from *Eachann Ròpa dies untold*, 8 an Gearran, GE 1,499.

2. ← Leads to *The lake dwellings burn on Loch chrom*, 24 an Cèitean, GE 1,525.

3. ← Follows from *The lake dwellings burn*, 24 an Cèitean, GE 1,525.

4. ← Leads to *The first seal-oil lamp at Caol leathan*, 22 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,562.

5. ← Follows from *Seal-oil lamps at Caol leathan*, 22 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,562.

6. ← Leads to *The fish-fence staked at Caol fhiadhaich*, 27 am Màrt, GE 1,598.

7. ← Follows from *The fish-traps of Caol fhiadhaich*, 27 am Màrt, GE 1,598.

- 25 AN GIBLEAN, GE 1,628** — *The upright looms of Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). At Muileann leathan in the north cloth is woven on standing frames, no longer twined by hand. The loom-weights of fired clay lie in rows in the houses, where they fell from the warp.⁹
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, GE 1,628** — *The standing frame raised at Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). A household at Muileann leathan raises the first upright loom on the northern stream, the warp held taut by loops of fired clay at its foot rather than by hand, so that a worker stands free to pass the weft with both hands and beat it home faster than any lap-worked cloth had gone.¹⁰
- 8 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,670** — *Beitris born at Muileann leathan* (Muileann leathan). Beitris is born into the third household to raise a standing frame at Muileann leathan, growing up under her mother's loom and taking her own frame in her twentieth year, known on the stream for cloth that lies flatter and holds its dye better than any other hand's.¹¹
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 1,671** — *The first tide-count*. Someone begins to mark the high-water line against a fixed rock. Why is not told; but the marks are cut at intervals more even than a fisherman's need would ask.¹²
- 28 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 1,671** — *The first tide-count begun*. An unnamed hand on an unnamed shore begins cutting a mark on a fixed rock at each high tide's furthest reach, a row of cuts kept at intervals no ordinary fisherman's need would ask for; the habit spreads to more than one shore within a generation, and none who keep it can say what it counts toward.¹³
- II AN GIBLEAN, GE 1,689** — *The king stops at Beitris's stall*. At Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹⁴ the king stops before a bolt of Beitris's blue-black cloth, tests the flatness of the weave with two fingers as he tests a flint edge with his thumb, and asks how the cloth is made to lie so; it is the only exchange between them any teller claims to have had whole from a witness.¹⁵
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,690** — *The king weds Beitris* (Dùn ìseal). Beitris goes south from Muileann leathan to Dùn ìseal as the king's wife, raising a frame of her own in a shed built to her asking, and teaches the standing weights to the hill's women in twos and threes until the craft has spread from her own shed to a dozen others.¹⁶

8. ← Follows from *Mòrag Chruidh and the salt-flats raid*, 9 am Faoilleach, GE 672.

9. ← Leads to *The standing frame raised at Muileann leathan*, 25 an Giblean, GE 1,628.

10. ← Follows from *The upright looms of Muileann leathan*, 25 an Giblean, GE 1,628.

11. ← Follows from *The upright looms of Muileann leathan*, 25 an Giblean, GE 1,628.

12. ← Leads to *The first tide-count begun*, 28 am Faoilleach, GE 1,671.

13. ← Follows from *The first tide-count*, 28 am Faoilleach, GE 1,671.

14. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

15. ← Follows from *The upright looms of Muileann leathan*, 25 an Giblean, GE 1,628.

16. ← Follows from *The upright looms of Muileann leathan*, 25 an Giblean, GE 1,628.

- 2 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,700** — *An Geamhradh Liath*¹⁷ (Dùn ìsail). The king's hair goes grey between one moon and the next in a single winter and no further, dark to grey all at one stroke; he says nothing of the cause, and the hill, having talked of little else through the dark months, lets the matter rest by the following Bealltainn.¹⁸
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 1,705** — *Murchadh Mòr born* (Dùn ìsail). Beitris bears the king a black-haired son, Murchadh, the only child either parent will raise together to see him grown; the women who nurse him remark only that he runs hot for an infant and sleeps sound through cold that keeps other babies crying.¹⁹
- 26 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,708** — *A second tide-rock at Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). The high-water marking is copied at Ros dhomhain on a boulder in the harbour mouth, the marks cut at the same intervals as on the first rock. Someone carried the practice there, and the interval with it.²⁰
- 26 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,708** — *The second tide-rock cut at Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). A young keeper at Ros dhomhain, hearing of the first tide-rock by report alone, begins a rock of his own in his harbour mouth, cutting the marks at the spacing he judges by memory of the telling, though he has never seen the first rock with his own eyes.²¹
- 26 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,708** — *The king and Beitris at the rock of Ros dhomhain* (Ros dhomhain). The king stands before the new-cut tide-rock at Ros dhomhain the better part of an afternoon and tells Beitris that a thing can be worth doing before anyone has worked out why; she carries the answer, the longest she ever had from him on any matter not a household's grazing or a stranger's quarrel, the rest of her life.²²
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,740** — *Beitris asks if she will be forgotten* (Dùn ìsail). In her seventieth year, with Murchadh grown and spoken of on the hill for the north he means to hold, Beitris asks the king whether he will forget her; he answers not with a plain word but by naming, quietly and in order, every wife he had before her, more names than she can hold the count of.²³
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 1,744** — *Beitris dies* (Dùn ìsail). Beitris dies in a mild autumn in her seventy-fourth year, Murchadh at her graveside a black-haired man of thirty-nine who looks no older than fifteen; the king buries her with his own hands and sits by the turned earth a night and a day, saying once that a warp holds what it is strung with.²⁴

17. the winter of GE 1,700 in which the king's hair went grey in a single season and no further

18. ← Follows from *Seal-oil lamps at Caol leathan*, 22 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,562.

19. ← Follows from *An Geamhradh Liath*, 2 an Dàmhair, GE 1,700.

20. ← Leads to *The second tide-rock cut at Ros dhomhain*, 26 an Gearran, GE 1,708; ← Leads to *The king and Beitris at the rock of Ros dhomhain*, 26 an Gearran, GE 1,708.

21. ← Follows from *A second tide-rock at Ros dhomhain*, 26 an Gearran, GE 1,708.

22. ← Follows from *A second tide-rock at Ros dhomhain*, 26 an Gearran, GE 1,708.

23. ← Follows from *The king and Beitris at the rock of Ros dhomhain*, 26 an Gearran, GE 1,708.

24. ← Follows from *The upright looms of Muileann leathan*, 25 an Giblean, GE 1,628.

10 AM MÀRT, GE 1,747 — *The lake is higher* (Ros dhomhain). The marks on the Ros dhomhain rock creep upward from keeper to keeper, and by the end of the age Loch chrom stands a hand higher on the rock than at the first cut. The keepers go on cutting.

THE YEARS GE 1,751 – 2,000

- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,760** — *Murchadh goes out with the flint-carriers* (Cnoc àrsaidh). Sixteen years after his mother's death, Murchadh can no longer sit in his father's hall and goes north with a train of flint-carriers bound for Cnoc àrsaidh, taking up a yoke among them without a word of who he was; it is three seasons before any man there learns whose son he has been carrying flint beside.
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 1,760** — *The lake still climbing on the Ros dhombhain rock* (Ros dhomhain). Passing through Ros dhomhain on his way north, Murchadh stands before the tide-rock his mother once showed him and finds the keeper's line of cuts crept a hand's width further up the stone since his childhood, so slowly that no single year's mark can be told from the year before or after.¹
- 8 AN GIBLEAN, GE 1,781** — *The flint of Cnoc àrsaidh* (Cnoc àrsaidh). A pit is worked for flint on the hill of Cnoc àrsaidh in the north-west, the only good flint on Dia-thìr. Its grey flakes are carried to hearths from one end of the island to the other.²
- 25 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 1,790** — *Murchadh meets Ailig Spor on Rathad na Spor*³ (Cnoc àrsaidh). On the road between Cnoc àrsaidh and Cruinneachadh an Àtha⁴, Murchadh comes to know Ailig Spor, a young carrier from the northern flats who tells him plainly that a yoke does not care whose back it is on; the two keep the friendship the whole of the years the road gives them.⁵
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,800** — *Ailig marries by the northern crossing*. Ailig Spor marries a woman of a household by the river-crossing on Rathad na Spor⁶ and raises two sons and a daughter on flint-carrying wages, all three walking the near stretches of the road themselves before they are grown; Murchadh stands godfather to the eldest.⁷
- II AM FAOILLEACH, GE 1,817** — *The flint road* (Àth leathan). A track is worn by the flint-carriers from Cnoc àrsaidh south and east toward the ford gathering. Near Àth leathan their feet sink it a yard deep.⁸
- II AM FAOILLEACH, GE 1,817** — *Rathad na Spor*⁹ worn a yard deep (Cnoc àrsaidh). The track between Cnoc àrsaidh and the northern river-crossing, worn by generations of carriers before Murchadh and Ailig were born, sinks a full yard below the level of the ground on either side, so that a man walking it casts no shadow beyond its banks and a stranger cresting the rise above it mistakes it for a dry ditch dug on purpose.¹⁰

1. ← Follows from *The lake is higher*, 10 am Màrt, GE 1,747.

2. → Caused by *Murchadh goes out with the flint-carriers*, 23 an Lùnastal, GE 1,760.

3. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

4. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

5. ← Follows from *The lake still climbing on the Ros dhombhain rock*, 21 an t-Sultain, GE 1,760.

6. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

7. ← Follows from *Murchadh meets Ailig Spor on Rathad na Spor*, 25 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,790.

8. ← Leads to *Rathad na Spor worn a yard deep*, 11 am Faoilleach, GE 1,817.

9. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1,818** — *A storm survived in the sunken road's own bank* (Cnoc àrsaidh). Caught two days from shelter by a late storm, Ailig thinks to have the yoke-gang dig into the sunken road's bank and roof it with the carriers' own yokes rather than risk the open ground; the gang comes through with nothing worse than cold fingers, where an older carrier swears they would otherwise have lost two or three men.¹¹
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 1,820** — *The households along the road remark Murchadh's unaging face* (Cnoc àrsaidh). It does not escape the households of Rathad na Spor¹², decade upon decade, that Murchadh carries a yoke with no more sign of years on him than a carrier three seasons in shows; some later carriers will not share a fire with him for reasons they give badly, but Ailig never once asks him the plain question every other man on the circuit wants to ask.¹³
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,834** — *Ailig gives up the road for the pit-mouth* (Cnoc àrsaidh). In his sixty-fourth year Ailig Spor hands his yoke to his youngest son and takes the lighter work of tallying at the Cnoc àrsaidh pit-mouth; Murchadh, who could by then claim a dozen reasons to walk the far circuits instead, finds himself always coming back through Cnoc àrsaidh at the turn of a season to sit an evening with him.¹⁴
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 1,838** — *Ailig Spor dies* (Cnoc àrsaidh). Ailig Spor dies in his sleep in his sixty-eighth year, four years a keeper and not a carrier, found by his own daughter with no mark of pain on him; Murchadh, two days south with a fresh gang who scarcely know his name, walks the two days back in one and stands at the graveside with a stillness the household has not seen on him before.¹⁵
- 1 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,838** — *Murchadh sets the pit-mouth's free flake as a standing custom* (Cnoc àrsaidh). Murchadh stays at Cnoc àrsaidh the better part of a month after Ailig's burying and tells the new keeper that the pit's first flake of any new working shall go on being given free to whoever asks, as it always had, and that he will see to it himself that the custom does not lapse.¹⁶
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1,853** — *The hawk lintel at Àth mhòr* (Àth mhòr). A hawk is carved on a lintel over a house door at Àth mhòr in the north, wings closed, head turned. It is the oldest carving of a hawk on the island, and of any bird.¹⁷

10. ← Follows from *The flint road*, 11 am Faoilleach, GE 1,817.

11. ← Follows from *Rathad na Spor worn a yard deep*, 11 am Faoilleach, GE 1,817.

12. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

13. ← Follows from *A storm survived in the sunken road's own bank*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, GE 1,818.

14. ← Follows from *The households along the road remark Murchadh's unaging face*, 18 an t-Samhain, GE 1,820.

15. ← Follows from *Ailig gives up the road for the pit-mouth*, 20 an Dàmhair, GE 1,834.

16. ← Follows from *Ailig Spor dies*, 3 am Faoilleach, GE 1,838.

17. ← Leads to *The hawk carved into the lintel at Àth mhòr*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 1,853.

13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 1,853 — *The hawk carved into the lintel at Àth mhòr (Àth mhòr).*

Walking the far eastern circuit alone, Murchadh watches a young man of Àth mhòr cut a hawk into his father's door-lintel by firelight over three evenings, wings closed and the head turned back over the shoulder; the carver says only that the shape came to him whole one night and would not leave him alone until he had cut it, and no carrier ever hears of an earlier bird cut in wood or stone anywhere on Dia-thìr.¹⁸

10 AM MÀRT, GE 1,890 — *Wolves at Tobar fhiadhaich (Tobar fhiadhaich).* At Tobar fhiadhaich wolves are buried whole and with care, laid on their sides as people are. No other beast is so buried in this age.¹⁹**10 AM MÀRT, GE 1,890** — *Murchadh sees the wolves buried at Tobar fhiadhaich (Tobar fhiadhaich).* In his hundred and eighty-fifth year Murchadh comes upon a household at Tobar fhiadhaich burying a wolf on its side with its legs drawn up as in sleep; asked why, an old woman of the household says the wolf keeps its own dead on the high ground and has earned better than the ditch, a care they have never spoken of outside the household before.²⁰**28 AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,891** — *Murchadh asks his father for the north (Dùn ìseal).* Murchadh comes south to Dùn ìseal and asks his father for the whole northern country Rathad na Spor²¹ runs through, which he has walked, he says, more times than any man living and knows better than any man living knows it.²²**26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 1,891** — *The king refuses Murchadh the north (Dùn ìseal).* The king answers that the north is Dòmhnall's to hold, given him sixteen hundred years before and well kept since, and that a share once given is not taken back for a better claim that comes after it; Murchadh rides north again within the week without asking a second time.²³**25 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 1,892** — *The first grievance of Ailean's line (Dùn ìseal).* Murchadh rides out of Dùn ìseal with a face his father's household has not seen on him before, nearer pride than the young man's face he wore going north the first time, and close under the pride, by the telling of those who marked it, the first grievance the hill ever had cause to lay at a son of Ailean's own naming.²⁴**23 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,925** — *The high pastures fail at Dùn ìseal.* A spring of near-ceaseless rain rots the high grazing at the root, and households begin killing beasts they would ordinarily have wintered, for want of anything left to feed them.²⁵

18. ← Follows from *The hawk lintel at Àth mhòr*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 1,853.

19. ← Leads to *Murchadh sees the wolves buried at Tobar fhiadhaich*, 10 am Màrt, GE 1,890.

20. ← Follows from *Wolves at Tobar fhiadhaich*, 10 am Màrt, GE 1,890.

21. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

22. ← Follows from *Murchadh sees the wolves buried at Tobar fhiadhaich*, 10 am Màrt, GE 1,890.

23. ← Follows from *Murchadh asks his father for the north*, 28 an Cèitean, GE 1,891.

24. ← Follows from *The king refuses Murchadh the north*, 26 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,891.

25. ← Follows from *Sileas born of the king's blood*, 9 am Màrt, GE 1,500.

- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 1,926** — *Sileas opens the store within the bank by the mouth, not the herd.* Sileas Bhàn orders the grain-pits cut into Dùn ìseal's own earthwork opened to every household by the count of mouths at its hearth rather than by the size of its herd, the first time the store is shared by that measure; a wealthier herdsman rides up to protest it to her face, and she does not change the measure.²⁶
- 9 AN GEARRAN, GE 1,927** — *Sileas Bhàn and the hungry years* (Dùn ìseal). Sileas Bhàn, eighth of the Stone Kings, of the king's blood, holds Dùn ìseal through years of failed grazing. No deed is told of her but that she held, and the list goes on after her.
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,928** — *Households begin refilling the store unasked.* With the grazing still short, households of Dùn ìseal's own ground begin returning grain to the bank's pits beyond what was drawn from them, a custom Sileas Bhàn lets stand without ordering it, judging it will hold firmer for growing its own root.²⁷
- 11 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,929** — *The grazing recovers.* The high pastures dry and thicken again within three years of their failing, as such lean spells generally did on that ground, though the store within the bank is not filled to its old level again for a decade.²⁸
- 9 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 1,965** — *The hunger at Baile chrom is first heard of at the hill* (Baile chrom). Word reaches Dùn ìseal, slow and uncertain, of two failed fishing seasons on the north-western shore at Baile chrom, of stores already gone to bark and boiled seaweed, and of graves being laid two deep for want of time to dig them singly.
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, GE 1,966** — *The hunger at Baile chrom* (Gorta Baile chrom²⁹). Hunger comes to the settlement on the site of the north-western Baile chrom. Its pots are left full of boiled bark and seaweed, and its grave-rows are doubled. No older hunger on Dia-thìr is tied to a place.³⁰
- 15 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 1,967** — *The king rides north-west with grain* (Baile chrom). Ailean Mòr rides to the north-western coast himself with the first grain that can be spared, by a road that has never before carried him, and is gone the better part of a season; he returns saying nothing of what he found, save that every hill of the kingdom is to look to its own store before the next storm season.³¹
- 13 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 1,967** — *Sileas sends grain along the whole north-western coast* (Baile chrom). Sileas Bhàn holds Dùn ìseal in the king's absence and sends three cartloads of grain and a small herd of goats after him, with instruction that they go to whichever hearths along that coast are worst served and not to Baile chrom alone, having heard the hunger reaches wider than one shore.³²

26. ← Follows from *The high pastures fail at Dùn ìseal*, 23 an Lùnastal, GE 1,925.

27. ← Follows from *Sileas Bhàn and the hungry years*, 9 an Gearran, GE 1,927.

28. ← Follows from *Households begin refilling the store unasked*, 20 an Dàmhair, GE 1,928.

29. The Great Hunger; lit. 'the famine of Baile chrom'

30. → Caused by *The hunger at Baile chrom is first heard of at the hill*, 9 an t-Sultain, GE 1,965.

31. ← Follows from *The hunger at Baile chrom*, 7 an Cèitean, GE 1,966.

32. ← Follows from *The hunger at Baile chrom*, 7 an Cèitean, GE 1,966.

IO AN DÀMHAIR, GE 1,968 — *No household near Dùn ìseal again lets its store run low.* Once the doubled grave-rows of Baile chrom are known at the hill, no household within a day's ride of Dùn ìseal again lets its own grain fall below a season's worth, whatever the grazing does, for fear of what might one day be asked of it.³³

33. ← Follows from *The hunger at Baile chrom*, 7 an Cèitean, GE 1,966.

THE YEARS GE 2,001 – 2,250

- 11 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,003** — *The wells of Achadh shean run low* (Achadh shean). The wells of Achadh shean in the east fall a hand lower than any digger there remembers, a thing thought at first too small to trouble the hill with.¹
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,004** — *A shepherd's boy walks to Dùn ìseal to report the cracking banks* (Achadh shean). A boy of Achadh shean walks three days to Dùn ìseal on his own feet rather than trust the telling to a rider, to say that the field banks his grandfather raised have cracked from dryness for the first time in three generations; Sileas Bhàn sends a rider east to look before sending any grain.
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,005** — *The springs of Achadh shean stop* (Achadh shean). The rider sent east returns saying the springs of Achadh shean have not merely run low but stopped outright, their whole visible flow gone at a season when they have never before failed within living telling.
- 8 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,006** — *The drought at Achadh shean* (Tìormachd Achadh shean²). The springs of Achadh shean in the east run dry so long that the field banks are forsaken and grown over. When people return they cut new fields on another line.³
- 8 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,006** — *The field banks of Achadh shean are forsaken* (Achadh shean). With the springs three years dry, the households of Achadh shean walk off their old field banks, leaving the dead barley standing in the row, and cut new fields on another line lower on the slope, where a lesser spring still runs thin but steady.⁴
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,007** — *Sileas refuses to have the dead field pulled down* (Achadh shean). Riding out to see the forsaken banks of Achadh shean, Sileas Bhàn refuses her own rider's suggestion that they be levelled, saying a bank tells a household what the ground once gave and what it stopped giving, and is worth more standing than pulled down.⁵
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,008** — *Sileas asks the king what her deed will be*. At Cruinneachadh an Àtha⁶ Sileas Bhàn asks Ailean Mòr what the list will say she did, having herself set no boundary stone, fought no war and raided no shore; he tells her that four hundred years of not failing, where failing was always the easier road, is itself the deed the list will keep.⁷

1. ← Follows from *No household near Dùn ìseal again lets its store run low*, 10 an Dàmhair, GE 1,968.

2. the Long Drought; lit. 'the drought of Achadh shean'

3. → Caused by *A shepherd's boy walks to Dùn ìseal to report the cracking banks*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,004; → Caused by *The springs of Achadh shean stop*, 8 an t-Samhain, GE 2,005; ← Leads to *The field banks of Achadh shean are forsaken*, 8 an Giblean, GE 2,006.

4. ← Follows from *The drought at Achadh shean*, 8 an Giblean, GE 2,006.

5. ← Follows from *The drought at Achadh shean*, 8 an Giblean, GE 2,006.

6. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

7. ← Follows from *Sileas refuses to have the dead field pulled down*, 5 am Faoilleach, GE 2,007.

- 4 AM MÀRT, GE 2,010** — *Sileas Bhàn gives Dùn ìseal to Tormod Liath*. In her five hundred and tenth year Sileas Bhàn gives the hill to Tormod Liath, a son of Iain Dubh of thirteen hundred and seventy years, ordering the store within the bank counted before witnesses so the new holder takes it up knowing to the basket what it holds.⁸
- 14 AM MÀRT, GE 2,010** — *Tormod Liath keeps the grain-measure unchanged*. In his first words as holder, Tormod Liath tells the households he will change nothing about the store within the bank, having watched it feed two hungers in his own lifetime and seeing no reason to improve on a measure that has already held.⁹
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,021** — *Tormod mends the bank and the boundary marks* (Dùn ìseal). In his first seasons holding Dùn ìseal, Tormod Liath sets right what the hungry years let go: the silted ditch, the leaning palisade, and the boundary marks between the hill's fields and the households', blurred by two lean summers of each man taking what he could.
- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,040** — *Tormod buries his eldest son* (Dùn ìseal). Tormod Liath's eldest son dies of years, the first of the three heirs Tormod outlives; the old holder stands at the burying still dark-haired, and is named by his own son's grandchildren as their grandfather's father.
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,047** — *The naming of the wind directions*. The eight winds are named, and every Dia-threach sailor after uses the names. Their meaning is dark even to those who speak them, and they have never been changed.
- 5 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,047** — *Na h-Ochd Gaothan*¹⁰ *are named*. Na h-Ochd Gaothan of the year, known before only by their feel, are given names all at once by no one the coasts can afterward name. Every coast that tells it uses the same eight names in the same order from that year on.¹¹
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,048** — *Fearchar Gobha brings the wind-names to Tormod* (Dùn ìseal). A salt-carrier of the hill, Fearchar Gobha, hears the eight wind-names at the coast fair and brings them up to Tormod Liath, who says only that a landholder has no business owning what belongs to the sea.¹²
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,050** — *Eilidh born in the valleys under the hill* (Dùn ìseal). A daughter of the king's blood is born in the valleys under Dùn ìseal and named Eilidh; grey-eyed from her first year, she grows up at her own hearth with no thought of holding anything more.¹³

8. ← Follows from *Sileas Bhàn and the hungry years*, 9 an Gearran, GE 1,927.

9. ← Follows from *Sileas Bhàn gives Dùn ìseal to Tormod Liath*, 4 am Màrt, GE 2,010.

10. the eight named winds

11. ← Follows from *The naming of the wind directions*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,047.

12. ⇌ At the same time *The naming of the wind directions*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,047.

13. ← Follows from *The naming of the wind directions*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,047.

- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,076** — *Three brothers raise Clachan nan Gaoth*¹⁴ at Ceann leathan (Ceann leathan). Aonghas, Dùghlas and Ailig mac Torcaill, brothers of the point, quarry eight stones from an outcrop above the landing and raise them in a ring, one for each named wind, so a sailor may lay a hand on the stone of the wind he wants before he puts out.
- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,084** — *The wind-stones of Ceann leathan* (Ceann leathan). Eight tall stones are set in a ring on the point at Ceann leathan, one for each of the named winds. Sailors of every later age touch the stone of the wind they want before they put out.¹⁵
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,084** — *The crooked stone reset* (Ceann leathan). One bad winter after Clachan nan Gaoth¹⁶ are first raised at Ceann leathan, the stone of the hardest offshore wind is found settled crooked and is dug out and reset on a footing of smaller stones, standing straighter and newer than its seven fellows ever after.¹⁷
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,100** — *Tormod buries his second son on the western slope*. Tormod Liath's second son, who held the hill's western grazing and never cared for the hall, is buried at his own asking on the slope where he herded, and Tormod says a man ought to be let choose his own ground if nothing else is left him to choose.
- 24 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,124** — *The wind-names carried to the islands* (Eilean fhada). The eight wind-names are used on Eilean fhada as on the main island. The markers on its high point bear eight cut notches, one facing each way.
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,124** — *The wind-names cut into the rock of Eilean fhada*. The people of Eilean fhada, off the northern cape, keep no ring of stones but cut the eight wind-names as notches into the rock of the island's highest ground, one facing each way, so a man lost in thick weather may find his bearing by touch.¹⁸
- 27 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,160** — *Raghnall Ceannfhionn dies* (Dùn ìseal). Raghnall Ceannfhionn, who waded into the ford to strike the bargain of salt for wool, dies in his fourteen hundred and first year; the ford keeps its autumn meeting that year as every year, and the two hills send more wool and more salt than the bargain asks.¹⁹
- 25 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,163** — *Tormod Liath* (Dùn ìseal). Tormod Liath, ninth of the Stone Kings, a grandson of the king, holds the hill so long that he outlives three heirs, and is remembered as old. In his time Dùn ìseal is given its second bank, and its ground is doubled.²⁰

14. the ring of eight wind-stones at Ceann leathan

15. → Caused by *Three brothers raise Clachan nan Gaoth at Ceann leathan*, 21 an t-Sultain, GE 2,076.

16. the ring of eight wind-stones at Ceann leathan

17. ← Follows from *The wind-stones of Ceann leathan*, 5 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,084.

18. ← Follows from *The wind-names carried to the islands*, 24 an Cèitean, GE 2,124.

19. ← Follows from *Raghnall Ceannfhionn makes peace*, 10 an Cèitean, GE 1,175.

20. → Caused by *Tormod mends the bank and the boundary marks*, 12 an Giblean, GE 2,021; → Caused by *Tormod buries his eldest son*, 15 an Faoilleach, GE 2,040; → Caused by *Tormod buries his second son on the western slope*, 25 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,100.

- 13 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,163** — *Tormod paces out the second bank* (Dùn ìseal). Tormod Liath walks the line of Dùn ìseal's second bank himself through two winters before calling the households in to dig, taking in the low ground by the spring without losing the height needed for a watch-fire.²¹
- 30 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,164** — *The households dig the second bank* (Dùn ìseal). The households of Dùn ìseal dig through a spring and a summer to raise the second bank, doubling the ground held within the hill's earth from some forty houses to very near a hundred.²²
- 1 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,180** — *Tormod buries his third son and tells him it does not hurt* (Dùn ìseal). The youngest and last of Tormod Liath's three sons dies asking his father, near the end, whether it hurts to be left each time; Tormod tells him no, the one lie the tellings of that hill ever charge against him.²³
- 2 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,185** — *Tormod goes fully grey* (Dùn ìseal). By his hundred and seventy-fifth year of holding, Tormod Liath is grey through, brows and beard with the rest, and the young of the hill, who never knew him dark, take him for the oldest thing on Dùn ìseal, older even than the second bank he raised.²⁴
- 3 AN GEARRAN, GE 2,193** — *The king raises Tormod from the mud at the gate* (Dùn ìseal). The king comes to Dùn ìseal's gate with a handful of his household and no word sent ahead; grey, stooped Tormod Liath kneels to him as every holder before him has knelt, and is raised again by a hand that has not aged since Tormod's father knelt the same way.²⁵
- 4 AM MÀRT, GE 2,193** — *A child asks why the old man kneels* (Dùn ìseal). A granddaughter of Tormod's second son, watching from the bank, asks her mother why the young stranger lets the old holder kneel to him as at a common gate; her mother tells her that evening, by the fire, what the hill has long known and rarely says aloud.²⁶
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,201** — *The Dia-thìrich name*. In this age the hill-folk begin to call themselves Dia-thìrich and the island Dia-thìr. The first use is not known; the eldest tellings take both names for granted. With the names goes the belief: they did not come; they were here.
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,201** — *Children begin to call themselves Dia-thìrich* (Dùn ìseal). The children of Dùn ìseal begin, unbidden by any elder, to call themselves Dia-thìrich and their island Dia-thìr, in place of hill-folk or the grove-born name Clann nan Dè²⁷; within a generation the old words fall out of use among the young.²⁸

21. ← Follows from *Tormod Liath*, 25 an Giblean, GE 2,163.

22. ← Follows from *Tormod Liath*, 25 an Giblean, GE 2,163.

23. → Leads to *Tormod Liath*, 25 an Giblean, GE 2,163.

24. ← Follows from *Tormod Liath*, 25 an Giblean, GE 2,163.

25. ← Follows from *Tormod Liath*, 25 an Giblean, GE 2,163.

26. ⇌ At the same time *Tormod Liath*, 25 an Giblean, GE 2,163.

27. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

28. ← Follows from *The Dia-thìrich name*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,201.

- 18 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,201** — *Tormod is told the island's new name by a boy of seven* (Dùn ìseal). A boy of the new ground within the second bank tells Tormod Liath, asked what clan he is, that he is Dia-thireach and that everyone is; Tormod answers only that it is a good enough name for a good enough island.²⁹
- 15 AN GEARRAN, GE 2,221** — *Ealag and Torcall Tochclair are promised by their households* (Dùn ìseal). Two households of the hill above Dùn ìseal, who share a slope and a spring, treat a match between Ealag and Torcall Tochclair as already settled. Torcall's mother carries the salt across to ask for it in the old way.
- 3 AN GEARRAN, GE 2,222** — *The salt is refused* (Dùn ìseal). Torcall's mother brings the salt back unaccepted. The elders of Ealag's household give her no reason, only that the match cannot be, and she comes home with her face set as it had never been set before.
- 2 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,223** — *The first forbidden marriage*. A marriage between two lineages is forbidden, for a reason no surviving telling gives. Already the Dia-thirich order themselves by blood, long before the coal gives them cause.³⁰
- 27 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,223** — *Torcall is turned away at every door* (Dùn ìseal). Torcall Tochclair goes himself to Ealag's father and her uncles and is told, in the same three words each time, that the marriage cannot be. None of them will say why, and he cannot tell whether none of them know it or all of them have sworn silence.³¹
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,223** — *Ealag's mother weeps and will not say* (Dùn ìseal). Ealag asks her own mother for the reason and is told only to stop asking, and her mother weeps, which Ealag has never seen her do, not even at a burying.³²
- 1 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,224** — *Ealag given to a household of the ford* (Fèill Muileann òg³³). Ealag is married to Donnchadh, a fisher of the ford town, who asks for her honestly and does not learn of the earlier match for three years.³⁴
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,238** — *Torcall hears of the black hill in the east*. Torcall Tochclair, restless at the coal-banks under the mountain, hears from traders of ground in the east with a look of coal about it, and begins asking the older diggers whether the vein is the island's only one.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,247** — *Lines recited at the ford* (Fèill Muileann òg³⁵). At the ford gathering households begin to recite their lines aloud before any marriage is made, seven names back on either side. These are the first genealogies of the common households; only the Line of the Mason is older. None survives whole.

29. ← Follows from *The Dia-thirich name*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,201.

30. → Caused by *Ealag and Torcall Tochclair are promised by their households*, 15 an Gearran, GE 2,221; → Caused by *The salt is refused*, 3 an Gearran, GE 2,222.

31. ← Follows from *The first forbidden marriage*, 2 an Lùnastal, GE 2,223.

32. ← Follows from *The first forbidden marriage*, 2 an Lùnastal, GE 2,223.

33. the fair at Muileann òg

34. ← Follows from *The first forbidden marriage*, 2 an Lùnastal, GE 2,223.

35. the fair at Muileann òg

30 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,247 — *The lines first recited at the ford.* Before any match is spoken at the fair, a household stands and gives its line aloud, seven names back on either side, so a forbidden blood may be named before the salt is carried. Ealag hears it and thinks of the four shut mouths that refused her.³⁶

26 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,247 — *Ealag tells Donnchadh of Torcall* (Fèill Muileann òg³⁷). That evening Ealag tells her husband of the match that was refused her. He says only that it explains a look she sometimes wears at fair-time, and asks nothing further.³⁸

5 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,250 — *Calum born to Eilidh* (Dùn ìseal). A son is born to Eilidh in the valleys under the hill and named Calum, dark from his birth; he will be the elder of her two sons and the one who stands where an heir stands.³⁹

36. ← Follows from *Lines recited at the ford*, 31 an Lùnastal, GE 2,247.

37. the fair at Muileann òg

38. ⇌ At the same time *Lines recited at the ford*, 31 an Lùnastal, GE 2,247.

39. ← Follows from *Lines recited at the ford*, 31 an Lùnastal, GE 2,247.

THE YEARS GE 2,251 – 2,500

23 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,262 — *Lachann agrees to go east with his brother* (Cnoc na Claise¹).

Torcall's younger brother Lachann, easier in temper but loyal to him, agrees to go east to the black hill with two other restless diggers, meaning to see Torcall satisfied and brought home again.

29 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,267 — *The first seeking of another vein* (Cnoc dhubh). Diggers from Dùn iséal open a trench on a hill near Cnoc dhubh in the east, seeking coal like the vein's. They leave it unfinished when two of them are crushed by a fall. The trench stays open, and what it would have found is not known.²

25 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,267 — *Lachann buried at the trench's mouth* (Cnoc na Claise³). Torcall will not have his brother carried elsewhere and buries him where he fell, at the mouth of the trench on the black hill. The other man killed with him is carried home by his own people.⁴

10 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,268 — *Torcall builds a shelter at the trench* (Cnoc na Claise⁵). When the other diggers pack their tools and go back to the coal-banks under the mountain, Torcall Tochclair stays, and builds himself a turf shelter at the trench's edge for the winter.⁶

12 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,270 — *Word of Torcall reaches Ealag* (Fèill Muileann òg⁷). A trader who stopped at the black hill brings word to the ford of a man sitting alone beside an open trench with his brother in the ground nearby, still saying he means to find the coal.⁸

10 AM MÀRT, GE 2,289 — *The stone that would not break*. A second opening for a new vein is made elsewhere on the island and fails wholly: common rock, and nothing beneath it. So it is first known that the vein under the mountain is alone of its kind.

7 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,290 — *The saying of the vein's choosing begins to travel*. After the second opening strikes only unbroken common stone, it is said across the island that the vein under the mountain is alone of its kind and chose its one place the way na Seachd Guail⁹ are said to have chosen theirs.¹⁰

1. the hill of the first trench for another vein (burg 198 in this age)

2. → Caused by *Torcall bears of the black hill in the east*, 10 an Dàmhair, GE 2,238; → Caused by *Lachann agrees to go east with his brother*, 23 an t-Sultain, GE 2,262.

3. the hill of the first trench for another vein (burg 198 in this age)

4. ← Follows from *The first seeking of another vein*, 29 an t-Sultain, GE 2,267.

5. the hill of the first trench for another vein (burg 198 in this age)

6. ← Follows from *The first seeking of another vein*, 29 an t-Sultain, GE 2,267.

7. the fair at Muileann òg

8. ← Follows from *The first seeking of another vein*, 29 an t-Sultain, GE 2,267.

9. the Seven Coals

10. ← Follows from *The stone that would not break*, 10 am Màrt, GE 2,289.

- 9 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,300** — *Ealag dies at the ford* (Fèill Muileann òg¹¹). Ealag dies in her own bed at the ford with her children about her, having lived her whole life after the refusal without the reason for it.¹²
- 17 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,305** — *The will for a third opening goes out of the island*. No elder forbids a third trench outright, but the wish for one fades everywhere at once, the way the wish for a refused match fades in two households without a word spoken between them.
- 18 **AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,310** — *A household gathers at the black hill's foot* (Cnoc na Claise¹³). Folk who come to the black hill for one reason or another begin to stay, since the ground is as good as any and the man who keeps the open trench asks nothing of them.
- 8 **AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,312** — *The prospecting ends*. No one tries a third opening in this age. The Dia-thirich hold that the vein chooses where it lies, and that the choice is not theirs to try.¹⁴
- 14 **AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 2,318** — *Torcall Tochclair dies at the trench* (Cnoc na Claise¹⁵). Torcall Tochclair dies at the black hill and is buried beside his brother at the trench's mouth. The household he gathered keeps the ground and does not fill the trench in.¹⁶
- 7 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,328** — *The first shared meal law*. A custom arises, unwritten, that any household with food to spare shall share it before the storm season.
- 2 **AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,331** — *The shore-woman's catch carried in whole* (Dùn ìseal). A woman of the shore households at Dùn ìseal, whose net takes more mackerel than her family can eat or smoke before it turns, carries three baskets of it to the bank herself rather than let it spoil unshared. Tormod Liath comes down from the hall to help her set them down. After it the sharing before the storms needs no one to ask.
- 4 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,340** — *A holder shamed into doubling his own surplus* (Dùn ìseal). A holder of one of the near valleys mocks a household that brings little to the sharing. His neighbours say nothing against him, but the next year he brings in double his own surplus unasked. No reciter keeps his name.¹⁷
- 5 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,356** — *Surplus shared at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). At Dùn ìseal the sharing before the storms is done in the open: every household brings its surplus within the bank, and it is divided by the count of mouths. The custom has no earlier place that is known.¹⁸

11. the fair at Muileann òg

12. ← Follows from *The first forbidden marriage*, 2 an Lùnastal, GE 2,223.

13. the hill of the first trench for another vein (burg 198 in this age)

14. → Caused by *The will for a third opening goes out of the island*, 17 an Cèitean, GE 2,305; ⇌ At the same time *A household gathers at the black hill's foot*, 18 an Giblean, GE 2,310.

15. the hill of the first trench for another vein (burg 198 in this age)

16. ← Follows from *The first seeking of another vein*, 29 an t-Sultain, GE 2,267.

17. ← Follows from *The first shared meal law*, 7 an Cèitean, GE 2,328.

- 7 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,360** — *Beasag born at Àth shean* (Àth shean). A daughter is born to a careful household at Àth shean, the ford below Dùn ìseal, some years after her father digs a grain pit under the byre floor against nothing he can name. Her mother dies bearing the last of her brothers three winters before the lean year that will end the household's place at the ford.¹⁹
- 5 **AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,360** — *Lachlann born on An Cnoc Ruadh*²⁰ (Cathair dhearg). A son is born in An Cnoc Ruadh's hall and named Lachlann, red-headed like so many of that line; he grows up wet to the knee on the lake shore and learns the salt-rake before the spear.²¹
- 9 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,370** — *Oighrig born to a herder of the near slopes* (Tobar dhireach). A daughter is born to Dòmhnall, a herder of the near slopes above Tobar dhireach with no kinship to Rìghrean na Cloiche²², and named Oighrig; she grows up sitting her household's turns at the slab and will draw the white stone at three-and-thirty.²³
- 12 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,377** — *A lean storm season at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Failed grazing and short-headed barley along the near valleys, with three weeks lost to a wind that will not turn, make the leanest storm season since the sharing began. The division at the bank is thinner than any household remembers, and old people come to be counted though they have nothing to bring.²⁴
- 10 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,377** — *Beasag watches the division made by the count of mouths* (Dùn ìseal). Beasag, seventeen, is sent to Dùn ìseal with her household's share in the lean year and sees the sharing divided by the count of mouths: a widow with four children carries home more than she brought, and a boy holds his first full sack too long to trust it. She says nothing of her father's pit.²⁵
- 14 **AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,378** — *A household turned out at Àth shean* (Àth shean). A household at Àth shean hides its spare grain in a pit under the floor and brings nothing to the sharing. When the pit is found the household is put out of the settlement with what it can carry. It is the first punishment under the custom that is remembered.²⁶
- 14 **AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,378** — *Beasag tells of her father's pit at the ford* (Àth shean). In the first mild days after the storms break, a woman mending net on the bank at Àth shean asks Beasag idly whether her father's byre came through the lean year as thin as the rest. Beasag answers true: there is a pit under the floor, and he never brought it all in.²⁷

18. → Caused by *The shore-woman's catch carried in whole*, 2 an t-Samhain, GE 2,331.

19. ← Follows from *A holder shamed into doubling his own surplus*, 4 an Dàmhair, GE 2,340.

20. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

21. ← Follows from *Calum born to Eilidh*, 5 am Faoilleach, GE 2,250.

22. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

23. ← Follows from *Surplus shared at Dùn ìseal*, 5 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,356.

24. ← Follows from *Surplus shared at Dùn ìseal*, 5 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,356.

25. ← Follows from *Surplus shared at Dùn ìseal*, 5 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,356.

26. ← Leads to *Beasag tells of her father's pit at the ford*, 14 an t-Samhain, GE 2,378; ← Leads to *Tormod Liath sends to open the floor at Àth shean*, 14 an t-Samhain, GE 2,378; ← Leads to *The household of Àth shean put out with what it can carry*, 14 an t-Samhain, GE 2,378.

27. ← Follows from *A household turned out at Àth shean*, 14 an t-Samhain, GE 2,378.

- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,378** — *Tormod Liath sends to open the floor at Àth shean* (Dùn ìseal). Word of the hidden pit reaches Tormod Liath at Dùn ìseal by way of Àth shean's own holder. He asks only whether the girl told it of her own will, unbeaten and unbribed, and on being told she had, sends his men to open the floor.²⁸
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,378** — *The household of Àth shean put out with what it can carry* (Àth shean). Grain enough for two households through the lean winter is found beneath the byre floor. Beasag's father is given until dark to take what his household can carry on its backs and to be off the ford's ground by morning: the first punishment under the sharing custom that is remembered.²⁹
- 12 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,379** — *Beasag's household settles east of the vein*. After eleven days on the road, Beasag's father builds a house on a nameless slope east of the vein, where the king's blood holds no hall and claims no grazing, among households that went out a generation before for their own reasons. He digs no pit under this floor.³⁰
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,380** — *Sileas Bhàn dies among her kin* (Dùn ìseal). Sileas Bhàn, who opened the store within the bank by the count of mouths, dies among her own kin in the valley below the bank in her eight hundred and eightieth year; Tormod Liath comes down from the hall to stand at her burying.³¹
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,385** — *Peigi born on An Cnoc Ruadh*³² (Cathair dhearg). A daughter is born to Lachlann Ruadh and named Peigi, black-haired and loud from her first night; she will meet her father's fosterling at the gate at fifteen and tell him he is too thin.³³
- 16 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,390** — *Tormod Liath dies at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Tormod Liath dies in his own hall, without wound or fever, in the three hundred and eightieth year of his holding, having outlived three heirs of his own body and buried each at the bank he built. Dùn ìseal mourns him the length of a season; scarcely a household on the hill remembers a holder before him.³⁴
- 14 AN GEARRAN, GE 2,390** — *Eilidh Ghlas takes up the hill* (Dùn ìseal). The holding of Dùn ìseal passes to Eilidh Ghlas, of the king's own blood, who has lived out those same generations in the valleys under the hill without thought of holding anything but her own hearth. She takes up the sharing custom with the hill itself, and weighs it at the bank herself in her first years.
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,390** — *Eilidh Ghlas asks after the pit at Àth shean* (Àth shean). Before the bank is even swept for the season's grain, Eilidh Ghlas sends to Àth shean to ask after the pit still known by the name of the man who dug it. She is told it stands empty, and says only that this is well.³⁵

28. ← Follows from *A household turned out at Àth shean*, 14 an t-Samhain, GE 2,378.

29. ← Follows from *A household turned out at Àth shean*, 14 an t-Samhain, GE 2,378.

30. ← Follows from *A household turned out at Àth shean*, 14 an t-Samhain, GE 2,378.

31. ← Follows from *Sileas Bhàn and the hungry years*, 9 an Gearran, GE 1,927.

32. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

33. ← Follows from *Lachlann born on An Cnoc Ruadh*, 5 an t-Sultain, GE 2,360.

34. ← Follows from *Beasag's household settles east of the vein*, 12 an Cèitean, GE 2,379.

- 15 AM MÀRT, GE 2,391** — *Calum Ciar stands where an heir stands* (Dùn ìseal). In the first sharing of his mother's own holding, Calum Ciar stands a pace behind Eilidh Ghlas's shoulder at the bank, and the ford takes notice of him for the first time. No one at Dùn ìseal afterward looks for another heir.³⁶
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,393** — *Eilidh weighs the old custom of the valleys* (Dùn ìseal). Eilidh Ghlas turns over, without acting on it, a custom she learned as a girl in the near valleys: that a household with two sons sometimes sends the younger to be raised at another hearth, so that he grows up loved rather than waiting on an inheritance not his.³⁷
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,394** — *The younger son born in a high river spring* (Dùn ìseal). A second son is born to Eilidh Ghlas at Dùn ìseal in a wet spring, when the river at Àth shean runs high enough to float the ford-stones. No reciter keeps his day, and none ever will.
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,400** — *Eilidh Ghlas* (Dùn ìseal). Eilidh Ghlas, tenth of the Stone Kings, of the king's blood, sends her younger son to the Red Hill to be fostered, the first fostering in either list. The son's name is not kept; only that he went, and that the peace of the ford held while he was there.³⁸
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,400** — *A boy who does not ask to ride out* (Dùn ìseal). Eilidh's younger son, six years old, watches his brother ride out with the men to renew the boundary stones and does not ask to go. His mother watches him a long while from the hall door and tells her steward that a house with only one door out of it is no house for a second son.³⁹
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,400** — *Word sent west to An Cnoc Ruadh*⁴⁰ (Dùn ìseal). Eilidh Ghlas sends word to Lachlann Ruadh, holder of An Cnoc Ruadh, asking that he take her younger son to be raised in his household. She gives it out as a mother's wish that the boy learn a trade of his own; the ford's peace is served by it besides.⁴¹
- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,400** — *Calum Ciar counts the miles at the gate* (Dùn ìseal). On the morning his brother leaves for An Cnoc Ruadh⁴², Calum Ciar stands long at the gate after the party is out of sight, and tells a groom who asks him in out of the wind that he is only counting how many days fifty miles there and back will take.⁴³

35. ← Follows from *A household turned out at Àth shean*, 14 an t-Samhain, GE 2,378.

36. ← Follows from *Peigi born on An Cnoc Ruadh*, 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,385.

37. ← Follows from *Calum Ciar stands where an heir stands*, 15 am Màrt, GE 2,391.

38. → Caused by *Eilidh Ghlas takes up the hill*, 14 an Gearran, GE 2,390; → Caused by *The younger son born in a high river spring*, 30 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,394; ← Leads to *A boy who does not ask to ride out*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400; ← Leads to *Word sent west to An Cnoc Ruadh*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400; ← Leads to *Calum Ciar counts the miles at the gate*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400; ← Leads to *Eilidh's parting at Àth shean*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400.

39. ← Follows from *Eilidh Ghlas*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400.

40. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

41. ← Follows from *Eilidh Ghlas*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400.

42. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,400** — *Eilidh's parting at Àth shean* (Àth shean). Eilidh Ghlas walks with her son's party as far as Àth shean and kneels to his height at the turning of the roads, telling him he is not sent for any wrong of his, that An Cnoc Ruadh⁴⁴ will be as much home to him as Dùn ìsail, and that she means to see him grown.⁴⁵
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,400** — *A mound left untouched on Rathad an t-Salainn*⁴⁶. On the road west, the household man Donnchadh stops before a low green mound and will go no nearer to it, telling the boy only that it is older than the road and the salt trade. A wise traveller, he is told, lets such places lie as he lets a wasp's nest lie.⁴⁷
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,400** — *Rionach's saying of the forked river* (Àth shean). Turning off Rathad an t-Salainn⁴⁸ for her own kin at Àth shean, Rionach tells the fosterling that a household not his own by birth is no loss to him but a doubling, as a forked river becomes two whole rivers rather than two lesser ones.⁴⁹
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,400** — *The fosterling comes to An Cnoc Ruadh*⁵⁰ (Cathair dhearg). Eilidh Ghlas's younger son comes down to the western lake shore at evening and is met at the gate by Lachlann Ruadh and his daughter Peigi, who tells her father plainly that he is too thin and will need feeding, and carries in his one bundle herself.
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,400** — *Lachlann forbids the naming of a king's son* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann Ruadh tells his household that the fosterling shall be called no king's son and no king's grandson, but a boy of the ford's people come to learn a trade, and warns his daughter Peigi he will hear of it if she names him otherwise again.
- 25 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,401** — *Lachlann Ruadh takes the fosterling* (Cathair dhearg). Lachlann Ruadh, holder of the Red Hill, takes the son of Eilidh Ghlas into his house. For it he is named Lachlann an Altraim, 'Lachlann of the fostering', and the Red Hill list calls him so more often than by his own name.⁵¹
- 29 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,401** — *Calum Ciar given the boundary stones* (Dùn ìsail). Calum Ciar is given the judging of the near valleys' boundary stones, the first trust of its kind laid on him, and settles a dispute between two herders over a shifted marker with a plainness his mother is said to have approved of.⁵²

43. ← Follows from *Eilidh Ghlas*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400.

44. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

45. ← Follows from *Eilidh Ghlas*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400.

46. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

47. ← Follows from *Eilidh's parting at Àth shean*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400.

48. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

49. ← Follows from *A mound left untouched on Rathad an t-Salainn*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400.

50. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

51. → Caused by *The fosterling comes to An Cnoc Ruadh*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400; → Caused by *Lachlann forbids the naming of a king's son*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400.

52. ← Follows from *Lachlann forbids the naming of a king's son*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400.

30 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,401 — *The fosterling first put out on the lake* (Cathair dhearg).

The fosterling is let out on Loch chrom in a boat for the first time, and comes back to An Cnoc Ruadh⁵³ wet through and pleased with himself, word of it carried east along Rathad an t-Salainn⁵⁴ to Dùn iséal by the carriers who walk it.⁵⁵

31 AM MÀRT, GE 2,402 — *Eilidh Ghlas visits An Cnoc Ruadh*⁵⁶ (Cathair dhearg). Eilidh

Ghlas comes to An Cnoc Ruadh as Lachlann Ruadh's guest and sits at his own board four days, asking after the tallies and the weather as she asks after her son. Walking with her son to the western point of the lake, she tells him she will not come again for some years.⁵⁷

26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,402 — *The fosterling rakes salt without breaking the crust* (Cathair dhearg).

Lachlann Ruadh puts a salt-rake into the fosterling's hands on the drying platform above Loch chrom and shows him the turn of the wrist his own family has kept for generations. By the fourth stroke the boy lifts a clean sheet of crust whole, and Peigi Dhubh tells him it is better than she managed her own first year.⁵⁸

25 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 2,402 — *An Cnoc Ruadh*⁵⁹ *list begins to call Lachlann of the fostering*

(Cathair dhearg). In these years An Cnoc Ruadh's reciters take up the habit of naming Lachlann Ruadh also Lachlann an Altraim, Lachlann of the fostering, until in time the second name is given by the list where the first once stood, and is never afterward unsaid.⁶⁰

24 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,403 — *Beathag gives up the list of the slab's turns* (Tobar dhìreach).

Beathag, who has kept the household order of the slab's night watch eleven years, says at the Samhain gathering that she will keep the list no longer, after a household comes two nights running to a turn already missed. Thirty-one households now stand on it, too many for one memory to hold true.

30 AM MÀRT, GE 2,403 — *The families agree to choose the slab's keeper by lot* (Tobar dhìreach).

At the slab's own clearing the families of Tobar dhìreach and the near valleys meet to settle the watch. An old man of the gathering proposes a single keeper chosen by lot, to hold the slab until death or infirmity, rather than turns by household. No vote is taken; the silence that follows is read as agreement.

26 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,403 — *Oighrig, first keeper by lot* (Tobar dhìreach). The families

who watch the slab agree to choose one keeper at a time by lot, and no longer to take turns by household. The first lot falls to a woman called Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill, and she keeps the slab for the rest of her life.⁶¹

53. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

54. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

55. ← Follows from *Calum Ciar given the boundary stones*, 29 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,401.

56. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

57. ← Follows from *Eilidh Ghlas*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400.

58. ← Follows from *Eilidh Ghlas visits An Cnoc Ruadh*, 31 am Màrt, GE 2,402.

59. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

60. ← Follows from *Lachlann Ruadh takes the fosterling*, 25 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,401.

61. → Caused by *Beathag gives up the list of the slab's turns*, 24 am Faoilleach, GE 2,403; → Caused by *The families agree to choose the slab's keeper by lot*, 30 am Màrt, GE 2,403; ← Leads to *The lot falls to Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill*, 26 an t-Samhain, GE 2,403.

26 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,403 — *The lot falls to Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill* (Tobar dhìreach).

At the next full dark, thirty-one households send one member each to draw from a bag of thirty pebbles and one marked white. The lot falls to Oighrig, a herder's daughter of three-and-thirty, who carries the marked stone in her belt from that night for the rest of her life.⁶²

24 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,403 — *Oighrig's father speaks of the shared name* (Tobar dhìreach).

Walking home from the drawing, Oighrig's father Dòmhnall, a herder of the near slopes with no kinship to Rìghrean na Cloiche⁶³, tells her she will spend the rest of her keeping answering travellers who mistake her for blood of Dòmhnall Clachach, the second of that name to hold the north.⁶⁴

28 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,404 — *The keepers' house* (Tobar dhìreach). A house is built beside

the slab at Tobar dhìreach for the holder of the lot, its door facing the stone. It is rebuilt on the same footing many times. It is the first building on Dia-thìr made only to be near the vein.⁶⁵

28 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,404 — *Taigh na Lice*⁶⁶ *raised at Tobar dhìreach* (Tobar dhìreach).

The families of the near valleys build Oighrig a house on the clearing's edge above the slab, its door set to face the stone and no other way, the first building on Dia-thìr raised for no reason but to stand near the vein.⁶⁷

20 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,404 — *Oighrig sits her first winter alone by the slab* (Tobar dhìreach).

Moved into the new house at the first hard frost, Oighrig finds the keeper's long unbroken watch harder than any turn shared with her own household, and begins to notice things about the stain and the stone's temper that a thousand years of turned watches had never set down.⁶⁸

29 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,405 — *The stone cup* (Tobar dhìreach). Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill

has a cup ground out of grey stone to the size of her own cupped hand, that the handful of coal may be the same for every household. The cup is carried round the hill settlements. Whether it outlasts the age is not known.⁶⁹

29 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,405 — *Oighrig comes to Niocol Snaidhear with her cupped hand*

(Tobar dhìreach). In her third year of keeping, Oighrig goes to the stone-worker Niocol Snaidhear and sets her own hand on his bench, cupped as for water, asking for a cup of grey stone that will hold exactly what it holds, so that no household's handful of coal runs bigger than another's by the accident of whose palm measures it.⁷⁰

62. ← Follows from *Oighrig, first keeper by lot*, 26 an t-Samhain, GE 2,403.

63. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

64. ← Follows from *The lot falls to Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill*, 26 an t-Samhain, GE 2,403.

65. ← Leads to *Taigh na Lice raised at Tobar dhìreach*, 28 an Dàmhair, GE 2,404.

66. the house of the slab at Tobar dhìreach

67. ← Follows from *The keepers' house*, 28 an Dàmhair, GE 2,404.

68. ← Follows from *Taigh na Lice raised at Tobar dhìreach*, 28 an Dàmhair, GE 2,404.

69. ← Leads to *Oighrig comes to Niocol Snaidhear with her cupped hand*, 29 an t-Sultain, GE 2,405; ← Leads to *The first two stone cups crack in the grinding*, 29 an t-Sultain, GE 2,405.

70. ← Follows from *The stone cup*, 29 an t-Sultain, GE 2,405.

- 29 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,405 — *The first two stone cups crack in the grinding* (Tobar dhìreach). Niocol Snaidhear loses a first cup to a hidden vein in the stone and a second to a hair-crack struck too hard near its finishing, and keeps the flawed second on his bench through the grinding of the third as a thing to learn the shape of a mistake by.⁷¹
- 29 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,406 — *Niocol finishes the cup ground to Oighrig's hand* (Tobar dhìreach). After eleven sittings across two summers, Niocol Snaidhear finishes a cup of grey stone fitted to Oighrig's hand, veined faintly white, holding exactly what her two cupped hands together cannot quite hold. She says the hand it copies is not her own but the hand of every hearth; Niocol begins a second cup as a copy before he is asked.⁷²
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,406 — *Word of the stone cup travels the near valleys* (Àth gharbh). News of Oighrig's cup and the trouble it answers reaches stone-workers at three other places within the year: a woman at Àth gharbh, an old man at Achadh dhìreach, and a household at Cnoc chaol, each asking to grind a copy against it.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,407 — *The stone cup copied* (Cnoc chaol). Copies of the keeper's cup are ground at Àth gharbh, Achadh dhìreach and Cnoc chaol, each tried against the first by filling it with water. Thereafter the hill settlements measure the coal with one measure.⁷³
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,407 — *Oighrig carries the first cup to Àth gharbh, Achadh dhìreach and Cnoc chaol* (Àth gharbh). Oighrig walks the near valleys over a year with the first cup wrapped in wool, testing each new copy against it by pouring water from one to the other on a flat stone, and sending two cups at Achadh dhìreach and one at Cnoc chaol back to the wheel when the levels do not match.⁷⁴
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,407 — *The four cups are ground true at Àth gharbh, Achadh dhìreach and Cnoc chaol* (Àth gharbh). The copies of the stone cup are finished: quickest at Àth gharbh, where the worker measures against Niocol's cup throughout rather than a hand alone; slowest at Achadh dhìreach, an old man's hands steadied by his grandson through the last evenings; and, despite two false starts, fastest of all begun at Cnoc chaol.⁷⁵
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,408 — *The meeting of the cups* (Coinneachadh nan Cupan⁷⁶). The keeper's cup and its three copies are carried to a spring on the moor between Àth gharbh and Tobar dhìreach, set side by side on a flat stone and filled from the spring in turn. The place is called Coinneachadh nan Cupan, the meeting of the cups. The hill settlements return to it whenever a cup is broken and a new one must be tried.⁷⁷

71. ← Follows from *The stone cup*, 29 an t-Sultain, GE 2,405.

72. ← Follows from *The stone cup*, 29 an t-Sultain, GE 2,405.

73. → Caused by *Word of the stone cup travels the near valleys*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,406; ← Leads to *Oighrig carries the first cup to Àth gharbh, Achadh dhìreach and Cnoc chaol*, 31 an Lùnastal, GE 2,407; ← Leads to *The four cups are ground true at Àth gharbh, Achadh dhìreach and Cnoc chaol*, 31 an Lùnastal, GE 2,407.

74. ← Follows from *The stone cup copied*, 31 an Lùnastal, GE 2,407.

75. ← Follows from *The stone cup copied*, 31 an Lùnastal, GE 2,407.

76. the meeting of the cups

77. ← Leads to *Coinneachadh nan Cupan on the moor*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,408; ← Leads to *The hills measure the coal with one measure*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,408.

28 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,408 — *Coinneachadh nan Cupan*⁷⁸ on the moor. At a nameless spring on the moor between Àth gharbh and Tobar dhìreach, chosen because it lies equal walking from all four places and belongs to no one household, the four keepers of the cups fill each from the same water on a flat stone and pass every cup down the line for each hand to weigh. The water stands level in all four; the place is called from that morning Coinneachadh nan Cupan.⁷⁹

28 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,408 — *The hills measure the coal with one measure* (Tobar dhìreach). From the year of Coinneachadh nan Cupan⁸⁰, the households from the slopes above Tobar dhìreach to the poor ground of Cnoc chaol measure their handful of the vein's coal by the one cup and its three copies, and not by the hand that happens to do the measuring, a change the reciters afterward give no more than a single line.⁸¹

31 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,408 — *Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill dies keeping the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill keeps the slab for the rest of her life, as the lot gave it her, and that rest is shorter than anyone at the clearing looked for: she dies in Taigh na Lice⁸² in the winter after Coinneachadh nan Cupan⁸³, and the families ask that a new lot be drawn.⁸⁴

2 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,409 — *Gilleasbuig Beag takes coal* (Eilean chrom). A keeper by lot, Gilleasbuig Beag, is found with a basket of broken coal from the vein in his own house. The households of the hills sit in judgement at the slab, row him out to Eilean chrom, and leave him there without a boat. He is the first known to be exiled for the vein.

10 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,409 — *The lot falls to Gilleasbuig Beag* (Tobar dhìreach). The bag of pebbles is filled again and passed among the households near the crack. The white stone comes out in the hand of Gilleasbuig Beag, a broad, quiet man known for mending roofs and cutting hazel, who goes pale rather than glad at what his open hand shows.⁸⁵

10 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,409 — *A basket found under the bed-place* (Tobar dhìreach). A kinswoman of Gilleasbuig, in his house on another errand, lifts a cloth expecting food and finds a basket of broken coal from the vein, more than any hand is owed by the handful. She says nothing that day, but tells her husband before she sleeps, and within three days the near valley knows.⁸⁶

78. the meeting of the cups

79. ← Follows from *The meeting of the cups*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,408.

80. the meeting of the cups

81. ← Follows from *The meeting of the cups*, 28 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,408.

82. the house of the slab at Tobar dhìreach

83. the meeting of the cups

84. ← Follows from *Oighrig, first keeper by lot*, 26 an t-Samhain, GE 2,403.

85. ← Follows from *Oighrig, first keeper by lot*, 26 an t-Samhain, GE 2,403.

86. ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig Beag takes coal*, 2 an Lùnastal, GE 2,409.

- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,409** — *Gilleasbuig does not deny it* (Tobar dhìreach). Called to the clearing, Gilleasbuig Beag owns the basket at once and says he took the coal against a hard winter, for an old mother who sleeps cold, and for no other use. He asks, when the judgement is given, what the stone gains by the coal's return that his mother does not lose by going without it.⁸⁷
- 19 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,409** — *The families judge Gilleasbuig by silence* (Tobar dhìreach). The households argue long in the cold before an old woman of Cnoc chaol says what none of the near families will say first: that the vein was never any one hearth's to keep behind a cloth, however true the love that took it. The clearing's silence, held past any voice rising to answer it, stands as the judgement.⁸⁸
- 25 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,409** — *Gilleasbuig Beag rowed to Eilean chrom*. Three men of the near households row Gilleasbuig Beag out to Eilean chrom and put him ashore, then pull back to open water and leave him without a boat to return in. He is the first anyone remembers exiled for the vein.⁸⁹
- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,409** — *A fire seen three nights on Eilean chrom*. The near coast watches a small fire on Eilean chrom's low rise the first night, smaller the second, and a coal's worth of red at dusk the third, gone before full dark. No fire is seen there again, and no boat is sent to learn why.⁹⁰
- 12 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,409** — *The basket set inside Taigh na Lice*⁹¹ (Tobar dhìreach). The kinswoman who found the coal carries the basket to Taigh na Lice at Tobar dhìreach and sets it under its cloth just inside the door. No household proposes burning it; it was not theirs to burn before Gilleasbuig took it, and the judgement has settled that it never will be.
- 21 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,409** — *The lot falls to Giorsal Bhàn* (Tobar dhìreach). A new lot is drawn from the same bag that gave the stone to Oighrig and then to Gilleasbuig, and this time it is Giorsal Bhàn's hand that opens on the white pebble. She closes her hand on it and says she will keep it, and moves into Taigh na Lice⁹² before the month is out.⁹³
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,411** — *The coal returned to the crack* (Tobar dhìreach). The coal from Gilleasbuig Beag's house is neither burned nor kept. The keeper after him carries it back to the slab and lays it beneath, piece by piece. The tellings make much of it: the coal went home.⁹⁴

87. ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig Beag takes coal*, 2 an Lùnastal, GE 2,409.

88. ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig Beag takes coal*, 2 an Lùnastal, GE 2,409.

89. ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig Beag takes coal*, 2 an Lùnastal, GE 2,409.

90. ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig Beag takes coal*, 2 an Lùnastal, GE 2,409.

91. the house of the slab at Tobar dhìreach

92. the house of the slab at Tobar dhìreach

93. ← Follows from *Oighrig, first keeper by lot*, 26 an t-Samhain, GE 2,403.

94. → Caused by *The basket set inside Taigh na Lice*, 12 an t-Samhain, GE 2,409; ← Leads to *Giorsal lays the coal back under the slab*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,411; ← Leads to *"The coal went home"*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,411.

- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,411 — *Giorsal lays the coal back under the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). On a still morning near the year's turn, Giorsal Bhàn kneels at the slab's lower edge and presses the broken coal back into the gap between stone and earth, piece by piece, returning a second day to finish it, until the basket holds nothing at all.⁹⁵
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,411 — *"The coal went home"* (Tobar dhìreach). By the summer after Giorsal Bhàn empties the basket into the slab's edge, the four words are already going round the near valley as if they had always been there: that the coal went home. No one near the crack can afterward say who spoke them first.⁹⁶
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,411 — *Eilean chrom left to itself*. The island stands ungrazed and unfished through the years after Gilleasbuig Beag's exile. Children of the near coast are told not to ask about the island with the spring on it, and are given the same short answer when they ask anyway.⁹⁷
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,412 — *Calum Ciar asks for the lot* (Dùn ìseal). Calum Ciar, the elder son of Eilidh Ghlas and eleventh of the Stone Kings, asks that the keeper's lot be drawn at Dùn ìseal in his sight. The households at the slab refuse him. The list sets down the refusal, which is more than it sets down of most things.⁹⁸
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,412 — *Calum Ciar comes to the clearing* (Tobar dhìreach). Calum Ciar, elder son of Eilidh Ghlas and eleventh to hold Dùn ìseal under the king, walks up the valley to the slab and asks that the next lot be drawn at Dùn ìseal in his own sight, so the hill may see the vein's lot drawn as honestly as the hill's own.⁹⁹
- 4 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,412 — *The families refuse Calum Ciar* (Tobar dhìreach). The households near the crack answer Calum Ciar with the same held silence they gave Gilleasbuig Beag: the lot has been drawn at the slab since the custom began and will go on being drawn there, in the sight of whoever near the crack cares to watch. Calum Ciar thanks them and does not argue it.¹⁰⁰
- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,413 — *Calum Ciar puts the question to the king*. At the ford that summer, Calum Ciar carries the same question to the king. The king hears him without anger or haste and says only that the slab is older than the hill, and older than the grove of his own crowning, and that he will not overrule so old a thing for the asking of a man not two hundred years in the world.
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,416 — *The kings and the keepers* (Dùn ìseal). After the refusal of Calum Ciar the lot is still drawn at the slab. The holders of the hill rule the grazing and the gatherings under the king, but not the vein, and the king does not overrule the slab. The line between the two holds for the rest of the age. It is not yet written anywhere.¹⁰¹

95. ← Follows from *The coal returned to the crack*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,411.

96. ← Follows from *The coal returned to the crack*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,411.

97. ← Follows from *Gilleasbuig Beag takes coal*, 2 an Lùnastal, GE 2,409.

98. ← Leads to *Calum Ciar comes to the clearing*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,412; ← Leads to *The families refuse Calum Ciar*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,412.

99. ← Follows from *Calum Ciar asks for the lot*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,412.

100. ← Follows from *Calum Ciar asks for the lot*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,412.

- 7 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,416** — *The line between hill and slab holds unwritten* (Dùn iséal). Calum Ciar goes home from the ford and asks nothing more of it. The hill rules the grazing and calls the gatherings, answering to the king for both; the keepers rule the vein, answering to no one the telling can name. The line is sworn to in no words either side writes down, and it holds.¹⁰²
- 1 **AN GEARRAN, GE 2,417** — *A' Ghaoth Dhubh*¹⁰³ (Cuan ruadh). A storm called A' Ghaoth Dhubh, the Black Wind, strips the thatch from every house on the east coast from Cuan ruadh to Ceann chiar. Of all storms it is the eldest whose name is kept.
- 8 **AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,417** — *The sharing holds after the Black Wind* (Ceann chiar). The settlements of the east coast feed the people of Cuan ruadh through a whole winter out of their shared surplus. None on that coast is known to die of hunger that season.
- 1 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,417** — *A' Ghaoth Dhubh*¹⁰⁴ *strips the east coast* (Cuan ruadh). A storm out of the south-east strikes before dawn with almost no warning, stripping the thatch from every roof between Cuan ruadh and Ceann chiar and driving three unhailed boats onto the rocks below the headland. No one of that coast dies in it, though many households lose stores, shelter and boats within a single day.¹⁰⁵
- 14 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,417** — *The coast's fishing fails before winter begins* (Cuan ruadh). Of Cuan ruadh's eleven boats, four are broken past mending and a fifth needs a new keel; granaries stand open to the sky along the whole stripped coast. A fishing that has never in memory failed outright fails that winter for want of boats and stores enough to work it.¹⁰⁶
- 5 **AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,417** — *The coast names the storm A' Ghaoth Dhubh*¹⁰⁷ (Cuan ruadh). The eldest of that coast, having no name ready when the storm struck, name it afterward for the ash-dark sky it leaves behind for three days. No reciter of the hill amends the name; every storm to strike that shore since is measured against it.¹⁰⁸
- 18 **AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,417** — *Inland valleys bear of the coast's ruin* (Cuan ruadh). A trader who meant to buy salt fish at Cuan ruadh finds instead a shore of broken boats and bare roof-trees, and carries word of it a day and more west to valleys that had never before troubled themselves over that coast's weather.¹⁰⁹

101. → Caused by *Calum Ciar puts the question to the king*, 19 an t-Samhain, GE 2,413; ← Leads to *The line between hill and slab holds unwritten*, 7 an Cèitean, GE 2,416.

102. ← Follows from *The kings and the keepers*, 7 an Cèitean, GE 2,416.

103. the Black Wind

104. the Black Wind

105. ← Follows from *A' Ghaoth Dhubh*, 1 an Gearran, GE 2,417.

106. ← Follows from *A' Ghaoth Dhubh*, 1 an Gearran, GE 2,417.

107. the Black Wind

108. ← Follows from *A' Ghaoth Dhubh*, 1 an Gearran, GE 2,417.

109. ← Follows from *The sharing holds after the Black Wind*, 8 an Giblean, GE 2,417.

- 14 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,417** — *The valleys send grain to Cuan ruadh unasked* (Cuan ruadh). Single households send what they can spare because a neighbour has already sent something, until the scatter of gifts grows too large for any one house to account for, and the valleys' holders agree to weigh and send it on by the count of mouths, as the sharing is kept at Dùn Ìseal, though none there had been taught the custom directly.¹¹⁰
- 2 AM MÀRT, GE 2,418** — *The beacon at Baile ìseal* (Taigh-solais Baile ìseal¹¹¹). A fire is built on the eastern cape where Taigh-solais Baile ìseal now stands, kept by the households of the coast in turn. It is lit to bring boats home in a storm, the tellings say, and not to warn them off.
- 10 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,418** — *The sharing reaches the east coast* (Cuan ruadh). Grain, salted meat and wool for roofing come down to Cuan ruadh through the winter on carts and cattle-backs, weighed by mouths and given without reckoning who at the coast has lost most. No household of that coast starves; the coast calls the custom only the bringing-in, or the help.¹¹²
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,418** — *Lileas begins to watch the dark return of the boats* (Cuan ruadh). One-and-twenty that hard winter, with her father's hand maimed and the household's boat unfit to swim, Lileas of Cuan ruadh spends idle hours on the shingle and comes to notice what the coast has never put into words: that a boat coming home after dark has nothing to steer the last stretch by but memory and the sound of the surf.¹¹³
- II AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,418** — *Lileas's household agrees to the fire* (Cuan ruadh). Lileas puts the keeping of a fire on the cape east of the village to her own household over a thin meal; her father, no longer trusting his maimed hand on a line, sees no harm in it and asks only that she carry the work herself.¹¹⁴
- 20 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,418** — *The eastern fire is first kept* (Cuan ruadh). Lileas and her younger brother carry driftwood and peat up the cape through a month of short winter days and build the fire in a stone-walled pit, driving flame and smoke seaward. She keeps it alone through nights that find no boat needing it, and more than one household of the village climbs the cape only to sit an hour with her.¹¹⁵
- 3 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,419** — *The beacon at Muileann bheag* (Taigh-solais Muileann bheag¹¹⁶). A second shore-fire is kept on the north coast, on the point where Taigh-solais Muileann bheag stands now. Under the tower the ash goes down through three yards of fire-reddened soil.

110. ← Follows from *The sharing holds after the Black Wind*, 8 an Giblean, GE 2,417.

111. the lighthouse at Baile ìseal

112. ← Follows from *The sharing holds after the Black Wind*, 8 an Giblean, GE 2,417.

113. ← Follows from *The beacon at Baile ìseal*, 2 am Màrt, GE 2,418.

114. ← Follows from *The beacon at Baile ìseal*, 2 am Màrt, GE 2,418.

115. ← Follows from *The beacon at Baile ìseal*, 2 am Màrt, GE 2,418.

116. the lighthouse at Muileann bheag

- 5 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,419 — *The beacon at Àth dhearg* (Taigh-solais Àth dhearg¹¹⁷). Households of the north-east coast keep a fire on the cape where Taigh-solais Àth dhearg now stands, and cut steps up to it from the shore. The steps are narrower than those at Seann Bhral, and less worn.
- 16 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,419 — *Word of the eastern fire travels the coast roads* (Cuan ruadh). Traders and travellers carry word of the fire on Cuan ruadh's cape along the roads faster than its own light could reach, and coasts that have suffered their own bad weather begin to want fires of their own.¹¹⁸
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,419 — *A fire is raised on the northern point*. On ground already scorched black by older shore-fires, the households of the hardest-running coast raise a fire that burns steadier from its first season, having Lileas's year of trial to learn by before laying their own wood.¹¹⁹
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,419 — *Seathan mac Pheadair keeps the north-eastern fire*. On the cape where the passage to the deeper water runs narrowest, a man named Seathan mac Pheadair takes up the keeping of a fire much as Lileas had, and cuts a stroke on a stone at its edge for every ship's light he sees pass safe by it.¹²⁰
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,420 — *The beacon at Tobar dhearg* (Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg¹²¹). A fire is kept for the boats of the south coast on the southern cape where Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg stands. With Baile chrom, Baile ìseal, Muileann bheag and Àth dhearg the coasts of the island are lit at five points.¹²²
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,420 — *The southern cape completes the five fires* (Tobar dhearg). Last of the four new fires and by every account the surest, the households of the southern cape raise theirs on a mound of stacked stone breast-high, clear of the spray. With the older fire on the Baile chrom headland, the coasts of Dia-thìr are now lit at five points.¹²³
- 28 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,420 — *A reciter names them the five fires* (Tobar dhearg). Before the southern mound is even finished, a reciter of that coast says that a boat lost off any shore of Dia-thìr now has a fire somewhere within its sight to steer toward, and names the five together the five fires, a name the coast keeps on every telling since.¹²⁴

117. the lighthouse at Àth dhearg

118. ← Follows from *The eastern fire is first kept*, 20 an t-Samhain, GE 2,418.

119. ← Follows from *The beacon at Muileann bheag*, 3 am Faoilleach, GE 2,419.

120. ← Follows from *The beacon at Àth dhearg*, 5 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,419.

121. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

122. ← Leads to *The southern cape completes the five fires*, 28 an Cèitean, GE 2,420; ← Leads to *A reciter names them the five fires*, 28 an Cèitean, GE 2,420.

123. ← Follows from *The beacon at Tobar dhearg*, 28 an Cèitean, GE 2,420.

124. ← Follows from *The beacon at Tobar dhearg*, 28 an Cèitean, GE 2,420.

- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,420** — *A boat is brought home to the eastern fire* (Cuan ruadh). Blown off its own water by a wind that will not hold steady, a boat out of a coast two villages north finds the coast of Dia-thir only by Lileas's fire, burning high on the cape with no house near it. The crew comes ashore whole, and Lileas tells the captain the fire is kept for whichever boat needs it, no more for him than for any other.¹²⁵
- 31 AM MÀRT, GE 2,421** — *The Sea-Watcher seen from Seann Skell* (Uilebheist na Mara¹²⁶). Four watchers on the north-western tower at Seann Skell see a back as long as three boats rise and go under off the point. It is the first sighting of the Sea-Watcher tied to a named place and a count of witnesses.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,421** — *Wreckage in the western water* (Spùinneadairean-mara). For a season planks of stitched boats, broken small, wash up along the western shore below the waters where raiders are afterwards seen. No bodies come with them, and no settlement on that coast lacks a boat.
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,421** — *The watchers see the long back in the water* (Seann Skell). Four men keeping the tower at Seann Skell watch a back long as three boats rise off the point in the failing light and go under without a sound. Their four tellings differ in every small particular but agree on the length and the silence.¹²⁷
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,421** — *Word of the sighting runs round the bay* (Seann Skell). The tale of the tower's watch grows a head and a neck by the time it has gone twice round the bay of Seann Skell, though the old women of that coast say only that the sea shows itself when it chooses and take no boat off the water for the telling.¹²⁸
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,421** — *Stitched planks come ashore south of Seann Skell* (Seann Skell). Through a season the wrack south of the tower gives up narrow stitched planks from more than one hull, shaped for open water and like nothing built on that coast, with not one scrap of cord, tool or bone to say what rode in them.¹²⁹
- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,421** — *No household will claim the wreck* (Seann Skell). Asked along the shore, no household admits to a boat of its own building broken among the planks, nor lacks a man, woman or child it cannot otherwise account for; the wreck stays a wreck with no name and no mourner.¹³⁰
- 9 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,421** — *Micheil Beag lays the planks against his wall* (Seann Skell). A fisherman of that coast, Micheil Beag, gathers the stitched wood along one wall and pieces two curved lengths of hull back into shape, finding boats narrower and longer in the beam than any the coast builds for its own close fishing.¹³¹

125. ← Follows from *The beacon at Baile iséal*, 2 am Màrt, GE 2,418.

126. the Sea-Watcher; lit. 'the monster of the sea'

127. ⇨ At the same time *The Sea-Watcher seen from Seann Skell*, 31 am Màrt, GE 2,421.

128. ← Follows from *The Sea-Watcher seen from Seann Skell*, 31 am Màrt, GE 2,421.

129. ⇨ At the same time *Wreckage in the western water*, 26 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,421.

130. ⇨ At the same time *Wreckage in the western water*, 26 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,421.

131. ⇨ At the same time *Wreckage in the western water*, 26 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,421.

- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,421** — *Anndra Breac comes to the wall of planks* (Seann Skell). Anndra Breac, a teller who has walked the western shore twenty years and more without a household of his own, hears Micheil Beag out and returns to look at the planking again by firelight more than once before the season turns.
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,421** — *Anndra shapes a fourth telling* (Seann Skell). Turning the planks and the tower's tale over through the winter, Anndra comes to think a boat lost whole but for its wood argues not a wreck close to shore but a crossing once made, long before any telling now kept remembers the making of it.
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,421** — *The coast bears him out without agreeing* (Seann Skell). Anndra tries the telling first on households that have fed him twenty years running; none of them denies it outright, and an old woman near Seann Skell tells him a tale a man cannot leave alone wants telling somewhere it will be properly heard.
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,422** — *Anndra Breac says 'we came'* (Fèill Muileann òg¹³²). At the ford gathering Anndra Breac, a teller of the western coast, recites a telling in which the people came to Dia-thìr over the sea. The households of the hills shout him down, and he is put out of the ford for the rest of his life. His telling is not kept; only the memory that he told it.¹³³
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,422** — *Anndra Breac tells the crossing at the ford*. At the yearly gathering, by the largest fire he can get a footing at, Anndra Breac tells a telling in which the hill-folk crossed the sea in boats once and lost more of themselves to the crossing than any telling now remembers.¹³⁴
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,422** — *The crowd shouts him down*. An old man of a hill household calls out that no teller says the hill-folk came from anywhere, for they were always here, and others take up the shout until Anndra's own voice can no longer be heard over the fire.¹³⁵
- 30 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,422** — *Every hearth of Dia-thìr closes to him*. No household strikes him and none needs to; by the roads home from the ford it is already understood that Anndra Breac is not to be fed at a hill hearth again, and by the following spring not one has.¹³⁶
- 19 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,422** — *The king laughs once and falls quiet*. Standing near enough his own fire to hear the telling, the king laughs low at some point in it those nearest him cannot agree on afterward, does not join the shouting nor still it, and is seen quiet the rest of that evening in a way his own kin know to read.¹³⁷

132. the fair at Muileann òg

133. → Caused by *Anndra Breac comes to the wall of planks*, 23 an t-Samhain, GE 2,421; → Caused by *Anndra shapes a fourth telling*, 30 an t-Samhain, GE 2,421; → Caused by *The coast bears him out without agreeing*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,421; ⇌ At the same time *Anndra Breac tells the crossing at the ford*, 29 an Giblean, GE 2,422; ⇌ At the same time *The crowd shouts him down*, 29 an Giblean, GE 2,422.

134. ⇌ At the same time *Anndra Breac says 'we came'*, 29 an Giblean, GE 2,422.

135. ⇌ At the same time *Anndra Breac says 'we came'*, 29 an Giblean, GE 2,422.

136. ← Follows from *Anndra Breac says 'we came'*, 29 an Giblean, GE 2,422.

137. ⇌ At the same time *Anndra Breac says 'we came'*, 29 an Giblean, GE 2,422.

- 15 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,422** — *The king will not choose between the tellings.* Asked afterward by a woman of his own kin whether the teller spoke true, the king answers only that he has heard many tellings of where his own people came from and has never troubled to choose one over another.¹³⁸
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,423** — *The doctrine said at the column* (Calbh Cnoc ghorm¹³⁹). After Anndra Breac, the saying cut on the column at Cnoc ghorm is spoken aloud at the opening of the ford gathering: we did not come; we were here. From this time it is said as a rule, and not only held as a belief.¹⁴⁰
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,423** — *The saying is spoken at the opening of the gathering.* The gathering at the ford opens for the first time with the saying of Calbh Cnoc ghorm¹⁴¹ spoken aloud before any business begins, we did not come, we were here, a thing said together from that year rather than kept only in each hearth's own quiet belief.¹⁴²
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,423** — *Anndra Breac walks south along the western strand* (Seann Skell). Seen once more below the tower at Seann Skell, walking the strand where the stitched planks still lie against Micheil Beag's wall, Anndra Breac walks on and does not look back; no teller of that coast claims to have fed, spoken to or buried him after.¹⁴³
- 25 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,424** — *The keepers of the Ros dhombhain rock* (Ros dhomhain). The tide-rock at Ros dhomhain passes to Seònaid Mhòr, who cuts her marks in pairs, one for high water and one for low. Her pairs can be read still. The keepers after her go back to single marks.
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,424** — *A third tide-rock at Inis thais* (Inis thais). Households at Inis thais cut their own high-water marks on the harbour rock, at the interval of Ros dhomhain. So three rocks are kept side by side. None tells why the interval is what it is.
- 19 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,424** — *Seònaid Mhòr cuts paired marks at Ros dhombhain* (Ros dhomhain). The keeper of the Ros dhomhain tide-rock takes to cutting two strokes for every tide instead of one, a mark for the water's highest reach and a shorter mark beside it for its lowest ebb, so that whoever reads the rock after her has the whole of the water's motion and not only its rising.¹⁴⁴
- 21 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,424** — *The spacing of the marks travels without its reasoning* (Inis thais). Households at Inis thais's own harbour, hearing only that Ros dhomhain's keeper cuts her marks at a certain interval, begin cutting their own high-water marks at that same spacing on a rock of their own, though none of them can say why that width and no other.

145

138. ← Follows from *Anndra Breac says 'we came'*, 29 an Giblean, GE 2,422.

139. the column at Cnoc ghorm

140. ⇔ At the same time *The saying is spoken at the opening of the gathering*, 21 an t-Sultain, GE 2,423.

141. the column at Cnoc ghorm

142. ⇔ At the same time *The doctrine said at the column*, 21 an t-Sultain, GE 2,423.

143. ← Follows from *Anndra Breac says 'we came'*, 29 an Giblean, GE 2,422.

144. ← Follows from *The keepers of the Ros dhombhain rock*, 25 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,424.

145. ← Follows from *A third tide-rock at Inis thais*, 20 an Dàmhair, GE 2,424.

- 26 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,424** — *Peigi Dhubh calls for a landing of laid stone* (Cathair dhearg). At the household's board, Lachlann Ruadh's daughter says plainly that a hill whose wealth now travels by water deserves better than an open shingle beach a winter tide can rearrange. Her father agrees, and the households of An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁴⁶ give a season's labour to the work.
- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,425** — *Ros dhombain grows* (Ros dhomhain). Ros dhomhain becomes the greatest settlement on the shores of Loch chrom, some sixty houses round the tide-rock. Its people fish now from boats and not from the shore.
- 23 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 2,425** — *The stone landing is set at the river-mouth* (Cathair dhearg). Course on course of quarried stone is laid where the fresh water of the lake meets the tide from the sea, until a boat can come alongside at any state of the water without a hand needed to haul it clear of the mud: An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁴⁷'s first way onto open water that does not depend on a beach's mercy.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,425** — *Lachlann Ruadh falls ill* (Cathair dhearg). A chill taken wading the shallows to right a boat settles in Lachlann an Altraim's chest and will not lift with the spring. He is five-and-sixty years old, an age An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁴⁸ reckons past complaint for a man who has spent his whole life wet to the knee in cold water.
- 26 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,425** — *Lachlann asks that the fostering be ended* (Cathair dhearg). On one of his last evenings Lachlann tells his daughter that a fostering kept a season too long stops being a kindness and becomes only a habit no one has ended, and asks her not to let her own fondness be the reason the peace of the ford goes one day longer without its proper marking.
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,425** — *Lachlann Ruadh dies at five-and-sixty* (Cathair dhearg). He dies in the hall he was born in, his daughter's hand in his own, the household gathered at the door with no closer claim on the bedside than the years they gave the hill. He held An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁴⁹ one-and-sixty years.
- 30 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,425** — *Peigi Dhubh holds An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁵⁰ at forty* (Cathair dhearg). She sits down at the board the morning after her father's burial and asks for the tallies before she asks for anything else. An Cnoc Ruadh's own steward says afterward that she keeps them straighter than her father ever did.
- 23 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,426** — *The Red Hill's harbour* (Cathair dhearg). The households of the Red Hill build a landing of laid stone at the river-mouth below the hill, where the harbour of Cathair dhearg is now. It is the Red Hill's first way onto the water, and by the lake and the Abhainn gheal to the sea.¹⁵¹

146. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

147. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

148. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

149. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

150. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

151. → Caused by *Peigi Dhubh calls for a landing of laid stone*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,424; → Caused by *The stone landing is set at the river-mouth*, 23 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,425.

- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,426** — *Peigi Dhubh of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Peigi Dhubh holds the Red Hill after Lachlann an Altraim. She sends the fostered son of Dùn ìseal home grown, with gifts of salt, and the peace of the ford holds a generation more.¹⁵²
- 23 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,426** — *Houses draw in round the rock and the landing* (Ros dhomhain). Boats from harbours further down the coast begin putting in at the new landing rather than carrying on to open beaches, and the scattered houses of that shore draw in closer round the tide-rock and the stone together until some sixty stand there, their people fishing now from boats of their own building.¹⁵³
- 31 AM MÀRT, GE 2,427** — *The foster-son returns* (Dùn ìseal). The son of Eilidh Ghlas comes home from the Red Hill to Dùn ìseal, bringing the salt-songs of the west. The Stone Kings' list gives him no name and no reign; he is remembered only as the one who went.
- 28 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,427** — *Peigi tells the fosterling he is to go home* (Cathair dhearg). Walking the new stone landing with him in the last light of an evening, Peigi says her father was right, and that she means to send him home before the year turns, with salt enough for a household to carry as gift and not as trade, so the hill of Dùn ìseal will know he is sent back with honour.¹⁵⁴
- 6 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,427** — *Seònaid Mbòr cuts a last pair of marks for him* (Ros dhomhain). On the evening before the train leaves, the keeper of the tide-rock cuts one more pair of marks at the rock's edge, though the tide calls for none, and will not say plainly what they are for beyond that the rock has marked every tide of his years there and should mark the last of them too.¹⁵⁵
- 2 AM MÀRT, GE 2,428** — *The first songs kept* (Baile ghorm). The salt-songs of the south and west are sung at the raking of the pans. They are the oldest songs on Dia-thìr whose words are said to survive: a refrain of four lines, which no one can now wholly construe.
- 14 AM MÀRT, GE 2,428** — *Bone pipes at Cnoc àrsaidh* (Cnoc àrsaidh). Pipes of hollow bird-bone, bored with four holes, are made in a house at the southern Cnoc àrsaidh near the panther road. They are the oldest instruments of the island.
- 29 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,428** — *The panthers turn back* (Imrich nam Pantar¹⁵⁶). The great cats come down the panther road near Imrich nam Pantar and turn back at the foothills without crossing. The hill-folk read it for a hard winter and store double. The winter is hard.

152. → Caused by *Lachlann Ruadh falls ill*, 19 an t-Sultain, GE 2,425; → Caused by *Lachlann asks that the fostering be ended*, 26 an t-Sultain, GE 2,425; → Caused by *Lachlann Ruadh dies at five-and-sixty*, 23 an t-Samhain, GE 2,425; → Caused by *Peigi Dhubh holds An Cnoc Ruadh at forty*, 30 an t-Samhain, GE 2,425.

153. ← Follows from *Ros dhombhain grows*, 26 an t-Ogmhios, GE 2,425.

154. ← Follows from *Peigi Dhubh of the Red Hill*, 21 an t-Sultain, GE 2,426.

155. ← Follows from *The keepers of the Ros dhombhain rock*, 25 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,424.

156. the panthers' crossing

- 4 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,428** — *Gilleonan bores the first bone pipes* (Cnoc àrsaidh). At Cnoc àrsaidh, Gilleonan bores four holes along a hollow bird-bone and finds a note he can raise and lower at will; children of three households gather to hear him play, the first instrument the island's tellers count as more than a horn blown flat.¹⁵⁷
- 5 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,428** — *Three cats turn back at the pass*. Watchers along Imrich nam Pantar¹⁵⁸ see three great cats, on three different days, halt at the throat of the highest pass and turn back south rather than finish the crossing every household's memory says they always finish.¹⁵⁹
- 14 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,428** — *The households along the road store double*. Reading the cats' turning for a kinder ground left behind and a harder winter ahead, the households nearest the pass lay in double against a season no cat that year would risk crossing into, and go short of nothing before the thaw.¹⁶⁰
- 23 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,428** — *Iain drives cattle onto Imrich nam Pantar*¹⁶¹ (Muileann bhàn). With the household's grazing run thin, Iain of Muileann bhàn takes four men and forty head of thin cattle up into the passes against the custom that keeps the crossing season's road clear of herds, meaning to bring them down fattened within the week.
- 28 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,428** — *The cattle lost in the passes* (Muileann bhàn). Herders from Muileann bhàn drive cattle into the passes out of season, against the custom of the crossing. The panthers take thirty head in a night, and the herders come down with nothing.¹⁶²
- 18 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,428** — *The foster-son of Dùn ìseal comes home* (Dùn ìseal). He walks Rathad an t-Salainn¹⁶³ east with a train of laden pack-beasts and three of An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁶⁴'s household, and comes in sight of the hill of Rìghrean na Cloiche¹⁶⁵ on the seventh evening, four-and-twenty years after he first walked the same road west at six years old.¹⁶⁶
- 6 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,428** — *Calum Ciar does not know his own brother* (Dùn ìseal). Meeting An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁶⁷'s train at the gate in his mother's stead, Calum Ciar asks the fosterling which of the household he might be, a lake wind and four-and-twenty years having left nothing in him his brother's eye could fasten on as kin.¹⁶⁸

157. ⇨ At the same time *Bone pipes at Cnoc àrsaidh*, 14 am Màrt, GE 2,428.

158. the panthers' crossing

159. ⇨ At the same time *The panthers turn back*, 29 an Giblean, GE 2,428.

160. ← Follows from *The panthers turn back*, 29 an Giblean, GE 2,428.

161. the panthers' crossing

162. → Caused by *Iain drives cattle onto Imrich nam Pantar*, 23 an Cèitean, GE 2,428.

163. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

164. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

165. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

166. ← Follows from *The foster-son returns*, 31 am Màrt, GE 2,427.

167. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

168. ← Follows from *The foster-son returns*, 31 am Màrt, GE 2,427.

- 4 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,428** — *Eilidh Gblas knows her son at the door* (Dùn ìseal). Carried out to the hall door, Eilidh speaks her younger son's name before he has said a word to tell her who he is, and weeps and holds him a long while before she lets even her elder son greet him in turn.¹⁶⁹
- 22 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,428** — *The salt refrain is sung at the pans of Baile ghorm* (Baile ghorm). At the fires of the salt-rakers he teaches, without meaning to teach anything, the four-line refrain sung at the crust on An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁷⁰'s own lake shore. An old raker keeps it whole from a single hearing, and it runs on afterward at the sea-shore pans in words An Cnoc Ruadh itself can no longer wholly construe.¹⁷¹
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,428** — *Rìghrean na Cloiche¹⁷²' list keeps him no name* (Dùn ìseal). When the reciters after Eilidh set down her reign and her sons, Calum Ciar takes his place among the holders as every holder before him; of the one who went to An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁷³ and came home grown, no year, no reign and no deed is written, and the list stands as if she bore only the one son.¹⁷⁴
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,428** — *The panthers take thirty head in the night*. On the fourth night a string of cats, the last and largest of that year's crossing, comes down on the herd; by first light thirty of the forty head are taken or scattered beyond finding.¹⁷⁵
- 28 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,428** — *Iain is lamed in the dark*. Throwing himself clear of a claw he never clearly sees, Iain twists his leg under him against a hidden stone; it sets crooked at the hip, and he walks from that winter with a stick and a roll to one side.¹⁷⁶
- 5 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,431** — *Baile dhombain cuts the first season's sign* (Baile dhomhain). The households of Baile dhomhain begin cutting a mark into every gatepost at the start of the crossing season and scraping it away at its close, the first mark the island's tellers know cut for a season rather than for any single event.
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,434** — *Caol bheag names its boats for the winds* (Caol bheag). The fishing households of Caol bheag fix the custom of naming each boat for the wind it is built to fish in, holding a boat unlucky under any other wind and never giving a drowned boat's name again.

169. ← Follows from *The foster-son returns*, 31 am Màrt, GE 2,427.

170. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

171. ← Follows from *The first songs kept*, 2 am Màrt, GE 2,428.

172. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

173. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

174. ← Follows from *The foster-son returns*, 31 am Màrt, GE 2,427.

175. ⇌ At the same time *The cattle lost in the passes*, 28 an Cèitean, GE 2,428.

176. ⇌ At the same time *The cattle lost in the passes*, 28 an Cèitean, GE 2,428.

- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,440** — *A wind-name is cut at Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). A cutter of that household sets one of Na h-Ochd Gaothan¹⁷⁷ names beside Seann-Dhaoine¹⁷⁸ own marks on the great boulder at Seann Chwen, choosing that stone, by his own word, because the name wanted a stone already old.
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,444** — *A family takes up the old burial ground unasked*. Kin new to that country begin clearing the thorn from the old burial ground's rows each spring though none of their own dead lie there, and within a few years every household near it has come to trust the keeping to them alone.
- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,447** — *The panther season kept at Baile dhombain* (Baile dhomhain). At Baile dhomhain in the south the households cut a sign on their gateposts at the start of the crossing season and scrape it off at its end. It is the first mark made on the island for a season.¹⁷⁹
- 13 AN GEARRAN, GE 2,447** — *The wind-stone at Seann Chwen* (Seann Chwen). One of the eight wind-names is cut in the Dia-thìreach manner on a boulder at the central Seann Chwen, over an older mark of the Seann-Dhaoine¹⁸⁰. In few places do the marks of the two peoples touch.¹⁸¹
- 14 AN GEARRAN, GE 2,447** — *Boats named for the winds* (Caol bheag). The fishing households of Caol bheag, who fish the north coast from the mouth of the Abhainn ghorm, name their boats for the winds they fish in. A boat named for the wrong wind is held unlucky, and the name of a boat that sinks is never given again.¹⁸²
- 14 AM MÀRT, GE 2,447** — *The Tuam keepers* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach¹⁸³). A family dwelling by Tuam Cnoc dhìreach takes on the clearing of thorn from the old graves. They bury none of their own there. They only keep it.¹⁸⁴
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,447** — *A grave at Tuam opened* (Tuam Cnoc dhìreach¹⁸⁵). Diggers laying a new row at Tuam Cnoc dhìreach break into a grave older than any they knew, lined with slabs cut in the manner of the Seann-Dhaoine¹⁸⁶. They close it and move the row, and none opens that grave again.¹⁸⁷

177. the eight named winds

178. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

179. ⇌ At the same time *Baile dhombain cuts the first season's sign*, 5 am Faoilleach, GE 2,431.

180. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

181. ⇌ At the same time *A wind-name is cut at Seann Chwen*, 8 an t-Samhain, GE 2,440.

182. ⇌ At the same time *Caol bheag names its boats for the winds*, 7 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,434.

183. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

184. ⇌ At the same time *A family takes up the old burial ground unasked*, 10 an Dàmhair, GE 2,444.

185. the mausoleum at Cnoc dhìreach

186. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

187. ⇌ At the same time *Diggers break into a slab-lined grave*, 12 an Giblean, GE 2,447.

- 12 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,447** — *Diggers break into a slab-lined grave.* Cutting a new row further back than any before it, the keepers' own diggers break into an older grave lined close with cut slabs in the manner of Seann-Dhaoine¹⁸⁸; they close it as carefully as they opened it and move the row a spear's length off.¹⁸⁹
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,447** — *No digger tries the older grave again.* The keeping family's eldest holds that a ground kept for the dead does not want its keepers asking after graves it was never given to keep, and no digger of that ground troubles the older grave a second time.¹⁹⁰
- 11 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,449** — *Pilgrims at Coille Naomh Muileann chiar*¹⁹¹ (Coille Naomh Muileann chiar). People begin to walk to the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar and sit a night at the line of the trees without entering. Their small fires, each of a single night, lie all along the edge.¹⁹²
- 11 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,449** — *Pilgrims begin sitting at Coille Naomh Muileann chiar*¹⁹³ (Muileann chiar). People from households that have never before walked so far begin coming singly and in pairs to sit a single night at the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar, keeping a small fire that burns out before morning, and go home saying only that the night leaves them quieter.¹⁹⁴
- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,450** — *Settlers from An Cnoc Ruadh*¹⁹⁵ *raise the first house at Cnoc bheag* (Cnoc bheag). Households come down from An Cnoc Ruadh to build at the edge of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁹⁶, taking timber only from the river's far side and never from the unclaimed wood, a line later marked by a row of unhewn stones.
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,451** — *A child lost in Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag*¹⁹⁷ (Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag). A child of the settlement at Cnoc bheag goes past the line of stones into Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag and is not found. The searchers stop at the stones, and the telling does not blame them.¹⁹⁸
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,451** — *A child of Cnoc bheag is lost past the stones.* A boy not yet seven goes missing near the line of stones at Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁹⁹'s edge; the settlement and its neighbours search three days into the wood without one sign of him.²⁰⁰

188. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

189. ⇌ At the same time *A grave at Tuam opened*, 12 an Giblean, GE 2,447.

190. ← Follows from *A grave at Tuam opened*, 12 an Giblean, GE 2,447.

191. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

192. ⇌ At the same time *Pilgrims begin sitting at Coille Naomh Muileann chiar*, 11 an Cèitean, GE 2,449.

193. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

194. ⇌ At the same time *Pilgrims at Coille Naomh Muileann chiar*, 11 an Cèitean, GE 2,449.

195. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

196. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

197. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

198. ⇌ At the same time *A child of Cnoc bheag is lost past the stones*, 9 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,451; ⇌ At the same time *Iain among the searchers who stop at the stones*, 9 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,451.

199. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

200. ⇌ At the same time *A child lost in Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag*, 9 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,451.

- 9 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,451** — *Iain among the searchers who stop at the stones.* Lame still from the passes, Iain of Muileann bhàn joins the search at Cnoc bheag and is the first to say aloud that a wood no household will fell or build nearer than its own river is not a wood that gives back what it takes; the searchers stop at the line of stones, and no teller lays the stopping at their door.²⁰¹
- 8 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,453** — *The first house at Cnoc bheag* (Cnoc bheag). Settlers from the Red Hill build at Cnoc bheag, near the edge of the forest. They take their timber from the far side of the river, and never from the unclaimed wood.²⁰²
- 6 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,455** — *The spring at Muileann ruadh* (Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh²⁰³). Pilgrims come in numbers to the warm springs at Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh, and a ring of shelters is built there. Here is set the eldest healing-tale of Dia-thìr: a herder came lame and walked home.²⁰⁴
- 6 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,455** — *Iain goes to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh*²⁰⁵. Seven-and-twenty years lame, and told by a neighbour of a warm water under the mountain that has eased other travellers' old hurts, Iain walks south on his stick and sits in the pool at first light, the heat working into the crooked hip as no binding ever had.²⁰⁶
- 6 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,455** — *Iain walks home whole; the cure-tale is set* (Muileann bhàn). Iain stays three days at the warm water and walks the road home to Muileann bhàn on his own two legs without the stick, in half the days the journey south had cost him; his own household, seeing him come up the rise, takes him at first for a stranger. The tale kept of it is the oldest cure the springs are told for: he came lame, and he walked home.²⁰⁷
- 28 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,457** — *The Hollow Man seen again* (Marbh-bheò²⁰⁸ Doire uaine). Two herders passing the Doire uaine hills after dark see a figure walk the ridge with no breath showing in the cold. They had no fire lit, and so, the telling says, they lived.²⁰⁹
- 28 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,457** — *Two herders see Marbh-bheò*²¹⁰ *on the ridge.* Caught by dark on the way home, two herders near Marbh-bheò's hills see a shape walk the ridge above them showing no breath in the bitter cold, though their own hangs white before them; they had lit no fire that evening, and so, the telling says, they lived.²¹¹

201. ⇌ At the same time *A child lost in Coille Naomb Cnoc bheag*, 9 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,451.

202. ⇌ At the same time *Settlers from An Cnoc Ruadh raise the first house at Cnoc bheag*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,450.

203. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

204. ⇌ At the same time *Iain goes to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh*, 6 an Lùnastal, GE 2,455; ⇌ At the same time *Iain walks home whole; the cure-tale is set*, 6 an Lùnastal, GE 2,455.

205. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

206. ⇌ At the same time *The spring at Muileann ruadh*, 6 an Lùnastal, GE 2,455.

207. ⇌ At the same time *The spring at Muileann ruadh*, 6 an Lùnastal, GE 2,455.

208. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

209. ⇌ At the same time *Two herders see Marbh-bheò on the ridge*, 28 an Cèitean, GE 2,457.

210. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

- 26 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,460** — *The covered hearth spreads* (Muileann chiar). The covered hearth, pit-dug and roofed, spreads from the Doire uaine hills to the settlements about Muileann chiar. From this comes the later rule that no open fire is lit on those slopes after dark.
- 30 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,460** — *Peigi Dhubh dies on An Cnoc Ruadb*²¹² (Cathair dhearg). Peigi Dhubh, who laid the stone landing and kept the tallies straighter than her father, dies on An Cnoc Ruadh in her seventy-sixth year, having held it five-and-thirty years; her boats go out the morning after her burying as she asked.²¹³
- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,460** — *The covered hearth spreads and the night rule hardens* (Muileann chiar). The pit-dug, stone-lidded hearth spreads from Marbh-bheò²¹⁴'s hills toward the settlements nearer Coille Naomh Muileann chiar²¹⁵, and it hardens there into a rule no council ever set: no open fire is lit on those slopes after dark.²¹⁶
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,462** — *Settlers at Caol mhòr* (Caol mhòr). Dia-thireach households settle at Caol mhòr in the north-west, on the strait where the Seann-Dhaoine²¹⁷ once hunted seal. They find the old middens and build on them.²¹⁸
- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,462** — *Caol mhòr's settlers set aside the marked midden stones* (Caol mhòr). Households raising walls from Seann-Dhaoine²¹⁹ shell midden at Caol mhòr will not turn a stone that carries a mark, cut or worn, and lay those aside in an unmortared line along the shore, so that two kinds of wall stand side by side there ever after.²²⁰
- 7 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,463** — *Somhairle walks the ground at Baile chrom* (Baile chrom). Somhairle finds the resettled fields at Baile chrom already byred and welled, and Donnchadh Ruadh shows him the old field-marks still standing half sunk beneath the new grass, ploughed by hands no household there now names aloud.
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,464** — *Settlers at Baile chrom in the north-west* (Baile chrom). Households from Cnoc ghorm settle again the ground at Baile chrom that the old hunger had emptied. They dig their storage pits deeper than any others on the coast.²²¹
- 18 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,464** — *The last thicket on Rathad an t-Salainn*²²² *is cut through* (Muileann àrsaidh). Carriers weary of the long way round cut through the last unbroken stand of thorn and birch on Rathad an t-Salainn to the north-west, so that Muileann àrsaidh stands a full day nearer the pans of Baile ghorm than it had ever stood before.

211. ⇨ At the same time *The Hollow Man seen again*, 28 an Cèitean, GE 2,457.

212. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

213. ← Follows from *Peigi Dhubh of the Red Hill*, 21 an t-Sultain, GE 2,426.

214. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

215. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

216. ⇨ At the same time *The covered hearth spreads*, 26 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,460.

217. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

218. ← Leads to *Caol mhòr's settlers set aside the marked midden stones*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,462.

219. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

220. ← Follows from *Settlers at Caol mhòr*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,462.

221. → Caused by *Somhairle walks the ground at Baile chrom*, 7 an Giblean, GE 2,463.

222. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,465** — *The first bank is turned east of the old workings* (Dùn thais). Settlers pushing toward the rising country dig a ditch and raise the spoil behind it at Dùn thais, a ring of earth built without any word sent from Dùn iséal and without any word sent back once it stood.
- 3 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,466** — *Muileann àrsaidh settled* (Muileann àrsaidh). Houses are built on the stream at Muileann àrsaidh in the north-west. Their flint comes from Cnoc àrsaidh, and their salt from the south, carried the length of the island.²²³
- 4 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,466** — *Fire clears the heavy ground at Achadh chaol* (Achadh chaol). Across three dry summers the households of Achadh chaol burn back the old scrub a field's width at a time and plough the black ground while the ash still holds its warmth, taking the first year a crop the older fields to the west had not equalled in a generation.
- 21 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,466** — *The last course is set on Cuan ruadh's wall* (Cuan ruadh). The households of Cuan ruadh finish laying stone to the eaves the whole circuit of the settlement, the first roofs on that coast built to stand against wind rather than merely to be raised again once it has passed.
- 31 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,467** — *A well is opened within Cathair fhada's bank* (Cathair fhada). Cathair fhada digs and lines a well inside its own earthwork, so that a household need not send its water-carriers down to the shore while a storm still has teeth in it.
- 5 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,468** — *The salt road to the north-west* (Muileann àrsaidh). A salt road runs from the pans of Baile ghorm by the ford gathering to the north-west. At Muileann àrsaidh the salt costs three times its price at the pans, and is paid for in flint and seal-skins.²²⁴
- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,468** — *Caol ruadh's fishers mark the strait's channels* (Caol ruadh). The fishers of the narrow strait take to tying woven buoys over the deep channels where the current runs hardest, a small custom that spreads along the coast in a carrier's mouth the way the paired tide-marks spread before it.
- 26 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,470** — *Doire ghlas settled* (Doire ghlas). Households settle under the oaks at Doire ghlas in the north. The settlement grows in rings, each built outside the last as the wood is cleared back.²²⁵
- 26 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,470** — *Households come down to Doire ghlas* (Doire ghlas). Families out of the near valleys settle in the grove where the king kept his seven nights, drawn by its shelter and its old cleared paths, and mark timber in the oaks themselves for the first of their new byres.²²⁶

223. → Caused by *The last thicket on Rathad an t-Salainn is cut through*, 18 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,464.

224. → Caused by *The last thicket on Rathad an t-Salainn is cut through*, 18 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,464.

225. ← Leads to *Households come down to Doire ghlas*, 26 an Giblean, GE 2,470; ← Leads to *Sombairle asks the household to spare three oaks*, 26 an Giblean, GE 2,470.

226. ← Follows from *Doire ghlas settled*, 26 an Giblean, GE 2,470.

- 26 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,470** — *Somhairle asks the household to spare three oaks* (Doire ghlas). Finding the three oldest trunks of the grove marked for the axe, Somhairle asks Fearchar mac Ailig's household to take their roof-beams elsewhere, giving no reason beyond that his father once set six pots beneath those particular trees.²²⁷
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,471** — *The three oaks are spared* (Doire ghlas). The household cuts its beams instead from younger growth a short walk east and leaves the three old trunks standing at the centre of the new settlement, ringed within a generation by houses that call the place only the ring under the oaks.²²⁸
- 28 AM MÀRT, GE 2,473** — *The east settled at Dùn thais* (Dùn thais). The hill-folk push east and build a banked enclosure at Dùn thais, on a hill above good grazing. It is the first stronghold of the Dia-thìrch away from Dùn iséal and the Red Hill.²²⁹
- 27 AN GEARRAN, GE 2,475** — *Achadh chaol cleared* (Achadh chaol). Fields are cleared at Achadh chaol in the east by fire and by picking stones. The picked stones are laid in banks round each field, and those banks bound the fields still.²³⁰
- 18 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,475** — *Somhairle finds grey in his beard*. A cheese-seller on the road through the near valleys remarks on the grey coming into Somhairle's beard, and he finds at a still pool that she has told him true: the first lines his face has shown in two thousand four hundred and thirty-five years.²³¹
- 23 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,476** — *Beathan sees his father's face has changed*. Coming on Somhairle unexpectedly at the slab, Beathan stops in the doorway before he crosses it, having seen in his father's face the beginning of an ageing neither of them has yet spoken of aloud.²³²
- 29 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,477** — *Cuan ruadh rebuilt* (Cuan ruadh). Cuan ruadh, stripped by the Black Wind, is rebuilt in stone to the height of the eaves. It is the first settlement of the east coast to build its walls against the wind and not only the cold.²³³

227. ← Follows from *Doire ghlas settled*, 26 an Giblean, GE 2,470.

228. ← Follows from *Doire ghlas settled*, 26 an Giblean, GE 2,470.

229. → Caused by *The first bank is turned east of the old workings*, 28 an t-Sultain, GE 2,465.

230. → Caused by *Fire clears the heavy ground at Achadh chaol*, 4 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,466.

231. ← Follows from *The three oaks are spared*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,471.

232. ← Follows from *Somhairle finds grey in his beard*, 18 an t-Sultain, GE 2,475.

233. → Caused by *The last course is set on Cuan ruadh's wall*, 21 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,466.

THE YEARS GE 2,501 – 2,750

- 13 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,523** — *Cathair fhada on the south coast* (Cathair fhada). Cathair fhada is founded on the south coast, between the old Seann Dunn and Seann Chwen. It draws its water from a well the Seann-Dhaoine¹ dug, and never speaks of where the well came from.²
- 14 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,570** — *Caol ruadh on the southern strait* (Caol ruadh). Fishing households settle Caol ruadh on the south coast and take the cod of the strait on long lines. Their middens are the first on the south coast to hold more fish than shell.³
- 25 AM MÀRT, GE 2,601** — *Murchadh rides north to hold the plain*. The king sends his son Murchadh north with sixty households to hold the northern plain in his name, the first of the king's sons given ground beyond the settled valleys to keep rather than merely to pass through.⁴
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,616** — *Baile Mòr mhòr in the north* (Baile Mòr mhòr). Houses are built at Baile Mòr mhòr on the northern plain, round a spring that never freezes. At its height it has some eighty houses, a great place for the age.⁵
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,616** — *Baile Mòr mhòr rises round the spring that never freezes* (Baile Mòr mhòr). Murchadh raises his hall on a rise above a spring that runs clear through every winter, and the households of the plain name the place Baile Mòr mhòr before it has earned the size of the name; within four centuries it stands eighty houses, the largest place north of An Cnoc Ruadh.^{6,7}
- 22 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,635** — *Sheep-households settle Baile gharbh* (Baile gharbh). Households take up the stony ground north-east of Murchadh's spring, keep sheep where the land will bear nothing heavier, and send their wool south along the coast road to Cruinneachadh an Àtha⁸ rather than north to Murchadh's own granary.
- 21 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,655** — *Baile fhiadhaich settled among the boar-thickets* (Baile fhiadhaich). Settlers build on the western coast where the boars run heaviest, hang tusks over their doors, and take boar for their chief meat; the island comes to know a man of that place by his gait, from a lifetime of walking ground a boar might break from underfoot.
- 15 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,662** — *Baile gharbh in the north-east* (Baile gharbh). Households settle the rough ground at Baile gharbh and live by sheep, not cattle. Their wool goes south along the coast to the ford gathering.⁹

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

2. → Caused by *A well is opened within Cathair fhada's bank*, 31 an Dàmhair, GE 2,467.

3. → Caused by *Caol ruadh's fishers mark the strait's channels*, 10 an t-Samhain, GE 2,468.

4. ← Follows from *Caol ruadh on the southern strait*, 14 an Giblean, GE 2,570.

5. ← Leads to *Baile Mòr mhòr rises round the spring that never freezes*, 13 an t-Sultain, GE 2,616.

6. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

7. ← Follows from *Baile Mòr mhòr in the north*, 13 an t-Sultain, GE 2,616.

8. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

9. → Caused by *Sheep-households settle Baile gharbh*, 22 an Giblean, GE 2,635.

- 19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,670** — *Cuan shean settled beside the old landing* (Cuan shean). Households take up a harbour beside a stone landing built by hands none of them can name, older than any wall near it, and use it as they find it rather than mend it, out of the caution settlers keep wherever Seann-Dhaoine¹⁰ work still stands.
- 18 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,703** — *Eithne nic Ailein is born*. A daughter is born to the king in the near valleys and named Eithne; she grows quicker of tongue than most of her father's blood troubles to be, and comes north, in time, to hold ground of her own rather than sit idle at any hearth.¹¹
- 17 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,709** — *Baile fhiadhaich on the west coast* (Baile fhiadhaich). Settlers build at Baile fhiadhaich on the western coast, where boars run in the thickets. They hang boar tusks over their doors, and boar is their chief meat for the rest of the age.¹²
- 16 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 2,720** — *The first of Murchadh's eleven sons is born*. The eldest of eleven sons is born to Murchadh over the better part of three centuries; each, coming of an age to want it, is given a corner of the plain to hold under his father rather than a place idle at his hearth.¹³

10. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

11. ← Follows from *Cuan shean settled beside the old landing*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,670.

12. → Caused by *Baile fhiadhaich settled among the boar-thickets*, 21 an Cèitean, GE 2,655.

13. ← Follows from *Eithne nic Ailein is born*, 18 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,703.

THE YEARS GE 2,751 – 3,000

- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,751** — *Dùn chrom is raised with its bank facing two ways* (Dùn chrom). Herders wanting the bank to face south and quarrymen wanting it to face north raise, between them, a single crooked earthwork that answers both wants at once and satisfies neither fully, and the bent fort stands from its first year with a name that fits it more ways than its builders meant.
- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,755** — *Cuan shean settled* (Cuan shean). Dia-thìreach households take up the harbour at Cuan shean on the west coast, beside an old landing of unknown builders, and use the landing without mending it.¹
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,780** — *Eilidh Ghlas dies* (Dùn ìseal). Eilidh Ghlas, who sent her younger son west to be raised and knew him at the door when he came home, dies in her seven hundred and thirtieth year; both her sons stand at her burying, and the list keeps only one of them.²
- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,790** — *Tobar dhearg rises round the red well* (Tobar dhearg). The keepers of a beacon on the southern cape build at last round a well whose water runs faintly red from the rock, and their settlement grows into the greatest place on that coast, its fire burning nightly for ships that have learned to watch for it.
- 7 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,801** — *Dùn chrom raised* (Dùn chrom). A banked hill-fort is raised at Dùn chrom in the midst of the island, between the Red Hill and the hills of the vein. Its bank faces both ways.³
- 10 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,802** — *The holders of Dùn chrom and Dùn thais quarrel over which way a bank should face* (Dùn chrom). Ruadhan Beag of Dùn chrom and the holder of Dùn thais fall into two winters of hard words over which way a bank ought to face, until Murchadh rides to hear them and leaves the ditch as it stands, finding a hundred years without an enemy a better argument than either holder makes against it.⁴
- 14 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 2,804** — *Beathan mac Shomhairle dies at Tobar dhìreach*. Beathan, son of Somhairle, who sat his nights at the slab since before Murchadh was born, dies in his two thousand two hundred and thirteenth year, the oldest death yet counted among the king's kin; the households of the north, hearing the number, begin for the first time to reckon what it may mean to outlive a holder's holder.⁵
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,847** — *Cathair mhòr below the old outpost* (Cathair mhòr). Households settle on the ground below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire⁶, where Cathair mhòr now stands. They take no stone from the ruin above them, though it is the nearest quarry.⁷

1. → Caused by *Cuan shean settled beside the old landing*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,670.

2. ← Follows from *Eilidh Ghlas*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,400.

3. → Caused by *Dùn chrom is raised with its bank facing two ways*, 14 an t-Sultain, GE 2,751.

4. ← Follows from *Tobar dhearg rises round the red well*, 11 an t-Samhain, GE 2,790.

5. ← Follows from *The holders of Dùn chrom and Dùn thais quarrel over which way a bank should face*, 10 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,802.

6. the watch-fort ruin

9 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,847 — *Eithne's households name the ground below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire*⁸ *Cathair mhòr* (Cathair mhòr). Settlers below a broken watch-tower ask Eithne, then a hundred and forty-four years old, to lay out their fields, and she stays; her households name the place Cathair mhòr, the great city, out of hope rather than size, and take no stone from the ruin above them.⁹

18 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 2,870 — *Households come to Cnoc naomh for its spring* (Cnoc naomh). Settlers take up a hill already called, by no teller then living able to say why, the holy hill, and keep its water and the fact of its holiness together without asking more of either.

19 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 2,890 — *Muileann naomh is founded on piles over the marsh* (Muileann naomh). The first houses of Muileann naomh stand on driven piles over standing marsh water between Tobar dhearg and the old Seann Skell, and are afterward moved to firm ground a bowshot inland once the piles prove the footing sound, keeping the name the marsh first gave them.

10 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,894 — *Cnoc naomh* (Cnoc naomh). Households come to settle on a hill for its spring, and the hill is already called Cnoc naomh, the holy hill. Why, is not known.¹⁰

8 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,900 — *The king takes back the western valleys from Murchadh*. After three hundred years in Murchadh's keeping, the king takes back the poorer western valleys of the northern plain and gives them to a grandson of An Cnoc Ruadh¹¹'s line, saying only that the ground had grown crowded enough to want a nearer hand; Murchadh does not argue it, and the plain stops speaking of it within the year.¹²

12 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,947 — *Tobar dhearg on the southern cape* (Tobar dhearg). The keepers of the beacon at Tobar dhearg build their settlement on the cape itself, round a well whose water runs reddish from the rock. It becomes the greatest place on the south coast.¹³

10 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 2,960 — *Calum Ciar dies at Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Calum Ciar, eleventh to hold Dùn ìseal under the king, dies in his seven hundred and eleventh year, having asked the slab for its lot once and never asked again; the king buries him on the hill beside his mother.¹⁴

24 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 2,986 — *Muileann naomh founded* (Muileann naomh). Muileann naomh is founded near the south coast, between the beacon at Tobar dhearg and the old Seann Skell. Its first houses stand on stilts over a marsh, and are afterwards moved to firm ground.¹⁵

7. ← Leads to *Eithne's households name the ground below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire Cathair mhòr*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,847.

8. the watch-fort ruin

9. ← Follows from *Cathair mhòr below the old outpost*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,847.

10. → Caused by *Households come to Cnoc naomh for its spring*, 18 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,870.

11. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

12. ← Follows from *Muileann naomh is founded on piles over the marsh*, 19 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,890.

13. → Caused by *Tobar dhearg rises round the red well*, 11 an t-Samhain, GE 2,790.

14. ← Follows from *Calum Ciar asks for the lot*, 4 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,412.

- 11 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 2,990** — *Diorbhail born at Tobar dhìreach* (Tobar dhìreach). A daughter is born to a household of the watch at Tobar dhìreach and named Diorbhail; she will say her own line back before she can tie a shoe, and carry Sloinneadh a' Chlachair¹⁶ after Somhairle.¹⁷
- 13 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 2,993** — *Diorbhail says her own line before she can tie a shoe* (Tobar dhìreach). A child of Tobar dhìreach not yet three years old says her line back four generations at her mother's fire, for the pleasure of the saying and not because she is asked, and the households of Na Glinn Àrda¹⁸ begin to remark on her the way a valley remarks on any child who does an ordinary thing early.
- 4 AN CÈITEAN, GE 2,997** — *Somhairle first sits Diorbhail by the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). Somhairle takes the seven-year-old Diorbhail up to the slab for a morning, on no more of an asking than that her mother has no need of her, and gives her the small tellings that ring the Line rather than the Line itself, holding that a thing given too soon to too young a head is given badly.
- 5 AN GIBLEAN, GE 2,999** — *The summons to An Cruinneachadh Mòr¹⁹ reaches the north*. Riders of the king's own household bring word to Baile Mòr mhòr that every holder of every share of the island is to come to a gathering at the ford of salt and wool greater than any before it; Murchadh sends word to his sons and to Eithne, and rides south himself with sixty of his household.
- 8 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,000** — *An Cnoc Ruadh²⁰'s salt-traders walk to An Cruinneachadh Mòr²¹* (Cathair dhearg). Word goes out along every road that Cruinneachadh an Àtha²² in the three thousandth year since the grove will be kept greater than any before it. Households of An Cnoc Ruadh's lake shore, among them An Cnoc Ruadh girl and her mother, walk the fourteen miles down with their salt wrapped against the damp.
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000** — *The great gathering at the ford* (Fèill Muileann òg²³). In the height of his days Ailean Mòr keeps a gathering at the ford of the salt and wool. The holders of the hill, the Red Hill, the salt shore, the north and the west set their hands in his. Some four hundred of his own blood stand about him, children and their children, more than the reciters can name in a night. Only the households east of the vein send no one.²⁴

15. → Caused by *Muileann naomb* is founded on piles over the marsh, 19 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,890.

16. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

17. ← Follows from *Muileann naomb* founded, 24 am Faoilleach, GE 2,986.

18. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

19. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

20. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

21. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

22. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

23. the fair at Muileann òg

- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000** — *The three grounds of the ford run together.* More households come in than the ford's three grounds, downstream, upstream and the rise beyond the river, were ever laid out to hold, until by the second morning no one can any longer say which bank belongs to whom, and a child sent for water is an hour finding her way back.²⁵
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000** — *Amber, pots and flint change hands at the ford.* Potters of the north-west, a stranger from the far west with strings of drilled amber, and carriers of eastern flint trade the first day of An Cruinneachadh Mòr²⁶ through, while households from opposite ends of the crowd sit down together to weigh what a marriage between their children might be worth.²⁷
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000** — *The reciters mark the three thousandth year since the grove.* An old reciter of the hill tells those at his fire that the year is the three thousandth since the grove was lit, and that word of the count has been carried out along every road that summer, drawing to the ford households who had never before troubled to send anyone to an ordinary gathering.²⁸
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000** — *The crowd opens for the king unbidden.* On the second morning the king comes down the hill road dressed as any herdsman, and the whole crowd between the road and the river opens a way for him without a word called, old people stepping back from the path with their eyes down as from nothing else at the gathering.²⁹
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000** — *An Cnoc Ruadh³⁰'s new holder is still called by his father's name* (Cathair dhearg). Among the five who wade out to put their hands between the king's, An Cnoc Ruadh's own holder is so newly come to his hall that half the crowd on the bank still names him for his father before catching themselves.³¹

24. → Caused by *The summons to An Cruinneachadh Mòr reaches the north*, 5 an Giblean, GE 2,999; → Caused by *An Cnoc Ruadh's salt-traders walk to An Cruinneachadh Mòr*, 8 an Dàmhair, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *The three grounds of the ford run together*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *Amber, pots and flint change hands at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *The reciters mark the three thousandth year since the grove*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *The crowd opens for the king unbidden*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *An Cnoc Ruadh's new holder is still called by his father's name*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *Somhairle stands nearest the king in the rings*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *Murchadh is pointed out among the king's blood*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *Eithne stands young-faced in the outer ring*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *The reciters reckon four hundred of the king's blood*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *A boy of the west asks whether it is one family*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *The east's absence is remarked and let go*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000; ← Leads to *An Cnoc Ruadh girl trails her hand in the warm ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

25. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

26. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

27. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

28. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

29. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

30. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

31. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000 — *Somhairle stands nearest the king in the rings.* Somhairle takes his place at the king's left hand in the river as the rings of the king's blood go in, two thousand nine hundred and sixty-two years old that summer and looking, those at the ford say afterward, every year of it.³²
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000 — *Murchadh is pointed out among the king's blood.* Murchadh, who holds the northern plain for his father and has by then eleven sons of his own scattered among the rings, is pointed out by name on the bank, a head taller than most beside him and looking, past his twelve hundredth year, no older than a young man.³³
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000 — *Eithne stands young-faced in the outer ring.* Eithne, not yet three hundred years old and looking a girl of twenty, stands laughing among the outer rings of the king's blood, named to the girl of An Cnoc Ruadh³⁴ by a woman of the ford who knows the lines by heart.³⁵
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000 — *The reciters reckon four hundred of the king's blood.* The naming of the king's children and their children runs from midday to sundown and is not finished when the light fails; word passes along the bank that the reciters have counted some four hundred of his blood standing in the river that day, more than at any gathering before it.³⁶
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000 — *A boy of the west asks whether it is one family.* A boy of a western household, standing beside An Cnoc Ruadh³⁷ girl at the bank while the naming goes on, asks her whether all of that in the water is truly one family, and neither child can find a plainer answer to give the other.³⁸
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000 — *The east's absence is remarked and let go.* Women of An Cnoc Ruadh³⁹ note at the fire that no household from east of the vein has come to the gathering a second year running, turn the matter over a little while without an answer, and let it go with the fine weather, unremembered again within the hour.⁴⁰
- 2 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,000 — *An Cnoc Ruadh⁴¹ girl trails her hand in the warm ford.* When the gathering has gone back to its fires and the king stands alone a while in the emptied ford at dusk, An Cnoc Ruadh girl, nearest the water of anyone left on the bank, finds it warm as bath-water round his legs and sees it smoke downstream of him in the last light.⁴²

32. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

33. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

34. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

35. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

36. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

37. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

38. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

39. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

40. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

41. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

42. ← Follows from *The great gathering at the ford*, 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,000.

THE YEARS GE 3,001 – 3,250

- 10 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 3,004** — *A basket-weavers' boy tries the slab and turns back to his creels* (Tobar dhìreach). A cousin of Diorbhail's goes up to the slab with her twice out of curiosity and finds he can make no sense of the names, choosing to learn the weaving of a creel that holds water instead. Neither thinks less of the other, and it stands as one more fact of the valleys: that the slab takes some and lets others alone.¹
- 9 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,006** — *Diorbhail catches a gap between two tellings* (Tobar dhìreach). Testing her own memory against a household's telling of itself at the ordinary fires, Diorbhail finds a name kept differently from the way the Line keeps it and brings both versions to Somhairle rather than choose between them, and he settles which telling holds truer and tells her the reason for it.²
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,008** — *Somhairle says at the fire he may not sit many more Samhains* (Tobar dhìreach). At a Samhain fire before the whole round of the watch-households, Somhairle says plainly that he does not know how many more such nights he will sit among them, and the gathering falls silent around him, having never before heard him say such a thing of himself.³
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,010** — *Somhairle gives Diorbhail Sloinneadh a' Chlachair⁴ whole* (Tobar dhìreach). Over a single night at the watch-fire, with Beathan's son sitting the turn beside them, Somhairle says the whole Sloinneadh a' Chlachair through twice without a name out of place, the same way it was given to him and to Beathan before her, and sets her own name at its foot when he is done.
- 17 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 3,011** — *The valleys turn to Diorbhail's fire before Somhairle's* (Tobar dhìreach). After the giving, households of Na Glinn Àrda⁵ begin bringing their children's names to Diorbhail's fire rather than Somhairle's, the way a valley turns by degrees from an old well to a new one dug beside it, the old well no less good for the turning.⁶
- 15 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 3,014** — *Somhairle's face is likened to a withered apple* (Tobar dhìreach). An old woman of the watch-households, seeing Somhairle at a distance one Bealltainn, says he has come to look like a withered apple left too long on the sill. The saying travels the valleys and sticks to him, so that in time the households speak of him by it as easily as by his own name.⁷

1. ← Follows from *Somhairle first sits Diorbhail by the slab*, 4 an Cèitean, GE 2,997.

2. ← Follows from *A basket-weavers' boy tries the slab and turns back to his creels*, 10 an t-Samhain, GE 3,004.

3. ← Follows from *Diorbhail catches a gap between two tellings*, 9 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,006.

4. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

5. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

6. ← Follows from *Somhairle gives Diorbhail Sloinneadh a' Chlachair whole*, 12 an Dàmhair, GE 3,010.

7. ← Follows from *The valleys turn to Diorbhail's fire before Somhairle's*, 17 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,011.

- 20 AN CÈITEAN, GE 3,018** — *Somhairle asks Diorbhail what waits for a man with no hall* (Tobar dhìreach). At a fire with no one else near enough to hear, Somhairle tells Diorbhail the one thing his own father never told him: that he does not know what waits for one of the grove's blood who took no wife of the king's giving and no share of the kingdom, having no hall to be carried into when his years run out.⁸
- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 3,022** — *Beathan's son clears the path for Somhairle's stick* (Tobar dhìreach). In Somhairle's last seasons, Beathan's son walks up before each Samhain to clear fallen branches from the path so the old man's stick will not catch in the dark, and sits longer at the slab on the nights Somhairle climbs to it, though no household asks this of him.⁹
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 3,025** — *Somhairle mac Ailein dies* (Tobar dhìreach). Somhairle mac Ailein, a son of Ailean Mòr born in his father's sixty-second year, dies in the high valleys at two thousand nine hundred and eighty-seven years, before his father. His line lives among Clann na Ceiste¹⁰ and holds no share of the hill. In each generation after him the long years are shorter.¹¹
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 3,025** — *Beathan's son finds Somhairle dead against the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). In the season the valleys keep for turning peat, Beathan's son finds Somhairle sitting against the slab in the grey of a morning, his stick fallen just out of reach, with no mark on him anywhere; word goes down to Dùn ìseal before noon on the fastest pony the round can put under a boy.¹²
- 7 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 3,025** — *The king buries Somhairle and keeps a night's vigil* (Tobar dhìreach). The king comes up on foot the last two miles, buries his son with his own two hands beside the slab, and sits on the turf afterward with his arms round his knees until an old reciter comes to ask, well after dark, whether he will come in to the fire.¹³
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, GE 3,026** — *Beathan's son takes up the whole watch at the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). With no household troubling to make it formal, Beathan's son takes the watch at the slab as his own to keep entire, as his father had kept it before Somhairle first divided the watching from the reciting between two hands.¹⁴

8. ← Follows from *Somhairle's face is likened to a withered apple*, 15 an Lùnastal, GE 3,014.

9. ← Follows from *Somhairle asks Diorbhail what waits for a man with no hall*, 20 an Cèitean, GE 3,018.

10. the Children of the Question

11. → Caused by *Diorbhail says her own line before she can tie a shoe*, 13 an Dàmhair, GE 2,993; → Caused by *Somhairle first sits Diorbhail by the slab*, 4 an Cèitean, GE 2,997; → Caused by *Somhairle gives Diorbhail Sloin-neadh a' Chlachair whole*, 12 an Dàmhair, GE 3,010; ← Leads to *Beathan's son finds Somhairle dead against the slab*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,025; ← Leads to *The king buries Somhairle and keeps a night's vigil*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,025.

12. ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Ailein dies*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,025.

13. ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Ailein dies*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,025.

14. ← Follows from *The king buries Somhairle and keeps a night's vigil*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,025.

26 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,028 — *Ceann mhin on the south-eastern shore* (Ceann mhin).

The south-eastern Ceann mhin is settled near Làrach an Dùin¹⁵. Its people are the first to live in sight of the fortress ruin, and they will not go up to it.

21 AN GIBLEAN, GE 3,030 — *Diorbhail keeps the Line by mouth and takes no share for it* (Tobar dhìreach). Diorbhail says the whole Line through twice each Samhain to any of the watch-households who will hear it, adding each year's names to its foot and setting none of it down on leaf or hide, and takes no share from any hall for the keeping, as Somhairle held she must.¹⁶

10 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 3,040 — *Ceann mhin's people will not climb to the ruin* (Ceann mhin). The households settled in sight of Làrach an Dùin¹⁷ ruin on the headland build their houses with their doors to the sea and their backs to the broken walls, and will not carry off the good dressed stone lying loose there for the taking, an old woman of that shore saying a wall raised by other hands keeps its own quarrel.¹⁸

12 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,055 — *The smiths of the southern Seann Skell beat out books faster than the sea wears them* (Seann Skell). Within a few generations of its resettling, the old harbour of the south becomes the busiest quay on that whole coast, boats going out on every tide and coming home heavy, and its smiths kept at the forge from first light beating out fish-hooks the fishing cannot outlast.

13 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,068 — *Achadh shean sinks its well before it breaks a furrow* (Achadh shean). The households returning to the fields cracked by the long drought sink a new well deep into the rock before they plant a single seed, and tell it after as a lesson to their children: dig first, plant after, a well proved in a dry summer being worth more than an early harvest.

23 AM MÀRT, GE 3,079 — *Seann Skell of the south* (Seann Skell). Dia-thìreach households take up the old harbour at the southern Seann Skell and keep its old name. Within a few generations it is the busiest landing on the south coast.¹⁹

15 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 3,081 — *A boy of Inis mhin is lost among the egg-ledges* (Inis mhin). A boy climbing after eggs is caught by dusk on a shelf below the cliff's highest nests, unhurt but unable to climb either way, and is brought up by torchlight on a rope woven that same night; afterward no one of that settlement works the cliffs alone, two to a rope by custom rather than any law spoken.

27 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 3,100 — *Raonaid born to the king on the eastern shore*. A daughter is born to the king by a wife of the eastern shore and named Raonaid; quick of eye and slow to anger, she will be the half-sister Ìomhar Dearg loves best of all his father's many children, and the hearth he comes home to.²⁰

15. the fortress ruin

16. ← Follows from *Somhairle mac Ailein dies*, 7 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,025.

17. the fortress ruin

18. ← Follows from *Ceann mhin on the south-eastern shore*, 26 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,028.

19. → Caused by *The smiths of the southern Seann Skell beat out books faster than the sea wears them*, 12 an Dàmhair, GE 3,055.

- 29 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,103** — *The first cairn rises above the fold at Muileann chaol* (Muileann chaol). When the head of one of the settling households dies, his kin carry stones up the slope above the cattle-fold and raise the first cairn there, one stone laid at a time by whoever had known him; within a lifetime the slope holds as many small heaps of stone as the fold below holds cattle in a good year.
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, GE 3,125** — *Achadh shean resettled* (Achadh shean). Households return to Achadh shean after the drought and cut new fields on the higher ground. They sink a deep well first and plant after, and the well does not fail again in this age.²¹
- 24 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 3,140** — *Fearchar Bacach dies at Dùn ìseal*. Fearchar Bacach, who has held Dùn ìseal for the king since he was lamed in the passes long before, dies quietly in his own bed at three thousand one hundred and thirty years of age; his house keeps the hill after him without any household troubling to remark that it is being kept.²²
- 22 AN GEARRAN, GE 3,140** — *Raonaid nic Ailein weds on the eastern shore* (Dùn ìseal). Raonaid nic Ailein, a daughter of the king born to a wife of the eastern shore, marries a herdsman of Fearchar's line from the river-lands below Dùn ìseal, known on that shore better by his flocks than by his name; her house there is afterward the hearth her half-brother Ìomhar Dearg comes back to between his wanderings.²³
- 23 AM MÀRT, GE 3,161** — *Baile Mòr ruadh settles ground its people call empty* (Baile Mòr ruadh). Households raise a broad red-earthed rise into Baile Mòr ruadh, a morning's walk from the old middens of Seann Dunn, calling the ground around them empty though the middens plainly say otherwise, and dig into nothing of what lies there.
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, GE 3,172** — *Inis mhin settled* (Inis mhin). A few households settle at Inis mhin on the eastern coast. They live by the eggs and birds of the cliffs, and trade feathers inland.²⁴
- 21 AN GIBLEAN, GE 3,179** — *A shepherd's flock will not cross the worn path at Làrach an Teampaill*²⁵. A shepherd wakes from a sun-warmed sleep to find his whole flock standing stock still along the path worn round Làrach an Teampaill, none grazing, none straying past its edge, and drives them home without letting a hoof cross it, telling after that his sheep had more sense of the place than he did.
- 20 AN CÈITEAN, GE 3,204** — *Ìomhar is born to the king and called Dearg for his hair*. A son is born to the king in the south and named Ìomhar, called Dearg for hair redder than his father's or his brothers', who grows up about the southern shores and the eastern marches asking, before his first century is out, why a man may not simply be given ground and left to hold it.²⁶

20. ← Follows from *Seann Skell of the south*, 23 am Màrt, GE 3,079.

21. → Caused by *Achadh shean sinks its well before it breaks a furrow*, 13 an t-Sultain, GE 3,068.

22. ← Follows from *The first cairn rises above the fold at Muileann chaol*, 29 an Dàmhair, GE 3,103.

23. ← Follows from *Raonaid born to the king on the eastern shore*, 27 an t-Samhain, GE 3,100.

24. → Caused by *A boy of Inis mhin is lost among the egg-ledges*, 15 an Lùnastal, GE 3,081.

25. the temple ruin

18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 3,218 — *Muileann chaol on its hill* (Muileann chaol). Households settle on the hill at Muileann chaol, above the upper reaches of the rivers. Where the library stands now there is a cattle-fold.

26. ← Follows from *A shepherd's flock will not cross the worn path at Làrach an Teampaill*, 21 an Giblean, GE 3,179.

THE YEARS GE 3,251 – 3,500

- 17 AN T-IÚCHAR, GE 3,264** — *Cairns on the hill at Muileann chaol* (Leabharlann Muileann chaol¹). At Muileann chaol a cairn is raised for each head of a household at death, on the slope above the fold. By the end of the age some forty stand there.²
- 18 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 3,310** — *Dòmhnall Clachach dies in the north country*. Dòmhnall Clachach, sent north from Dùn iséal more than three thousand years before and known there only as the stone-cutter's son, dies among people who never troubled themselves with what he had once been, at three thousand three hundred and eight years of age; word of it reaches the hill a full season after the burying.³
- 15 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 3,311** — *Baile Mòr ruadh in the east* (Baile Mòr ruadh). Baile Mòr ruadh grows up near the eastern Seann Dunn, on land its people call empty. The middens of Seann Dunn lie a morning's walk away, and the settlers do not dig into them.⁴
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,357** — *The temple ruin avoided* (Làrach an Teampaill⁵). The Diathùrich of the eastern hills pass Làrach an Teampaill without stopping and take no stone from it. A path is worn round it at a distance.⁶
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,403** — *Ceann leathan's contests* (Còmhrag Ceann leathan⁷). At Ceann leathan the gathering by the wind-stones ends with wrestling and the lifting of stones. The heaviest, a black boulder, lies on the point still, and few have raised it.⁸
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,403** — *Alasdair Làidir takes every fall of the contests at three-and-twenty* (Ceann mhin). At the yearly contests below Clachan nan Gaoth⁹ of Ceann leathan, a young herdsman's son named Alasdair Làidir throws every man who stands against him from first light to last, the youngest ever known to do it, and is given by custom the first try at Clach a' Neirt¹⁰ that has never once been raised.¹¹
- 12 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,403** — *A grey stranger lifts the black boulder at Ceann leathan* (Ceann mhin). After Alasdair Làidir's strength fails against it, an unknown grey-haired traveller steps from the watching crowd, sets his hands to Clach a' Neirt¹² and raises it to his knees, then sets it down again gently rather than dropping it, and walks off the headland refusing to give any name the reciters might carry.¹³

1. the Library at Muileann chaol

2. → Caused by *The first cairn rises above the fold at Muileann chaol*, 29 an Dàmhair, GE 3,103.

3. ← Follows from *Iombar is born to the king and called Dearg for his hair*, 20 an Cèitean, GE 3,204.

4. → Caused by *Baile Mòr ruadh settles ground its people call empty*, 23 am Màrt, GE 3,161.

5. the temple ruin

6. → Caused by *A shepherd's flock will not cross the worn path at Làrach an Teampaill*, 21 an Giblean, GE 3,179.

7. the yearly melee at Ceann leathan; lit. 'the combat of Ceann leathan'

8. ← Leads to *Alasdair Làidir takes every fall of the contests at three-and-twenty*, 12 an Dàmhair, GE 3,403; ← Leads to *A grey stranger lifts the black boulder at Ceann leathan*, 12 an Dàmhair, GE 3,403.

9. the ring of eight wind-stones at Ceann leathan

10. the black boulder of the Ceann leathan contests

11. ← Follows from *Ceann leathan's contests*, 12 an Dàmhair, GE 3,403.

12. the black boulder of the Ceann leathan contests

- 6 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 3,410** — *The tale of the lifted stone wears smooth at other fires* (Seann Skell). Carried from hearth to hearth along the southern coast, the tale of the grey stranger gains, within a few winters, a taller stranger, a one-handed lift and, at one fire near the southern Seann Skell, hands said to glow like a smith's iron, an embellishment Alasdair Làidir spends the rest of his life correcting wherever he hears it repeated.¹⁴
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 3,450** — *The ford gathering grows* (Fèill Muileann òg¹⁵). The ford gathering at Muileann òg now draws households from every coast. Its ground is parted by custom: the salt people downstream, the hill people upstream, the flint people on the far bank.¹⁶
- 3 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 3,450** — *An old woman at the ford sets a matching tale beside Alasdair's doubted one*. At Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹⁷, crowded that year, an old man past his wrestling years tells, once more, of the stone lifted and gently set down at Ceann leathan; a grey-haired woman at the same fire answers his young doubters not by taking his side but by recalling a near-identical telling she heard thirty years before, from a different mouth entirely, at a fire near the southern Seann Skell.¹⁸
- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,496** — *Stone axes from the north* (Àth àrsaidh). Axes of polished green stone from a quarry near Àth àrsaidh in the north-west are carried all over the island. They are too fine for work; most are laid unused in graves or under house floors.¹⁹
- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,496** — *Ìomhar Dearg wants a green axe for use, not for a grave* (Àth àrsaidh). At a wake in the north-west, Ìomhar Dearg turns over the dead man's green axe before it goes under the turf and asks the son, plainly, for one of his own to carry and use, having buried enough kin himself to want a tool that earns its keep before it earns its grave.²⁰
- 1 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,496** — *The cutters of Àth àrsaidh turn Ìomhar away* (Àth àrsaidh). An old cutter at the quarry tells Ìomhar Dearg that no green axe was ever cut to be swung, only shown, and that a man wanting an edge for work should go to a common smith and leave the green stone to the graves it is already promised to.²¹
- 25 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,497** — *Ìomhar's grey axe outlives forty years of use* (Àth àrsaidh). Ìomhar Dearg has a common smith cut him a plain grey axe that same winter, and uses it, reground more than once, for the better part of forty years before the head cracks on a misjudged root and he buries it himself in the ground it first turned.²²

13. ← Follows from *Ceann leathan's contests*, 12 an Dàmhair, GE 3,403.

14. ← Follows from *Ceann leathan's contests*, 12 an Dàmhair, GE 3,403.

15. the fair at Muileann òg

16. ← Leads to *An old woman at the ford sets a matching tale beside Alasdair's doubted one*, 3 an Lùnastal, GE 3,450.

17. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

18. ← Follows from *The ford gathering grows*, 3 an Lùnastal, GE 3,450.

19. ← Leads to *Ìomhar Dearg wants a green axe for use, not for a grave*, 1 an t-Sultain, GE 3,496; ← Leads to *The cutters of Àth àrsaidh turn Ìomhar away*, 1 an t-Sultain, GE 3,496.

20. ← Follows from *Stone axes from the north*, 1 an t-Sultain, GE 3,496.

21. ← Follows from *Stone axes from the north*, 1 an t-Sultain, GE 3,496.

22. ← Follows from *The cutters of Àth àrsaidh turn Ìomhar away*, 1 an t-Sultain, GE 3,496.

THE YEARS GE 3,501 – 3,750

- 13 AN GIBLEAN, GE 3,547** — *The quarry at Àth àrsaidh (Àth àrsaidh).* The green-stone quarry at Àth àrsaidh is worked by a few households who trade in nothing else, and the chips about it lie knee-deep. Before the age ends the quarry is forsaken, and the axes cease.¹
- 13 AN GIBLEAN, GE 3,547** — *The last cutter of Àth àrsaidh dies without an apprentice (Àth àrsaidh).* The seam of true green stone runs thin under every cut the households of Àth àrsaidh try, and the last cutter who still holds the old skill dies that year with no apprentice behind him, his own sons having gone to herding rather than a stone that no longer pays for the teaching.²
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,588** — *The moor takes the north (Doire ghlas).* The oak falls back, as the pollen in the bog under Doire ghlas shows. Heather, birch and bog-moss spread over the northern lowlands, and the groves that give the north its many Doire names shrink to the sheltered valleys, where they stand yet. In the north this is remembered as the time the winters lengthened.³
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,588** — *The oak-groves of the north shrink to the sheltered valleys (Doire ghlas).* About Doire ghlas and the low ground north of it, heather, birch and bog-moss spread over ground the oak had held unchallenged for longer than any household's reckoning, and the groves that gave the north its many doire-names draw back to valleys the wind cannot reach.⁴
- 6 AM MÀRT, GE 3,610** — *Stepping-stones cross Abhainn fhionn dry-shod.* A household below the willow flats lays flat stones across the shallowest bend of Abhainn fhionn one summer's low water at a time, until within two generations a man may cross the whole width stone to stone in every season but true flood, the first made river-crossing the island has seen.
- 15 AM MÀRT, GE 3,628** — *The river crossings of Abhainn fhionn (Abhainn fhionn).* Stepping-stones are laid across Abhainn fhionn at its shallows, the first made crossing of any river on the island. They are older than the first bridges, and in places lie beneath them.⁵
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 3,680** — *A drowning at the fords of Abhainn chaol (Abhainn chaol).* A spate on Abhainn chaol takes a party of twelve crossing its fords with salt. Thereafter none crosses there in the wet season.⁶
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 3,680** — *Twelve are taken at the fords of Abhainn chaol.* A spate with no warning a slower rise would have given takes a party of twelve crossing with salt at the fords of Abhainn chaol; five bodies go to their own kin, four unclaimed to the nearest household willing to dig, and three are never found.⁷

1. ← Leads to *The last cutter of Àth àrsaidh dies without an apprentice*, 13 an Giblean, GE 3,547.

2. ← Follows from *The quarry at Àth àrsaidh*, 13 an Giblean, GE 3,547.

3. ← Leads to *The oak-groves of the north shrink to the sheltered valleys*, 19 an t-Sultain, GE 3,588.

4. ← Follows from *The moor takes the north*, 19 an t-Sultain, GE 3,588.

5. → Caused by *Stepping-stones cross Abhainn fhionn dry-shod*, 6 am Màrt, GE 3,610.

6. ← Leads to *Twelve are taken at the fords of Abhainn chaol*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,680; ← Leads to *Ìombar comes two days too late to the drowning*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,680.

10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 3,680 — *Ìomhar comes two days too late to the drowning.* Word reaches Ìomhar Dearg two days' walk south of Abhainn chaol and he comes as fast as the road allows, arriving to a river already fallen back to its ordinary height and the households of both banks already burying what could be found; no household crosses those fords in the wet season after.⁸

9 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,703 — *Niall is born to Raonaid on the eastern shore* (Dùn ìseal). Raonaid nic Ailein bears a son on the eastern shore in a colder autumn than the last three running; her half-brother Ìomhar Dearg finds more of her quickness than of his own long line in the child's first evening.⁹

12 AN CÈITEAN, GE 3,726 — *The Black Wind remembered at Ceann chiar* (Ceann chiar). The people of Ceann chiar, rebuilding after the Black Wind, set a stone in the midst of their settlement and cut on it a mark for every house lost: twenty-two.¹⁰

12 AN CÈITEAN, GE 3,726 — *Ceann chiar cuts two-and-twenty marks for A' Ghaoth Dhubh*¹¹ (Ceann chiar). Rebuilding after A' Ghaoth Dhubh that scattered their roofs a generation before, the households of Ceann chiar set a stone in their new-laid houses and cut a plain stroke for every house the wind took, two-and-twenty marks in a row with no names beside them.¹²

7. ← Follows from *A drowning at the fords of Abhainn chaol*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,680.

8. ← Follows from *A drowning at the fords of Abhainn chaol*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,680.

9. ← Follows from *Ìomhar comes two days too late to the drowning*, 10 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,680.

10. ← Leads to *Ceann chiar cuts two-and-twenty marks for A' Ghaoth Dhubh*, 12 an Cèitean, GE 3,726.

11. the Black Wind

12. ← Follows from *The Black Wind remembered at Ceann chiar*, 12 an Cèitean, GE 3,726.

THE YEARS GE 3,751 – 4,000

- 7 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 3,771** — *A dry year on the eastern plain* (Muileann bhàn). The rivers of the eastern plain run low for a whole summer, and the households of Dùn ìseal and Muileann bhàn drive their cattle to the warm springs to drink. The shared surplus holds, and no deaths are counted.¹
- 7 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 3,771** — *A dry summer is answered by the shared surplus* (Dùn ìseal). The rivers of the eastern plain run so low one summer that Dùn ìseal and Muileann bhàn drive their cattle to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh² to drink; the surplus each household had kept against such a year holds long enough that no death is counted for the thirst of it.³
- 9 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 3,817** — *A second wave on the south coast* (Tonn Mhòr Cnoc chaol⁴). The sea comes in again over the low ground at Cnoc chaol, less far than before. The new houses stand higher on the slope, and none is lost.⁵
- 9 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 3,817** — *A lesser wave comes in at Cnoc chaol*. The sea rises again over the low ground at Cnoc chaol, less far than the wave the coast still tells of; the new houses built higher on the slope since that first wave take no loss, the water finding only empty byres to carry off.⁶
- 4 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,863** — *The ground shakes at Cill ghlas again* (Scàineadh Cill ghlas⁷). The old crack at Cill ghlas moves again, and the spring shifts back uphill. The line of white stones is broken in two places, and is laid again.⁸
- 4 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,863** — *The crack at Gleann na Scoltaidh⁹ moves again*. The old crack in the ground shifts once more, moving the spring back uphill and breaking the line of white stones that marks the danger in two places; the households walk out with fresh stone and lay the line again exactly as their grandmothers laid it the first time.¹⁰
- 15 **AN T-IUCHAR, GE 3,900** — *Dùghall born to Ìomhar Dearg*. A son is born to Ìomhar Dearg and named Dùghall, a grave, red-haired child with none of his cousin Niall's laughter in him; Ìomhar, near seven hundred years old, carries him on his wanderings before the boy can walk.¹¹

1. ← Leads to *A dry summer is answered by the shared surplus*, 7 an Lùnastal, GE 3,771.

2. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

3. ← Follows from *A dry year on the eastern plain*, 7 an Lùnastal, GE 3,771.

4. the Great Wave; lit. 'the great wave of Cnoc chaol'

5. ← Leads to *A lesser wave comes in at Cnoc chaol*, 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,817.

6. ← Follows from *A second wave on the south coast*, 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 3,817.

7. the Rending; lit. 'the splitting of Cill ghlas'

8. ← Leads to *The crack at Gleann na Scoltaidh moves again*, 4 an Dàmhair, GE 3,863.

9. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

10. ← Follows from *The ground shakes at Cill ghlas again*, 4 an Dàmhair, GE 3,863.

11. ← Follows from *The crack at Gleann na Scoltaidh moves again*, 4 an Dàmhair, GE 3,863.

- 5 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 3,908** — *Cnoc bheag under the Carragh* (Cnoc bheag). Households settle on the bank of the Abhainn iséal at Cnoc bheag, a short walk from Carragh Cnoc bheag¹². They set their houses so that no door faces the stone.
- 7 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,920** — *Households settle at Cnoc bheag with no door facing the stone* (Cnoc bheag). A generation settles on the bank of Abhainn iséal a short walk from the standing stone at Cnoc bheag, and sets its houses, by no law anyone can name, so that no door among them faces the stone; every household built after keeps the same pattern unquestioned.¹³
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,955** — *The seal rocks of Inis bhàn* (Inis bhàn). The households of Inis bhàn on the lower Abhainn iséal take seals from the skerries off the river mouth by agreement, one household to a rock. A rock taken out of turn is the commonest quarrel in their tellings.¹⁴
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,955** — *Inis bhàn settles the seal-rocks by the tally of the turn* (Inis bhàn). The households by the seal-rocks off the river mouth at Inis bhàn take one rock to a household in its own turn, kept on notched sticks; a rock taken out of turn is the coast's commonest quarrel, settled always by counting the tally aloud rather than raised voices.¹⁵
- 10 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 3,960** — *Ìomhar Dearg asks the king for ground of his own* (Dùn iséal). Nearly eight hundred years into a wandering right that let him sit at any hearth on the island, Ìomhar Dearg asks the king, on the hill, for ground held in his own name rather than his blood's, wanting a piece of earth that answers to him before it answers to anyone else.¹⁶
- 8 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 3,960** — *The king gives Ìomhar the river-grazing of the eastern marches* (Dùn iséal). The king grants Ìomhar Dearg thin-soiled river-grazing between the last settled households and the open country to the east, telling him only that a share given is a share that can be taken back, as every share on the island has been and will go on being.¹⁷
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 3,960** — *Ìomhar stands on his own ground looking east* (Dùn iséal). At the day's end Ìomhar Dearg stands alone on the eastern river-grazing, thin grass under his own feet for the first time in nearly eight centuries of walking ground that answered to another name, and looks east toward country he has not yet walked.¹⁸
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,000** — *Fields at Achadh mhòr* (Achadh mhòr). The wide field at Achadh mhòr, near the warm springs, is cleared and banked, the largest single field of the age. Its bank is laid with the stones of an older wall that no one claims.

12. the obelisk at Cnoc bheag

13. ← Follows from *Cnoc bheag under the Carragh*, 5 an t-Sultain, GE 3,908.

14. ← Leads to *Inis bhàn settles the seal-rocks by the tally of the turn*, 1 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,955.

15. ← Follows from *The seal rocks of Inis bhàn*, 1 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,955.

16. ← Follows from *Inis bhàn settles the seal-rocks by the tally of the turn*, 1 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,955.

17. ← Follows from *Ìomhar Dearg asks the king for ground of his own*, 10 an Dàmhair, GE 3,960.

18. ← Follows from *The king gives Ìomhar the river-grazing of the eastern marches*, 8 an t-Samhain, GE 3,960.

THE YEARS GE 4,001 – 4,250

- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 4,008** — *Achadh mhòr's wide field is cleared under Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh*¹ (Achadh mhòr). A household near Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh clears and banks the widest single field the eastern country has yet cut from the rough, laying its bank on the stones of an older wall whose builders none of them can name, and grows in a good year wheat enough for three households where before there had been land for none.²
- 20 AN GEARRAN, GE 4,021** — *An Cnoc Ruadh's boats come to be kept at Baile ghlas* (Baile ghlas). Boats drawn up in stone and turf sheds at Baile ghlas along the lake shore come, within a generation, to put out oftener than An Cnoc Ruadh's own strand, so that the harbour built beside the hill grows quietly into the hill's chief fishing ground.
- 22 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 4,034** — *Achadh naomh fences its spring before it raises a house* (Achadh naomh). Settlers at Achadh naomh lead a spring round in channels of their own digging and fence it before a single wall is raised, so that a stranger coming on the place first might take the water, and not the people, for what had been settled there.
- 7 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,047** — *The harbour at Baile ghlas* (Baile ghlas). The households of the Red Hill draw up their boats at Baile ghlas, along the lake shore from the hill, in sheds of stone and turf. It becomes the fishing harbour of the Red Hill.⁴
- 24 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,058** — *Two households at Caol shean give their disputed landing to no one* (Caol shean). Rather than let a quarrel over a stretch of river landing run on with no keeper near enough to draw a lot on it, two households of Caol shean sit out a night together and give the ground to the landing itself, for whoever has a boat drawn up there and no other claim; the households are, within two generations, thoroughly mixed by marriage.
- 5 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 4,091** — *Achadh naomh's spring-fields* (Achadh naomh). Settlers at Achadh naomh in the north water their fields from a spring they will not build over, and lead the water round it in channels. The spring is fenced before any house is.⁵
- 25 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,100** — *Catriona born of the king's blood* (Dùn ìseal). A daughter of the king's blood is born in the valleys under the hill and named Catriona; before she is ten she can give a household's line back seven names, and the hill begins to watch her as a valley watches a child who does an ordinary thing early.⁶
- 10 AM MÀRT, GE 4,128** — *Caol gharbh on the rough strait* (Caol gharbh). Households settle at Caol gharbh on the north-east coast and fish the strait in skin boats. They lay paddles beside their dead.

1. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

2. ← Follows from *Fields at Achadh mhòr*, 2 an t-Samhain, GE 4,000.

3. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

4. → Caused by *An Cnoc Ruadh's boats come to be kept at Baile ghlas*, 20 an Gearran, GE 4,021.

5. → Caused by *Achadh naomh fences its spring before it raises a house*, 22 am Faoilleach, GE 4,034.

6. ← Follows from *Achadh naomh's spring-fields*, 5 an t-Ògmhios, GE 4,091.

- 8 AN GIBLEAN, GE 4,183** — *Doire chiar* (Doire chiar). A settlement grows up under the dark oaks at Doire chiar in the north. Its people pen pigs in the wood and drive them out to the acorns at the fall of the year.
- II AM FAOILLEACH, GE 4,228** — *The river landing at Caol shean* (Caol shean). Caol shean, on the Abhainn ìseal east of the vein, becomes the river landing of the hill households of the east. Salt, fish and seal-skins come up the river to it from the coast, and go on from it into the keepers' country.⁷
- 27 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 4,240** — *Ailis is born east of the vein* (Dùn dhearg). A girl named Ailis is born at what will become Dùn dhearg, into a household already turf-cutting for the fort's first bank, and grows up along the ditch's edge hearing, at her own hearth, tellings of a king beyond the vein who does not grow old.⁸
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,250** — *A trader tells Ailis of the gate at Dùn ìseal* (Caol shean). A cloth-trader passing through Caol shean's landing tells the children at a hearth of standing at the very gate of Dùn ìseal and seeing a young-faced man come in at it who has held that hill, by every account at the gate, since before its walls were built; the child Ailis asks whether it does not frighten his own children to grow old beside him, and gets no clear answer.⁹

7. → Caused by *Two households at Caol shean give their disputed landing to no one*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,058.

8. ← Follows from *Two households at Caol shean give their disputed landing to no one*, 24 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,058.

9. ← Follows from *Ailis is born east of the vein*, 27 an Dàmhair, GE 4,240.

THE YEARS GE 4,251 – 4,500

- 9 **AN GEARRAN, GE 4,274** — *Dùn dhearg raised* (Dùn dhearg). A hill-fort with a double bank is raised at Dùn dhearg, east of the vein, by households who owe nothing to Dùn ìseal. The Stone Kings' list does not name its holders; it says only that Dùn dhearg came not to the gatherings.¹
- 9 **AN GEARRAN, GE 4,274** — *The households east of the vein raise the double bank at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Owing nothing to Dùn ìseal and asking leave of no one, the households of the eastern country dig a deep ditch and raise a double bank at Dùn dhearg, sharing out the labour and afterward the ground within it by households and not by standing, so that the fort itself sets, without any law behind it, the custom the country keeps from then on.²
- 1 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,275** — *A holdout household is left outside Dùn dhearg's second bank* (Dùn dhearg). A family that refuses to send hands to the digging is simply left with its grazing outside the second bank when the ground is drawn, and asks within a generation, of its own accord and under no compulsion, to be let in on the same terms as its neighbours, its late hands reckoned at somewhat less than hands sent early.³
- 10 **AN DÀMHAIR, GE 4,292** — *Gille-Bride's father born in Na Glinn Àrda*⁴. A son is born in Na Glinn Àrda to a household of Somhairle's line, which keeps Sloinneadh a' Chlachair⁵ and takes no share; he will live three hundred and eight years, fewer than his own father, and father Gille-Bride.⁶
- 11 **AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,304** — *Ruairidh born to Dùghall Dearg*. A son is born to Dùghall Dearg, son of Ìomhar Dearg, and named Ruairidh, grey-eyed like his great-grandfather the king; Ìomhar holds him at his naming and says the boy will outlive the river-grazing and most of what stands on it.⁷
- 30 **AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,310** — *Ailis's husband is buried on the slope above Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). The net-mender of Caol shean whom Ailis married in her twenty-second year dies at Dùn dhearg an old man by any island's reckoning, and is carried out and laid on the slope above the houses with his own net-needle set in the ground at his feet.⁸
- 28 **AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,320** — *Seumas born on An Cnoc Ruadh*⁹ (Cathair dhearg). A son is born in An Cnoc Ruadh's hall and named Seumas; the reciters of the lake shore mark his birth in the roll as they have marked every holder's since Beathag Ruadh.¹⁰

1. ← Leads to *The households east of the vein raise the double bank at Dùn dhearg*, 9 an Gearran, GE 4,274.

2. ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg raised*, 9 an Gearran, GE 4,274.

3. ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg raised*, 9 an Gearran, GE 4,274.

4. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

5. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

6. ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg raised*, 9 an Gearran, GE 4,274.

7. ← Follows from *A holdout household is left outside Dùn dhearg's second bank*, 1 an Lùnastal, GE 4,275.

8. ← Follows from *Ruairidh born to Dùghall Dearg*, 11 an t-Sultain, GE 4,304.

9. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

- 16 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 4,321** — *Ailis sets out for the ford with seal-skins* (Dùn dhearg). In her eighty-first year Ailis of Dùn dhearg carries three winters' store of seal-skins the length of the island toward Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹¹, meaning to trade them for salt and to stand in the river of the old tellings before her legs fail her; six of that country go with her, the first of Dùn dhearg's people to make the journey.
- 14 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,321** — *Dùn dhearg comes to the ford* (Fèill Muileann òg¹²). In the time of Catriona Mhòr the households of Dùn dhearg come to the ford gathering for the first time, bringing seal-skins and asking for salt. They are given ground of their own on the far bank.¹³
- 26 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,321** — *The east reaches the ford after five days on the road*. Ailis's party finds households along the road who have never heard of the country east of the vein, and sleeps a night with a family whose grandfather claims a telling, four hands removed, of An Cruinneachadh Mòr¹⁴ held in the three-thousandth year of the Grove; by the fourth day they walk unremarked among a general traffic of salt- and wool-carriers bound the same way.¹⁵
- 6 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,322** — *Ìomhar Dearg names the east 'the short-lived' at the ford*. At the fire where Catriona hears Ailis out, Ìomhar Dearg, holding river-grazing nearby, asks carelessly why ground should be troubled over for people who will all be dead within one of his own lifetimes, and calls them, in that breath, the short-lived; Ailis answers that she has five days' walking behind her and no wish to spend any of what time she has left arguing with a man who will have five centuries to be sorry in.¹⁶
- 4 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 4,322** — *Young Catriona gives Dùn dhearg ground at the ford*. Catriona, of the king's blood and not yet two hundred and twenty-five years old, hears Ailis of Dùn dhearg out at the ford, asks after the double bank and whether it answers to anyone, and gives the eastern households ground of their own on the far bank, this year and every year after, asking no oath in return and receiving none.¹⁷
- 3 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 4,322** — *Salt is carried home to Dùn dhearg without any oath given* (Dùn dhearg). Ailis's party trades its seal-skins for salt enough to see three households through a hard winter and walks home east of the vein without having sworn anything to the ford or to the hill, and the elders of Dùn dhearg agree, hearing it told, that ground held and no word owed for the holding suits them exactly as it stands.¹⁸

10. ← Follows from *Catriona born of the king's blood*, 25 an t-Samhain, GE 4,100.

11. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

12. the fair at Muileann òg

13. → Caused by *Ailis sets out for the ford with seal-skins*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, GE 4,321.

14. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

15. ← Follows from *Ailis sets out for the ford with seal-skins*, 16 an t-Ògmhios, GE 4,321.

16. ← Follows from *The east reaches the ford after five days on the road*, 26 an t-Samhain, GE 4,321.

17. ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg comes to the ford*, 14 an t-Samhain, GE 4,321.

18. ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg comes to the ford*, 14 an t-Samhain, GE 4,321.

- 13 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,325** — *Settlers at Àth fhiadhaich* (Àth fhiadhaich). Households settle at Àth fhiadhaich in the south-eastern hills, by a ford where wild cattle cross. They take the calves and rear them, and their herds become the best in those hills.
- 15 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,325** — *Ailis dies on the slope above the double bank* (Dùn dhearg). Ailis dies at eighty-five in her own house on the eastern slope of Dùn dhearg's bank, three years after her one journey to the ford, and is buried beside her husband; her grandchildren keep the tale of the seal-skins and the woman of the king's blood who asked nothing back for the ground she gave.¹⁹
- 19 AN GIBLEAN, GE 4,327** — *The ford of the wild cattle is settled at Àth fhiadhaich* (Àth fhiadhaich). A household settles a stony crossing in the south-eastern hills where wild cattle come down to drink, and rears the calves born on the near bank apart from the wild herd until, within three generations, that ford's cattle are spoken of the length of the coast as the best in the hills.²⁰
- 17 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,328** — *Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). Households from the Red Hill settle the point at Ceann àrsaidh on the Abhainn fhionn. They find an old river landing there and name the place for it: the ancient headland.
- 19 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,328** — *Cnoc thais in the north-west* (Cnoc thais). Households settle on the damp hill at Cnoc thais in the north-west and drain it with ditches. The ditches carry water still.
- 16 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 4,328** — *Inis mhòr* (Inis mhòr). Households settle Inis mhòr on the Abhainn ghorm in the north-east and live by the fish of its sheltered pools. They build their houses in two rows facing each other, the oldest street on Dia-thìr.
- 18 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,330** — *Households build about the old landing at Ceann àrsaidh* (Ceann àrsaidh). People out of An Cnoc Ruadh²¹'s country find an old river landing on the Abhainn fhionn, stones set for a boat's keel by hands none living can name, and build their houses about it, naming the place for what they found.²²
- 9 AM MÀRT, GE 4,335** — *Inis mhòr's two facing rows are raised* (Inis mhòr). Households settle Inis mhòr on the Abhainn ghorm and build their houses in two rows facing each other across a single trodden way, so that a neighbour's fire may be borrowed without crossing open ground in the rain; it is the oldest street any teller remembers on Dia-thìr.²³
- 27 AN GIBLEAN, GE 4,347** — *Baile gheal in the south-west* (Baile gheal). Baile gheal is founded on the south-western plain round a house with white-limed walls. The lime is burned from the shells of the old middens along the coast.

19. ← Follows from *Salt is carried home to Dùn dhearg without any oath given*, 3 an t-Iuchar, GE 4,322.

20. ← Follows from *Settlers at Àth fhiadhaich*, 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,325.

21. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

22. ← Follows from *Ceann àrsaidh*, 17 an t-Sultain, GE 4,328.

23. ← Follows from *Inis mhòr*, 16 an Dàmhair, GE 4,328.

- 26 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,347** — *Àth bheag on the eastern coast* (Àth bheag). Households settle the small ford at Àth bheag on the far eastern coast, the easternmost dwelling of the age on the main island. Their boats go out after the geese on the islands.
- 26 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,347** — *Catriona Mhòr* (Dùn ìseal). Catriona Mhòr, twelfth of the Stone Kings and of the king's blood, holds Dùn ìseal under him; hers is the last name in the spoken list. It is told that she knew every household of the hills by its line seven names back.
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 4,347** — *Seumas Òg of the Red Hill* (Cathair dhearg). Seumas Òg holds the Red Hill, and with him the spoken list of the Red Hill ends. In the next age what the reciters kept of it is written down.
- 23 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 4,347** — *The two lists recited together* (Fèill Muileann òg²⁴). At the ford gathering, in the time of Catriona Mhòr, the list of the Stone Kings and the list of the Red Hill are recited one after the other from the first name to the last. It takes from dusk to dawn. For the first time both are heard whole.
- 13 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,347** — *Catriona takes the bill of Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). Catriona, of the king's blood and two hundred and forty-seven years old, takes Dùn ìseal formally as the twelfth to hold it of Rìghrean na Cloiche²⁵ line, known already for a memory that can give any household's line back seven names without pausing to think.²⁶
- 23 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,347** — *Seumas Òg takes An Cnoc Ruadh*²⁷ (Cathair dhearg). A young man of seven-and-twenty named Seumas takes up the holding of An Cnoc Ruadh his own line has kept since the palisade first burned, the same season Catriona takes Dùn ìseal; his name will be the last An Cnoc Ruadh's own spoken roll carries.²⁸
- 23 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,347** — *The two rolls are spoken whole at the ford in one night*. Eòin gives the whole roll of Rìghrean na Cloiche²⁹ from Ailean Mòr to Catriona's own name, and Ùna gives the whole roll of An Cnoc Ruadh³⁰ from Beathag Ruadh to Seumas Òg's, from dusk to the grey before morning; it is the first time either roll is heard whole, and those nearest the king see him smile when his own name is spoken.³¹
- 29 AM MÀRT, GE 4,350** — *Lots drawn for the slab* (Tobar dhìreach). The lot for the keeper of the slab is drawn now among households from every part of the hills, not only those near the crack. The keepers' house at Tobar dhìreach becomes a place of pilgrimage.³²

24. the fair at Muileann òg

25. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

26. ← Follows from *Catriona Mhòr*, 26 an Cèitean, GE 4,347.

27. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

28. ← Follows from *Seumas Òg of the Red Hill*, 23 an t-Iuchar, GE 4,347.

29. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

30. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

31. ← Follows from *The two lists recited together*, 23 an t-Iuchar, GE 4,347.

32. ← Leads to *The lot for the slab is drawn from every part of the hills*, 29 am Màrt, GE 4,350.

- 29 **AM MÀRT, GE 4,350** — *The lot for the slab is drawn from every part of the hills* (Tobar dhìreach). Where the lot for the keeper of the slab was once drawn only from households near the crack, it comes in these years to be drawn from every part of the hills alike, and Tobar dhìreach becomes a place walked to for its own sake by households whose grandparents never heard the crack mentioned.³³
- 4 **AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 4,351** — *A nameless hand recuts Calbh Cnoc ghorm*³⁴. A hand from Catriona's own hill goes out to Calbh Cnoc ghorm and recuts its worn grooves along their old lines before the rain can lose them; some who come after hold that a single stroke changed in the recutting, though none can agree which, or prove any changed at all.
- 28 **AN GEARRAN, GE 4,353** — *The keepers number nine* (Tobar dhìreach). The keepers of the slab are made nine, one drawn by lot for each of nine districts of the hills. They meet at the slab when a keeper dies, and at no other time.³⁵
- 28 **AN GEARRAN, GE 4,353** — *Luchd-faire na Lice*³⁶ *settle at nine* (Tobar dhìreach). The keepers settle at nine, one drawn by lot for each of nine districts of the hills that no household has ever marked on the ground but every household somehow knows the edge of; the nine meet at the slab only when one of their number dies.³⁷
- 9 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,355** — *Coal in every hearth by the handful*. Every household of the hills burns its handful of the coloured coal, measured in a copy of the stone cup, on one night in the dark of the year, the night later kept as Samhain. All burn at once by agreement, so that the low fires of the handful show on every hillside on the same night.
- 10 **AN GIBLEAN, GE 4,358** — *A handful refused at Cnoc dhubh* (Cnoc dhubh). The household of the Cnoc dhubh trench, where the two diggers were crushed, refuses its handful of coal for as long as any remembers. No household before it is known to have chosen not to burn at all.
- 18 **AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,358** — *The handful comes to be burned all at once by agreement*. Without any lot or law behind it, every household in reach of another comes to burn its measured handful of an gual dathach³⁸ on the same dark night, each watching for the first low flame on the nearest hill before lighting its own; the night comes to be called Oidhche na Glaiçe^{39, 40}

33. ← Follows from *Lots drawn for the slab*, 29 am Màrt, GE 4,350.

34. the column at Cnoc ghorm

35. ← Leads to *Luchd-faire na Lice settle at nine*, 28 an Gearran, GE 4,353.

36. the keepers of the slab, chosen by lot

37. ← Follows from *The keepers number nine*, 28 an Gearran, GE 4,353.

38. the coloured coal

39. the night of the handful, Samhain

40. ← Follows from *Coal in every hearth by the handful*, 9 an Cèitean, GE 4,355.

- 8 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,358** — *Cnoc na Claise*⁴¹'s household refuses its handful (Cnoc na Claise). The descendants of Torcall Tochclair, who stayed by the trench where his brother was crushed, will not burn the handful with the rest of the hills and give no single answer twice for it; Catriona sends no one to compel them, and none at the slab asks her to.⁴²
- 28 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,360** — *The cord of Dùn ìseal grows to nine hundred knots* (Dùn ìseal). Finding she can no longer carry the whole tally of households in her own head, Catriona sets her people to counting them plainly on a knotted cord, a knot to a hearth, which grows through her years of holding to some nine hundred knots, the largest count made on Dia-thìr in the age; the king's own kin are never upon it.
- 4 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 4,361** — *Counting the households* (Dùn ìseal). The people of Catriona Mhòr count the households of the hills by knots on a cord, a knot to a hearth. The cord of Dùn ìseal is said to have borne some nine hundred knots, the greatest count made on Dia-thìr in this age.⁴³
- 2 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,364** — *The saying on the column recut* (Calbh Cnoc ghorm⁴⁴). The words on the column at Cnoc ghorm, worn shallow, are recut in their old grooves by a hand from the hill of the Stone Kings. Some later readers hold that the recutting changed a letter; none can prove which.⁴⁵
- 30 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 4,366** — *The tally stones of Seann Dunn are set back in their old order* (Seann Dunn). A family digging a house-floor into an old midden at Seann Dunn strikes a row of upright stones each cut with a single stroke, knows them for the tally stones of the coast's old people, and sets them back as they lay rather than break them for the floor, building further along the midden's shoulder instead.
- 1 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,367** — *The last Seann-Dhaoine*⁴⁶ midden disturbed (Seann Dunn). Households at the eastern Seann Dunn cut into the old midden for a house-floor and find the tally stones. They put them back in the order they lay and build elsewhere.⁴⁷
- 28 AN GEARRAN, GE 4,369** — *The south-eastern coast rows its dead to Eilean ìseal*. The custom grows along the south-eastern coast of rowing the newly dead out to Eilean ìseal rather than burying them on the mainland shore, whether learned from the old coast people's graves across the strait or come to of itself; the tellings let the question stand unsettled.
- 30 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,370** — *Eilean ìseal given to the dead* (Eilean ìseal). The households of the south-east coast begin to row their dead to Eilean ìseal, after the old manner of the Seann-Dhaoine⁴⁸. Whether they learned it from the Seann Vell graves on Eilean dhearg, or came to it of themselves, is not told.⁴⁹

41. the hill of the first trench for another vein (burg 198 in this age)

42. ← Follows from *A handful refused at Cnoc dbubh*, 10 an Giblean, GE 4,358.

43. → Caused by *The cord of Dùn ìseal grows to nine hundred knots*, 28 an t-Sultain, GE 4,360.

44. the column at Cnoc ghorm

45. → Caused by *A nameless hand recuts Calbh Cnoc ghorm*, 4 an t-Ògmhios, GE 4,351.

46. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

47. → Caused by *The tally stones of Seann Dunn are set back in their old order*, 30 am Faoilleach, GE 4,366.

48. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

- 31 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,370** — *Eilean chrom stays unfished*. No household puts out a boat to fish the waters of Eilean chrom, where Gilleasbuig Beag was left with no boat to come back in; his fire was seen three nights running the first year and then no more, and the island stays empty and unfished.
- 10 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 4,373** — *Gilleasbuig Beag's island* (Eilean chrom). Eilean chrom, where Gilleasbuig Beag was left, stays empty and unfished. His fire is seen on it for three nights, the tellings say, and then no more.⁵⁰
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 4,376** — *The keepers ask to be named* (Fèill Muileann òg⁵¹). The nine keepers of the slab ask Catriona Mhòr to declare their charge before the whole ford gathering, so that no king after her may draw the lot at Dùn ìseal. She neither refuses nor agrees, and the matter is left to the next age.⁵²
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 4,376** — *The nine keepers ask Catriona to declare their charge*. The nine of Luchd-faire na Lice⁵³ come up together at the ford and ask Catriona, then in her twenty-ninth year of holding, to declare their charge over the slab, the lot and the handful before the whole gathering so that no king after her may reach for it as Calum Ciar once did; she names the eldest of them by his own line before he finishes bowing.⁵⁴
- 9 AN T-IUCHAR, GE 4,376** — *Catriona answers the keepers: not this year, ask me again*. Catriona gives the nine keepers neither refusal nor consent, telling them only, "Not this year," and then, before the eldest can press her further, "Ask me again"; the nine go back to their own fires by the slab to wait.⁵⁵
- 4 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,380** — *Eòin Beul-binn and Ùna Ruadh die within two years of each other*. Eòin, whose voice carried the whole roll of Rìghrean na Cloiche⁵⁶ across one night at the ford, dies in his eightieth year, and Ùna, who answered him roll for roll for An Cnoc Ruadh⁵⁷, follows him within two years in her seventy-third; the telling of that single night passes from then on at second hand.⁵⁸
- 9 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,389** — *Catriona falls ill on the hill* (Dùn ìseal). In her two hundred and eighty-ninth year the sickness comes on Catriona that will not leave again; she keeps her seat at Dùn ìseal as long as she is able, still able to give a household's whole line back seven names, and the nine keepers, hearing of it, send no word asking again.⁵⁹

49. → Caused by *The south-eastern coast rows its dead to Eilean ìseal*, 28 an Gearran, GE 4,369.

50. → Caused by *Eilean chrom stays unfished*, 31 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,370.

51. the fair at Muileann òg

52. ← Leads to *The nine keepers ask Catriona to declare their charge*, 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 4,376; ← Leads to *Catriona answers the keepers: not this year, ask me again*, 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 4,376.

53. the keepers of the slab, chosen by lot

54. ← Follows from *The keepers ask to be named*, 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 4,376.

55. ← Follows from *The keepers ask to be named*, 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 4,376.

56. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

57. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

58. ← Follows from *Catriona answers the keepers: not this year, ask me again*, 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 4,376.

59. ← Follows from *Eòin Beul-binn and Ùna Ruadh die within two years of each other*, 4 an t-Samhain, GE 4,380.

- 7 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,390** — *Seumas Òg dies on An Cnoc Ruadh*⁶⁰ (Cathair dhearg). Seumas Òg, the last name An Cnoc Ruadh's spoken roll carries, dies in his seventy-first year in the winter before Catriona Mhòr, and the lake shore keeps no holder's fire for him after, only its own.⁶¹
- 4 AM MÀRT, GE 4,391** — *The king's kin bring their claims to the hill* (Dùn ìseal). After Catriona Mhòr's death every soul of the king's blood within three days' walk comes to Dùn ìseal to press a claim on the hill, each able to say the two names of a line whose second name is always Ailean's; the king hears every claim with the same still face.
- 12 AM MÀRT, GE 4,391** — *The king takes back the hill* (Dùn ìseal). Catriona Mhòr dies, and with her the list of the Stone Kings ends. Her kin put forward many claims to Dùn ìseal, and Ailean Mòr gives the hill to none of them. He comes to it himself and holds it in his own hand, as in the first days.⁶²
- 12 AM MÀRT, GE 4,391** — *The king holds the hill and gives it to none* (Dùn ìseal). The king tells the gathered claimants that no line among them is better than another and that Catriona Mhòr's line cannot be handed to a stranger's open palm; he will hold the hill himself, as before Gormshuil first took it up in his name.⁶³
- 21 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,395** — *The first marriage reckoned openly for a share*. A young man of a minor line is married to a woman three lines removed from the king, and his father says openly at the betrothal fire that the match is made to bring five lines instead of three nearer the front of the reckoning, should the king ever name an heir.
- 20 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 4,402** — *A daughters' claim disputed at a betrothal*. A household holding good grazing but no claim of its own is joined by marriage to one that claims through four generations of daughters, and the hill argues without settling whether a claim run through daughters weighs more or less than one run through sons.⁶⁴
- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,408** — *A betrothal broken over a nearer claim*. A grandmother breaks off her granddaughter's marriage within the month of its making, having found a nearer claim on the groom's own side that she judges would weigh the match's worth downward; the hill takes it as proof that every marriage among the blood is now made for its shares and not for anything else.⁶⁵
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,420** — *A household of the western slopes loses its grazing*. A household that has held grazing on the western slopes eleven generations is told, without reason given, to remove itself to ground of equal size two valleys over before winter; asked directly why, the king says only that a share given has always been a share that can be taken back.

60. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

61. ← Follows from *Seumas Òg of the Red Hill*, 23 an t-Iuchar, GE 4,347.

62. → Caused by *The king's kin bring their claims to the hill*, 4 am Màrt, GE 4,391; ← Leads to *The king holds the hill and gives it to none*, 12 am Màrt, GE 4,391.

63. ← Follows from *The king takes back the hill*, 12 am Màrt, GE 4,391.

64. ← Follows from *The first marriage reckoned openly for a share*, 21 an t-Sultain, GE 4,395.

65. ← Follows from *A daughters' claim disputed at a betrothal*, 20 an Dàmhair, GE 4,402.

15 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 4,480 — *Raonaid nic Ailein dies at the river-meadow.* Raonaid nic Ailein, the king's daughter, dies at her own river-meadow in her one thousand three hundred and eightieth year; the king sits with her the better part of a day and a night, as he sat once with Gormshuil and once with Somhairle, and speaks of it to no one after.⁶⁶

13 AN GEARRAN, GE 4,480 — *The king takes back Raonaid's grazing.* Within the month of Raonaid nic Ailein's burying the king sends word that the river-meadow grazing is wanted elsewhere and that Niall Òg, her nearest of that line, is to remove his household from it; Niall answers, as he has come to answer every such word, with a laugh.

66. ← Follows from *A household of the western slopes loses its grazing*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,420.

THE YEARS GE 4,501 – 4,603

- II AN GEARRAN, GE 4,520** — *Dùn dhearg will not bow* (Dùn dhearg). The king sends to Dùn dhearg and to the households east of the vein, bidding them come in to him. They send his messenger back with nothing, and swear among themselves that they will owe nothing to Dùn ìseal nor to its king. From that year the spears of the east are gathered at Dùn dhearg.¹
- II AN GEARRAN, GE 4,520** — *The king sends Niall Òg to Dùn dhearg* (Dùn ìseal). The king chooses Niall Òg to carry word east of the vein, bidding the households of Dùn dhearg come in to him at last, judging that a man known for asking nothing on his own account is less likely to be mistaken for the leading edge of a conquest.²
- 2 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,520** — *Niall Òg finds Dùn dhearg wanting nothing of the bill* (Dùn dhearg). Niall Òg crosses the vein and finds the double bank of Dùn dhearg larger and better kept than any western telling had prepared him for, its forges and granary proof of a country that has gone far, by its own hands, toward needing nothing from Dùn ìseal.³
- I AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 4,520** — *Fearghal Donn refuses the king's asking* (Dùn dhearg). Fearghal Donn, holder of Dùn dhearg, hears the king's messenger before the whole household and answers that his people have raised their own bank and buried their own dead without any man's leave, and will not be counted among a kin who marry for shares and wait a thousand years for a hill never given.⁴
- II AN T-IUCHAR, GE 4,520** — *Niall Òg carries the refusal home* (Dùn ìseal). Niall Òg rides back to Dùn ìseal and gives Fearghal Donn's word to the king plainly; the king says he had looked for no other answer, thanks him for the carrying of it, and turns to the next claim waiting for him.⁵
- 15 AM FAOILLEACH, GE 4,521** — *The spears of the east are kept to hand* (Dùn dhearg). Word reaches Dùn ìseal by traders, not by any messenger sent for the purpose, that the households about Dùn dhearg have begun keeping their own spears closer than ever before, against a quarrel none of them will name; the king does nothing about it that anyone can see.⁶
- 17 AN DÙBHLACHD, GE 4,541** — *A woman of Clann na Ceiste⁷ speaks over the child*. An old woman of Clann na Ceiste, come down from the slab to see the new child, tells Gille-Bride that a boy born short-lived among the long-lived will learn early what his own kin have never needed to learn until late: how much of a life can be made to matter in however much of it is given.⁸

1. ← Leads to *The king sends Niall Òg to Dùn dhearg*, 11 an Gearran, GE 4,520.

2. ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg will not bow*, 11 an Gearran, GE 4,520.

3. ← Follows from *The king sends Niall Òg to Dùn dhearg*, 11 an Gearran, GE 4,520.

4. ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg will not bow*, 11 an Gearran, GE 4,520.

5. ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg will not bow*, 11 an Gearran, GE 4,520.

6. ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg will not bow*, 11 an Gearran, GE 4,520.

7. the Children of the Question

8. ← Follows from *Gille-Bride's father born in Na Glinn Àrda*, 10 an Dàmhair, GE 4,292.

- 18 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,543** — *Ceallach is born in Na Glinn Àrda*⁹. A son is born to Gille-Bride of Somhairle's line in Na Glinn Àrda and is called Ceallach; he is slower to walk and to run than the children before him, the first sign, told back afterward, that the years were coming down faster in him than in his father.¹⁰
- 7 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,550** — *The eve of the Binding*. The handful is kept everywhere in the hills, the keepers are nine, the sharing before the storms is kept on every coast, and the saying is spoken at every gathering. None of it is yet declared, and no oath is yet sworn over the vein. The king holds Dùn ìseal in his own hand, his kin wait about him for their shares, and the spears of the east gather at Dùn dhearg.¹¹
- 11 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,570** — *Fearghal Donn dies at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Fearghal Donn, who had held Dùn dhearg since before Niall Óg was sent to him and sent back with nothing, dies an old man in his own bed at the fort; the households east of the vein bury him as they buried Ailis, without word sent to the hill and none expected back.¹²
- 9 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 4,570** — *Artair takes up the holding of Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). Artair, Fearghal Donn's son, takes up the holding of Dùn dhearg with no more ceremony than his father had used, and says at the burying itself that he will hold what his father held and ask nothing further of the hill until the day it asks something of him.¹³
- 14 AM MÀRT, GE 4,599** — *Gille-Bride's father dies in his three hundred and eighth year*. Gille-Bride's father dies at Samhain in his three hundred and eighth year, fewer years than his own father had, dying as most of that line has learned to die: without illness or wound, simply slower each year until one morning he does not rise from his own hearthstone.¹⁴
- 12 AN GIBLEAN, GE 4,599** — *Word runs that the kin will gather below Dùn ìseal* (Dùn ìseal). At the burying, word runs among the fires that the king's kin mean at last to come down out of their scattered holdings and gather in the valley below Dùn ìseal, each line with its own tents and its own fire, to wait together upon the shares left uncounted since Ca-trìona Mhòr's death.¹⁵
- 4 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,601** — *The kin come down household by household* (Dùn ìseal). Through the summer the king's kin come down into the valley below Dùn ìseal household by household and line by line, no single word sent to call any of them, until the valley holds more tents and more fires than any one household has ever seen gathered in one place.¹⁶

9. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

10. ← Follows from *A woman of Clann na Ceiste speaks over the child*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,541.

11. → Caused by *The first marriage reckoned openly for a share*, 21 an t-Sultain, GE 4,395; → Caused by *A household of the western slopes loses its grazing*, 17 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,420; → Caused by *The king takes back Raonaid's grazing*, 13 an Gearran, GE 4,480; → Caused by *The spears of the east are kept to hand*, 15 am Faoilleach, GE 4,521.

12. ← Follows from *Ceallach is born in Na Glinn Àrda*, 18 an t-Samhain, GE 4,543.

13. ← Follows from *Fearghal Donn dies at Dùn dhearg*, 11 an Cèitean, GE 4,570.

14. ← Follows from *Artair takes up the holding of Dùn dhearg*, 9 an t-Ògmhios, GE 4,570.

15. ← Follows from *The king takes back the hill*, 12 am Màrt, GE 4,391.

16. ← Follows from *The eve of the Binding*, 7 an Lùnastal, GE 4,550.

- 3 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 4,601** — *Murchadh Mòr brings his sons and grandsons down* (Dùn ìseal). Murchadh Mòr comes down from the northern plain with a column of sons and grandsons that takes three days to pass any one point on the road, carrying more tent-cloth, it is said, than the valley below Dùn ìseal has ever seen brought to one place at once.¹⁷
- 7 AN DÀMHAIR, GE 4,601** — *Eithne's knot-keeper counts every soul on the new ground* (Dùn ìseal). Eithne comes down from below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire¹⁸ with her own household, and her knot-keeper walks at its head with the household's cord wound about his arm, meaning to be seen keeping count of every soul who sets foot on the new ground, and does so from the first day to the last.¹⁹
- 5 AN T-SAMHAIN, GE 4,601** — *Ìomhar Dearg pitches nearest the vein* (Dùn ìseal). Ìomhar Dearg comes down from the eastern marches nursing a hundred years' grievance over river-grazing he judges his by use if not by the king's word, and pitches his tents nearer the vein than any other line thinks wise, exactly, everyone agrees, like him.²⁰
- 10 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,602** — *Sine nan Snaidhm keeps the cord of the whole valley* (Dùn ìseal). Sine nan Snaidhm, knot-keeper of the household cord at Dùn ìseal, walks the growing valley of tents checking each new fire against the cord she carries, so that within a season no soul is pitched there, of the king's blood or of any household following it down, whose count she has not kept.²¹
- 8 AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,602** — *A steward is set over every line* (Dùn ìseal). By the second summer a steward stands over every line camped below Dùn ìseal, holding no ground and no lordship, only charged to speak for its household at the common fires and see its people fed and housed while the waiting goes on, until the valley looks less like a gathering than a town that never raised walls.²²
- 8 AN CÈITEAN, GE 4,603** — *Sluagh an Ear²³ begins to gather at Dùn dhearg* (Dùn dhearg). In the spring Sluagh an Ear begins gathering at Dùn dhearg under Artair, who is said to have waited three years, since he first took up his father's holding, for the very stillness of the hill to break; word of the gathering reaches the western fires within the week.²⁴
- 30 AN T-ÒGMHIOS, GE 4,603** — *Gille-Bride and Ceallach come down to see the valley* (Dùn ìseal). Gille-Bride walks down out of Na Glinn Àrda²⁵ with Ceallach, now grown but already, though neither says it, walking more slowly than a man of his years should, and the two stand at evening looking over more fires than either has ever seen gathered at once.²⁶

17. ← Follows from *The kin come down household by household*, 4 an t-Sultain, GE 4,601.

18. the watch-fort ruin

19. ← Follows from *Murchadh Mòr brings his sons and grandsons down*, 3 an Dàmhair, GE 4,601.

20. ← Follows from *Eithne's knot-keeper counts every soul on the new ground*, 7 an Dàmhair, GE 4,601.

21. ← Follows from *Ìomhar Dearg pitches nearest the vein*, 5 an t-Samhain, GE 4,601.

22. ← Follows from *Sine nan Snaidhm keeps the cord of the whole valley*, 10 an Lùnastal, GE 4,602.

23. the host of Dùn dhearg and the eastern households

24. ← Follows from *Dùn dhearg will not bow*, 11 an Gearran, GE 4,520.

25. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

26. ← Follows from *Sluagh an Ear begins to gather at Dùn dhearg*, 8 an Cèitean, GE 4,603.

- 5 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *Sine nan Snaidhm names Gille-Bride the one soul asking nothing* (Dùn ìseal). Sine nan Snaidhm tells Gille-Bride that his name is on no cord she carries, since he has asked for no ground and no share from anyone, and that he is, that night, the only soul in the whole valley of whom that can be said.²⁷
- 20 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *The king goes down to meet the east with a handful of household* (Dùn ìseal). Near the end of summer the king comes down from Dùn ìseal with no more than three tents' worth of his own household, going to meet the east himself, while every line camped in the valley says, each at its own fire, that it will follow him within a day or two.²⁸
- 21 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *The king sends Gille-Bride home to the hills* (Dùn ìseal). Gille-Bride asks the king plainly whether he too should come down to the ford; the king tells him to go home to his own people instead, since whatever comes of it will want telling afterward by someone who was not in it, and his line has always been better at the telling than the coming.²⁹
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *The host of Dùn dhearg musters at the ford* (Dùn dhearg). Every household east of the vein sends its spears down to the river below Dùn dhearg in the last days of an Lùnastal, camping the whole night along a mile of the east bank under Artair mac Fhearghail, meaning to hold the crossing before the king's kin can gather against them.
- 29 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *Artair mac Fhearghail recalls the answer sent to the king* (Dùn dhearg). At the fires the first night, Artair mac Fhearghail repeats to the host the answer his father Fearghal Donn once sent back with the king's messenger, that the households east of the vein would keep their own bank and owed the hill at Dùn ìseal nothing, and says the answer has not changed in eighty years.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *The east finds the king alone at the ford* (Dùn dhearg). At sunrise the host of Dùn dhearg finds a single man sitting on the stone at the head of the ford, his kin nowhere on the far bank; word runs down the fires that the king's own household has quarrelled over the shares of his kingdom and would not follow him east.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *The first rush breaks on the king at the ford* (Dùn dhearg). Two hundred spears go into the ford together at sunrise on the first day and are thrown back with the king alone in the water among them; the host sees the river run red below the crossing before the morning mist has fully lifted.
- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *The east tries the ford's edges and its throwing spears* (Dùn dhearg). Through the first day the host tries the deep channel above and below the ford to come at the king from the side, and by afternoon empties its fletchers' whole store throwing spears from the bank; neither the crossing nor the throwing turns him from his stone.

27. ← Follows from *Gille-Bride and Ceallach come down to see the valley*, 30 an t-Ògmhios, GE 4,603.

28. ← Follows from *The eve of the Binding*, 7 an Lùnastal, GE 4,550.

29. ← Follows from *The king goes down to meet the east with a handful of household*, 20 an Lùnastal, GE 4,603.

- 30 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *A household of Caol shean loses a man to the first day's ford* (Dùn dhearg). A net-mender's kinsman of Caol shean, twenty years unhurt at every boundary quarrel of the eastern country, goes into the first rush and is not seen to come out of the river; his wife asks after him at every fire down the bank until evening, then asks no more.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *The dead of the host begin to dam the ford* (Dùn dhearg). On the second day the drowned and the slain lie so thick at the shallows below the crossing that the river backs up over the gravel, running warm and red, and the men of Dùn dhearg must climb their own dead to reach water shallow enough to cross.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *The king draws a boy of Dùn dhearg from the river with his own hand* (Dùn dhearg). In the press of the second day the king takes the spear from the hands of a sixteen-year-old of the eastern host as a mother takes a knife from a child, and the boy is carried out alive on the east bank; the telling of that hand is kept by the east long after his name is forgotten.
- 31 AN LÙNASTAL, GE 4,603** — *Artair mac Fhearghail counsels the host to go in together* (Dùn dhearg). On the second night, with some of the host ready to go home, Artair mac Fhearghail tells the fires that the king is flesh and must have an end, as a cliff has an end before the sea, and counsels every spear of the east to go into the river together on the third day and not draw back.
- I AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,603** — *The whole strength of the east goes into the river together* (Dùn dhearg). At first light on the third day every spear the east country has enters the ford at once and does not draw back, the host closing on the king from three sides the whole day long while the dead already in the water rise higher than the shallows had ever stood.
- I AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,603** — *A light is seen on the water around the king* (Dùn dhearg). In the afternoon of the third day men near the middle of the ford see a light low along the river's surface where the king stands, of no colour any of them had a word for, and say afterward only that they saw every colour in it and none, and would say no more.
- I AN T-SULTAIN, GE 4,603** — *The king's kin fail to come to the ford* (Dùn dhearg). Through all three days at the ford below Dùn dhearg, no household of the king's own blood, and no spear of the hills, comes down the western track to stand with him; Sluagh an Ear³⁰ has the river to itself the whole time.

30. the host of Dùn dhearg and the eastern households

PART EIGHT

A Gazetteer of the Age

A

Achadh chaol (Achadh chaol). Founded 27 an Gearran, GE 2,475. A settlement in the east where, across three dry summers from the two thousand four hundred and sixty-sixth year, households burned back the old scrub a field's width at a time and ploughed the black ground while the ash still held its warmth, taking the first year a crop the older fields to the west had not equalled in a generation. The stones they picked from the new fields they laid in banks round each field, and those banks bound the fields for the rest of the age. Known for fields cleared by fire and bounded by picked stone.

Achadh dhìreach (Baile Mòr dhomhain). Founded 16 an Cèitean, VE 303. The oldest hearths of Na Glinn Àrda¹ stand at Achadh dhìreach. In the nine hundred and second year three brothers clearing a strip for barley turned up a hearth laid true and never lit, and the valley left the strip unploughed and covered the hearth with peat until no living person remembered where it lay. Anna nic Coinnich was born two fields from it and kept the full hand all her life. In the thousand and sixty-sixth year Eanraig Ruadh, old and cold, burned a whole basket of an gual dathach² in one night, and his house went up in a flame of a colour no one had a word for, with his wife Beathag and a grandchild within; the hearthstone split and ran with colour until the king knelt and laid his hand across it and it greyed. The king named the full hand a good custom and made no law of it. Eanraig's son kept the grey stone for his new hearth, and one of the four stone cups was ground here in Oighrig's years. Known for the unlit hearth and the basket burning.

Achadh mhòr (Achadh mhòr). Founded 2 an t-Samhain, GE 4,000. A field country near Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh³ in the east, where in the four thousand and eighth year a household cleared and banked the widest single field the eastern country had yet cut from the rough, the largest of the age. It laid its bank on the stones of an older wall whose builders none could name, and grew in a good year wheat enough for three households where before there had been land for none. Known for the widest field of the age.

Achadh naomh (Achadh naomh). Founded 5 an t-Ògmhios, GE 4,091. A settlement in the north beside a spring held sacred, whose settlers led the water round in channels of their own digging and fenced the spring before a single wall was raised, so that a stranger coming on the place might take the water, and not the people, for what had been settled there. They watered their fields from the channels and would not build over the spring. Known for the spring fenced before any house.

Achadh shean (Achadh shean). Founded 21 an Giblean, GE 3,125. An old field in the east whose wells fell a hand lower than any digger remembered in the two thousand and third year. A shepherd's boy walked three days to Dùn ìseal to say that the field banks his grandfather raised had cracked from dryness; the springs stopped outright, and the households walked off their old banks and cut new fields lower on the slope. Sileas Bhàn refused to have the dead field pulled down, saying a bank tells a household what the ground once gave and what it stopped giving. The households came back in the three thousand one hundred and twenty-fifth year, cut new fields on the higher ground, and sank a deep well before they broke a furrow; the well did not fail again in the age. Known for the drought and the well dug first.

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

2. the coloured coal

3. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

An Cnoc Ruadh⁴ (now Cathair dhearg) (Cathair dhearg). Founded 6 an Dàmhair, GE 18. An Cnoc Ruadh stood above the western end of Loch chrom, a palisaded hall over salt-pans and boats, held by a line older than the king's crowning. Beathag Ruadh held it when the valleys came in to the king and did not come; Uisdean Mòr cut the ditch across the neck, and saw his palisade burned twice, and at last knelt in the ford to put his hands between the king's in the two hundred and ninetieth year. Seonag weighed the salt tallies before the king with a pebble bag; Murchadh Gearr walked Rathad an t-Salainn⁵ every autumn; Lachlann Ruadh took Eilidh Ghlas's younger son to foster and was called Lachlann an Al-traim for it. Peigi Dhubh laid the stone landing at the river-mouth, and the harbour grew round it. The hill traded salt for Dùn ìseal's wool at the ford fourteen miles off, and its reciters kept their own roll, from Beathag Ruadh to Seumas Òg, which was spoken whole at the ford only once. Known for salt, the palisade, and the fosterling.

Àth àrsaidh (Àth àrsaidh). Founded 12 an t-Samhain, GE 3,458. An ancient ford in the north-west near a quarry of green stone, whose polished axes were carried all over the island in the three thousand four hundred and ninety-sixth year, too fine for work, laid unused in graves and under house floors. Ìomhar Dearg asked the cutters for one to carry and use and was told no green axe was ever cut to be swung, only shown; he had a common grey axe made instead and used it forty years. The few households who worked the quarry traded in nothing else, and the chips about it lay knee-deep. The seam ran thin under every cut, and in the three thousand five hundred and forty-seventh year the last cutter who held the old skill died with no apprentice; the quarry was forsaken, and the axes ceased. Known for the green axes never swung.

Àth bheag (Àth bheag). Founded 26 an Cèitean, GE 4,347. A small ford on the far eastern coast, settled in the four thousand three hundred and forty-seventh year, the easternmost dwelling of the age on the main island. Its households went out in boats after the geese on the islands offshore and raked salt from the flats beside the ford. It sent its geese-feathers inland by the traders' road and knew the hill only by report. The households kept the sharing before the storms as the coast kept it, weighing their surplus by the count of mouths on the shingle, and they cut the eight wind-names on a driftwood post above the landing so that a boat going out after the geese might know which wind would bring it home. Known for the geese on the islands.

Àth fhiadhaich (Àth fhiadhaich). Founded 13 an Dùbhlachd, GE 4,325. A stony crossing in the south-eastern hills where wild cattle came down to drink. Households settled it in the four thousand three hundred and twenty-fifth year and reared the calves born on the near bank apart from the wild herd, until within three generations that ford's cattle were spoken of the length of the coast as the best in the hills. The settlers came from the valleys under Dùn ìseal and kept the sharing before the storms, bringing calves as their surplus rather than grain. Their herds were driven to the ford in the autumns, and in the years of the waiting below the hill they sold beasts to the camps of the king's kin. Known for the wild cattle's ford.

4. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

5. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

Àth gharbh (Cuan ghlas). Founded 13 an Gearran, VE 4,424. A rough ford on the drovers' road through Na Glinn Àrda⁶, where the beasts were rested and watered. In a hearth of peat ash here the valleys say an gual dathach⁷ was first burned by a household outside Clann a' Chlachair⁸, one sliver at a time. The custom of the full hand is told as beginning among the few households of this ford, after a sick child was warmed too generously, and from here it spread to every hearth of Na Glinn Àrda within a few years. In Oighrig's keeping a woman of Àth gharbh ground the first of the copies of the stone cup, measuring against Niocol Snaidhear's cup throughout, and she finished it quickest of the three. Coinneachadh nan Cupan⁹ was held at a nameless spring on the moor between Àth gharbh and Tobar dhireach, chosen because it lay equal walking from all four places. The drovers who rested there carried the custom of the full hand and the tidings of the cups the length of Na Glinn Àrda, and the ford's own households were among the first to sit a turn at the slab when the watch was drawn from every part of the hills. Known for the drovers' ford where the full hand began.

Àth mhòr (Àth mhòr). Founded 1 an t-Ògmhios, GE 1,847. A great ford of the north on the far eastern circuit of Rathad na Spor¹⁰. In the thousand eight hundred and fifty-third year a young man of the ford cut a hawk into his father's door-lintel by firelight over three evenings, wings closed and the head turned back over the shoulder; he said only that the shape had come to him whole one night and would not leave him alone until he had cut it. Murchadh watched him cut it. It is the oldest carving of a hawk on the island, and of any bird, and the lintel was set again over every door the household built after. Known for the hawk lintel.

Àth shean (Àth shean). Founded 9 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,361. The old ford below Dùn ìseal where the road west crosses its river. A careful household of the ford dug a grain pit under its byre floor against nothing it could name, and brought nothing of it to the sharing; in the lean storm season of the two thousand three hundred and seventy-seventh year the daughter of the house, Beasag, saw the division made by the count of mouths and the next spring told a neighbour the truth of the pit. Tormod Liath asked only whether she had told it of her own will, and sent to open the floor. The household was given until dark to take what it could carry and be off the ford's ground: the first punishment under the sharing that is remembered. It settled east of the vein and dug no pit under its new floor. The pit kept the man's name for generations, and stood empty. Eilidh Ghlas knelt here to her younger son's height when he went west to be fostered. Known for the hidden pit, and the first punishment.

6. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

7. the coloured coal

8. the Mason's children, the Mason's line

9. the meeting of the cups

10. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

B

Baile chrom (Baile chrom). Founded 2 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,464. A settlement on the far north-west coast where, after two failed fishing seasons in the nineteen hundred and sixty-sixth year, the stores went to bark and boiled seaweed and the graves were laid two deep for want of time to dig them singly; no older hunger on Dia-thìr is tied to a place. The king rode north-west with the first grain that could be spared, by a road that had never carried him, and Sileas Bhàn sent carts after him for the whole coast. The ground lay empty for five hundred years. In the two thousand four hundred and sixty-fourth year households from Cnoc ghorm settled it again, and Somhairle found them already byred and welled, the old field-marks half sunk beneath the new grass. They dug their storage pits deeper than any others on the coast. Known for the hunger, and the deep pits.

Baile dhomhain (Baile ghorm). Founded 7 an t-Samhain, GE 2,388. A settlement a short walk inland of Baile ghorm, across whose fields the panthers' road ran. In the two thousand four hundred and thirty-first year its households began cutting a sign on their gateposts at the start of the crossing season and scraping it away at its close, the first mark the island's tellers know cut for a season rather than for any one event; by the two thousand four hundred and forty-seventh year the custom was kept at every gate. The households shut their stock in while the cats passed. Known for the gatepost sign of the crossing season.

Baile fhiadhaich (Baile fhiadhaich). Founded 17 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,709. A settlement on the western coast where the boars ran heaviest in the thickets. Its settlers hung boar tusks over their doors and took boar for their chief meat for the rest of the age, and the island came to know a man of that place by his gait, from a lifetime of walking ground a boar might break from underfoot. Its households kept the sharing before the storms by bringing boar meat salted in An Cnoc Ruadh¹'s salt, and it was said at the ford that no settlement of the west brought fatter shares or quarrelled longer over the weighing of them. Known for boar tusks over the doors.

Baile gharbh (Baile gharbh). Founded 15 an Lùnastal, GE 2,662. The stony ground north-east of Murchadh's spring, settled by households who kept sheep where the land would bear nothing heavier. They sent their wool south along the coast road to Cruinneachadh an Àtha² rather than north to Murchadh's own granary, and the wool market they kept grew with the flocks of the moor settlements about them. The flocks were small and hardy, and the households cut the eight wind-names into their fold-posts, reading weather by the post that stood in the lee. Their wool came to the ford in bales tied with their own twisted rope, and was known there by it. Known for sheep and wool for the ford.

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

2. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

Baile gheal (Baile gheal). Founded 27 an Giblean, GE 4,347. A settlement founded on the south-western plain in the four thousand three hundred and forty-seventh year, round a house whose walls were limed white. The lime was burned from the shells of Seann-Dhaoine^{3'} middens along the coast, which the settlers judged no one's any longer to keep; the households took their name from the house and kept its walls white every spring. It traded cloth and lime along the coast road and sent its people to the ford. The settlers came from the older harbours of the south-west, and the first of them to lime her walls white did so, the telling says, so that her husband could find the house from the sea in the dusk. Known for the white-limed house.

Baile ghlas (Baile ghlas). Founded 7 an Cèitean, GE 4,047. A harbour along the lake shore from An Cnoc Ruadh⁴, where the hill's households drew up their boats in sheds of stone and turf. Within a generation of the first sheds the boats kept there put out oftener than from An Cnoc Ruadh's own strand, and in the four thousand and forty-seventh year it was An Cnoc Ruadh's fishing harbour in all but the reciters' naming. It was never banked or palisaded, trusting to the hill above it. Its boat-sheds were built long and low against the lake's winds, each shed holding two boats, and the households of the hill took turns at the drawing-up after every storm. Its fishers were among the first on the lake to cut the paired tide-marks on their own landing stones. Known for An Cnoc Ruadh's boat-sheds.

Baile ghorm (Baile ghorm). Founded 7 an t-Ògmhios, GE 622. Tràigh an t-Salainn⁵ of the south, where the salt-folk scraped the flats and dried the crust on the shingle. In the six hundred and seventy-second year Mòrag Chruaidh came down on it with eleven spears and took salt, losing seven of her own, whose names the hill kept at its fire. In the six hundred and eighty-third year they made shallow clay basins behind the shingle bar, the first salt-works of the island, and raised a bank behind the pans. Iain Dubh came down in the seven hundred and twenty-seventh year at dawn with more spears, and Tadhg Garbh's spear killed him on the clay. The next summer the king walked south alone; the salt-folk raised spears against him and lowered them, and old Mòr knelt on the wet shingle and gave him a double handful of salt, and from that day the shore was called the king's. The salt-folk built a cairn of their own with seven stones in it, and in the fosterling's day An Cnoc Ruadh's own salt refrain was sung at their pans in words An Cnoc Ruadh itself could no longer construe. Known for the salt-pans and the double handful.

3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

4. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

5. the salt shore

6. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

Baile Mòr mhòr (Baile Mòr mhòr). Founded 13 an t-Sultain, GE 2,616. A rise on the northern plain above a spring that ran clear through every winter, where Murchadh Mòr raised his hall in the two thousand six hundred and sixteenth year after the king sent him north with sixty households. The households of the plain named the place Baile Mòr mhòr before it had earned the size of the name; at its height it held some eighty houses, the largest place north of An Cnoc Ruadh⁷. Murchadh's eleven sons, born over the better part of three centuries, were each given a corner of the plain to hold under their father. The king's summons to An Cruinneachadh Mòr⁸ reached it in the two thousand nine hundred and ninety-ninth year, and Murchadh rode south with sixty of his household. Known for Murchadh's hall by the spring that never froze.

Baile Mòr ruadh (Seann Tarr). Founded 15 an Lùnastal, GE 3,311. A broad red-earthed rise near the eastern Seann Dunn, settled in the middle of na Bliadhnachan Fada⁹ by households who called the ground around them empty though Seann-Dhaoine¹⁰ middens lay a morning's walk away and plainly said otherwise. They dug into nothing of what lay there. The settlement grew into a place of some size by the three thousand three hundred and eleventh year, raising its houses of the red stone of the rise. Known for the empty ground beside the middens.

C

Cala nan Taighean Cruinne¹. Founded 3 an t-Sultain, GE 1,347. A harbour of round, turf-roofed houses at the deep-water side of the river mouth below Loch chrom, near enough An Cnoc Ruadh² to pay it salt. The first houses were raised in the thousand three hundred and forty-seventh year, where the king's blood had first come down to the sea, and within a season the households were paying their salt to An Cnoc Ruadh rather than keeping it among themselves, with no word sent from Dùn Ìosal to start it. An Cnoc Ruadh's list counts them among its holder's households, and the harbour's boats carried salt up the lake to the ford in the autumns. Known for the round houses that paid An Cnoc Ruadh salt.

Caol bheag (Caol bheag). Founded 14 an Lùnastal, GE 2,414. A river-mouth settlement of fishing households on the north coast, at the mouth of the Abhainn ghorm. They fixed the custom of naming each boat for the wind it was built to fish in, held a boat unlucky under any other wind, and never gave a drowned boat's name again. The custom was settled by the two thousand four hundred and forty-seventh year and spread along the north coast with the wind-names themselves. Known for boats named for the winds.

7. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

8. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

9. the long years of Ailean's kin

10. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

1. the round-house harbour paying salt to the Red Hill (burg 26 in this age)

2. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

Caol fhiadhaich (Caol fhiadhaich). Founded 12 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,547. A river-mouth on a wild strait where, in the thousand five hundred and ninety-eighth year, households staked a fence of woven wattle out into the ebb to trap salmon on the falling tide. The fence washed out twice before the third setting held, and the same line of stake-holes was fished again every year after through the rest of the age. Its smoked salmon went to Cruinneachadh an Àtha³ and along the coast road. Known for the fish-fence and its stake-holes.

Caol gharbh (Caol gharbh). Founded 10 am Màrt, GE 4,128. A settlement on the rough strait of the north-east coast, taken up in the four thousand one hundred and twenty-eighth year by households who fished the strait in skin boats. They laid paddles beside their dead, and their boats were heavier in the beam than any on that coast, for the strait's sake. Its fishers named their boats for the winds as the north coast did, and gave no drowned boat's name again. In the lean years they brought dried fish inland to the sharing, and a household that kept its catch back found no boat willing to put out beside it the next season. Known for the paddles laid beside the dead.

Caol leathan (Caol leathan). Founded 12 am Faoilleach, GE 1,560. A settlement on the wide strait on the western coast where, in the thousand five hundred and sixty-second year, a household set a hollowed stone with seal oil and a wick of moss on its hearth-ledge and lit it: the first light on Dia-thìr that was not a hearth, giving little smoke. Within three winters every house on that stretch kept one burning through the dark months, and the lamps went along the coast with the seal-hunters. Known for the first seal-oil lamps.

Caol mhòr (Caol mhòr). Founded 31 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,462. The great strait in the north-west, where Seann-Dhaoine⁴ once hunted seal and heaped their shell middens high along the strand. Hill-folk households settled here in the two thousand four hundred and sixty-second year and built on the middens, raising their walls, where they built in stone at all, from what the tide had not carried off. They would not turn a stone that carried a mark, cut or worn, and laid those aside in an unmortared line along the shore, so that two kinds of wall stood there side by side. Known for the marked stones laid aside.

Caol ruadh (Muileann naomh). Founded 14 an Giblean, GE 2,570. A fishing strait on the southern coast named for the red rock that watches it. Its fishers took to tying woven buoys over the deep channels where the current ran hardest, a custom that spread along the coast in carriers' mouths as the paired tide-marks had spread before it. The settlement was taken up in earnest in the two thousand five hundred and seventieth year, and it traded with the harbour of Seann Skell and the marsh settlement at Muileann naomh. Its households kept the sharing before the storms along the whole strait, and in A' Ghaoth Dhubh⁵'s winter sent dried fish north along the coast road with the grain from the valleys. Known for the buoys over the channels.

3. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

4. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

5. the Black Wind

Caol shean (Caol shean). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, GE 4,196. An old river port on the narrows of the Abhainn ìseal east of the vein. In the four thousand and fifty-eighth year two households quarrelling over a stretch of the landing sat out a night together and gave the ground to the landing itself, for whoever had a boat drawn up there; within two generations they were thoroughly mixed by marriage. By the four thousand two hundred and twenty-eighth year it was the river landing of the hill households of the east, where salt, fish and seal-skins came up from the coast; a cloth-trader passing through told the child Ailis of the young-faced man at the gate of Dùn ìseal, and she married a net-mender of the landing. Known for the landing given to no one.

Cathair fhada (Cathair fhada). Founded 13 an Cèitean, GE 2,523. A long ridge in the south between the valleys and the coast, where households settled in the middle centuries within an earth bank. It dug and lined a well inside its own earthwork in the two thousand four hundred and sixty-seventh year so that its water-carriers need not go down to the shore while a storm still had teeth in it, and the town was taken up in earnest a generation later. It traded south to the coast and north to the ford, and sent its people to An Cruinneachadh Mòr⁶ in the three thousandth year. Its households kept the handful by the cup and the sharing by the count of mouths, and in the lean years they opened their store within the bank to the coast below them as Dùn ìseal had opened its own. Known for the well within the bank.

Cathair gheal (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 5 am Màrt, GE 1,378. A rise above the firth on the far western coast, where a long-house forty paces long, byre and hall under one roof, was raised in the thousand four hundred and sixteenth year, timbered from Rathad na Spor⁷'s own hills and roofed with turf. It was the greatest building of the age in the north-west and was spoken of the length of the coast. A spark from an untended hearth caught the byre-end thatch four years later and the hall burned with the byre; the household raised it again on the same footing before the next winter, holding the ground proved good whatever the fire proved of the roof, and left its scorch mark for anyone to see. It burned and was raised again once more before the age was out. Known for the long-house burned twice.

Cathair mhòr (Cathair mhòr). Founded 9 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,847. Households settled on the ground below a broken watch-tower of Seann-Dhaoine⁸ in the two thousand eight hundred and forty-seventh year and asked Eithne nic Ailein, then a hundred and forty-four years old, to lay out their fields; she stayed. Her households named the place Cathair mhòr, the great city, out of hope rather than size, and took no stone from the ruin above them though it was the nearest quarry. Eithne's knot-keeper walked at the head of her household with its cord about his arm when she came down to the valley below Dùn ìseal in the last years. Known for Eithne's fields below the ruined tower.

6. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

7. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

8. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

Ceann àrsaidh (Ceann àrsaidh). Founded 17 an t-Sultain, GE 4,328. A point on the Abhainn fhionn where households from An Cnoc Ruadh⁹'s country found an old river landing, its stones set for a boat's keel by hands none living could name, and built their houses about it in the four thousand three hundred and twenty-eighth year. They named the place for what they found, the ancient headland, and used the landing as they found it rather than mend it, as settlers did wherever Seann-Dhaoine¹⁰ work still stood. The households came down from the lake shore by boat, and the landing took their boats at every state of the river as it had taken Seann-Dhaoine' boats. They kept An Cnoc Ruadh's roll at their fires as their own. Known for the old landing on the Abhainn fhionn.

Ceann chiar (Seann Tarr). Founded 10 an Dùbhlachd, GE 2,404. A harbour on the eastern coast at the southern end of the shore A' Ghaoth Dhubh¹¹ stripped. It fed the people of Cuan ruadh through the winter after the storm out of its shared surplus, and no one on that coast is known to have died of hunger that season. Rebuilding after A' Ghaoth Dhubh, the households set a stone in the midst of their houses and cut a plain stroke on it for every house the wind had taken, two-and-twenty marks in a row with no names beside them. Known for the stone of the twenty-two houses.

Ceann leathan (Seann Chwen). Founded 19 an t-Samhain, GE 2,061. A broad headland on the gulf where, in the two thousand and seventy-sixth year, three brothers of the point, Aonghas, Dùghlas and Ailig mac Torcaill, quarried eight stones from an outcrop above the landing and raised them in a ring, one for each of the named winds, so a sailor might lay a hand on the stone of the wind he wanted before he put out. The stone of the hardest offshore wind settled crooked in a bad winter and was dug out and reset on a footing of smaller stones, standing straighter and newer than its seven fellows ever after. The yearly contests of strength were held below Clachan nan Gaoth¹², and it was here that Alasdair Làidir threw every man at three-and-twenty and a grey stranger lifted the black boulder to his knees and set it down gently. Known for Clachan nan Gaoth and the lifted boulder.

Ceann mhin (Ceann mhin). Founded 26 an Dùbhlachd, GE 3,028. A harbour on the south-eastern shore below Làrach an Dùin¹³, the ruin of the old builders, settled by fishing households in the three thousand and twenty-eighth year. They built their houses with doors to the sea and backs to the broken walls, and would not go up to the ruin or carry off its dressed stone lying loose for the taking; an old woman of that shore said a wall raised by other hands keeps its own quarrel. The contests below Clachan nan Gaoth¹⁴ at Ceann leathan drew its young men every autumn, and it was a son of this shore's herders, Alasdair Làidir, who threw every man who stood against him at three-and-twenty. Known for the harbour under the ruin.

9. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

10. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

11. the Black Wind

12. the ring of eight wind-stones at Ceann leathan

13. the fortress ruin

14. the ring of eight wind-stones at Ceann leathan

Cnoc àrsaidh. Founded 14 an t-Samhain, GE 2. The hill in the north-west where a pit was worked for the only good flint on Dia-thir, its grey flakes carried to hearths from one end of the island to the other. The carriers' track ran from the pit-mouth south and east toward Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹⁵, and by the thousand eight hundred and seventeenth year it was worn a yard deep. Murchadh, the king's son by Beitris, came here with the flint-carriers in the thousand seven hundred and sixtieth year and carried a yoke for three seasons before any man learned whose son he was; he walked the road with Ailig Spor for the whole of the years it gave them, and when Ailig took the lighter work of tallying at the pit-mouth Murchadh came back through at the turn of every season to sit an evening with him. After Ailig's burying Murchadh set it as a standing custom that the first flake of any new working be given free to whoever asked. Known for the flint-pit and the free first flake.

Cnoc àrsaidh (Cnoc àrsaidh). Founded 11 am Màrt, GE 2,405. A southern settlement near Imrich nam Pantar¹⁶, where Gilleonan bored four holes along a hollow bird-bone in the two thousand four hundred and twenty-eighth year and found a note he could raise and lower at will; children of three households gathered to hear him play. The bone pipes are the oldest instruments of the island. The households kept watch on the passes in the crossing season, and in that same spring three great cats were seen to turn back at the highest pass. Known for the bone pipes.

Cnoc bheag (Cnoc bheag). Founded 5 an t-Sultain, GE 3,908. A settlement on the bank of the Abhainn ìseal a short walk from the old standing stone. The generation that settled it in the three thousand nine hundred and eighth year set its houses, by no law anyone could name, so that no door faced the stone, and every household built after kept the same pattern unquestioned. Known for no door facing the stone.

Cnoc bheag (Cill thais). Founded 8 an t-Iuchar, GE 2,453. A settlement at the edge of Coille Naomh Cnoc bheag¹⁷, raised by households come down from An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁸ in the middle of the age. They took their timber only from the river's far side and never from the unclaimed wood, and marked the line with a row of unhewn stones. When a boy not yet seven was lost past the stones in the two thousand four hundred and fifty-first year, the settlement and its neighbours searched three days into the wood without one sign of him; Iain of Muileann bhàn, lame from the passes, said aloud that a wood no household would fell was not a wood that gave back what it took, and the searchers stopped at the stones. Known for the line of stones at the forest's edge.

15. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

16. the panthers' crossing

17. the sacred forest at Cnoc bheag

18. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

Cnoc chaol. Founded 4 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,648. A village of low houses on the south coast under a narrow hill, where the sea rose past every mark it had kept in the seven hundred and seventy-seventh year and came in over the houses in the night, taking twelve of the shore's people and leaving a hand's depth of grey sand over every hearth it did not carry away. Seasaidh, seven years old, was carried up the slope by her mother; her father was among the twelve. The survivors rebuilt higher on the slope and left the old ground unbuilt, and when a lesser wave came in the three thousand eight hundred and seventeenth year it found only empty byres below the new houses. The measure of the full hand was ground into a stone cup here, despite two false starts, in Oighrig's keeping. Known for the wave, and the houses on the slope.

Cnoc chaol (Muileann dhearg). Founded 22 an Cèitean, GE 2,404. A settlement on a narrow hill in the near valleys, on poor ground. One of the four stone cups was ground here in Oighrig's keeping, and the copy was begun fastest of the three despite two false starts; the cups were sent back to the wheel when their levels would not match, until at Coinneachadh nan Cupan¹⁹ the water stood level in all four. From that year its households measured their handful of coal by the one cup and its copies. An old woman of Cnoc chaol was the first to say at the slab, in the judgement of Gilleasbuig Beag, that the vein was never any one hearth's to keep behind a cloth. Known for one of the four cups.

Cnoc fhionn (Baile ruadh). Founded 25 an t-Samhain, VE 3,715. A fair hill of sheltered farms in the north-east, settled long before the grove and keeping its old ways through the whole of na Bliadhnachan Fada²⁰. The king's word reached it late and lightly, and it was never asked for spears. Its barley went down to Seann-Dhaoine²¹ harbour at Seann Tarr while there were Seann-Dhaoine there to take it, and to the hill-folk who settled Seann Tarr after them. It sent its young to Cruinneachadh an Àtha²² from the time the gathering became yearly, and its ale went south with them. Known for barley, and the road to Seann Tarr.

Cnoc ghorm (Cnoc ghorm). Founded 15 an Dàmhair, GE 1,362. A green rise in the north-west where the settlements lived on seal, fish and deer until the thousand three hundred and seventy-ninth year, when small herds driven up Rathad na Spor²³ by stages over three summers brought cattle there for the first time. The first calves born on the rise were watched through their first winter by the whole settlement in turn. It became the farm town of the north-west, and its hides went south by Rathad na Spor. Known for the first cattle of the north-west.

19. the meeting of the cups

20. the long years of Ailean's kin

21. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

22. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

23. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

Cnoc na Claise²⁴. Founded 5 an Dàmhair, GE 2. A black hill in the east where Torcall Toch-lair, refused the marriage he was promised and restless at the coal-banks under the mountain, went with his brother Lachann and two other diggers to open a trench for a second vein. In the two thousand two hundred and sixty-seventh year the trench fell in on two of them, Lachann among them, and Torcall buried his brother at the trench's mouth and would not leave. He built a turf shelter at the trench's edge, and folk who came to the hill for one reason or another began to stay, since the ground was as good as any and the man who kept the trench asked nothing of them. He died there and was buried beside his brother. His household kept the ground, did not fill the trench in, and in Catriona's years refused to burn its handful of coal with the rest of the hills, giving no single answer twice for it. Known for the open trench and the refused handful.

Cnoc naomh (Cnoc naomh). Founded 10 an t-Samhain, GE 2,894. A hill south of the valleys already called, by no teller then living able to say why, the holy hill. Households came to it for its spring in the two thousand eight hundred and seventieth year and settled it in earnest a generation later, keeping its water and the fact of its holiness together without asking more of either. The households cut the spring's channel no deeper than they found it, and lit no fire within sight of the source. In An Cruinneachadh Mòr²⁵ of the three thousandth year they sent water from the holy spring to the ford in sealed pots, and it was poured into the river at dusk. Known for the spring of the holy hill.

Cnoc thais (Cnoc thais). Founded 19 an t-Sultain, GE 4,328. A damp hill in the north-west settled in the four thousand three hundred and twenty-eighth year by households who drained it with ditches before they built, and grazed its wet slopes with sheep. The ditches carried water through the rest of the age, and the households traded with the mill-folk of Muileann àr-saidh below them. The ditches were cut to a line the eldest of the settlers paced out alone over a whole wet winter, and no household afterward moved a ditch without the others walking it first. They measured their coal by the cup like every hearth of the hills. Known for the drained hill.

Cuan ruadh (Cuan ruadh). Founded 1 an t-Sultain, GE 2,387. The easternmost harbour of the island. In the two thousand four hundred and seventeenth year a storm out of the south-east stripped the thatch from every roof between Cuan ruadh and Ceann chiar and drove its boats onto the rocks below the headland; the coast named it A' Ghaoth Dhubh²⁶ for the ash-dark sky it left behind. The valleys sent grain unasked, weighed by the count of mouths, and the coast called it only the bringing-in. The winter after, Lileas, whose father's hand was maimed, kept a fire on the cape east of the village for boats coming home in the dark, the first of the five fires. Sixty years later the households laid stone to the eaves round the whole settlement, the first walls on that coast built against wind. Known for A' Ghaoth Dhubh, and Lileas's fire.

24. the hill of the first trench for another vein (burg 198 in this age)

25. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

26. the Black Wind

Cuan shean (Cuan shean). Founded 18 an t-Ògmhios, GE 2,755. A harbour on the west coast beside a stone landing built by hands none of its settlers could name, older than any wall near it. Households took it up in the two thousand six hundred and seventieth year and used the landing as they found it rather than mend it, out of the caution settlers kept wherever Seann-Dhaoine²⁷ work still stood; the harbour was fully settled by the two thousand seven hundred and fifty-fifth year and shipped the western grain along the coast. Known for the old landing used unattended.



Doire chiar (Doire chiar). Founded 8 an Giblean, GE 4,183. A settlement that grew up under the dark oaks in the north in the four thousand one hundred and eighty-third year. Its people penned pigs in the wood and drove them out to the acorns at the fall of the year, and felled no oak they could spare. The households of the dark oaks kept the full hand at their hearths like every settlement of the hills, and sent their measure to be tried against a copy of the stone cup when the lot for the slab came to be drawn from every part of the hills. Their pigs went to the ford in the autumns, driven the whole way on foot. Known for pigs driven to the acorns.

Doire ghlas (Doire ghlas). Founded 26 an Giblean, GE 2,470. The grey oak grove where the six pots of na Seachd Guail¹ were set under the oldest trees and Ailean kept his seven nights, fasting, until Coimhdeach na Fine² named him king. Coinneach, his brother, camped beyond the ring of oaks and could not cross it; he found his brother warm at dawn with the frost standing off him in a bare ring. For more than two thousand years no household built there, the grove being held the king's and Coimhdeach na Fine's and no one's else. In the two thousand four hundred and seventieth year households of the near valleys came down into its shelter and marked the old oaks for their byres; Somhairle asked Fearchar mac Ailig's household to spare the three oldest trunks, because his father had once set pots beneath them, and they cut their beams from younger growth. The houses ringed the three oaks within a generation, and the place was called the ring under the oaks. In the later centuries the moor crept up on it from the north, and the oaks drew back into the sheltered hollows. Known for the vigil and the three oaks left standing.

Doire shean (Doire shean). Founded 14 an Lùnastal, GE 695. An old oak grove on the south-west coast. In the seven hundred and fifth year pots of coiled clay, fired in open bonfires in the lee of the oaks, were first made here, and two of the first of them reached Dùn ìseal within the season. Within a few lifetimes the whole southern shore used them, and pots were among the first goods that strangers to both hills set out beside the wool and salt at the ford. The potters dug their clay from the same bank for generations and traded their wares down the drovers' roads. Known for the first pots.

27. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

1. the Seven Coals

2. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

Dùn chrom (Dùn chrom). Founded 7 am Faoilleach, GE 2,801. A banked hill-fort in the midst of the island, between An Cnoc Ruadh³ and the hills of the vein. Herders wanting the bank to face south and quarrymen wanting it to face north raised a single crooked earthwork that answered both wants at once and satisfied neither, and the fort stood from its first year with a name that fitted it more ways than its builders meant. Its holder Ruadhan Beag quarrelled two winters with the holder of Dùn thais over which way a bank ought to face, until Murchadh rode to hear them and left the ditch as it stood, finding a hundred years without an enemy a better argument than either holder made. Known for the bank that faced two ways.

Dùn dhearg (Dùn dhearg). Founded 9 an Gearran, GE 4,274. A hill-fort east of the vein with a double bank, raised in the four thousand two hundred and seventy-fourth year by households who owed nothing to Dùn ìseal and asked leave of no one. They shared out the labour, and afterward the ground within, by households and not by standing; a family that sent no hands was left outside the second bank and asked within a generation to be let in on the same terms. Ailis carried seal-skins from here to the ford, and Catrìona of the king's blood gave the eastern households ground there asking no oath. In the four thousand five hundred and twentieth year the king sent Niall Òg to bid Dùn dhearg come in to him, and Fearghal Donn sent him back with nothing. From that year the spears of the east were gathered here, and under Artair mac Fhearghail the host mustered along the river below the fort in the last days of an Lùnastal, meaning to hold the crossing. Known for the double bank, and the refusal.

Dùn ìseal (Dùn ìseal). Founded 9 an Lùnastal, GE 1. The hill of the first kingdom. Ailean Mòr came to it from the grove in the first summer with eleven of his kin, sat under its lip through the first winter hearing the households of the valleys, and set the flint-pit to making spear-heads for anyone who asked. The bank was pegged out in the snow of the second spring and raised in the ninth year, with antler picks and flint scrapers; Gormshuil kept its gate, and after her, Rìghrean na Cloiche⁴ held it for the king, twelve in all, from Dòmhnall Clachach to Catrìona Mhòr. Sileas Bhàn cut grain-pits into the bank and opened them by the count of mouths; Tormod Liath paced out the second bank and doubled the ground within it to near a hundred houses. Here the sharing before the storms began, here Calum Ciar asked for the slab's lot, and here Catrìona's cord was knotted to nine hundred hearths. In the last years the valley below the hill filled with the tents of the king's kin, each line with its own fire and its own steward, waiting on shares the king would not give. Known for the king's hill, the bank and the store within it.

Dùn thais (Dùn thais). Founded 28 am Màrt, GE 2,473. A hill above good grazing in the east, where settlers pushing toward the rising country dug a ditch and raised the spoil behind it in the two thousand four hundred and sixty-fifth year, a ring of earth built without any word sent from Dùn ìseal and without any word sent back once it stood. It was the first banked place of the hill-folk away from Dùn ìseal and An Cnoc Ruadh⁵. Somhairle stood on the bank some years after and found it a smaller, rougher thing than his father's hill. Its holder quarrelled two winters with Ruadhan Beag of Dùn chrom over which way a bank ought to face, until Murchadh rode down and left both ditches as they stood. Known for the first bank east of the old workings.

3. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

4. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

5. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

G

Glenn na Scoltaidh¹. Founded 25 an Giblean, GE 2. A green valley walled by low scarps two days inland from the coast, where Seasaidh came as a bride with Pàl, a drover's son. In the eight hundred and twenty-seventh year the ground opened below Pàl's byre, a crack that ran along the valley and moved its spring to a new channel. The king walked the length of the crack and forbade nothing. Twenty years later Seasaidh, in her old age, carried white stones up from the stream bed and set them a stride back from the crack's edge, choosing them for their whiteness so a child running in poor light might see where the safe ground ended; the valley finished the line after her, and no house was raised within a stone's throw of the crack. In the three thousand eight hundred and sixty-third year the crack moved again and the spring shifted back uphill and broke the line in two places, and the households laid it again exactly as their grandmothers had. Known for the crack and the white stones.

I

Inis bhàn (Inis bhàn). Founded 16 an Giblean, GE 3,916. A settlement on the lower Abhainn iséal by the skerries off the river mouth, where the households took seals by agreement, one household to a rock in its own turn, kept on notched sticks. A rock taken out of turn was the commonest quarrel of that coast, settled always by counting the tally aloud rather than by raised voices. Known for the seal-rocks taken in turn.

Inis mhin (Achadh naomh). Founded 20 an Cèitean, GE 3,172. A smooth low island joined to the shore by a causeway on the eastern coast, where a few households settled in the three thousand one hundred and seventy-second year to live by the eggs and birds of the cliffs, trading feathers inland. A boy caught by dusk on a shelf below the highest nests was brought up by torchlight on a rope woven that same night, and from then no one of the settlement worked the cliffs alone: two to a rope, by custom rather than any law spoken. Its feathers went inland to the ford and to the valleys under Dùn iséal, where they stuffed the bolsters of the king's kin in the waiting years. Known for the egg-cliffs and the two to a rope.

Inis mhòr (Inis mhòr). Founded 16 an Dàmhair, GE 4,328. A fishing settlement on the Abhainn ghorm in the north-east, taken up in the four thousand three hundred and twenty-eighth year by households who lived by the fish of its sheltered pools. They built their houses in two rows facing each other across a single trodden way, so that a neighbour's fire might be borrowed without crossing open ground in the rain: the oldest street any teller remembers on Dia-thìr. The two rows faced each other close enough for a word to cross between doors, and the settlement kept its sharing in the trodden way itself, each household setting out its surplus at its own door to be divided by the count of mouths before the storms. Known for the oldest street.

1. the valley where the ground opened (burg 123 in this age)

Inis thais (Inis thais). Founded 21 an Lùnastal, GE 2,408. A harbour of the south-west where, in the two thousand four hundred and twenty-fourth year, households hearing only that the Ros dhomhain keeper cut her marks at a certain interval began cutting their own high-water marks on the harbour rock at that same spacing, though none of them could say why that width and no other. So three tide-rocks were kept side by side on the island, and the interval travelled without its reasoning. Known for the third tide-rock.



Muileann àrsaidh (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 3 an t-Samhain, GE 2,466. A settlement on a stream in the north-west, built in the two thousand four hundred and sixty-sixth year, after carriers weary of the long way round cut through the last unbroken thicket on Rathad an t-Salainn¹ and brought the place a full day nearer the pans of Baile ghorm. Its flint came from Cnoc àrsaidh and its salt from the south, carried the length of the island by Cruinneachadh an Àtha²; at the stream the salt cost three times its price at the pans and was paid for in flint and seal-skins. Known for the far end of Rathad an t-Salainn.

Muileann bhàn (Muileann bhàn). Founded 24 an Dàmhair, GE 2,378. A settlement of herders on the eastern plain, below the passes the panthers cross. In the two thousand four hundred and twenty-eighth year Iain of Muileann bhàn drove forty head of thin cattle into the passes out of season, against the custom of the crossing, and the panthers took thirty head in a night; he came down lamed at the hip. Twenty-seven years later he walked south to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh³ on his stick, sat in the pool three days, and walked home whole. In the three thousand seven hundred and seventy-first year, when the rivers of the eastern plain ran low all summer, its households drove their cattle to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh to drink, and the shared surplus held. Known for the cattle lost in the passes, and Iain's cure.

Muileann chaol (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 18 an t-Ògmhios, GE 3,218. A hill above the upper reaches of the rivers where, in the three thousand one hundred and third year, the kin of a settling household's head carried stones up the slope above the cattle-fold and raised the first cairn there, one stone laid at a time by whoever had known him. Within a lifetime the slope held as many small heaps of stone as the fold below held cattle in a good year. The households settled the hill fully in the three thousand two hundred and eighteenth year, round the cattle-fold. Known for the cairns above the cattle-fold.

1. the salt road from the pans to the north-west
2. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool
3. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh

Muileann leathan (Muileann leathan). Founded 24 an Giblean, GE 1,610. A settlement on a northern stream where cloth was first woven on standing frames, the warp held taut by weights of fired clay rather than by hand, in the thousand six hundred and twenty-eighth year; a worker stood free to pass the weft with both hands. Beitris was born into the third household to raise a frame here, and her blue-black cloth lay flatter and held its dye better than any other hand's. The king stopped at her stall at the ford, tested the weave with two fingers, and married her; she went south to Dùn iséal and taught the standing weights to the hill's women until the craft had spread to a dozen sheds. The loom-weights lie in rows in the houses of the stream where they fell from the warp. Known for the standing looms, and Beitris.

Muileann naomh (Muileann naomh). Founded 24 am Faoilleach, GE 2,986. A settlement near the south coast between Taigh-solais Tobar dhearg⁴ and the old Seann Skell, whose first houses stood on driven piles over standing marsh water. They were moved to firm ground a bowshot inland once the piles had proved the footing sound, and kept the name the marsh first gave them. It was founded in earnest in the two thousand nine hundred and eighty-sixth year and traded with the fishers of the strait at Caol ruadh. The marsh gave the settlers eels and wildfowl in plenty, and the moving of the houses to firm ground was done over three summers, one row at a time, so that no household was ever without a roof while it was done. Known for the houses on piles over the marsh.

R

Ros bheag (Ros bheag). Founded 2 an Dàmhair, GE 1,274. The bay of hawks on the west coast, settled in the thousand two hundred and seventy-fourth year by three hill households too many for the grazing above Baile ghorm, the first hill-folk on that shore. They built round and turf-roofed, a little back from the beach, and fished with lines and baskets from the shore and not from boats. Beathag, eldest of the crossing, walked the nine days on her own feet and was the first buried within sound of that tide. Flòraidh was born here, found amber in the wrack at nine, learned the drill from a blind drill-master, and carried the finest bead of the western strand the length of the island to lay it at the ford at the king's word. She married the boat-mender's son who followed her west, and was buried facing the water. Known for amber, and Flòraidh's bead.

Ros dhomhain (Ros dhomhain). Founded 19 an t-Iuchar, GE 1,694. A settlement at the harbour mouth on Loch chrom, where in the thousand seven hundred and eighth year a young keeper cut marks for the high water on a boulder, at the interval of the first tide-rock, which he had never seen. The king stood before it with Beitris the better part of an afternoon and told her a thing can be worth doing before anyone has worked out why. The marks crept upward from keeper to keeper as the lake rose, a hand's width in a lifetime. Seònaid Mhòr cut her marks in pairs, for high water and low, and cut a last pair for the fosterling on the evening before he went home. By the two thousand four hundred and twenty-fifth year some sixty houses stood round the rock and An Cnoc Ruadh's stone landing, the greatest settlement on the shores of Loch chrom, its people fishing from boats of their own building. Known for the tide-rock and its rising marks.

4. the lighthouse at Tobar dhearg

1. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

Ros ruadh (Ceann mhòr). Founded 21 an Dùbhlachd, VE 3,075. A red headland on the north-west coast where fishing households kept lines and hide boats long before the hill had a king. The king's word reached it late and lightly: it sent no spears to any quarrel of the valleys and was asked for none. In the hungry years, when the fishing failed along that whole coast and the graves at Baile chrom were laid two deep, Sileas Bhàn's grain came up the shore to the headland in carts, and its households kept the custom of the store after, laying a season's fish by against the next bad year. Its boats went out further than most on that coast, and its people told the voyage of the first boats as their own. Its fishers cut the eight wind-names on the rock of the headland in the manner of Eilean fhada, a notch facing each way, and a boat that came home in the dark steered by the fire on the Baile chrom headland to the north once that fire was kept. Known for a headland of hide boats on the north-west coast.

S

Seann Dunn (Cnoc dhubh). Founded 5 an Cèitean, VE 642. A town of Seann-Dhaoine¹ on the Abhainn chaol a little above the river mouth, on footings no hill-folk laid. Its middens were Seann-Dhaoine' own, and its tally stones, each cut with a single stroke, stood up-right in them. The hill-folk who came after them built along the middens' shoulder. In the four thousand three hundred and sixty-sixth year a family digging a house-floor struck a row of the tally stones, knew them for what they were, and set them back as they lay rather than break them; a year later the last of Seann-Dhaoine' middens here was disturbed, and the households closed it again. Known for the tally stones set back.

Seann Skell (Muileann àrsaidh). Founded 10 an Gearran, VE 1,404. A harbour of Seann-Dhaoine² on the far north-west coast, with a tower on its point older than any telling. The hill-folk who came there kept Seann-Dhaoine' name for it and a watch in the tower. In the two thousand four hundred and twenty-first year four watchers saw a long back rise off the point in the failing light and go under without a sound; that season the wrack south of the tower gave up stitched planks from hulls built for open water, and no household would claim them. Micheil Beag laid the planks against his wall, and Anndra Breac, a teller of that shore, made from them a telling of a crossing that he carried to the ford and was shouted down for. He was last seen walking south along the strand below the tower. Known for the tower's watch and the stitched planks.

Seann Skell (Seann Skell). Founded 29 am Faoilleach, GE 2,664. A harbour of Seann-Dhaoine³ on the southern coast, empty through the first two thousand years of the age and taken up again by fishing households in the long settling. Within a few generations of its re-settling it was the busiest quay on that coast, boats going out on every tide and its hook-makers at work from first light beating out bone hooks faster than the fishing could wear them. The tale of the grey stranger who lifted the boulder at Ceann leathan grew hands like a smith's iron at a fire near here, an embellishment Alasdair Làidir spent the rest of his life correcting, and an old woman of this shore carried her own telling of the stone to the ford. Known for the busiest quay of the south.

1. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

3. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

Seann Skell (Seann Skell). Founded 6 an Gearran, VE 173. Seann-Dhaoine⁴ river harbour on the Abhainn naomh, with a mole and a tower at its mouth. The hill-folk of the upper river were saying its old name before any of them had seen it, in the year Beathan was born. In the six hundred and twenty-eighth year Iain mac Fhearchair brought eleven souls of his household down the river to the empty harbour, marked the ground, and forbade the tower; the household used Seann-Dhaoine' mole as it found it, and when a winter storm broke the mole's oldest stretch Iain would not build with the broken stone. His daughter Marsaili held the household after him, went out in the first hide boats the harbour had held since Seann-Dhaoine, and chose how a household newly of the sea should bury the first one the sea took. Known for the mole, the tower, and Marsaili's boats.

T

Tobar dhearg (Tobar dhearg). Founded 12 an Dàmhair, GE 2,947. A southern cape where the households raised the last and surest of the five fires in the two thousand four hundred and twentieth year, on a mound of stacked stone breast-high, clear of the spray; a reciter of that coast named the five together before the mound was finished. The keepers of the fire built at last round a well whose water ran faintly red from the rock, and the settlement on the cape grew into the greatest place on the south coast, its fire burning nightly for boats that learned to watch for it. Known for the southern fire and the red well.

Tobar dhìreach (Cnoc bhàn). Founded 25 an t-Iuchar, VE 42. The well village of Na Glinn Àrda¹ that keeps the slab laid over the mason's crack, the eldest of the three wells that claim it. In the thousand and seventy-first year a wet spring opened a crack below the slab's stain, and the households laid white stones along it. From the thousand one hundred and twentieth year the families nearest the crack sat the slab in turn through the dark half of every year, a household at a time; Beathan mac Shomhairle sat among the first six, and Gilleonan and Ìde kept their first turn the same winter. The king came up alone once and sat a night among them. In the two thousand four hundred and third year the families chose one keeper by lot, and Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill drew the white stone; a house was built for her with its door to the slab, and Niocol Snaidhear ground her a stone cup. Gilleasbuig Beag, who drew after her, was rowed to Eilean chrom for a basket of coal, and Giorsal Bhàn laid the coal back under the slab. Somhairle died against the slab in the three thousand and twenty-fifth year and is buried beside it; Diorbhail kept the Line after him. In Catriona's years the lot was drawn from every part of the hills, the keepers were made nine, and Taigh na Lice² became a place walked to for its own sake. Known for the slab, the lot and Taigh na Lice.

4. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

1. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

2. the house of the slab at Tobar dhìreach

Tobar fhiadhaich (Tobar fhiadhaich). Founded 10 an t-Samhain, GE 1,879. A wild spring on the moor whose herders walked the same paths through the whole of the age, and whose spring was said never to fail. The households of the spring buried wolves whole and with care, laid on their sides with their legs drawn up as in sleep, a care they spoke of to no one outside the household; an old woman told Murchadh, who came on a burying in the thousand eight hundred and ninetieth year, that the wolf kept its own dead on the high ground and had earned better than the ditch. No other beast was so buried in the age. Known for the wolves buried whole.

PART NINE

The Appendices

APPENDIX A

The King, Rìghrean na Cloiche and An Cnoc Ruadh

An Aois Ailein¹ had one king and many holders. Ailean Mòr mac Shuibhne was crowned in the grove at Doire ghlais in the first year and ruled the whole island until he fell at the ford below Dùn dhearg in the last days of the age, four thousand six hundred and three years later. Under him the hill of Dùn ìseal was held in his name by a line of his own blood that the reciters called Rìghrean na Cloiche², and An Cnoc Ruadh³ by the lake was held by a line that was not his blood at all and swore to him and not to Dùn ìseal. An Dà Chlàr⁴ were spoken, never written, in this age. They give each holder a name and a place in the order and say almost nothing of how long each held; where the years are known they are given here from the tellings, with each ruler's age at the taking of the holding and at death.

The king

Ailean Mòr mac Shuibhne, Rìgh Chlann nan Dè⁵. He was twenty-four when he kept the seven nights in the grove and was crowned on the eighth, and four thousand six hundred and twenty-six when he fell. He did not age after the grove: his hair went grey in a single winter in about his seventeen-hundredth year of kingship and changed no further. The king married several times; the tellings name Muireall, the mother of Gormshuil, who died in the twenty-fourth year of the hill; Sorcha, a woman of the valleys, the mother of Somhairle and Iain Dubh; and Beitris of Muileann leathan, the weaver, the mother of Murchadh. He named every wife before Beitris to her in order when she asked whether he would forget her. He heard judgements in person in the first years, gave the north to Dòmhnall Clachach, walked south alone to Tràigh an t-

1. the Age of Ailean

2. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

3. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

4. the two oral king-lists, of the Stone Kings and the Red Hill

5. king of the godkin, the first king's style

Salainn⁶ after Iain Dubh was killed there, and in the last age of his reign took back Dùn ìseal into his own hand when Catrìona Mhòr died, giving it to none of her kin.

Rìghrean na Cloiche

Rìghrean na Cloiche⁷, counts the king himself first and Catrìona Mhòr twelfth and last. Each holder after the king held Dùn ìseal under him, heard its judgements, called its gatherings and kept its bank. The list passes from one name to the next without saying how long each held or what came between.

	HOLDER	BORN	HELD	DIED	AGE AT DEATH
1	Ailean Mòr mac Shuibhne	twenty-four years before the grove	from the first year	at the ford, the four thousand six hundred and third year	4,626
2	Gormshuil nic Ailein	before the grove	27 – 76	76	81
3	Dòmhnall Clachach	2	76 – 227	3,310	3,308
4	Fearchar Bacach	10	from 227	3,140	3,130
5	Mòrag Chruaidh	290	to 719, holding in 672	1,610	1,320
6	Iain Dubh	45	719 – 727	727, slain	682
7	Raghnall Cean-nfhionn	760	holding in 1,175	2,160	1,400
8	Sileas Bhàn	1,500	to 2,010, holding in 1,927	2,380	880
9	Tormod Liath	640	2,010 – 2,390	2,390	1,750
10	Eilidh Ghlas	2,050	from 2,390	2,780	730
11	Calum Ciar	2,250	holding in 2,412	2,960	710
12	Catrìona Mhòr	4,100	holding in 4,321 and after	4,391	291

Years are counted from the grove.

Gormshuil nic Ailein, the king’s eldest daughter by Muireall, was born before the grove and had none of na Bliadhnachan Fada⁸. She kept the gate of the hill from the

6. the salt shore
7. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'
8. the long years of Ailean's kin

ninth year and held it from her thirty-second year, and died at eighty-one beside a father who looked her grandson's age. It was at her grave that the hill understood na Bliadhnachan Fada were the grove's alone.

Dòmhnall Clachach, the first child born to the king after the grove, took the hill at seventy-four and set the boundary stones of the valleys in the hundred and seventh year. At two hundred and twenty-five he asked his father for unsettled ground and was given the north, and he grew old there among people who called him only the stone-cutter's son. He died at three thousand three hundred and eight.

Fearchar Bacach, lamed in Cogaidhean nan Gleann⁹, took the hill at two hundred and seventeen when his brother rode north, and was carried to the gatherings in a chair of woven birch: the first ruler on Dia-thìr remembered for a hurt. He carried his lameness near three thousand years and died at three thousand one hundred and thirty.

Mòrag Chruaidh, Dòmhnall's daughter, the first of the king's grandchildren to carry na Bliadhnachan Fada, raided Tràigh an t-Salainn¹⁰ at Baile ghorm in her three hundred and eighty-second year and lost seven, whose names the hill kept at its fire. She rode to An Cnoc Ruadh¹¹, weighed Seonag's pebble bag against her own spears, and raised no raid again. She gave the hill to Iain Dubh at four hundred and twenty-nine and died at one thousand three hundred and twenty.

Iain Dubh, a son of the king by Sorcha, took the hill at six hundred and seventy-four and held it eight years. He went down to the salt-pans at dawn with more spears than Mòrag had taken and was killed on the clay by Tadhg Garbh, at six hundred and eighty-two. His son Tormod stood at his cairn.

Raghnall Ceannfhionn, Fearchar's son, found the hill's salt-kists near empty in his four hundred and fifteenth year and waded into the ford to meet the holder of An Cnoc Ruadh, and the two hills agreed salt for wool. He died at one thousand four hundred.

Sileas Bhàn, of the king's blood, held the hill through the hungry years, opened the store within the bank by the count of mouths, and was told by the king that four hundred years of not failing was itself the deed the list would keep. She gave the hill to Tormod Liath at five hundred and ten and died at eight hundred and eighty among her kin in the valley.

Tormod Liath, Iain Dubh's son, took the hill at one thousand three hundred and seventy, raised the second bank, outlived three sons, went grey through, and died in his own hall in the three hundred and eightieth year of his holding, at one thousand seven hundred and fifty.

9. the king's early wars bringing in the valleys

10. the salt shore

11. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

Eilidh Ghlas, of the king's blood, took the hill at three hundred and forty. She sent her younger son to be fostered at An Cnoc Ruadh, the first fostering in either list, and knew him at the door when he came home. She died at seven hundred and thirty.

Calum Ciar, Eilidh's elder son, asked in his hundred and sixty-second year that the keeper's lot be drawn at Dùn ìseal in his sight, and was refused; the list sets the refusal down. He died at seven hundred and ten.

Catrìona Mhòr, of the king's blood, gave the households of Dùn dhearg ground at the ford at two hundred and twenty-one, took the hill formally at two hundred and forty-seven, knew every household of the hills by its line seven names back, and had the households counted on a cord of nine hundred knots. She answered the nine keepers "not this year; ask me again", and died at two hundred and ninety-one. With her the spoken list ends.

The list of An Cnoc Ruadh

An Cnoc Ruadh¹² kept its own holders and its own list, An Cnoc Ruadh's roll, and swore to the king from the two hundred and ninetieth year and never to Dùn ìseal. None of its holders had na Bliadhnachan Fada¹³. The list sets every holder of Uisdean Mòr's line "after her father" or "after his father", whatever lay between.

	HOLDER	BORN	HELD	DIED	AGE AT DEATH
1	Beathag Ruadh	before the grove	named in 18	40	73
2	Uisdean Mòr	225	250 – 312	312	87
3	Seonag nic Uisdein	670	holding in 694	741	71
4	Murchadh Gearr	1,215	1,240 – 1,280	1,280	65
5	Lachlann Ruadh, Lachlann an Al-traim	2,360	holding in 2,401 – 2,425	2,425	65
6	Peigi Dhubh	2,385	2,425 – 2,460	2,460	75
7	Seumas Òg	4,320	holding in 4,347	4,390	70

Beathag Ruadh held the hill by the lake when the valleys came in to the king, and stayed away. She was fifty-one when the tellings first name her and died at seventy-three. **Uisdean Mòr** took the hill at twenty-five, cut the ditch across the neck, saw the palisade burn twice, and knelt to the king in the ford at sixty-five; he died at eighty-sev-

12. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

13. the long years of Ailean's kin

en. **Seonag nic Uisdein** counted her people by pebbles in a bag and was twenty-four when Mòrag Chruaidh came to her; she died at seventy-one. **Murchadh Gearr** took the hill at twenty-five and walked Rathad an t-Salainn¹⁴ every autumn to be seen upon it; he died at sixty-five. **Lachlann Ruadh** took Eilidh Ghlas's younger son to foster at forty-one and was called Lachlann an Altraim for it; he died at sixty-five, asking that the fostering be ended. **Peigi Dhubh** took the hill at forty, sent the fosterling home with salt, and laid the stone landing; she died at seventy-five. **Seumas Òg** took the hill at twenty-seven and died at seventy; his is the last name An Cnoc Ruadh's spoken roll carries. Between the holders the list names, others held whose names it does not keep, among them the unnamed holder who waded to meet Raghnaill Ceannfhionn and the new holder who stood in the river at An Cruinneachadh Mòr¹⁵ of the three thousandth year.

The king's children and blood named in this volume

The king's children born after the grove had na Bliadhnachan Fada¹⁶; each generation after them had fewer, and no child of the kin outlived its long-lived parent's span.

NAME	PARENT	BORN	DIED, OR AT THE CLOSE OF THE AGE	HOLDING
Gormshuil nic Ailein	the king and Muireall	before the grove	76, at 81	Dùn ìseal
Dòmhnall Clachach	the king	2	3,310, at 3,308	Dùn ìseal, then the north
Fearchar Bacach	the king	10	3,140, at 3,130	Dùn ìseal
Somhairle mac Ailein	the king and Sorcha	38	3,025, at 2,987	none; lived among Clann na Ceiste
Iain Dubh	the king and Sorcha	45	727, slain at 682	Dùn ìseal
Murchadh Mòr	the king and Beitris	1,705	living, near 2,900	the northern plain
Eithne nic Ailein	the king	2,703	living, near 1,900	the ground below Làrach an Dùin-fhaire
Raonaid nic Ailein	the king, by a wife of the eastern shore	about 3,100	4,480, in her 1,380th year	a river-meadow, taken back
Ìomhar Dearg	the king	3,204	living, near 1,400	river-grazing of the eastern marches

14. the salt road from the pans to the north-west
15. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year
16. the long years of Ailean's kin

NAME	PARENT	BORN	DIED, OR AT THE CLOSE OF THE AGE	HOLDING
Mòrag Chruaidh	Dòmhnall Clachach	290	1,610, at 1,320	Dùn ìseal
Raghnall Ceannfhionn	Fearchar Bacach	760	2,160, at 1,400	Dùn ìseal
Tormod Liath	Iain Dubh	640	2,390, at 1,750	Dùn ìseal
Beathan mac Shomhairle	Somhairle and Cairistiona	591	2,804, at 2,213	none; kept the slab
Niall Òg	Raonaid and a herdsman of Fearchar's line	3,703	living	none
Dùghall Dearg mac Ìomhair	Ìomhar Dearg	3,900	living, past 700	none in this age
Ruairidh Glas	Dùghall Dearg	4,304	living, near 300	none in this age
Sileas Bhàn, Eilidh Ghlas, Calum Ciar, Catrìona Mhòr	of the king's blood	see Rìghrean na Cloiche		Dùn ìseal

Murchadh Mòr had eleven sons, born over the better part of three centuries, each given a corner of the northern plain; the four hundred of the king's blood reckoned standing in the river at An Cruinneachadh Mòr¹⁷ are not named one by one in any telling that survives.

Sloinneadh a' Chlachair and Somhairle's line

Sloinneadh a' Chlachair¹⁸, runs from Neachdan the mason to Ailean, and was given whole by Coinneach mac Shuibhne, the king's mortal brother and the first teller of his deeds, to Gormshuil before he died in the fifty-fifth year. Somhairle carried it after, among Clann na Ceiste¹⁹ in Na Glinn Àrda²⁰, and gave it whole to his son Beathan in the eleven hundred and fortieth year and to Diorbhail, a child of the watch at Tobar dhìreach, in the three thousand and tenth; Diorbhail kept it by mouth and took no share for it. Somhairle's own line held no share of the hill. It runs from Somhairle to Beathan, and from Beathan to the son who cleared the path for Somhairle's stick and kept the whole watch at the slab after him; the tellings name his descendants only as they come to Gille-Bride, whose father died in his three hundred and eighth year, and

17. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year
18. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'
19. the Children of the Question
20. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

to Gille-Bride's son Ceallach, born in the four thousand five hundred and forty-third year, in whom the years were already coming down faster than in his father.

Luchd-faire na Lice

The families near the crack sat the slab in turn, a household at a time, from the eleven hundred and twentieth year. From the two thousand four hundred and third year they drew one keeper by lot. **Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill**, a herder's daughter of three-and-thirty, drew the white stone first and kept the slab until she died in the winter after Coinneachadh nan Cupan²¹. **Gilleasbuig Beag**, a roof-mender, drew after her and was rowed to Eilean chrom for a basket of coal. **Giorsal Bhàn** drew after him and laid the coal back under the slab. The tellings do not name the keepers after Giorsal one by one. In Catriona Mhòr's years the lot was drawn from every part of the hills, and the keepers were made nine, one for each of nine districts no household ever marked on the ground.

The holders of Dùn dhearg as the east names them

Rìghrean na Cloiche²² list does not name the holders of Dùn dhearg; it says only that Dùn dhearg came not to the gatherings. The households east of the vein name two. **Fearghal Donn**, who held the double bank when the king sent Niall Òg in the four thousand five hundred and twentieth year, sent the messenger back with nothing and died an old man in his own bed in the four thousand five hundred and seventieth. **Artair mac Fhearghail**, his son, took up the holding with no more ceremony than his father had used and led Sluagh an Ear²³ down to the ford below the fort in the last days of an Lùnastal of the four thousand six hundred and third year.

21. the meeting of the cups

22. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'

23. the host of Dùn dhearg and the eastern households

APPENDIX B

The Reverence of the Hearths

An Aois Ailein¹ had no priests, no temple and no god at the hearth. What it had was a set of customs about fire, coal, the dead and certain places, kept by households who could seldom say where a custom had begun and never troubled to write one down. This appendix gathers them as the tellings of the age give them: Aithris a' Chruthachaidh² kept among Clann na Ceiste³; the slab and those who watched it; the handful, the basket, the cup and Oidhche na Glaice⁴; the sharing before the storms; the saying spoken at the ford; the unlit and the covered hearths; the holy woods; and the keeping of the dead.

No god at the hearth

The hill-folk of this age made no offering at the hearth and named no one who lived in the fire. Coimhdeach na Fine⁵, belonged to the grove and to Sloinneadh a' Chlachair⁶, and the tellings put him in only two places: before Diarmad of that line in the oldest days, and in the grove on the eighth night, when he named Ailean king. No household of the age claimed to have seen him, and none set a place for him. No one prayed to the king himself. He was knelt to at gates and in fords, as a holder is knelt to, and he raised those who knelt with his own hand; the hill talked of his warmth and his unageing face in the way a valley talks of weather, and let the matter rest.

The king's warmth

The one wonder the age took for granted was the king himself. A girl of Dùn iséal stood near his untended fire in the first hard winter and was warmed through though

1. the Age of Ailean

2. the Telling of the Making

3. the Children of the Question

4. the night of the handful, Samhain

5. the Keeper of the Kin; lit. 'the guardian of the kindred'

6. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

no flame burned close enough to account for it; Coinneach found him warm at dawn after the vigil with the frost standing off him in a bare ring; the water of the ford ran warm round his legs at An Cruinneachadh Mòr⁷ and smoked downstream of him in the dusk. At Achadh dhìreach he laid his open hand across a hearthstone running with colour and it greyed under his palm. At An Cnoc Ruadh⁸, in the summer Uisdean knelt, a frost came down out of a clear sky in an t-Ògmhios and put a white rime on the grass along the whole lake shore; the tellings call it Reothadh an Rìgh⁹, and Uisdean's people could not say afterward whether it was his doing or the sky's. The hill spoke of these things in the way a valley speaks of weather, and made no rite of any of them. No one asked him for rain or a good calving. The hill asked him for judgements, and for grain in a hungry year, and he gave both.

Aithris a' Chruthachaidh among Clann na Ceiste

The households of Na Glinn Àrda¹⁰, Clann na Ceiste¹¹, kept Sloinneadh a' Chlachair¹² and the tellings that ring it. Coinneach mac Shuibhne gave the Line whole to Gormshuil; Somhairle, who asked his father for no land and was counted a single mouth at a single hearth, carried it among Na Glinn Àrda for near three thousand years, gave it to Beathan and then to Diorbhail, and set in it what he saw on the three shores of Seann-Dhaoine¹³. The keepers of the Line took no share from any hall for the keeping, and set none of it down on leaf or hide. It was said twice through without a name out of place when it was given, and after that each Samhain to any of the watch-households who would hear it, with the year's names added at its foot. Clann na Ceiste held that a thing given too soon to too young a head is given badly, and that a question the ground does not mean to answer is best let lie.

The slab and its keepers

At Tobar dhìreach a slab lay over the mason's crack, stained where Teine a' Chlachair¹⁴ was said to have come up out of the vein. In the thousand and seventy-first year a crack

7. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

8. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

9. the unseasonable frost of early an t-Ògmhios GE 290 on the Red Hill's lake shore, named for the night of the palisade's second burning

10. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

11. the Children of the Question

12. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

13. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

14. the mason's fire, the first fire

opened in the turf below it and the households laid white stones along it. From the eleven hundred and twentieth year the families nearest the crack sat by the slab in turn, a household at a time, through the dark half of every year. What they watched for none ever said; Gilleonan, after forty years of sitting it, asked Beathan, and Beathan answered that he did not know and never had. The king sat one night among them and said nothing of why he came.

In the two thousand four hundred and third year the turns wore too thin for one memory to hold and the families agreed to choose one keeper by lot, from a bag of pebbles with one marked white. The first keeper had a house raised beside the slab with its door facing the stone, the first building on Dia-thìr made only to be near the vein. When a keeper was found with a basket of the vein's coal, the families judged him by a silence held past any voice rising to answer it and rowed him to Eilean chrom without a boat; the basket was set inside Taigh na Lice¹⁵ under its cloth and was neither burned nor kept, and the keeper after him laid the coal back under the slab piece by piece. The coal went home, the valleys said. Calum Ciar asked that the lot be drawn at Dùn Ìseal in his sight and was refused, and the king would not overrule a thing older than the grove of his own crowning. From then the holders of the hill ruled the grazing and the gatherings, and the keepers ruled the vein, and the line between them was sworn to in no words either side wrote down. In Catrìona Mhòr's years the lot was drawn from every part of the hills, the keepers were made nine, and the nine asked to have their charge declared before the whole gathering. She told them to ask again.

The handful, the cup and Oidhche na Glaice

An gual dathach of the vein was burned by the handful. The custom that no fire should have more of it than one cupped hand could hold took hold in all the hill settlements about the thousand and eleventh year, nowhere written and everywhere kept: làn na glaise, 's gun tuilleadh, a full hand and no more. The king named it a good custom at Achadh dhìreach after Eanraig Ruadh burned a whole basket in one night and his house went up in a flame of no colour anyone had a word for, and he made no law of it. Oighrig nic Dhòmhnaill had a cup ground from grey stone to the size of a cupped hand so that no household's handful ran bigger than another's by the accident of whose palm measured it; its copies were tried against it with water at Coinneachadh nan Cupan¹⁶, and from then the hills measured the coal with one measure. In Catrìona's years every household came to burn its handful on the same dark night, each

15. the house of the slab at Tobar dhìreach

16. the meeting of the cups

watching for the first low flame on the nearest hill before lighting its own. One household only, Torcall Tochclair's at the black hill, refused to burn at all.

The sharing before the storms

Any household with food to spare shared it before the storm season: this too was unwritten. At Dùn Ìseal it was done in the open, every household bringing its surplus within the bank to be divided by the count of mouths and not by the size of a herd, as Sileas Bhàn had opened the store in the hungry years. The first punishment under it that is remembered fell on a household of Àth shean that hid its grain in a pit under the byre floor; it was put out with what it could carry. After A' Ghaoth Dhubh¹⁷ the valleys sent grain to the east coast unasked, and the coast called the custom only the bringing-in, or the help.

The saying

The hill-folk did not hold that they had come to Dia-thìr from anywhere. The saying cut on Calbh Cnoc ghorm¹⁸, we did not come, we were here, was held at every hearth long before it was spoken aloud. When Anndra Breac told a telling at the ford in which the people crossed the sea, the crowd shouted him down and every hearth closed to him; from the next year the gathering opened with the saying spoken together before any business began. The words on Calbh Cnoc ghorm, worn shallow, were recut in their old grooves by a hand from Catriona's hill.

The unlit hearth and the covered hearth

At Achadh dhìreach a hearth was laid true, with a slip of an gual dathach¹⁹ beside it, and never lit; the valley left it under peat and ploughed round the strip it lay in. In the hills where Marbh-bheò²⁰ was told of, no open fire was lit after dark. A herding family new to that country lit one and was never found; two herders who had lit none saw Marbh-bheò walk the ridge with no breath showing in the cold and lived. The covered hearth, pit-dug and lidded with stone, spread from those hills toward the settlements nearer Coille Naomh Muileann chiar²¹, and hardened there into a rule no council set.

17. the Black Wind

18. the column at Cnoc ghorm

19. the coloured coal

20. the Hollow Man of Doire uaine; lit. 'dead-alive'

21. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

The platforms on Loch chrom burned to the waterline in one night, and no household built on the lake again in the age.

Holy woods, holy ground and the places of Seann-Dhaoine

Some woods were not entered. At the edge of the forest at Cnoc bheag the settlers took their timber only from the river's far side and marked the line with unhewn stones; when a child went past the stones and was not found, the searchers stopped at them, and the telling did not blame them. At the edge of Coille Naomh Muileann chiar²² people came singly and in pairs to sit one night by a small fire that burned out before morning, and went home quieter. Cnoc naomh was already called holy when households came to it for its spring, and they kept its water and its holiness together without asking more of either. Seann-Dhaoine²³ work was let stand wherever it stood: the tower at Seann Skell, Làrach an Dùin²⁴ ruin above Ceann mhin, Làrach an Teampaill²⁵ in the eastern hills with a path worn round it at a distance, the old landings used unmended, the marked stones of the middens laid aside, the tally stones set back as they lay.

The dead

The hill buried its dead in the ground and raised cairns over those it meant to remember: Iain Dubh's on the hill, the salt-folk's own at Baile ghorm with seven stones for the seven of Mòrag's raid, and the slope of small cairns above the fold at Muileann chaol, one stone laid at a time by whoever had known the dead. Mòrag named her seven at the hill's fire on the night kept for the dead, and the naming went on at the same fire after her. At the old burial ground a family who buried none of their own there cleared its thorn each spring, and when diggers broke into an older grave lined with Seann-Dhaoine²⁶ slabs they closed it and moved the row a spear's length off. The households of the rough strait laid paddles beside their dead. At Tobar fhiadhaich wolves were buried whole, laid on their sides as people were. In the last centuries the households of the south-east coast began to row their dead out to Eilean ìseal, after the old manner of Seann-Dhaoine or of themselves; the tellings let the question stand.

22. the holy wood of Muileann chiar, Flidais's wood

23. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

24. the fortress ruin

25. the temple ruin

26. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

APPENDIX C

RECKONING: YEARS FROM THE GROVE, NA BLIADHNACHAN FADA AND THE TURNING YEAR

An Aois Ailein¹ counted its years from the grove. Every telling of the age that gives a year gives it as a count from the night Ailean was crowned at Doire ghlas: the ninth year of the hill, the thousand and sixty-sixth year, the three thousandth year since the grove. The count needed no other beginning, for no one alive in the age remembered one, and the king, who did, never offered another. This appendix sets out how the age counted its years, its lists and its lives; how it divided the turning year; and the marks it cut to keep time on the coasts.

The count from the grove

The reckoning was the king's own. In the first years the hill counted by the years of the hill, which were the grove's years under another name, for the king came to Dùn iséal in the summer of his crowning; within a generation the reciters spoke only of the grove. The reciters of Dùn iséal kept the count by mouth, and the households learned it from them at the gatherings. It was an unbroken count, never begun again at the taking of a holding: Sileas Bhàn held the hill in the nineteen hundred and twenty-seventh year, not in her first. A thousandth year was marked as a thing worth travelling for. In the three thousandth year since the grove, word of the count was carried out along every road that summer, and it drew to the ford households who had never before troubled to send anyone to an ordinary gathering.

Ordinary households kept their own years less exactly. They counted by holders, by storms and by marriages: the winter A' Ghaoth Dhubh² came, the year the second bank was dug, the summer the foster-son came home. Most tellings of the age give a year only for what touched the hill, and leave the rest to the order of events.

1. the Age of Ailean

2. the Black Wind

Lists without lengths

The lists of the age are orders of names, not counts of years. Rìghrean na Cloiche³ gives twelve names from Ailean to Catrìona Mhòr; the list of An Cnoc Ruadh⁴ gives its own holders from Beathag Ruadh to Seumas Òg, and sets every holder of Uisdean Mòr's line "after his father" or "after her father" though Seonag was born more than three hundred years after Uisdean died. Neither list says how long any holder held, or what lay between one name and the next. The reciters held that the list keeps who and in what order, and that the length of a holding is the business of those who lived under it. When An Dà Chlàr⁵ were spoken one after the other at the ford in Catrìona's time, from dusk to the grey before morning, it was the first time either was heard whole, and the tellings count the hours of the night and not the years of the holders.

The households' own lines were orders of the same kind. At the ford, before any marriage was made, each household gave its line aloud seven names back on either side, so that a forbidden blood might be named before the salt was carried. Catrìona Mhòr could give any household's line back seven names without pausing to think.

Na Bliadhnachan Fada

The power of the coals was Ailean's alone, and he did not age after the grove. His children born after it had na Bliadhnachan Fada⁶, and every generation after them had fewer: the longest life in a generation was never longer than the longest in the one before, and no child of the kin outlived its long-lived parent's span. Those born before the grove, like Gormshuil, and those not of the king's blood, like every holder of An Cnoc Ruadh⁷, had ordinary lives. The long-lived aged slowly and then, near the end, all at once: Tormod Liath went grey through in his hundred and seventy-fifth year of holding, and Somhairle found the first lines in his face in his two thousand four hundred and thirty-fifth year, and came in his last years to look, a woman of the watch-households said, like a withered apple left too long on the sill.

NAME	GENERATION	YEARS LIVED
Ailean Mòr	the king	4,626, slain
Somhairle mac Ailein	a son	2,987
Dòmhnall Clachach	a son	3,308

3. the Stone Kings; lit. 'the kings of the stone'
4. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line
5. the two oral king-lists, of the Stone Kings and the Red Hill
6. the long years of Ailean's kin
7. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

NAME	GENERATION	YEARS LIVED
Fearchar Bacach	a son	3,130
Iain Dubh	a son	682, slain
Murchadh Mòr	a son	near 2,900 at the close of the age, living
Eithne nic Ailein	a daughter	near 1,900 at the close of the age, living
Raonaid nic Ailein	a daughter	1,380
Ìomhar Dearg	a son	near 1,400 at the close of the age, living
Beathan mac Shomhairle	a grandson	2,213
Tormod Liath	a grandson	1,750
Raghnall Ceannfhionn	a grandson	1,400
Mòrag Chruaidh	a granddaughter	1,320
Sileas Bhàn	of the blood	880
Eilidh Ghlas	of the blood	730
Calum Ciar	of the blood	710
Gille-Bride's father	of Somhairle's line	308
Catriona Mhòr	of the blood	291
Gormshuil nic Ailein	born before the grove	81

The kin reckoned their own ages in the ordinary way until the counting grew too long to be worth saying aloud. Ìomhar Dearg, near five hundred at his nephew's birth, had stopped troubling to count them; Somhairle had stopped counting in the ordinary way long before, as Clann na Ceiste⁸ counted, by Samhains sat and not by years. Ceallach, born to Gille-Bride in the four thousand five hundred and forty-third year, was slower to walk and to run than the children before him, the first sign, told back afterward, that the years were coming down faster in him than in his father.

The turning year

The year of the age was a year of two halves and Na Ceithir Fèilltean⁹. The dark half began at Samhain, when the herds came down and the slab's watch began; the light half began at Bealltainn, when they went up. Between them lay the feast of the lambing in the cold and Lùnastal at the harvest. Samhain was the night the hill kept for its dead, when Mòrag's seven were named at the fire, and in Catriona's years it was the night on which every household burned its handful of an gual dathach¹⁰ together,

8. the Children of the Question

9. the four quarter-feasts

watching for the first low flame on the nearest hill. The gatherings of the valleys were held at the feasts, and Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹¹ in the autumn after the shearing and the salt-raking. The months of the reckoning, from am Faoilleach to an Dùbhlachd, were used by the reciters of the hill for the days of the great deeds, and by few others.

The panthers kept a season of their own. Twice a year the great cats crossed the passes by the same road, and every household near the road knew the crossing season and kept its herds out of the passes while it lasted. At Baile dhomhain the households cut a sign on their gateposts at the start of the crossing season and scraped it away at its end, the first mark on the island cut for a season. When three cats turned back at the highest pass in the two thousand four hundred and twenty-eighth year, the households read it for a hard winter and stored double, and the winter was hard.

Na h-Ochd Gaothan

In the two thousand and forty-seventh year Na h-Ochd Gaothan¹² of the year were given names all at once, by no one the coasts could afterward name, and every coast that told them used the same eight names in the same order from that year on. Their meaning was dark even to those who spoke them, and they were never changed. The brothers of Ceann leathan raised a ring of eight stones for them on the point; the people of Eilean fhada cut the names as notches into the rock of their highest ground, one facing each way, so a man lost in thick weather might find his bearing by touch; a cutter of Seann Chwen set one of the names beside Seann-Dhaoine¹³ own marks on the great boulder there, because the name wanted a stone already old; and the fishers of Caol bheag named each boat for the wind it was built to fish in.

The tide-rocks

In the sixteen hundred and seventy-first year an unnamed hand on an unnamed shore began to cut a mark on a fixed rock at each high tide's furthest reach, at intervals more even than any fisherman's need would ask. A young keeper at Ros dhomhain began a rock of his own in the seventeen hundred and eighth year at the spacing he judged by memory of the telling, and the households of Inis thais cut a third in the two thousand four hundred and twenty-fourth, at the Ros dhomhain interval, though none of them could say why that width and no other. Seònaid Mhòr of Ros dhomhain cut her

10. the coloured coal

11. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

12. the eight named winds

13. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thirich

marks in pairs, one for high water and one for low; the keepers after her went back to single marks. On the Ros dhomhain rock the marks crept upward from keeper to keeper, so slowly that no one year's mark could be told from the next, until the lake stood a hand higher on the stone than at the first cut. The keepers went on cutting. The king told Beitris, standing before the rock, that a thing can be worth doing before anyone has worked out why.

Tallies and counts

The age counted things more than it counted time. Seann-Dhaoine¹⁴ cut single strokes on flat stones at the edges of their middens, then counted their dead in fives, until their tally stones thickened together on three coasts and stopped. Seonag of An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁵ counted her people by pebbles in a bag, one to a household. The seal-rock households of Inis bhàn kept their turns on notched sticks. The keeper of the tide-rock at Ros dhomhain cut a stroke for every tide, and Seathan mac Pheadair a stroke for every ship's light he saw pass safe by his fire. The greatest count of the age was Catriona Mhòr's cord, a knot to a hearth, which grew to some nine hundred knots; Sine nan Snaidhm kept its like for the whole valley of tents below Dùn ìseal in the last years, and the king's own kin were never upon it.

14. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

15. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

APPENDIX D

Peoples: Seann-Dhaoine, the Hill-Folk and the East

Three peoples, or four, shared Dia-thìr in An Aois Ailein¹, and only one of them lasted the age. Seann-Dhaoine², whom the hill-folk called the Seann-Dhaoine, held the coasts when the king was crowned and were silent within six hundred years. The hill-folk, who called themselves Clann nan Dè³ and then Dia-thìrich, spread from the valleys under Dùn ìseal to every coast. Among them the salt-folk of the south and the lake-folk of An Cnoc Ruadh⁴ kept ways of their own long after they knelt to the king; and in the last centuries the households east of the vein grew into a people who owed the hill nothing and said so.

The last centuries of Seann-Dhaoine

Seann-Dhaoine⁵ built harbours, towers, moles, a shell causeway at Seann Warr, fortresses whose ruins stood above Ceann mhin and Cathair mhòr, and a temple in the eastern hills. They had a script, cut on stone, that no hill-folk could read. The hill-folk traded with them at the shore by gesture, in silence kept on both sides: Dùghall Cean-naiche walked the road down to their shore for sixty-two years and never learned a word of their tongue, and his father, who had asked once, was met with a courtesy that would not be moved.

In the three hundred and eighth year Seann-Dhaoine began to cut single strokes on flat stones at the edges of their middens, one stone to a household, a mark and then another, simpler than their script. Forty years later they began to keep count of their dead. At the eastern Seann Warr the counting stones were built into a wall, some three thousand strokes in all, and the king rode east with Somhairle to see it and stood before it a long while without speaking. At Seann Tarr the stones were cut in fives and set

1. the Age of Ailean

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

3. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

4. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

5. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

in the floor of a house that was lived in over its own dead. About the four hundred and seventieth year the stones thickened together on three coasts at once, more strokes to each stone and more stones to each course; death came on three coasts together, and what it was the strokes do not tell. At Seann Chwen the last tally stone was left half-cut in the five hundred and tenth year, two strokes finished and a third begun and forsaken, the chisel marks stopping in mid-groove. After it no work of Seann-Dhaoine can be dated. Their middens stopped growing, their harbours silted, and their script was cut no more. Somhairle rode the three shores in one circuit and set the silence in the Line.

The hill-folk kept Seann-Dhaoine' place-names and set before them only their own word for old: Seann Dunn, Seann Chwen, Seann Skell, Seann Warr, Seann Tarr. They turned nothing into their own tongue, and the roots of those names were not understood. For the rest of the age Seann-Dhaoine' work was let stand: the hill-folk took up their empty harbours and used the moles and landings unmended, built on their middens but laid the marked stones aside, set their tally stones back as they lay, took no stone from their ruins, closed their graves when they broke into them, and walked round the temple at a distance.

The hill-folk and the name

The people of the grove called themselves Clann nan Dè⁶, the children of the gods, and the king Rìgh Chlann nan Dè⁷. Most of the age they were simply the hill-folk, the households of the valleys under Dùn ìseal and of Na Glinn Àrda⁸, who spread down every river to every coast. In the two thousand two hundred and first year the children of Dùn ìseal began, unbidden by any elder, to call themselves Dia-thìrich and their island Dia-thìr, and within a generation the old words fell out of use among the young. A boy of seven told Tormod Liath that he was Dia-thìreach and that everyone was; Tormod answered that it was a good enough name for a good enough island. With the names went the belief of the saying on Calbh Cnoc ghorm⁹: they did not come; they were here.

Clann na Ceiste¹⁰, the households of Na Glinn Àrda, kept Sloinneadh a' Chlachair¹¹ and the slab, took no share of any hall, and asked their questions of the

6. the godkin; lit. 'the children of the gods'

7. king of the godkin, the first king's style

8. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

9. the column at Cnoc ghorm

10. the Children of the Question

11. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

ground and not of the king. Somhairle lived among them nearly three thousand years, counted a single mouth at a single hearth, and his line held no share of the hill after him.

Lines and the forbidden marriage

The hill-folk ordered themselves by blood long before the coal gave them cause. In the two thousand two hundred and twenty-third year the match of Ealag and Torcall Tochclair, which two households who shared a slope and a spring had treated as settled, was refused, and every elder of Ealag's household gave the same three words, that it could not be, and no reason. Ealag was married to a fisher of the ford town and lived her whole life without the reason; Torcall went east to dig for a second vein. Twenty-four years later, at Cruinneachadh an Àtha¹², households began to give their lines aloud before any match was spoken, seven names back on either side, so that a forbidden blood might be named before the salt was carried: the first genealogies of the common households. Only Sloinneadh a' Chlachair¹³ is older. Of the king's own kin, in the last centuries every marriage among the blood came to be reckoned for the shares it brought nearer the front of a reckoning the king never made; the hill argued without settling whether a claim through daughters weighed more or less than one through sons.

The king's kin

By the last centuries of the age the king's blood was a people within the people. It was reckoned at some four hundred at An Cruinneachadh Mòr¹⁴ of the three thousandth year, and it went on growing. The kin held grazing in every part of the island by the king's giving, and the king took shares back as freely as he gave them: Ìomhar Dearg's river-grazing, Raonaid's river-meadow within the month of her burying, a household's western slopes after eleven generations. When Catriona Mhòr died and the king held the hill in his own hand, every soul of the blood within three days' walk came to press a claim, each able to say the two names of a line whose second name was always Ailean's. From then the kin married for shares. After the four thousand six hundredth year they came down out of their holdings, household by household and line by line, and camped in the valley below Dùn ìseal, each line with its own tents, its own fire and its

12. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

13. the Line of the Mason; lit. 'the pedigree of the Mason'

14. the great gathering at the ford in the three thousandth year

own steward, until the valley looked less like a gathering than a town that never raised walls. Gille-Bride of Somhairle's line, who asked for no ground and no share, was the one soul in the valley whose name was on no cord.

The salt-folk

The salt-folk of Baile ghorm scraped the flats of the south coast and dried the crust on the shingle, and in the six hundred and eighty-third year made shallow clay basins behind the shingle bar, the first salt-works of the island. They had no king and a hill without salt had none of theirs. Mòrag Chruaidh raided them and lost seven; Iain Dubh came down on them with more spears and was killed by Tadhg Garbh; and the king came down alone, and they raised spears and lowered them, and old Mòr knelt on the wet shingle and gave him a double handful of salt. The southern shore was his from that day, with no blood shed and none paid. The salt-folk raised a cairn of their own for Iain Dubh with seven stones in it for the seven of Mòrag's raid, having come to think of both raids as one account, and sang at the raking of the pans the four-line refrain the fosterling later brought them from An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁵'s lake shore, the oldest song on Dia-thìr whose words are said to survive.

The lake-folk of An Cnoc Ruadh

An Cnoc Ruadh¹⁶'s people lived by salt and fish at the western end of Loch chrom, behind a palisade on the neck of their hill. They were not the king's blood and had none of na Bliadhnachan Fada¹⁷. They swore to the king in the two hundred and ninetieth year when Uisdean Mòr knelt in the ford, but kept their own holders and their own list and never swore to Dùn ìseal. Salt went from their pans for the hill's wool at the ford from Raghnaill Ceannfhionn's wading on, and married across the water at the ford within a generation. They settled Cala nan Taighean Cruinne¹⁸, the landing of laid stone below the hill, the boat-sheds at Baile ghlas, Cnoc bheag at the forest's edge and the old landing at Ceann àrsaidh; their children, fostered or born, learned the salt-rake before the spear.

15. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

16. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

17. the long years of Ailean's kin

18. the round-house harbour paying salt to the Red Hill (burg 26 in this age)

The coasts

The households who took up the empty coasts after Seann-Dhaoine¹⁹ became peoples of their own by the middle of the age. The river-folk who came down the Abhainn namh to Seann Skell had never dwelt by the water before and learned from Marsaili how a household newly of the sea buries one the sea has taken. The west-coast households of the bay of hawks fished from the shore and not from boats and drilled amber from the wrack. The east-coast households lived through A' Ghaoth Dhubh²⁰ on the sharing of the valleys and kept five fires for the boats. The south-coast harbours became the busiest quays of the island. Each coast kept the eight wind-names, the hand-ful and the sharing as the valleys did, and each thought itself the valleys' equal.

The east

East of the vein lay country the king's blood held no hall in and claimed no grazing on. Households went out into it a generation at a time for their own reasons, among them Beasag's household from Àth shean after the hidden pit was found, and they dug no pits under their new floors. In the four thousand two hundred and seventy-fourth year the eastern households raised a double bank at Dùn dhearg, owing nothing to Dùn ìseal and asking leave of no one, and shared out the labour and afterward the ground within it by households and not by standing. They came to the ford for the first time in Catrìona's day with seal-skins, and she gave them ground on the far bank asking no oath. Ìomhar Dearg called them the short-lived; Ailis of Dùn dhearg answered that she had five days' walking behind her and no wish to spend what time she had left arguing with a man who would have five centuries to be sorry in. When the king sent Niall Òg to bid them come in, Fearghal Donn answered that his people had raised their own bank and buried their own dead without any man's leave, and would not be counted among a kin who married for shares and waited a thousand years for a hill never given. From that year the spears of the east were gathered at Dùn dhearg.

19. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

20. the Black Wind

APPENDIX E

Land and Trade: the Ford, the Roads and the Weather

Dia-thìr in An Aois Ailein¹ was an island of households, not of towns. At the grove there was one hill with a bank, one hill with a palisade by the lake, Seann-Dhaoine² empty harbours on every coast and the hearths of Na Glinn Àrda³; by the close of the age there were banked places in the east, the north and the midlands, harbours on every coast, and a gathering at the ford that drew households from all of them. This appendix sets out the ford and its grounds, the roads that ran to it, the goods that went along them, the fires kept for the boats, and the weather, water and ground the age had to live with.

Cruinneachadh an Àtha

The ford lies fourteen miles below An Cnoc Ruadh⁴, where the lake-folk's salt and the hill's wool first met. In the thousand one hundred and seventy-fifth year Ragnall Ceannfhionn found his grandfather's salt-kists near empty, rode west with nine companions so that the company would not be taken for a raid, and waded into the ford to meet the holder of An Cnoc Ruadh in the water. They agreed salt for wool. Both hills were the king's, and neither was the other's; the king would not do their talking for them. The bargain held on nothing written, only on each side's wish to be trusted the year after: when An Cnoc Ruadh refused a thin, unwashed clip, Ragnall sent a better one the next spring with fleece besides, and neither hill pressed harder than a fair measure again.

Traders with no part in either household began to bring flint, dried fish and pots on the appointed days and set their wares apart, and no one afterward remembered deciding to let them stay. In the twelve hundred and eighth year the meeting became a

1. the Age of Ailean

2. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

3. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

4. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

yearly gathering, and the first marriage of the ford was made on the trodden ground with both banks' households standing for it. No meeting-place on the island was used longer without a break. By the twelve hundred and sixtieth year the children who ran between the stalls made no distinction between the hill's side of the water and An Cnoc Ruadh's.

The gathering had three grounds: the salt people downstream, the hill people upstream, and the flint people on the rise beyond the river. By the three thousand four hundred and fiftieth year it drew households from every coast. It was at the ford that the lines were first recited before a marriage, that Flòraidh laid her amber bead in the old ground among the ribbons and worked bones other travellers had left there, that Anndra Breac was shouted down, that the saying was first spoken at the opening, that An Dà Chlàr⁵ were heard whole in one night, and that Catrìona gave the households of Dùn dhearg ground of their own on the far bank.

In the three thousandth year since the grove the gathering was kept greater than any before it. More households came in than the three grounds were ever laid out to hold, until by the second morning no one could say which bank belonged to whom. The king came down the hill road dressed as any herdsman and the crowd opened a way for him without a word called; five holders waded out to put their hands between his; the rings of his blood went into the river, Somhairle at his left hand, Murchadh a head taller than most, Eithne laughing in the outer ring; and the reciters counted some four hundred of his blood standing in the water. No household from east of the vein came. When the gathering had gone back to its fires the king stood alone in the emptied ford at dusk, and a girl of An Cnoc Ruadh found the water warm as bath-water round his legs and saw it smoke downstream of him.

The roads

Rathad an t-Salainn⁶ ran from the pans of Baile ghorm by the ford to An Cnoc Ruadh⁷ and on to the north-west. Murchadh Gearr walked it every autumn to be seen upon it, and every household on it had seen An Cnoc Ruadh's holder pass in the flesh. In the two thousand four hundred and sixty-fourth year carriers cut through its last unbroken thicket, and Muileann àrsaidh stood a day nearer the pans; at the far end the salt cost three times its price at the pans and was paid for in flint and seal-skins. Eilidh Ghlas's younger son walked it west at six years old, fifty miles and more from Dùn iséal

5. the two oral king-lists, of the Stone Kings and the Red Hill

6. the salt road from the pans to the north-west

7. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

to An Cnoc Ruadh, past a low green mound his guide would go no nearer to, and walked it east again twenty-four years later with a train of laden pack-beasts.

Rathad na Spor⁸ ran from the pit at Cnoc àrsaidh in the north-west south and east toward Cruinneachadh an Àtha⁹, worn by generations of carriers with yokes on their shoulders until, by the eighteen hundred and seventeenth year, it sank a full yard below the ground on either side and a stranger took it for a dry ditch dug on purpose. Carriers caught by storm dug into its banks and roofed themselves with their yokes. Cattle were walked up it to Cnoc ghorm in the north-west. Murchadh walked it for a hundred and thirty years and asked his father for the country it ran through, and was refused.

The drovers' roads of Na Glinn Àrda¹⁰ ran by fords like Àth gharbh, where the beasts were rested and the full hand began, and by Àth shean, the old crossing below Dùn iséal. The coast road ran round the east and south, and carried grain to Cuan ruadh after A' Ghaoth Dhubh¹¹.

The goods

Salt from An Cnoc Ruadh¹²'s pans on the lake shore and from the clay basins at Baile ghorm, raked from the crust without breaking it, went to every hearth that could pay in wool, fish or flint. **Wool** came down from the hill and from the sheep-households of Baile gharbh. **Flint** from the one good pit on the island went to hearths from one end of it to the other in grey flakes, and the first flake of every new working was given free to whoever asked. **Pots** of coiled clay, fired in open bonfires, were first made at Doire shean in the seven hundred and fifth year, and within a few lifetimes the whole southern shore used them. **Amber** came out of the western wrack and was drilled with flint points by a few hands on the bay of hawks. **Cloth** was woven on standing frames with fired-clay weights at Muileann leathan from the sixteen hundred and twenty-eighth year, and Beitris taught the standing weights to the hill's women. **Light** came first from seal-oil lamps of hollowed stone at Caol leathan. **Salmon** came from the wattle fence at Caol fhiadhaich, **seal-skins** from the rocks of Inis bhàn and the east, **feathers** from the cliffs of Inis mhin, **boar** from Baile fhiadhaich, and **green axes** from the quarry at Àth àrsaidh, too fine for work, until the quarry was forsaken. The one thing

8. the flint-carriers' road from Cnoc àrsaidh

9. the yearly gathering at the ford of salt and wool

10. the high valleys of Clann na Ceiste about the slab

11. the Black Wind

12. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

no one traded was the vein's coal, which went by the handful to every hearth and was sold by none.

The boats

The oldest boat on Dia-thìr known in its whole shape is a dug-out hollowed from a single oak trunk, long enough for six, sunk at a landing on the Abhainn uaine in the seven hundred and sixteenth year. The river-folk who came down to Seann Skell built small hide boats and trusted them to open tide for the first time in the six hundred and fortieth year. The first households of the west coast fished from the shore and not from boats. Stitched planks from hulls built for open water, like nothing built on any coast of the island, washed up south of Seann Skell in the two thousand four hundred and twenty-first year, and no household claimed them. Peigi Dhubh laid a landing of laid stone below An Cnoc Ruadh¹³ so a boat could come alongside at any state of the water, and the fishing households of Caol bheag named their boats for the winds.

The five fires

After A' Ghaoth Dhubh¹⁴ a young woman of Cuan ruadh, Lileas, kept a fire on the cape east of the village for boats coming home in the dark, in a stone-walled pit, driving flame and smoke seaward. Word of it travelled the coast roads faster than its light, and within two years there were fires on the northern point, on the north-eastern cape where Seathan mac Pheadair cut a stroke for every ship's light he saw pass safe, and on the southern cape on a mound of stacked stone breast-high. With the older fire on the Baile chrom headland, the coasts of Dia-thìr were lit at five points, and a reciter named them the five fires. They were lit to bring boats home, the tellings say, and not to warn them off.

Weather, water and ground

Storms. The first storm the reciters of Dùn ìseal named came in the hundred and forty-seventh year; its name is lost, only the memory of the naming remains. It stripped Dùn ìseal's thatch and broke Seann-Dhaoine¹⁵' shell causeway at Seann Warr in three places. A' Ghaoth Dhubh¹⁶ of the two thousand four hundred and seven-

13. the Red Hill where Cathair dhearg now stands, and its line

14. the Black Wind

15. the Old Ones, the people before the Dia-thìrich

16. the Black Wind

teenth year stripped every roof between Cuan ruadh and Ceann chiar, and it is the eldest storm whose name is kept. Cuan ruadh rebuilt in stone to the eaves, and Ceann chiar cut a mark for every house lost: twenty-two.

Waves. In the seven hundred and seventy-seventh year the sea came far inland over the village at Cnoc chaol and left a sheet of sand a hand thick on its hearths, with the shells of deep-water creatures in it; the village was not rebuilt on the same ground. When the sea came in again in the three thousand eight hundred and seventeenth year, less far, the new houses stood higher on the slope and none was lost.

The crack. In the eight hundred and twenty-seventh year a crack a man could fall into opened across a valley two days inland and moved its spring a hundred paces downhill. The king walked its length and forbade nothing; Seasaidh laid white stones a stride back from its edge, and no house was built within a stone's throw of it for the rest of the age. It moved again in the three thousand eight hundred and sixty-third year and broke the line in two places, and the line was laid again.

Hunger and drought. Two failed fishing seasons emptied Baile chrom in the nineteen hundred and sixty-sixth year, the oldest hunger on Dia-thìr tied to a place. The springs of Achadh shean ran dry forty years later and the field banks were forsaken. The rivers of the eastern plain ran low for a whole summer in the three thousand seven hundred and seventy-first year, and the cattle of Dùn ìseal and Muileann bhàn were driven to Fuarain Theth Muileann ruadh¹⁷ to drink. Each time the store within the bank and the sharing held.

The lake and the moor. The marks on the Ros dhomhain rock crept upward from keeper to keeper until Loch chrom stood a hand higher than at the first cut. In the north, about Doire ghlas, heather, birch and bog-moss spread over the oak ground in the three thousand five hundred and eighty-eighth year, and the groves that gave the north its many doire-names drew back into valleys the wind could not reach.

The fords. A spate on the Abhainn chaol took a party of twelve crossing with salt in the three thousand six hundred and eightieth year, and none crossed there in the wet season after. Stepping-stones were laid across the Abhainn fhionn at its shallows a stone at a time until a man might cross dry-shod in every season but true flood: the first made crossing of any river on the island.

17. the warm springs below Muileann ruadh